JANE EYRE (Introduction)

- **Charlotte Brontë**, married name **Mrs. Arthur Bell Nicholls**, pseudonym **Currer Bell**, (born April 21, 1816, Thornton, Yorkshire England— died March 31, 1855, Haworth, Yorkshire).
- English novelist noted for *Jane Eyre* (1847), a strong narrative of a woman in conflict with her natural desires and social condition. The novel gave new truthfulness to Victorian fiction.
- She later wrote *Shirley* (1849) and Villette (1853).
- Her father was Patrick Brontë (1777–1861), an Anglican clergyman. Irish-born, he had changed his name from the more commonplace Brunty. After serving in several parishes, he moved with his wife, Maria Branwell Brontë, and their six small children to Haworth amid the Yorkshire moors in 1820, having been awarded a rectorship there.
- Soon after, Mrs. Brontë and the two eldest children (Maria and Elizabeth) died, leaving the father to care for the remaining three girls— Charlotte, Emily, and Anne—and a boy, Branwell.
- In 1824 Charlotte and Emily, together with their elder sisters before their deaths, attended Clergy Daughters' School at Cowan Bridge, near Kirkby Lonsdale, Lancashire.
- The fees were low, the food unattractive, and the discipline harsh. Charlotte condemned the school (perhaps exaggeratedly) long years afterward in *Jane Eyre,* under the thin disguise of Lowood Institution, and its principal, the Reverend William Carus Wilson, has been accepted as the counterpart of Mister Brocklehurst in the novel.
- Charlotte and Emily returned home in June 1825, and for more than five years the Brontë children learned and played there, writing and telling romantic tales for one another and inventing imaginative games played out at home or on the desolate moors.
- In 1831 Charlotte was sent to Miss Wooler's school at Roe Head, near Huddersfield, where she stayed a year and made some lasting friendships; her correspondence with one of her friends, Ellen Nussey, continued until her death and has provided much of the current knowledge of her life.
- In 1832 she went home to teach her sisters but in 1835 returned to Roe Head as a teacher. She wished to improve her family's position, and that was the only outlet that was offered to her unsatisfied energies. Branwell, moreover, was to start on his career as an artist, and it became necessary to supplement the family resources.
- The work, with its inevitable restrictions, was uncongenial to Charlotte. She fell into ill health and melancholia and in the summer of 1838 terminated her engagement.
- In 1839 Charlotte declined a proposal from the Reverend Henry Nussey, her friend's brother, and some months later one from another young clergyman.
- At the same time Charlotte's ambition to make the practical best of her talents and the need to pay Branwell's debts urged her to spend some months as governess with the Whites at Upperwood House, Rawdon.

- Branwell'stalents for writing and painting, his good classical scholarship, and his social charm had engendered high hopes for him, but he was fundamentally unstable, weak-willed, and intemperate. He went from job to job and took refuge in alcohol and opium.
- Meanwhile, his sisters had planned to open a school together, which their aunt agreed to finance.
- In February 1842 Charlotte and Emily went to Brussels as pupils to improve their qualifications in French and acquire some German. The talent displayed by both brought them to the notice of Constantin Héger, a fine teacher and a man of unusual perception.
- Madame Héger appears to have become jealous of her. The nature of Charlotte's attachment to Héger and the degree to which she understood herself have been much discussed. His was the most-interesting mind she had yet met, and he had perceived and evoked her latent talents. His strong and eccentric personality appealed both to her sense of humour and to her affections.
- She offered him an innocent but ardent devotion, but he tried to repress her emotions. The letters she wrote to him after her return may well be called love letters. When, however, he suggested that they were open to misapprehension, she stopped writing and applied herself, in silence, to disciplining her feelings.
- However Charlotte's experiences in Brussels are interpreted, they were crucial for her development. She received a strict literary training, became aware of the resources of her own nature, and gathered material that served her, in various shapes, for all her novels.
- In the autumn of 1845 Charlotte came across some poems by Emily, and that discovery led to the publication of a joint volume of *Poems by Currer, Ellis and Acton Bell* (1846), or Charlotte, Emily, and Anne; the pseudonyms were assumed to preserve secrecy and avoid the special treatment that they believed reviewers accorded to women. The book was issued at their own expense. It received few reviews and only two copies were sold. Nevertheless, a way had opened to them, and they were already trying to place the three novels they had written.
- Charlotte failed to place *The Professor: A Tale* but had, however, nearly finished *Jane Eyre: An Autobiography*, begun in August 1846 in Manchester,where she was staying with her father, who had gone there for an eye operation. When Smith, Elder and Company, declining *The Professor*, declared themselves willing to consider a three-volume novel with more action and excitement in it, she completed and submitted it at once.

- *Jane Eyre* was accepted, published less than eight weeks later (on October 16, 1847), and had an immediate success, far greater than that of the books that her sisters published the same year.
- In the following years Charlotte went three times to London as the guest of her publisher; there she met the novelist William Makepeace Thackerayand sat for her portrait by George Richmond.
- She stayed in 1851 with the writer Harriet Martineau and also visited her future biographer,Elizabeth Gaskell, in Manchester and entertained her at Haworth.
- *Villette* was published in January 1853. Meanwhile, in 1851, she had declined a third offer of marriage, that time from James Taylor, a member of Smith, Elder and Company.
- Her father's curate, Arthur Bell Nicholls (1817–1906), an Irishman, was her fourth suitor. It took some months to win her father's consent, but they were married on June 29, 1854, in Haworth church. They spent their honeymoon in Ireland and then returned to Haworth, where her husband had pledged himself to continue as curate to her father. He did not share his wife'sintellectual life, but she was happy to be loved for herself and to take up her duties as his wife.
- She began another book, *Emma,* of which some pages remain. Her pregnancy, however, was accompanied by exhausting sickness, and she died in 1855.
- A three-volume edition of her letters, *The Letters of Charlotte Brontë*, edited by Margaret Smith was published in 1995–2004.

What was Charlotte Bronte famous for?

- Charlotte Brontë was an English novelist best known for *Jane Eyre* (1847), the story of an independent young governess who overcomes hardships while remaining true to her principles. It blended moral realism with Gothic elements.

- Her other novels included *Shirley* (1849) and *Villette* (1853)
  - What were Charlotte Bronte's siblings name?

- Charlotte Brontë was one of six children. Her two eldest sisters (Maria and Elizabeth) died when she was young. She had a brother named Patrick Branwell and two sisters, Emily and Anne, who were also novelists. The three sisters published together under the names Currer, Ellis, and Acton Bell.

  What was Charlotte Bronte's childhood like?

- Her father, Patrick Brontë, was an Anglican clergyman. He moved his family to Haworth amid the Yorkshire moors in 1820. When they weren't away at school, the Brontë children learned and played there, writing and telling romantic tales for one another and inventing imaginative games played out at home or on the desolate moors.

  Where did Charlotte Bronte go to school?

- In 1824 Charlotte attended Clergy Daughters' School in Lancashire. Her experiences there, including harsh discipline and terrible food, influenced the portrayal of Lowood Institution in *Jane Eyre*.

- In 1842 Charlotte and Emily went to Brussels as pupils to improve their French and acquire some German. Her experiences there inspired the characters and incidents in *Villette*.

DENG 303

1. **Charlotte Bronte: Jane Eyre: Introduction of the author and the text.**

Charlotte Bronte was an English writer and artist, the oldest of the three Bronte sisters who made due into adulthood and whose books progressed toward becoming works of art of English writing.

She enrolled in school at Roe Head in January 1831, matured 14 years. She left the year after to show her sisters, Emily and Anne, at home, returning in 1835 as a tutor. In 1839 she embraced the job as tutor for the Sidgwick family yet left following a couple of months to come back to Haworth where the sisters opened a school, however neglected to draw in students. Rather, they went to composing and they every previously distributed in 1846 under the nom de plumes Currer, Ellis and Acton Bell. Her first novel *The Professor* was dismissed by distributers, her second novel Jane Eyre was distributed in 1847. The sisters admitted to their Bell pen names 1848, and by the next year were praised in London artistic circles.

Brontë encountered the early deaths of every one of her kin. She ended up pregnant not long after her marriage in June 1854 however passed on 31 March 1855, in all likelihood from hyperemesis gravidarum, a confusion of pregnancy which caused her exorbitant sickness and vomiting.

Charlotte Brontë was born on 21 April 1816 in Market Street Thornton, west of Bradford in the West Riding of Yorkshire, the third of the six offspring of Maria (née Branwell) and Patrick Brontë (once in the past surnamed Brunty), an Irish Anglican priest. In 1820 her family moved a couple of miles to the town of Haworth, where her dad had been designated interminable clergyman of St Michael and All Angels Church. Maria kicked the bucket of disease on 15 September 1821, leaving five girls, Maria, Elizabeth, Charlotte, Emily and Anne, and a child, Branwell, to be dealt with by her sister, Elizabeth Branwell.

In August 1824, Patrick sent Charlotte, Emily, Maria and Elizabeth to the Clergy Daughters' School at Cowan Bridge in Lancashire. Charlotte kept up that the school's poor conditions forever influenced her wellbeing and physical improvement, and hurried the deaths of Maria

(brought into the world 1814) and Elizabeth (brought into the world 1815), who both died because of tuberculosis in June 1825. After their deaths of his sisters, Patrick expelled Charlotte and Emily from the school. Charlotte utilized the school as the reason for Lowood School in *Jane Eyre*.

Brontë's first composition, *The Professor*, did not verify a distributer, despite the fact that she was delighted by an empowering reaction from *Smith, Elder and Co*. of Cornhill, who communicated an enthusiasm for any more extended works Currer Bell may wish to send. Brontë reacted by completing and sending a second composition in August 1847. A month and a half later, *Jane Eyre* was distributed. It recounts to the account of a plain tutor, Jane, who, after challenges in her initial life, begins to look all starry eyed at her boss, Mr Rochester. They get married, however simply after Rochester's crazy first wife, of whom Jane at first has no information, dies in an emotional house fire. The book's style was inventive, consolidating naturalism with gothic acting, and kicked off something new in being composed from a strongly evoked first-individual female perspective. Brontë accepted workmanship was most persuading when dependent on close to home involvement; in *Jane Eyre* she changed the experience into a novel with all inclusive appeal.

Jane Eyre had quick business achievement and at first gotten positive audits. Speculation about the character and sexual orientation of the strange Currer Bell uplifted with the production of Wuthering Heights by Ellis Bell (Emily) and Agnes Gray by Acton Bell (Anne). Accompanying the hypothesis was an adjustment in the basic response to Brontë's work, as allegations were made that the composing might have been “coarse”, a judgment all the more promptly made once it was suspected that Currer Bell was a woman. However, offers of *Jane Eyre* kept on being solid and may even have expanded because of the novel building up notoriety for being an “improper” book. A capable novice craftsman, Brontë actually did the illustrations for the second release of *Jane Eyre* and in the mid year of 1834 two of her artistic creations were appeared at a show by the Royal Northern Society for the Encouragement of the Fine Arts in Leeds.

The novel *Jane Eyre* changed exposition fiction by being the first to concentrate on its hero's good and profound advancement through a close first-individual story, where activities and occasions are hued by a mental force. Charlotte Brontë has been known as the

"primary history specialist of the private cognizance", and the artistic precursor of essayists like Proust and Joyce.

The book contains components of social analysis, with a solid feeling of Christian profound quality at its centre, and is considered by numerous individuals to be comparatively radical in view of Jane's individualistic character and how the novel methodologies the points of class, sexuality, religion and feminism.

2. Charlotte Bronte: Jane Eyre: Analysis and Theme.

Jane Eyre is a young orphan being raised by Mrs. Reed, her cruel, wealthy aunt. A servant named Bessie provides Jane with some of the few kindnesses she receives, telling her stories and singing songs to her. One day, as punishment for fighting with her bullying cousin John Reed, Jane's aunt imprisons Jane in the red-room, the room in which Jane's Uncle Reed died. While locked in, Jane, believing that she sees her uncle's ghost, screams and faints. She wakes to find herself in the care of Bessie and the kindly apothecary Mr. Lloyd, who suggests to Mrs. Reed that Jane be sent away to school. To Jane's delight, Mrs. Reed concurs.
Once at the Lowood School, Jane finds that her life is far from idyllic. The school's headmaster is Mr. Brocklehurst, a cruel, hypocritical, and abusive man. Brocklehurst preaches a doctrine of poverty and privation to his students while using the school's funds to provide a wealthy and opulent lifestyle for his own family. At Lowood, Jane befriends a young girl named Helen Burns, whose strong, martyrlike attitude toward the school's miseries is both helpful and displeasing to Jane. A massive typhus epidemic sweeps Lowood, and Helen dies of consumption. The epidemic also results in the departure of Mr. Brocklehurst by attracting attention to the insalubrious conditions at Lowood. After a group of more sympathetic gentlemen takes Brocklehurst's place, Jane's life improves dramatically. She spends eight more years at Lowood, six as a student and two as a teacher.
After teaching for two years, Jane yearns for new experiences. She accepts a governess position at a manor called Thornfield, where she teaches a lively French girl named Adèle. The distinguished housekeeper Mrs. Fairfax presides over the estate. Jane's employer at Thornfield is a dark, impassioned man named Rochester, with whom Jane finds herself falling secretly in love. She saves Rochester from a fire one night, which he claims was started by a drunken servant named Grace Poole. But because Grace Poole continues to work at Thornfield, Jane concludes that she has not been told the entire story. Jane sinks into

despondency when Rochester brings home a beautiful but vicious woman named Blanche Ingram. Jane expects Rochester to propose to Blanche. But Rochester instead proposes to Jane, who accepts almost disbelievingly.

The wedding day arrives, and as Jane and Mr. Rochester prepare to exchange their vows, the voice of Mr. Mason cries out that Rochester already has a wife. Mason introduces himself as the brother of that wife—a woman named Bertha. Mr. Mason testifies that Bertha, whom Rochester married when he was a young man in Jamaica, is still alive. Rochester does not deny Mason's claims, but he explains that Bertha has gone mad. He takes the wedding party back to Thornfield, where they witness the insane Bertha Mason scurrying around on all fours and growling like an animal. Rochester keeps Bertha hidden on the third story of Thornfield and pays Grace Poole to keep his wife under control. Bertha was the real cause of the mysterious fire earlier in the story. Knowing that it is impossible for her to be with Rochester, Jane flees Thornfield.

Penniless and hungry, Jane is forced to sleep outdoors and beg for food. At last, three siblings who live in a manor alternatively called Marsh End and Moor House take her in. Their names are Mary, Diana, and St. John (pronounced "Sinjin") Rivers, and Jane quickly becomes friends with them. St. John is a clergyman, and he finds Jane a job teaching at a charity school in Morton. He surprises her one day by declaring that her uncle, John Eyre, has died and left her a large fortune: 20,000 pounds. When Jane asks how he received this news, he shocks her further by declaring that her uncle was also his uncle: Jane and the Riverses are cousins. Jane immediately decides to share her inheritance equally with her three newfound relatives.

St. John decides to travel to India as a missionary, and he urges Jane to accompany him—as his wife. Jane agrees to go to India but refuses to marry her cousin because she does not love him. St. John pressures her to reconsider, and she nearly gives in. However, she realizes that she cannot abandon forever the man she truly loves when one night she hears Rochester's voice calling her name over the moors. Jane immediately hurries back to Thornfield and finds that it has been burned to the ground by Bertha Mason, who lost her life in the fire. Rochester saved the servants but lost his eyesight and one of his hands. Jane travels on to Rochester's new residence, Ferndean, where he lives with two servants named John and Mary.

At Ferndean, Rochester and Jane rebuild their relationship and soon marry. At the end of her story, Jane writes that she has been married for ten blissful years and that she and Rochester enjoy perfect equality in their life together. She says that after two years of blindness, Rochester regained sight in one eye and was able to behold their first son at his birth.

Character List

Jane Eyre - The protagonist and narrator of the novel, Jane is an intelligent, honest, plain-featured young girl forced to contend with oppression, inequality, and hardship. Although she meets with a series of individuals who threaten her autonomy, Jane repeatedly succeeds at asserting herself and maintains her principles of justice, human dignity, and morality. She also values intellectual and emotional fulfillment. Her strong belief in gender and social equality challenges the Victorian prejudices against women and the poor.

Edward Rochester - Jane's employer and the master of Thornfield, Rochester is a wealthy, passionate man with a dark secret that provides much of the novel's suspense. Rochester is unconventional, ready to set aside polite manners, propriety, and consideration of social class in order to interact with Jane frankly and directly. He is rash and impetuous and has spent much of his adult life roaming about Europe in an attempt to avoid the consequences of his youthful indiscretions. His problems are partly the result of his own recklessness, but he is a sympathetic figure because he has suffered for so long as a result of his early marriage to Bertha.

St. John Rivers - Along with his sisters, Mary and Diana, St. John (pronounced "Sinjin") serves as Jane's benefactor after she runs away from Thornfield, giving her food and shelter. The minister at Morton, St. John is cold, reserved, and often controlling in his interactions with others. Because he is entirely alienated from his feelings and devoted solely to an austere ambition, St. John serves as a foil to Edward Rochester.

Mrs. Reed - Mrs. Reed is Jane's cruel aunt, who raises her at Gateshead Hall until Jane is sent away to school at age ten. Later in her life, Jane attempts reconciliation with her aunt, but the old woman continues to resent her because her husband had always loved Jane more than his own children.

Bessie Lee - The maid at Gateshead, Bessie is the only figure in Jane's childhood who regularly treats her kindly, telling her stories and singing her songs. Bessie later marries Robert Leaven, the Reeds' coachman.

Mr. Lloyd - Mr. Lloyd is the Reeds' apothecary, who suggests that Jane be sent away to school. Always kind to Jane, Mr. Lloyd writes a letter to Miss Temple confirming Jane's story about her childhood and clearing Jane of Mrs. Reed's charge that she is a liar.

Georgiana Reed - Georgiana Reed is Jane's cousin and one of Mrs. Reed's two daughters. The beautiful Georgiana treats Jane cruelly when they are children, but later in their lives she befriends her cousin and confides in her. Georgiana attempts to elope with a man named Lord Edwin Vere, but her sister, Eliza, alerts Mrs. Reed of the arrangement and sabotages the plan. After Mrs. Reed dies, Georgiana marries a wealthy man.

Eliza Reed - Eliza Reed is Jane's cousin and one of Mrs. Reed's two daughters (along with her sister, Georgiana). Not as beautiful as her sister, Eliza devotes herself somewhat self-righteously to the church and eventually goes to a convent in France where she becomes the Mother Superior.

John Reed - John Reed is Jane's cousin, Mrs. Reed's son, and brother to Eliza and Georgiana. John treats Jane with appalling cruelty during their childhood and later falls into a life of drinking and gambling. John commits suicide midway through the novel when his mother ceases to pay his debts for him.

Helen Burns - Helen Burns is Jane's close friend at the Lowood School. She endures her miserable life there with a passive dignity that Jane cannot understand. Helen dies of consumption in Jane's arms.

Mr. Brocklehurst - The cruel, hypocritical master of the Lowood School, Mr. Brocklehurst preaches a doctrine of privation, while stealing from the school to support his luxurious lifestyle. After a typhus epidemic sweeps Lowood, Brocklehurst's shifty and dishonest practices are brought to light and he is publicly discredited.

Maria Temple - Maria Temple is a kind teacher at Lowood, who treats Jane and Helen with respect and compassion. Along with Bessie Lee, she serves as one of Jane's first positive female role models. Miss Temple helps clear Jane of Mrs. Reed's accusations against her.

Miss Scatcherd - Jane's sour and vicious teacher at Lowood, Miss Scatcherd behaves with particular cruelty toward Helen.

Alice Fairfax - Alice Fairfax is the housekeeper at Thornfield Hall. She is the first to tell Jane that the mysterious laughter often heard echoing through the halls is, in fact, the laughter of Grace Poole—a lie that Rochester himself often repeats.

Bertha Mason - Rochester's clandestine wife, Bertha Mason is a formerly beautiful and wealthy Creole woman who has become insane, violent, and bestial. She lives locked in a secret room on the third story of Thornfield and is guarded by Grace Poole, whose occasional bouts of inebriation sometimes enable Bertha to escape. Bertha eventually burns down Thornfield, plunging to her death in the flames.

Grace Poole - Grace Poole is Bertha Mason's keeper at Thornfield, whose drunken carelessness frequently allows Bertha to escape. When Jane first arrives at Thornfield, Mrs. Fairfax attributes to Grace all evidence of Bertha's misdeeds.

Adèle Varens - Jane's pupil at Thornfield, Adèle Varens is a lively though somewhat spoiled child from France. Rochester brought her to Thornfield after her mother, Celine, abandoned her. Although Celine was once Rochester's mistress, he does not believe himself to be Adèle's father.

Celine Varens - Celine Varens is a French opera dancer with whom Rochester once had an affair. Although Rochester does not believe Celine's claims that he fathered her daughter Adèle, he nonetheless brought the girl to England when Celine abandoned her. Rochester had broken off his relationship with Celine after learning that Celine was unfaithful to him and interested only in his money.

Sophie - Sophie is Adèle's French nurse at Thornfield.

Richard Mason - Richard Mason is Bertha's brother. During a visit to Thornfield, he is injured by his mad sister. After learning of Rochester's intent to marry Jane, Mason arrives with the solicitor Briggs in order to thwart the wedding and reveal the truth of Rochester's prior marriage.

Mr. Briggs - John Eyre's attorney, Mr. Briggs helps Richard Mason prevent Jane's wedding to Rochester when he learns of the existence of Bertha Mason, Rochester's wife. After John Eyre's death, Briggs searches for Jane in order to give her her inheritance.

Blanche Ingram - Blanche Ingram is a beautiful socialite who despises Jane and hopes to marry Rochester for his money.

Diana Rivers - Diana Rivers is Jane's cousin, and the sister of St. John and Mary. Diana is a kind and intelligent person, and she urges Jane not to go to India with St. John. She serves as a model for Jane of an intellectually gifted and independent woman.

Mary Rivers - Mary Rivers is Jane's cousin, the sister of St. John and Diana. Mary is a kind and intelligent young woman who is forced to work as a governess after her father loses his fortune. Like her sister, she serves as a model for Jane of an independent woman who is also able to maintain close relationships with others and a sense of meaning in her life.

Rosamond Oliver - Rosamond is the beautiful daughter of Mr. Oliver, Morton's wealthiest inhabitant. Rosamond gives money to the school in Morton where Jane works. Although she is in love with St. John, she becomes engaged to the wealthy Mr. Granby.

John Eyre - John Eyre is Jane's uncle, who leaves her his vast fortune of 20,000 pounds.

Uncle Reed - Uncle Reed is Mrs. Reed's late husband. In her childhood, Jane believes that she feels the presence of his ghost. Because he was always fond of Jane and her mother (his sister), Uncle Reed made his wife promise that she would raise Jane as her own child. It is a promise that Mrs. Reed does not keep

Themes

Love Versus Autonomy

Jane Eyre is very much the story of a quest to be loved. Jane searches, not just for romantic love, but also for a sense of being valued, of belonging. Thus Jane says to Helen Burns: "to gain some real affection from you, or Miss Temple, or any other whom I truly love, I would willingly submit to have the bone of my arm broken, or to let a bull toss me, or to stand behind a kicking horse, and let it dash its hoof at my chest" (Chapter 8). Yet, over the course of the book, Jane must learn how to gain love *without* sacrificing and harming herself in the process.

Her fear of losing her autonomy motivates her refusal of Rochester's marriage proposal. Jane believes that "marrying" Rochester while he remains legally tied to Bertha would mean rendering herself a mistress and sacrificing her own integrity for the sake of emotional gratification. On the other hand, her life at Moor House tests her in the opposite manner. There, she enjoys economic independence and engages in worthwhile and useful work, teaching the poor; yet she lacks emotional sustenance. Although St. John proposes marriage, offering her a partnership built around a common purpose, Jane knows their marriage would remain loveless.

Nonetheless, the events of Jane's stay at Moor House are necessary tests of Jane's autonomy. Only after proving her self-sufficiency to herself can she marry Rochester and not be asymmetrically dependent upon him as her "master." The marriage can be one between equals. As Jane says: "I am my husband's life as fully as he is mine. . . . To be together is for us to be at once as free as in solitude, as gay as in company. . . . We are precisely suited in character—perfect concord is the result" (Chapter 38).

Religion

Throughout the novel, Jane struggles to find the right balance between moral duty and earthly pleasure, between obligation to her spirit and attention to her body. She encounters three main religious figures: Mr. Brocklehurst, Helen Burns, and St. John Rivers. Each represents a model of religion that Jane ultimately rejects as she forms her own ideas about faith and principle, and their practical consequences.

Mr. Brocklehurst illustrates the dangers and hypocrisies that Charlotte Brontë perceived in the nineteenth-century Evangelical movement. Mr. Brocklehurst adopts the rhetoric of Evangelicalism when he claims to be purging his students of pride, but his method of subjecting them to various privations and humiliations, like when he orders that the naturally curly hair of one of Jane's classmates be cut so as to lie straight, is entirely un-Christian. Of course, Brocklehurst's proscriptions are difficult to follow, and his hypocritical support of his own luxuriously wealthy family at the expense of the Lowood students shows Brontë's wariness of the Evangelical movement. Helen Burns's meek and forbearing mode of Christianity, on the other hand, is too passive for Jane to adopt as her own, although she loves and admires Helen for it.

Many chapters later, St. John Rivers provides another model of Christian behavior. His is a Christianity of ambition, glory, and extreme self-importance. St. John urges Jane to sacrifice her emotional deeds for the fulfillment of her moral duty, offering her a way of life that would require her to be disloyal to her own self

3. Animal Farm: Introduction to the author and the text:

George Orwell, alias Eric Arthur Blair, (conceived June 25, 1903, Motihari, Bengal, India—died on January 21, 1950, London, England), English author, writer, and commentator acclaimed for his books *Animal Farm* (1945) and *Nineteen Eighty Four* (1949), the last a significant enemy of idealistic novel that looks at the perils of extremist principle.

Born as Eric Arthur Blair, Orwell never completely deserted his unique name, yet his first book, *Down and Out in Paris* and *London,* showed up in 1933 as crafted by George Orwell (the surname he got from the excellent River Orwell in East Anglia). In time his pen name turned out to be so firmly appended to him that few individuals yet relatives realized his genuine name was Blair. The adjustment in name compared to a significant move in Orwell's way of life, wherein he transformed from a mainstay of the British majestic foundation into a scholarly and political dissident.

In 1927 Orwell, on leave to England, chose not to come back to Burma, and on January 1, 1928, he made the unequivocal stride of leaving from the majestic police. As of now in the fall of 1927 he had begun a strategy that was to shape his character as an author. Having felt remorseful that the boundaries of race and rank had forestalled his blending with the Burmese, he figured he could appease a portion of his blame by inundating himself in the life of poor people and outsider individuals of Europe. Wearing worn out garments, he went into the East End of London to live in shabby cabin houses among workers and poor people; he spent a period in the ghettos of Paris and filled in as a dishwasher in French inns and cafés; he tramped the streets of England with expert vagrants and joined the general population of the London ghettos in their yearly departure to work in the Kentish hopfields.

In 1944 Orwell finished *Animal Farm,* a political fable based on the story of the Russian Revolution and its betrayal by Joseph Stalin. In the book a group of barnyard animals overthrow and chase off their exploitative human masters and set up an egalitarian society of their own. Eventually the animals' intelligent and power-loving leaders, the pigs, subvert the revolution and form a dictatorship whose bondage is even more oppressive and heartless than that of their former human masters. ("All animals are equal, but some animals are more equal

than others.") At first Orwell had difficulty finding a publisher for the small masterpiece, but when it appeared in 1945, *Animal Farm* made him famous and, for the first time, prosperous.

Animal Farm was one of Orwell's finest works, full of wit and fantasy and admirably written. It has, however, been overshadowed by his last book, *Nineteen Eighty-four* (1949), a novel he wrote as a warning after years of brooding on the twin menaces of Nazism and Stalinism. The novel is set in an imaginary future in which the world is dominated by three perpetually warring totalitarian police states. The book's hero, the Englishman Winston Smith, is a minor party functionary in one of those states. His longing for truth and decency leads him to secretly rebel against the government, which perpetuates its rule by systematically distorting the truth and continuously rewriting history to suit its own purposes. Smith has a love affair with a like-minded woman, but then they are both arrested by the Thought Police. The ensuing imprisonment, torture, and re-education of Smith are intended not merely to break him physically or make him submit but to root out his independent mental existence and his spiritual dignity until he can love only the figure he previously most hated: the apparent leader of the party, Big Brother. Smith's surrender to the monstrous brainwashing techniques of his jailers is tragic enough, but the novel gains much of its power from the comprehensive rigour with which it extends the premises of totalitarianism to their logical end: the love of power and domination over others has acquired its perfected expression in the perpetual surveillance and omnipresent dishonesty of an unassailable and irresistible police state under whose rule every human virtue is slowly being suborned and extinguished. Orwell's warning of the potential dangers of totalitarianism made a deep impression on his contemporaries and upon subsequent readers, and the book's title and many of its coined words and phrases ("Big Brother is watching you," "newspeak," "doublethink") became bywords for modern political abuses.

Orwell wrote the last pages of *Nineteen Eighty-four* in a remote house on the Hebridean island of Jura, which he had bought from the proceeds of *Animal Farm.* He worked between bouts of hospitalization for tuberculosis, of which he died in a London hospital in January 1950.

4. George Orwell: Animal Farm: Summary and Theme:

After Mr. Jones, the owner of Manor Farm, falls asleep in a drunken stupor, all of his animals meet in the big barn at the request of old Major, a 12-year-old pig. Major delivers a rousing political speech about the evils inflicted upon them by their human keepers and their need to rebel against the tyranny of Man. After elaborating on the various ways that Man has exploited and harmed the animals, Major mentions a strange dream of his in which he saw a vision of the earth without humans. He then teaches the animals a song — "Beasts of England" — which they sing repeatedly until they awaken Jones, who fires his gun from his bedroom window, thinking there is a fox in the yard. Frightened by the shot, the animals disperse and go to sleep. After the death of Old Major, the animals spend their days secretly planning the rebellion, although they are unsure when it will occur. Because of their intelligence, the pigs are placed in charge of educating the animals about Animalism, the name they give to the philosophy expounded by Major in Chapter 1. Among the pigs, Snowball and Napoleon are the most important to the revolution. Despite Mollie's concern with ribbons and Moses' tales of a place called Sugarcandy Mountain, the pigs are successful in conveying the principles of Animalism to the others.

The rebellion occurs when Jones again falls into a drunken sleep and neglects to feed the animals, who break into the store-shed in search of a meal. When Jones and his men arrive, they begin whipping the animals but soon find themselves being attacked and chased off the farm. The triumphant animals then destroy all traces of Jones, eat heartily, and revel in their newfound freedom. After a tour of Jones' house, they decide to leave it untouched as a museum. Snowball changes the sign reading "Manor Farm" to "Animal Farm" and paints the Seven Commandments of Animalism on the wall of the barn. The cows then give five buckets of milk, which Napoleon steals.

Despite the initial difficulties inherent in using farming tools designed for humans, the animals cooperate to finish the harvest — and do so in less time than it had taken Jones and his men to do the same. Boxer distinguishes himself as a strong, tireless worker, admired by all the animals. The pigs become the supervisors and directors of the animal workers. On Sundays, the animals meet in the big barn to listen to Snowball and Napoleon debate a number of topics on which they seem never to agree. Snowball forms a number of Animal Committees, all of which fail. However, he does prove successful at bringing a degree of literacy to the animals, who learn to read according to their varied intelligences. To help the animals understand the general precepts of Animalism, Snowball reduces the Seven

Commandments to a single slogan: "Four legs good, two legs bad." Napoleon, meanwhile, focuses his energy on educating the youth and takes the infant pups of Jessie and Bluebell away from their mothers, presumably for educational purposes.

The animals learn that the cows' milk and windfallen apples are mixed every day into the pigs' mash. When the animals object, Squealer explains that the pigs need the milk and apples to sustain themselves as they work for the benefit of all the other animals.

As summer ends and news of the rebellion spreads to other farms (by way of pigeons released by Snowballand Napoleon), Jones spends most of his time in a pub, complaining about his troubles to two neighbouring farmers: Pilkington and Jones; Frederick.

In October, Jones and a group of men arrive at Animal Farm and attempt to seize control of it. Snowball turns out to be an extraordinary tactician and, with the help of the other animals, drives Jones and his men away. The animals then celebrate their victory in what they call "The Battle of the Cowshed."

During the following year, the animals work harder than ever before. Building the windmill is a laborious business, and Boxer proves himself a model of physical strength and dedication. Napoleon announces that Animal Farm will begin trading with neighbouring farms and hires Mr. Whymper, a solicitor, to act as his agent. Other humans meet in pubs and discuss their theories that the windmill will collapse and that Animal Farm will go bankrupt. Jones gives up his attempts at retaking his farm and moves to another part of the county. The pigs move into the farmhouse and begin sleeping in beds, which Squealer excuses on the grounds that the pigs need their rest after the daily strain of running the farm.

That November, a storm topples the half-finished windmill. Napoleon tells the animals that Snowball is responsible for its ruin and offers a reward to any animal who kills Snowball or brings him back alive. Napoleon then declares that they will begin rebuilding the windmill that very morning.

As the human world watches Animal Farm and waits for news of its failure, the animals struggle against starvation. Napoleon uses Mr. Whymper to spread news of Animal Farm's sufficiency to the human world. After learning that they must surrender their eggs, the hens

stage a demonstration that only ends when they can no longer live without the rations that Napoleon had denied them. Nine hens die as a result of the protest.

The animals are led to believe that Snowball is visiting the farm at night and spitefully subverting their labour. He becomes a constant (and imagined) threat to the animals' security, and Squealer eventually tells the animals that Snowball has sold himself to Frederick and that he was in league with Jones from the very beginning.

One day in spring, Napoleon calls a meeting of all the animals, during which he forces confessions from all those who had questioned him (such as the four pigs in Chapters 5 and 6 and the three hens who lead the protest) and then has them murdered by the dogs. Numerous animals also confess to crimes that they claim were instigated by Snowball. Eventually, the singing of "Beasts of England" is outlawed and a new song by Minimus, Napoleon's pig-poet, is instituted, although the animals do not find the song as meaningful as their previous anthem.

The following year brings more work on the windmill and less food for the workers, despite Squealer's lists of figures supposedly proving that food production has increased dramatically under Napoleon's rule. As Napoleon grows more powerful, he is seen in public less often. The general opinion of him is expressed in a poem by Minimus that lists his merits and virtues. More executions occur while Napoleon schemes to sell a pile of timber to Frederick — who is alternately rumored to be a sadistic torturer of animals and the victim of unfounded gossip.

After the completion of the new windmill in August, Napoleon sells the pile of timber to Frederick, who tries to pay with a check. Napoleon, however, demands cash, which he receives. Whymper then learns that Frederick's banknotes are forgeries, and Napoleon pronounces the death sentence on the traitorous human.

The next morning, Frederick and 14 men arrive at Animal Farm and attempt to take it by force. Although the humans are initially successful, after they blow up the windmill, the animals are completely enraged and drive the men from the farm. Squealer explains to the bleeding animals that, despite what they may think, they were actually victorious in what will hereafter be called "The Battle of the Windmill."

Some days later, the pigs discover a case of whisky in Jones' cellar. After drinking too much of it, Napoleon fears he is dying and decrees that the drinking of alcohol is punishable by death. Two days later, however, Napoleon feels better and orders the small paddock (which was to have been used as a retirement-home for old animals) to be ploughed and planted with barley. The chapter ends with Muriel rereading the Seven Commandments and noticing, for the first time, that the Fifth Commandment now reads, "No animal shall drink alcohol to excess."

After celebrating their so-called victory against Frederick, the animals begin building a new windmill. Their efforts are again led by Boxer who, despite his split hoof, insists on working harder and getting the windmill started before he retires.

Food supplies continue to diminish, but Squealer explains that they actually have more food and better lives than they have ever known. The four sows litter 31 piglets; Napoleon, the father of all of them, orders a schoolroom to be built for their education. Meanwhile, more and more of the animals' rations are reduced while the pigs continue to grow fatter. Animal Farm is eventually proclaimed a Republic, and Napoleon is elected President.

Once his hoof heals, Boxer works as hard as he can at building the windmill — until the day he collapses because of a lung ailment. After he is helped back to his stall, Squealer informs them that Napoleon has sent for the veterinarian at Willingdon to treat him. When the van arrives to take Boxer to the hospital, however, Benjamin reads its side and learns that Boxer is actually being taken to a knacker, or glue-boiler. Clover screams to Boxer to escape, but the old horse is too weak to kick his way out of the van, which drives away. Boxer is never seen again. To placate the animals, Squealer tells them that Boxer was not taken to a knacker but that the veterinarian had bought the knacker's truck and had not yet repainted the words on its side. The animals are relieved when they hear this. The chapter ends with a grocer's van delivering a crate of whisky to the pigs, who drink it all and do not arise until after noon the following day.

Years pass, and Animal Farm undergoes its final changes. Muriel, Bluebell, Jessie, and Pincher are all dead, and Jones dies in an inebriates' home. Clover is now 14 years old (two years past the retiring age) but has not retired. (No animal ever has.) There are more animals on the farm, and the farm's boundaries have increased, thanks to the purchase of two of Pilkington's fields. The second windmill has been completed and is used for milling corn.

All the animals continue their lives of hard work and little food — except, of course, for the pigs.

One evening, Clover sees a shocking sight: Squealer walking on his hind legs. Other pigs follow, walking the same way, and Napoleon also emerges from the farmhouse carrying a whip in his trotter. The sheep begin to bleat a new version of their previous slogan: "Four legs good, two legs better!" Clover also notices that the wall on which the Seven Commandments were written has been repainted: Now, the wall simply reads, "ALL ANIMALS ARE EQUAL / BUT SOME ANIMALS ARE MORE EQUAL THAN OTHERS." Eventually, all the pigs begin carrying whips and wearing Jones' clothes.

In the novel's final scene, a deputation of neighboring farmers are given a tour of the farm, after which they meet in the dining-room of the farmhouse with Napoleon and the other pigs. Mr. Pilkington makes a toast to Animal Farm and its efficiency. Napoleon then offers a speech in which he outlines his new policies: The word "comrade" will be suppressed, there will be no more Sunday meetings, the skull of old Major has been buried, and the farm flag will be changed to a simple field of green. His greatest change in policy, however, is his announcement that Animal Farm will again be called Manor Farm. Soon after Napoleon's speech, the men and pigs begin playing cards, but a loud quarrel erupts when both Napoleon and Pilkington each try to play the ace of spades. As Clover and the other animals watch the arguments through the dining-room window, they are unable to discriminate between the humans and the pigs.

4. George Orwell: Animal Farm: Summary and Theme.

The Corruption of Socialist Ideals in the Soviet Union

Animal Farm is most famous in the West as a stinging critique of the history and rhetoric of the Russian Revolution. Retelling the story of the emergence and development of Soviet communism in the form of an animal fable, *Animal Farm* allegorizes the rise to power of the dictator Joseph Stalin. In the novella, the overthrow of the human oppressor Mr. Jones by a democratic coalition of animals quickly gives way to the consolidation of power among the pigs. Much like the Soviet intelligentsia, the pigs establish themselves as the ruling class in the new society.

The struggle for preeminence between Leon Trotsky and Stalin emerges in the rivalry between the pigs Snowball and Napoleon. In both the historical and fictional cases, the idealistic but politically less powerful figure (Trotsky and Snowball) is expelled from the revolutionary state by the malicious and violent usurper of power (Stalin and Napoleon). The purges and show trials with which Stalin eliminated his enemies and solidified his political base find expression in *Animal Farm* as the false confessions and executions of animals whom Napoleon distrusts following the collapse of the windmill. Stalin's tyrannical rule and eventual abandonment of the founding principles of the Russian Revolution are represented by the pigs' turn to violent government and the adoption of human traits and behaviors, the trappings of their original oppressors.

Although Orwell believed strongly in socialist ideals, he felt that the Soviet Union realized these ideals in a terribly perverse form. His novella creates its most powerful ironies in the moments in which Orwell depicts the corruption of Animalist ideals by those in power. For *Animal Farm* serves not so much to condemn tyranny or despotism as to indict the horrifying hypocrisy of tyrannies that base themselves on, and owe their initial power to, ideologies of liberation and equality. The gradual disintegration and perversion of the Seven Commandments illustrates this hypocrisy with vivid force, as do Squealer's elaborate philosophical justifications for the pigs' blatantly unprincipled actions. Thus, the novella critiques the violence of the Stalinist regime against the human beings it ruled, and also points to Soviet communism's violence against human logic, language, and ideals.

The Societal Tendency toward Class Stratification

Animal Farm offers commentary on the development of class tyranny and the human tendency to maintain and reestablish class structures even in societies that allegedly stand for total equality. The novella illustrates how classes that are initially unified in the face of a common enemy, as the animals are against the humans, may become internally divided when that enemy is eliminated. The expulsion of Mr. Jones creates a power vacuum, and it is only so long before the next oppressor assumes totalitarian control. The natural division between intellectual and physical labor quickly comes to express itself as a new set of class divisions, with the "brainworkers" (as the pigs claim to be) using their superior intelligence to manipulate society to their own benefit. Orwell never clarifies in *Animal Farm* whether this negative state of affairs constitutes an inherent aspect of society or merely an outcome contingent on the integrity of a society's intelligentsia. In either case, the novella points to the

force of this tendency toward class stratification in many communities and the threat that it poses to democracy and freedom.

The Danger of a Naïve Working Class

One of the novella's most impressive accomplishments is its portrayal not just of the figures in power but also of the oppressed people themselves. *Animal Farm* is not told from the perspective of any particular character, though occasionally it does slip into Clover's consciousness. Rather, the story is told from the perspective of the common animals as a whole. Gullible, loyal, and hardworking, these animals give Orwell a chance to sketch how situations of oppression arise not only from the motives and tactics of the oppressors but also from the naïveté of the oppressed, who are not necessarily in a position to be better educated or informed. When presented with a dilemma, Boxer prefers not to puzzle out the implications of various possible actions but instead to repeat to himself, "Napoleon is always right." *Animal Farm* demonstrates how the inability or unwillingness to question authority condemns the working class to suffer the full extent of the ruling class's oppression.

The Abuse of Language as Instrumental to the Abuse of Power

One of Orwell's central concerns, both in *Animal Farm* and in *1984,* is the way in which language can be manipulated as an instrument of control. In *Animal Farm,* the pigs gradually twist and distort a rhetoric of socialist revolution to justify their behavior and to keep the other animals in the dark. The animals heartily embrace Major's visionary ideal of socialism, but after Major dies, the pigs gradually twist the meaning of his words. As a result, the other animals seem unable to oppose the pigs without also opposing the ideals of the Rebellion. By the end of the novella, after Squealer's repeated reconfigurations of the Seven Commandments in order to decriminalize the pigs' treacheries, the main principle of the farm can be openly stated as "all animals are equal, but some animals are more equal than others." This outrageous abuse of the word "equal" and of the ideal of equality in general typifies the pigs' method, which becomes increasingly audacious as the novel progresses. Orwell's sophisticated exposure of this abuse of language remains one of the most compelling and enduring features of *Animal Farm,* worthy of close study even after we have decoded its allegorical characters and events.

5. Vijay Tendulkar: Kanyadaan: Introduction of the author and the text.

The first Marathi playwright who has transformed the regional theatre into the national theatre is Tendulkar. It is observed that Tendulkar has not just contributed to the modern Marathi theatre but has given it a new dimension also. His plays disturb the audience by raising complex issues that remain unsettled even today in the contemporary society. It is subtle and complex nature of his plays that gives him a place of pride in the international galaxy of playwrights. Thus, Tendulkar's theatre may be said to have bridged the gulf between the traditional and the modern Indian theatre. Tendulkar is an individualist and, as such, presents an individual versus society. Thus, he stands for individual freedom. His plays put forth several questions without providing any answer to them. The playwright seeks to present the modern man with his predicament, his challenges, his difficulties, and his complexities. The life seen around is projected as it is and the dramatist makes no effort to moralize or philosophize it. Most of Tendulkar's plays are seen as written in naturalistic vein. He depicts the scenes and situations from the day-today life. While portraying life as it is, his attention is, by and large, focused, not on the happy, gleeful aspects of life but on human weaknesses, follies, and foibles. It is noticed that Tendulkar aims at giving the crude and banal aspects of life a dramatic garb. He uses drama as a means to raise questions rather than to provide solutions, but one cannot term his plays as problem plays like those of Ibsen, Shaw, or Galsworthy, since the plays depict the socio-cultural and political reality of human life.

Kanyadaan (Gift of a Daughter) (1983) is the play for which Vijay Tendulkar was awarded the Saraswati Samman. But for the same play he was criticised and faced the anger of the audience in the form of Chappal throwing when it was staged in Marathi. The spectators considered it as an anti-dalit play and could not find the main purpose of the playwright. So while receiving the award Tendulkar says "As its creator, I respect both Verdicts." "Kanyadaan, is the most controversial play of Vijay Tendulkar. It deals with extremely sensitive social and political issue, namely, the conflict between the upper caste (Savarna) and Dalits, a phenomenon still rampantly prevalent in several parts of India."

If one looks at the play as the last major one by Tendulkar, he seems to be setting his scores with the detractors of Ghashiram Kotwal, In connection with the earlier play, he had to suffer a lot of Public harassment and humiliation for his alleged attack on the orthodox Poona Brahmins during the Peshwa period. The political radicals, of course had no problems with the play. In fact, they were gleefully delighted by Tendulkar's satire on the Brahmin

orthodoxy. The conservatives in their turn had challenged him to write a similar play on the other section of society, and proclaimed that Poona Brahmins, shorn of their age-old eminence and power, were the softest target imaginable. Tendulkar to do him credit, did script a film called "Samana" in which he targeted the co-operative sugar industry, the most powerful political force in Maharashtra. But then the shenanigans of the co-operative sugar barons are far too well known for them to enjoy the iconic status of a Nana Phadnvis and there was no uproar about the film as there was about Ghashiram Kotwal. Now in Kanyadaan, Tendulkar takes on the members of the Poona Brahmin community on to the other side of the political spectrum, as political progressives with socialist leanings. What interests a student of Tendulkar the dramatist is the date of the play, 1983 is a time when, with the impending disintegration of the soviet union and its empire, the Leftist ideology crumbled into the dustbin of history as its internal self-contradictions came to the fore. Now, perhaps, time was ripe to launch an attack on the radicals and their naivette and hypocrisy which were always perceived but not openly pointed out for fear of being termed a reactionary. Tendulkar saw the chance of meeting the challenge thrown at him by the conservatives years before and in the process be with the times, killing, thus, two birds with one stone!" An over idealistic democratic couple, their revolutionary daughter who marries a down caste poet and gets disillusioned in the consequent turn of events due to the unexpectedly barbaric behaviour of her life partner are presented on stage by Tendulkar with a contemporary relevance." Kanyadaan, is a play with two acts, five scenes and it has limited characters. As the title suggests, the play centers around marriage. It is an unusual marriage in the sense that it brings in its wake complex problem – problems at once self-created and unforeseen. Jyoti, the daughter of Nath Devalikar, an MLC who insists on democracy at home, has promised to marry Arun Athavali, a Dalit youth. When she informs her parents, her father is ecstatic, but her mother Seva and brother Jayaprakash are unhappy, after they meet Arun and are shocked by his language and behaviour. Arun's excuse for his attitude is the mistreatment meted out to his family and forefathers at the hands of society. Jyoti's decision to marry Arun leads to a crisis which worsens after marriage, as Arun proves to be a violent husband. Around them, the country too, is marching towards Emergency. At the end, Jyoti is forced to come to terms with her fate as Arun's wife, as she realizes that it is not possible to improve people and change society. Tendulkar has focused on a problem that there is no bridge between the various sections of society and that the attempt to overcome a taboo often leads to greater pitfalls than one can handle.

6. Vijay Tendulkar: Kanyadaan: Analysis and Theme.

The essential theme of Tendulkar's plays is that they present a perplexing, distressing, and complex situation in all seriousness. Its' characters carry no message, in overt or covert terms. He minces no words in moralizing or philosophizing. He presents the existing reality of human predicament, as he perceives it with his own naked eyes. With the treatment of the details of actual life, his plays become more and more realistic. Besides, the ideas put forward in the plays are thought-provoking and revolutionary. Tendulkar's plays manifest his strong dissatisfaction with the prevailing social order. They deal with miseries and sufferings caused by the cruel forces and conventions of society. The world he has projected looks strange or fantastic at times, but it is real. All his articles, stories, and plays reveal that the tone of his writing is realistic, at times satirical and poignant. Inter-caste marriages are a big deal in India, big enough to get you killed, or even worse. Yes, situation is improving and today over 11% marriages are inter-caste, but the problems surrounding it mutate and manage to persist.[7] "Caste is a notion; it is a state of the mind", writes Ambedkar, which prevents us from having a "consciousness of kind". By "consciousness of kind", Ambedkar was invoking the phrase coined by American sociologist Franklin Giddings, who defined it as, "a state of consciousness in which any being, whether low or high in the scale of life, recognises another conscious being as of like kind with itself."

Even among the educated, stereotypes of caste exist in abundance (or stereotypes of 'category', given the fact that for most upper-caste Hindus and other members of the non-reserved section the problem of caste is "felt" only when it concerns the issue of reservations.)

One reason why caste is so deeply embedded within the Indian psyche is because in India, I dare to claim, the "experts" in genetics far outnumber the experts on cricket. Of course, almost every person in the world has his personal views on how and why people are the way they are, but the existence of caste in India makes it more likely that the views will be plain wrong.

The play Kanyadan centers round the theme of marriage. Jyoti, a daughter of the Brahmin activist couple, Nath and Seva, marries Arun, a Dalit poet. She ignores the conditions laid by her mother and brother who fear that she will find it difficult to cope with her marital career. Arun's inhuman treatment to Jyoti, despite her pregnancy, breaks her father Nath. Her father's former admiration for Arun changes now into dislike. But the inhuman beating by

Arun becomes a routine affair with Jyoti. Her marriage turns into a nightmare. The failure of marriage changes her from a simple, sensitive girl into an assertive, determined lady. The play ends with the accusation of her father that it is he who has made her mentally crippled. Jyoti becomes the object of audience's sympathy and Arun that of antipathy. The play Kanyadan also depicts the senseless wastage of Jyoti in fulfilling her father's dreams or idealistic values into reality. The play Kanyadan portrays a middle class progressive family. Impressed by her father's social work, Seva, her mother and Nath, her father Jyoti takes a decision of an inter-caste marriage. Both, her father and mother, are very sincere in their social commitments. However, they differ in their views, opinions, and approaches. Seva works for the problems of Dalits with a conscious mind. She is well 96 aware of the reality of their lives. She objects Jyoti's decision of marrying a Dalit boy and tries her best to give her a caution about the risks in it. But Nath hardly care to think of the prospects of such a marriage. With her father's permission, Jyoti marries Arun and later on faces the evil consequences of her decision as feared by her mother. She follows the dictates of her sentimental, idealistic father and ignores the warnings of her cautious, rational mother, and invites serious threats to her marriage. In the play Kanyadan, Tendulkar exposes the characters that are victims of their sham hollow idealism. While portraying the women characters that play roles as important as Tendulkar shows them exploited, oppressed, and humiliated. Suffering is their lot, their inescapable fate.

All the characters in Tendulkar's plays are the victims either of their evil nature or of hostile circumstances. Bitter experiences in their individual lives leave them frustrated, harsh, and crude, and others tragic. The simple, sensitive, tender-hearted characters suffer miseries calmly and quietly, and the violent, aggressive characters suffer miseries on others as a part of their revenge on society. In the sadist tendencies of the characters can be seen the deterministic overtones of the plays. So, what is remarkable about the Tendulkar's play is neither the story nor the character but the extreme situation reflected of the fate, circumstance, or chance. However, one may see that the characters are, to use existentialist jargon, 'condemned to be free' while they are facing their entrapment or predicament. Tendulkar's plays reflect contemporary Indian society. Most of them are real life incidents. However, the plays are neither subjective nor sentimental in their treatment. In the portrayal of his characters, Tendulkar remains as a detached spectator. Thus, he attains what Keats calls 'negative capability' or what Eliot and Pound call contemporaneity in his plays. Most of Tendulkar's plays deal with the lives of middle class people. He shows something unfamiliar

and strange about them. Nevertheless, they are real also. The plays show man's life is 'cribbed, cabined, and confined'.

One can easily notice that Tendulkar, in his plays, rejects idealized ways of life and attains complete accuracy in presenting 'details of the details', deserted objectivity, and frankness in depicting life as a brutal struggle for survival. He never praises nor blames the 100 characters for the actions within or without their control. Most of the characters and themes are typically middle-class and of working class people we come across in our day to day life. They are motivated by such animalistic drives as sex, hunger, and fear and play out undetermined roles in an atmosphere clouded by depravity, sordidness, and violence.

7. P. B Shelley: To Wordsworth

Introduction to the author P.B Shelley: The life and works of Percy Bysshe Shelley epitomize Romanticism in the two its limits of cheerful delight and agonizing sadness. The real topics are there in Shelley's sensational if short life and in his works, mysterious, moving, and enduring: the eagerness and agonizing, the defiance to power, the exchange with nature, the intensity of the visionary creative mind and of verse, the quest for perfect love, and the untamed soul ever looking for opportunity—these Shelley exemplified in the manner he carried on with his life and live on in the generous collection of work that he left the world after his unbelievable demise by suffocating at age twenty-nine. While Shelley imparts numerous essential subjects and images to his incredible peers, he has left his exceptional stamp on Romanticism: the production of ground-breaking images in his visionary quest for the perfect, in the meantime tempered by a profound distrust. His idea is described by an emphasis on taking the dubious side of issues, even at the danger of being disagreeable and disparaged. From the earliest starting point of his profession as a distributed essayist at the bright age of seventeen, for a mind-blowing duration, and even to the present day the very name of Shelley has evoked either the most grounded fervency or the hottest commendation, verging on love. More than some other English Romantic essayist, with the conceivable exemption of his companion George Gordon, Lord Byron, Shelley's life and notoriety have had a history and life of their own separated from the notoriety of his different works.

Born on 4 August 1792—the time of the Terror in France—Percy Bysshe Shelley (the "Bysshe" from his granddad, a companion of the domain) was the child of Timothy and Elizabeth Shelley. As the senior child among one sibling, John, and four sisters, Elizabeth, Mary, Margaret, and Hellen, Percy remained in line not exclusively to acquire his granddad's significant bequest yet in addition to sit in Parliament one day. In his situation as most established male tyke, youthful Percy was cherished and respected by his sisters, his folks, and even the workers in his initial rule as youthful master of Field Place, the family home close Horsham, Sussex. Lively and creative, he conceived recreations to play with his sisters and recounted to phantom stories to an enrapt and willing-to-be-excited group of spectators. Percy Bysshe Shelley was a persuasive English Romantic artist. He was viewed as a radical both politically and socially. He was great companions with Lord Byron and wedded to Mary Shelley, known for the novel Frankenstein.

However, the idyllic and receptive world of Field Place did not prepare him for the regimented discipline and the taunting boys of Syon House Academy, which Shelley entered in 1802. Here Shelley was subjected to the usual bullying, made all the worse by his failure to control his temper and his poor skills in fighting. The most positive memories Shelley had of his two years at Syon House were undoubtedly of the imaginative and lively lectures of Adam Walker on science-electricity, astronomy, and chemistry-an interest which Shelley retained throughout his life. In Shelley’s free-ranging mind there was no contradiction between an interest in science and an appetite for trashy Gothic romance thrillers, such as Matthew Gregory Lewis’s popular *The Monk*(1795).

The text:

To Wordsworth

Poet of Nature, thou hast wept to know
That things depart which never may return:
Childhood and youth, friendship and love’s first glow,
Have fled like sweet dreams, leaving thee to mourn.
These common woes I feel. One loss is mine
Which thou too feel’st, yet I alone deplore.
Thou wert as a lone star, whose light did shine

On some frail bark in winter's midnight roar:
Thou hast like to a rock-built refuge stood
Above the blind and battling multitude:
In honoured poverty thy voice did weave
Songs consecrate to truth and liberty,—
Deserting these, thou leavest me to grieve,
Thus having been, that thou shouldst cease to be.

Summary of the poem:

Directed toward the poet and man William Wordsworth had become by 1814 with the publication of *The Excursion,* Shelley commences an ironically calculated quatrain that slyly touches upon many of the great themes associated most closely with William Wordsworth: nature, death and loss, nostalgia for the lost innocence of childhood and youth, the bonds of friendship and the excitement of falling in love before bringing down the blade that cuts by asserting that Wordsworth's contemporary work is absent all these things, leaving the aging poet to become someone who now only mourns the loss of these concerns.

And then another slicing cut when Shelley suggests that not just that he feels all the things so described but that in reality they common. The implicit undertone here being one to question Wordsworth's originality. Then he draws back the sword of irony and performs the final cut after asserting that he feels a loss too—which Wordsworth surely shares—but which he alone deplores. This loss will form the basis for the remainder of the poem and essentially teak the form of eulogy for Wordsworth's greatest work and best days which are now forever behind him.

The eulogy cuts two ways with Shelley on the one hand describing Wordsworth as a lone star only to immediately undermine that metaphor with imagery of the light from his star shining upon bare tree in the middle of the night during winter. Wordsworth is then compared to the sturdiness of a refuge carved into rock only for that refuge to be perched above the blind multitudes below. This image sets the stage for Shelley to move his attack on Wordsworth from the literary to the political as he references the poems the young Wordsworth wrote honouring the radical liberalism of the underclass fighting for truth and liberty. The poem ends on the image of Wordsworth having deserted these ideals as he aged into political conservatism. It is the loss of this Wordsworth that Shelley deplores while Wordsworth merely feels the loss of his younger self.

Themes in the poem:

Changing of the Guard

One of the initial themes that Shelley examines in this short poem is the cyclical nature of literary heroes. He admits that Wordsworth is an iconic figure in the opening words by referring to him as “poet of nature.” But his true goal is illuminated in the fact that he uses just one line to list the thematic composition of Wordsworth’ most respected works: Youth, love and friendship. Then the zinger: “These common woes I feel.” In one sweetly fell swoop, Shelley serves to undercut the high prestige enjoyed by Wordsworth by suggesting he, too, writes about those things and, perhaps if no probably, is writing about them at a higher level now than is Wordsworth. Shelley foreshadows the end of the poem here by offering himself as the logical inheritor of the mantle of “poet of nature.”

Eulogy for a Poet Past Him Prime

The middle section of the poet is a brilliant display of Shelley’s masterfully of language. He situates Wordsworth as the reigning king of his time by comparing him to a bright star, a solid fortress and a lion whose voice was enjoyed by the multitudes. But with judicious use of word choice, Wordsworth becomes a lonely star whose light shone in the past, a fortress constructed of rocks subject to weakening and crumbling roaring to crowds suffering blindness. He both builds up Wordsworth as a great figure and subsequently tears him down by the admonition that he was a great thing in the past.

Poetic Apostasy

The eulogy of the greatness now gone comes to a conclusion by concluding that the greatness has died as a result of apostasy on Wordsworth’s part. Wordsworth’s sad contemporary status as a poet past his prime forced to hand over his crown becomes the final edgy section of the poem in which Shelley gives him one last nod to his greatness by reminding him of why he attracted multitudes in the first place: by writing “Songs consecrate to truth and liberty.” Shelley then accuses him of deserting that radical element which made his voice roar so loudly. This desertion of his progressivism is what makes Shelley grieve and in making this decision, Wordsworth now ceases to be. Consider his final words the 18th century Romantic poet version of Shelley telling the very much alive Wordsworth that he is now “dead to me.”

8. Shelley: ‘Prometheus’

Text

Monarch of Gods and Dæmons, and all Spirits
But One, who throng those bright and rolling worlds
Which Thou and I alone of living things
Behold with sleepless eyes! regard this Earth
Made multitudinous with thy slaves, whom thou
Requitest for knee-worship, prayer, and praise,
And toil, and hecatombs of broken hearts,
With fear and self-contempt and barren hope.
Whilst me, who am thy foe, eyeless in hate,
Hast thou made reign and triumph, to thy scorn,
O'er mine own misery and thy vain revenge.
Three thousand years of sleep-unsheltered hours,
And moments aye divided by keen pangs
Till they seemed years, torture and solitude,
Scorn and despair,—these are mine empire:—
More glorious far than that which thou surveyest
From thine unenvied throne, O Mighty God!
Almighty, had I deigned to share the shame
Of thine ill tyranny, and hung not here
Nailed to this wall of eagle-baffling mountain,
Black, wintry, dead, unmeasured; without herb,
Insect, or beast, or shape or sound of life.
Ah me! alas, pain, pain ever, for ever!

No change, no pause, no hope! Yet I endure.
I ask the Earth, have not the mountains felt?
I ask yon Heaven, the all-beholding Sun,
Has it not seen? The Sea, in storm or calm,
Heaven's ever-changing Shadow, spread below,

Have its deaf waves not heard my agony?
Ah me! alas, pain, pain ever, for ever!

The crawling glaciers pierce me with the spears
Of their moon-freezing crystals, the bright chains
Eat with their burning cold into my bones.
Heaven's wingèd hound, polluting from thy lips
His beak in poison not his own, tears up
My heart; and shapeless sights come wandering by,
The ghastly people of the realm of dream,
Mocking me: and the Earthquake-fiends are charged
To wrench the rivets from my quivering wounds
When the rocks split and close again behind:
While from their loud abysses howling throng
The genii of the storm, urging the rage
Of whirlwind, and afflict me with keen hail.
And yet to me welcome is day and night,
Whether one breaks the hoar frost of the morn,
Or starry, dim, and slow, the other climbs
The leaden-coloured east; for then they lead
The wingless, crawling hours, one among whom
—As some dark Priest hales the reluctant victim—
Shall drag thee, cruel King, to kiss the blood
From these pale feet, which then might trample thee
If they disdained not such a prostrate slave.
Disdain! Ah no! I pity thee. What ruin
Will hunt thee undefended through wide Heaven!
How will thy soul, cloven to its depth with terror,
Gape like a hell within! I speak in grief,
Not exultation, for I hate no more,
As then ere misery made me wise. The curse
Once breathed on thee I would recall. Ye Mountains,
Whose many-voicèd Echoes, through the mist
Of cataracts, flung the thunder of that spell!

Ye icy Springs, stagnant with wrinkling frost,
Which vibrated to hear me, and then crept
Shuddering through India! Thou serenest Air,
Through which the Sun walks burning without beams!
And ye swift Whirlwinds, who on poisèd wings
Hung mute and moveless o'er yon hushed abyss,
As thunder, louder than your own, made rock
The orbèd world! If then my words had power,
Though I am changed so that aught evil wish
Is dead within; although no memory be
Of what is hate, let them not lose it now!
What was that curse? for ye all heard me speak.

Summary of the poem: *Prometheus Unbound* by Percy Bysshe Shelley is a lyrical drama told in four acts. In the first act, Prometheus, the Titan, is bound to a rock. When morning dawns, Prometheus cries out against the "Monarch of Gods and Daemons," who is Jupiter (Zeus in the Greek pantheon). As the hawks begin to tear at his flesh for the day, he recounts his suffering and claims that he is greater than Jupiter. The Earth commiserates with him against Jupiter's tyranny. She tells him that there are two realities—the current reality and the shadow reality.

Prometheus summons the Phantasm of Jupiter to restate his curse and then repents, but Mercury—the messenger god—arrives with words from Jupiter and the Furies. He tells Prometheus that Jupiter has willed a new punishment for Prometheus. Mercury offers him pity but reminds him that he has to oppose him because Prometheus opposed Jupiter. Mercury asks Prometheus to reveal the secret that he alone knows—the fate of Jupiter—but Prometheus refuses, even when Mercury offers him freedom and exaltation. Thunder rolls and Mercury leaves; the Furies begin torturing Prometheus by telling him that they attack humankind; for the champion of humankind, this is a great blow indeed, but Prometheus accepts it as part of his martyrdom.

He reflects that even though he would never want to be a mortal, there is a promise of peace with death. Spirits come and speak to Prometheus, proclaiming that he will "quell this horseman grim" because of his secret knowledge.

In act 2, Oceanid Asia summons her sister Panthea. They talk about life since Prometheus's fall. They discuss dreams, and when the Echoes arrive, they follow when beckoned. The Echoes promise that if they do, an unspoken voice will wake in an unknown world. They arrive in a forest among spirits and fauns. From there, they are sent to the cave of the Demogorgon, where Asia questions the Demogorgon about the world's creator. The Demogorgon answers that God created everything, both good and bad. Asia demands the Demogorgon provide her with a name for God. They talk about how Jupiter rules the universe, and how Prometheus gave humans fire, mining knowledge, speech, science, and medicine.

Asia asks when Prometheus will be freed. The cave opens and Demogorgon leaves on his chariot. The Hours come to transport Asia and Panthea. On this journey to a mountaintop, Asia undergoes a change that reveals to her that it is through her love that she discovers paradise.

That is where act 3 takes place—in heaven. Jupiter and the other gods hold court, and Jupiter claims to have conquered everything but the soul of man. He speaks of the rise of Demogorgon, who appears then and says he is Eternity, Jupiter's child—and therefore more powerful than the sky god. At first, Jupiter seeks Eternity's mercy, saying that not even Prometheus would make him suffer. When Eternity does not answer, Jupiter attacks him. However, the elements will not help Jupiter; he falls.

Ocean and Apollo talk about Jupiter's fall. Hercules frees Prometheus, who thanks him. He tells Asia there is a cave where they can be with one another for all time. Earth describes death to Asia, who does not understand at first because she is immortal. Earth summons a spirit to guide Prometheus, Asia, and their friends to a temple that was once dedicated to worshipping Prometheus and tells them that they can live there in that cave. When they arrive, the Hours tell them that since Jupiter's fall, mankind is free. They have abandoned their thrones and live peacefully but not without passion.

In act 4, the spirits of the dead Hours and the human mind rejoice over the peace brought about by the end of Jupiter's tyranny. Panthea and Ione describe a chariot with a winged infant—the Spirit of Earth. The Earth and Moon sing together about the peace and freedom mankind is now experiencing, and how there are no secrets left hidden from them—humans

even control the lightning. The Demogorgon appears and speaks at the end of Prometheus Unbound, to laud Prometheus's victory.

Prometheus Unbound (1820) deals with the aftermath of Prometheus stealing fire from the gods and giving it to humans. Shelley was inspired to write Prometheus Unbound by the classical trilogy of plays known as Prometheia, written by Aeschylus during the height of Ancient Greek power. The great difference between the two works is that in Aeschylus's work, Prometheus and Zeus reconcile; they do not in Shelley's work. Prometheus Unbound is what is known as a closet drama—that is, Shelley never intended it to be performed on stage. It was meant to be performed in the reader's mind's eye.

Themes in the poem:

In the classical story of Prometheus, the Titan is punished by the ruler of the Greek Gods, Zeus, for giving humanity the gift of fire. By giving humans fire Prometheus gives mankind the ability to survive in the wilderness and to make use of the tools of his environment. Fire in the story thus symbolizes knowledge and civilization, while the fact that Prometheus is punished for his gift to mankind has traditionally suggested that providing humans with knowledge is an act of transgression. There are thus clear parallels between Prometheus's story and the Book of Genesis, in which Adam and Eve eat from the tree of knowledge in the Garden of Eden, against God's wishes, and, as a result, bring sin into the world. In his version of *Prometheus Unbound*, however, Shelley draws on both classical and Christian imagery to challenge the idea that knowledge is sinful or transgressive. Instead, his *Prometheus Unbound* suggests that knowledge is something that *helps* humanity because it gives them the capacity to fully understand their own behaviour and, in turn, allows them to freely make wise and moral choices.

Shelley's poem opens on the image of Prometheus chained to the mountain, suffering under the punishment administered by Jupiter (the Roman counterpart of Zeus). This image immediately establishes Prometheus's action of providing humans with knowledge as an affront to the Gods. In fact, the entire first act of *Prometheus Unbound* focuses on Prometheus's torture at the hands of Jupiter, who has ruled supreme over Heaven, the Earth, and mankind since Prometheus's capture. By focusing on Prometheus's punishment rather than his transgression, Shelley highlights Jupiter's cruelty. This helps Shelley to frame Jupiter as the villain of *Prometheus Unbound* and center the rebellious and defiant Prometheus as the hero. This, in turn, positions the gift of knowledge as something worth any cost.

Jupiter's cruelty is further highlighted in Act 2, when Asia, a sea nymph who is Prometheus's wife, explains that Prometheus originally gave knowledge to Jupiter on the condition that the god "let man be free." Jupiter however, enslaved mankind, and as such Prometheus gave human beings knowledge so that they could tame the hostile environment that Jupiter had provided for them. At first, man used this knowledge for good, inventing language, science, and the arts, until Jupiter captured Prometheus and spread his own negative example—of greed, fear and power-lust—among mankind. Asia's description of Prometheus's transgression, and Jupiter's response to it, highlights the fact that what is considered by Jupiter to be a sin actually had a positive effect on humanity and that, although Prometheus is punished like a criminal, he has really acted in humanity's best interests by trying to provide them with knowledge.

However, because Jupiter has bound Prometheus (who symbolizes knowledge and free will) humanity has become misguided and used its knowledge for evil instead of good. By binding Prometheus, Jupiter has placed restrictions on knowledge: though humanity makes use of the tools that knowledge has allowed them to create, they cannot use them effectively for good because they lack the self-knowledge and the free-will to fully comprehend their own behavior. This is in keeping with the fact that, although Shelley was a radical thinker who felt that education was a gift, he was also wary of the effects of unchecked scientific exploration, which was an ever-growing concern in the nineteenth century. Shelley felt that empirical science, with no sense of morals or ethics to underpin it, could lead humanity to disaster. (This is also the theme of *Frankenstein,* written by Mary Shelley, Shelley's wife, which had the subtitle *The Modern Prometheus.)* Shelley's Prometheus suggests that, in the wrong hands, knowledge can be a destructive force as well as a tool of freedom.

Prometheus is the only being in the world whom Jupiter cannot conceal knowledge from, and therefore cannot subdue. Jupiter is thus afraid of Prometheus and the influence that the Titan's guidance would have on humanity, as this would allow humankind to think for themselves and question Jupiter's authority. Ironically, then, although Prometheus is bound, he is truly free from Jupiter's evil influence as he fully understands both the potential evil and the potential good of his actions. As a result, Prometheus is able to choose wisely, with good, rather than evil, in mind.

After Jupiter has fallen, Prometheus is freed by Hercules and a new age of wisdom and freedom is established on earth. Jupiter's fall signifies the liberation of knowledge among

mankind. The Furies previous description of a confused world in which the wise have no love, and the loving have no wisdom, has been defeated and, instead, knowledge mixed with love and compassion is available to all. Celebrating his freedom, Prometheus states that man is also “now free,” explicitly linking his own fate with the whole of humankind’s.

Prometheus anticipates that this liberation of knowledge will lead to the discovery of “arts unimagined” and notes that “man grows wise and kind, and veil by veil, evil and error fall.” This suggests that the result of Prometheus toppling Jupiter has been an increase in knowledge among human beings. Shelley therefore suggests that knowledge, when used with noble aims in mind, is a positive force for mankind and will advance the progress of civilization, potentially alleviating suffering in the world. According to Shelley, it is only by making knowledge fully available to all, and by allowing people the freedom to explore and question beliefs, that humanity can advance as a species—because only then will people have the tools available to choose the wisest course for the greatest good.

9. Alfred Lord Tennyson: Introduction to the author

Born on August 6, 1809, in Somersby, Lincolnshire, England, Alfred Lord Tennyson is one of the most well-adored Victorian writers. Tennyson, the fourth of twelve youngsters, demonstrated an early ability for composing. At twelve years old he composed a 6,000-line epic sonnet. His father, Reverend George Tennyson, coached his children in traditional and current dialects. During the 1820s, in any case, Tennyson's father started to have mental breakdowns that were exacerbated by liquor abuse. One of Tennyson's siblings had vicious squabbles with his father, a second was later limited to a crazy haven, and another turned into an opium someone who is addicted.

Tennyson got away home in 1827 to go to Trinity College, Cambridge. In that equivalent year, he and his sibling Charles distributed Poems by Two Brothers. Despite the fact that the sonnets in the book were generally juvenilia, they pulled in the consideration of the "Messengers," an undergrad abstract club driven by Arthur Hallam. The "Messengers" gave Tennyson, who was colossally modest, with much required kinship and certainty as a writer. Hallam and Tennyson turned into the best of companions; they visited Europe together in 1830 and again in 1832. Hallam's abrupt passing in 1833 incredibly influenced the youthful

artist. The long funeral poem In Memoriam and huge numbers of Tennyson's different ballads are tributes to Hallam.

In 1830, Tennyson distributed Poems, Chiefly Lyrical and in 1832 he distributed a subsequent volume entitled just Poems. A few analysts denounced these books as "influenced" and "darken." Tennyson, stung by the surveys, would not distribute another book for a long time. In 1836, he ended up connected to Emily Sellwood. When he lost his legacy on an awful interest in 1840, Sellwood's family cancelled the commitment. In 1842, nonetheless, Tennyson's Poems in two volumes was a huge basic and prominent achievement. In 1850, with the production of In Memoriam, Tennyson wound up one of Britain's most well known writers. He was chosen Poet Laureate in progression to Wordsworth. In that same year, he married Emily Sellwood. They had two children, Hallam and Lionel.

The Lady of Shalott

At 41 years old, Tennyson had set up himself as the most well known writer of the Victorian time. The cash from his verse (now and again surpassing 10,000 pounds for each year) enabled him to buy a house in the nation and to write in relative disconnection. His appearance—an enormous and hairy man, he normally wore a shroud and a wide overflowed cap—improved his reputation. He read his verse with a blasting voice, regularly contrasted with that of Dylan Thomas. In 1859, Tennyson distributed the primary lyrics of Idylls of the Kings, which sold in excess of 10,000 duplicates in a single month. In 1884, he acknowledged a peerage, getting to be Alfred Lord Tennyson. Tennyson died on October 6, 1892, and was covered in Westminster Abbey.

The Lady of Shalott

Part I

On either side the river lie
Long fields of barley and of rye,
That clothe the wold and meet the sky;
And through the field the road runs by
    To many-towered Camelot;

And up and down the people go,
Gazing where the lilies blow
Round an island there below,
    The island of Shalott.

Willows whiten, aspens quiver,
Little breezes dusk and shiver
Through the wave that runs for ever
By the island in the river
    Flowing down to Camelot.
Four grey walls, and four grey towers,
Overlook a space of flowers,
And the silent isle imbowers
    The Lady of Shalott.

By the margin, willow-veiled,
Slide the heavy barges trailed
By slow horses; and unhailed
The shallop flitteth silken-sailed
    Skimming down to Camelot:
But who hath seen her wave her hand?
Or at the casement seen her stand?
Or is she known in all the land,
    The Lady of Shalott?

Only reapers, reaping early
In among the bearded barley,
Hear a song that echoes cheerly
From the river winding clearly,
    Down to towered Camelot:
And by the moon the reaper weary,
Piling sheaves in uplands airy,
Listening, whispers "'Tis the fairy
    Lady of Shalott."

Part II

There she weaves by night and day
A magic web with colours gay.
She has heard a whisper say,
A curse is on her if she stay
    To look down to Camelot.
She knows not what the curse may be,
And so she weaveth steadily,
And little other care hath she,
    The Lady of Shalott.

And moving through a mirror clear
That hangs before her all the year,
Shadows of the world appear.
There she sees the highway near
    Winding down to Camelot:
There the river eddy whirls,
And there the surly village-churls,
And the red cloaks of market girls,
    Pass onward from Shalott.

Sometimes a troop of damsels glad,
An abbot on an ambling pad,
Sometimes a curly shepherd-lad,
Or long-haired page in crimson clad,
    Goes by to towered Camelot;
And sometimes through the mirror blue
The knights come riding two and two:
She hath no loyal knight and true,
    The Lady of Shalott.

But in her web she still delights
To weave the mirror's magic sights,
For often through the silent nights

A funeral, with plumes and lights
    And music, went to Camelot:
Or when the moon was overhead,
Came two young lovers lately wed;
"I am half sick of shadows," said
    The Lady of Shalott.

Part III

A bow-shot from her bower-eaves,
He rode between the barley-sheaves,
The sun came dazzling through the leaves,
And flamed upon the brazen greaves
    Of bold Sir Lancelot.
A red-cross knight for ever kneeled
To a lady in his shield,
That sparkled on the yellow field,
    Beside remote Shalott.

The gemmy bridle glittered free,
Like to some branch of stars we see
Hung in the golden Galaxy.
The bridle bells rang merrily
    As he rode down to Camelot:
And from his blazoned baldric slung
A mighty silver bugle hung,
And as he rode his armour rung,
    Beside remote Shalott.

All in the blue unclouded weather
Thick-jewelled shone the saddle-leather,
The helmet and the helmet-feather
Burned like one burning flame together,
    As he rode down to Camelot.
As often through the purple night,

Below the starry clusters bright,
Some bearded meteor, trailing light,
    Moves over still Shalott.

His broad clear brow in sunlight glowed;
On burnished hooves his war-horse trode;
From underneath his helmet flowed
His coal-black curls as on he rode,
    As he rode down to Camelot.
From the bank and from the river
He flashed into the crystal mirror,
"Tirra lirra," by the river
    Sang Sir Lancelot.

She left the web, she left the loom,
She made three paces through the room,
She saw the water-lily bloom,
She saw the helmet and the plume,
    She looked down to Camelot.
Out flew the web and floated wide;
The mirror cracked from side to side;
"The curse is come upon me," cried
    The Lady of Shalott.

Part IV

In the stormy east-wind straining,
The pale yellow woods were waning,
The broad stream in his banks complaining,
Heavily the low sky raining
    Over towered Camelot;
Down she came and found a boat
Beneath a willow left afloat,
And round about the prow she wrote
    The Lady of Shalott.

And down the river's dim expanse,
Like some bold seër in a trance
Seeing all his own mischance--
With a glassy countenance
    Did she look to Camelot.
And at the closing of the day
She loosed the chain, and down she lay;
The broad stream bore her far away,
    The Lady of Shalott.

Lying, robed in snowy white
That loosely flew to left and right--
The leaves upon her falling light--
Through the noises of the night
    She floated down to Camelot:
And as the boat-head wound along
The willowy hills and fields among,
They heard her singing her last song,
    The Lady of Shalott.

Heard a carol, mournful, holy,
Chanted loudly, chanted lowly,
Till her blood was frozen slowly,
And her eyes were darkened wholly,
    Turned to towered Camelot.
For ere she reached upon the tide
The first house by the water-side,
Singing in her song she died,
    The Lady of Shalott.

Under tower and balcony,
By garden-wall and gallery,
A gleaming shape she floated by,
Dead-pale between the houses high,
    Silent into Camelot.

Out upon the wharfs they came,
Knight and burgher, lord and dame,
And round the prow they read her name,
    The Lady of Shalott.

Who is this? and what is here?
And in the lighted palace near
Died the sound of royal cheer;
And they crossed themselves for fear,
    All the knights at Camelot:
But Lancelot mused a little space;
He said, "She has a lovely face;
God in his mercy lend her grace,
    The Lady of Shalott."

Summary:

This is a pretty long poem, and a lot goes on, but Tennyson makes it easier to follow along by breaking the action up into four parts. We'll take you through them quickly, to give you an overview:

Part 1: The poem opens with a description of a field by a river. There's a road running through the field that apparently leads to Camelot, the legendary castle of King Arthur. From the road you can see an island in the middle of the river called the Island of Shalott. On that island there is a little castle, which is the home of the mysterious Lady of Shalott. People pass by the island all the time, on boats and barges and on foot, but they never see the Lady. Occasionally, people working in the fields around the island will hear her singing an eerie song.

Part 2: Now we actually move inside the castle on the island, and Tennyson describes the Lady herself. First we learn that she spends her days weaving a magic web, and that she has been cursed, forbidden to look outside. So instead she watches the world go by in a magic mirror. She sees shadows of the men and women who pass on the road, and she weaves the things she sees into her web. We also learn that she is "half sick" of this life of watching and weaving.

Part 3: Now the big event: One day the studly Sir Lancelot rides by the island, covered in jewels and shining armor. Most of this chunk of the poem is spent describing Lancelot. When his image appears in the mirror, the Lady is so completely captivated that she breaks the rule and looks out her window on the real world. When she does this and catches a glimpse of Lancelot and Camelot, the magic mirror cracks, and she knows she's in trouble.

Part 4: Knowing that it's game over, the Lady finds a boat by the side of the river and writes her name on it. After looking at Camelot for a while she lies down in the boat and lets it slip downstream. She drifts down the river, singing her final song, and dies before she gets to Camelot. The people of Camelot come out to see the body of the Lady and her boat, and are afraid. Lancelot also trots out, decides that she's pretty, and says a little prayer for her.

Theme of the poem:

“The Lady of Shalott” has most often been read as an allegory of the artist’s condition in a society indifferent or even hostile to art. The Victorian age was not, by and large, especially sympathetic to art and artists. Many Victorians believed that poetry had had its day and could offer little of use in an age of serious scientific, industrial, and social effort. Put plainly, many Victorians believed that poetry “did” nothing, that it was merely idleness and frippery. Others, perhaps no more sympathetic to the real requirements of the artist, suggested that poetry could justify itself if it celebrated the serious social achievements of the modern age—if, in other words, it put itself to work providing moral edification for the reading masses. Certainly, many of Tennyson’s contemporaries took him to task for writing poems remote in their imaginative wonders from the mundane struggles and triumphs of the passing hour. Tennyson had a strong tendency to idealize the isolated, self-absorbed artist rapt in his visions of unearthly beauty, and this “art for art’s sake” doctrine came in for strong criticism from well-meaning Victorian critics. “The Lady of Shalott” is, in one dimension, Tennyson’s allegorical rejoinder to those utilitarian critics.

In the allegorical scheme, Camelot represents the world of commerce, politics, social responsibility, and daily life. Lancelot himself represents the temptations of worldly fame and power to which the artistic temperament succumbs at its peril. The mirror and the web

represent the arts, and the lady the artist. This schematizing is reductive but not inaccurate, for the poem is at some level almost certainly a dramatization of the artist's desperate condition in a world of commercial energies, democratic sentiment, and mass standardization. The artist, like the lady, is strong only in a world of images, and the price of this strength is isolation. Like the lady, the artist's connection to the busy world of real life can only be tangential; his or her songs are at most overheard in the bustle of politics and business. In an age making insistent demands on the strenuous efforts of individuals in cooperation with social ventures, the artist may inevitably feel misgivings about his self-absorption and isolation, but the artistic temperament also knows that no reconciliation with such a world is possible except at the cost of artistic integrity. Lancelot is desired at the cost of imaginative power.

If this is Tennyson's allegorical view of the artist's position, it is a view far removed from the strong poetic faith of his Romantic predecessors such as Percy Bysshe Shelley and William Wordsworth. The great Romantic poets had believed in the transforming power of poetry. They believed that it was strong enough to act upon the real world and that the poet was a person of might—not so Tennyson, at least not in "The Lady of Shalott." If the lady is Tennyson's allegorized poet, then his poet is hiding out and is imperiled in a world of intractable fact. The lady is no match for the commercial power of Camelot; by comparison, her mirror is fragile and her web tenuous, and she turns from them only to be destroyed.

10. Tennyson: The Lotus Eaters

Text

"Courage!" he said, and pointed toward the land,
"This mounting wave will roll us shoreward soon."
In the afternoon they came unto a land
In which it seemed always afternoon.
All round the coast the languid air did swoon,
Breathing like one that hath a weary dream.
Full-faced above the valley stood the moon;
And like a downward smoke, the slender stream
Along the cliff to fall and pause and fall did seem.

A land of streams! some, like a downward smoke,
Slow-dropping veils of thinnest lawn, did go;
And some thro' wavering lights and shadows broke,
Rolling a slumbrous sheet of foam below.
They saw the gleaming river seaward flow
From the inner land: far off, three mountain-tops,
Three silent pinnacles of aged snow,
Stood sunset-flush'd: and, dew'd with showery drops,
Up-clomb the shadowy pine above the woven copse.

The charmed sunset linger'd low adown
In the red West: thro' mountain clefts the dale
Was seen far inland, and the yellow down
Border'd with palm, and many a winding vale
And meadow, set with slender galingale;
A land where all things always seem'd the same!
And round about the keel with faces pale,
Dark faces pale against that rosy flame,
The mild-eyed melancholy Lotos-eaters came.

Branches they bore of that enchanted stem,
Laden with flower and fruit, whereof they gave
To each, but whoso did receive of them,
And taste, to him the gushing of the wave
Far far away did seem to mourn and rave
On alien shores; and if his fellow spake,
His voice was thin, as voices from the grave;
And deep-asleep he seem'd, yet all awake,
And music in his ears his beating heart did make.

They sat them down upon the yellow sand,
Between the sun and moon upon the shore;
And sweet it was to dream of Fatherland,
Of child, and wife, and slave; but evermore

Most weary seem'd the sea, weary the oar,
Weary the wandering fields of barren foam.
Then some one said, "We will return no more";
And all at once they sang, "Our island home
Is far beyond the wave; we will no longer roam."

Summary

Odysseus tells his mariners to have courage, assuring them that they will soon reach the shore of their home. In the afternoon, they reach a land "in which it seemed always afternoon" because of the languid and peaceful atmosphere. The mariners sight this "land of streams" with its gleaming river flowing to the sea, its three snow-capped mountaintops, and its shadowy pine growing in the vale.

The mariners are greeted by the "mild-eyed melancholy Lotos-eaters," whose dark faces appear pale against the rosy sunset. These Lotos-eaters come bearing the flower and fruit of the lotos, which they offer to Odysseus's mariners. Those who eat the lotos feel as if they have fallen into a deep sleep; they sit down upon the yellow sand of the island and can hardly perceive their fellow mariners speaking to them, hearing only the music of their heartbeat in their ears. Although it has been sweet to dream of their homes in Ithaca, the lotos makes them weary of wandering, preferring to linger here. One who has eaten of the lotos fruit proclaims that he will "return no more," and all of the mariners begin to sing about this resolution to remain in the land of the Lotos-eaters.

The rest of the poem consists of the eight numbered stanzas of the mariners' choric song, expressing their resolution to stay forever. First, they praise the sweet and soporific music of the land of the Lotos-eaters, comparing this music to petals, dew, granite, and tired eyelids. In the second stanza, they question why man is the only creature in nature who must toil. They argue that everything else in nature is able to rest and stay still, but man is tossed from one sorrow to another. Man's inner spirit tells him that tranquility and calmness offer the only joy, and yet he is fated to toil and wander his whole life.

In the third stanza, the mariners declare that everything in nature is allotted a lifespan in which to bloom and fade. As examples of other living things that die, they cite the "folded leaf, which eventually turns yellow and drifts to the earth, as well as the "full-juiced apple," which ultimately falls to the ground, and the flower, which ripens and fades. Next, in the

fourth stanza, the mariners question the purpose of a life of labor, since nothing is cumulative and thus all our accomplishments lead nowhere. They question “what...will last,” proclaiming that everything in life is fleeting and therefore futile. The mariners also express their desire for “long rest or death,” either of which will free them from a life of endless labor.

The fifth stanza echoes the first stanza’s positive appeal to luxurious self-indulgence; the mariners declare how sweet it is to live a life of continuous dreaming. They paint a picture of what it might be like to do nothing all day except sleep, dream, eat lotos, and watch the waves on the beach. Such an existence would enable them peacefully to remember all those individuals they once knew who are now either buried (“heaped over with a mound of grass”) or cremated (“two handfuls of white dust, shut in an urn of brass!”).

In the sixth stanza, the mariners reason that their families have probably forgotten them anyway, and their homes fallen apart, so they might as well stay in the land of the Lotos-eaters and “let what is broken so remain.” Although they have fond memories of their wives and sons, surely by now, after ten years of fighting in Troy, their sons have inherited their property; it will merely cause unnecessary confusion and disturbances for them to return now. Their hearts are worn out from fighting wars and navigating the seas by means of the constellations, and thus they prefer the relaxing death-like existence of the Land of the Lotos to the confusion that a return home would create.

In the seventh stanza, as in the first and fifth, the mariners bask in the pleasant sights and sounds of the island. They imagine how sweet it would be to lie on beds of flowers while watching the river flow and listening to the echoes in the caves. Finally, the poem closes with the mariners’ vow to spend the rest of their lives relaxing and reclining in the “hollow Lotos land.” They compare the life of abandon, which they will enjoy in Lotos land, to the carefree existence of the Gods, who could not care less about the famines, plagues, earthquakes, and other natural disasters that plague human beings on earth. These Gods simply smile upon men, who till the earth and harvest crops until they either suffer in hell or dwell in the “Elysian valleys” of heaven. Since they have concluded that “slumber is more sweet than toil,” the mariners resolve to stop wandering the seas and to settle instead in the land of the Lotos-eaters.

Form

This poem is divided into two parts: the first is a descriptive narrative (lines 1–45), and the second is a song of eight numbered stanzas of varying length (lines 46–173). The first part of

the poem is written in nine-line Spenserian stanzas, so called because they were employed by Spenser in The Fairie Queen. The rhyme scheme of the Spenserian stanza is a closely interlinked *ABABBCBCC,* with the first eight lines in iambic pentameter and the final line an Alexandrine (or line of six iambic feet). The choric song follows a far looser structure: both the line-length and the rhyme scheme vary widely among the eight stanzas.

Commentary

This poem is based on the story of Odysseus's mariners described in scroll IX of Homer's Odyssey Homer writes about a storm that blows the great hero's mariners off course as they attempt to journey back from Troy to their homes in Ithaca. They come to a land where people do nothing but eat lotos (the Greek for our English "lotus"), a flower so delicious that some of his men, upon tasting it, lose all desire to return to Ithaca and long only to remain in the Land of the Lotos. Odysseus must drag his men away so that they can resume their journey home. In this poem, Tennyson powerfully evokes the mariners' yearning to settle into a life of peacefulness, rest, and even death.

The poem draws not only on Homer's *Odyssey*, but also on the biblical Garden of Eden in the Book of Genesis. In the Bible, a "life of toil" is Adam's punishment for partaking of the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge: after succumbing to the temptation of the fruit, Adam is condemned to labor by the sweat of his brow. Yet in this poem, *fruit* (the lotos) provides a *release* from the life of labor, suggesting an inversion of the biblical story.

Tennyson provides a tempting and seductive vision of a life free from toil. His description of the Lotos Land rivals the images of pleasure in Milton's "L'Allegro" and Marvell's "The Garden." Yet his lush descriptive passages are accompanied by persuasive rhetoric; nearly every stanza of the choric song presents a different argument to justify the mariners' resolution to remain in the Lotos Land. For example, in the second stanza of the song the mariners express the irony of the fact that man, who is the pinnacle and apex of creation, is the only creature made to toil and labor all the days of his life. This stanza may also be read as a pointed inversion and overturning of Coleridge's "Work without Hope," in which the speaker laments that "all nature seems at work" while he alone remains unoccupied.

Although the taste of the lotos and the vision of life it offers is seductive, the poem suggests that the mariners may be deceiving themselves in succumbing to the hypnotic power of the flower. Partaking of the lotos involves abandoning external reality and living instead in a world of appearances, where everything "seems" to be but nothing actually is: the Lotos Land emerges as "a land where all things always seemed the same" (line 24). Indeed, the word

“seems” recurs throughout the poem, and can be found in all but one of the opening five stanzas, suggesting that the Lotos Land is not so much a “land of streams” as a “land of seems.” In addition, in the final stanza of the choric song, the poem describes the Lotos Land as a “hollow” land with “hollow” caves, indicating that the vision of the sailors is somehow empty and insubstantial. The reader, too, is left with ambivalent feelings about the mariners’ argument for lassitude. Although the thought of life without toil is certainly tempting, it is also deeply unsettling. The reader’s discomfort with this notion arises in part from the knowledge of the broader context of the poem: Odysseus will ultimately drag his men away from the Lotos Land disapprovingly; moreover, his injunction to have “courage” opens—and then overshadows—the whole poem with a sense of moral opprobrium. The sailors’ case for lassitude is further undermined morally by their complaint that it is unpleasant “to war with evil” (line 94); are they too lazy to do what is right? By choosing the Lotos Land, the mariners are abandoning the sources of substantive meaning in life and the potential for heroic accomplishment. Thus in this poem Tennyson forces us to consider the ambiguous appeal of a life without toil: although all of us share the longing for a carefree and relaxed existence, few people could truly be happy without any challenges to overcome, without the fire of aspiration and the struggle to make the world a better place.

Themes

The Reconciliation of Religion and Science

Tennyson lived during a period of great scientific advancement, and he used his poetry to work out the conflict between religious faith and scientific discoveries. Notable scientific findings and theories of the Victorian period include stratigraphy, the geological study of rock layers used to date the earth, in 1811; the first sighting of an asteroid in 1801 and galaxies in the 1840s; and Darwin’s theory of evolution and natural selection in 1859. In the second half of the century, scientists, such as Fülöp Semmelweis, Joseph Lister, and Louis Pasteur, began the experiments and work that would eventually lead to germ theory and our modern understanding of microorganisms and diseases. These discoveries challenged traditional religious understandings of nature and natural history.

For most of his career, Tennyson was deeply interested in and troubled by these discoveries. His poem “Locksley Hall” (1842) expresses his ambivalence about technology and scientific progress. There the **Speaker** feels tempted to abandon modern civilization and return to a savage life in the jungle. In the end, he chooses to live a civilized, modern life and

enthusiastically endorses technology. *In Memoriam* connects the despair Tennyson felt over the loss of his friend Arthur Hallam and the despair he felt when contemplating a godless world. In the end, the poem affirms both religious faith and faith in human progress. Nevertheless, Tennyson continued to struggle with the reconciliation of science and religion, as illustrated by some of his later work. For example, "Locksley Hall Sixty Years After" (1886) takes as its protagonist the speaker from the original "Locksley Hall," but now he is an old man, who looks back on his youthful optimism and faith in progress with scorn and skepticism.

The Virtues of Perseverance and Optimism

After the death of his friend Arthur Hallam, Tennyson struggled through a period of deep despair, which he eventually overcame to begin writing again. During his time of mourning, Tennyson rarely wrote and, for many years, battled alcoholism. Many of his poems are about the temptation to give up and fall prey to pessimism, but they also extol the virtues of optimism and discuss the importance of struggling on with life. The need to persevere and continue is the central theme of :In Memoriam" and "Ulysses" (1833), both written after Hallam's death. Perhaps because of Tennyson's gloomy and tragic childhood, perseverance and optimism also appear in poetry written before Hallam's death, such as "The Lotos-Eaters" (1832, 1842). Poems such as "The Lady of Shalott" (1832, 1842) and "The Charge of the Light Brigade" (1854) also vary this theme: both poems glorify characters who embrace their destinies in life, even though those destinies end in tragic death. The Lady of Shalott leaves her seclusion to meet the outer world, determined to seek the love that is missing in her life. The cavalrymen in "The Charge of the Light Brigade" keep charging through the valley toward the Russian cannons; they persevere even as they realize that they will likely die.

The Glory of England

Tennyson used his poetry to express his love for England. Although he expressed worry and concern about the corruption that so dominated the nineteenth century, he also wrote many poems that glorify nineteenth-century England. "The Charge of the Light Brigade" praises the fortitude and courage of English soldiers during a battle of the Crimean War in which roughly 200 men were killed. As poet laureate, Tennyson was required to write poems for specific state occasions and to dedicate verse to Queen Victoria and her husband, Prince Albert. Nevertheless, Tennyson praised England even when not specifically required to do so.

In the “ Idylls of the King”, Tennyson glorified England by encouraging a collective English cultural identity: all of England could take pride in Camelot, particularly the chivalrous and capable knights who lived there. Indeed, the modern conception of Camelot as the source of loyalty, chivalry, and romance comes, in part, from Tennyson’s descriptions of it in the “ Idylls of the King” and “The Lady of Shalott.”

Jane Eyre

INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF CHARLOTTE BRONTE

Charlotte Brontë's father was a rural clergyman. She lost her mother when she was five years old. Brontë's two older sisters—Maria and Elizabeth—died from an illness that they likely contracted at their harsh boarding school. Though outwardly plain, Brontë had an active imaginative life, writing stories of an elaborate fantasy world called Angria. Brontë's first of four novels—*Jane Eyre*—was immediately and widely popular, and brought her into London literary circles. Her sisters Emily and Anne were also successful novelists. After losing all of her siblings to illness, Brontë married a clergyman she respected, but did not love. She died at 38 of complications during her first pregnancy.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The Victorian period brought sweeping changes across British society, and writers like Brontë explored its crises and progress. Abroad, the British expanded into a global empire that brought wealth from colonies. With the Industrial Revolution at home, manufacturing became Britain's economic backbone. As the middle class found lucrative opportunities, a new laboring class struggled for wages, job security, and adequate working and living conditions. *Jane Eyre* includes themes of reforms that emerged from the crisis: better political representation, working conditions, and education. Few of these reforms came immediately for women, who had limited status in Victorian society. As Jane strives for economic and personal independence, she touches on the issues of class, economics, and gender roles that affected Victorian Britain at large.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

The most popular literary form in the Victorian period was the novel, and *Jane Eyre* illustrates many of its defining characteristics: social relevance, plain style, and the narrative of an individual's inner thoughts. *Jane Eyre* is indebted to earlier Gothic novels, with its mysteries, supernatural events, and picturesque scenery. But as Jane matures, her autobiography likewise takes on Victorian themes and characteristics. *Jane Eyre* is a *Bildungsroman*, or a coming-of-age story, in which the protagonist's aspirations are set against the pressures and expectations of society. Victorian novels, including *Jane Eyre*, depict social panoramas with characters representing different economic and social classes, as well as gender differences. Brontë uses Jane's marriage as a metaphor for resolving England's political issues. Victorian novels with similar styles and goals include Charles Dickens' semi-autobiographical coming-of-age story, *David Copperfield* (1849-50), and Elizabeth Gaskell's *Mary Barton* (1848) and *North and South* (1855).

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *Jane Eyre: An Autobiography*
- **When Written:** 1847
- **Literary Period:** Victorian
- **Genre:** Victorian novel. *Jane Eyre* combines Gothic mystery, a romantic marriage plot, and a coming-of-age story.
- **Setting:** Northern England in the early 1800s.
- **Climax:** Jane telepathically hears Rochester's voice calling out to her.
- **Point of View:** First person. Jane recounts her story ten years after its ending.

EXTRA CREDIT

Bells and Brontës: The Brontës became a literary powerhouse when Charlotte, Emily, and Anne all wrote successful first novels. Each sister published under a masculine-sounding pseudonym based on their initials. Charlotte Brontë became "Currer Bell"; Emily Brontë wrote *Wuthering Heights* (1845-46) as "Ellis Bell", and Anne Brontë published *Agnes Gray* (1847) as "Acton Bell." Women could enter the marketplace as writers and novelists, but many writers, including the Brontës and Mary Anne Evans ("George Eliot"), used male pseudonyms to keep from being dismissed as unimportant.

PLOT SUMMARY

Jane Eyre is an orphaned girl living with her aunt Mrs. Reed at Gateshead Hall. Mrs. Reed and her children treat Jane cruelly, and look down on her as a dependent. Punishing her for a fight with her cousin that she didn't start, Mrs. Reed locks her in a red room where Jane's uncle, Mr. Reed, had died years before. His ghostly presence terrifies Jane. Soon after, Mrs. Reed sends Jane to the Lowood Institution, a charity school run by the hypocritical Mr. Brocklehurst. Lowood has terrible conditions and a harsh work ethic, though the compassionate supervisor, Maria Temple, intervenes sometimes to give the girls a break. At Lowood, Jane makes friends with another student, Helen Burns, who helps Jane learn to endure personal injustice and believe in a benevolent God. Helen, however, is sick with consumption and dies. When a typhus epidemic decimates the school's student population, new management takes over and improves Lowood's conditions. Jane flourishes under her newly

considerate teachers, and after six years, becomes a teacher herself.

Ms. Temple marries and leaves Lowood, and the eighteen-year-old Jane advertises for a job as a private tutor. She is hired to become the governess of the young Adèle Varens. Adèle is the ward of Mr. Rochester—the older, swarthy, and commanding master of Thornfield Hall. While in residence at Thornfield, Jane frequently hears strange laughter, and one night rescues Mr. Rochester from a fire in his bedroom. On another occasion, Jane helps Mr. Rochester secretly bandage and send away a man named Mr. Mason who was slashed and bitten on the third floor of the Mansion. Rochester blames a quirky servant, Grace Poole, but Jane is skeptical.

Mr. Rochester brings a party of English aristocrats to Thornfield, including the beautiful but calculating Blanche Ingram. She aims to marry him, but Mr. Rochester turns Blanche away, as he is increasingly drawn to the plain, but clever and direct Jane. Mr. Rochester soon asks Jane to marry him. Jane, who has gradually fallen in love with Rochester, accepts. Rochester hastily prepares the wedding. But during the small ceremony, a London lawyer intervenes and declares that Mr. Rochester already has a wife—Bertha Mason from the West Indies. Her brother, Mr. Mason, appears to confirm this. Mr. Rochester reluctantly admits to it, and takes everyone to the third floor, where Bertha is revealed as a raving lunatic, looked after by Grace Poole. Rochester was tricked into the marriage and he appeals to Jane to come away with him anyway, but Jane refuses to be his mistress. After a dream that warns her to flee temptation, Jane sneaks away from Thornfield at dawn.

Penniless in a region of England she does not know, Jane experiences three bitter days of begging, sleeping outside, and nearly starving. Eventually she comes upon and is taken in at Moor House—the home of Mary, Diana, and St. John Rivers, a stern local clergyman. St. John gives Jane a position teaching in a rural school. Jane discovers that an uncle she's never met has died and left her 20,000 pounds. That uncle turns out to be related to the Rivers siblings, so Jane suddenly has cousins. In her joy at finding family, she divides her fortune equally between them.

St. John has plans to go to India as a missionary, and he proposes marriage to Jane so she'll accompany and work for him. Jane feels familial affection but no love for St. John. She says she would go as St. John's sister, but he will accept no conditions. St. John's forceful personality almost convinces Jane to sacrifice herself and marry him. But in her confused emotional state, Jane experiences a telepathic flash: she hears Rochester's voice calling to her. She immediately leaves to seek out Rochester.

Jane finds Thornfield Hall destroyed from a fire that Bertha had set in Jane's old bedroom. During the blaze, Bertha had jumped from the roof and died. Rochester saved his servants, but suffered injuries that left him blind and missing a hand. Jane meets the humbled Rochester at Ferndean, his woodland retreat, and promises always to take care of him. They marry, bring back Adèle from boarding school, and have a son. Rochester eventually regains sight in one eye.

CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Jane Eyre — The protagonist and narrator, Jane is an orphaned girl caught between class boundaries, financial situations, and her own conflicted feelings. In her youth and again as a governess, Jane must depend on others for support. Jane feels isolated, and strives for her personal freedom and meaningful connections with others—to find the loving family she never had. Jane is intelligent, imaginative, and principled. She defies many restrictive social conventions, especially those affecting women. As the novel progresses, Jane learns to temper her passions with self-control—she controls her feelings with judgment based on self-respect and Christian humility. She must reconcile her contradictory desires to be both independent and to serve a strong-willed man. Religion helps Jane to gain a mature understanding of herself as a self-respecting individual who credits her feelings, but also defers to God.

Edward Fairfax Rochester — The wealthy master of Thornfield Hall and Jane's employer and, later, her husband. Over the course of his life, he grows from a naive young man, to a bitter playboy in Europe, to a humble yet still strong man worthy of Jane. Both share similar virtues and seek their personal redemption. Yet Rochester errs in giving more rein to his feelings than his judgment and in expecting the world to submit to his will, as when he tries to marry Jane while still concealing Bertha and his secrets. In his distress after losing his eyesight, Rochester comes to accept his need of guidance and respect for God. His final strength comes from his newfound humility.

St. John Rivers — A parson with two sisters at Moor House, and Jane's cousin. Much like Jane, St. John is a restless character, searching for a place and purpose in life. Like Mr. Rochester, St. John has a commanding personality, but the two men contrast in their range of feelings. St. John relinquishes worldly happiness for a commitment to his religious principles. His stern religious faith makes him self-denying and cold.

Bertha Mason — Rochester's insane Creole wife from Jamaica who is locked away on the third floor of Thornfield. Bertha is portrayed less as a human being than as a Gothic monster or a vampire. Because of her Creole or mixed race parentage, Bertha reveals Victorian prejudices about other ethnicities. She represents Rochester's monstrous secrets.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Adèle Varens — Jane's young pupil at Thornfield, who is Mr. Rochester's ward. As Jane reforms Adèle's "French" characteristics with an English education, she symbolically restores Mr. Rochester's morality from his previous lifestyle.

Céline Varens — Adèle's mother, Céline Varens is a flirty French singer who was also Mr. Rochester's mistress. As Rochester's mistress, Céline was essentially a hired woman, submitting to the shallow status of a dependent. She represents the opposite of what Jane wants in her relationship.

Blanche Ingram — A beautiful socialite who wants to marry Mr. Rochester. Blanche embodies the shallow and class-prejudiced woman of the old aristocracy.

Rosamond Oliver — A rich and beautiful woman who supports Jane's school at Morton. She loves St. John, but marries a wealthy man when it becomes clear that St. John's focus is on his missionary work.

Diana and Mary Rivers — Jane's cousins and St. John's sisters. Similar to Jane in intellect and personality, they show Jane heartfelt compassion that contrasts with St. John's more dutiful sense of charity.

Mrs. Fairfax — The housekeeper at Thornfield Hall.

Grace Poole — The mysterious servant at Thornfield who watches over Bertha Mason. Her name suggests religious grace, which Rochester cannot find until Bertha's suicide.

Richard Mason — The timid brother of Bertha Mason, and Rochester's former business partner in Jamaica.

John Eyre — Jane and the Rivers' uncle. A successful wine merchant who leaves Jane an inheritance of 20,000 pounds.

Uncle Reed — As Jane's maternal uncle, he adopts the orphaned Jane and makes his wife promise to care for her as their own child.

Mrs. Reed — Jane's aunt by marriage, and the matron of Gateshead Hall. Mrs. Reed feels threatened by Jane, who has superior qualities to her own children. Mrs. Reed represents the anxiety of a wealthy and conservative social class, which acts defensively to protect itself from independent minds like Jane's.

John Reed — Mrs. Reed's son, and a bully.

Georgiana Reed — A spoiled daughter of Mrs. Reed, and later a superficial socialite.

Eliza Reed — Mrs. Reed's third child, who is more reserved and stern than her siblings.

Bessie Lee — A house servant of Mrs. Reed, Bessie is the only person at Gateshead to treat Jane with any kindness.

Mr. Lloyd — An apothecary.

Mr. Brocklehurst — The parson and hypocritical overseer of Lowood Institution. Mr. Brocklehurst advocates a severe religious program of self-improvement—denying the body to save the soul. But unlike St. John Rivers, the pampered Mr. Brocklehurst does not practice what he preaches.

Maria Temple — The headmistress of Lowood school. Ms. Temple serves as a mother figure and a model of intellectual refinement, gentle authority, and emotional sensibility for Jane and Helen. Both girls feel a deep connection to Ms. Temple.

Helen Burns — Jane's best friend at Lowood, and a model of personal strength and even temperament for Jane. Helen is a withdrawn intellectual with an optimistic religious view of universal salvation that contrasts with St. John's beliefs.

Miss Scatcherd — A cruel teacher at Lowood school.

Miss Abbot — A servant at Gateshead.

Mr. Briggs – The lawyer who, during Jane's first wedding ceremony with Rochester, reveals that Rochester is already married to Bertha Mason.

THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.

LOVE, FAMILY, AND INDEPENDENCE

As an orphan at Gateshead, Jane is oppressed and dependent. For Jane to discover herself, she must break out of these restrictive conditions and find love and independence. Jane must have the freedom to think and feel, and she seeks out other independent-minded people as the loving family she craves. Jane, Helen Burns, and Ms. Temple enjoy a deep mutual respect, and form emotional bonds that anticipate the actual family Jane finds in Mary and Diana Rivers. Yet Jane also has a natural instinct toward submission. When she leaves Lowood to find new experiences, she describes herself as seeking a "new servitude." In her relationship with men, she has the inclination toward making first Rochester and then St. John her "master."

Over the course of the novel, Jane strives to find a balance between service and mastery. Jane blends her freedom with her commitments to love, virtue, and self-respect. At the end, Jane is both guide and servant to Rochester. She finds and creates her own family, and their love grows out of the mutual respect of free minds.

SOCIAL CLASS AND SOCIAL RULES

Life in 19th-century Britain was governed by social class, and people typically stayed in the class into which they were born. Both as an orphan at Gateshead and as a governess at Thornfield, Jane holds a

position that is *between* classes, and interacts with people of every level, from working-class servants to aristocrats. Jane's social mobility lets Brontë create a vast social landscape in her novel in which she examines the sources and consequences of class boundaries. For instance, class differences cause many problems in the love between Jane and Rochester. Jane must break through class prejudices about her standing, and make people recognize and respect her personal qualities. Brontë tries to illustrate how personal virtues are better indicators of character than class.

Yet the novel doesn't entirely endorse breaking every social rule. Jane refuses, for instance, to become Rochester's mistress despite the fact that he was tricked into a loveless marriage. Jane recognizes that how she sees herself arises at least partly out of how society sees her, and is unwilling to make herself a powerless outcast for love.



GENDER ROLES

In 19th-century England, gender roles strongly influenced people's behavior and identities, and women endured condescending attitudes about a woman's place, intelligence, and voice. Jane has an uphill battle to become independent and recognized for her personal qualities. She faces off with a series of men who do not respect women as their equals. Mr. Brocklehurst, Rochester, and St. John all attempt to command or master women. Brontë uses marriage in the novel to portray the struggle for power between the sexes. Even though Bertha Mason is insane, she is a provocative symbol of how married women can be repressed and controlled. Jane fends off marriage proposals that would squash her identity, and strives for equality in her relationships. For its depiction of Jane's struggle for gender equality, *Jane Eyre* was considered a radical book in its day.



RELIGION

Religion and spirituality are key factors in how characters develop in the novel. Jane matures partly because she learns to follow Christian lessons and resist temptation. Helen Burns introduces Jane to the New Testament, which becomes a moral guidepost for Jane throughout her life. As Jane develops her relationship with God, Mr. Rochester must also reform his pride, learn to pray, and become humble. Brontë depicts different forms of religion: Helen trusts in salvation; Eliza Reed becomes a French Catholic nun; and St. John preaches a gloomy Calvinist faith. The novel attempts to steer a middle course. In Jane, Brontë sketches a virtuous faith that does not consume her individual personality. Jane is self-respecting and religious, but also exercises her freedom to love and feel.



FEELING VS. JUDGMENT

Just as *Jane Eyre* can be described as Jane's quest to balance her contradictory natural instincts toward independence and submission, it can also be described as her quest to find a balance between passionate feeling on the one had and judgment, or repression of those feelings, on the other. Through the examples of other characters in the novel, such as Eliza and Georgiana, Rochester and St. John—or Bertha, who has no control over her emotions at all—*Jane Eyre* shows that it's best to avoid either extreme. Passion makes a person silly, frivolous or even dangerous, while repression makes a person cold. Over the course of the novel, Jane learns how to create a balance between her feelings and her judgment, and to create a life of love that is also a life of serious purpose.



THE SPIRITUAL AND THE SUPERNATURAL

Brontë uses many themes of Gothic novels to add drama and suspense to *Jane Eyre*. But the novel isn't just a ghost story because Brontë also reveals the *reasons* behind supernatural events. For instance, Mr. Reed's ghost in the red-room is a figment of Jane's stressed-out mind, while Bertha is the "demon" in Thornfield. In *Jane Eyre*, the effects of the supernatural matter more than the causes. The supernatural allows Brontë to explore her characters' psyches, especially Jane's inner fears. The climactic supernatural moment in the novel occurs when Jane and Rochester have a telepathic connection. In the text, Jane makes it clear that the connection was not supernatural to her. Instead, she considers that moment a mysterious spiritual connection. Brontë makes their telepathy part of her conceptions of love and religion.

SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



THE RED-ROOM

The red-room symbolizes how society traps Jane by limiting her freedom due to her class, gender, and independent streak.



FIRE AND ICE

Fire is a symbol of emotion in the novel. Mr. Rochester has a fiery personality, while St. John is associated with ice and snow, symbolizing his dispassionate character. Jane draws arctic scenes in her portfolio that symbolize death. She wants the vitality that fire brings, but also

to keep it under control. On the other hand, Bertha Mason, who has no control over her feelings, is a pyromaniac. The inferno at Thornfield illustrates the danger of letting the passions run wild.



EYES

The eyes are the windows to the soul in *Jane Eyre*. Jane is especially attracted to Mr. Rochester's black and brilliant eyes, which symbolize his temper and power. After Mr. Rochester loses his eyesight in the fire, Jane *becomes* his eyes: metaphorically, Jane now holds the position of mastery. Bertha has bloodshot eyes that match her violent nature. The novel also emphasizes the mind's eye—an active imagination.



FOOD

In *Jane Eyre*, food symbolizes generosity, nourishment, and bounty, and hunger symbolizes cruelty and a lack of nourishment. Brontë uses food and hunger to reveal how people treat each other—who is charitable, and who isn't. For instance, the lack of food at Lowood reveals the school's cruelty and religious hypocrisy. Ms. Temple, on the other hand, provides food and is compassionate and generous. Food has religious significance in the novel as well—physical hunger represents a deeper spiritual craving.



PORTRAITS AND PICTURES

Through dreams and drawings, Jane visualizes her deepest feelings. Jane's portfolio contains pictures that symbolize her life. Portraits can also stand in for people's characters. Jane compares her portraits of herself and Blanche Ingram, which mirror the differences in the two women's personalities and social class. Jane's portrait of Rosamond Oliver is the closest that St. John ever gets to happiness on earth. In each case, the visual picture takes on a new reality. Brontë, making her own picture of society in *Jane Eyre*, likewise wanted to give her novel real relevance.

QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Penguin Classics edition of *Jane Eyre* published in 2006.

Chapter 1 Quotes

❝ You have no business to take our books; you are a dependant, mama says; you have no money; your father left you none; you ought to beg, and not to live here with gentlemen's children like us.

Related Characters: John Reed (speaker), Jane Eyre

Related Themes:

Page Number: 13

Explanation and Analysis

Jane has sought refuge from her aunt and cousins in a book, when her cousin John Reed barges in and insults her. Jane was orphaned several years earlier, and now it's only a few months since her uncle - the only member of the Reed family who was kind to her - also died, and the rest of the family feels free to share their scorn and disdain for Jane. Here John belittles Jane's presumption in taking a book to read from among the family collection, for she could not be further from being a member of the family.

Though John's words are cruel, his actions are those of a child, and he seems to be buoyed and his opinions confirmed by those of his mother. Indeed, he repeats his mother's words in calling Jane a "dependent," and in assuming that this is such a negative term. The family's official line underlines several widespread beliefs at this time: that social classes were to be kept separate for a reason, for instance, and that those who are poor or vulnerable are justifiably so, and should remain in that position.

Chapter 2 Quotes

❝ Returning, I had to cross before the looking-glass; my fascinated glance involuntarily explored the depth it revealed. All looked colder and darker in that visionary hollow than in reality: ... the strange little figure there gazing at me, with a white face and arms specking the gloom, and glittering eyes of fear moving where all else was still, had the effect of a real spirit.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker)

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 18

Explanation and Analysis

Locked in the red-room after her outburst against John Reed, Jane Eyre looks into the mirror and thinks about the dire straits in which she finds herself, now that her kindly uncle has died and she is a ward of a family that hates her. Here Jane looks at herself as if at a stranger - and, what's

more, as if at a ghost. In some ways, this effect of estrangement, or making the familiar strange, underlines how isolated and alone Jane feels. She cannot feel herself a part of this family, but has nowhere else to turn, no one else to love her; and as a child, she must continue to rely on others.

This passage also sets up an interest in the otherworldly that will characterize the rest of the book. Even the most realistic, bodily characters can slip into and out of a feeling of grounded reality - one that can easily feel not so real when the circumstances become strange enough.

Chapter 4 Quotes

Ere I had finished this reply, my soul began to expand, to exult, with the strangest sense of freedom, of triumph, I ever felt. It seemed as if an invisible bond had burst, and that I had struggled out into unhoped-for liberty.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker)

Related Themes:

Page Number: 44

Explanation and Analysis

During an interview between Jane, Mrs. Reed, and the headmaster of the Lowood school, Mr. Brocklehurst, Mrs. Reed warns Mr. Brocklehurst that Jane is a compulsive liar. Jane, almost in spite of herself, exclaims that Mrs. Reed is the real liar, and a despicable person besides. Up until this point, Jane has largely retained control of her feelings, keeping her despair and unhappiness inside (except, perhaps, for the one time she lashed out at John). Now she does not feel guilty for letting her feelings override her sense of propriety, but rather relieved and exuberant.

The rest of the book will take a more measured tone on the proper balance between feeling and judgment. Indeed, since Jane is a girl in nineteenth-century England, such shows of passion are to be considered shocking if not dangerous.Here, though, Jane is shown to be so repressed and so unhappy that a rude outburst is really her only chance to express herself, to regain some sense of her own person above and beyond the cruel way she's been treated. Her declaration of the truth about Mrs. Reed is the first time that she senses that things may not always remain as they were, and that she might be able to set her own standards for what is right, outside the confines of the Reed family.

Chapter 8 Quotes

I resolved, in the depth of my heart, that I would be most moderate ... I told her all the story of my sad childhood. Exhausted by emotion, my language was more subdued than it generally was when it developed that sad theme; and mindful of Helen's warnings against the indulgence of resentment, I infused into the narrative far less of gall and wormwood than ordinary. Thus restrained and simplified, it sounded more credible: I felt as I went on that Miss Temple fully believed me.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Maria Temple, Helen Burns

Related Themes:

Page Number: 84

Explanation and Analysis

Jane, along with Helen Burns, has been invited into Miss Temple's office, where Jane is prompted to share her life story with her friend and their teacher. No one has ever asked her to do such a thing before, and in a way Jane's tentative narrative serves as a rehearsal for the story she is now sharing with us, a far larger audience of readers. But even as she is eager to share what has happened to her already in her short life, she is wary of offending yet another adult, or of "indulging" in resentment. Miss Temple and Helen are among the few people that have shown Jane kindness and the kind of love that usually comes from family, and she is worried that they may not believe her tale, and thus that she'll lose this cherished connection. It is by keeping track of her feelings, and being careful not to lose her temper, that Jane realizes she has the best chance of keeping these two women in her life.

The refreshing meal, the brilliant fire, the presence and kindness of her beloved instructress, or, perhaps, more than all these, something in her own unique mind, had roused her powers within her ... [Helen] suddenly acquired a beauty more singular than that of Miss Temple's—a beauty neither of fine color nor long eyelash, nor pencilled brow, but of meaning, of movement, of radiance.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Maria Temple, Helen Burns

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 86

Explanation and Analysis

Helen and Ms. Temple have reacted to Jane's story with grace and goodness, and after the shame of Mr. Brocklehurst's visit, Jane begins to recover. Even the tea and cakes given to her by Miss Temple are a sign of generosity until now largely absent in Jane's life. Now, she begins to feel that this particularly female bond is actually giving her the strength to carry on - a strength that has something mystical or spiritual about it, as Jane connects it to a sense of her budding "powers."

Although Jane has long been an admirer of Miss Temple's beauty, she now starts to realize as well that there can be an even more striking beauty that comes from inner, rather than external, attractiveness. Helen is the most devout person she's ever met, and her religion seems to give her a kind of physical as well as spiritual glow. As she further develops her friendship with both Helen and with Miss Temple, Jane learns certain lessons and chooses certain role models that were simply not available to her in the Reed family's home.

Chapter 10 Quotes

❝ I tired of the routine of eight years in one afternoon. I desired liberty; for liberty I gasped; for liberty I uttered a prayer; it seemed scattered on the wind then faintly blowing. I abandoned it and framed a humbler supplication; for change, stimulus: that petition, too, seemed swept off into vague space: "Then," I cried, half desperate, "grant me at least a new servitude!"

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker)

Related Themes:

Page Number: 102

Explanation and Analysis

Jane has graduated first in her class at school, and has decided to stay on in order to become a teacher herself. Soon, though, Miss Temple leaves for a distant land. For a long time, Jane has felt somewhat restless, trapped in an oppressive school because she is without family, poor, and female, and thus opportunities to support herself are scarce. Until now, Jane has not rebelled against these strictures: instead, she has chosen to work within them, carving out a place for herself that is tolerable mainly because of her adoration of Miss Temple. With her mentor gone, though, suddenly Jane sees no reason to continue at the school.

However, even in the midst of "gasping" for freedom, Jane is both realistic and humble enough to recognize that she cannot yearn for an entirely different lifestyle. She does pray to God, but little by little adapts her prayer so as to fit her circumstances. As she does so, nonetheless, she recognizes that because of her social position, and because of her current circumstances, there are few things she could do that would actually give her greater liberty. Finally, she accepts that she may continue to feel oppressed wherever she may goes - but she insists that even that would be preferable to staying in the same place, where she knows all too well the exact outlines of her "servitude."

Chapter 11 Quotes

❝ While I paced softly on, the last sound I expected to hear in so still a region, a laugh, struck my ear. It was a curious laugh; distinct, formal, mirthless. I stopped: the sound ceased, only for an instant; it began again, louder: for at first, though distinct, it was very low. It passed off in a clamorous peal that seemed to wake an echo in every lonely chamber; though it originated but in one, and I could have pointed out the door whence the accents issued.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Bertha Mason

Related Themes:

Page Number: 126

Explanation and Analysis

Jane is attempting to settle into her new life at Thornfield, but as Mrs. Fairfax finishes up her tour, Jane hears something entirely unexpected in such a quiet, gloomy house: laughter. Here the supernatural quality of the scene is, paradoxically, described in careful, measured detail. Jane attempts to determine the exact qualities of the laugh, the exact properties of its pitch and location. Indeed, she is soon able to fix her judgment on the exact spot from which the sound is coming.

For now, Brontë keeps the reader, as well as Jane, in the dark regarding this mysterious element of Thornfield. Rather than showing the laugh to be a figment of Jane's imagination, this passage stresses her careful capacity of judgment, underlining the book's understanding of the supernatural and the real as not opposites but as mutually productive.

Chapter 12 Quotes

I climbed the three staircases, raised the trap-door of the attic, and having reached the leads, looked out afar over sequestered field and hill, and along dim sky-line—that then I longed for a power of vision which might overpass that limit; which might reach the busy world, towns, regions full of life I had heard of but never seen—that then I desired more of practical experience than I possessed; more of intercourse with my kind, of acquaintance with variety of character, than was here within my reach.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 129

Explanation and Analysis

Although Jane has found things to enjoy about her new life in Thornfield, and in her occupation as Adèle's tutor, she has not entirely shaken off the restlessness that encouraged her to leave her former school in the first place. Here, as Jane climbs to the highest point in the mansion, her physical steps mimic her more emotional desire to float up and away from the day-to-day duties and humdrum life to which she is condemned, largely because of her social class and gender, of course.

Jane is portrayed as eager, curious, and fascinated about the wide world around her. She is clear-headed in that she recognizes how little she knows about this world, despite feeling naturally attracted to it. Indeed, Jane is deeply frustrated by the disconnect between her desire to see more and learn more, and her understanding that such knowledge lies beyond her grasp. As her eyes survey the vast landscape before her, this vision serves as her only and partial means of truly experiencing something beyond her small reality.

It is in vain to say human beings ought to be satisfied with tranquillity: they must have action; and they will make it if they cannot find it. Millions are condemned to a stiller doom than mine, and millions are in silent revolt against their lot. Nobody knows how many rebellions besides political rebellions ferment in the masses of life which people earth. Women are supposed to be very calm generally: but women feel just as men feel; they need exercise for their faculties, and a field for their efforts, as much as their brothers do ... It is thoughtless to condemn them, or laugh at them, if they seek to do more or learn more than custom has pronounced necessary for their sex.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 129

Explanation and Analysis

As Jane continues to muse on the subject of her own position in society, she broadens her perspective to consider the lot of oppressed and marginalized groups in general. Jane recognizes that many other people are in worse situations than herself, but for her this fact only underlines the unfairness and despair to which an entire segment of the population is subjected. Indeed, Jane makes an analogy between those who are oppressed and rebel through political revolution, and those who struggle in more individual ways, through family and community structures that are smaller than those of a nation.

Jane also points to a paradox about the way that women's roles are defined at the time. In some ways, they are considered weak and fragile, and therefore unable to support themselves or to take on the same kinds of responsibilities or to show the same kind of independence as men. They would let their feelings overwhelm them, the argument goes. Yet at the same time, women are expected to curb outbursts of feeling - something they can only do if they use their full capacities of rational judgment. This paradox is one that Jane increasingly seeks to condemn, and that Bronte more broadly points out in this very prescient passage.

Chapter 14 Quotes

I don't think, sir, you have a right to command me, merely because you are older than I, or because you have seen more of the world than I have; your claim to superiority depends on the use you have made of your time and experience.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Edward Fairfax Rochester

Related Themes:

Page Number: 157

Explanation and Analysis

Over the course of the first long conversation between Jane and Rochester, Jane's feelings towards the man quickly become complicated. On the one hand, she does feel a real connection to him, and admires the fact that he is largely willing to chat with her as an equal. Here, though, Jane uses the opportunity that Rochester has given to her to stress that, for her, equality is not just something that can be parceled out here and there, as a sign of good will. If Rochester really wants to treat Jane as an equal, he will have to hear what she has to say on the subject of anything that comes up - including, here, gender relations themselves.

Jane dismisses typical assumptions made about the reasons why men should be considered superior to women. Of course Rochester has seen more of the world than she has, Jane says - she would never, as a woman, be permitted to travel around the world by herself, and even if she could, her financial circumstances would prevent her. Independence, for Jane, is thus not necessarily only a personal character attribute: it is also a function of luck and circumstance, and it has little bearing on true moral equality.

Chapter 17 Quotes

"He is not to them what he is to me," I thought: "he is not of their kind. I believe he is of mine;—I am sure he is—I feel akin to him—I understand the language of his countenance and movements: though rank and wealth sever us widely, I have something in my brain and heart, in my blood and nerves, that assimilates me mentally to him ... I must, then, repeat continually that we are for ever sundered:—and yet, while I breathe and think, I must love him."

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Edward Fairfax Rochester

Related Themes:

Page Number: 203

Explanation and Analysis

Jane has been relegated to a corner of the room at the party, where she can observe all that is going on between Rochester and his guests. Jane feels alienated from the wealthy, privileged women at the event. But as she observes Rochester with them, she realizes that she does in fact feel a profound kinship with Rochester, so profound that she believes he belongs with her far more than with people of his own class and social strata.

Jane's affinity with Rochester is not one of rational, detached judgment, in which similarities and differences, appropriate distinctions and parallels, might be carefully considered. Instead it is something she feels emotionally. At the same time, Jane herself is careful to study and identify this blossoming feeling of love for Rochester; she doesn't get carried away by her feelings but rather respects their reality as she tries to figure out what it is that she feels, and what must be the result.

Chapter 18 Quotes

I saw he was going to marry her, for family, perhaps political reasons, because her rank and connections suited him; I felt he had not given her his love, and that her qualifications were ill adapted to win from him that treasure. This was the point—this was where the nerve was touched and teased—this was where the fever was sustained and fed: *she could not charm him.*

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Edward Fairfax Rochester, Blanche Ingram

Related Themes:

Page Number: 216

Explanation and Analysis

As a member of the servants, Jane is considered largely invisible by many of the guests to Thornfield, including Blanche Ingram, which gives her the opportunity to observe the woman and Rochester from a distance. Jane isn't certain why Rochester is going to marry Blanche. The reasons she imagines are vague and uncertain: this is too distant a reality for Jane for her be able to understand the motivations driving the upper classes. What she does know, however - and what surely is the one known factor that she can take solace in, now that she herself is in love with Rochester - is that he does not truly love Blanche, nor will he ever. Here Jane resigns herself to losing Rochester based on the social norms of upper-class marriage, but she does not resign herself to failing to win his heart.

Chapter 20 Quotes

❝ What crime was this that lived incarnate in this sequestered mansion, and could neither be expelled nor subdued by the owner?—what mystery, that broke out now in fire and now in blood, at the deadest hours of night? What creature was it, that, masked in an ordinary woman's face and shape, uttered the voice, now of a mocking demon, and anon of a carrion-seeking bird of prey?

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Bertha Mason

Related Themes:

Page Number: 243

Explanation and Analysis

Jane has accompanied Rochester to Grace Poole's upper-floor room, where they have found Mr. Mason bleeding and writhing. While Rochester goes to fetch a doctor, Jane is left alone with Mr. Mason and with her own thoughts. This chapter had begun with a frightening scream that had echoed through the mansion, and Jane now wildly begins to wonder what might be the source of such a cry.

In a series of questions, posed far more out of anxiety and fear than out of a scientific desire to get to the bottom of the mystery, Jane becomes progressively more eloquent and descriptive, even if morbidly so. She calls the source of the scream a "mystery," "creature," and "voice," thus underlining how she has only the vaguest sense of what has taken place. The book leaves us, too, in suspense: will the novel now turn even more to the assumptions of Gothic fiction, and embrace the supernatural, or will it remain within the realm of realistic prose?

Chapter 22 Quotes

❝ I am strangely glad to get back again to you: and wherever you are is my home—my only home.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Edward Fairfax Rochester

Related Themes:

Page Number: 283

Explanation and Analysis

Jane is on her way back to Thornfield after remaining at her aunt's deathbed, and she happens to cross paths with Rochester, who has bought a carriage, presumably for himself and Blanche. However, Jane is relieved to be leaving the still-oppressive walls of her childhood home with the Reeds, and she admits to Rochester that she is happy to return to Thornfield. Jane's statement would have been considered quite frank, even perhaps a little shocking, to readers at the time. To permit herself to share her own opinions, especially ones of a vulnerable nature, Jane pushes aside the notions of gender and social roles that require a female servant to remain meek and quiet, not speaking unless spoken to. For Jane, though, the realization that Thornfield has, strangely, become a kind of home for her is so remarkable that she feels the need to share that development with someone she cares about.

Chapter 23 Quotes

❝ I sometimes have a queer feeling with regard to you—especially when you are near me, as now: it is as if I had a string somewhere under my left ribs, tightly and inextricably knotted to a similar string situated in the corresponding quarter of your little frame.

Related Characters: Edward Fairfax Rochester (speaker), Jane Eyre

Related Themes:

Page Number: 291

Explanation and Analysis

Rochester has told Jane that he is to marry Blanche, and that he has found a governess job for her in Ireland. Soon, though, it becomes clear that Rochester's motivations in telling this to Jane are different. He seems to be attempting to determine what her feelings for him are, before he shares his own. If Jane doesn't share them, he has a ready-made solution and can send her away - thus ensuring that his social superiority over her escapes unscathed. Here, though, Rochester does make tentative steps towards suggesting that he loves Jane.

Though not exactly eloquently, he tries to do justice to the feeling he has around Jane, a feeling that proves to be almost too difficult for words. In general, this sentiment is one of profound unity between two people: Rochester feels such so closely tied to Jane that it is as if a truly physical bond united them. The book accepts that such unity can exist, and indeed describes it in terms of spiritual communion, which gives Rochester and Jane a religious analogy for the love they feel for each other.

Chapter 24 Quotes

He stood between me and every thought of religion, as an eclipse intervenes between man and the broad sun. I could not, in those days, see God for His creature: of whom I had made an idol.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Edward Fairfax Rochester

Related Themes:

Page Number: 316

Explanation and Analysis

At first, Jane is thrilled by the prospect of marrying Rochester, with whom she is so in love. But little by little, the gaps between their social stations and their assumptions about proper gender roles begin to grow clearer. Here, another problem arises: the fact that Jane so adores Rochester that he begins to take on the nature of an idol, someone to be worshipped instead of God.

As narrator, Jane is looking back on her earlier self, and in passages like this, narrator-Jane shows a disapproval and even regret towards character-Jane. According to her Christian beliefs, only God can be worshipped and idolized: idolizing anyone else, indeed, is a great sin. In addition, putting Rochester on such a pedestal will prevent Jane from embracing her own independence, a value that she has held dear for so long. This disconnect between what narrator-Jane knows to be true and what character-Jane cannot help from doing and thinking will inevitably have to be resolved.

Chapter 25 Quotes

I faced the wreck of the chestnut-tree; it stood up black and riven: the trunk, split down the centre, gaped ghastly ... their great boughs on each side were dead, and next winter's tempests would be sure to fell one or both to earth: as yet, however, they might be said to form one tree—a ruin, but an entire ruin.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker)

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 318

Explanation and Analysis

On the day of the wedding, Jane wanders outside and sees a chestnut tree that has been struck by lightning. Turning all her powers of observation on the tree, Jane finds it to be a powerful image, though at the same time ominous and troubling. The tree is in a vulnerable, delicate state at the moment: its many boughs are dead, but have not yet fallen to earth, though it is inevitable that they will do so. Trees struck by lightning are sometimes used in the Bible as a sign for the power and will of God. Jane, cognizant of this history, most likely is troubled by the thought that, on a day that should be joyful and carefree, there is such a frightening symbol of what may lie ahead. The "ruin" of the tree, for a reader who has finished *Jane Eyre*, also foreshadows the ruin of the place that she and Rochester call home. Although the novel ends up revealing certain supernatural-seeming elements as based in reality (though still disturbing), in other ways it continues to stress the possibility of connecting natural, supernatural, and social affairs symbolically.

Chapter 26 Quotes

What it was, whether beast or human being, one could not, at first sight, tell: it grovelled, seemingly, on all fours; it snatched and growled like some strange wild animal: but it was covered with clothing, and a quantity of dark, grizzled hair, wild as a mane, hid its head and face.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Bertha Mason

Related Themes:

Page Number: 338

Explanation and Analysis

Finally, for the first time, Jane lays eyes on the source of all the strange happenings and mysterious sounds that have seemed to haunt Thornfield. But this first sight fails to substantially clarify the situation, or help Jane understand who this person is - even though she knows intellectually that it must be Bertha Mason, Rochester's legal wife.

Bertha is described not in human but in animal terms. Indeed, it is the inability to describe her as a woman that locates the source of her insanity. Jane may have pressed at the borders of what is permitted and is not among women, especially of a particular social class, but she now witnesses someone who has thrown all those strictures out entirely. As Bertha fails to act as a proper woman, as a proper wife to her husband, the book has no way left to describe her other than by considering her non-human, making an analogy to the animal world.

Chapter 27 Quotes

"Who in the world cares for *you*? Or who will be injured by what you do?" Still indomitable was the reply—"*I* care for myself. The more solitary, the more friendless, the more unsustained I am, the more I will respect myself. I will keep the law given by God; sanctioned by man.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker)

Related Themes:

Page Number: 365

Explanation and Analysis

Jane has learned the truth about Rochester and his existing wife, and she realizes that she must leave Thornfield. The prospect is daunting, even terrifying: Jane does not know where she'll go or what she'll do, and of course she is still in love with Rochester despite his deceit. Here, she mounts an internal debate between the part of herself that would despair about her lack of ties to the world, and the part of herself that - rather than insisting that those ties *do* exist - embraces her isolation. Jane comes to recognize that her independence is a virtue rather than a fault. It ensures that she answers only to the laws of God, rather than to the more transient desires of other people, or even of herself.

Chapter 28 Quotes

This was the climax. A pang of exquisite suffering—a throe of true despair—rent and heaved my heart. Worn out, indeed, I was; not another step could I stir. I sank on the wet doorstep: I groaned—I wrung my hands—I wept in utter anguish. Oh, this spectre of death! Oh, this last hour, approaching in such horror! Alas, this isolation—this banishment from my kind!

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker)

Related Themes:

Page Number: 385

Explanation and Analysis

After wandering in the wilderness, weak from exhaustion and hunger, Jane finally follows a distant light to its source: but when she arrives at the door of the home, the servant refuses to let her in, and locks her out. Although Jane has tried to remain stoic until now, this show of unkindness is the last straw. She breaks down, finally allowing her feelings to overwhelm her careful poise and judgment as she weeps and groans.

The wanderer in the wilderness is a trope - an often-repeated literary device - that can be found in both Old and New Testaments of the Bible: both Job and Jesus are sent into the wilderness at one point to battle temptation. Jane's time in the wilderness is similarly her moment of greatest struggle, when her embrace of independence no longer is characterized by an exhilarating sense of freedom but actually threatens to destroy her. As Jane, narrating, recalls her thoughts at her darkest moment, the use of repeated exclamations and dashes highlights the tone of acute despair.

Chapter 32 Quotes

St. John, no doubt, would have given the world to follow, recall, retain her, when she thus left him; but he would not give one chance of heaven, nor relinquish, for the elysium of her love, one hope of the true, eternal Paradise.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), St. John Rivers, Rosamond Oliver

Related Themes:

Page Number: 424

Explanation and Analysis

Jane and St. John have begun to speak frankly about St. John's feelings for Rosamond Oliver. Jane has guessed that St. John is in love with her, and he admits that this is true. However, he cannot imagine Rosamond accompanying him far away as the wife of a missionary. St. John's faith is such that he cannot consider giving up his livelihood as missionary even on account of his love for another human being: for him this kind of love is not as significant as the love he finds in serving God. At the same time, St. John's admission reflects his assumptions about the proper role of women in marriage: Rosamond's role would be to serve him as he is serving God, and he cannot imagine any other way.

Again the surprised expression crossed his face. He had not imagined that a woman would dare to speak so to a man. For me, I felt at home in this sort of discourse. I could never rest in communication with strong, discreet, and refined minds, whether male or female, till I had passed the outworks of conventional reserve, and crossed the threshold of confidence, and won a place by their heart's very hearthstone.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), St. John Rivers

Related Themes:

Page Number: 432

Explanation and Analysis

As Jane and St. John speak of the latter's love for Rosamond, St. John grows surprised that Jane would presume to speak to him so frankly of such private matters. St. John is not used to women speaking to him in such a manner: indeed, propriety and social custom make it nearly certain that very few women will broach such private topics with a man, even one with whom they are close. While Jane has acted somewhat ashamed of her propensity for frankness and openness before, here she wholeheartedly embraces this attitude, and in addition claims that there is little she can do about it: it is just part of her nature. Jane even claims a positive ethical status for such openness, arguing that convention can often mask what is real and true, while speaking frankly honors each person much more.

Chapter 33 Quotes

I looked at the blank wall: it seemed a sky thick with ascending stars,—every one lit me to a purpose or delight. Those who had saved my life, whom, till this hour, I had loved barrenly, I could now benefit. They were under a yoke,—I could free them: they were scattered,—I could reunite them: the independence, the affluence which was mine, might be theirs too.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), St. John Rivers, Diana and Mary Rivers

Related Themes:

Page Number: 445

Explanation and Analysis

Jane has learned that she is heir to an enormous fortune, and in addition that the Rivers are her cousins, so that she now has a larger family than she ever realized. Jane has long sought independence by choosing her own way in life and by insisting on her own rights and her own, individual life, apart from all others. Now she realizes that independence need not entail isolation. Indeed, her financial independence is wrapped up in the revelation of a true family.

As a result, Jane comes to consider independence as a value that can take place within the structure of a family, and even within the limitations and responsibilities that being part of a family entails. By helping her new cousins with her inheritance, Jane will be able to ensure that they escape the kind of "yoke" under which she herself struggled; but she also will tie their life to her own in a way that she had scarcely thought possible earlier in her life.

Chapter 37 Quotes

I will be your neighbor, your nurse, your housekeeper. I find you lonely: I will be your companion—to read to you, to walk with you, to sit with you, to wait on you, to be eyes and hands to you. Cease to look so melancholy, my dear master; you shall not be left desolate, so long as I live.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Edward Fairfax Rochester

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 502

Explanation and Analysis

As Jane reunites with Rochester, she exhibits a complex and nuanced, if not ambivalent, understanding of the relationship between love and independence - one that has been affected by her time at Thornfield but also by the revelation that she is now financially independent. Here, Jane calls Rochester her master, as she was accustomed to do when she served as his daughter's governess. As she vows to be his "nurse" and "housekeeper," she also seems to accede to proper gender roles and even embrace this role of subservience.

However, other ways that Jane characterizes this relationship transform her vow into one of a relationship between equals. To be Rochester's neighbor or companion is not to submit to him as a woman to a man, but rather to consider each person as mutually necessary and mutually fulfilling. Jane continues to rely on some of the assumptions of her time in terms of family and gender roles, but she also carves out a more unique, progressive place for herself and Rochester based on her own beliefs and desires.

Chapter 38 Quotes

Reader, I married him.

Related Characters: Jane Eyre (speaker), Edward Fairfax Rochester

Related Themes:

Page Number: 517

Explanation and Analysis

The last chapter of the novel begins with this famous line. Of course, the most significant aspect of the passage is that it underlines how, after so many difficulties and one frustrated attempt, Jane and Rochester finally end up together. By making "I" the subject of the sentence, however, Jane underlines her agency in choosing to marry Rochester, and makes the act one of independence rather than of choosing to submit herself to a "master" in another way. The acknowledgement of the reader also reminds us that an older Jane has been narrating this story all along, looking back on her earlier self and using that opportunity to pass judgment and to point out her own self-development.

SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

PROLOGUE

Writing as her pseudonym "Currer Bell," the author thanks her public and her publishers, but attacks literary critics who expect authors to stick to stylistic and moral conventions. Instead, she explains that appearances and beliefs must be examined and the plain truth must be revealed.

Bell's comments offer an early suggestion of Jane's personality. Independent and inquiring, Jane breaks through conventions and gets to deeper truths about society.

She dedicates her novel to someone who she thinks does this brilliantly—William Thackeray, the Victorian satirist and author of *Vanity Fair*. She praises Thackeray for being a "social regenerator" who writes books to correct the warped social system.

This dedication shows one of the main objectives of Jane Eyre: to expose social problems and then "regenerate" or reform them.

CHAPTER 1

On a dreary afternoon in Gateshead Hall, the ten-year-old Jane Eyre, who has been forbidden by her Aunt from playing with her three cousins, finds a curtained window seat where she can read. Jane pages through a copy of the *History of British Birds*. Its many **pictures** inspire her to imagine mysterious stories and arctic scenes.

Jane sitting and reading by herself, not allowed to play with her cousins, establishes her odd and lonely position at Gateshead Hall. Yet her willingness to find a book to read, rather than just moping, establishes her independence.

Jane's bullying cousin John Reed barges in and insults her, calling her a penniless orphan and beggar and a servant in his house. When he knocks her down with the book, Jane fights back for the first time in her life. The two children scuffle.

Because Jane is an orphan, the wealthy Reeds treat her as a dependent—someone who relies on their support. They treat her more like a servant than a family member.

Stunned, John goes crying to Mrs. Reed: his mother and Jane's aunt. Mrs. Reed, despite Jane's protests, accuses Jane of starting the fight. As punishment, Mrs. Reed orders Jane to be locked in the **red-room**. The red-room is a lavishly furnished and rarely used bedroom where, nine years previous, Mrs. Reed's husband (Jane's uncle) had died.

Jane's punishment is ironic—at the moment Jane asserts her independence, her freedom is taken away. The Reeds are tyrants and hypocrites, refusing to recognize Jane's virtues and their own vices.

CHAPTER 2

Two servants, Bessie Lee and Miss Abbot, haul the wildly struggling Jane upstairs. Shocked at her violent outbreak, they scold her for disrespecting Mrs. Reed, her benefactress and master. They tell Jane that she depends on Mrs. Reed's generosity. Without it, she would have to go to the poor house.

Because of her uncertain status in the family and in the social hierarchy, Jane is a prisoner of Mrs. Reed's "generosity" as well as the red-room. Adopted children like Jane had few, if any, options of their own.

They lock Jane alone in the **red-room**. Jane catches sight of her gaunt reflection in the mirror and broods on the injustice of Gateshead Hall, where she is always being insulted and punished while the Reed brats enjoy every privilege. She knows that the kindly Mr. Reed would never have treated her so badly. Mr. Reed brought her to Gateshead, and it was his dying wish that Mrs. Reed raise Jane like one of her own children.

Alone with her reflection and her thoughts, Jane starts to realize what she deserves as an individual, and what was promised to her by Mr. Reed—to be treated with love and respect. Though she is powerless, she knows that she deserves better.



Jane thinks about the dead and how, when wronged, they can arise to seek revenge. Suddenly, Jane is overwhelmed with a sense of Mr. Reed's presence in the room. Convinced she sees his ghost, Jane screams in terror. The servants open the door, but Mrs. Reed refuses to believe Jane or to let her out. Locked back into the red-room again, Jane faints.

Imagined or not, the ghost sets the tone for many of the supernatural elements in the novel. Jane wants revenge, but it takes a terrifying form in Mr. Reed's spirit. Jane must learn another, more controlled way to confront injustice.



CHAPTER 3

Jane wakes up in the nursery, cared for by Bessie, and by the local apothecary, Mr. Lloyd. Bessie tells Jane that she thinks that Mrs. Reed mistreated her, nurses Jane, and even sings Jane a song, but Jane is melancholy and unreachable. Jane only feels better when she gets a book—*Gulliver's Travels*, a fanciful satire by Jonathan Swift, which she believes is a factual story of distant places.

For her own children, Mrs. Reed would have hired a real doctor rather than an apothecary. Jane takes refuge in her imagination which, as with Mr. Reed's ghost, can sometimes be too powerful and distort the truth.



As Jane recovers, Mr. Lloyd asks her about her health and her well-being. Jane confesses her unhappiness and her regrets about having no family, but says she does not want to leave and become a beggar. Even if she had family, Jane says she would not want to rejoin them if they were very poor.

Poverty has affected Jane deeply enough to challenge her desire for family. Dependents and young women on their own had it rough—they could either work for someone or hit the streets.



Mr. Lloyd asks Jane if she'd like to attend school. Jane gladly says yes. He obtains permission from Mrs. Reed, who is thrilled to get rid of her niece.

Education is necessary for an orphan girl like Jane to create a place for herself in society.



Later, Jane overhears Bessie telling Miss Abbot the story of Jane's family. Jane's father was a poor clergyman. Jane's mother, a Reed, married him against her wealthy family's wishes, and they disowned her. Just after Jane was born, Jane's father caught typhus while helping the poor, and both of Jane's parents soon died. Jane's uncle Mr. Reed adopted her. Mr. Reed also died within a year, but made his wife, Mrs. Reed, promise to raise Jane like one of their own children—John, Eliza, and Georgiana.

Jane's parents are split between the working class and the upper-class gentry (people who owned property). Jane's mother chose love and her own desires over her family's money. Jane will do the same eventually. Like her mother, Jane is determined to earn respect for herself, and for women in general.



CHAPTER 4

For two months, Jane anxiously waits for her schooling to start. She is finally interviewed by Mr. Brocklehurst—the aloof and stern headmaster of the Lowood school. He lectures Jane about religion, especially about the virtue of consistency. Mrs. Reed warns him that Jane is a liar, and Mr. Brocklehurst promises to inform her future teachers.

Another painfully ironic moment—as will become clear, Brocklehurst is hardly pious or consistent, while it is Mrs. Reed who is the liar. Once again, Mrs. Reed does harm to her niece, whom she should protect.



Jane is so hurt by Mrs. Reed's false accusation that she can't stop herself from angrily exclaiming that her aunt makes her sick and is herself a cruel and deceitful person. Mrs. Reed is dumbstruck and subdued by Jane's bold criticism. Afterwards, Jane feels a thrilling mix of victory and fear at her uncontrolled passions.

Jane's passionate nature arises. By asserting herself, she stops others from misrepresenting and taking advantage of her. But she also knows that because of her social position, her outburst is out of line. She must learn to control her passions.



The Reeds continue to shun Jane during her remaining time at Gateshead. Yet Jane makes friends with Bessie and speaks to her with a new "frank and fearless" attitude. Bessie treats her to stories and **cakes** and tells Jane she likes her better than the Reed kids.

Jane is beginning to mature because she sees through—and speaks out against—the hypocritical and cruel conventions that silence and repress her.



CHAPTER 5

Four days later, on a January morning, Jane leaves Gateshead. The carriage trip winds through a dreary landscape and lets Jane off at an uninviting, haunted-looking compound—the Lowood school.

The barren winter landscape resembles the lifeless and stern environment that Jane will find at Lowood school.



The Lowood school is a charity school for orphan girls, ranging in age, and all wearing drab rough uniforms. On her first day, Jane witnesses the strictly regimented routine. Teachers order the girls around in formation. Students share beds in long dormitories, and must eat sparse and sometimes inedible **meals**.

Brontë uses Lowood to satirize the conditions in girls' charity schools (two of her sisters died in such a school). Because it's a charity school, Mrs. Reed didn't pay anything to send Jane to school there.



The school's superintendent, Ms. Maria Temple, intervenes to provide some better **food**. Ms. Temple also teaches several subjects. Jane respects her for her kindness and knowledge.

Ms. Temple is a mother figure for Jane. She provides love and sustenance (physical and spiritual) that Mrs. Reed never did.



Jane spots a solitary girl reading. The girl is Helen Burns, an orphan herself. Jane is not used to talking to strangers, but she feels an immediate connection to Helen. Jane asks her a lot of questions about the school, the teachers, and Mr. Brocklehurst, which Helen answers carefully and with respect.

Helen is independent and intellectual like Jane. But she is much more restrained and refuses to say anything negative about the people running the school—though she could.



In the afternoon, a bitter teacher history teacher named Miss Scatcherd kicks Helen out of class and makes her stand in the middle of the school room for all to see. Jane cannot understand how Helen can bear the humiliation so quietly.

Helen's experience here parallels the Reeds' mistreatment of Jane, but Helen does not fight the injustice, as Jane passionately did. She endures it.

CHAPTER 6

On Jane's second day at the school, she wakes up shivering to a meager **breakfast**. She finds that her wash water is frozen in its pitcher.

Lowood's "discipline" is actually neglect. But the girls have no power to change anything.

In classes, Jane is overwhelmed by the lessons, but is fascinated by watching Helen Burns across the room. Even though Helen answers many difficult questions in her class, Miss Scatcherd goes out of her way to criticize and punish Helen. When she whips Helen across the neck, Jane is amazed that Helen doesn't flinch or cry.

Jane feels a connection with Helen that she never feels with anyone else. Humiliated and even physically injured, Helen is a Christ-like figure who endures unjust persecution without complaint.

Later, Jane tells Helen how she should furiously resist such unjust treatment. Helen explains to Jane her philosophy of turning the other cheek, and her belief in a beautiful afterlife that gives her hope and patience to endure suffering in this world.

Helen's religious views help her endures her suffering. Helen's optimistic faith will contrast with the stern Christianity of characters later in the book.

CHAPTER 7

Conditions at Lowood remain harsh. On weekly Sunday walks to Mr. Brocklehurst's church, the poorly-clothed girls suffer exposure to frigid weather. They are constantly cold and underfed. In sympathy, Jane gives most of her small **meals** to other starving girls.

Mr. Brocklehurst's type of religion is cold and lifeless. His "charity" is literally killing the girls he is supposed to teach and nourish. In contrast, Jane nourishes others even when she herself is underfed.

One day, Mr. Brocklehurst, who is rarely present at the school itself, visits Lowood with his rich, well-dressed relatives. In front of the school, he reemphasizes the rules of his harsh educational program to Ms. Temple, who had been bending the rules out of kindness to the girls. She fumes in silence. On seeing a girl's curly red hair, he demands that all the girls' hair be cut off for the sake of modesty.

Mr. Brocklehurst enjoys wealth and comforts while the girls suffer. He would "starve the body to save the soul," but doesn't practice what he preaches. The haircuts show how the girls are denied their feelings and individuality. Ms. Temple fumes silently because, as a female teacher, she has no real power.

Jane is terrified that Mr. Brocklehurst will remember his promise to Mrs. Reed to tell all the teachers that Jane is a liar. Jane is so nervous that she accidentally drops her chalk slate during his visit. Mr. Brocklehurst then makes her stand on a high stool in front of everyone, says that Jane is deceitful, and tells all the students and teachers to avoid her.

Jane is concerned that her new friends, Helen and Ms. Temple, will reject her because of Mrs. Reed's lies. She does not yet understand the deeper bonds of friendship and love.

Jane is devastated, but takes heart from Helen Burns, who smiles at Jane every time she passes by.

Drawing strength from Helen's approval, Jane learns to endure.



CHAPTER 8

After school is dismissed that evening, thinking that she is hated by everyone, Jane collapses into tears. Helen Burns reassures Jane that she is pitied, not hated, by her peers. Helen also promises that even if the whole world despised her, Jane would still find friendship and protecting love in her faith.

Almost above all things, Jane "cannot bear to be solitary and hated." She is searching for meaningful connections to others and to her own beliefs. Helen's faith appeals to orphans and the struggling poor.



Ms. Temple brings the two girls to her office and treats them to tea and **cake**. Jane tells Ms. Temple that she is not a liar, and relates her life story, trying hard to be moderate and humble. Ms. Temple and Helen talk of learned subjects, and Jane watches them in awe. To Jane, they seem radiant with intelligence and purity.

The three women share a sisterhood of humility, persistence, and honesty. Helen's intelligence and moral purity shine through her outward appearance. Jane hopes the same will be true for her.



Ms. Temple promises to write to Mr. Lloyd to confirm that Jane's assertion that she is not a liar. Mr. Lloyd soon writes back to exonerate Jane, and Ms. Temple announces in front of the whole school that Jane is innocent of Mr. Brocklehurst's charges.

The public clearing of Jane's reputation makes the school a friendly place again. Ms. Temple takes back some of Brocklehurst's power to shape the girls' identities.



Jane returns to her studies with new vigor and excels in French and drawing. She now prefers the impoverished Lowood to the luxuries of Gateshead.

Money isn't everything. Even at Lowood, Jane feels enriched by her friends and studies.



CHAPTER 9

Spring brings better weather, but the dampness of the school grounds results in an epidemic of typhus that infects more than half of Lowood's students. Many are sent home. Many others die. Jane, meanwhile, is encouraged to wander outside for her health, and she takes great pleasure in the lush scenery and flowers. In the midst of spring's renewal, Jane contemplates death for the first time.

The Lowood epidemic recalls Brontë's own sisters' deaths, and illustrates the plight of poor women. The contrast of spring's rebirth with death wakes Jane up to life's contradictions. Spring is a transitional time, and Jane is transitioning out of her youth.



Jane soon learns that Helen is also deathly ill. Helen suffers from consumption (tuberculosis), not typhus, and is being held in quarantine in Ms. Temple's room.

In Victorian literature, characters like Helen who are too sensitive or pure for the harsh world often died of consumption.



One night Jane sneaks to Helen's bedside. Helen assures Jane that she is not scared of dying because she will be leaving behind the suffering of the world and going to her God. They fall asleep in each other's arms. By morning, Helen is dead.

Helen's profound faith in an afterlife teaches Jane to give up on some of the petty struggles of life. The girls' bond is unbreakable, even by death.



Helen is buried in an unmarked grave. But 15 years later, someone (probably Jane) places a headstone on the grave that is carved with the word "Resurgam"—Latin for "I will rise again."

The gravestone's inscription extends the novel's comparison of Helen to Christ.



CHAPTER 10

The epidemic and deaths expose the depravity at Lowood and Mr. Brocklehurst's neglect. New management takes over and improves the school.

Mr. Brocklehurst's negligence comes back to him. He receives divine and social justice.



Eight years pass. Jane excels in her studies during that time. Driven by a wish to please her teachers, she graduates first in her class and becomes a teacher at the school herself. But when Ms. Temple marries and leaves for a distant country, Jane yearns for a change herself, to venture out into the wide world and find a "new servitude."

Marriage interferes with women's relationships, and Jane is "orphaned" again when Ms. Temple leaves. Now Jane feels isolated and restless and wants her freedom, to define herself. Yet at the same time she yearns for "servitude."



Jane posts a newspaper advertisement for her services as a tutor, and a week later is offered a job by a Mrs. Fairfax to teach a young girl at the manor of Thornfield.

Jane's ad symbolizes her entrance into independent public life, though as a poor woman she must still serve others.



Just as she's leaving Lowood, Jane gets a surprise visit from Bessie. Bessie updates Jane about the Reeds—Georgiana tried to run off with a young lord, but her jealous sister Eliza ratted her out to Mrs. Reed. John Reed is failing school, spending money wildly, and generally disappointing his mother. Bessie thinks that Jane is far more accomplished than any of the Reed children.

Through her devotion to her education, Jane has gained self-confidence, admirable skills, and a respectable social position. Mrs. Reed may have rated her children above Jane, but raised without discipline and integrity, they turned out poorly.



Bessie also notes that Jane's family (the Eyres) was poor but respected—they even owned property. In fact, seven years previous (shortly after Jane left Gateshead), Jane's uncle John, a well-to-do wine merchant, had visited Gateshead looking for her. He didn't have time to visit her at Lowood, because he was headed to the island of Madeira on business.

Jane's social position becomes a little clearer. Though poor, she is a member of the gentry. Jane's uncle is a self-made man and a solid middle-class figure. His virtues parallel Jane's.



CHAPTER 11

Jane arrives at Thornfield Hall at night, and therefore can't make out much more than the house's exterior splendor in the dark. She meets the kind old Mrs. Fairfax, who leads her through the cavernous house to a cozy and snug bedroom. To Jane's surprise, Mrs. Fairfax is not the owner of Thornfield but the head housekeeper. She learns from Mrs. Fairfax that Mr. Rochester owns the place but only shows up intermittently. Mrs. Fairfax describes Rochester as peculiar, well-traveled, and a good master.

With its dark splendor, mysterious and absent master, and suggestive name, Thornfield Hall has a Gothic feel to it. Jane, like Mrs. Fairfax, is a servant and dependent to the "master" of the house. These servants and dependents, it seems, will be her new "family."



Jane meets her new pupil, the hyperactive French girl Adèle Varens, whose mother was a French singer and dancer and who is Rochester's ward. Later, Mrs. Fairfax leads Jane on a tour of the luxuriously furnished house. The third floor is packed with old furniture, odds and ends of the past. Jane considers it strange enough for a ghost to live in.

How and why Rochester has a ward deepens the mystery surrounding him. Did he have an affair, breaking social and religious ethics? The strange third floor adds Gothic flavor to Thornfield Hall.



After they leave the third floor, strange laughter echoes above them, spooking Jane. Mrs. Fairfax blames the noise on Grace Poole, a servant and seamstress whom Mrs. Fairfax scolds and reminds to "remember directions."

Thornfield's supernatural qualities grow even more pronounced.



CHAPTER 12

Jane eases into the habits of life at Thornfield. She is comfortable and likes the bright but spoiled Adèle, but she soon starts to feel discontented, confined, and restless. She thinks that people are wrongfully constrained by their roles in society, especially women, and that all humans need stimulation. Jane finds some comfort in occasionally strolling along the third-floor passageway and allowing her imagination to wander.

Jane is a restless and curious soul who wants a purpose in life. Yet at the same time she still lets her imagination wander, and daydreams fantastical stories. Jane's thoughts about women and confinement foreshadow the appearance of Bertha, a woman who really is imprisoned.



Jane frequently hears the strange laughter on the third floor, and observes Grace Poole coming and going with her servant work. Jane is puzzled by Grace Poole, whose plain curt personality doesn't seem to match the bizarre sounds she hears from the third floor.

The scapegoating of Grace Poole reflects Brontë's belief that false appearances must be scrutinized to uncover hidden truths—the same view that Brontë presents in her Preface.



As Jane carries a letter to the post one winter evening, she hears a horse approaching. The dreary scene and the noise make her think of Bessie's ghost stories about "Gytrash," a spirit creature, sometimes horse and sometimes dog, which pursues travelers at night. Sure enough, out comes a huge intimidating dog, but it is immediately followed by a horse and rider that dispel Jane's worries about ghosts.

Here Brontë blends the Gothic style with realism. She makes it seem as if something supernatural is happening and then explains the causes behind those events. This approach is sometimes called the "explained supernatural."



The horse then slips and falls on a sheet of ice. Jane helps up the rider, a dark and stern-faced man, who questions Jane about her position at Thornfield before riding away. On returning to Thornfield, Jane discovers from the servants that the gentleman was Edward Rochester, who has returned home.

Jane and Rochester's first encounter sets the tone for much of their future relationship. Jane helps Rochester, her "master," while Rochester stays in disguise with Jane, hiding his real identity and history from her.

CHAPTER 13

The next evening, Jane and Adèle join Rochester for tea. Rochester seems distant and moody, and speaks in commands, sometimes impolitely. They talk of Adèle's progress and Jane's personal history.

Rochester's language and manner identify him as a man accustomed to having power.

When he learns that Jane can draw, Rochester is intrigued and asks to see her work. Jane's **pictures** show sublime and desolate scenes, including a drowning on a bleak ocean, storm clouds behind a young woman's luminous face, and a cloaked grim reaper near arctic icebergs. The viewing wraps up the evening.

The pictures are all characteristic of a Romantic interest in the visionary and the sublime. They also suggest the isolation and turmoil of Jane's mind. The coming storm image forecasts the emotional turmoil ahead.

Jane mentions to Mrs. Fairfax that she finds Rochester unpleasantly abrupt. Mrs. Fairfax explains that Rochester has a difficult personality because of his troubled past. He inherited Thornfield from his older brother nine years earlier. Before that, their father had given his entire estate to Rochester's older brother, but had wanted to set up Rochester (who's fist name is Edward) to be wealthy too, and arranged some scheme that didn't work out and continues to be problematic and painful. Mrs. Fairfax is evasive about the scheme and the matter remains a mystery.

Rochester is a product of class rules. When Jane Eyre was written, the first-born son of wealthy families usually inherited everything, while other children were set up to be rich through specific careers or lucrative marriages. Later in the novel, Jane goes against this tradition by sharing her inheritance equally with her cousins.

CHAPTER 14

Jane barely sees Rochester, until one night after dinner he calls for Jane and Adèle to join him. He gives Adèle the gift from Paris that he's been impatiently waiting for, and she goes off to play. Rochester, who seems a bit drunk, chats amiably with Jane, and she answers with all of her usual directness. Rochester asks if Jane thinks he's handsome. Jane bluntly says no, even though she secretly admires his **eyes**. They converse about each other's personalities, about treating people directly and on equal terms. It seems to her that Rochester sometimes speaks as if he were reading her mind.

Rochester cannot be himself around Jane yet—he needs to get drunk to converse with her at all. Yet Jane already senses a deep, almost spiritual connection with him that cuts across social boundaries. Even so, for all his talk of treating people directly and on even terms, Rochester does neither of those things with Jane. He summons her to come talk with him, and keeps secrets.

Describing himself, Rochester claims to be a man of experience and unfortunate circumstances, hardened from flesh into "Indian-rubber." He makes obscure references to his past and his plans for reforming himself, but Jane gets confused by his vagueness and she stops the conversation.

Rochester's desire to reform suggests some illicit behavior on his part that's troubling him. His desire to remake himself from "Indian-rubber" into flesh contrasts with Helen's faith in transcending the flesh.



Adèle soon returns, dressed up in a new pink gown, and dances around. Rochester says that Adèle reminds him of her French mother, Céline Varens. Rochester promises to someday explain to Jane more about how and why Adèle became his ward.

Adèle is a living symbol of Rochester's past, which he wants to reform. But he will need Jane's help, symbolized in part by her role as Adèle's tutor.



CHAPTER 15

One afternoon, Rochester takes Jane aside and explains his history with Adèle. Years ago in Paris, Rochester fell for Céline Varens, a French singer. Rochester caught Céline with another man, ended the relationship, and wounded the man in a duel. Céline claimed that Adèle was Rochester's daughter, which Rochester doubts based on her looks. Even so, when Céline abandoned Adèle, Rochester brought her back to England to insure her a good upbringing.

Rochester raises and educates Adèle as a way of trying to repent for his past. To 19-century readers, it would seem inappropriate for Rochester to walk alone with Jane and talk about his morally questionable history. Jane seems to walk a fine line between being an equal and a servant.



That night, Jane thinks over Rochester's story and realizes that she really likes speaking with him now that he no longer acts like such a haughty aristocrat around her.

The connection between Jane and Rochester deepens when Rochester abandons his secrecy and aristocratic formality.



Later, when trying to sleep, Jane is disturbed by strange noises in the hallway, a demonic laugh at her door, and footsteps retreating to the third floor. She runs into the hallway and sees smoke coming from Rochester's bedroom—Rochester is asleep, but his bed curtains are on **fire**. She douses the curtains with water, putting out the fire and saving his life.

The Gothic mystery in Thornfield deepens, and becomes more dangerous. A fire in the bedroom suggests that the raging passion symbolized by the fire is connected to love, sex, and marriage.



Rochester, now awake, rushes up to the third floor. He returns and asks Jane if she's ever heard the demonic laughter before. When Jane responds that she has heard Grace Poole's laugh, Rochester quickly says, "Just so. Grace Poole—you have guessed it." He makes Jane promise to keep quiet about the events of the night. Emotionally moved, Rochester confesses his deep gratitude to Jane and goes to sleep on the sofa in the library. Jane spends a wakeful night contemplating her new emotions.

Jane again saves Rochester, just as she did when his horse slipped in Chapter 12. Though deeply grateful to Jane and seemingly on the verge of telling her that he loves her, Rochester continues to keep secrets and does not treat Jane as an equal. Jane's own feelings for Rochester become passionate.



CHAPTER 16

In the morning, Jane is surprised that the servants believe that the previous night's fire started when Rochester accidentally fell asleep with a lit candle next to his bed, and that he woke just in time to extinguish the flames. Jane is astonished when Grace Poole—who seems nothing like a nervous criminal—confirms the story. When Jane asks about the laughter, Grace assures Jane that she imagined it, but that she should probably keep her bedroom door locked anyway.

Jane realizes that Rochester has lied on purpose, and is keeping her in the dark about all of the "supernatural" events taking place at Thornfield. Blaming Jane's imagination plays on the stereotype that are flighty and over-imaginative.



To Jane's dismay, Rochester soon leaves for a nearby estate to join a party of aristocrats, including the beautiful Blanche Ingram. Jane chastises herself for thinking she ever had a chance with Rochester. She draws two **pictures**—a homely self-portrait and a romantic image of Blanche—to remind her of their respective social positions, and to cure herself of any expectation that she might win Rochester's love.

Jane believes Rochester will be forced to marry someone in his social class, regardless of his feelings. The two styles of the portraits reinforce the unbridgeable gap that Jane senses between herself and the upper class. Her her despair reveals her growing feelings for Rochester.



CHAPTER 17

Rochester is gone for a week when Jane is upset to learn from Mrs. Fairfax that he may go to Europe for a year. But a week later, Mrs. Fairfax reports a new plan—Rochester will be returning to Thornfield in three days with a group of guests.

The prospect of Rochester's absence forces Jane to confront her feelings for him more fully.



Meanwhile, Jane keeps an eye on Grace Poole, who spends most of her time alone upstairs. Jane is amazed that Grace interacts normally with the other servants. She becomes convinced that there's something odd going on when she overhears one servant gossiping that Grace gets paid more than the other servants.

Jane begins to piece together the mystery of the "supernatural" events that have been blamed on Grace Poole.



When Rochester's party arrives, they go into the parlor. Adèle, starry eyed, wanders through an adoring crowd in a French dress while Jane, wearing a Quakerish frock, retreats to a corner to observe.

Jane's "Quakerish" dress contrasts the more flashy dress of the aristocrats. It represents her modesty and moral purity.



Blanche Ingram is the belle of the ball and looks as beautiful as Jane imagined. The flirty Blanche hones in on Rochester and, taking a crack at Jane, loudly discusses all of the dreadful governesses that she's had. She then makes Rochester sing a duet with her.

Blanche's class-based crack about governesses indicates that she senses that Jane is a potential competitor for Rochester.



Watching Rochester with Blanche, Jane realizes that she's helplessly in love with him. She sneaks away, about to cry, but Rochester catches her in the hallway. He lets her leave when he sees that she's about to cry, but demands that she come to the nightly parties for as long as his guests remain at Thornfield. He finishes with the words, "Good-night, my—" before cutting himself off.

Jane's emotion comes from her belief that her social position will make it impossible for Rochester to love her. Rochester almost reveals his own feelings for Jane. Yet, by commanding her to attend the parties, he still doesn't treat her as an equal.



CHAPTER 18

The guests remain for several days. Each night Jane has to watch Blanche flirt with Rochester, including during a game of charades from which Jane is excluded.

Rochester forces Jane to attend the parties, while the other guests exclude her. None of them treat her as an equal.



Jane senses that Blanche, despite all her efforts, cannot charm Rochester. Still, she thinks Rochester will probably marry Blanche, perhaps for political or social reasons that Jane doesn't understand.

Jane continues to believe that Rochester will place a higher priority on class constraints than on his emotions.



One day, Rochester is away on business. A strange gentleman—Mr. Mason—comes looking for him. The man's unusual, vacant appearance makes Jane uneasy. She learns from Mr. Mason that he and Rochester both had business in the West Indies.

Mr. Mason's disturbing nature seems to link him to the Gothic events at Thornfield. His West Indies origins make him an outsider, and therefore suspect.



A few nights later, while Rochester is still away, an old gypsy woman comes to the house to tell the fortunes of the party. Blanche demands to be first, but returns from the library looking disappointed. The other girls twitter about the gypsy's surprising knowledge. The old woman then requests to see Jane.

The gypsy's presence emphasizes Brontë's interest in a supernatural connection between minds, which will come into play later in the novel.



CHAPTER 19

Alone with Jane, the gypsy hides behind a large hat. She describes how Jane feels lonely and represses her feelings. Though initially skeptical, Jane is awed by how much insight the gypsy has into her feelings. The gypsy says that Jane is very close to achieving happiness. She tells Jane that Blanche's dismay resulted from the gypsy's telling her that Rochester wasn't as rich as he seemed.

The gypsy really does seem to have mystical powers, and can see right into Jane's heart. Blanche, meanwhile, is revealed as totally shallow and interested only in money rather than love or any emotional connection.



The gypsy asks Jane about any love interests, which Jane denies having. Jane admits she is alone, but not sad. She says that thoughts of someday building a school cheer her up.

Blanche and the other women asked about love and husbands. Jane focuses on her own independent dreams.



As the gypsy woman continues speaking, her voice deepens, and Jane suddenly recognizes the gypsy's voice and hand—the gypsy is Rochester in disguise! (For a moment, Jane had suspected that the gypsy was Grace Poole.)

The disguise represents how Rochester masks the truth about his identity. He plays with people, including Jane, and shows them little respect.



Though furious with Rochester for fooling her, Jane still mentions Mr. Mason's arrival at Rochester. Rochester staggers and Jane holds him up. Rochester asks Jane if she would shun him if he were to experience a scandal. Jane promises to stand by him, and goes to bring Mr. Mason to Rochester.

Rochester's question implies that he doesn't think Jane would accept him for who he really is. It also suggests that he might be linked to the supernatural events at Thornfield. Jane is devoted to Rochester, however, and wants to serve him.



CHAPTER 20

That night, a scream rips through the midnight silence at Thornfield. All the guests run into the hallway, but Rochester calms everyone by saying that the noise came from a servant having a nightmare.

Secrets cannot be contained forever. The secrets of Rochester's past break out violently after being repressed for so long.



Once everyone has returned to bed, Rochester taps on Jane's bedroom door and asks for her help. They go up to Grace Poole's third floor room, where Mr. Mason lies bleeding from knife and bite wounds in his arm. They bandage him up and Rochester leaves to fetch a doctor, demanding that Jane and Mr. Mason not speak to each other while he's gone.

Jane is earning Rochester's confidence. But, by demanding silence, Rochester still tries to silence his past secrets. His late-night visit to Jane's bedroom would have been considered risqué in Brontë's time.



Jane is left alone in the dark with Mason. From Grace Poole's locked room down the hall emerge "canine" snarling sounds and human groans. Before dawn, Rochester returns with the surgeon. They sew up Mason and send him away before any of the guests wake.

Jane is kept in the dark about Rochester's secret, which seems more grave than ever. Since Mason could reveal Rochester's secrets, he must be silenced and removed from Thornfield.



Rochester takes Jane for a walk in the garden. He tells her about an obviously autobiographical story of a young man who got himself into serious trouble as a youth and then, to escape from that error, went on to lead a life of luxury and sinful excess. He asks, What if that man now wants to find redemption by living a good and moral life with a wife but is blocked from marrying her by the rules of society? Should he ignore those rules? Jane responds that the person should look not to any other person for redemption, but to God. Rochester then says that he will marry Blanche for his "regeneration," and changes the subject.

To gain redemption ("regeneration") from his secret sin, Rochester wants to ignore particular rules of society. He wants to take a short cut to redemption by marrying Blanche and living virtuously from here on out, without ever revealing his secret past. Jane's answer makes it clear that such shortcuts never work and are themselves immoral, but Rochester is not yet ready to hear it.



CHAPTER 21

One afternoon, a messenger from Gateshead brings Jane some shocking news. John Reed, heavily in debt from gambling, has committed suicide. Now Mrs. Reed is deathly ill and demands to see Jane, who travels from Thornfield to Gateshead.

With his debts, drinking, and suicide, John Reed contrasts with Jane's learning and poise, showing that virtues are not based on class.



At Gateshead, Jane has a pleasant reunion with Bessie. The Reed sisters, meanwhile, have grown into two very different types of people. Eliza is stern, organized, and highly religious, while Georgiana is a social butterfly who gushes about her romances.

The Reed sisters are caricatures of judgment and feeling taken to extremes. Jane has learned to avoid extremes and instead seeks balance.



Though she's on her deathbed, Mrs. Reed shows no remorse for her treatment of Jane. On the tenth day of Jane's visit, Mrs. Reed calls Jane into her room and confesses to keeping a letter from Jane. Jane's uncle—John Eyre, a successful wine merchant—had requested custody of Jane three years ago. But Mrs. Reed, hoping to squash any chance of Jane's getting ahead in life, told him that Jane had died of fever at Lowood. Jane is upset and angry, but nonetheless tries to heal her relationship with Mrs. Reed. She rebuffs Jane, and dies that night.

Mrs. Reed is a liar and lacks the religious virtue of repentance. Like Rochester in the attack on Mr. Mason and the fire in his room, Mrs. Reed has created a cover-up. He wants things his way, just as Mrs. Reed does, and is willing to lie to get what he wants. In contrast to them, and like a good Christian, Jane is able to forgive Mrs. Reed despite her awful actions.



CHAPTER 22

Jane stays at Gateshead for a month to settle the affairs of the Mrs. Reed's estate. Georgiana soon goes to London and eventually marries a rich gentleman. Eliza decides to enter a French convent where she eventually becomes Mother Superior.

Brontë criticizes Georgiana as just another rich aristocrat and portrays Eliza as a strict unfeeling nun in order to criticize Roman Catholicism.



While at Gateshead, Jane gets a letter from Mrs. Fairfax that says Rochester has gone to London to buy a carriage, presumably in preparation for his marriage to Blanche. Jane fears that her days at Thornfield are numbered.

Everyone assumes Rochester will marry Blanche because she is a member of his class. Blanche, living at Thornfield, would surely send Jane away.



On the road, Jane unexpectedly meets Rochester, who's out driving his new carriage. Rochester begs her to look at the carriage and to tell him "if you don't think it will suit Mrs. Rochester exactly." Jane is so excited to see Rochester that she exclaims how glad she is to return to him, and adds that "wherever you are is my home—my only home."

Jane's feelings for Rochester are now on full display. Yet her passionate declaration seems excessive and inappropriate since Rochester will most likely marry another woman...



CHAPTER 23

Two weeks after Jane returns to Thornfield, Rochester finds her in the garden and tells her that his plans to marry Blanche are decided. He tells Jane that he has found a governess job for her in Ireland. Jane, upset, says that Ireland is too far away. Jane explains how much she loves Thornfield. Rochester requests that she stay. But Jane fiercely declares her independence and equality, and rebukes him for choosing a loveless marriage.

Jane stands up to Rochester for prioritizing social concerns ahead of his feelings. Jane's passionate response comes in part from her thwarted feelings for Rochester, but also because he seems to think he can send her away, or keep her near, as he wishes.



Rochester confesses that he has no plans to marry Blanche. He was only trying to make Jane jealous. He passionately asks Jane to marry him. Jane at first thinks Rochester is teasing her, but he convinces her. Jane, overwhelmed with emotion, agrees to marry him.

Rochester loves Jane, but even in proposing to her he distorted the truth to make it seem like he was marrying Blanche. He still has not fully revealed himself or his secrets to Jane.



The weather suddenly changes into a downpour, and the couple rushes inside, where Rochester kisses Jane. Later that night, lightning splits the chestnut tree where they had sat when Rochester proposed.

The storm represents divine disapproval of the marriage. Rochester's secrets will split up their marriage, just as lightning split the tree.



CHAPTER 24

Rochester promises a wedding in four short weeks. After the engagement is announced, Mrs. Fairfax congratulates Jane weakly and warns her about men and marriages between unequal parties. Jane is irritated with Mrs. Fairfax's assumptions, but is also still a little suspicious of her fiancé.

In Brontë's time, it would have been scandalous for a gentleman to marry his governess. It's unclear if Mrs. Fairfax knows about Bertha, but even if not, she has reason to be suspicious of his rush to marry.



Feeling like she's living a fairy tale, Jane is exuberantly happy—at first. But when Rochester starts lavishing expensive gifts and flattering compliments on her, Jane feels objectified and degraded. She demands to be treated normally, to live on the salary she earns as a tutor, and to dress in her plain outfits.

Rochester treats Jane like Céline Varens. Jane refuses to be his love object, dependent on his gifts and money. Her self-respect stems from independence, not inflated self-esteem.



Jane privately decides to answer the letter from her uncle, John Eyre, which Mrs. Reed had kept from her. She does so because she thinks that if John Eyre made her his heir, as the letter stated, she would be closer to Rochester's equal in terms of class.

Unlike Blanche, Jane doesn't value money for its own sake. She needs it to be independent, to meet Rochester as an equal. Despite her love for Rochester, she senses the match isn't right.



Throughout the wedding planning process, Jane resists Rochester's romantic overtures. To put him off, she argues with him and aggravates him. But even so, she still worships him like an idol.

Jane puts Rochester before her love of God, which is a serious sin in Christianity and will require her repentance.



CHAPTER 25

The wedding day approaches and everything is packed for a honeymoon to Europe. While Rochester is briefly away on business, Jane wanders outside to see the lightning-blasted chestnut tree.

Jane's visit to the split tree shows that subconsciously she knows there is something wrong with this marriage even before she learns about Bertha.



When Rochester returns the next day, the day before the wedding, Jane tells him of the strange things that happened while he was away. First, she dreamed about being alone on a long, empty road with a pitiful crying child. In a second dream, she was waiting for Rochester at a ruined Thornfield with the same child, but tripped and dropped the child.

Jane's dreams suggest the distance she still feels from Rochester. The suffering child symbolizes an unhealthy future for their marriage. The decaying Thornfield foreshadows its actual destruction and represents the mess of Rochester's life.



This second dream startled Jane awake, and in the darkness of her room she saw a strange woman with wild hair and a discolored "savage" face going through her closet. The woman put on the wedding veil Rochester had bought for Jane, then tore it in half and stomped on it. Rochester dismisses the story as just another dream, then says that the woman must have been Grace Poole. Finally, he promises to explain everything a year and a day into their marriage.

Bertha appears as a terrifying image of a bride, which parallels Jane's anxieties about her marriage. The ripped veil, like the split tree, represents how Jane's wedding will be broken up. Instead of telling Jane the truth, Rochester delays his confession—an ominous start to a marriage based on equality.



Jane spends the night cradling Adèle in the nursery behind a bolted door. She cries when leaving Adèle in the morning.

As an independent tutor, Adèle represents the life that Jane is leaving behind.



CHAPTER 26

On the morning of the wedding, as Rochester hurries Jane to the church, Jane notices two strangers in the churchyard. The strangers also attend the ceremony. When the priest asks if anyone has any objections to the marriage about to take place, one of the strangers stands up and announces that there is an "impediment" to the marriage. Rochester insists that the ceremony proceed, but the clergyman refuses.

Rochester thought he was above the civil laws represented by the lawyer, and the religious laws represented by the church. He refused to repent his actions or reveals his secrets. Now, with the unraveling of his marriage, he must pay the price for his arrogant self-centeredness.



The stranger identifies himself as Mr. Briggs, a London lawyer, and reveals that Rochester is already married. 15 years ago in Jamaica, Rochester married a Creole woman, Bertha Mason, who still lives in Thornfield. The other stranger turns out to be her brother, Mr. Mason, who timidly comes forward to confirm the story.

Like Bertha, Mr. Mason is characterized negatively—as scheming, timid, and strange-looking—because of prevailing class prejudices against his West Indies origins and mixed-race background.



Rochester is furious. He concedes that the story is true, but stresses that neither Jane nor anyone else knew of Bertha. His wife is insane, he says, and is kept locked away on the third floor of Thornfield. He brings everyone back to Thornfield and they go up to the third floor. Behind a secret door stands Grace Poole and a disheveled "lunatic" pacing in the shadows. This is Bertha, who seems half-human, half-animal to Jane. Bertha attacks Rochester and he wrestles her into a chair. He goes on to explain that her family hid her insanity until after their marriage.

Bertha is made out to be a violent and insane monster, but there is method in her madness: all of her violence is directed against the people who took away her freedom, love, and identity. Her rage is unchecked. She is all feeling, no judgment. Ironically, Rochester, who has kept Bertha secretly locked up, claims to be a victim of families hiding their secrets.



Mr. Mason then reveals to Jane that he learned about her wedding plans with Rochester from a business acquaintance—Jane's uncle. After receiving Jane's letter, John Eyre sent Mason to save her from the sham marriage. John Eyre could not make the trip, as he is dying of consumption (tuberculosis).

Even though the fault would be Rochester's, Jane's reputation and future prospects would be ruined by this marriage.



Jane locks herself into her room. Feeling that all her hopes have been destroyed, she succumbs to a flood of sorrow over the troubles and betrayals that she has endured. She turns to God, and prays.

Jane is tested when she loses her entire family at Thornfield. Alone again, she calls upon the faith that Helen taught her.



CHAPTER 27

Jane realizes that she must leave Thornfield. But when she steps out of her room, she finds Rochester waiting for her. He asks her forgiveness. Jane doesn't respond, though she secretly forgives him immediately. Rochester then pleads with her to come live with him in southern France. Though she still loves him deeply, Jane refuses to go with him and become his mistress.

Jane loves Rochester, and so forgiving him is easy. Yet she knows that love is not everything, and that becoming Rochester's mistress would ruin her in the eyes of the law and God. A mistress can never be the equal of her lover, so Jane refuses to go with him.



Rochester admits that he acted cowardly and wrong and tells Jane the full truth about his past. Rochester's father left his entire fortune to his eldest son, Rochester's older brother. Rochester's father tried to secure a fortune for Rochester by making him a partner with Mason in the West Indies and arranging a marriage for him to Bertha, who was promised a huge inheritance. Rochester met Bertha only briefly, but was dazzled by her exoticism and beauty. However, after marrying her, Rochester learned that Bertha's mother was not dead, as he had been told. Rather, she was insane. Bertha is herself violent, coarse, and profoundly self-indulgent. Before long, she also followed her mother into insanity.

Aside from Jane, Rochester never respected the women in his life as thinking individuals, and in turn he paid an awful price. Like Adèle, Bertha inherits bad traits from her foreign mother—an example of typical Victorian prejudice against foreigners. Whereas Brontë characterizes the French as fickle, she portrays people from the West Indies as exotic, sensual, and temperamental.



By this point Rochester's father and brother had died. Legally bound to Bertha, Rochester returned to England, secretly installed her at Thornfield, and hired Grace Poole to watch over her. He then left Thornfield and spent years looking for another wife, specifically a European woman. Finding no one, Rochester plunged into debauchery with many mistresses, including Céline Varens. In the end, consorting with mistresses made him disgusted with himself, as it seemed almost like buying a slave. Eventually, he returned to England with Adèle. Then he met Jane, whom he loved from the first moment.

Rochester tries to escape his past by covering it up, and then by hiding from it through cheap pleasures and mistresses. He comes to realize that taking mistresses can only cover up his pain for so long, since it is itself sinful and exploitative. While his generous act of taking in Adèle shows his underlying goodness, his inability to reveal his secrets shows his pride.

For an instant, Jane considers staying with Rochester, reasoning that she deserves a devoted man after a life of isolation and neglect. She also fears that she may never find another. Yet at the same time she knows that she will respect herself only if she does what she knows is right. Still, she remains at Thornfield. But that night, Jane's mother appears to her in a dream and tells her to flee temptation. Fighting her own desires, Jane sneaks away from Thornfield with her modest belongings and hires a carriage on an unknown road.

Jane's mother is a spirit, a supernatural entity, yet Jane's dream could also just be an expression of her subconscious. Either way, the spirit carries a religious message. It helps Jane to renounce temptation and give up what she loves most in order to preserve her virtue. In the end, Jane prizes her independence and self-worth above her love for Rochester.

CHAPTER 28

Jane soon runs out of money. The carriage drops her off at a crossroads, and she realizes moments later that she left her belongings in the departed coach. With nowhere to turn, she spends the night outdoors contemplating the stars and God.

Stripped of everything and at a crossroads in her life, Jane begins a spiritual trial. She finds comfort in nature, which represents God's presence.

Jane walks into a nearby village to ask for work, which is scarce. She tries to exchange her gloves and handkerchief for **food**, but she is refused. Burning with shame but desperately hungry, Jane begs at a farm for some leftover porridge fed to the hogs.

Jane's quest for independence reaches a low point. Though on her own, she is dependent on strangers for charity. Her plight reflects the hardships of England's poor.

Weak from hunger and despair, Jane wanders into the wilderness expecting to die. She follows the light of a distant candle and finds a country house (Moor House) with two young women—the sisters Mary and Diana Rivers—inside studying German. Jane knocks, but the servant, Hannah, turns her away as a suspicious beggar.

Like the crossroads, the wilderness represents Jane's lack of direction in her time of trial. The candlelight is a beacon of hope that brings her to Moor House and to God.

Jane collapses outside, believing death is imminent and vowing to wait for God's will. Just then, the women's brother, St. John (pronounced "Sinjin") arrives home. He brings Jane into the house, where the River sisters give Jane food and a dry bed. Jane does not want to be discovered, so she identifies herself by a the false name of "Jane Elliott."

Jane gives herself up to God's will, as opposed to focusing on her own feelings, and is saved. Nonetheless, like Rochester, she and is not truthful with those who saved her.

CHAPTER 29

Jane is semi-conscious for three days. On waking on the fourth day, she finds her clothes cleaned and gets a hot **meal**. She criticizes Hannah for turning her away the night before. Hannah apologizes, then tells Jane about the Rivers family. Their father lost his fortune in a business deal and died just three weeks ago. Mary and Diana are still in school and afterwards will look for governess jobs. St. John is a poor parson.

There's a Christian allegory in Jane rising again after three days, just as Christ did after the crucifixion. And just as Christ was in a sense reborn, Jane is metaphorically born into a new family. The family also seems to be of her class, with two sisters in school and a parson who, like her father, works with the poor.



Later, Jane gives the Rivers a brief personal history, but refuses to reveal her real name or any details about her former employer. She claims to have no ties and no connections in England, and asks for help looking for work of any kind. St. John is firm but charitable, and promises to help. Mary and Diana, much warmer personalities than their brother, assure Jane that she can stay with them.

Like Rochester, Jane disguises her own identity and hides her past, as if she could make a new start. She wants to be self-supporting and free of her previous life, but this is an illusion. St. John, like Rochester, is a commanding male character.



CHAPTER 30

Jane quickly becomes friends with Mary and Diana. They share books and conversation, Jane teaches them drawing, and they all enjoy the hardy natural landscape. A month passes in this way, but then Mary and Diana must leave for their jobs as governesses in wealthy households. The Rivers sisters tell Jane that they suspect that St. John will also leave, maybe forever, to become a missionary.

Jane finds kinship and love with Mary and Diana, as she once did with Helen and Ms. Temple. They share an emotional and intellectual bond. The Rivers sisters mirror Jane in their educations, missing parents, and governess jobs.



St. John, unlike his sisters, remains pensive and distant at home. Jane visits his church and hears him preach a stern sermon that leaves her feeling sad. In conversation, the two of them realize that they both feel restless but in different ways.

Like Jane, St. John is restless for a "new servitude." But he seems to serve out of a cold religious passion that does not allow for any human feelings.



St. John offers Jane a position running a small school for the poor children of his parish in Morton. The pay and lodgings are meager, but Jane is glad for the job's independence, so she accepts.

The teaching job fits Jane's personality: independent, modest, and respectable. Jane can nurture virtues, not empty social conventions, in her students.



Soon after, a letter arrives informing St. John, Mary, and Diana that their wealthy uncle John has just died and left them nothing, with his fortune going to an unknown "other relation." They tell Jane that it was their uncle who led their father into his disastrous business failure.

The uncle turns out to be Jane's uncle, too—John Eyre. As his heir, Jane will have the opportunity to reconcile the families and repay the Rivers's charity.



CHAPTER 31

Jane starts work at her school. She has 20 students with little education. While Jane believes that personal potential is not limited to social class, she cannot help feeling a little degraded in becoming a small-town teacher and fears her life is going nowhere. Still, she thanks God for guiding her decision not to become Rochester's mistress.

As a teacher, Jane will instill in her students the education that gave her self-respect and strong morals. Since Jane has grown so much, the job now feels small to her, just as being Rochester's mistress would have felt small.



In conversation, St. John reassures Jane that he also had doubts about choosing his career in the parish church, but that now he has found his life's purpose—to become a missionary in India. St. John speaks with conviction about choosing the difficult but noble path in life.

St. John and Jane both have strong personalities and convictions, but their values differ. Jane learns from St. John about determination, but will choose a different path.



One of the school's benefactors is the rich and classically beautiful Rosamond Oliver. Jane can see that Rosamond and St. John are in love.

Rosamond's name is French for the "rose of the world." She represents the earthly desire that St. John rejects for his cold spiritual principles.



CHAPTER 32

As the days pass, Jane starts to enjoy her teaching, makes progress with her students, and becomes a respected favorite in the community. She enjoys her new life, but is unsettled by persistent and stirring dreams of Rochester.

Unlike St. John, Jane can't leave her true feelings behind. Jane's dreams are a window into her emotions and spirituality.



Rosamond makes frequent visits to the school, conveniently arriving when St. John is also there. Jane notices that St. John is visibly affected by Rosamond's presence. At home, Jane draws a **portrait** of Rosamond and offers it to St. John, hoping to learn more about his feelings. Infatuated, St. John gazes at the portrait and daydreams for a blissful 15 minutes. Jane sees her opportunity and boldly suggests that St. John marry Rosamond. St. John admits his love for her, but doubts that Rosamond would take well to missionary work. St. John says that he will not exchange earthly delights for the heavenly kingdom he is working so hard to reach. Suddenly, St. John spots something on the edge of Jane's drawing paper. He tears off a corner of it and, looking agitated, leaves abruptly. Jane, confused, dismisses the act as meaningless.

Jane surprises St. John in speaking to him more boldly and directly than women typically do. Jane wants St. John and Rosamond to marry in part because their happiness would substitute for the marriage that Jane cannot have. The portrait Jane draws represents passion and imagination. St. John's eventual rejection of these things reveals the main difference between St. John and Jane—Jane won't completely reject her feelings. What St. John sees on Jane's drawing paper is not immediately clear.



CHAPTER 33

The following night, St. John fights through the **snow** to visit Jane. He tells her a story which, to Jane's astonishment, is her own personal history. It ends with something she didn't know: after Jane disappeared from Thornfield, an urgent message came that her uncle John Eyre had died and left her a fortune of 20,000 pounds.

St. John is associated with ice and snow, symbolizing his cold personality and lack of affectionate emotions. The money will make Jane independent, without having to work or to marry for financial security.



Notices and letters were posted everywhere to find Jane. One reached St. John because John Eyre is in fact his uncle, too. St. John reveals to Jane his full name: St. John Eyre Rivers. His mother was Jane's father's sister, so St. John, Mary, and Diana are all Jane's cousins. St. John says he pieced together the mystery from the scrap of drawing paper he grabbed at the end of Chapter 32: it had her signature, "Jane Eyre." Jane is elated to suddenly have close family, and decides the best thing she could do is share her new fortune equally among all of them. Jane hopes the money will allow Mary, Diana, and St. John all to be financially independent and to live nearby.

Rochester ended up married to Bertha because social convention is that people do not share inheritances. Out of love and gratitude to the Rivers, Jane breaks that social rule. As for the Rivers, Jane's generosity rewards their true Christian charity, which was given without any expectation of compensation. In sharing her inheritance, Jane also atones for the injustices of her uncle, whose dealings impoverished the Rivers' father.



CHAPTER 34

When the winter holidays arrive, Jane closes her school and spends a happy Christmas with Mary and Diana, who have returned from their jobs. St. John, on the other hand, is increasingly distant and cold. Asked about Rosamond Oliver, St. John tells them she has recently married a wealthy aristocrat.

The cheery holidays illustrate the loving home that Jane has found. St. John though has little respect for worldly connections. He won't even admit unhappiness for having lost Rosamond.



One day, St. John finds Jane studying German and suggests that she learn "Hindostanee" instead—the language he's studying for his missionary work in India. Jane agrees, and notes that she feels as if St. John is slowly gaining a strong influence over her, but one that leaves her cold.

As happened with Rochester, Jane instinct towards "servitude" lead her into a position as a helper to a strong and commanding man.



Time passes. That summer, St. John takes Jane on a walk in the hills. St. John tells Jane she has admirable qualities, and proposes that she marry him and accompany him on his missionary work. But Jane's "heart is mute." She recognizes that she could never be happy as St. John's wife. She tells him she would only go to work in India as his sister. He responds that in denying his proposal she is denying the Christian faith.

Unlike Rochester, St. John only admires Jane's qualities for their usefulness. He wants her to be a traditional religious wife—an aide to her husband. He doesn't love her; he only loves his religion. While St. John believes that human hearts should only serve God, Jane wants the freedom to feel.



CHAPTER 35

St. John continues to try to convince Jane to marry him. Jane knows that working in India would be a tremendous sacrifice: the heat and heavy labor would soon take her life. She reflects that death doesn't scare her, but that she wants to feel real love in life. Diana agrees that Jane shouldn't go, saying that St. John wants Jane merely to be a tool in his great missionary cause.

Living an independent life, experiencing new feelings, and finding love are all important to Jane. She shows respect for God by trying to find a path that is true to all of her needs.



One evening after dinner, St. John reads prayers aloud with such fervor and command that Jane feels compelled to accept his marriage proposal.

The strength of St. John's mission and faith almost overwhelms Jane.



Yet just as she's about to give in, Jane hears Rochester's voice calling for help as if from a great distance: "Jane! Jane! Jane!" She rushes outside and cries out a promise to come to him.

While Jane's heart is "mute" to St. John, it speaks directly to Rochester. Jane's spiritual connection to Rochester restores her independence.



CHAPTER 36

As Jane prepares to leave to go to Thornfield, St. John slips a note under her door urging her to resist temptation. Though unsure herself, Jane feels that what's she's doing is right and that the voice and the "wondrous shock of feeling" she felt were real.

St. John thinks that all feeling is wrong. He does not value passion or human love. But Jane, while herself unsure, still believes in it.



On the journey to Thornfield, Jane thinks about the differences the year away has made in her. Formerly poor and alone, she now has a family and a fortune.

Jane used to be dependent on Rochester for family and money. Now she returns to him for love, and is independent.



At Thornfield, though, Jane is astonished to find the house burned down and in ruins.

Jane's dreams in Chapter 25 foreshadowed this destruction.



Jane learns what happened from the proprietor of a local inn. Bertha escaped and set Jane's old bedroom on **fire**. As the inferno spread, Rochester helped all the servants get out safely. But he could not save Bertha, who stood on the roof laughing maniacally and then jumped to her death. In the collapsing building, Rochester was badly injured: he lost a hand and lost his **sight**. He lives nearby in a modest house called Ferndean.

Bertha uses fire to destroy the room where Jane, who stole Bertha's husband's love, lived. Fire symbolizes Bertha's unrestrained passions and madness. The inferno represents the fatal consequences of Rochester's secrets. He loses his eyes, symbols of his pride and power, as punishment from God.



CHAPTER 37

Jane travels to Ferndean, which is deep in the forest. When she arrives, she sees Rochester in the yard. He looks physically strong still, but now his face looks desperate and sad. Rochester shrugs off the help of a servant, wanders hesitatingly around the yard, and returns inside.

In crisis, Rochester ends up in the woods, just as Jane wandered in the wilderness during her crisis. Though diminished, Rochester still tries to remain independent, refusing all help.



Jane knocks and talks with the servants at the door. Jane then takes to Rochester a tray with a glass of water that he had asked a servant to bring him. Jane enters the parlor and offers him the water. He recognizes Jane's voice and thinks at first that she is a ghost, but then catches her hand and takes her into his arms, brimming with emotion.

Jane literally takes the place of the servant by bringing the tray—she returns to Rochester to serve him forever. Rochester may be physically powerless, but he is still her master.



Jane updates Rochester about her new wealth and leads him on about St. John, jokingly using jealousy to distract him from misery. Rochester mentions all of his infirmities, and advises Jane to go her own way. But Jane, loving him more than ever, promises never to leave him again. Rochester asks her to marry him. Jane joyfully accepts.

Jane's teasing and Rochester's newfound humility show that Jane is also Rochester's master. They are equals—each other's masters—and so their marriage is a joining of two independent people.



Rochester tells Jane about his new repentant relationship with God. He feels punished for his pride and now prays regularly. One evening, asking for God's help in restoring his happiness, he had involuntarily called out for "Jane! Jane! Jane!" and felt as if he heard her respond. Jane is awed by their shared connection. Serving as "his prop and his guide," she leads him home.

Rochester was punished for his pride and arrogance through divine justice. Rochester finally finds redemption through religion. Like Jane after her time of trials that led her to Moor house, Rochester is chastened, prayerful, and humble.



CHAPTER 38

The final chapter begins with the famous line: "Reader, I married him." Remaining at Ferndean, Jane and Rochester have a small, quiet wedding and live in perfect harmony. Jane never tires of guiding her husband, reading aloud to him, and describing the landscape to him. St. John never comments on Jane's marriage, but Mary and Diana are overjoyed about it.

Jane is Rochester's prop and his guide, both his servant and his master. She becomes his eyes, which were a symbol of his power. St. John does not respond because human love means nothing to him, but the rest of Jane's family is joyful.



Jane visits Adèle and finds her unhappy in a harsh school. Jane transfers her to a more liberal one closer to home. Through a good English education, Adèle's "French defects" are purged and she grows into a polite and principled young woman.

Jane represents specifically English values, nurtured in good homes and schools. In reforming Adèle, Jane also reforms Rochester's sinful past.



Two years into their marriage, Rochester partially regains sight in one eye in time to see the birth of their first baby: a son who inherits Rochester's brilliant black **eyes**.

Rochester's regained sight shows how God tempers justice with mercy. The son represents Rochester's redemption.



Writing ten years after the events of the novel, Jane informs the reader that Diana and Mary both have married respectable and caring husbands and visit regularly. St. John went to India alone. She says that in his last letter, St. John said that he had a premonition of his death, and she adds that she does not expect another letter from him. Jane ends by saying that she doesn't grieve for St. John, who has done God's work, and then quotes St. John's last letter, in which he begs his Master, Jesus Christ, to take him soon.

St. John is solitary and strong, but his fate is sad. He and Jane both craved and found a "master" they can serve. Unlike St. John, however, Jane doesn't sacrifice herself (or her life) in order to serve that master and be virtuous. Instead, Jane has found a balance between love and purpose, and between independence and service.



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TOPIC: CHARLOTTE BRONTE **Plot Overview**

SUMMARY PLOT OVERVIEW

Jane Eyre is a young orphan being raised by Mrs. Reed, her cruel, wealthy aunt. A servant named Bessie provides Jane with some of the few kindnesses she receives, telling her stories and singing songs to her. One day, as punishment for fighting with her bullying cousin John Reed, Jane's aunt imprisons Jane in the red-room, the room in which Jane's Uncle Reed died. While locked in, Jane, believing that she sees her uncle's ghost, screams and faints. She wakes to find herself in the care of Bessie and the kindly apothecary Mr. Lloyd, who suggests to Mrs. Reed that Jane be sent away to school. To Jane's delight, Mrs. Reed concurs.

Once at the Lowood School, Jane finds that her life is far from idyllic. The school's headmaster is Mr. Brocklehurst, a cruel, hypocritical, and abusive man. Brocklehurst preaches a doctrine of poverty and privation to his students while using the school's funds to provide a wealthy and opulent lifestyle for his own family. At Lowood, Jane befriends a young girl named Helen Burns, whose strong, martyrlike attitude toward the school's miseries is both helpful and displeasing to Jane. A massive typhus epidemic sweeps Lowood, and Helen dies of consumption. The epidemic also results in the departure of Mr. Brocklehurst by attracting attention to the insalubrious conditions at Lowood. After a group of more sympathetic gentlemen takes Brocklehurst's place, Jane's life improves dramatically. She spends eight more years at Lowood, six as a student and two as a teacher.

After teaching for two years, Jane yearns for new experiences. She accepts a governess position at a manor called Thornfield, where she teaches a lively French girl named Adèle. The distinguished housekeeper Mrs. Fairfax presides over the estate. Jane's employer at Thornfield is a dark, impassioned man named Rochester, with whom Jane finds herself falling secretly in love. She saves Rochester from a fire one night, which he claims was started by a drunken servant named Grace Poole. But because Grace Poole continues to work at Thornfield, Jane concludes that she has not been told the entire story. Jane sinks into despondency when Rochester brings home a beautiful but vicious woman named Blanche Ingram. Jane expects Rochester to propose to Blanche. But Rochester instead proposes to Jane, who accepts almost disbelievingly.

The wedding day arrives, and as Jane and Mr. Rochester prepare to exchange their vows, the voice of Mr. Mason cries out that Rochester already has a wife. Mason introduces himself as the brother of that wife—a woman named Bertha. Mr. Mason testifies that Bertha, whom Rochester married when he was a young man in Jamaica, is still alive. Rochester does not deny Mason's claims, but he explains that Bertha has gone mad. He takes the wedding party back to Thornfield, where they witness the insane Bertha Mason scurrying around on all fours and growling like an animal. Rochester keeps Bertha hidden on the third story of Thornfield and pays Grace Poole to keep his

wife under control. Bertha was the real cause of the mysterious fire earlier in the story. Knowing that it is impossible for her to be with Rochester, Jane flees Thornfield.

Penniless and hungry, Jane is forced to sleep outdoors and beg for food. At last, three siblings who live in a manor alternatively called Marsh End and Moor House take her in. Their names are Mary, Diana, and St. John (pronounced "Sinjin") Rivers, and Jane quickly becomes friends with them. St. John is a clergyman, and he finds Jane a job teaching at a charity school in Morton. He surprises her one day by declaring that her uncle, John Eyre, has died and left her a large fortune: 20,000 pounds. When Jane asks how he received this news, he shocks her further by declaring that her uncle was also his uncle: Jane and the Riverses are cousins. Jane immediately decides to share her inheritance equally with her three newfound relatives.

St. John decides to travel to India as a missionary, and he urges Jane to accompany him—as his wife. Jane agrees to go to India but refuses to marry her cousin because she does not love him. St. John pressures her to reconsider, and she nearly gives in. However, she realizes that she cannot abandon forever the man she truly loves when one night she hears Rochester's voice calling her name over the moors. Jane immediately hurries back to Thornfield and finds that it has been burned to the ground by Bertha Mason, who lost her life in the fire. Rochester saved the servants but lost his eyesight and one of his hands. Jane travels on to Rochester's new residence, Ferndean, where he lives with two servants named John and Mary.

At Ferndean, Rochester and Jane rebuild their relationship and soon marry. At the end of her story, Jane writes that she has been married for ten blissful years and that she and Rochester enjoy perfect equality in their life together. She says that after two years of blindness, Rochester regained sight in one eye and was able to behold their first son at his birth.

Love Versus Autonomy

Jane Eyre is very much the story of a quest to be loved. Jane searches, not just for romantic love, but also for a sense of being valued, of belonging. Thus Jane says to Helen Burns: "to gain some real affection from you, or Miss Temple, or any other whom I truly love, I would willingly submit to have the bone of my arm broken, or to let a bull toss me, or to stand behind a kicking horse, and let it dash its hoof at my chest" (Chapter 8). Yet, over the course of the book, Jane must learn how to gain love *without* sacrificing and harming herself in the process.

Her fear of losing her autonomy motivates her refusal of Rochester's marriage proposal. Jane believes that "marrying" Rochester while he remains legally tied to Bertha would mean rendering herself a mistress and sacrificing her own integrity for the sake of emotional gratification. On the other hand, her life at Moor House tests

her in the opposite manner. There, she enjoys economic independence and engages in worthwhile and useful work, teaching the poor; yet she lacks emotional sustenance. Although St. John proposes marriage, offering her a partnership built around a common purpose, Jane knows their marriage would remain loveless.

Nonetheless, the events of Jane's stay at Moor House are necessary tests of Jane's autonomy. Only after proving her self-sufficiency to herself can she marry Rochester and not be asymmetrically dependent upon him as her "master." The marriage can be one between equals. As Jane says: "I am my husband's life as fully as he is mine. . . . To be together is for us to be at once as free as in solitude, as gay as in company. . . . We are precisely suited in character—perfect concord is the result" (Chapter 38).

Religion

Throughout the novel, Jane struggles to find the right balance between moral duty and earthly pleasure, between obligation to her spirit and attention to her body. She encounters three main religious figures: Mr. Brocklehurst, Helen Burns, and St. John Rivers. Each represents a model of religion that Jane ultimately rejects as she forms her own ideas about faith and principle, and their practical consequences.

Mr. Brocklehurst illustrates the dangers and hypocrisies that Charlotte Brontë perceived in the nineteenth-century Evangelical movement. Mr. Brocklehurst adopts the rhetoric of Evangelicalism when he claims to be purging his students of pride, but his method of subjecting them to various privations and humiliations, like when he orders that the naturally curly hair of one of Jane's classmates be cut so as to lie straight, is entirely un-Christian. Of course, Brocklehurst's proscriptions are difficult to follow, and his hypocritical support of his own luxuriously wealthy family at the expense of the Lowood students shows Brontë's wariness of the Evangelical movement. Helen Burns's meek and forbearing mode of Christianity, on the other hand, is too passive for Jane to adopt as her own, although she loves and admires Helen for it.

Many chapters later, St. John Rivers provides another model of Christian behavior. His is a Christianity of ambition, glory, and extreme self-importance. St. John urges Jane to sacrifice her emotional deeds for the fulfillment of her moral duty, offering her a way of life that would require her to be disloyal to her own self.

Although Jane ends up rejecting all three models of religion, she does not abandon morality, spiritualism, or a belief in a Christian God. When her wedding is interrupted, she prays to God for solace (Chapter 26). As she wanders the heath, poor and starving, she puts her survival in the hands of God (Chapter 28). She strongly objects to Rochester's lustful immorality, and she refuses to consider living with him while church and state still deem him married to

another woman. Even so, Jane can barely bring herself to leave the only love she has ever known. She credits God with helping her to escape what she knows would have been an immoral life (Chapter 27).

Jane ultimately finds a comfortable middle ground. Her spiritual understanding is not hateful and oppressive like Brocklehurst's, nor does it require retreat from the everyday world as Helen's and St. John's religions do. For Jane, religion helps curb immoderate passions, and it spurs one on to worldly efforts and achievements. These achievements include full self-knowledge and complete faith in God.

Social Class

Jane Eyre is critical of Victorian England's strict social hierarchy. Brontë's exploration of the complicated social position of governesses is perhaps the novel's most important treatment of this theme. Like Heathcliff in *Wuthering Heights,* Jane is a figure of ambiguous class standing and, consequently, a source of extreme tension for the characters around her. Jane's manners, sophistication, and education are those of an aristocrat, because Victorian governesses, who tutored children in etiquette as well as academics, were expected to possess the "culture" of the aristocracy. Yet, as paid employees, they were more or less treated as servants; thus, Jane remains penniless and powerless while at Thornfield. Jane's understanding of the double standard crystallizes when she becomes aware of her feelings for Rochester; she is his intellectual, but not his social, equal. Even before the crisis surrounding Bertha Mason, Jane is hesitant to marry Rochester because she senses that she would feel indebted to him for "condescending" to marry her. Jane's distress, which appears most strongly in Chapter 17, seems to be Brontë's critique of Victorian class attitudes.

Jane herself speaks out against class prejudice at certain moments in the book. For example, in Chapter 23 she chastises Rochester: "Do you think, because I am poor, obscure, plain, and little, I am soulless and heartless? You think wrong!—I have as much soul as you—and full as much heart! And if God had gifted me with some beauty and much wealth, I should have made it as hard for you to leave me, as it is now for me to leave you." However, it is also important to note that nowhere in *Jane Eyre* are society's boundaries bent. Ultimately, Jane is only able to marry Rochester as his equal because she has almost magically come into her own inheritance from her uncle.

Gender Relations

Jane struggles continually to achieve equality and to overcome oppression. In addition to class hierarchy, she must fight against patriarchal domination—against those who believe women to be inferior to men and try to treat them as such. Three central male figures threaten her desire for equality and dignity: Mr. Brocklehurst, Edward Rochester, and St. John Rivers. All three are misogynistic on some level. Each tries to keep Jane in a submissive position, where she is unable to express her own thoughts and feelings. In her quest for independence and self-knowledge, Jane must escape Brocklehurst, reject St. John, and come to Rochester only after ensuring that they may

marry as equals. This last condition is met once Jane proves herself able to function, through the time she spends at Moor House, in a community and in a family. She will not depend solely on Rochester for love and she can be financially independent. Furthermore, Rochester is blind at the novel's end and thus dependent upon Jane to be his "prop and guide." In Chapter 12, Jane articulates what was for her time a radically feminist philosophy:

Women are supposed to be very calm generally: but women feel just as men feel; they need exercise for their faculties, and a field for their efforts as much as their brothers do; they suffer from too rigid a restraint, too absolute a stagnation, precisely as men would suffer; and it is narrow-minded in their more privileged fellow-creatures to say that they ought to confine themselves to making puddings and knitting stockings, to playing on the piano and embroidering bags. It is thoughtless to condemn them, or laugh at them, if they seek to do more or learn more than custom has pronounced necessary for their sex.

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Jane Eyre - The protagonist and narrator of the novel, Jane is an intelligent, honest, plain-featured young girl forced to contend with oppression, inequality, and hardship. Although she meets with a series of individuals who threaten her autonomy, Jane repeatedly succeeds at asserting herself and maintains her principles of justice, human dignity, and morality. She also values intellectual and emotional fulfillment. Her strong belief in gender and social equality challenges the Victorian prejudices against women and the poor.

Edward Rochester - Jane's employer and the master of Thornfield, Rochester is a wealthy, passionate man with a dark secret that provides much of the novel's suspense. Rochester is unconventional, ready to set aside polite manners, propriety, and consideration of social class in order to interact with Jane frankly and directly. He is rash and impetuous and has spent much of his adult life roaming about Europe in an attempt to avoid the consequences

of his youthful indiscretions. His problems are partly the result of his own recklessness, but he is a sympathetic figure because he has suffered for so long as a result of his early marriage to Bertha.

St. John Rivers - Along with his sisters, Mary and Diana, St. John (pronounced "Sinjin") serves as Jane's benefactor after she runs away from Thornfield, giving her food and shelter. The minister at Morton, St. John is cold, reserved, and often controlling in his interactions with others. Because he is entirely alienated from his feelings and devoted solely to an austere ambition, St. John serves as a foil to Edward Rochester.

Mrs. Reed - Mrs. Reed is Jane's cruel aunt, who raises her at Gateshead Hall until Jane is sent away to school at age ten. Later in her life, Jane attempts reconciliation with her aunt, but the old woman continues to resent her because her husband had always loved Jane more than his own children.

Bessie Lee - The maid at Gateshead, Bessie is the only figure in Jane's childhood who regularly treats her kindly, telling her stories and singing her songs. Bessie later marries Robert Leaven, the Reeds' coachman.

Mr. Lloyd - Mr. Lloyd is the Reeds' apothecary, who suggests that Jane be sent away to school. Always kind to Jane, Mr. Lloyd writes a letter to Miss Temple confirming Jane's story about her childhood and clearing Jane of Mrs. Reed's charge that she is a liar.

Georgiana Reed - Georgiana Reed is Jane's cousin and one of Mrs. Reed's two daughters. The beautiful Georgiana treats Jane cruelly when they are children, but later in their lives she befriends her cousin and confides in her. Georgiana attempts to elope with a man named Lord Edwin Vere, but her sister, Eliza, alerts Mrs. Reed of the arrangement and sabotages the plan. After Mrs. Reed dies, Georgiana marries a wealthy man.

Eliza Reed - Eliza Reed is Jane's cousin and one of Mrs. Reed's two daughters (along with her sister, Georgiana). Not as beautiful as her sister, Eliza devotes herself somewhat self-righteously to the church and eventually goes to a convent in France where she becomes the Mother Superior.

John Reed - John Reed is Jane's cousin, Mrs. Reed's son, and brother to Eliza and Georgiana. John treats Jane with appalling cruelty during their childhood and later falls into a life of drinking and gambling. John commits suicide midway through the novel when his mother ceases to pay his debts for him.

Helen Burns - Helen Burns is Jane's close friend at the Lowood School. She endures her miserable life there with a passive dignity that Jane cannot understand. Helen dies of consumption in Jane's arms.

WOLFNOTE SUMMARY OF...

GEORGE ORWELL's

ANIMAL FARM



Table of Contents

Context
The Author
List of Characters
Characterisation

Introduction
Chapter 1
Chapter 2
Chapter 3
Chapter 4
Chapter 5
Chapter 6
Chapter 7
Chapter 8
Chapter 9
Chapter 10
Conclusion

Questions and Answers

Context

This story is set in Manor Farm later to be renamed Animal Farm.

The most respected animal at Manor Farm is the prize boar called Old Major. He is concerned at the neglect and cruelty he and the fellow animals suffer at the hands of Farmer Jones and his men. Just prior to his death, he tells the other animals of his dream for a new life for them all, but this can only take place if the animals rebel against Farmer Jones.

This opportunity arises shortly after Old Major's death when the animals drive the drunken farmer and his men from the farm and they call their new home Animal Farm.

Immediately, the pigs assume control over the administration of the farm and they draw up the Seven Commandments, which is the basis of the new system known as Animalism and is founded on Old Major's ideas.

From the start, there is a battle for power over the animals by two young boars named Napoleon and Snowball.

When Jones tries to recapture the farm, Napoleon and Snowball unite, but after the Battle of the Cowshed, the two young boars are in conflict once again.

Using trained dogs, which Napoleon has reared from puppies, he eventually wins the power struggle and Snowball is chased from the farm. Napoleon adopts many of Snowball's ideas, including the windmill project.

Initially, the new animal society is successful, but soon the animals' living conditions worsen due to the increasing appetites of the inefficient pigs and dogs. Slowly the Seven Commandments are transformed in order to support the pigs' actions.

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Whenever things go wrong in the community, Napoleon blames Snowball and threatens the animals with the return of Farmer Jones if they do not continue working hard for Animal Farm. Using threats and the odd execution, Napoleon maintains order.

Unknown to the rest of the animals, he negotiates with neighboring human farmers regarding the sale of produce.

Despite further attempts by the humans to retake the farm, the animals continue their control and eventually the windmill is completed. However, it is only the pigs that benefit from the prosperity obtained by the farm and their behavior towards the rest of the animals becomes more human-like. They start walking on their hind legs and carrying whips.

The story ends with the working animals observing Napoleon through the farmhouse windows entertaining his human neighbors.

It is now impossible to distinguish pigs from men.

The Author

Eric Blair's pseudonym was 'George Orwell'. He was born in India in 1903, son of an Indian Civil Servant. Traditionally, he was brought to England to be educated, and eventually ended up at Eton on a scholarship in 1917.

He graduated in 1921 and decided not to go to University, but took up a post with the Civil Service in Burma, and he became a Sergeant in the Indian Imperial Police. He served in Burma until 1927 and reports are that he did not rest easy with the authority he had to wield over the Burmese people, and he resigned his post in 1927.

He spent a year among the homeless, and these experiences formed the basis of his first book called 'Down and Out in Paris and London', published in 1933.

He worked as a teacher and after he married, ran a village pub and general store with his wife. At this time he was only making a small income from his written work and it was not until after the war that he would earn sufficient as an author.

He became involved in the Spanish Civil War and ended up enlisting on the Republican side. This decision was to result in him and his wife being forced to leave Spain. He wrote the book 'Homage to Catalonia' in 1938 based on his experiences in Spain.

He suffered from tuberculosis, which prevented him serving in the armed forces during the war, but he did accept a position in the Home Guard.

He was also an active socialist and produced many works during the war for various newspapers.

In 1945, the first of the two books for which he is generally known was published, 'Animal Farm'. This book was particularly successful in the United States, and Orwell at last enjoyed a good income from this.

Orwell was one of the few people who can be regarded as classless. He was a passionate socialist and regarded as extremely honest. It is surprising, therefore, that he was able to show this, having been educated at Eton, but he was more at home in a public house than in the halls of Eton.

He had the courage to pursue his convictions, thus his involvement in the Spanish Civil War. He strongly opposed the major forces in the world during his time such as Stalinism and Fascism, and through the power of his pen, did all he could to decry these orthodoxies in his works 'Animal Farm' and 'Homage to Catalonia', which should be read in tandem.

He had moved to the Scottish Hebrides so that he could concentrate more on his writing, in particular adding the finishing touches to '1984' which was published in 1949.

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Orwell's projection of a society in the near future was greatly acclaimed, and was standard reading material for English students in Great Britain.

Orwell died prematurely in London in early 1950 from exhaustion and poor health.

LIST OF CHARACTERS

THE ANIMALS

NAPOLEON (young boar)

Napoleon eventually becomes the tyrant of Animal Farm, which he obtains through his ruthlessness and cunning character. As the story develops, he becomes more distant from the rest of the animals. Like his namesake, Napoleon Bonaparte he is the chief revolutionary in the animals' overthrow of Farmer Jones. This revolution was designed to bring about Old Major's vision for the future, but Napoleon takes the responsibility for twisting Old Major's dream so that it becomes unrecognizable. He is also an opportunist and is able to manipulate events to his own purpose.

SNOWBALL (young boar)

Of all the pigs, Snowball is the most articulate and innovative. He can visualize Old Major's dream and does all in his power to make it a reality. He is used initially by Napoleon for his tactical ability and his intelligence, but once he has served his purpose, he is disposed of by Napoleon. Initially he provided an important link between the pigs and the other animals and in this respect his persuasive rhetoric was an asset. Unlike Napoleon he showed courage in the battles, but it is his naïve nature that fails to alert him to Napoleon's lust for power.

SQUEALER (pig)

On the departure of Snowball, Squealer becomes Napoleon's right-hand pig. He too has strong powers of communication and is used to twist the doctrines of Old Major. One might describe him as a propagandist of the animal society promoting Napoleon's ideas, but like Napoleon he too is a hypocrite. He is the eyes and ears of Napoleon, and keeps him informed regarding any dissent amongst the other animals.

OLD MAJOR (old boar)

At the start of the story, he is the oldest animal on the farm and would have become the natural leader in the new order. He sows the seeds of revolution, but does not see this come into fruition. He is the only pig to truly care for all the farm animals, and is thus respected by them all.

BOXER (cart-horse)

Boxer is a kind, hard-working horse of immense strength and contributes greatly to the initial success of Animal Farm. What he lacks in intelligence, he makes up for with his physical prowess and is able to ensure that the labor-intensive projects are completed successfully. His lack of intelligence is exploited by the pigs and he remains loyal to the new system despite its flaws. Napoleon feels challenged by the respect Boxer enjoys from the other animals. His death towards the end of the story is one of the most tragic aspects of Animal Farm.

CLOVER (mare)

Like Boxer, she is a hard worker for the community, and Orwell takes pains to supply the reader with a detailed character analysis. She is protective of her foals and displays kindness to all the animals, but in particular to Boxer. Like Boxer, she represents the true working class of the animal community. She perhaps understands the ideals of animalism better than Boxer, and she remains loyal to these doctrines with the hope that Old Major's dream will eventually be fulfilled. She realizes that the pigs are being manipulative, but lacks the courage to oppose them.

BENJAMIN (donkey)

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Unlike the two cart-horses, Benjamin is intelligent and soon realizes the ideals of animalism are not being followed, and is cynical about their new way of life under Napoleon's rule. His loyalty lies with Boxer and Clover, but he recognizes that the pigs are no better than the humans. His views are not considered by the other animals during the initial success of Animal Farm, but eventually he is proved right.

MOLLY (mare)

Molly was more a pet for the farmer and has reservations about the new order, and contributes little to the working of Animal Farm. The revolution results in a loss of the privileges she enjoyed under Farmer Jones' regime, and she soon leaves the community so that she can enjoy life elsewhere.

MOSES (raven)

A highly religious bird, Moses tells the animals stories about the life hereafter on Sugar Candy Mountain. He is untrustworthy and some animals suspect him of being a spy, but for whom they are not sure. At the start of the story he is a human pet, but returns later and is accepted by the pigs.

THE DOGS

The dogs are closely linked to the pigs, some being reared by Napoleon from puppies. They quickly change their loyalty from Farmer Jones to Napoleon. They enjoy a privileged position alongside the pigs solely due to the fact that they are the police force of the animal society.

THE SHEEP

Not surprisingly, the sheep represent the most stupid element of the animal society. They have the most difficulty in understanding the aims of the revolution and in learning to become literate. They abbreviate the Seven Commandments to one slogan, "Four legs good, two legs bad". The pigs use the sheep as a means of oppressing free speech by encouraging them to bleat ceaselessly.

THE PIGS

As a group they are considered by the other animals as the most intelligent and capable of creatures. It is they who devise the Commandments on which the new order will be based. Collectively, they make all the decisions and innovations necessary on the farm.

THE HENS

These are the only animals to put up any resistance to Napoleon. They remember one of Old Major's initial ideals that hens' eggs should not be taken, as this is "inhumane". When Napoleon instructs that this is to continue, they rebel by smashing their eggs. They are cruelly oppressed by Napoleon.

THE CAT

Like Molly, the cat loses a lot after the revolution and her selfish attitude is evident when she cannot appreciate that the animals suffer at the hands of Farmer Jones. She is prepared to enjoy the benefits of the revolution, but is a parasite and does not work towards Animal Farm's success. She does agree that making the animals literate is a good idea, and attempts to persuade the sparrows to learn how to read.

THE HUMANS

FARMER JONES

Jones manages his farm poorly and is often drunk and during these times he forgets to feed his stock or ensure that they are safely bedded down for the night. The farm is a means for supporting his drunkenness and he puts very little effort into the farm, treating his livestock cruelly. He is used by the pigs as a threat when some show dissent, so he has a more influential part to play in the storyline after he has been forcibly removed from Manor Farm. His wife is rarely mentioned in the book, but she too is portrayed unfavorably.

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PILKINGTON

He is a neighboring farmer who is also neglectful of his stock, spending most of his time hunting and fishing. Napoleon tries to persuade him to attack the farm in an attempt to play him off against another neighboring farmer, Frederick. For a short time towards the end of the story, he becomes an ally to the pigs.

FREDERICK

In contrast to Jones and Pilkington, Frederick runs an efficient farm realizing that you get more out of your farm if you put more effort into it. He is, however, a shrewd individual and in his dealings with Napoleon he is shown to be an adept businessman, successfully tricking Napoleon.

CHARACTERISATION

Orwell provides precise characterizations for the main animals in the early Chapters of the book. He describes Old Major clearly in the third paragraph of Chapter 1 – "ensconced on his bed of straw, under a lantern which hung from a beam. He was twelve years old and had lately grown rather stout, but he was still a majestic-looking pig with a wise and benevolent appearance in spite of the fact that his tushes had never been cut."

We learn that Napoleon "was a large, rather fierce-looking Berkshire boar …… not much of a talker, but with a reputation for getting his own way."

For Snowball we read that he "was a more vivacious pig, quicker in speech and more inventive, but was not considered to have the same depth of character."

The other major pig in the story is Squealer and we never obtain a real clue as to his character, for his role is that of mouthpiece of Napoleon. We can assume that he is a survivor, and bends with the wind, and he is ideally suited to the role of Napoleon's propaganda machine because of his persuasive rhetoric. An example of this was during the milk and apples situation, in that the animals did not receive a share of this produce. Squealer's response was, "Comrades! You do not imagine, I hope, that we pigs are doing this in a spirit of selfishness and privilege? Many of us actually dislike milk and apples. …… Our sole object in taking these things is to preserve our health. Milk and apples contain substances absolutely necessary to the well-being of a pig. We pigs are brain workers. …… Day and night we are watching over your welfare." The reader can imagine similar rhetoric being transmitted over Tannoy systems in Red China and Russia to the commune workers.

For Boxer we learn that he is "an enormous beast, nearly eighteen hands high, and as strong as any two ordinary horses put together. A white stripe down his nose gave him a somewhat stupid appearance, and in fact he was not of first rate intelligence, but he was universally respected for his steadiness of character and tremendous powers of work."

Finally, Orwell describes the donkey Benjamin after the rebellion thus, "the donkey seemed quite unchanged …… He did his work in the same slow obstinate way that he had done in Jones' time, never shirking and never volunteering for extra work either. When asked whether he was not happier now that Jones was gone, he would only say 'Donkeys live a long time. None of you has ever seen a dead donkey' and the others had to be content with this cryptic answer."

INTRODUCTION

George Orwell started this project in the winter of 1943 and it was designed to be a parody on the Russian Revolution of 1917 and subsequent history. His satire on 20th Century Russia is one of the reasons why the book has been so successful in the west, and in particular in the United States.

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The history of Animal Farm has many parallels with that of Russia. When you consider that Old Major is based on Karl Marx and Farmer Jones is Tsar Nicolas II, you can soon make similar comparisons with the other characters in the book. More details of this will be given in the Questions section at the end.

However, to merely limit the comparison of Animal Farm to Russian history is to do an injustice to the subject matter of this book. Orwell makes deeper suggestions concerning human nature within the storyline and the reader should be aware of this.

Animal Farm is one of the milestones of Utopian fiction and stands alongside such works as Plato's 'Republic', Sir Thomas More's 'Utopia', and Swift's 'Gulliver's Travels'.

Orwell's main thrust in this novel is an attempt to protect true socialism from communism and his anti-Utopian theme is directed at this aim.

CHAPTER 1

The drunken Mr. Jones fails to finish his chores before going to bed and he leaves the chicken coup open.

Major holds a meeting in the barn and he tells the animals about his dream for a better future for all the animals on the farm – a world in which they rule themselves and live in freedom and peace. This new world would have a set of rules by which the animals would live, e.g. that they would not live in a house and they would always walk on four legs, except for the chickens. He teaches them a song called, 'Beasts of England' -

"Beasts of England, beasts of Ireland,

beasts of every land and clime,

hearken to my joyful tidings

of the golden future time.

"Rings shall vanish from our noses,

and the harness from our back,

bit and spur shall rust forever,

cruel whips no more shall crack.

"For that day we all must labor,

though we die before it break;

cows and horses, geese and turkeys,

all must toil for freedom's sake."

The noise wakens the farmer who fires his gun into the animals to suppress the noise.

Interpretation

It requires an effort of imagination by the reader to truly appreciate the strange situation of this storyline.

Orwell helps us to do this by telling the story exclusively through the eyes of the animals, so we soon view them as a collection of "citizens". Although we view events from the animals' perspective, the view is always kept impersonal. This approach keeps the human beings always in the background and the main action is contained within the animal world.

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Orwell is anxious to provide a character analysis of the main animals and he does this right at the start through the descriptive paragraphs covering the animals entrance to the big barn, for example – in describing Boxer the cart-horse, Orwell says that he has "a white stripe down his nose which gave him a somewhat stupid appearance, and in fact he was not of first-rate intelligence". He uses other succinct phrases in dealing with the other animals. By and large, most of the animals do not change throughout the storyline. The livestock retain enough animal characteristics for the story to have authenticity, but their ideas and dialogue are distinctly human.

The reader quickly adapts to this idea that animals can think and talk like humans on hearing Old Major's speech.

The doctrine that Old Major spouts is clearly similar to the ideas of Marx and also Lenin. From these principles will emerge 'Animal Farm'.

Although the animals will soon adopt Old Major's ideology, they will then lose the peaceful pastoral scene that Old Major describes in his song, 'Beasts of England'.

Old Major's dream for the future is naïve and over-sentimentalized. Perhaps he thinks it will never take place, and that animals will always be slaves of humans.

It is important that the reader quickly establishes the nature of each animal in the storyline, and so the paragraphs dealing with their entry into the barn should be read in depth.

CHAPTER 2

Old Major dies, but his words are still ringing in the ears of the animals and in particular the pigs. They are led by Napoleon, Snowball and Squealer, and they head the rebellion against Farmer Jones who has again forgotten to feed or milk the animals. He is driven out of the farm and the animals are amazed at the ease with which this is achieved.

They set about destroying all the reminders of the farmer's control over them, and the instruments he used to punish them.

Napoleon makes his play for absolute power by securing control over the food supply. He also draws up Seven Commandments that are written on the barn wall so that all animals can read and learn.

Now that the animals are working for themselves, they produce a bumper harvest with no wastage, and the cows are milked on a regular basis. The hens expect to see an improvement in their food by the addition of milk, but this fails to transpire.

Interpretation

Farmer Jones' continued neglect on top of the Old Major's speech and death proves a catalyst for the revolution. We learn that the farm is located in a remote spot, and the animals together quickly overthrow the farmer and his men, and chase them from the farm.

The revolution is led by two young boars, Snowball and Napoleon, supported by Squealer.

We note that when the animals refer to one another they use the word comrade, thus providing the Communist tone to the society that the animals are creating.

We also observe that not all the animals greet the revolution warmly, in particular Molly the Jones' horse wants to know if she will still be allowed to wear ribbons, and Moses the tame raven keeps bringing in a religious perspective to proceedings, referring to Animal Heaven or Sugar Candy Mountain.

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Although the animals work well together at first and produce an excellent harvest, there are still indications that Old Major's ideal is not going to be achieved. The ruling pigs have already condensed Old Major's ideology into Seven Commandments as follows:-

"1. Whatever goes upon 2 legs is an enemy.

2. Whatever goes upon 4 legs, or has wings, is a friend.

3. No animal shall wear clothes.

4. No animal shall sleep in a bed.

5. No animal shall drink alcohol.

6. No animal shall kill any other animal.

7. All animals are equal."

Orwell's aim here is to show how the new animal society degenerates from this initial stance.

The reader senses that the pigs are not being totally honest with the other animals. What has happened to the cows' milk?

At this stage, we are not sure whether these minor glitches will be remedied or whether this Utopian society will totally fall apart.

However, we are clear that not all animals are equal, and we already have a class society where the pigs, by consensus, organize the running of Animal Farm.

As with Communism (Marxism), animals call one another 'Comrade' in the society of animalism.

As we have said before, this satire is not just aimed at 20th Century Russia, but at the age-old evils of humanity - selfishness, pride and hypocrisy.

Orwell wishes to stress that in any society there would be stalwarts such as Boxer the shire horse, and Napoleon the prize boar.

We will see that power corrupts pigs and humans alike.

In addition to satire, there is much irony in this story as well. Perhaps the reader is surprised that the animals so readily accept the replacement of their human masters, by the pig masters, accepting that an animal's status depends on its intelligence. It is their folly that they accept this position from the outset. They do not seek to enforce the Seventh Commandment. Perhaps this should have been the First Commandment.

It is interesting to note that the actual event of rebellion is covered in just two paragraphs. Perhaps this is the author's comment on how quickly revolution can occur.

CHAPTER 3

Through the long hot summer the animals toiled on the farm except for the pigs who supervised the work.

The hardest worker of all was Boxer the horse, who was admired by all the other animals.

At the end of the summer, their hard work produced bumper levels of food, and all the animals played their part, even the ducks and hens that cleared the fields of every stalk and seed.

Soon, most of the animals were able to read and write, although the pigs were most adept at this.

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An additional slogan was added to the Commandments that read, "Four legs good, two legs bad". The sheep got into the habit of bleating this slogan incessantly.

Sunday was set aside as a day of rest, and breakfast was held later, followed by a meeting where the work rotas for the forthcoming week were discussed.

The animals noticed that there was not a distribution of milk and apples amongst all the animals, and Squealer was given the task of explaining to the other animals that the pigs, being brain workers, required these items in order to keep them healthy. He threatened the animals that if the farm was to fail through the pigs' poor health, then Jones might be able to gain control of Animal Farm.

Interpretation

We now witness the slow erosion of the original ideals of the Animal Farm society.

The pigs already hold an elite position and although their management position is accepted by the rest of the animals, they are less happy about them receiving the privilege of having sole access to the milk and apples.

During the summer months, the animals experience a level of happiness not previously enjoyed on the farm. Although they are working hard apart from the pigs, their efforts bear fruit in the fact that there will be sufficient food to carry them through the winter months.

There is a general feeling of well-being amongst most of the animals, but there are ominous indications that this will be the peak of the society and that disruptive times are ahead.

The reader may note the sinister actions of Napoleon who takes responsibility in rearing the puppies.

We also see Napoleon's hand behind Squealer's actions in trying to placate the animals regarding the distribution of milk and apples.

There is also the start of the power struggle between Napoleon and Snowball, who never seem to be able to agree at the Sunday meetings. This power struggle is, of course, a representation between the struggles in Russia involving Trotsky and Stalin, following the death of Lenin.

The animals feel that they are being given more independence because they are now able to read and write, but this is a fallacy, as the power clearly rests with the pigs that are controlled by Napoleon and Snowball.

Just as Russia had its slogans during the early years of communism, so does the society on Animal Farm with the "Four legs good, two legs bad" doctrine.

Much store is also placed in symbolism, and the pigs introduce the flag that signifies the animals' revolt, and honors Old Major who instigated the rebellion.

The irony in this Chapter is the fact that the animals are still exploited, for the humans have been replaced by the pigs. Boxer is the animal that is most duped. His immense physical strength enables him to carry out a great deal of work, but this is coupled with a placid nature, and he is therefore easily manipulated.

The reader realizes that there is going to be a climax in the relationship between Snowball and Napoleon, because they are unable to negotiate and come to a consensus, as Napoleon in particular regards negotiation as a sign of weakness. At present Napoleon is astute enough to realize that Snowball is the innovator and organizes the animals with great effect, but soon his usefulness will diminish.

We also see the emergence of Squealer who plays a pivotal role in this society. His main attribute is his brilliant rhetoric and he is to some extent able to appease the other animals by cleverly distorting Major's original plan. Napoleon uses Squealer, just as Hitler used Goebbels as his Minister of Propaganda.

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CHAPTER 4

Autumn approaches and the rift between Snowball and Napoleon get wider.

Snowball wishes to ensure the security of Animal Farm by spreading the revolution to the neighboring farms, whilst Napoleon wishes to increase the farm's efficiency.

The events on Animal Farm now concern the neighboring farmers, Mr. Frederick and Mr. Pilkington, and they would like to profit from this situation by gaining control over Animal Farm. Their motive is to gain property rather than to assist Jones who is portrayed as a weak, ineffectual man who now spends most of his time in the Public House.

Using pigeons, Snowball becomes aware of the plans of the neighboring farmers and he sets about making plans to repel any invasion from the humans. The pigeons are also used to spread word to the other farmers' animals regarding the rebellion. Soon the humans make an attempt to restore order to Animal Farm, but Snowball organizes the animals and the invasion fails totally. Although a sheep is killed, the animals are delighted at their success in the Battle of the Cowshed. At the end of this action, Snowball is considered by the animals as a hero and master tactician. All are pleased with Snowball's popularity except Napoleon.

During the battle, a stable lad is knocked unconscious by Boxer who had forgotten that his hooves were iron-shod. He shows compassion towards the unfortunate boy, in stark contrast to Snowball who cries, "The only good human being is a dead one". Both Boxer and Snowball receive a Military Decoration for their efforts in the battle, "Animal Hero – 2nd Class". The dead sheep also received this award posthumously.

Interpretation

Orwell deliberately portrays most of the humans in the story in an unfavorable light.

Jones is the drunk and poor farm manager, and Messrs. Frederick and Pilkington are the greedy neighbors who wish to retake the farm and benefit from the animals' harvest. They totally underestimate the animals because Snowball is able to predict their actions, and they fall into the animals' trap.

The paragraphs describing the battle are some of the most descriptive in the book and Orwell generates a feeling of excitement through his imaginative writing.

The animals' success arises from the discipline instilled in them by Snowball who leads by example, showing great courage against the armed humans.

This Chapter shows Snowball at the pinnacle of his career on Animal Farm. In addition to being an innovator and prime mover in the society, he has now become their hero. He is becoming too popular with the animals from Napoleon's perspective. We will see later how Snowball's actions in the battle are totally distorted towards the end of the story.

We note that the humans join together to liberate Animal Farm, both Frederick and Pilkington helped by Jones attack the farm. If they are successful, Jones will have to pay a heavy price to the other two farmers, and that is why Pilkington and Frederick lead the assault.

Again, the reader cannot escape the similarity with events that took place in Russia during the Communist Revolution. We note that decorations are awarded to the brave animals that led the assault, and that the victory will be celebrated periodically during the calendar year.

Paradoxically, the irony that is present in this Chapter and that will come to fruition later in the story, does not lead to humour, but to tragedy. The animals do not realize it, but they have been tricked by the pigs. They think that their victory will lead to a permanent change in their lives, but just as the peasants in Russia found out when they lost the Tsars and gained the Dictators - the animals have lost the humans and gained the pigs; their lives will not be greatly altered by the end of the story.

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CHAPTER 5

Molly is seen fraternizing with a human at the edge of the farm and she is challenged about this. A few days later, she disappears and it is later learned that she is seen drawing a trap. She was never happy about the change in her personal circumstances after the rebellion and she is never referred to again by the animals.

The friction between Snowball and Napoleon intensifies. Snowball wishes the animals to build a windmill that will enable a lot of physical work to be taken away from the animals, and they will be able to enjoy a three-day week. Snowball also feels that the farm can only be permanently secure if the revolution spreads to the other farms. Napoleon wants the animals to concentrate on increasing productivity.

During the Sunday meetings the sheep, prompted by Napoleon try to disrupt Snowball's eloquent speeches with their bleating.

Napoleon views Snowball's actions as a direct challenge to his authority, and using the dogs that he had reared from puppies, Napoleon chases Snowball from the farm. The animals are amazed at this turn of events and now suddenly, they feel vulnerable to Napoleon's power.

Squealer is again used as a tool to calm the animals, but he is now accompanied by three dogs that intimidate the animals.

A few weeks later, Napoleon adopts Snowball's idea concerning the building of a windmill.

Snowball is not seen again.

Interpretation

The main event in Chapter 5 is Napoleon's coup over Snowball. It contains the two main ingredients that contribute to success – surprise and violence.

Napoleon also demonstrates that he too can be a tactician and he has clearly planned this coup carefully.

Although Snowball was prepared for the Battle of the Cowshed, he was not prepared for this banishment from Animal Farm.

The reader notices that Snowball spent a great deal of time preparing his plans for the building of a windmill, consulting various books in the farmhouse and drawing up his plans in the barn. His hard work is not wasted however, for Napoleon will use Snowball's invention at a later date.

These events are a rude awakening for the animals; for they now realize that they will be under the power of a Dictator who uses the dogs as personal bodyguards that will be released on any animal that steps out of line. This is a direct reference to Stalin's regime where those Comrades who failed to be manipulated by the system were banished from it.

There are now clear indications that the pigs are becoming more like humans. The dogs react towards Napoleon just as they would have reacted to Jones.

Napoleon is quickly learning the art of being a Dictator. The Sunday meetings and the Debates will be replaced by a system where the pigs tell the other animals what to do.

The expulsion of Snowball is the key turning point regarding Animal Farm. His scheme for the windmill would have been hard to put into practice, but if successful would have brought benefits for the whole community. Although Napoleon will try to adopt these plans, his first priority is not to benefit the farm as a whole, but to maintain his power as Dictator of Animal Farm.

Snowball is likened to Trotsky who had a purer and somewhat idealistic view of Socialism, as opposed to Napoleon and Stalin's view of Socialism, which we term as Communism.

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Snowball recognizes the power of propaganda, but wishes to use this to encourage the animals on the neighboring farms to rebel, whereas Napoleon uses propaganda as a means to keep a tight control over the animals on Animal Farm.

It is useful for the reader to now look back at Old Major's vision for Animal Farm, and compare it to what has in fact transpired.

One feels a certain amount of frustration towards the end of this Chapter as Squealer succeeds in convincing some of the animals that Napoleon is a fit leader for them.

CHAPTER 6

In addition to the general running of the farm, the animals now have to work on building the windmill, which requires the quarrying of stone and its transportation to the hilltop.

The animals' happy memories of their first summer now seem very distant as their conditions become more oppressive.

Boxer remains the example to the other animals, and they are inspired by his hard work.

Soon it was necessary for the animals to work on Sunday afternoons as well, but with a common purpose they labored hard to make a success of the windmill. Their main challenge was the breaking up of the stone into suitable sized pieces, for no animal could use a pick or crowbar. In the end, the animals used gravity by dropping boulders onto other boulders in order to produce smaller pieces. However, the process was slow and laborious.

Clover was concerned that Boxer was working too hard, but her warnings went unheeded.

Although the animals were working harder than they had when Jones was in charge, at least they had sufficient amounts of food to eat.

The animals learned that Napoleon had now started trading with the other farms. This seemed to go against the basic ideology of Animal Farm. Napoleon advised the animals that he had engaged a solicitor to act on their behalf. He ended his speech by saying, "Long live Animal Farm!" and they all sang "Beasts of England". Some of the more intelligent animals questioned this action.

There were also rumors that Animal Farm would be conducting business with Messrs. Pilkington and Frederick.

The pigs now took up residence in the farmhouse, and again Squealer justified this action by saying that the pigs required peace and quiet in order to carry out their brain work.

Clover felt that the pigs' actions went against the Seven Commandments. As she had difficulty in reading, she asked Muriel to read the 4th Commandment, which read, "No animal shall sleep in a bed with sheets". Clover was sure that this Commandment had never mentioned sheets, and Squealer explained that there was no rule about animals sleeping in a bed without sheets.

A gale hits the farm and the animals awake to find their windmill destroyed.

Napoleon blames this on Snowball, calling it an act of terrorism.

Interpretation

The reader now witnesses the start of the 2-tier system within Animal Farm.

Napoleon and some of the pigs do not wish to share in the hardship endured by the other animals, and so that they can lead a more luxurious life, trading commences with the neighboring farms. Using propaganda, Squealer infers that all the animals will benefit from this trading.

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Unwittingly, Boxer becomes the main support for Napoleon, his idealistic view blinding him to the deception he and the other animals suffer from. Like all true dictators, Napoleon is establishing a totally different life for himself and his lieutenants and the rest of the community have to work hard to support his regime.

Orwell uses a favorite theme regarding the manipulation of history. Slowly, one by one, the original Seven Commandments are revised. For Napoleon realizes that in order to control the present and the future, he must change recent history in order to support the current doctrine. It is fortunate that the animals have poor memories, and their only grasp of the past is through the inscribed Commandments on the barn wall, which are amended whilst they work in the fields or on the windmill.

Napoleon and the pigs are slowly transforming into "humans" mimicking their behavior.

Boxer's blind acceptance of these changes means that the majority of the animals are content to fall in line. They, after all, hold Boxer in high esteem due to the hard work he puts in to the running of the farm. Boxer holds an extreme position, and is in stark contrast to Benjamin who is skeptical about all the changes that happen on the farm and the delusion of animalism.

Again there are similarities between Animal Farm and Russia between the two wars. Napoleon announces his 2-year plan for building the windmill directly mirroring the infamous 5-year Plans of Stalin. Although Napoleon recognizes the importance of the windmill, the main aim of its construction is to keep the animals occupied so that they have little time to ponder the changes that are being made on the farm. Stalin used the same tactics in keeping control over the masses in Russia, and Boxer symbolizes these masses on the farm.

Napoleon is creating a totalitarian society whose success is based on isolating the members from the outside world. Animal Farm and its occupants have been separated from the rest of the world so that they can easily accept their harsh conditions because they know nothing else.

There are many parallels in today's world regarding such systems, namely China after the Second World War, and Afghanistan and North Korea in more recent times. At the head of such a system is, of course, an omnipotent leader who lives a godlike existence, and the main purpose of the masses is to support this leader.

CHAPTER 7

Unknown to the animals, the consequences of trading with the other farms results in a food shortage the following winter, which is bitterly cold.

Napoleon introduces rationing, but this will be supplemented by potatoes when this crop is harvested. Unfortunately, the potato crop fails and soon rumors spread throughout the countryside that the animals on Animal Farm are starving. Napoleon views these rumors as undermining his position, so he invites his lawyer to visit the farm where they have filled the bins with sand covered by a shallow layer of meal. The lawyer returns and tells the community that all is well on Animal Farm.

Napoleon is now rarely seen and spends most of his time in the farmhouse, and Squealer becomes his mouthpiece.

The hens are ordered to lay eggs and they rebel against this instruction, viewing it as murder. Their food rations are stopped and they hold out in the rafters of the barn for a week, but finally succumb to laying eggs for sale. Many of them have died of starvation in the process.

The farm also has a stock of matured timber and both Pilkington and Frederick are eager to purchase this. In order to obtain a good price, Napoleon plays one farmer off against the other.

Napoleon continues to use Snowball as a scapegoat for all the ills being faced by the community. He suggests that Snowball has always been a traitor and that he is working with the farmers to overthrow animalism on Animal Farm. In order to support the view that Snowball is a traitor, Napoleon needs to spread some propaganda. He orders an assembly of all the animals in the yard and he makes a rare

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appearance accompanied by his nine huge dogs. Three of the dogs suddenly attack Boxer, but he's more than a match for them, and while two retreats, Boxer pins the third under his hoof and waits for Napoleon to respond. Napoleon suggests that Boxer lets the dog go.

The four pigs that had suggested that Sunday's meetings should continue are forced to confess that they have been in touch with Snowball and collaborated in the destruction of the windmill. Once they have made their confession, the dogs rip their throats out. They are soon followed by the three hens who organized the egg rebellion plus other animals that have shown dissent in the past. Napoleon has reinforced his power over the animals through this purge, but still Boxer views these events with naivety, believing that Napoleon must be right.

Later, the animals note that one of the Commandments appears to have changed - "No animal shall kill any other animal without cause".

After the slaughter, the animals return to the site of the windmill bemused. Boxer vows to rebuild the windmill, subconsciously immersing himself in work rather than facing reality.

Squealer informs the animals that there is now no need to sing "Beasts of England". A new song will be composed in honor of their leader, Napoleon.

Interpretation

We now see that Napoleon is totally corrupted by power, and his position is maintained by the suffering of others. With the aid of his bodyguard of dogs, he is able to root out those animals that in his view do not conform, regardless of their contributions to Animal Farm. The attack on Boxer, the cornerstone of the animals' efforts, was no doubt prompted by Napoleon, but he clearly underestimated Boxer's physical power. Boxer views the attack as merely an accident and regards Napoleon as the only qualified leader of the animals. He cannot contemplate the idea that he is worth nothing in Napoleon's eyes.

The day of the purge marks a milestone in the development of Napoleon's empire. "Since Jones had left the farm, until today, no animal had killed another animal. Not even a rat had been killed."

It is surprising that Napoleon killed four of his own kind, but he is using the doctrine that if you are not for Napoleon's revolution, then you must be against it. As will be seen later in the story, Napoleon intends to breed his own master race, a clear symbol of Nazi Germany.

The animals have to accept the fact that the executions were of traitors. If not, then they have to accept the situation that conditions are worse than they were under Jones.

Orwell uses a clever technique towards the end of this Chapter by shifting the narrative. The reader now views the situation through the unconscious thoughts of Clover using a poetic description of the farm.

> "These scenes of terror and slaughter were not what they had looked forward to on that night when Old Major first stirred them to rebellion. If she herself had had any picture of the future, it had been of a society of animals set free from hunger and the whip, all equal"

CHAPTER 8

At last the winter was over and the animals worked even harder to complete the windmill.

Some animals had thought that the walls were too thin on the original windmill, so this time the walls were made twice as thick, which meant an even harder task for the animals. They were kept going by the thought that once the windmill was completed, their lives would be easier.

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Napoleon concludes his deal concerning the sale of timber to Frederick, but it turns out that the money used to buy the timber is forged.

Soon after, Frederick with fifteen men, attack the farm and blow up the windmill with gunpowder. The Battle of the Windmill results in the death of many animals, and it is only through the intervention of the dogs that the humans are driven off. They also lose three men.

Squealer tries to lead the victory celebrations, but the animals find it difficult to see how they won the battle, as they lost so many animals and the windmill was destroyed.

The pigs discover a crate of whisky and celebrate in the farmhouse. It is noted that another Commandment now seems to read differently from that originally remembered - "No animal shall drink alcohol to excess".

The effect of the explosion on the windmill is disastrous to the morale of the animals, but Boxer tries to rally them vowing that he will rebuild the windmill.

One of the pigs, Minimus, composes a song in honor of Comrade Napoleon:

"Friend of the fatherless!

Fountain of happiness!

Lord of the swill-bucket! Oh, how my soul is on

Fire when I gaze at thy

Calm and commanding eye,

Like the sun in the sky,

Comrade Napoleon! ……

"Had I a suckling pig,

Ere he had grown as big

Even as a pint bottle or as a rolling-pin,

He should have learned to be

Faithful and true to thee,

Yes, his first squeak should be

Comrade Napoleon."

The poem was inscribed on the wall at the opposite end of the barn from the Seven Commandments.

Interpretation

The pigs are naïve in thinking that they have taken advantage of the humans by selling the timber to Frederick at a high price, and their smugness is soon replaced by anger when they realize that they have been paid in forged notes.

Napoleon's reaction is to put Frederick on the top of his wanted list and his incompetence is soon blotted out with the battle that follows.

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Unlike the Battle of the Cowshed, the Battle of the Windmill is a total failure, mainly due to the fact that the humans were in control of this affair rather than the animals. It is clear that if Snowball had still been on the scene, then matters might have turned out differently in the battle.

To the outside world, the windmill is the symbol of animalism and in destroying this symbol you destroy the animal society. Napoleon failed to ensure that the windmill was adequately protected.

Using propaganda, Napoleon through Squealer turns this defeat into victory, and throughout all this, the animals still forlornly hope that Old Major's dreams will eventually come to fruition.

Napoleon now views the animals as a means to an end. He clearly wishes to try and keep the remaining animals on board, and this can be achieved through fear. He still uses propaganda in trying to brainwash the animals, but like all such dictators, he has lost touch with those that he rules. Ironically, he is now starting to believe his own propaganda, and even some of the least intelligent of the animals are beginning to see through the façade of Napoleon.

They used to enjoy singing their old song, and what has been put in its place is uninspiring and tasteless.

There is now a steady shift away from the unreserved loyalty shown by Boxer towards the cynicism of Benjamin, who was lucky to escape the purge. He was wise enough to limit his outspoken views.

The reader again witnesses a further humanizing of the pigs with their excessive alcohol drinking, which leads to the amendment of another Commandment.

Apart from the loss of life at the Battle of the Windmill, there were also animals who suffered serious injuries, in particular Boxer who split a hoof. This marks his slow deterioration in the months ahead.

Towards the end of the Chapter, Orwell again makes good use of irony for at last the animals discover who has been amending the Commandments. Squealer is discovered in a heap below the wall showing the Commandments with a pot of paint and a brush. This comes as no surprise to the reader, but again Orwell uses third person narrative in order to provide the animals' perspective to this incident. However, the penny does not fully drop with some of the animals. They are now in the habit of not thinking for themselves, but having the pigs do this for them.

CHAPTER 9

Boxer's split hoof incurred in the Battle of the Windmill takes a long time to heal and causes him much pain.

Winter comes round again and there is once more a shortage of food, but Squealer is quick to assure the animals that life has improved since the time of Jones.

Thirty-one piglets are produced from the four sows on the farm, and Napoleon takes full responsibility for their education, and they are to be kept separate from the other animals.

Napoleon formally proclaims that Animal Farm is a Republic and he will be its President.

At the start of the rebellion, it had been agreed that there should be a retirement age for animals, and for horses this was fixed at twelve. A pasture had been set aside for retired animals but now this has been ploughed up, and the animals are concerned that there will be a change in policy regarding the retirement of animals. With Boxer's hoof healed, he continues to work as hard as ever, even though he is now past twelve years old. Suddenly, Boxer collapses and is unable to continue his work. A cart arrives, which the pigs say will take Boxer to the animal hospital, but some of the animals are able to read on the side of the cart the words, "Alfred Simmonds, Horse Slaughterer and Glue Boiler". Clover urges Boxer to break out of the cart, but he is too weak. All the animals join in the cry, "Get out Boxer, get out!" The animals try to persuade the horses drawing the cart to stop, but they just continue in their stupid fashion.

A few days later, Squealer informs the animals that there had been malicious rumors that Boxer had been sold to the horse slaughterer. He had in fact been taken to the vet, and the cart used was an old cart and

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the sign had not been painted out. Despite Napoleon spending much on medicines for Boxer, he sadly died and a party was to be held in his honor. On the day of the party, "a grocer's van drove up from the town and delivered a large wooden crate to the farmhouse". Rumor had it that the crate contained whisky.

Interpretation

Boxer's collapse and subsequent slaughter provides the most moving passages in the book. These passages emphasize the hopelessness of the animals' situation and how they are trapped in a world from which there is no escape except through death or desertion.

Boxer receives no reward for the efforts he had made over the years to make Animal Farm a success. He is sold for a case of whisky, which only the pigs will enjoy.

We receive indications that Napoleon is breeding the next generation of pigs indoctrinating them in his philosophy, and they will be taught to support his totalitarian state.

The reader may like to recall the initial passages of the book and compare the situation now being experienced by the animals. They live in harsh conditions, hungry and cold outside the farmhouse while the pigs enjoy all the luxuries inside the warm farmhouse.

We also note that the pigs allow Moses, the tame raven, to return to the farm and he continues telling the animals about the life after death to be enjoyed on Sugar Candy Mountain. Although the field designated for retirement has now been turned over to producing wealth for the farm, the animals can still hope for a better life on Sugar Candy Mountain.

The reader may sympathize with Boxer, but also realize that he has been very stupid, for he failed to see that Major's vision was not shared by Napoleon. The only blessing is that Boxer will not witness the final irony played out in Chapter 10.

The reader feels a sense of frustration at this point in the book, hoping against hope that the animals will rise up against the pigs that control them. Clearly they are unfit to control the farm, demonstrated by the fact that they used the money from Boxer's slaughter to purchase alcohol rather than food for the animals.

The final irony is that the animals are now ordered to build a schoolhouse in which the next generation of pigs (rulers) will be educated. This is a clear indication that the animals will not be rid of Napoleon when he dies because there will be others to follow in his trotters.

CHAPTER 10

Many years have now passed and few of the original animals that were involved in the rebellion are left.

Animal Farm is now populated by a new generation of animals who only vaguely remember the doctrines of animalism.

The farm now boasts two windmills and the farm is both efficient and prosperous, but this has had little effect on the conditions that the animals live under, apart from the pigs and the dogs, whose situation has slowly continued to improve over the years.

One day the peace of the farmyard is broken by a terrifying neigh from Clover, and the animals witness Squealer walking on his back legs carrying a whip, followed by a long line of pigs doing the same. In the barn, the Commandments have been erased and replaced by a single slogan, "All animals are equal, but some animals are more equal than others". From that day on, the pigs supervise the other animals carrying whips.

The sheep now bleat a different slogan, "Four legs good, two legs better".

The animals' world has been turned upside down, especially for Clover and Benjamin, the latter being particularly morose, as all his early fears have turned into reality.

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That night, sounds of hilarity come from the farmhouse and some of the animals approach the house and look through the windows. They see Napoleon and the other leading pigs partying with the humans, Pilkington and some others. They are toasting the prosperity of Manor Farm. The name "Animal Farm" has been abolished. They are playing a game of cards and both Napoleon and Pilkington cheat, and there is a violent quarrel. The party ends in uproar with angry shouting, and the witnessing animals, "looked from pig to man, and from man to pig, and from pig to man again: but already it was impossible to say which was which."

Interpretation

Napoleon has made his position secure as head of this Totalitarian State. He has achieved this by purging the dissenters, controlling the food supply, ensuring that future generations are indoctrinated into his system, and by keeping the workers occupied through toil enforced by fear. As the first generation of animals dies out, so do the original ideas of Major. When we arrive at Chapter 10, few animals remember the initial Commandments and none have the will to oppose Napoleon's regime. The Seven Commandments are replaced by the nonsensical slogan concerning the equality of animals. This is, perhaps, one of the most famous quotations to come from Orwell's pen.

The animals are now reduced to hoping for a better life after death rather than any comfort on Animal Farm, which has reverted back to Manor Farm.

Napoleon is also able to keep control due to the fact the farm is isolated and there is now no mechanism for the animals to contact the outside world.

One cannot expect a happy ending to this tale. Orwell, a true Socialist, wishes to decry Communism, or as it is called here Animalism, and the Fascist and Totalitarian systems that are based on this doctrine. None of these societies exercise freedom, justice and equality, which are the foundations of the Democratic Socialist society that Orwell supported.

The book ends with the humans taking centre-stage, just as they did at the start of the book, thus they frame the whole story.

The final paragraphs of the book are again taken from Clover's viewpoint in the third person narrative, and they provide a poignant end to "Animal Farm".

CONCLUSION

Although 'Animal Farm' is only 10 Chapters in length, it is extremely thought-provoking and it represents a milestone in satirical literature. Its appeal is that it passes comment on various Communist and Fascist regimes which were particularly prevalent in the 20th Century, but it also gives an insight into human behavior.

Orwell continues this theme in his other works, in particular '1984', 'Homage to Catalonia', and 'The Collected Essays, Journalism and Letters', which were edited by Sonia Orwell.

In contrast to 'Animal Farm', Aldous Huxley's novel 'Brave New World' covers the creation of a new society.

A cartoon version of Animal Farm hit the screens in the mid 1950's, but it contains a totally different ending to the novel.

QUESTIONS for STUDY with IDEAS for ANSWERS

Q: Napoleon's totalitarian regime on Animal Farm is the core feature of this novel. What do you understand by 'a totalitarian regime'?

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Ideas:

Totalitarian, Fascist or Authoritarian States are all the same in that they involve the destruction of principles and personal relationships. The State conditions its citizens to adhere to the principles of the society and this is enforced by fear. Those that oppose the State are disposed of through exile or extermination.

Patriotism for the country is replaced with patriotism for the leader and his successors, for through propaganda, the leader is the country.

Most States have a 2-tier system where a small privileged minority controls the vast majority who do the bulk of the work. Part of this minority is the army and police who help enforce the control.

Through propaganda, the majority are made to believe that the minority have few privileges and lead similar lives to the masses.

As well as indoctrinating the next generation of citizens, the State also needs to avoid contact with the outside world.

Q: 'Animal Farm' is a satirical novel aimed at discrediting Russian history from the Revolution in 1917 until the end of the Second World War. The characters and events in the story represent features of Russian history. Please expand.

Ideas:

The animals are exploited by Jones who represents Tsar Nicolas II, and dissent comes from Old Major who spouts his view of the future, which is similar to that of Karl Marx. The revolution takes place as a consequence of Major's rhetoric and therefore, he is similar to Lenin. After the revolution, the neighboring farms are concerned that this uprising will spread, just as Europe was concerned in 1917.

The humans mount an assault on Animal Farm, just as the European-backed White Army did in Russia, with a view to re-installing the Tsar on his throne. This invasion is repulsed by Snowball, just as Trotsky did in opposing the White Army.

Stalin later disposed of Trotsky, just as Napoleon deposed Snowball.

Squealer represents Stalin's propaganda machine, used to dupe Boxer who represents the Russian masses.

The Pilkington farm can be represented by the British Empire, while Frederick refers to Germany.

Just as the Battle of the Cowshed refers to the attempted invasion by the White Army, so does the Battle of the Windmill represent the German invasion in World War II.

Stalin's 5-year plans are directly mirrored by the projects to build the windmills.

We finally see Orwell's disdain for Stalin as he suggests that the drunken party in the final Chapter symbolizes Stalin's meeting with the West at the Teheran Conference.

There are many other parallels contained within the pages of 'Animal Farm'. List these.

Q: As we have said, this is a satirical novel, and Orwell uses irony in order to support his views. Please give examples.

Ideas:

Remember, irony is the stating of one thing while intending the opposite. Irony is normally used to provide humour, but here we witness a sad irony.

The main ironic theme, which takes place throughout the entire novel, is the transition of the pigs into 'human beings'.

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At the start, we have Old Major's clear vision of the future that outlaws humans and all their features. It goes against his ideals to copy human habits, but one by one the central rules are amended and then ignored. Therefore, those that originally revolted against Farmer Jones, turn into humans.

In conclusion the revolution has failed.

Orwell means us to associate the Seven Commandments inscribed on the wall of the barn with the Ten Commandments set in stone in the Bible. These laws should be unchangeable, but ironically, the pigs amend the Commandments so that the final effect is that the rule is turned into an opposite meaning.

There are many small ironies e.g. the cat wishing to encourage the sparrows to learn to read so that he can get close to them and catch them. The prime mover for the cat is its instinct to hunt and kill the birds, but it will use the doctrine on educating animals in order to fulfill its instinct.

Q: Orwell uses much symbolism in 'Animal Farm'. Give some examples.

Ideas:

Symbolism is used to support the satire and irony that runs through the book.

Humans are not depicted favorably in this novel, which is written from the animals' perspective. They symbolize evil and they use instruments of terror to control the animals, e.g. whips, harnesses, bits and so on.

The fact that they walk on two legs is a characteristic that is distinctly human and is referred to in the slogan bleated by the sheep, "Four legs good, two legs bad".

When the pigs adopt the posture of walking on two legs holding whips, the full circle has been achieved.

The windmill symbolizes the success of Animal Farm and that is why it is destroyed by the neighboring farmers, but it also symbolizes the conflict between Snowball and Napoleon. For the animals the windmill symbolizes the chance of an easier life, and that is why they are determined to see it completed. To the pigs, it symbolizes 'the good life' for them.

Orwell makes a particular symbolic reference to the suffering of the Soviet people in the 1930's when farms were put under State control in the form of collectives. Many farmers opposed this and killed their cattle just as the hens on Animal Farm destroyed their eggs. It is though that between ten and fifteen million peasants died as a result of the famine during these years.

There are many more examples of symbolism in this novel. List as many as you can.

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Biography George Orwell

Early Life of George Orwell

 George Orwell, (25 June 1903 – 21 January 1950) has proved to be one of the twentieth century's most influential and thought provoking writers. His relatively small numbers of books have created intense literary and political criticism. Orwell was a socialist, but at the same time he did not fit into any neat ideology. At times, he exasperated the more doctrinaire left wingers with his enthusiasm for taking opposing views. He was foremost a political writer, but for Orwell his object was not to promote a certain point of view, but to arrive at the truth; exposing the hypocrisy and injustice prevalent in society.

Orwell in Burma

Orwell had a fascinating life story. Brought up by in a poor, aspiring middle class family, Orwell was educated at Eton and left with firmly held "middle class" values, but at the same time a sense of unease with his social position. For want of a better job, Orwell took a job with the Burmese civil service. It was here in Burma, that Orwell would begin to assert his independence from his privileged upbringing. Revealingly, Orwell later told how he found himself rooting for the local population, and despising the Imperial ideology which he represented. He resigned from his position in 1927. In an essay *Shooting the Elephant* he describes he feelings on Burma:

"Theoretically and secretly of course, I was always for the Burmese and all against the oppressors, the British. As for the job I was doing I hated it more bitterly than I can perhaps make clear" (1)

It was in the nature of George Orwell to try and see a situation from other people's point of view. He was unhappy at accepting the conventional social wisdom. In fact, he grew to despise his middle class upbringing so much he decided to spend time as a tramp. He wanted to experience life from the view of the gutter. His vivid experiences are recorded in his book "*Down and out in Paris and London*". No longer could Orwell be described as a "Champagne Socialist"; by living with the poorest and underprivileged, he gained a unique insight into the practical workings of working class ideas and working class politics.

The Road to Wigan Pier

In the middle of the great depression, Orwell undertook another experience travelling to Wigan; an industrial town in Lancashire experiencing the full effects of mass unemployment and

poverty. Orwell freely admitted how, as a young child, he was brought up to despise the working class. He vividly tells how he was obsessed with the idea that the working classes smelt:

"At a distance.. I could agonise over their sufferings, but I still hated them and despised them when I came anywhere near them." (2)

The Road to Wigan Pier offered a penetrating insight into the condition of the working classes. It was also a right of passage for Orwell to live amongst the people he had once, from a distance, despised. *The Road to Wigan Pier* inevitably had a political message; but characteristically of Orwell it was not all pleasing to the left. For example, it was less than flattering towards the Communist party. This was despite the book being promoted by a mostly Communist organisation – The Left Book club.

Orwell and the Spanish Civil War

It was fighting in the Spanish Civil war that Orwell came to really despise Communist influences. In 1936, Orwell volunteered to fight for the fledgling Spanish Republic, who at the time were fighting the Fascist forces of Gen Franco. It was a conflict that polarised nations. To the left, the war was a symbol of a real socialist revolution, based on the principles of equality and freedom. It was for these ideals that many international volunteers, from around the world, went to Spain to fight on behalf of the Republic. Orwell found himself in the heart of the Socialist revolution in Barcelona. He was assigned to an Anarchist – Trotskyist party – P.O.U.M. More than most other left wing parties, they believed in the ideal of a real Marxist revolution. To members of the P.O.U.M, the war was not just about fighting the Fascist menace but also delivering a Socialist revolution for the working classes. In his book, "*Homage to Catalonia*" Orwell writes of his experiences; he notes the inefficiency with which the Spanish fought even wars. He was enthused by the revolutionary fervour of some of his party members; however, one of the overriding impressions was his perceived betrayal of the Republic, by the Stalinist backed Communist party.

"the Communists stood not upon the extreme Left, but upon the extreme right. In reality this should come as no surprise, because the tactics of the Communist parties elsewhere" (3)

Unwittingly he found himself engaged in a civil war amongst the left, as the Soviet Union backed Communist party turned on the Trotskyite factions like P.O.U.M. In the end, Orwell narrowly escaped with his life, after being shot in the throat. He was able to return to England, but he had learnt at first hand how revolutions could easily be betrayed; ideas that would later shape his seminal work "*Animal Farm*"

During the war Orwell was declared unfit for active duty. He actively supported the war effort (He didn't wait for the Soviet Union to enter like some communists.)

The two great novels of Orwell were "*Animal Farm*" and "*1984*". Animal Farm is a simple allegory for revolutions which go wrong, based primarily on the Russian revolution.

Citation : Pettinger, Tejvan. “Biography of George Orwell”, Oxford, *www.biographyonline.net* 3 Feb. 2013

Who Was George Orwell?
George Orwell was a novelist, essayist and critic best known for his novels *Animal Farm* and *Nineteen Eighty-Four*. He was a man of strong opinions who addressed some of the major political movements of his times, including imperialism, fascism and communism.

Family & Early Life
Orwell was born Eric Arthur Blair in Motihari, India, on June 25, 1903. The son of a British civil servant, Orwell spent his first days in India, where his father was stationed. His mother brought him and his older sister, Marjorie, to England about a year after his birth and settled in Henley-on-Thames. His father stayed behind in India and rarely visited. (His younger sister, Avril, was born in 1908. Orwell didn't really know his father until he retired from the service in 1912. And even after that, the pair never formed a strong bond. He found his father to be dull and conservative.
According to one biography, Orwell's first word was "beastly." He was a sick child, often battling bronchitis and the flu.
Orwell took up writing at an early age, reportedly composing his first poem around age four. He later wrote, "I had the lonely child's habit of making up stories and holding conversations with imaginary persons, and I think from the very start my literary ambitions were mixed up with the feeling of being isolated and undervalued." One of his first literary successes came at the age of 11 when he had a poem published in the local newspaper.

Education
Like many other boys in England, Orwell was sent to boarding school. In 1911, he went to St. Cyprian's in the coastal town of Eastbourne, where he got his first taste of England's class system.
On a partial scholarship, Orwell noticed that the school treated the richer students better than the poorer ones. He wasn't popular with his peers, and in books, he found comfort from his difficult situation. He read works by Rudyard Kipling and H.G. Wells, among others.
What he lacked in personality, he made up for in smarts. Orwell won scholarships to Wellington College and Eton College to continue his studies.
After completing his schooling at Eton, Orwell found himself at a dead end. His family did not have the money to pay for a university education. Instead, he joined the India Imperial Police Force in 1922. After five years in Burma, Orwell resigned his post and returned to England. He was intent on making it as a writer.

Early Writing Career
After leaving the India Imperial Force, Orwell struggled to get his writing career off the ground and took all sorts of jobs to make ends meet, including being a dishwasher.
Orwell's first major work explored his time eking out a living in these two cities. The book provided a brutal look at the lives of the working poor and of those living a transient existence. Not wishing to embarrass his family, the author published the book under the pseudonym George Orwell.
'Burmese Days' (1934)
Orwell next explored his overseas experiences in *Burmese Days*, which offered a dark look at British colonialism in Burma, then part of the country's Indian empire. Orwell's interest in political matters grew rapidly after this novel was published.

War Injury and Tuberculosis
In December 1936, Orwell traveled to Spain, where he joined one of the groups fighting against General Francisco Franco in the Spanish Civil War. Orwell was badly injured during his time with a militia, getting shot in the throat and arm. For several weeks, he was unable to speak. Orwell and his wife, Eileen, were indicted on treason charges in Spain. Fortunately, the charges were brought after the couple had left the country.
Other health problems plagued the talented writer not long after his return to England. For years, Orwell had periods of sickness, and he was officially diagnosed with tuberculosis in 1938. He spent several months at the Preston Hall Sanatorium trying to recover, but he would continue to battle with tuberculosis for the rest of his life. At the time he was initially diagnosed, there was no effective treatment for the disease.

Literary Critic & BBC Producer
To support himself, Orwell took on various writing assignments. He wrote numerous essays and reviews over the years, developing a reputation for producing well-crafted literary criticism.

Animal Farm

INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF GEORGE ORWELL

Eric Blair was born and spent his youth in India. He was educated at Eton in England and from 1922-27, he served in the Indian Imperial Police in Burma. Through his autobiographical work about poverty in London (*Down and Out in Paris and London*, 1933), his experiences in colonial Burma (*Burmese Days*, 1934), and in the Spanish Civil War (*Homage to Catalonia*, 1938), and the plight of unemployed coal miners in England (*The Road to Wigan Pier*, 1937), Blair, who wrote under the name George Orwell, exposed and critiqued the human tendency to oppress others politically, economically, and physically. Orwell particularly hated totalitarianism, and his most famous novels, *Animal Farm* and *1984*, are profound condemnations of totalitarian regimes. Orwell died at the age of 47 after failing to treat a lung ailment.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

In 1917, two successive revolutions rocked Russia and the rest of the world. The first revolution overthrew the Russian monarchy (the Tsar) and the second established the USSR, the world's first Communist state. Over the next 30 years, the Soviet government descended into a totalitarian regime that used and manipulated socialist ideas of equality among the working class to oppress its people and maintain power. *Animal Farm* is an allegory of the Russian Revolution and the Communist Soviet Union. Many of the animal characters in *Animal Farm* have direct correlations to figures or institutions in the Soviet Union.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

The literary work most often mentioned alongside *Animal Farm* is Orwell's own *1984*. It envisions a future in which a dictatorship monitors and controls the actions of all its citizens. Like *Animal Farm*, *1984* depicts the horrific constraints that totalitarian governments can impose on human freedom. Other popular novels with antitotalitarian themes include Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World*, Ray Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451*, and Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale*. *Animal Farm* specifically critiques Communism, as put forth by Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels's *The Communist Manifesto*, through its allegorical Animalism ideology. In his autobiographical writing, Orwell cited the British author W. Somerset Maugham as a major influence on his work, though he also wrote about his love of the works of Shakespeare and Charles Dickens, as well as the work of some of his contemporaries including T. S. Eliot and D. H. Lawrence.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Animal Farm
- **When Written:** 1944-45
- **Where Written:** England
- **When Published:** 1945
- **Literary Period:** Modernism
- **Genre:** Allegorical Novel
- **Setting:** A farm somewhere in England in the first half of the 20th century
- **Climax:** The pigs appear standing upright and the sheep bleat, "Four legs good, two legs better!"
- **Antagonist:** Napoleon specifically, but the pigs and the dogs as groups are all antagonists.
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Tough Crowd. Though *Animal Farm* eventually made Orwell famous, three publishers in England and several American publishing houses rejected the novel at first. One of the English editors to reject the novel was the famous poet T.S. Eliot, who was an editor at the Faber & Faber publishing house. One American editor, meanwhile, told Orwell that it was "impossible to sell animal stories in the U.S.A."

Red Scare. Orwell didn't just write literature that condemned the Communist state of the USSR. He did everything he could, from writing editorials to compiling lists of men he knew were Soviet spies, to combat the willful blindness of many intellectuals in the West to USSR atrocities.

PLOT SUMMARY

Manor Farm is a small farm in England run by the harsh and often drunk Mr. Jones. One night, a boar named Old Major gathers all the animals of Manor Farm together. Knowing that he will soon die, Old Major gives a speech in which he reveals to the animals that men cause all the misery that animals endure. Old Major says that all animals are equal and urges them to join together to rebel. He teaches them a revolutionary song called "Beasts of England." Old Major dies soon after, but two pigs named Snowball and Napoleon adapt his ideas into the philosophy of Animalism. They set about trying to spread Animalism's ideals to the other animals on the farm, but this proves to be an uphill battle. The carthorses, Boxer and Clover,

prove to be their best disciples, as they're able to distill Animalism into simple arguments and share them with the other animals.

Three months later, Mr. Jones neglects to feed his animals for more than 24 hours. The animals revolt and chase Mr. Jones and the farmhands off of the farm in what ends up being an easy victory. The animals promptly burn all items that allowed Mr. Jones to maintain power, such as whips, bits, and knives. The next morning, the animals tour the farm and the pigs reveal that over the last few months, they've taught themselves to read. Snowball is the best at writing, and with white paint he amends the farm's gate to read "Animal Farm." At the big barn, Snowball also writes the tenets of Animalism, which he and Napoleon distilled into Seven Commandments. The commandments state that all animals are equal, and no animal may act like a human by sleeping in a bed, walking on two legs, killing other animals, or drinking alcohol. They state that humans are the only enemy. The animals turn to the hay harvest after the pigs figure out how to milk the cows, but the milk begins to disappear.

The absence of humans means that the animals are far more successful than Mr. Jones ever was. There's enough food, and the animals take pride in being able to feed themselves with their own labor. The pigs are clever enough to figure out how to perform certain tasks without standing on two legs, while Boxer seems as strong as three horses and adopts the motto "I will work harder!" All the animals throw themselves into the running of the farm except for the vain horse Mollie, who makes lots of excuses as to why she can't work. Benjamin the donkey seems not to care about anything and cryptically tells everyone that donkeys live a long time.

Snowball organizes committees for the animals—which are mostly unsuccessful—and more successfully teaches animals to read. The dogs, the pigs, the goat Muriel, and Benjamin are the only ones who become fully literate. Less intelligent animals, such as the sheep, only learn the letter A and cannot remember the Seven Commandments, so Snowball distills this down into the maxim "Four legs good, two legs bad." He has to explain to the birds why this is acceptable, since they have only two legs. Napoleon, meanwhile, takes the nine new puppies to train, insisting it's more useful to focus on educating the young. A fight for power soon develops between Snowball and Napoleon.

Snowball and Napoleon send out pigeons to neighboring farms to spread the word to other animals. The other farmers sympathize with Mr. Jones, but only want to make the situation work for them. Fortunately for the animals, their neighbors, Mr. Pilkington of Foxwood Farm and Mr. Frederick of Pinchfield Farm, hate each other, though they're both terrified of what happened at Animal Farm. In October, Mr. Jones and some men invade the farm with a gun. The animals fight bravely and send the men racing away, though Boxer is distraught when he believes he killed a stable boy. Snowball gives a speech about the importance of dying for Animal Farm and they agree to fire Mr. Jones's gun twice per year, on the anniversaries of the rebellion and of the Battle of the Cowshed. They also come up with military honors and confer one on Snowball.

In the winter, Mollie disappears to serve a man in town. The pigs argue over how to plan the coming season and the rivalry between Snowball and Napoleon comes to a head over Snowball's idea to build a **windmill**. Snowball convinces animals by insisting that a windmill would give them electricity and ensure they only have to work three days per week, while Napoleon quietly insists this is nonsense. At the final debate about the windmill, Napoleon summons the puppies, whom he secretly reared to be his own vicious servants, and has them chase Snowball from Animal Farm. Napoleon tells the other animals that Snowball was a "bad influence," eliminates the animals' right to vote, and takes "the burden" of leadership on himself. He sends around a pig named Squealer, who persuades the animals that Napoleon has their best interests at heart.

Three weeks later Napoleon decides they should build the windmill after all—the windmill, he insists, was his idea to begin with, but Snowball stole his plans. The animals set to work, with Boxer leading. Focusing on the windmill reduces the productivity of the farm, and all the animals but the pigs and the dogs get less to eat. Napoleon institutes work on Sundays that's voluntary, but animals who don't work will receive reduced rations. The pigs engage a solicitor named Mr. Whymper to represent them and begin to trade with other farms. They move into Mr. Jones's farmhouse and start to sleep in beds. This confuses Clover, who thought this was forbidden. When she asks Muriel to read her the Commandment about beds, it reads: "No animal shall sleep in a bed with sheets." Squealer, accompanied by dogs, insists that if the pigs don't get enough sleep, Mr. Jones will return.

That winter, a storm destroys the partially complete windmill. Napoleon blames the catastrophe on the "traitor" Snowball and insists that Snowball is hiding out at Foxwood. Humans insist that the windmill fell because of the weather and though the animals don't believe it, they build the walls of the second windmill twice as thick. Napoleon covers up that the farm doesn't have enough food, and in January, tells the hens that he's agreed to trade 400 eggs per week for grain. The hens are distraught, as they'd all planned on hatching spring chicks, so they revolt and sacrifice their eggs. Napoleon cuts their rations and the hens give up after five days, after nine hens die. Napoleon circulates that they died of disease and catches wind that Snowball is sneaking onto Animal Farm and causing mischief, such as trampling eggs and stealing. One evening, Squealer insists that Snowball is in league with Mr. Frederick and has been on Mr. Jones's side the whole time. Boxer is dumbfounded and notes that Snowball fought with them, but Squealer insists that according to Napoleon, Snowball is on Mr.

Jones's side.

Four days later, Napoleon sets his dogs on four young pigs and Boxer during a meeting. Boxer paws the dogs away, but the dogs rip the pigs' throats out after they confess to conspiring with Snowball. Other animals confess heinous crimes as well, and the dogs kill all of them. The remaining animals gather at the windmill, and Boxer suggests that this happened because they've done something wrong. Clover can't formulate her thoughts into words, but she thinks that this wasn't what she had in mind when she joined the rebellion. However, she still thinks that this is better than living under Mr. Jones and vows to accept Napoleon's leadership. She leads the animals in a round of "Beasts of England," but Squealer stops by and announces that the song is now banned: the revolution it speaks of has happened, so it's no longer useful. Minimus the pig composes a new song that none of the animals like as much. A few days after the massacre, Clover remembers that the Seven Commandments stated that animals shouldn't kill each other, but when she asks Muriel to read the Commandments on the barn, the Commandment reads that animals can't kill each other without cause.

The animals work harder than ever, and Squealer regularly reads them figures that show the farm's productivity is up by 200 to 500 percent. Napoleon stays inside the farmhouse most of the time, guarded by the dogs. When Minimus composes a poem in Napoleon's honor, Napoleon has it written on the barn next to the Commandments and a portrait of himself. Napoleon negotiates with Mr. Frederick and Mr. Pilkington about timber on the property he'd like to sell, and tensions run high. They finish the windmill in the fall and soon after, Napoleon announces he sold the timber to Mr. Frederick after promising it to Mr. Pilkington. The money will buy the animals the machinery for the windmill. Mr. Whymper, however, reveals that Mr. Frederick paid for the timber with forged banknotes. Mr. Frederick and his men, many with guns, invade Animal Farm and blow up the windmill. The enraged animals chase them away but feel discouraged until Squealer points out that they achieved a great victory. The pigs discover a case of whiskey and after initially announcing that Napoleon is dying, they declare that all spare fields will be planted with barley. All of it will go to the pigs. One night, animals hear a crash and find Squealer next to the barn with a broken ladder and paint. The next morning, the Commandments read that animals shouldn't drink to excess.

As Boxer approaches retirement, he refuses to take time to let his injuries heal. He wants to see the windmill done. When 31 piglets, all Napoleon's children, are born in the spring, Napoleon announces that they need to build a schoolhouse and institutes a rule that all other animals must let pigs pass. Napoleon is unanimously voted to be the farm's president when it becomes a republic. In the summer, Boxer collapses while working on the windmill, and Napoleon announces that a human vet will treat him. When the van comes to collect Boxer, however, Benjamin rouses everyone: the van reads that Boxer is going to the glue factory. They never see Boxer again, and Squealer insists that the van was recently purchased by a vet and hadn't yet been repainted. The pigs come up with money to buy more whiskey a few days later.

Years pass. Now only a few of the remaining animals on the farm experienced the revolution. Even fewer remember its goals. They complete the first windmill and begin a second, but neither windmill will electrify the farm. The pigs teach themselves to walk on two legs, begin carrying whips, and teach the sheep to bleat "Four legs good, two legs better." When Clover and Benjamin check the Seven Commandments, they only see the statement: "All animals are equal. But some animals are more equal than others." The pigs make peace with their human neighbors and have a feast, but both Napoleon and Mr. Pilkington cheat at cards and begin a fight. The other animals are shocked to discover that they can no longer tell the pigs from the humans.

CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Napoleon – The primary antagonist of the novel; a pig who is one of Old Major's disciples, along with Snowball. At first, Napoleon and Snowball work together to develop the ideology of Animalism and spread its ideals throughout all the animals on the farm, but Napoleon proves to have very different goals than Snowball. Where Snowball is relatively idealistic and wants to help others, Napoleon soon proves himself cruel and power hungry. When the conflict comes to a head over whether or not to build a **windmill**, Napoleon reveals that he's trained nine dogs to be his secret police force, chases Snowball off the farm, and institutes a totalitarian state at Animal Farm. He maintains his rule by demanding unwavering loyalty and trust from his subjects, and he achieves at least outward displays of trust through intimidation and the spread of misinformation through propaganda. Napoleon is often the one to make grand, sinister-sounding pronouncements, but then always sends the pig Squealer around to convince everyone that Napoleon is actually acting in their best interests—and never in his own self-interest. He's especially interested in developing an educated ruling class, which he does by educating the dogs, and later by insisting on educating the 31 piglets he fathers in a special schoolhouse. Throughout the novel, Napoleon proves himself to be paranoid, self-important, and unable to accept that he's wrong—he blames all manner of horrible things on either Snowball or the neighboring farmers. By the end of the novel, Napoleon is undistinguishable from the humans he has denounced along: he is fat, powerful, and begins to walk on two legs, wear clothes, and carry a whip. In Napoleon's eyes, it's a good thing that the other animals are so hungry and powerless,

and he insists that this state of affairs is called for in Animalism. He ultimately changes Animal Farm's name back to Manor Farm in a bid to make it seem more palatable to the farmers, and he proves himself to be just as corrupt as his human counterparts. **Napoleon** *symbolizes Stalin, who led the Soviet Union from 1930 until his death in 1953.*

Snowball – At first, a friend and companion of Napoleon's. Together, Snowball and Napoleon develop the theory of Animalism from the ideas of Old Major's speech, and later they distill these ideas down into the Seven Commandments. Snowball is responsible for generating the maxim "four legs good, two legs bad," which he teaches to the sheep and other less intelligent animals in order to give them some version of the Seven Commandments to repeat. Despite being the generator of this maxim, in the months after, the phrase often gets used against Snowball during Sunday meetings, as the sheep often start bleating the maxim out of the blue during Snowball's speeches. It's implied that these interruptions are Napoleon's work, as the two pigs develop an intense rivalry in the months after the rebellion. Snowball is somewhat of an idealistic individual; he proposes that the farm animals build a **windmill** in order to generate electricity, which he suggests will ultimately lead to a three-day workweek. He also comes up with a variety of other schemes and groups aimed at improving the animals' lives and education status, and he also promotes spreading news of the rebellion far and wide. Despite his idealism, however, Snowball still shows himself to be willing to exploit the other animals for his own gain, as when he says nothing about taking the milk and apples for the pigs only. On the day that the animals vote to build the windmill, Napoleon exiles Snowball by setting his attack dogs on him. After this, Snowball disappears as a character, but Napoleon continues to invoke Snowball as a nefarious figure who conspires against Animal Farm, is in league with humans, and is intent on messing everything up on the farm. Through this, Napoleon discredits Snowball's bravery and actions in the Battle of the Cowshed and makes it so no animal can feel any affinity for Snowball. **Snowball** *symbolizes Trotsky, a rival of Stalin exiled from Russia and assassinated on Stalin's orders in Mexico in 1940.*

Boxer – A huge, gentle carthorse. Boxer isn't especially intelligent—he only learns the first four letters of the alphabet—but Old Major's speech and the equality expressed in the Seven Commandments appeals to his generous nature. Because of this, Boxer becomes one of Napoleon and Snowball's biggest disciples as they attempt to spread the ideals of Animalism to others, as Boxer is capable of making simple, easy to understand arguments to his peers. After the rebellion, Boxer then becomes one of the most valuable members of Animal Farm, as he's fully sold on its ideals, entirely loyal to Napoleon, and convinced that his hard work is absolutely essential to the success of the farm. On that final point, Boxer is right: his labor is what makes it so that the animals are able to build both attempts at their **windmills**. To this end, Boxer adopts two personal mottos: "I will work harder," and "Napoleon is always right." Through these mottos, the novel shows how someone like Boxer sacrifices himself to the cause at the expense of everything, including his health, his intellect, and his possibility for advancement. Boxer never realizes that Napoleon is the reason conditions are so poor on Animal Farm, and he never becomes aware of his own strength or power to change anything. This means that when Boxer collapses, he fully believes that Napoleon is going to send him to a human veterinarian—and he can't read the writing on the van that comes to take him away, which is a van bound for a glue factory. By the time other animals alert Boxer to what's going on, Boxer is far too weak to make any successful attempt to save himself, and instead, his death goes on to benefit the ruling class of pigs on Animal Farm. **Boxer** *represents the male working class and peasants of the Soviet Union.*

Benjamin – A jaded donkey with the skeptical view that life will always be difficult and painful. Because of this outlook, Benjamin isn't surprised when the pigs corrupt the revolution and transform Animal Farm into a totalitarian state. Though his skepticism proves to be well-founded and he alone among the animals seems aware of what's going on, it also renders him ineffective as he's unwilling to speak up or do anything to stop it. He also consistently refuses to explain what's going on to his friends, as when he refuses to read the Seven Commandments to Clover and alone understands what he's seeing when the animals find Squealer and paint next to a broken ladder and the Seven Commandments. This comes back to haunt him when Napoleon betrays Boxer and sends him to the glue factory—though Benjamin does speak up and tell the animals what's going on, it's too late to save Boxer. **Benjamin** *represents those who were aware of Stalin's unjust and oppressive policies but did nothing to try to stop them.*

Squealer – A fat pig who's a skilled orator. Squealer works closely with Snowball and Napoleon at first—and later, just Napoleon—to interpret or distill what the pigs' plan is for the other animals. Squealer is purportedly able to convince animals of anything, and he's very effective in his job. Sometimes he's effective because of the way he's able to manipulate language; other times, Squealer is effective because the attack dogs accompany him. He benefits from Napoleon's rule, as Squealer is often tasked with addressing the animals during Sunday meetings and gets the same extensive rations as the rest of the pigs. At the end of the novel, Squealer learns to walk on two legs and teaches the sheep the new maxim "Four legs good, two legs better!" He's present at the meeting between the pigs and the farmers. **Squealer** *represents the Soviet press, which Stalin controlled throughout his rule.*

Old Major – A revered old boar who, at the beginning of the novel, gathers the animals together to speak to them about what's wrong with their world. He proposes that humanity is

their one true enemy, as people profit off of what animals produce without producing anything themselves—and specifically in the case of Mr. Jones, humans are cruel, unfeeling, and abuse those below them. Old Major's speech forms the basis for Animalism, a theory that Napoleon and Snowball develop in the three months after Old Major's death. Old Major dies a few months before the revolution and so never gets to see his ideas play out in the real world, but Napoleon does eventually disinter Old Major's head so that the other animals can walk past it reverently. **Old Major** *symbolizes both Karl Marx and Vladimir Lenin, the fathers of Communism.*

Clover – A gentle, motherly, and powerful carthorse. She supports the revolution, as she naturally takes it upon herself to protect those weaker than she is, and she recognizes this kind of communal spirit echoed in the Seven Commandments. When Animal Farm begins to descend into a totalitarian state under Napoleon, however, Clover becomes dismayed—but she doesn't have the will, personality, or education to resist the pigs. Clover never becomes fully literate and only learns the alphabet, and so she's unable to detect changes to the Seven Commandments and buys into everything the pigs say. In this sense, she becomes a witness to the corruption, though she only vaguely understands that something went wrong—but still believes that the totalitarian state she finds herself living in must be better than life under Mr. Jones. **Clover** *symbolizes the female working class and peasants of the Soviet Union.*

Mr. Jones – The original owner of Manor Farm. Once a strict and fierce master, in the years before the story begins, Mr. Jones became drunk, careless, and ineffective, as well as casually cruel and arrogant. Mr. Jones's carelessness and cruelty are the final straw for the animals: they instigate a rebellion when he neglects to feed them and then tries to beat them when they break into the stores of grain. Though Mr. Jones attempts to take back Animal Farm, his attempt is unsuccessful and none of the other farmers have much genuine sympathy for him. **Mr. Jones** *symbolizes the Russian Tsar in the early 20th century.*

Mr. Pilkington – The gentleman farmer who owns Foxwood, one of Animal Farm's neighbors. Foxwood is large, sprawling, and old-fashioned, and Mr. Pilkington himself spends more time hunting and on leisure activities than he does farming. Though Napoleon vilifies Mr. Pilkington at various times, Mr. Pilkington does appear to enter into an agreement to buy timber from Animal Farm in good faith—but he rudely pulls his support for Animal Farm when Napoleon double-crosses him. Mr. Pilkington attends the final card game at Animal Farm and tries to cheat Napoleon. **Mr. Pilkington** *represents the Allies before World War II.*

Mr. Frederick – The owner of the neighboring farm of Pinchfield. He's vicious, cruel, and calculating, and rumors circulate that he's especially horrible to his farm animals. After suffering abuse from Napoleon, Mr. Frederick ultimately purchases timber from Animal Farm, but pays for it with counterfeit bills, and days later, attacks Animal Farm and blows up the **windmill**. Though he's successful in this endeavor, he disappears from the story after this point. **Mr. Frederick** *symbolizes the fascist Germans and Hitler in particular.*

The Cat – A greedy and self-serving farm cat. She's only interested in participating in the rebellion when there's no cost or danger to do so, and she's only willing to support Animalism when it might help her—though it's implied that she doesn't truly believe in the ideology even then; she parrots its ideals to try to dupe birds she'd like to eat. The cat disappears before Napoleon turns Animal Farm into an entirely totalitarian state.

Mollie – A vain, white horse who, prior to the rebellion, pulls Mr. Jones's cart. She loves sugar and wearing pretty ribbons in her mane, and she never cares much for the revolution—supporting it would mean she couldn't have sugar or ribbons. Because of this, she abandons Animal Farm and enters into service for another human only a few months after the rebellion. **Mollie** *symbolizes the selfish and materialistic middle class.*

The Sheep – Some of the least intelligent animals on Animal Farm. They never become fully literate and can't remember the Seven Commandments, but Snowball teaches them the maxim "Four legs good, two legs bad," which they love and bleat all the time. They're receptive to propaganda and follow orders without questioning anything. **The sheep** *represent the duped citizens of a totalitarian state.*

The Hens – Unintelligent laying hens on Animal Farm. They're initially fully behind the rebellion and the ideals of Animal Farm but become somewhat disillusioned—and terrified—when Napoleon insists that they must surrender their eggs. The hens' rebellion is unsuccessful, and nine die over the course of their five-day resistance. **The hens** *correspond to the Ukrainian peasants who attempted to resist Stalin's five-year plan and died.*

The Dogs – Jessie, Bluebell, Pincher, and the nine attack dogs provide the pigs with the brute force necessary to terrorize the other animals. In return, the dogs receive special privileges and often sit close to the pigs. They don't rule, but they live comfortably and get enough to eat because they support the pigs. **The dogs** *symbolize the Soviet secret police.*

Muriel – A white goat; one of the few animals who becomes fully literate. While **Muriel** doesn't correspond to any one person, *she can be seen as a representation of educated individuals who are able to interpret what's going on, but who don't have the charisma or the power to speak their minds.*

MINOR CHARACTERS

Moses – A tame raven and Mr. Jones's special pet. The animals dislike him because he doesn't work, but many of them do believe his stories about Sugarcandy Mountain, a wonderful

place where animals go when they die. **Moses** *represents organized religion, and specifically the Russian Orthodox Church.*

Mr. Whymper – The solicitor whom Napoleon hires to represent Animal Farm to the outside world. He's shrewd and calculating, and by the end of the novel, has done well for himself. **Mr. Whymper** *represents the capitalists who got rich doing business with the USSR.*

Minimus – A pig who writes propaganda poems and songs praising Napoleon and Animal Farm. **Minimus** *represents the takeover of art by propaganda in a totalitarian state that aims to control what its citizens think.*

Mrs. Jones – Mr. Jones's wife.

THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



TOTALITARIANISM

George Orwell once wrote: "Every line of serious work that I have written since 1936 has been [...] against totalitarianism." *Animal Farm*, Orwell's tale of the titular farm animals' takeover of a provincial English farm and their development of a totalitarian state there, is no exception. Totalitarianism is a form of government in which the state seeks to control every facet of life, from economics and politics to each individual's ideas and beliefs. Different totalitarian states have different justifications for their rule, but *Animal Farm* suggests that all totalitarian regimes are fundamentally the same: those in power care only about maintaining their power by any means necessary, and they do so by oppressing the individual and the lower classes.

While *Animal Farm* is, most directly, a pointed critique of the USSR, the totalitarian regime established by Joseph Stalin in the early 20th century. However, the book also implies at various points that the USSR was not—and indeed, isn't—the only totalitarian regime worth critiquing. At the beginning of the novel, Mr. Jones's running of Manor Farm reads as similarly totalitarian and despotic to Stalin's regime. Mr. Jones spends his time drinking and hires corrupt, unfeeling cronies to run the farm while his animals toil their lives away, only to be slaughtered or otherwise killed gruesomely when they're no longer useful to him. The animals' lives are short and guaranteed to be lived in hunger, while Mr. Jones lives in relative luxury and believes that the natural order of things is that he, as a human, should be the one in charge of his animals. After the animals overthrow Mr. Jones and Napoleon the pig takes over the farm, the animals themselves begin to emulate this oppressive hierarchy despite basing their initial uprising on the notion that all animals are equal. At the end of the novel, it's possible to see that if the other farmers who visit Napoleon's Animal Farm aren't yet running totalitarian farming establishments already, the hunger to do so is definitely there—Mr. Pilkington notes that it's commendable that Napoleon manages to eke so much labor out of his animals while providing so little in the way of food and other care. This makes it clear that the tendency for a government or organization to lean toward totalitarianism is often present, even if it's not always evident in practice at a given time. In other words, Napoleon as a totalitarian dictator isn't an anomaly—he's part of a much larger tendency of powerful leaders to consolidate and hoard as much power as possible.

The way that Napoleon, Stalin, and other leaders, fictional and real, achieve these totalitarian states is by controlling every aspect of life in their state. Napoleon demonstrates that this is particularly achievable through offering education and elite job training to some, while denying those opportunities to many—while also assuring the "many," through propaganda and pro-state events, that things are as they should be. While the pig Snowball takes it upon himself to attempt to educate everyone on Animal Farm, Napoleon insists that it's not worth it to educate the animals who are already adults and instead, it's better to focus on educating the youth. This does several things. First, by having an uneducated adult population, Napoleon ensures that those adults won't be able to teach their offspring to think and potentially push back on him. Those adults also won't be able to push back themselves, both because of their own illiteracy and because of how little power they have to begin with. Then, while Napoleon uses "youth" to describe who he wants to educate, the youth are at first just the dogs' nine puppies and later, are just the 31 piglets he fathered. Educating the puppies turns them into nine vicious adult dogs that mirror the Soviet secret police and go on to help Napoleon maintain his rule, while the young pigs represent an educated and powerful ruling class. Essentially, when Napoleon mentions educating youth, he very purposefully doesn't include the young chicks, ducklings, calves, or foals in the term, thereby relegating them to a position in society where they're unable to advocate for themselves or for change—or indeed, even to understand that speaking up is something they can or should do.

In addition to controlling education and advancement opportunities, the novel also illustrates the role of propaganda in a totalitarian state. From Napoleon's initial takeover of Animal Farm to the very end of the novel, he skillfully deploys propaganda in the form of the Seven Commandments themselves, as well as the skilled orator pig Squealer and the pig Minimus, who composes songs and poems that praise Animal Farm and Napoleon. Importantly, much of what the pigs

write and say to the other farm animals comes in the form of absolutes, as when Old Major says initially that animals should never concede that they might have common interests with men, or when Squealer insists that the pigs need all the food they can get—or else Mr. Jones will surely return. Importantly, the exhausted and uneducated animals have complete trust that Napoleon has their best interests at heart—something Squealer reminds them of constantly—in addition to the inability to recognize the pigs' propaganda efforts for what they are. In this way, Napoleon creates a cult of personality around himself that is fueled by fear, ignorance, and the deeply-held belief that Napoleon's version of Animal Farm (while still short on food and requiring hard work) is the best possible scenario.

Animal Farm offers no real remedies for overthrowing totalitarianism. Indeed, the end of the novel, in which both pigs and humans are revealed to be equally corrupt and interested in presiding over totalitarian states, is extremely grim. However, the very existence of the novel itself allows readers to understand how a totalitarian state comes into being, gains power, and holds onto it. Knowing how this process happens and has happened historically, as well as recognizing one's own power to not let this happen in the first place, the novel suggests, are the best thing readers can do to guard against totalitarianism in their own lifetimes.



REVOLUTION AND CORRUPTION

Animal Farm depicts a revolution in progress. Like all popular revolutions, the uprising in *Animal Farm* develops out of a hope for a better future, in which farm animals can enjoy the fruits of their own labor without the overbearing rule of humans. At the time of the revolution, all of the animals on Mr. Jones's farm, even the pigs, are committed to the idea of universal equality—but these high ideals that fueled the revolution in the first place gradually give way to individual and class-based self-interest. *Animal Farm* thus illustrates how a revolution can be corrupted into a totalitarian regime through slow, gradual changes.

At first, the revolution creates the sense that there could be a bright future in store for Animal Farm. Old Major makes a number of objectively true points in his speech to the animals, such as that Mr. Jones is a cruel and unfeeling master who cares little or not at all for their wellbeing, and that humans themselves don't produce anything (like eggs or milk). The Seven Commandments that Snowball and Napoleon come up with in the months after are similarly idealistic, and, in theory, lay the groundwork for a revolution that truly will elevate individual workers above horrible, totalitarian leaders like Mr. Jones. Indeed, when the rebellion surprisingly happens, things initially seem as if they're going to go in a positive direction for everyone: there are debates among the animals, animals have the ability to propose items for discussion, and every animal participates in the working of the farm. Best of all, the animals pull in the best and fastest hay harvest that the farm has ever seen, suggesting that their revolution has benefits in addition to freeing them from a cruel situation under Mr. Jones. It seems possible that they'll truly be able to make self-government work.

However, the novel also offers early clues that corruption begins to take hold on Animal Farm long before Napoleon takes drastic steps to turn it into a totalitarian state, even when by most metrics, things seem to be going smoothly and fairly. For instance, it's not an accident that only the pigs and the dogs are the ones who become fully literate. While to a degree, this becomes a chicken and egg question (in terms of which came first: literacy or corrupt power), the fact remains that the only literate creatures are the ones who ultimately seize control. Further, even idealistic Snowball insists to the other animals that because the literate pigs are "mindworkers" engaged in figuring out how exactly to run the farm, they need the entire crop of apples and all the cows' milk. This power shift takes place during that first exceptional hay harvest, making it clear that things aren't as rosy as the hay yield, and the increased productivity it suggests, might lead one to believe.

The corruption doesn't end with the theft of milk and apples; by the end of the novel, the pigs sleep in the farmhouse, have a school for their pig children, drink alcohol, and consume sugar off of the Jones's set of fine china—all things initially forbidden in some form in the original Seven Commandments. However, one of the most corrupt things that the pigs do is to modify the Seven Commandments to effectively legalize whatever it is they decide they want to do, from drinking alcohol to sleeping in beds. This corruption is something that most animals don't notice, while those that do are either cowed into pretending that they don't notice or executed for expressing concern. This combination of fear and unthinking trust in leaders, the novel suggests, is one of the most important elements that allows corruption to flourish.

Though the animals' rebellion began as one against humans and everything they stand for in the animals' eyes—greed, alcoholism, decadence, and cruelty, among other vices—it's telling that the novel ends when animals, led by Clover, cannot tell Napoleon and his pig cronies apart from the human farmers who came for a tour and dinner. With this, the novel proposes that revolution is something cyclical that repeats throughout time. Because of corruption, those individuals who are powerful to begin with or who overthrow cruel and heartless leaders will inevitably come to resemble those former leaders, once they understand what it's like to occupy such a position of power. In this sense, Orwell paints a grim view of revolution as a whole, as *Animal Farm* demonstrates clearly that even when the ideals of a revolution may be good, it's all too easy to twist those ideals, fall prey to corruption, and poison the movement, harming countless powerless individuals in the process.



CLASS WARFARE

One of the main tenets of Animalism, the ideology that Napoleon and Snowball develop, is that all animals are equal. However, it doesn't take long for the pigs to begin to refer to themselves as "mindworkers" to distinguish themselves from the other animals, who work as physical laborers. Through this, *Animal Farm* shows how differences in education and occupation lead to the development of a class hierarchy, which leads inevitably to class warfare, in which one class seeks to dominate the other. Though *Animal Farm* suggests that the "mindworking" or intellectual class will almost always prevail in this struggle, it also goes to great lengths to suggest that whether because of ignorance, inaction, or fear, this is something that the working class allows to happen.

Even as early as Old Major's speech, it's possible to detect that there are class divisions at play on Manor Farm. It's telling, for one, that it's a pig who's giving the speech, and that the other pigs sit closest to the platform while the other animals fill in behind them. The respect that all animals have for Old Major, and the seating arrangements, suggest that pigs as a species already occupy a special and revered place on the farm. Following the rebellion, the pigs prey on this structure by using their literacy to catapult themselves to positions of power as "mindworkers," or those in charge of figuring out how to run the farm (rather than doing the manual work of running the farm). Because of the pigs' literacy, they're able to effectively take control over every aspect of the farm and subjugate those they believe to be less intelligent or less powerful than they are. They do so in part by making it extremely scary and dangerous to stand up to them, which Napoleon does by training nine attack dogs and sending them out with the pigs when they spread news. With the dogs— known killers—around, no one dares ask too many questions that might betray their dissatisfaction with their lives.

As objectively successful as the pigs may be in this endeavor, *Animal Farm* goes to great lengths to show that especially at the beginning, the pigs are only able to achieve superior status by tricking others into thinking they're less powerful. This is especially apparent in the case of Boxer, a good-hearted but unintelligent carthorse. Boxer throws himself into the work of cultivating the farm—his personal motto becomes, "I will work harder"—and he fully supports Napoleon and Napoleon's rule, even when at times, Boxer recognizes that Napoleon isn't actually acting in Boxer and the other workers' best interests. The fact that he's not a mindworker, however, means that Boxer never pushes back on this much. This all comes to a head during Napoleon's trials and executions of "traitorous" farm animals, when Napoleon sets his dogs on four young pigs, and three of the dogs attack Boxer. Boxer sends two dogs flying and pins the third under his massive hoof—it's clear, through the dog's terrified reaction, that if Boxer were so inclined, he could do away with Napoleon and Napoleon's brutal dogs with a couple of kicks. Napoleon's power as a mindworker, however, means that he's created an environment in which Boxer isn't aware of his own physical strength. Part of being part of the lower class, *Animal Farm* suggests, is not being aware of one's power to effectively fight back against rulers like Napoleon, even if just physically. This state of not recognizing even one's physical power to fight back, furthermore, isn't unique to Boxer; if the non-pig farm animals were somehow able to band together, it's possible they could've ousted Napoleon through force.

On the other end of the spectrum, the novel offers Benjamin, the jaded donkey who believes that no matter what, life will be difficult, and everyone will work against him. Notably, Benjamin, unlike Boxer, becomes completely literate within a few months and seems to alone in his awareness of the pigs' corruption and attempts to manipulate the animals. Benjamin, however, stubbornly refuses to read the ever-changing Commandments to others and never sees a reason to enlighten his fellow working animals as to what's going on. As a result, when Benjamin finally does speak up about Napoleon's betrayal of Boxer and reads that Boxer is headed for the glue factory rather than the vet, it's too late to do anything: the animals don't have enough time to trap the van containing Boxer on farm property, and Boxer is too ill and weak to break out of the van. Through this, the novel illustrates how willful inaction and ignorance of all sorts work together to keep the lower classes oppressed: those who know what's going on never alert those who might be able to fight, while those capable of fighting never figure out who their true enemy is, and therefore are never able to do anything but support the state that oppresses them.

Through this, *Animal Farm* paints a picture of class struggle in which once class divisions are established, it's very difficult to change them or break them down, even in light of guiding principles like the Seven Commandments that would theoretically suggest that class shouldn't exist in the first place. However, even more damning is the novel's assertion that this is something that the repressed lower classes allow to happen to them when they're unable to identify their oppressors or refuse to speak out when they do see what's going on. The novel ultimately suggests that silence—especially when combined with fear and a lack of education—is the primary reason for oppression and the reason why the upper classes are able to maintain their power so effectively.



LANGUAGE AS POWER

From the beginning of the popular revolution on Manor Farm, language—both spoken and written—is instrumental to the animals' collective success, and later to the pigs' consolidation of power. Through *Animal Farm*, Orwell illustrates how language is an influential tool that individuals can use to seize power and manipulate others via propaganda, while also showing that education and

one's corresponding grasp of language is what can turn someone into either a manipulative authority figure or an unthinking, uneducated member of the working class.

At the novel's beginning, the animals are on equal footing in terms of education, more or less—though Old Major has had time in his retirement to think about the state of the world and develop his theory that man is the root of all the animals' problems, none of the animals, at this point, are literate or can do much more than expound on their ideas. Right after the rebellion, however, the pigs reveal that Old Major's speech was the start of what will become their rise to power in two distinct ways. First, the pigs Napoleon and Snowball spent the three months between Old Major's speech and the rebellion distilling Old Major's ideas into a theory they call Animalism; second, the pigs taught themselves to read. Taken together, these efforts turn the pigs into an intellectual class and provide them the basis for going on to refer to themselves as "mindworkers," or individuals whose contributions to society are intellectual in nature, and therefore don't have to contribute by doing manual labor or something of the sort. In this sense, the pigs' grasp of language is what propels them to power in the first place.

It doesn't take long, however, before the pigs begin to abuse their power. Though Snowball takes it upon himself to try to teach every farm animal to read, his efforts are overwhelmingly unsuccessful—only Muriel and Benjamin ever become fully literate. Most other animals only learn some of the alphabet, and in the case of the sheep, never get past the letter A. While the novel is consistent in its assertion that this is because animals like the sheep and Boxer are unintelligent, it's also important to note that, in terms of the working of the farm, Boxer and the sheep are more valuable for the physical labor they can perform than for anything they might be able to do intellectually. Further, because of the hard labor required of the animals, it's implied that there's little time for someone like Boxer to work at learning to read, and indeed, when Boxer begins to think about his retirement, he suggests he'd like to take the time—which he's never had before—to learn the rest of the alphabet. By contrast, education and achieving literacy for pig and dog youth soon becomes a center point of the pigs' rule, especially once Napoleon declares they need a school for pig children—a project that, conveniently for the powerful pigs, also leaves the animals tasked with building the school no time to learn anything themselves.

The consequences of the other animals' illiteracy and lack of education, the novel shows, is that it makes them susceptible to blindly believing misinformation and propaganda that the pigs spread through Squealer and Minimus. Not only can animals like Clover not recognize when the pigs tamper with the Seven Commandments and alter them to meet their needs; Clover also cannot remember correctly what the Commandments *used* to be. Further, *Animal Farm* also shows how the extremely uneducated, such as the sheep (and, it's implied, Boxer) can be manipulated into becoming important tools for spreading propaganda. Though Boxer is unable to read, he nevertheless trusts his leaders completely and so adopts the maxim "I will work harder," which the other animals find more compelling and noble than any of the flowery speeches that Napoleon or Squealer give. The sheep, on the other hand, are unable to memorize the Seven Commandments and so learn a maxim that Snowball develops: "Four legs good, two legs bad." This maxim in particular is so simplistic as to be almost meaningless, in addition to containing no nuance. The fowl, for instance, have two legs and take issue with this maxim until Snowball is able to explain to them why they're actually wrong—and because of their lack of intelligence and Snowball's grasp of language, he's able to effectively convince them that the maxim functions as it should.

By the end of the novel, the pigs are so powerful that their language and intellectualism doesn't have to make sense—or be true—in any way; rather, it simply has to *look like* they're smart and in charge. Squealer's constant recitation of figures "proving" that Animal Farm is producing more than ever function to make him look powerful and intelligent, but the animals are unable to fully reconcile that in reality, they have little food no matter what Squealer says. Similarly, the final change to the Seven Commandments, in which the Commandments change from seven (albeit altered) guiding principles to the phrase "All animals are equal, but some animals are more equal than others" encapsulates this idea. The phrase mocks the meaning of the word "equal," for one—if all animals are equal, there shouldn't be a hierarchy among them, when clearly, there is one—while also being ambiguous enough for the pigs to essentially make the phrase mean whatever they want it to. In this sense, it allows them to maintain their power, since they can insist the phrase means they *should* have more power, while also still employing words like "equal" that make the other animals feel as though, per the phrase, everything is still fine. In this way, *Animal Farm* shows clearly how those in power and with a firm grasp of language can easily use it to manipulate those who don't have the education or memory to stand up to them—and in doing so, keep those individuals down, deny them any possibility of advancement, and create the illusion that things are just as they should be.



THE SOVIET UNION

While *Animal Farm* condemns all forms of totalitarianism, it's most explicitly a bitter attack on the Soviet Union. Though Orwell supported the ideals of socialism, he strongly opposed the Soviet Union's descent into totalitarianism under Stalin in the decades before and during World War II. *Animal Farm* satirically attacks the Soviet Union by mirroring many events from Soviet history, and though *Animal Farm* is subtitled "A Fairy Story," almost nothing that happens in it is at all fantastical; nearly every event, and

indeed every **character**, correlates to a historical event, person, or group of people.

The first portion of the novel has parallels to the final years of the 19th century and the first few decades of the 20th century. Mr. Jones is a parallel to Tsar Nicholas, the final monarch of Russia, whose family was widely seen as decadent and unconcerned with the fact that many Russians at that point were starving and wildly dissatisfied with their rulers. Old Major represents Vladimir Lenin, a Marxist revolutionary who led the Bolshevik Party that ultimately ousted Nicholas during the Bolshevik Revolution of 1917. Like Old Major, Lenin didn't survive to see his ideals come to fruition; rather, his associate Leon Trotsky, represented by Snowball in the novel, took over and advocated for spreading revolutions all over the world (as when Snowball proposes sending out more pigeons to spread word of the rebellion to neighboring farms) and planned to modernize what, by this time, had become the USSR. Joseph Stalin exiled Trotsky, however, and ultimately assassinated him in Mexico. Stalin, like his literary counterpart Napoleon, didn't care much for debate, and instead amassed power, developed a totalitarian state, and relied heavily on propaganda to control the population. Events on Animal Farm after Napoleon's takeover mirror many that happened in the USSR during his rule, including Stalin's Five Year Plans (the first and second **windmills**), rebellions on the part of farmers and sailors (the hens' rebellion), and Stalin's show trials and executions (the confessions and executions of the four young pigs and other animals). The novel ends with a parallel to the Tehran Conference in 1943, during which Winston Churchill of Great Britain, Franklin D. Roosevelt of the US, and Stalin met to discuss how to achieve peace after World War II, an event that Orwell mocks when both Mr. Pilkington (the Allies) and Napoleon cheat at cards, presciently predicting what would ultimately develop into the Cold War between the US and the USSR.

Notably, *Animal Farm* focuses intently on the inner monologues and experiences of those who don't have much or any power, such as Clover and Boxer (who symbolize female and male peasant workers, respectively). Through Clover's experience in particular, Orwell paints a picture of 40 years' worth of history that was alternately, and at times simultaneously, hopeful and horrific—and often hungry and scary for those without power, education, or the means to escape—as Mollie, the cat, and the real-life middle class do and did. Further, Orwell doesn't stop at vilifying the USSR alone. Instead, he suggests that capitalists who got rich doing business with the USSR, as represented by Mr. Whymper, and ultimately, the allies who gave Stalin a legitimate place on the world stage, as represented by the farmers' visit to Animal Farm at the end of the novel, are also to blame for what happened. Through this, Orwell cautions against romanticizing any aspect of Russian or USSR history, as even though he may have sympathized with the ideals that drove the revolution to begin with, he makes it very clear that the fruits of the revolution are nothing anyone should aspire to. Rather than helping anyone, the revolutions actually led to starvation, fear, death, and trauma of all sorts.

SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.

CHARACTER NAMES

As Orwell wrote *Animal Farm* as an allegory—a symbolic representation of real events—many characters and events in the novel symbolize individuals or groups in the Russian Revolution and the Soviet Union. Some of the characters who symbolize individuals or groups in Soviet society include Mr. Jones (the Russian Tsar and the old aristocratic order); Old Major (Karl Marx and Vladimir Lenin); Napoleon (Stalin); Snowball (Trotsky); Squealer (the press); the dogs (the secret police); and Moses the Raven (organized religion). Nearly all of the other animals represent the working class and Soviet peasants.

THE WINDMILL

The windmill represents the massive infrastructure construction projects and modernization initiatives that Soviet leaders instituted immediately after the Russian Revolution, specifically Joseph Stalin's Five-Year Plans. The way that the animals go hungry in order to build the windmill in the first place mirrors how the Five Year Plans, while intended to create enough food for everyone, were wildly unsuccessful and led to widespread famine in the early 1930s. Later in the novel, the windmill also comes to symbolize the pigs' totalitarian triumph: the other animals work to build the windmill thinking it will benefit everyone, but even after it benefits only the pigs, the animals continue to believe that it benefits all of them.

QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Signet Classics edition of *Animal Farm* published in 1996.

Chapter 1 Quotes

"Why then do we continue in this miserable condition? Because nearly the whole of the produce of our labour is stolen from us by human beings."

Related Characters: Old Major (speaker), Mr. Jones

Related Themes:

Page Number: 7

Explanation and Analysis

Old Major gives a rallying speech to the other farm animals. He claims, here, that animals are trapped in a system that extracts the products of their labor and therefore makes them dependent on their human masters.

The entirety of Old Major's speech is built on a socialist framework, and this line is particularly reminiscent of Soviet speech patterns and ideology. That "labour" has been "stolen" speaks to the common Marxist critique of alienated labor: in this account, Karl Marx, the theoretical origin for communism, believed that capitalist practices had divorced the producers of commodities from the actual use of those commodities. Instead of, for example, building one's own car or farming one's own corn, capitalism had forced people to build cars and farm corn for others. Old Major is subtly invoking this idea when he points out that what the animals produce is "stolen." Whereas the Marxist sense was more metaphorical or symbolic, in this case the stealing is literal. The animals are thus a useful way to make abstract concepts concrete (as any good allegory does). Orwell's work therefore positions the animals as both engaging in and representing a revolution against the "miserable condition" of capitalism. Their relative successes and failures can be read as the corresponding values and limits of other revolutionary movements.

"Man is the only real enemy we have. Remove Man from the scene, and the root cause of hunger and overwork is abolished for ever. Man is the only creature that consumes without producing. He does not give milk, he does not lay eggs, he is too weak to pull the plough, he cannot run fast enough to catch rabbits. Yet he is lord of all the animals. He sets them to work, he gives back to them the bare minimum that will prevent them from starving, and the rest he keeps for himself."

Related Characters: Old Major (speaker), Mr. Jones

Related Themes:

Page Number: 7-8

Explanation and Analysis

The boar Old Major gives this rousing speech after calling the other animals into the barn. He argues that humans hold an unfair power over animals, for they take the animals' resources without offering anything in return.

Old Major's rhetoric employs many features characteristic of revolutionary speech. For instance, it posits the existence of a single evil that, if removed, would fix all issues. In making man the single and "root cause" of the animals' hardship, Old Major glosses over any differences or quibbles among the animals themselves. To do so, he selects the quality that all animals hold in common except humans: resource production. Though Old Major could have chosen a value that, say, people and some animals have in common, his decision instead allows the animals to unify against this false "lord."

Orwell here shows the efficacy of this revolutionary speech, while also pointing out its false premise: that all animals can be considered equal and will live in harmony and without hunger once humanity is removed. The story thus becomes a parody of the socialist and soviet efforts to unify disparate groups or people in the fight to overturn governmental systems—for that tactic predicts the fact that new lords will simply replace the vanquished humans.

"Remember, comrades, your resolution must never falter. No argument must lead you astray. Never listen when they tell you that Man and the animals have a common interest, that the prosperity of the one is the prosperity of the others. It is all lies. Man serves the interests of no creature except himself. And among us animals let there be perfect unity, perfect comradeship in the struggle. All men are enemies. All animals are comrades."

Related Characters: Old Major (speaker), Mr. Jones

Related Themes:

Page Number: 10

Explanation and Analysis

As Old Major's rousing speech draws to a close, he gives these final polemical statements. They draw harsh boundaries between humans and animals and offer a specific, prescriptive strategy for the animals to unite.

What stands out in Old Major's language here is his absolutism: each sentence carries a term such as "never," "no," "all," and "perfect," thus permitting no space for nuance or exceptions. The goal in employing such terms is to draw strict boundaries that consolidate one group against another. By defining a singular and complete evil—"All men

are enemies"—Old Major can link a disparate set of animals with the single term "comrades." Thus adopting a direct foe becomes the essential way to consolidate a group with a direct purpose.

Yet Orwell also implies the danger inherent in this kind of rhetoric: Old Major insists, for instance, that the animals not take into account any other perspectives. When he says, "No argument" and "It is all lies," Old Major does not actually offer compelling counter-evidence, but rather asserts that any potential criticism should be ignored without due consideration. This sort of blind acceptance is precisely what will allow new tyrants to take control in the animal world after they have overthrown the humans—for Old Major has paved the way for them by indoctrinating the animals with authoritarian values and squashing the merit of independent thought.

Chapter 2 Quotes

THE SEVEN COMMANDMENTS

1. *Whatever goes upon two legs is an enemy.*
2. *Whatever goes upon four legs, or has wings, is a friend.*
3. *No animal shall wear clothes.*
4. *No animal shall sleep in a bed.*
5. *No animal shall drink alcohol.*
6. *No animal shall kill any other animal.*
7. *All animals are equal.*

Related Characters: Napoleon, Snowball, Old Major

Related Themes:

Page Number: 24-25

Explanation and Analysis

After having successfully ousted Mr. Jones and taken control of the farm, the pigs publicly display these tenets of Animalism. They detail the new rules of Animal Farm, which has been founded on a communal philosophy.

The tone of these commandments continues the kind of absolutist rhetoric employed by Old Major in his rousing speech. They all begin with words that permit no exception—"Whatever," "no," and "all"—and thus unify the farm animals under well-defined terms. Their society is thereby shown to stem from a singular ideology, developed by Old Major, rather than from a democratic election or debate process. By publicly displaying the commandments, they imply that any social contention can be resolved by returning to these seven rules.

The order of the commandments deserves some additional attention: By first designating "an enemy" and then "a friend," the commandments situate the fear of humans as the farm's core value. Through this detail, Orwell seems to point out how the USSR, along with other authoritarian regimes, rely first and foremost on a well-defined enemy in order to derive their other societal values. Indeed, almost all the commandments refer indirectly to humans, defining animal behaviors as anti-consumer and anti-economic. Only the last two commandments actually speak to morality as it concerns inter-animal relations, and the term "equal" remains deliberately unclear. Orwell thus stresses how an ideologically-driven society derives power but also creates ambiguity through its strict public rules.

Chapter 3 Quotes

"I will work harder!"

Related Characters: Boxer (speaker)

Related Themes:

Page Number: 29

Explanation and Analysis

Boxer adopts this phrase as his motto in the animal's new society. He becomes the epitome of the socialist work ethic, in which one derives one's value from the ability to contribute to the wellbeing of others.

Above all, this sentence shows how Boxer has fully internalized the values of Animalism. He is motivated to work ever harder based on a striking commitment to the society, and to his belief that he can improve the lives of others simply through hard work. Indeed, he is quite effective in this endeavor, and is able to aid the animals in producing an excellent harvest.

Yet the phrase also speaks to his narrow-minded perspective: Boxer does not consider other ways that he could approach life, but rather identifies fully with a single quality: his physical strength. Orwell renders him a caricature of how adherents to socialism were required to behave dependently: the best workers were instructed not to reflect on their position in the system, but simply drive themselves to work ever harder. Boxer thus demonstrates both the efficacy of a revolution like that in the USSR, as well as the significant drawbacks to such a structure.

> Nobody stole, nobody grumbled over his rations, the quarreling and biting and jealousy which had been normal features of life in the old days had almost disappeared.

Related Characters: Old Major

Related Themes:

Page Number: 29

Explanation and Analysis

Immediately after the animals take control of the farm, their society seems to be functioning extremely well. The text presents an ideal scenario in which Animalism solves not only the external fight with humans but also the internal strife between animal factions.

Once more, a set of absolutist terms—"nobody" and "almost disappeared" highlight how extensively the change has permeated the farm. These changes refer to the interpersonal dealings of the animals, which, the reader can presume, normally included stealing, grumbling, quarreling, biting, and jealousy. Thus not only has Animalism prevented bad actions done by some animals to each other; it has also eliminated bad thoughts such as "jealousy." It seems that the revolution has indeed successfully led to the equity and peace envisioned by Old Major. Orwell thus shows how the early moments after a revolutionary event can indeed bring about the intended effects—and that only later will the less positive outcomes manifest themselves.

> "Four legs good, two legs bad."

Related Characters: The Sheep (speaker), Snowball

Related Themes:

Page Number: 34

Explanation and Analysis

Snowball invents this phrase when the sheep are unable to learn the commandments of Animalism. Yet the sheep cannot actually make sense of the specific nature of the sentence and thus apply it constantly to irrelevant contexts.

The sentence reflects both the need to simplify ideological language and the drawbacks of oversimplification. The fact that the sheep cannot read or memorize the full Commandments is a metaphor for how less-educated members of a populace often cannot fully make sense of the political regime under which they live. In light of that divide, leaders must translate the tenets of the regime into increasingly simple language. The sheep's way of responding to the phrase—applying it randomly—shows the way those distilled slogans will rapidly shift contexts and be misappropriated when they are unleashed in the general populace.

Once more, the most essential part of Animalism is shown to be the opposition to humans: it does not concern the actual ways that animals should treat each other, but rather focuses on the enemy of "two legs bad." "Four legs good," pointedly, does not refer to whether a relative hierarchy exists between animals, and it even leaves open the chance that animals who stand on two legs could disrupt this binary. Thus the phrase showcases how the original commandments of Animalism become diluted, and how they are perverted in the process.

> "Comrades!" he cried. "You do not imagine, I hope, that we pigs are doing this in a spirit of selfishness and privilege? Many of us actually dislike milk and apples. Milk and apples (this has been proved by Science, comrades) contain substances absolutely necessary to the well-being of a pig. We pigs are brainworkers. The whole management and organization of this farm depend on us. Day and night we are watching over your welfare. It is for your sake that we drink that milk and eat those apples."

Related Characters: Squealer (speaker), Napoleon, Snowball

Related Themes:

Page Number: 35-36

Explanation and Analysis

Squealer gives this speech to defend the way the pigs have hoarded milk and apples away from the other animals. He claims that they need the nutrients from the foodstuffs to properly run the farm and thus best serve the needs of others.

This speech represents a critical turning point in the novel: whereas previously the pigs' subterfuge had remained secretive and unacknowledged, here they publicly admit to withholding resources from the other animals. Their explanation is that such unequal distributions actually will have overall positive effects on the animal society. In this way, they take advantage of an ambiguity in the idea of equality: if equality is defined based on social well-being, the thinking goes, then redistributing resources to the

intelligent pigs could theoretically create *more* equality by bettering the lives of all.

Squealer's flowery language also harnesses uncertainty and vagueness as a propaganda strategy. He uses the rhetorical question, "You do not imagine" to ridicule any potential criticism and summons the abstract idea of "Science" as an objective standard without offering any specific data. Squealer also claims that the pigs' supposedly selfish behavior is actually entirely selfless. In these ways, he becomes a parody of governmental speeches that justify the unfair distribution of resources to those in power.

Chapter 4 Quotes

"I have no wish to take life, not even human life," repeated Boxer, and his eyes were full of tears.

Related Characters: Boxer (speaker)

Related Themes:

Page Number: 43

Explanation and Analysis

During the Battle of the Cowshed, Boxer believes that he has killed a stable boy. After the animals finish the battle, Boxer mourns the fact that he has unintentionally become a murderer. Boxer's sadness is indicative of both a striking moral compass and a naive relationship to his strength. He feels an intense ethical burden over killing the stable boy, and the fact that his reaction is motivated by emotion indicates that this wish to preserve all life is somehow innate to his identity. Orwell contrasts this quality with the more artificial Animalism system, which is based on harsh principles rather than emotional sensitivity to specific events.

Boxer's perspective also notably separates him from other interpretations of Animalism, which would require that animals kill humans. But while Boxer's ethical beliefs bring him into conflict with the Seven Commandments of Animalism, he remains unable to fully articulate the disparity. His role continues to be that of a powerful worker, committed to toiling ever more and to representing society. This laudable single-mindedness also leaves him blind to the way the pigs have taken advantage of his strength—not only to cultivate the farm, but also to go against Boxer's own moral wishes.

Chapter 5 Quotes

At this there was a terrible baying sound outside, and nine enormous dogs wearing brass-studded collars came bounding into the barn. They dashed straight for Snowball, who only sprang from his place just in time to escape their snapping jaws.

Related Characters: Napoleon, The Dogs, Snowball

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 52-53

Explanation and Analysis

After the animals agree to pursue Snowball's plan for the windmill, Napoleon unleashes his dog minions. They successfully oust Snowball and allow Napoleon to implement a tyrannical regime over the other animals.

The dogs, here, represent the use of military force by political leaders to dispose of each other. Napoleon has reared the dogs (i.e., built up a secret military) in case such an instance arrives, but he delays unleashing them until the population of animals goes against his own wishes. Orwell thus points out how military force can be harnessed in direct opposition to democratic or socialist principles of equality. It becomes a way for leaders with more military power but less social appeal to impose their whims on the world. The specific historical parallel here is how in the USSR, Stalin (represented by Napoleon) used force to overcome Trotsky (Snowball) after the two disagreed on the future of the country. Orwell stresses the irony of this action by showing just how clearly Napoleon's actions—attacking another animal—violate the rules of Animalism.

"No one believes more firmly than Comrade Napoleon that all animals are equal. He would be only too happy to let you make your decisions for yourselves. But sometimes you might make the wrong decisions, comrades, and then where should we be?"

Related Characters: Squealer (speaker), Napoleon

Related Themes:

Page Number: 55

Explanation and Analysis

Squealer offers these comments to shore up Napoleon's recent tyrannical actions against Snowball. He claims that power should be concentrated in the hands of fewer animals because others will inevitably make wrong decisions.

Once more, Squealer uses clever rhetorical tactics to convince the other less intelligent animals to give up their freedoms and rights. He first reiterates the central tenet of Animalism—"that all animals are equal"—which makes it seem that the later comments will not violate the principle, even if that is precisely what they do. His further comments rest on this idea that democratically chosen decisions may not, indeed, be preferable for the other animals and that they should therefore cede their rights to the supposedly smarter animals. The phrase "be only too happy" casts Napoleon as falsely willing to acquiesce, while the taunting rhetorical question "where should we be?" goads the audience. Orwell thus emphasizes the essential role of propaganda in maintaining control of a populace.

"Napoleon is always right."

Related Characters: Boxer (speaker), Napoleon

Related Themes:

Page Number: 56

Explanation and Analysis

Boxer makes this characteristically terse comment after listening to Squealer's defense of Napoleon. Instead of responding to the specific terms, however, he offers his universal adherence to the leader.

This line reiterates Boxer's role as a committed adherent to the political regime on the Animal Farm. He continues to deal in the absolute of "always right" even after evidence has been presented that would contradict that firm belief. Unable to take into account how Napoleon's military tactics conflict with his own anti-violent system of ethics, Boxer blindly reaffirms his belief in the leader of the moment. He thus symbolizes the unquestioning supporter of a totalitarian governmental system, one who is persuaded by propaganda and will believe in the system despite indications that it is no longer effective. As a result, he will go on to be used and victimized by the very state to which he has pledged his unyielding loyalty and for which he has worked so hard.

Chapter 6 Quotes

"Comrades, do you know who is responsible for this? Do you know the enemy who has come in the night and overthrown our windmill? SNOWBALL!"

Related Characters: Napoleon (speaker), Snowball

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 69-70

Explanation and Analysis

After the half-finished windmill is destroyed by a storm, Napoleon investigates the rubble. He suddenly concludes, here, that Snowball destroyed it in an act of political subterfuge.

By blaming Snowball, Napoleon is able to protect his own reputation and motivate the animals to work even harder at rebuilding the windmill. Whereas his authority could have potentially been challenged for having recommended bad practices, attributing the destruction to Snowball renders himself both immune to criticism and necessary for the future defense of his followers. Napoleon can use the idea of Snowball as a shadowy, nefarious figure to effectively instill fear into the animal populace.

This tactic notably parallels the motivation behind the animals' revolution in the first place: they blamed a single enemy, the humans, for all their hardships. Orwell thus points out how any given political regime will gather support by selecting such an adversary—whether it be false or accurate—and organizing popular support against that foe. Developing a culture of fear around an unseen or arbitrary enemy allows a group to justify its tactics and explain away any negative events as the result of those enemies' actions.

Chapter 7 Quotes

If a window was broken or a drain was blocked up, someone was certain to say that Snowball had come in the night and done it, and when the key of the store-shed was lost, the whole farm was convinced that Snowball had thrown it down the well. Curiously enough, they went on believing this even after the mislaid key was found under a sack of meal.

Related Characters: Squealer, Snowball

Related Themes:

Page Number: 78

Explanation and Analysis

As the conditions on Animal Farm continue to worsen, rumors spread through Squealer that Snowball is conducting an extensive campaign of sabotage against the farm. Here, all negative events are attributed to him, even in the face of direct evidence to the contrary.

Snowball here becomes less an actual agent and more of a social tool to unify the animals. That "someone was certain" to blame him indicates that the animals are not rationally responding to each negative event, but rather are immediately using Snowball as a stock response to the issue. This reaction indicates that Squealer's propaganda campaign has successfully reordered the way the animals think about the events on the farm. They have come to see these moments as the result of neither poor leadership nor chance occurrence, but rather due to a paranoid belief in foreign espionage.

The animals believe this theory even in the face of direct counter-evidence— for instance, when the location of the "mislaid key" clearly indicates that Snowball has not disposed of it in a well. Orwell thus makes a mockery of how willing citizens are to accept the fear mongering tactics of despotic regimes, such as that of the USSR. Once leadership decides on a single enemy, the populace is apt to reinterpret *all* events as the result of transgressions by that enemy.

> If she herself had had any picture of the future, it had been of a society of animals set free from hunger and the whip, all equal, each working according to his capacity, the strong protecting the weak [...] Instead - she did not know why - they had come to a time when no one dared speak his mind, when fierce, growling dogs roamed everywhere, and when you had to watch your comrades torn to pieces after confessing to shocking crimes.

Related Characters: Napoleon, The Dogs, Clover

Related Themes:

Page Number: 86-87

Explanation and Analysis

This passage describes Clover's disheartened response to the current state of Animal Farm. She observes that its present conditions are directly opposed to what she had envisioned during the earlier revolution.

Clover's observations reflect the disenchantment that many felt as the Soviet Union grew poorer and increasingly despotic. She points out the distance between the original image—"set free" and "all equal"—with the current reality of repression and violence. Unlike some of the other animals, who remain unable to compare these two things, Clover's memory allows her to reflect on the difference between ideal goal and pragmatic implementation. Yet the subtle addition "she did not know why" stresses how she still cannot locate the exact causes of the current state of terror. She may notice that conditions are bad, but she cannot tie that observation to Napoleon's behavior. Thus Clover represents an ultimately passive citizen, one who can note the occurrence of bad events but cannot make sense of why those events are indeed taking place.

> *"Animal Farm, Animal Farm,*
> *Never through me shalt thou come to harm!"*

Related Characters: Minimus (speaker)

Related Themes:

Page Number: 88

Explanation and Analysis

The pig Minimus composes this new song to replace the now-banned "Beasts of England." This choice represents the increasing crackdown on animal behavior and the turn away from the revolutionary ideas that were spoken of in the original song.

It is revealing, here, to consider exactly why the pigs would want to ban "Beast of England." Recall that the song represented the triumphs of the animals against the despotic human and promised, through that revolution, equality for all. Now that the pigs have taken on more and more human characteristics—and gathered increasing stores of power—they have actually become the hierarchical establishment that "Beasts of England" challenges. As a result, they fear the very revolutionary ideology that created Animal Farm to begin with and take it upon themselves to censor the information that the other animals receive.

Minimus's new song swaps out the idea of universal Animalism in order to doubly reaffirm the role of the state: "Animal Farm, Animal Farm." Ironically, it is through the state that the animals are supposed to be protected from

harm—when in fact the government is the main instrument of terror. Orwell points out the irony in much socialist propaganda, in which the promises of protection were actually used to create a state that violated the rights of the people. The fact that "Minimus" means "smallest" in Latin also speaks to the relative triviality of this song. Whereas "Beasts of England" aggrandized the feats of the animals, the new text downplays their relative merits, instead stressing how they should remain passive with respect to the state.

Chapter 8 Quotes

At the foot of the end wall of the big barn, where the Seven Commandments were written, there lay a ladder broken in two pieces. Squealer, temporarily stunned, was sprawling beside it, and near at hand there lay a lantern, a paint-brush, and an overturned pot of white paint. [...] None of the animals could form any idea as to what this meant, except old Benjamin, who nodded his muzzle with a knowing air, and seemed to understand, but would say nothing.

Related Characters: Squealer, Benjamin

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 108-109

Explanation and Analysis

After the pigs begin to consume alcohol, Squealer is discovered modifying the Commandments to sanction their behavior. Though most of the animals are unable to make sense of the event, the skeptic Benjamin is unsurprised by what he sees.

The novel has previously implied that the pigs were modifying the commandments, but here their actions become fully conspicuous: not only does Squealer reinterpret the laws with clever propaganda, but he also literally rewrites them to suit the whims of the pigs. What is more surprising about this passage, however, is how the animals are unable to make sense of the event. Orwell points out how, even when confronted with clear evidence of political malpractice, a populace will not necessarily be able to make sense of it or agree to do anything about it. Due perhaps to exhaustion, a lack of education, or simply fear, the animals are still unable to challenge the leaders. Benjamin's character might seem to offer a source of insight, for from the beginning, he has been skeptical and observant of the pigs' actions. Yet his passivity and unwillingness to share his opinions renders him fundamentally ineffective, thus pointing out that knowledge of corruption does not necessarily lead to changing it.

Chapter 9 Quotes

Besides, in those days they had been slaves and now they were free, and that made all the difference, as Squealer did not fail to point out.

Related Characters: Mr. Jones, Squealer

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 113

Explanation and Analysis

As the conditions deteriorate on Animal Farm, the pigs organize a series of celebrations. They aggrandize the supposed freedom of the animals from their previous human overlords.

This ironic sentence epitomizes the false story the pigs have told about Animal Farm's society. Their belief that things today are preferable to the past relies solely on the abstract idea of being "slaves" versus "free," rather than the actual conditions experienced by the animals. That this supposed distinction "made all the difference" implies that the animals are not considering other significant differences that may make their current lives equivalent to or worse than they were under the rule of Mr. Jones. And the addition of the clause "as Squealer did not fail to point out" reiterates how this belief is more a trick of rhetoric than an actual indication of content. The passage thus corroborates Orwell's presentation of the animals as unable to gain an objective viewpoint on their situation. Blinded by the pigs' rhetoric and crippled by weak memories, they continue to believe in the improvement of their society.

Chapter 10 Quotes

Somehow it seemed as though the farm had grown richer without making the animals themselves any richer—except, of course, for the pigs and the dogs.

Related Characters: The Dogs, Minimus, Squealer, Napoleon

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 129

Explanation and Analysis

The story has now jumped several years into the future, and the narrator observes how the relative wealth of the farm is distributed unevenly among the animals.

Introducing the phrase with the term "somehow" speaks to the incredulity and naïveté of the animals. Despite having witnessed the pigs' actions for many years, they remain unable to see exactly why wealth is being unfairly sequestered in their hands. Yet the "of course" stresses how this process is logical considering the story thus far, and how it is at least understood on some level by the animals. Orwell thus points out how the populace in such a fascist regime oscillates between recognition of and blindness to what is taking place. In particular, as time has gone by and few of the animals can recall a different form of society, the current political regime becomes normalized, and inequality fades into the "of course" of a natural order.

"Four legs good, two legs *better*!"

Related Characters: The Sheep (speaker), Squealer

Related Themes:

Page Number: 134

Explanation and Analysis

When the pigs begin walking on two legs, the sheep change their earlier stock phrase. Having been trained by Squealer, they replace "two legs bad" with "two legs better."

The extent and ease of the change to the phrase is remarkable. Whereas earlier acts of propaganda or commandment-revision simply altered phrases slightly, here the text has been entirely rewritten. Yet Squealer has maintained the sonic and rhythmic flow of the phrase, swapping in "better," which begins with the same "b" sound as "bad" and thus makes the change in the slogan more subtle. His action reiterates how the Animal Farm society is founded less on principles and more on a set of empty terms that can be manipulated at will. Unable to actually make sense of what they are saying, the sheep rapidly swap out the new phrase for the old one—and the other animals seem unable to resist the strategy. Orwell has now transformed the pigs into complete human-analogs, showing how after a revolution, the new leaders have a natural tendency to mimic old ones—and then to adjust their principles to slowly revert to the old power structure.

ALL ANIMALS ARE EQUAL, BUT SOME ANIMALS ARE MORE EQUAL THAN OTHERS.

Related Characters: Squealer, Napoleon, Clover, Benjamin

Related Themes:

Page Number: 134

Explanation and Analysis

When Benjamin recounts the Seven Commandments, he sees only this single statement. The pigs have evidently replaced the other principles with this one.

This law is a mockery of the term "equal," and it epitomizes perfectly how the pigs have manipulated the word throughout the text. Presumably, if all the animals are indeed equal, there would be no ability to form a hierarchy between different "types" of equalities. Yet the pigs' actions have relied on just this idea, for instance when they claimed that they needed more and better food in order to best help the other animals. The phrase makes explicit what they have been doing all along: manipulating language and ideology to suit their own ends.

Yet, once again, the strategy is effective instead of incriminating. Reducing a set of seven principles to just a single one also shows how simplification can be an instrument of these despotic regimes. Distilling a more complex set of ideas into a single, highly ambiguous formulation gives the pigs great freedom to interpret the laws as they wish. They can both maintain the supposed ideology of the revolution—"All animals are equal"—and allow for corruption and the preferential position of being "more equal than others." Orwell thus stresses how simplified phrases and positions are critical instruments of despotic regimes—and how any equal society has a natural tendency to reorganize itself such that some become "more equal" than others.

The creatures outside looked from pig to man, and from man to pig, and from pig to man again; but already it was impossible to say which was which.

Related Characters: Mr. Pilkington, Squealer, Napoleon, Clover

Related Themes:

Page Number: 141

Explanation and Analysis

In the novel's closing passage, the pigs are seen playing cards with neighboring farmers. When they squabble over cheating, the narrator reflects how the two species are essentially indistinguishable.

These lines confirm the way the pigs have slowly come to mimic the oppressors they overthrew in the beginning of the book. Whereas before, the animals seemed unaware of this parallel, here they finally see it manifested before them. That the pigs and men are playing poker is no symbolic accident: it stresses their selfish behavior as authority figures and the way they play fast and loose with resources in a way that harms normal citizens and animals. They become, thus, representations of world leaders casually throwing around wealth and lives stolen from others. It is notable, too, that this reflection is caused by the pigs and humans fighting over cheating: what makes the pigs finally akin to humans is not their liaisons or trade deals, nor the way they consume alcohol or sleep in beds, but rather the way they persist in deceiving each other even when they have no need. Orwell implies that the fundamental character of leader-regimes like that of the USSR is a pervasive and unending greed, even once one has acquired a position of wealth and power.

SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

The owner of Manor Farm, Mr. Jones, locks his henhouses for the evening—but he's too drunk to remember to shut everything before he goes to bed. As soon as the lights are off in the farmhouse, the animals all stir and make their way to the big barn, where the old boar, Old Major, wants to address everyone. Old Major lies on a raised platform. The three dogs and all the pigs come in first and settle right in front of the platform. The hens and pigeons perch in windows and the rafters; the sheep and cows settle behind the pigs; and Boxer and Clover, the carthorses, lie down in the back. Clover settles a brood of orphaned ducklings in the crook of her leg as the cantankerous old donkey, Benjamin, and the goat Muriel join the horses.

To begin with, all the animals exist under Mr. Jones's somewhat totalitarian regime, and therefore are on somewhat equal footing at this point. However, pay attention to the way in which the animals arrange themselves. That the pigs and the dogs go to the front naturally suggests that they already hold an important place on the farm, while the fact that a pig is giving this speech is another indication that these two species are somehow superior to the others. In this sense, this represents the beginnings of class distinctions on the farm.

The foolish mare Mollie shakes her braided and beribboned mane while she munches sugar, and the cat finds the warmest spot between Boxer and Clover. The cat doesn't listen to Old Major at all. Seeing that everyone but old Moses, the tame raven, is present, Old Major begins. He addresses everyone as "comrades" and announces that he's going to die soon but wants to share his wisdom and a dream he had with everyone before he does. He says that the nature of their lives is horrendous: they only get enough food to keep them going, and once they're no longer useful, Mr. Jones kills them. Animals, he insists, are slaves, though they don't have to be. Manor Farm would support many animals comfortably if only humans didn't steal the products of their labor. If they remove man, they won't be hungry or overworked.

Mollie and the cat are representative of the middle classes who, prior to the Bolshevik Revolution in 1917, were already pretty comfortable with their lot in life, as represented by Mollie's ability to obtain sugar and the cat's beeline for the best, warmest spot and lack of interest in what happens. Everything that Old Major says paints a horrific picture of what life is like on the farm. His speech as a whole mirrors The Communist Manifesto by Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, in that the problem is the ruling class and that the lower classes are allowing themselves to be subjugated.

Old Major insists that humans are the only creatures who consume without producing anything, like milk or eggs. He asks the animals to consider all they've given up, from gallons of milk to hundreds of eggs to Clover's four foals, gone forever. Old Major points out that Mr. Jones butchers pigs, will someday sell Boxer to the glue factory when he can't work, and drowns dogs when they get too old. Man, Old Major suggests, is the root of all evil. Getting rid of men through rebellion would free the animals, and Old Major insists that the rebellion will come in due course. He warns everyone that they can't entertain the idea that humans and animals have common interests; they must believe that all men are enemies and all animals are comrades.

Again, the idea that humans are the only creatures who don't produce anything is a direct parallel to The Communist Manifesto, as Marx proposes that the real evil is that people don't get to enjoy the fruits of their own labor—rather, they make chairs or farm for others who then profit off of their labor. Notice that Old Major uses absolutes when he warns the animals that they cannot ever think that animals and humans might be able to work together. This means that if the animals take this seriously, there will be little room for nuance.

Suddenly, the dogs catch sight of four rats listening in and chases them back to their holes. Old Major calls for silence and insists that they must vote on whether wild animals are enemies or comrades. The assembly votes overwhelmingly in favor of wild animals being comrades. Only the cat and the dogs vote no, but some discover later that the cat voted on both sides. Solemnly, Old Major insists again that they can't forget that man is their enemy, but they also can't ever come to resemble man by drinking alcohol, sleeping in beds, or trading. He also says that animals cannot terrorize each other, as they're all equal.

Despite the absolutist language Old Major uses, it's important to keep in mind his warning that once the animals achieve a revolution, they cannot come to resemble those who once oppressed them. With this, he alludes to the idea that revolution and rebellion are, to a degree, cyclical and it's normal for those who seize power to want to have all of it—while also warning everyone to be on the lookout for corruption.

Old Major explains that he's going to teach everyone a song that his mother taught him part of long ago. It's called "Beasts of England" and it speaks of a "golden future time" in which animals will be free from human tyranny. All the animals, both the highly intelligent and the less intelligent, learn it quickly and they sing it all together five times through. They only stop when Mr. Jones shoots his gun into the side of the barn, breaking up the meeting.

"Beasts of England" represents the unifying power of language: every animal, no matter how smart, can learn it, rally around it, and take heart in its revolutionary content. However, note that it idealizes the coming revolution, which leaves little room for the realities of human (or animal) nature to complicate things.

CHAPTER 2

Old Major dies three nights later, in early March. Over the next three months, his ideas capture the imaginations of the more intelligent animals on Manor Farm, specifically the pigs. Two young boars, Napoleon and Snowball, see that they must prepare for the promised rebellion. With a small fat pig named Squealer, who is a brilliant orator and can convince listeners of anything, they hold secret meetings and develop Old Major's teachings into a system they call Animalism. They try to explain the theory to others, but it's slow going. Many animals suggest they owe loyalty to Mr. Jones and others point out that they'll starve without Mr. Jones to feed them. Others insist simply that they don't need to care about what might happen long after they're dead.

The differences between how the pigs begin to think about the revolution and how the other animals think about the revolution again start to show how class will develop on the farm. The pigs are already becoming part of an intellectual class concerned with abstract ideas and education, while the concerns of the masses—or in this case, the lower classes—are mostly concerned with making it through the day and don't have the energy to consider the possibility that things will ever get better.

Mollie asks the silliest questions, such as if there will be sugar after the rebellion and if she'll still be able to wear ribbons in her mane. Snowball patiently tries to impress upon her that she doesn't need sugar and that the ribbons are a badge of slavery, but Mollie seems unconvinced. The pigs also have issues with the tame raven Moses. Though he doesn't work and therefore isn't well-liked, he also tells tales about a place called Sugarcandy Mountain, a beautiful place where animals go when they die. Many animals believe in Sugarcandy Mountain, and the pigs work hard to convince those believers otherwise. Boxer and Clover, however, prove to be the pigs' best disciples. They're not incredibly intelligent, but they distill the pigs' ideas into simple arguments that they share with the other animals.

As a parallel to the comfortable middle class, Mollie's main concern is whether she'll be able to maintain her comparatively decadent lifestyle after the rebellion—a lifestyle that Snowball suggests is indicative of Mollie having bought into the idea that being "enslaved" by the upper classes and trying to move up is totally fine. Moses, meanwhile, is a parallel to organized religion, which in the pigs' mind distracts people from thinking about what truly matters—the rebellion in this life, not heaven in the next one (as represented by Sugarcandy Mountain).

The rebellion arrives much earlier and happens much more easily than anyone expected. Mr. Jones has, in the last few years, begun drinking more, so he neglects his animals and property. In June, when the hay is almost ready to cut, Mr. Jones goes to Willingdon, gets extremely drunk, and is gone for a full 24 hours. His lazy farmhands hunt rabbits and don't feed the animals, and when Mr. Jones gets back, he falls right back to sleep. The hungry animals snap, break down the door of the store shed, and eat. Mr. Jones wakes up and leads his farmhands in whipping the animals, but the animals revolt and turn on the men. Terrified, the humans race down the drive, and Mrs. Jones packs a bag and slips out a back way. The animals slam the gate behind Mr. Jones.

One of the most important things to note here is that the rebellion happens when animals use their physical strength as one to overthrow their leader, something that, unfortunately for those in the lower classes, the animals will go on to forget. This event as a whole is a parallel to the Bolshevik Revolution, in which the Red Army—as well as Tsar Nicholas's own guards—turned on him and ousted him quickly. As in the novel, the revolution grew out of dissatisfaction with the way Tsar Nicholas was running the country.



The animals first gallop gleefully around the farm and then destroy evidence of Mr. Jones's power. They throw bits, dog chains, and knives down the well, and they burn halters and whips. Snowball even throws the horses' mane and tail ribbons into the fire, insisting that ribbons are clothes and the mark of humans. Animals, he suggests, should go naked. At this, Boxer throws the straw hat he wears in the summer to protect his ears from flies on the fire. Napoleon serves everyone a double ration, and the animals sing "Beasts of England" seven times and sleep well.

Singing "Beasts of England" here again allows the animals to connect through language. At this point, the song likely has more meaning for more animals, since they now have, in theory, reached the "golden time" the song speaks of. Boxer's choice to throw his very useful straw hat on the fire again shows how absolutist the ideology guiding this revolution is, as there's no room for nuance and the possibility that purely useful things should be able to remain.



In the morning, the animals all rush to the top of a hill to gaze upon the farm. They inspect every building and pasture, ending with the farmhouse. Napoleon and Snowball lead the animals into the house for a tour. They're in awe of the luxury until they realize Mollie is missing, but they find her playing with Mrs. Jones's hair ribbons and reprimand her. The animals agree to maintain the farmhouse as a museum; no animal should live there. After breakfast, Snowball and Napoleon call everyone together for an announcement. They reveal that the pigs have been teaching themselves to read and write over the past few months. Everyone watches as Snowball covers up "Manor Farm" on the gate with "Animal Farm."

The farmhouse itself is a symbol of decadence and of totalitarian rule, as it contains all the fruits of Mr. Jones's illegitimately or immorally amassed wealth. The proposal to make it a museum, meanwhile, will in theory offer the animals a touchstone of what not to do, thereby saving them from corruption. The revelation that the pigs taught themselves to read and write throws a wrench in things, as it means that they'll be more powerful than the other illiterate animals. Renaming the farm is only the first instance of the pigs literally rewriting history.



Then, at the big barn, the pigs explain that they've come up with the Seven Commandments, which convey the ideals of Animalism. Snowball climbs a ladder and paints the rules on the side of the barn. They read that anyone on two legs is an enemy, while anyone on four legs or with wings is a friend. Animals shouldn't wear clothes, sleep in a bed, drink alcohol, or kill other animals. The final rule is that all animals are equal. Snowball reads it aloud for everyone and then calls everyone for the hay harvest. The cows protest, as they haven't been milked. The animals wonder what to do with the milk, but Napoleon gallantly tells everyone not to worry about it. When the animals return that evening from the hay fields, the buckets of milk are gone.

The Seven Commandments encapsulate the idealistic nature of the rebellion as, in theory at least, they set out the groundwork for the animals to celebrate themselves. Vilifying everything that makes humans human, however, leaves little room for the animals to advance, given that the novel has already laid out the expectation that as individuals become more powerful (as through literacy, for one), they effectively become more human. The missing milk is an early clue, too, that this revolution isn't as rosy as it might seem at first.



CHAPTER 3

Every animal, down to the ducks and the hens, works hard to bring the hay in. The pigs are clever enough to figure out how to do this without tools that involve standing on two legs, while Boxer and Clover know the intricacies of bringing hay in. Because the pigs are so intelligent, they don't actually work and instead assume leadership positions. It takes the animals less than time than it ever did Mr. Jones to bring in the hay, and the harvest is bigger than it's ever been. Throughout the summer, things work perfectly. The animals are thrilled to eat food that they produced for themselves and not have to share it with humans.

Though it seems like everything is going smoothly, note that the pigs are already elevating themselves above the rest of the animals by assuming leadership positions rather than laboring physically. This again is an indicator that class divisions are developing on Animal Farm, and that the pigs are the ones who will end up assuming privileged, upper-class roles in this society.

Some things prove difficult, such as threshing the corn without a threshing machine, but the pigs are clever enough to figure it out and Boxer is strong enough to pull them through. Everyone admires Boxer, as he seems as strong as three horses and even gets up 30 minutes earlier than everyone else to labor where he's needed most. His motto becomes, "I will work harder!" All the animals work as hard as they can, save for Mollie and the cat. Mollie struggles to rise in the morning and often leaves work early because of stones in her hooves, while the cat disappears during work time and shows up for meals with excellent excuses. Benjamin seems unchanged since the rebellion. He cryptically repeats that donkeys live a long time and that no one else has seen a dead donkey when asked if life is better without Mr. Jones.

Boxer is a representation of male peasants in the USSR. The success of Animal Farm—which represents the Soviet Union—rests on these peasants performing as much labor as possible, something that Boxer throws himself into with gusto. His personal motto suggests, however, that he's overly idealistic and is putting the ideals of the revolution above his own self-interest in a way that, in the end, won't serve him. Meanwhile, Benjamin broadly represents intellectuals who, the novel suggests, could see what was going to come—his cryptic answers suggest that he's aware that revolutions happen on a cycle, and that the farm will inevitably find itself right back where it started.

On Animal Farm, there's no work on Sundays. After a late breakfast, the animals hoist a flag that Snowball painted with a white hoof and horn on a green field. The animals then attend a meeting in the big barn, where they discuss the work for the week ahead and put forth resolutions for debate. The pigs are the only ones who propose resolutions and Napoleon and Snowball are the most active debaters. However, they never seem to be able to agree on anything. The meeting ends with a round of "Beasts of England."

On paper, the system that the animals work out should work for everyone. In theory, everyone gets a say in what happens. However, it's still telling that the pigs are the only ones who ever speak up. They do this because of their education and their rising class status, while the animals' willingness to go along with this suggests that they'll be easily manipulated into giving up their voices in the future.

The pigs adopt the harness room as their headquarters and study books from the farmhouse in the evenings. Snowball organizes committees such as the Egg Production Committee for the hens and the Whiter Wool Movement for the sheep, but these projects fail. His only success is with the reading and writing classes—every animal is somewhat literate by fall. The dogs learn to read well, but only read the Seven Commandments. Muriel learns to read and reads newspapers out loud, while Benjamin is completely literate but refuses to read. Clover learns the whole alphabet but cannot read words, while Boxer learns the first four letters and nothing more. Mollie, meanwhile, learns only to spell her name.

The different animals' varying degrees of literacy, as well as what they choose to read once literate, speak to how class will continue to develop thanks to language. The dogs' choice to read only the Seven Commandments suggests that they'll become loyal to the cause and are uninterested in truly educating themselves, while Muriel's willingness to read newspapers suggests an interest in the outside world—and possibly, in other ideas of how life should be.

The less intelligent animals, such as the sheep, learn only the letter A and struggle to memorize the Seven Commandments. Snowball reduces them to the maxim "Four legs good, two legs bad." At first, this goes over poorly with the birds, who have only two legs, but Snowball explains to them that what makes humans evil is their hands—and birds don't have hands. Everyone else also learns the maxim and the sheep take to repeating it for hours on end.

Coming up with this maxim illustrates how easy it can be to distill somewhat complex ideas into an easily digestible, easily repeatable phrase that lacks nuance. It's impossible to tell, from the phrase, that Snowball's explanation should actually be correct—but because of his grasp of language, he can essentially make the maxim mean whatever he wants it to.



Napoleon takes an interest in the nine puppies born to the dogs, which arrive soon after the hay harvest. He takes them to educate himself, believing that it's more important to educate the young than teach everyone else to read. The other animals soon forget about the puppies, but they do discover that the missing milk ends up in the pigs' mash. The pigs insist that they should get all the fallen apples, which the other animals assumed would be divided evenly. Squealer makes the case that the pigs are "brainworkers" and therefore need the milk and apples in order to care for everyone else—if they don't get them, Mr. Jones will come back. The animals see his point and say nothing when the main crop of apples also goes to the pigs.

Notice that when Napoleon insists on educating the young, the only "young" he seems truly interested in educating are the puppies—that is, children of a literate, somewhat powerful class, not the offspring of any of the cows, sheep, or chickens. Doing this allows Napoleon to start to dictate who's worthy of education and through doing so, dictate who's able to move up the class system and gain power. Squealer's insistence that the pigs need the milk and apples because of their work shows that the pigs are already beginning to take advantage of the system they've set up.



CHAPTER 4

By late summer, half of England knows about Animal Farm. Snowball and Napoleon send out pigeons to spread the word to other animals and teach them "Beasts of England," while Mr. Jones sits in the bar in Willingdon and complains about his fate. The other farmers sympathize but refuse to help—they all want to make his misfortune work for them. Luckily for the animals, the owners of the two neighboring farms hate each other. The gentlemanly Mr. Pilkington owns Foxwood, an overgrown and old-fashioned farm on one side, while the shrewd Mr. Frederick owns Pinchfield on the other side. They hate each other too much to agree on anything, even if it's in their best interests. Despite this, they're terrified of what happened on Animal Farm. Mr. Pilkington and Mr. Frederick try to keep their animals in the dark about what happened there and insist on continuing to call it Manor Farm.

The other farmers' desire to make Mr. Jones's misfortune work in their best interests suggests that when it comes to leaders like these farmers, it's natural for them to want to amass as much power as possible with little regard for how their power might negatively affect those below them—in this case, the animals all over the country. Mr. Pilkington and Mr. Frederick's terror at what happened on Animal Farm shows that it's possible for rebellion like what happened there to happen anywhere; in essence, these leaders are aware that they're in a precarious and easily-toppled position.



None of the rumors that Mr. Frederick or Mr. Pilkington spread about Animal Farm, however, land well with their animals. Over the next year, animals that were once easygoing begin to act out and the humans cannot stop their animals from singing "Beasts of England." In October, pigeons arrive with the news that Mr. Jones and men from Foxwood and Pinchfield are coming up the driveway to retake the farm. Mr. Jones has a gun. Snowball is prepared and sends animals to their posts. First, the pigeons and geese dive bomb and harass the men. Then, Muriel, Benjamin, and the sheep converge to butt and kick them. The men are too strong, so at Snowball's signal, the animals race into the barnyard.

The miniature rebellions on the part of the other farmers' animals speaks again to the power of language to unify people around a common cause, especially since the rebellious atmosphere is spreading due to "Beasts of England." At this point, it still looks hopeful that the revolution might go in a good direction and avoid too much corruption. The attack by the men on Animal Farm mirrors the Russian Civil War, which took place not long after Tsar Nicholas was forced out.



To the men this looks like a retreat, so they rush after the animals. In the yard, however, the horses, cows, and pigs charge. Mr. Jones shoots at Snowball, but only grazes his back. Snowball flattens Mr. Jones as Boxer strikes at men with his front hooves. Even the cat leaps on a man, and the animals send the men racing for the main gate. Boxer, however, mournfully paws at a stable boy who appears to be dead and insists that he didn't mean to kill anyone. Snowball insists that Boxer was right to kill the boy; he's better off dead.

Though the cat does participate in this battle, it's implied that there's little risk to the cat. In this sense, it becomes clear that the cat is only interested in supporting the revolution if the revolution is in line with what it wants anyway. Snowball's advice to Boxer shows how it's possible for leaders to corrupt people's strength and use it for their own personal gain, ethical or not.

The animals realize that Mollie is missing and find her hiding in her stall, terrified of the gun. When the animals return to the barnyard, they discover that the stable boy wasn't dead and ran off. Nerves give way to excitement and a celebration of their victory. They run up the flag, sing "Beasts of England," and they bury the one sheep who died in the battle. Snowball gives a speech emphasizing that animals must be willing to die for Animal Farm, and the animals create the honor of "Animal Hero, First Class," which they give to Snowball. They also give the deceased sheep the honor of "Animal Hero, Second Class." Together, the animals decide to call this conflict the Battle of the Cowshed, and when they find Mr. Jones's gun, they decide to set it up and fire it twice per year on the anniversaries of the battle and the rebellion.

Unlike the cat, whose reasons and motives are somewhat less clear, it's obvious to Mollie that participating in the battle would put her at risk of losing out on ribbons and sugar, so she's not going to participate. Snowball's speech in its entirety begins to illustrate how he's starting to train the lower classes to be entirely loyal to the state—and even willing to die for it. Establishing holidays commemorating the revolution and the Battle of Cowshed create built-in times for Snowball to remind the animals of their duty to the state, as well as their pride in what they've created.

CHAPTER 5

As winter approaches, Mollie becomes more difficult to deal with. She's often late for work and complains, but she spends most of her time gazing at her reflection in the drinking pool. One day, Clover takes Mollie aside and quietly asks if she really saw Mollie allowing a man from Foxwood to pet her nose. Mollie denies this accusation, but she can't look Clover in the eye. Secretly, Clover goes to Mollie's stall and discovers a stash of sugar and ribbons. Mollie disappears, and after a few weeks, pigeons report that they've seen her in Willingdon happily pulling a dogcart and wearing ribbons.

Mollie leaving is a parallel to how many in the middle class simply left the USSR while they still could. If Snowball or Napoleon were to assess her motivations and the implications of her leaving, they'd likely say that Mollie has bought into the narrative that she needs to strive to become a member of the ruling class in order to leave a successful life—something that Animalism tries to discount by insisting that class itself is silly. This is hypocritical, of course, as the pigs are becoming their own upper class.

The weather becomes bitterly cold in January, so the animals can't do anything in the fields. They attend many meetings and the pigs plan out the coming season, something the animals accept as natural given how intelligent the pigs are. The other animals still get to ratify the pigs' decisions, however. The system would be perfect, except that Snowball and Napoleon disagree on every point. Snowball is better at speaking and convincing animals at meetings, but Napoleon is better at convincing animals individually between meetings. He's especially successful with the sheep, who begin bleating "Four legs good, two legs bad" in the middle of meetings—and especially in the middle of Snowball's speeches.

Again, when the animals accept outright that the pigs should make decisions because they're smarter, it shows how the uneducated lower classes essentially give away a lot of their power by not recognizing their own right to an opinion—or, for that matter, their ability to voice it. The relationship between Snowball and Napoleon mirrors that between Trotsky and Stalin, especially in the way the two were able to connect (or not) with potential supporters.

Snowball speaks often about farming theory and develops complicated schemes. Napoleon comes up with no ideas of his own, but quietly insists that Snowball's schemes are silly. Their biggest dispute, however, is over the **windmill**. Snowball proposes that they build one on the highest point on the farm, as it would be able to give the farm electricity, which would then allow the animals to enjoy leisure time while machines work for them. It takes Snowball a few weeks to develop the plans in chalk on the smooth floor of a shed. The other animals can't make sense of the drawing, but it looks impressive, so everyone visits daily—except for Napoleon. Napoleon does visit once, contemplates the plans, and then urinates on them.

Trotsky had grand plans to modernize the USSR and bring it into the modern world, plans symbolized by the windmill. Note that with Snowball, he makes it clear that modernization like this is actually in line with the ideals of the revolution in that all the animals will benefit from putting in this work on the front end. They'll all enjoy electricity and the ensuing leisure time. This suggests that in an ideal situation, there would be fewer class distinctions, since leisure time is a mark of being higher-class—one can only enjoy leisure time if they don't have to work all the time.



Snowball is upfront that building the **windmill** will be difficult. They'll have to carry stone, build walls, and somehow procure cables, but he insists they can do it in a year. After this, he says, the animals will only have to work three days per week. Napoleon argues that they need to increase their food production and that focusing on the windmill will lead to starvation. The farm is deeply divided over the windmill, but the only animal who doesn't take a side is Benjamin. He insists that no matter what happens, life will continue to be awful.

Napoleon in particular plays to the concerns of the lowest, most uneducated classes by insisting that the windmill is a pipe dream that will leave them all in dire hunger. This begins to create an environment of fear, as many animals are probably starting to fear that if this windmill idea goes through, their reasonably happy lives will disappear instantly.



The other question that occupies the animals is that of the farm's defense, as they all recognize that their conflict with humans isn't over—they expect humans to try to reinstate Mr. Jones, especially since news of the animals' victory at the Battle of the Cowshed has spread. Napoleon insists they must train the animals to use firearms, while Snowball proposes they send out more pigeons to stir up revolution elsewhere. The other animals can't make up their minds and agree with whoever's talking at any given time.

Snowball makes the case here that if Animal Farm is able to incite rebellion all over England, they'll effectively get rid of all the people who might want to stop them—and then, there will be no reason to fight, since there's no one to fight in the first place. This represents a more idealistic take on things, as it holds that rebellion like this is always good and will always end well, if only the rebellion keeps going.



Snowball finishes his plans for the **windmill** and brings it to a vote at the Sunday meeting. He makes his case logically. Napoleon then stands and says only that the windmill is nonsense, and nobody should vote for it. In response, Snowball jumps up, shushes the sheep, and passionately explains why they need the windmill. His passion wins over the animals as he talks about how electricity can operate farming machinery, as well as equip stalls with lights, hot and cold water, and heat. Just as everyone seems decided, Napoleon stands, looks at Snowball, and whimpers oddly. Suddenly, nine ferocious dogs bound into the barn and chase Snowball all the way through a hedge. The animals realize that these dogs are the nine puppies Napoleon educated.

The events in this passage make it clear that while it's possible to use language persuasively to bring someone to one's side, what will win in the end is brute strength and fear, as represented by the nine attack dogs. Napoleon doesn't have to say anything, he just has to make it clear that anyone who agrees with Snowball's rhetoric will be chased down and possibly killed. Removing Snowball also means that Napoleon has a clear path to declaring himself leader, which will allow him to turn Animal Farm into a terrifying totalitarian state.



Napoleon stands on the raised platform, surrounded by the dogs. The other animals notice that these dogs wag their tails at Napoleon just like other dogs used to wag at Mr. Jones. Napoleon announces that there will be no more Sunday meetings, as they're unnecessary and waste time. Farm policy will be decided by a special pig committee that he oversees, and the committee will convey their decisions to the others when they all sing "Beasts of England." There will be no more debates. The other animals, even Boxer, are dismayed. Four young pigs squeal in disapproval, but the dogs growl and silence them. The sheep bleat "Four legs good, two legs bad!" for 15 minutes.

Napoleon's announcements make it clear to the reader, if not entirely to the animals, that no one else will have any power in his state: he oversees the pig committee, after all, which means that he can still squash ideas that he doesn't like. The fact that the young pigs' disapproval is so quickly silenced by the dogs again shows the power of brute force and fear over language and illustrates how leaders like Napoleon shut down open communication in order to take power.



Later, Squealer makes the rounds to explain the new rules. He points out that Napoleon is sacrificing himself by taking on the difficult job of leadership, and he must do so because the other animals might make the wrong decisions. Squealer asks where they'd be if they'd followed Snowball, but someone points out that Snowball fought bravely at the Battle of the Cowshed. Squealer insists that bravery isn't as important as loyalty or obedience and implies that Snowball's role in the battle was exaggerated. He reminds everyone again that if they're not disciplined, Mr. Jones will return. This convinces the animals entirely—anything that might help Mr. Jones must stop. Boxer declares that if Napoleon says it, it must be right.

Using Squealer like this essentially allows Napoleon to employ a good cop, bad cop strategy, as he terrified the animals during the meeting—but now, Squealer can make everything okay by "explaining" it to everyone. However, Squealer is clearly on Napoleon's side, as he insists that the other animals aren't capable of making good decisions. Specifically, spreading misinformation about Snowball allows Napoleon to make the case that he himself is the only one the animals can trust.



Winter turns into spring and the plowing begins. Every Sunday, the animals gather in the barn to get their orders for the week. Napoleon disinters Old Major's skull and asks everyone to walk past it reverently, while during meetings, the animals sit separated. Napoleon, Squealer, and a pig named Minimus sit together surrounded by the nine dogs, while the other pigs sit behind them. The rest of the animals sit in the body of the barn, looking at the pigs. Three weeks after Snowball's departure, Napoleon announces that they'll build the **windmill**. It will take two years and will require everyone's rations to be reduced.

Digging up Old Major's skull is a nod to the fact that Stalin disinterred Lenin's skull and treated it in a similar manner. This has the effect of making the animals constantly declare loyalty and reverence to the state, as represented by both Napoleon and Old Major, the "father" of the revolution. The way the animals sit in the barn, however, shows clearly that there are major class divisions at play. The dogs and the pigs have all the power, while the others have little or none.



Later, Squealer explains privately that Napoleon never opposed the **windmill**—it had been his idea and Snowball stole his plans. Napoleon only appeared to oppose the windmill to get rid of Snowball, whom he declares is dangerous and a bad influence. Squealer says that this is called "tactics," a word the other animals don't understand. Squealer is persuasive and has three dogs with him, so the animals don't ask questions.

When Squealer insists on calling Napoleon's scheming "tactics," a word the other animals don't know, it shows how he's beginning to use language to make himself seem smart and competent. But really, using language like this is just a way to scare the other animals and impress upon them how unintelligent he thinks they are.



CHAPTER 6

The animals work like slaves that year, but they're happy knowing that humans won't profit from their efforts. They work 60-hour weeks through the summer, and in August, Napoleon announces that they'll work on Sunday afternoons. This is voluntary, but animals who don't work Sundays will see reduced rations. The harvest is less successful this year and mishaps mean that the animals missed planting certain crops. The winter is guaranteed to be difficult.

This work on Sunday is clearly voluntary in name only, but because the other animals are so poorly educated and devoted to the cause, they can't parse out that voluntary doesn't actually mean anything here. Further, by focusing on the idea that humans won't profit from their work, the pigs can instead direct attention to the cause.

Construction on the **windmill** proves difficult as well. There's a quarry on the farm and a stash of other building materials, but the animals cannot break the rocks in the quarry without standing on their hind legs. After a few weeks, the animals begin hauling huge boulders to the top of the quarry and toppling them over the edge to shatter. The horses, sheep, Muriel, and Benjamin all haul stone to the site of the windmill. The process is exhausting. Boxer seems stronger than ever; he singlehandedly keeps the other animals from sliding back down the hill, begins getting up 45 minutes before everyone else to work, and carries loads of stone to the windmill alone. He ignores Clover's warnings to not strain himself.

When Boxer throws himself into the windmill project, it shows how thoroughly hoodwinked he is into thinking that he must sacrifice his own wellbeing for the wellbeing of the state—in other words, he's being encouraged to put national interest above his own, with results that the novel shows later are disastrous. That Boxer is so instrumental to this process, however, means that he looks like the ideal worker to other animals, who will likely try to emulate his actions.

The summer is reasonable for the animals. They don't have more food than they had under Mr. Jones, but they don't have less. The animals find that their methods of performing tasks are more efficient than human methods, and since the animals don't steal, they don't have to worry about maintaining fences and hedges. Despite all of this, late in the summer, the animals realize they need things like oil, nails, dog biscuits, and horseshoes. Later, they'll need tools, machinery, and seeds. Nobody knows how to get these things. One Sunday morning, Napoleon announces that Animal Farm will trade with the neighboring farms for the items they need. He's going to sell hay, wheat, and later, possibly eggs. Napoleon tells the hens that they should welcome this sacrifice.

The problem with an isolated state, the novel shows, is that it's impossible to create everything the state needs—thus, it will at some point become necessary to trade with others. Remember, however, that trading with neighboring farms would technically be forbidden by Old Major, as he made it very clear that the animals shouldn't have common interests with humans—and trading with them qualifies as such. This shows, then, how those ideals are consistently being corrupted as the needs of the state evolve.

The other animals are vaguely uneasy, as they remember the Seven Commandments stating that the animals shouldn't engage in trade or use money. The four young pigs speak up timidly, but the growling dogs silence them, and the sheep begin bleating "Four legs good, two legs bad!" Napoleon explains that the animals won't have to see much of the humans, as he's hired a solicitor named Mr. Whymper to deal with their affairs. After the meeting, Squealer sets everyone at ease by telling them privately that they must all be imagining that they can't engage in trade or use money, but that this was just a rumor started by Snowball. This is comforting for the animals to hear.

That Mr. Whymper wants to work for Napoleon and Animal Farm in the first place speaks to how much there is to gain by trading with a state like Animal Farm—he doesn't have to agree with any of its ideology in order to make a buck. By offering Mr. Whymper as a character, Orwell is able to critique the capitalist countries and individuals who got rich working with the USSR while ignoring the humanitarian atrocities. Blaming Snowball for the rumors, meanwhile, saves Napoleon from having to admit how hypocritical and corrupt he's becoming.

Mr. Whymper visits every Monday. The animals avoid him as much as possible, but they do pridefully watch Napoleon—on four legs—giving orders to a two-legged human. Other humans hate Animal Farm more than ever. They all believe that Animal Farm will go bankrupt at some point and that the **windmill** will fail—but against their will, they do develop a grudging respect for the animals' efficiency. They even begin to call it Animal Farm instead of Manor Farm. Rumors circulate that Napoleon is going to strike a deal with either Mr. Pilkington or Mr. Frederick, but not with both.

No matter how corrupt it may be for Napoleon to go against the Seven Commandments and hire Mr. Whymper, the fact remains that this is still a great public relations stunt for him to be seen in such a powerful position over a human. This has the effect of both boosting his reputation and prestige at home, as well as legitimizing him and Animal Farm in the eyes of the neighboring farms (as represented by the farmers' willingness to call the farm Animal Farm).

About this time, the pigs move into the farmhouse. Squealer circulates to assure everyone that it's not actually true that there was a resolution forbidding animals living inside—it's necessary, since the pigs are the brains of the farm, for them to have a quiet place to work. Referring to Napoleon as "Leader," Squealer also insists that it's more dignified for Napoleon to live in a house. Despite Squealer's insistences, some animals are disturbed to learn that the pigs eat in the kitchen and sleep in the beds. Boxer brushes this off, but Clover remembers that there was a rule against sleeping in beds. She asks Muriel to read her the commandment about beds to confirm, but it now reads that no animal will sleep in a bed with sheets. Clover doesn't remember this, but since it's in writing, she reasons that it must've always been this way.

Notice how Squealer frames his argument: the pigs are doing such important and necessary work for the farm that they don't just deserve, but truly need to live in the luxury of the farmhouse. Essentially, he insists that the pigs have to be corrupt and continue to improve the markers of their class by moving into the farmhouse, while the other animals remain hungry and living in the barns. When Clover decides everything is fine since the Commandment is in writing, it shows how easy it is to dupe an uneducated population with a poor memory—there's little understanding that just because something's in writing doesn't make it true.

Squealer, accompanied by a few dogs, passes by and helps put things in perspective for Clover. He points out that there never was a ruling against beds, since the word "bed" just refers to a place to sleep. Sheets are the problem, as they're a human invention. He assures Clover that the beds are only as comfortable as they need, and the pigs need their sleep since they need to keep their wits about them—if they don't, Mr. Jones might return. Knowing that Mr. Jones's return would be disastrous, the animals agree with Squealer and say nothing when days later, the pigs announce that they'll get up an hour later than everyone else.

Though Squealer is clearly splitting hairs here when he makes the distinction between beds and sheets, it feels impossible for Clover to push back at all because of the dogs. This shows how the fear and violence of an organization like the secret police (as represented by the dogs) allows powerful individuals to not have to make total sense in what they say, since what they say doesn't really matter that much. Because of the threat the dogs pose, Squealer could say almost anything, and nobody would object.

The animals are tired but happy when fall arrives. The stores of food for the winter are low after the sale of the hay and corn, but the **windmill** is almost halfway done and that bolsters their spirits. After the harvest, the animals dedicate themselves to building up the walls of the windmill. Boxer even spends hours at night working alone, and everyone except Benjamin spends their spare time admiring the structure. In November, however, a storm blows through. One morning, the animals wake and see that the windmill is in ruins. They run to the windmill and mournfully look at the fallen stone.

Pay attention to the fact that the animals are looking at a very lean winter, but yet, feel good because of the windmill. In this sense, the windmill comes to represent the state and how it refocuses attention onto its strengths to detract from very real problems within it. The storm destroying the windmill foreshadows what's to come: the windmill and the things it promises will be far more difficult to achieve.

Napoleon rushes to the site and snuffles around sharply. He suddenly stops and quietly says that Snowball came in at night and destroyed the **windmill**. Napoleon sentences Snowball to death and announces rewards for anyone who captures him. They discover pig prints leading to a hole in the hedge near Foxwood, and Napoleon declares that they're Snowball's. He cries that they must build all winter to show Snowball up.

Blaming the windmill's destruction on Snowball is a smart move for Napoleon, as it means that nobody is going to blame him for shoddy planning and not having a plan B. Further, he's then able to use this deflection to unite the animals against Snowball as a common enemy—and in doing so, comes up with a way to convince the animals to work even harder in support of the state.



CHAPTER 7

The winter is bitter and cold, but the animals toil on the **windmill** knowing that the humans will be thrilled if they don't finish on time. The humans spitefully pretend that the windmill fell because the walls were too thin, not because of Snowball. The animals know better, but they decide to build three-foot-thick walls just in case. Snow stops their progress for a while and the animals struggle to feel hopeful. Squealer gives many speeches on the dignity of labor, but the animals find more inspiration in Boxer. In January, rations are reduced when they discover that the potatoes went bad. The animals don't have much to eat and fear they'll starve to death, but they conceal this from the outside world. Napoleon devises strategies to make it seem to Mr. Whymper that there's lots of food.

Note that while the humans' spite comes from the fairly impartial omniscient narrator, it's likely more reflective of the effectiveness of Napoleon's campaign to cast all humans as the enemy, who of course will be thrilled to see the animals fail. That the animals find so much inspiration in Boxer also speaks to the success of Napoleon's attempt to, at least in terms of rhetoric, elevate the worker to a revered place in society. When Napoleon covers up the fact that they don't have food, it speaks also to the way that Napoleon feels he must look big and powerful to his enemies who may take advantage of his weakness.



Near the end of January, Napoleon recognizes that he has to find grain somewhere. He spends most of time in the farmhouse guarded by the fierce dogs. When he occasionally comes out, it's a ceremonious affair and dogs surround him. Squealer conducts the Sunday meetings. One morning, he announces that the hens will need to surrender their eggs: Napoleon entered into a contract to trade 400 eggs per week for enough grain to support them until summer. The hens are enraged, as they all plan to raise spring chicks, so they rebel. Hens lay eggs in the rafters at first, but Napoleon cuts their rations. The rebellion lasts five days, during which time nine hens die, before the hens give up. Napoleon insists that the nine hens died of disease.

Napoleon's current living conditions begin to situate him as a tried and true totalitarian leader: the constant guard of dogs suggests that he's somewhat paranoid that people are out to get him, while the ceremony surrounding his outings creates an even bigger cult of personality. The hens' rebellion can be seen as a parallel to a variety of rebellions that took place in the USSR in response to Stalin's Five Year Plans. These included rebellions by sailors and farmers, specifically those farmers who were victims of the Holodomor genocide in Ukraine (Stalin cut off their food, resulting in millions of deaths).



Rumors circulate that Snowball is hiding at Foxwood or Pinchfield, while Napoleon's relationships with both farms improve. Animal Farm has a pile of timber that Mr. Whymper suggests selling, and both Mr. Pilkington and Mr. Frederick want to buy it. Napoleon deliberates in his decision to sell, and whenever it seems he's close to selling to one farmer, rumors fly that Snowball is on that farmer's farm and he changes his mind. Early in the spring, the animals discover with horror that Snowball has been sneaking onto the farm. He supposedly comes in nightly to trample eggs and steal, and the animals begin to blame everything wrong or upset on Snowball. This continues even when the animals find the key to the store-shed (which Snowball supposedly threw down a well) under a sack of meal.

In the years preceding World War II, Stalin flirted with making deals with both the Allies (Mr. Pilkington) and with Hitler (Mr. Frederick). This is symbolized in the novel by the sale of the timber, which (in theory, at least), would improve relations with whomever Napoleon chooses to sell to. Continuing to vilify Snowball continues to mean that Napoleon can essentially do whatever he wants and blame bad things on someone else. It becomes apparent that all of these bad things are staged when the animals find the key that supposedly went down a well under the sack—a sign of corruption and an attempt to manipulate the population.



Napoleon announces an investigation into Snowball's activities. He and his dogs tour the farm, finding evidence of Snowball's scent everywhere. This frightens everyone. One evening, Squealer calls the animals to tell them that they've discovered something terrible: Snowball sold himself to Mr. Frederick and Pinchfield, and he plans to lead their attack on Animal Farm. Further, Snowball was in league with Mr. Jones all along, which they know because of newly discovered documents. Squealer insists that Snowball's attempt to destroy them all at the Battle of the Cowshed makes sense now. The animals are dumbfounded, as most of them remember that Snowball fought valiantly for them and that Mr. Jones shot Snowball.

Keep in mind that while Napoleon insists that they have documents proving Snowball's treason, none of the other animals will be able to read and confirm those documents for themselves—Napoleon could have anything on paper and still be able to make this point, given how undereducated his subjects are. Continuing to cast doubt on Snowball's loyalty at all gives Napoleon a way to make the animals trust him and him alone—which also has the effect of making the animals trust no one else, even those who might genuinely want to help.



Boxer questions this and shares his recollection of events, but Squealer insists he's mistaken—they have, in Snowball's own writing (which Boxer unfortunately cannot read) that Snowball was going to give them all away. His plot would've succeeded if Napoleon hadn't leapt at Mr. Jones crying "Death to Humanity" and bit Mr. Jones's leg. This graphic description helps the animals remember that Squealer's recollection is the correct one, but Boxer uneasily says that he still thinks that Snowball was on their side at the Battle of the Cowshed. Firmly, Squealer insists that according to Napoleon, Snowball was in league with Mr. Jones long before the rebellion took place. This satisfies Boxer, since Napoleon said it, but Squealer gives him an ugly look as he tells the animals to keep an eye out for Snowball's secret agents, who are all over the farm.

Squealer makes the stakes very clear here when he reminds Boxer that Boxer isn't capable of reading Snowball's documents. This impresses upon Boxer that he truly isn't as intelligent as the pigs, which makes him far more willing to accept their rule and their stories as fact. Squealer is able to do this in part because he knows that despite his questioning, Boxer is unwaveringly loyal to Napoleon and the state he stands for—so insisting that Napoleon says that these are the facts is the only surefire way to convince Boxer.



Four days later, Napoleon orders the animals to assemble in the yard and emerges from the farmhouse, wearing both his first- and second-class Animal Hero medals and surrounded by the dogs. The animals cower as Napoleon whimpers. The dogs drag the four young pigs to the front and three dogs leap at Boxer. Boxer slings them aside and pins one before looking at Napoleon for what to do next. Napoleon tells Boxer to let the terrified dog go. The four pigs are the same ones that protested when Napoleon did away with the Sunday meetings, and they confess crimes without hesitation. They say that they've been working with Snowball and planned to help him give Animal Farm to Mr. Frederick. They also corroborate that Snowball worked with Mr. Jones. When they're done, the dogs tear their throats out.

It's clear from the way that Boxer handles the dogs' attack that if he wanted to, he could oust Napoleon and the guard dogs without much trouble—but his unthinking loyalty to Napoleon means that he both doesn't understand who the enemy is, and doesn't know that he has the strength to do anything about this unjust treatment. In this way, Napoleon ensures that Boxer knows exactly where things stand: because Boxer doesn't know his own strength, he doesn't know that he can just do away with the dogs easily.

Napoleon asks who else has something to confess. Three hens confess that in a dream, Snowball told them to disobey Napoleon. A goose confesses to stealing corn and a sheep confesses that they urinated in the drinking pool on Snowball's orders. Others confess crimes and Napoleon slaughters them all. When it's over, the other animals slink away, unsure which is more shocking: the fact that the dead animals were in league with Snowball, or their punishment. This is the first time since Mr. Jones's departure that there's been bloodshed on the farm. The animals—except for the cat, who disappeared—lie down together near the **windmill** while Boxer paces. Boxer announces that he wouldn't have believed that this could happen on Animal Farm, but it must've happened because they're at fault. He vows to get up an hour earlier and promptly rushes to the quarry.

These confessions and executions, especially those of the four young pigs, mirror Stalin's "show trials," in which many people confessed to all sorts of crimes and were killed for it. Notice that the cat is gone now—once the society stopped working for her, she got out because unlike the other animals, she had the means to do so. When Boxer blames the animals—or the working class—instead of recognizing that Napoleon is turning into a bloodthirsty, power hungry tyrant, it shows how successful Napoleon has been in manipulating the situation to favor him over anyone else.

Clover and the other animals remain by the **windmill**. They look out over Animal Farm and remember that they own all of it. Tears fill Clover's eyes and though she can't formulate her thoughts, if she could, she'd think that this wasn't the goal when they rebelled. Her idea of the future was animals free from abuse and hunger, working together, the strong protecting the weak. Instead, now nobody can speak their mind, dogs growl, and they have to watch their friends be killed for confessing to awful crimes. She doesn't think of rebellion or disobedience, however, as she still recognizes that this is better than Mr. Jones's return would be. She'll accept Napoleon's leadership, even if this wasn't what she hoped for.

Pay attention to the narrator's assertion that Clover cannot formulate her thoughts. This, the novel suggests, is why Clover and her fellow working class animals aren't able to stand up to Napoleon: they're too tired, overworked, and uneducated to be able to effectively formulate their thoughts and voice their concerns. Because of this, they can, to a degree, recognize that there's hypocrisy and corruption at play—but if they're not able to harness language to talk about it, it's meaningless.

Clover begins to sing "Beasts of England" and the other animals join in and sing it mournfully. When they finish their third time through, Squealer and two dogs arrive and announce that "Beasts of England" has been abolished. Stiffly, he explains that it's no longer necessary since the rebellion ended earlier with the execution of the traitors. The society portrayed in "Beasts of England" is now established, so the song is useless. The animals are frightened, and some consider protesting, but the sheep begin to bleat "Four legs good, two legs bad" and this ends any discussion. Minimus composes a song that begins "*Animal Farm, Animal Farm, / Never through me shalt thou come to harm!*" For most animals, the new song doesn't measure up to "Beasts of England."

Squealer (and likely Napoleon) recognize that Animal Farm is in a place right now that's not all that different from Mr. Jones's rule, which necessitated "Beasts of England" as a unifying song. Now, however, allowing "Beasts of England" to be sung means that there's a chance the animals would realize that what they have now isn't actually what's spoken of in "Beasts of England." In short, the song might stir them to rebellion all over again, necessitating this censorship to keep the pigs and dogs in power.



CHAPTER 8

A few days later, some animals think they remember that the Sixth Commandment said that animals shouldn't kill other animals. Nobody says anything to the pigs or the dogs, but Clover feels that the executions aren't in line with this rule. She asks Benjamin to read her the Commandment, but he refuses so, Muriel reads instead. The Commandment reads, "No animal shall kill any other animal WITHOUT CAUSE." She sees that the Commandment wasn't violated.

Benjamin's refusal to read the Commandments, when it seems he's the only one who understands anything, continues to situate him as someone who enables the pigs' rule by keeping silent. Clover, on the other hand, doesn't have the education or the suspicion of her leaders to recognize that the Commandment truly was changed.



The animals work harder than they ever have. The **windmill**, in addition to regular farm work, means they sometimes wonder if they work harder now than they did for Mr. Jones, but possibly for less food. On Sunday mornings, Squealer reads lists of figures that prove production is up by at least 200 percent and sometimes up by 500 percent. The animals don't question this, especially since many don't remember clearly how things were before—but they also think some days that they'd rather have more food and less of the figures.

What the narrator says would suggest that life is actually worse now than it was under Mr. Jones, which makes Squealer's figures look especially silly—if there really was 500 percent more food, the animals wouldn't be so hungry. Instead, Squealer's figures are a way for him to look powerful and knowledgeable, all the while feeding the workers uplifting lies about how great things are.



Napoleon is now seldom seen in public. He never goes out without the dogs, and now, a black rooster that marches ahead and trumpets. In the farmhouse, he lives alone and eats off of the Crown Derby dinner service. Squealer and the other pigs relay his messages, and it's decided that the farm will fire the gun on Napoleon's birthday. These days, Napoleon is referred to as "our Leader, Comrade Napoleon," and the pigs refer to him as Father of All Animals, Protector of the Sheep-fold, and other such titles. Animals credit Napoleon for everything, from good laying rates to the clean water. Minimus expresses these feelings in a poem, which reads that Napoleon cares for everyone and everyone is faithful to Napoleon. Napoleon asks Squealer to paint it on the big barn next to a portrait of him.

Everything that Napoleon asks for and begins to do in this passage continues to situate him as a totalitarian leader, in power because he works hard and strategically to cultivate a cult of personality that reveres him above all else—and gives him the credit for everything good happening on Animal Farm, true or not. That animals revere Napoleon so much speaks to his success in this endeavor, while Minimus's poem and Squealer's portrait mirror the role that portraits like these have played in totalitarian regimes worldwide, from Chairman Mao in China to Hitler in Nazi Germany.



Napoleon busies himself negotiating with Mr. Frederick and Mr. Pilkington about the timber. Mr. Frederick wants it badly, but he won't offer a good price—and rumors still circulate that he wants to attack Animal Farm and destroy the **windmill**. Pinchfield supposedly still houses Snowball too, and in the summer, three hens confess that Snowball inspired them to try to murder Napoleon. After their execution, Napoleon begins sleeping guarded by dogs and appoints a pig to taste his food for poison. Napoleon eventually agrees to sell the timber to Mr. Pilkington and enters into an agreement to trade regularly with him. As the windmill's completion approaches, rumors of an impending attack from Mr. Frederick grow stronger, and rumors circulate of all the cruel things Mr. Frederick does to his animals.

These negotiations continue to parallel Stalin's dealings with both the Allies and Hitler during the eve and early days of World War II. Napoleon's increasing paranoia speaks to how precarious he realizes his position is and suggests that no matter what kinds of rumors he may circulate about either Mr. Frederick or Mr. Pilkington, he suspects that either of them might have the power to take over Animal Farm. This then makes it necessary to convince the animals that they can't trust anyone but Napoleon, so that they won't help oust him in a possible invasion.

One Sunday, Napoleon announces that he never considered selling the timber to such a horrible human as Mr. Frederick. He commands the pigeons to leave Foxwood alone and also to spread the slogan "Death to Frederick." Later in the summer, the animals discover that with the help of a goose, Snowball mixed the wheat and corn seeds with weeds. The goose commits suicide, and the animals learn that Snowball never received "Animal Hero, First Class." Rather, he was punished for cowardice after the Battle of the Cowshed and made up the story of the honor to make himself look better. Squealer convinces everyone that their memories were faulty.

Continuing to make Snowball the evil henchman responsible for every ill on Animal Farm makes Napoleon's hold on power even stronger, as he's then able to position himself as the one who got rid of Snowball and gave the farm normalcy and stability. Again, Squealer is able to convince the animals that they didn't remember correctly because the animals don't have much education to draw on, and they work too hard to be able to put much effort into their minds at all.

The animals finish the **windmill** in the fall, though Mr. Whymper is still in the process of negotiating for the machinery. The animals are tired but proud of their work, and they think of what the windmill will be able to do for them. Napoleon announces that they'll name the windmill Napoleon Mill. Two days later, Napoleon announces that he sold the timber to Mr. Frederick. He changes the pigeons' message to "Death to Pilkington," says the rumors about Mr. Frederick's cruelty are untrue, and insists that Snowball is living in luxury at Foxwood. The pigs are thrilled, as Napoleon's dealings made Mr. Frederick raise his price by £12, to be paid in cash. The money will buy the machinery for the windmill.

There's no real way to verify if any of Napoleon's dealings worked the way he and his cronies insist they did—but though the animals may be shocked, they also have nothing to do but accept Napoleon's words as fact, given how tight and scary his control over the farm is. Making the deal with Mr. Frederick is a reference to the non-aggression pact that Stalin signed with Hitler, which said that Hitler wouldn't attack the USSR—something that Hitler promptly went on to do.

Mr. Frederick's men cart away the timber quickly and when it's gone, the animals gather to reverently inspect the banknotes. Three days later, Mr. Whymper arrives with horrible news: the banknotes are forgeries. Napoleon immediately sentences Mr. Frederick to death and warns that Pinchfield might attack Animal Farm. He also sends pigeons to Foxwood with nice messages. The next morning, Mr. Frederick's men attack. There are 15 men, many with guns, and the animals cannot stand up to the bullets. They're forced to hide, and even Napoleon looks nervous. The pigeons return with a note from Mr. Pilkington reading, "Serves you right."

The attack by Mr. Frederick and his men parallels the opening of the Eastern Front of World War II, in which Hitler's armies began to invade the USSR, and within months were within 40 miles of the capital city of Moscow. Stalin's men were unable to effectively fight back, and the Allies were understandably unwilling to work with Stalin after he signed the non-aggression pact with Hitler.

Mr. Frederick and his men gather around the **windmill**. At first it looks like they're going to try to knock it down, but Benjamin nods in amusement and notes that they're going to blow it up. He's right: after a deafening explosion, the windmill is gone. The enraged animals charge. Boxer kills three men and the dogs bite and terrify the rest. The animals win, but they're bloody and tired. They gather around the windmill's foundations and note that they won't even be able to reuse the stones. Squealer skips up to them looking satisfied as the gun booms in the distance. Squealer cries that it's to celebrate their victory. Boxer points out that this wasn't a victory since the men destroyed the windmill. He insists that they just won back what they had before, which Squealer says *is* a victory.

The destruction of the windmill and the animals' ensuing victory continues to parallel the German occupation of the Soviet Union, though the Soviet forces did eventually emerge victorious. Notice that the animals—the ones who actually did the hard work of fighting off the armed men—have a far more realistic view of what happened and what will happen going forward. Squealer, however, has to spin this to look like a grand victory, as that's the only way to lift spirits and trick the animals into thinking that this is far more meaningful than they suspect it is.

At the barnyard, Boxer feels the pellets in his leg and begins to mentally prepare himself to rebuild the **windmill**. It occurs to him that he's 11 now and maybe isn't as strong as he once was. However, when he and the other animals see their flag, hear the gun, and listen to Napoleon's speech, they all agree that this was a great victory. They solemnly bury the killed animals, name the battle the Battle of the Windmill, and Napoleon confers the new Order of the Green Banner on himself. Everyone forgets the forged banknotes.

Pay attention to the way that the celebration brings the animals around to Squealer and Napoleon's way of thinking. This makes it clear that the purpose of these celebratory exercises is to remind the lower classes what exactly they're fighting for—the state—and distract from whatever injuries, illness, or other wrongs they're suffering at the hands of the state.

A few days later, the pigs discover a case of whiskey. That night, the animals hear loud singing that sounds suspiciously like "Beasts of England" coming from the farmhouse, and Napoleon inexplicably gallops around the yard in Mr. Jones's hat. In the morning, Squealer is the first to emerge at nine a.m. He announces that Napoleon is dying because Snowball poisoned his food. Squealer says that Napoleon's final pronouncement that drinking alcohol is punishable by death. By the next afternoon, Napoleon is entirely well and asks Mr. Whymper to purchase books on brewing and distilling, and orders that the pasture for retired animals should be planted with barley.

That the pigs mistake Napoleon's hangover for death shows clearly how unprepared the pigs are to be members of the human world—even though they're clearly headed in that direction, given their discovery of alcohol and Napoleon's jaunt in Mr. Jones's hat (which, remember, is a piece of clothing and therefore forbidden as a mark of humanity). Reallocating the retirement pasture to alcohol production (barley) shows that Napoleon is more than willing to do things that help himself at the expense of those who have, for the most part, served him selflessly.

One night at about midnight, the animals wake to a crash. They discover a broken ladder by the Seven Commandments along with Squealer, who is stunned on the ground next to a lantern, a paintbrush, and white paint. The dogs surround Squealer and escort him back to the farmhouse. No one but Benjamin seems to understand anything. A few days later, Muriel sees that the Commandment that she thought forbade drinking alcohol actually forbids drinking alcohol *to excess*.

This is the first and only real proof that the reader ever gets that the pigs are tampering with the Commandments. When the animals cannot figure out what's going on, it shows that they're entirely loyal to Napoleon and his rule—and cannot fathom that the person leading them could possibly want to hurt him. That would, after all, be against the Seven Commandments.

CHAPTER 9

Boxer's split hoof takes a long time to heal. He refuses to take time off from work on the **windmill**, but in the evenings, he shares with Clover that his hoof is painful. Clover and Benjamin encourage Boxer to be careful, but Boxer insists he wants to see the windmill done before he retires. The age of retirement for horses is 12 on Animal Farm, and though no animal has yet retired, they'll all receive a generous pension when the time comes. Boxer's 12th birthday is next summer.

Even though Boxer looks forward to retirement, keep in mind that Napoleon just reallocated the retirement pasture for barley—a suggestion that Boxer is being overly idealistic about whether or not retirement is even in the cards for him. His devotion to the windmill and to Animal Farm, meanwhile, shows that he's still easily manipulated into serving those projects at the expense of his own health.



The winter is cold and hard. The animals, except for the pigs and dogs, suffer reduced rations. Squealer explains that equality in rations isn't in line with Animalism—and furthermore, that they're not short on food and are doing better than they did in the days of Mr. Jones. He points out all the things that are better now and the animals believe him, in part because they barely remember Mr. Jones. They're also thrilled that they're free, not slaves. That spring, the four sows give birth to 31 piglets, all obviously Napoleon's children. Napoleon announces plans for a schoolroom for them but teaches them himself in the farmhouse kitchen. The piglets aren't allowed to play with other animals, and it becomes law that other animals should step aside for pigs. Pigs can also wear ribbons in their tails on Sundays.

The hungry animals imply that clearly, there's not enough food—while Squealer's figures and insistence that food equality isn't in line with Animalism allows him to abuse language to trick the animals into believing that this is as it should be. At this point, the pigs are also seriously corrupting language, as the original Seven Commandments have lots of room to argue for ration equality. When Napoleon insists on only educating these 31 piglets and insists that other animals should step aside, he gives these piglets a leg up in the world while reminding the other animals that they're of a lower class than the pigs.



The farm is fairly successful this year, but it's still short on money. The animals need building materials and sugar for Napoleon, so Napoleon increases the hens' egg quota to 600 per week. He reduces rations twice over the winter, though the pigs seem to put on weight. In late winter, the animals smell cooking barley from the brew-house and wonder if they'll get a warm mash for supper. However, the pigs announce that the pigs will get all the barley—as well as a pint of beer per day. Napoleon gets a half-gallon. Despite the hardships, life has more dignity. Napoleon holds "Spontaneous Demonstrations" weekly to celebrate Animal Farm. This often takes the form of a military-style parade, followed by speeches and songs. The animals enjoy the celebrations, as it helps them forget that they're hungry.

The "Spontaneous Demonstrations" are, again, a way for Napoleon to focus his subjects' attentions on the state and how awesome it is, while also detracting from all the things that are going wrong. That the pigs are getting beer while the other animals get nothing is another mark of corruption, while the success of Napoleon's rule is evident when the narrator insists that life has more dignity. In many ways, life is exactly the same as it was under Mr. Jones—the animals feel like there's more dignity just because Napoleon tells them so.



In April, Animal Farm becomes a Republic in need of a president. Napoleon is the only candidate and wins the election unanimously. He uncovers more documents detailing Snowball's dealings with Mr. Jones, including some saying that Snowball led the human forces and shouted, "Long live humanity!" Moses returns and continues to not work while talking about Sugarcandy Mountain. The animals like the idea of Sugarcandy Mountain since their lives are so hard, and oddly, the pigs allow Moses to stay and even give him an allowance of beer.

Now that the pigs are effective rulers over the other animals, Moses—and the religion he represents—isn't such a huge threat. Indeed, the idea of Sugarcandy Mountain makes the animals even more likely to continue to submit to Napoleon's demands, as they now have hope that things will get better in the afterlife. In this sense, Moses gets his beer because he's giving the pigs another tool to hang onto their power.



Boxer works harder than ever once his hoof heals—though all the animals work like slaves. His coat begins to look somewhat dull and he seems to function on determination alone, but the animals reason he'll pick up once summer comes. Clover and Benjamin warn him to take care of himself, but Boxer ignores them. One summer evening, however, Boxer falls while dragging stone to the **windmill**. The animals rush to him and Boxer weakly tells Clover that his lung has collapsed, but he doesn't care—his work means the others will be able to finish the windmill without him. He's looking forward to retirement now.

When the narrator insists that all the animals work like slaves, it makes it clear that none of the promises of the rebellion have come true: the animals may feel as though things are fine, but Boxer's sudden downturn in health shows clearly that living in this totalitarian state means that he must sacrifice everything, including his health, in order to support it.

Except for Benjamin and Clover, all the animals run to tell Squealer what happened. Squealer concernedly tells Boxer that Napoleon is going to send him for treatment at the Willingdon veterinary hospital. This disturbs the animals, but Squealer convinces them that the vet is better able to help Boxer. Boxer manages to limp back to his stall and remains there for two days. Benjamin and Clover stay at his bedside when they're not working and listen to Boxer talk about studying the alphabet once he's retired.

Boxer's desire to study the alphabet suggests that on some level, Boxer recognizes that getting some education will be the key to spending his old age like Old Major did—as a visionary, with time to think about the world and how it works. His belief that he'll be able to retire, however, is indicative of his blind trust that Napoleon still has his best interests at heart.

The van arrives to take Boxer away in the middle of the day, while the other animals are working. The animals are astonished when Benjamin races for them, braying that they're taking Boxer away. The animals race back to see Boxer in a big horse-drawn van with lettering on the side. They yell goodbye to Boxer, but Benjamin reads the writing on the van: "Alfred Simmonds, Horse Slaughterer and Glue Boiler." The man whips his horses and they race down the drive. Clover shouts for Boxer to get out, and Boxer kicks a few times—but he's too weak. They never see Boxer again. Three days later, Squealer announces that Boxer died in the hospital and that he was with Boxer to the end. Boxer's last words were in support of the **windmill**, Napoleon, and Animal Farm.

It takes the obviously impending death of his best friend to rouse Benjamin to action, but at this point, it's too late. Boxer's unthinking loyalty to Animal Farm, which robbed him of knowledge of his strength—combined with Benjamin's silence—means that Benjamin never alerted Boxer to the fact that if he'd chosen to do so, he could've stopped Napoleon's reign of terror long ago with a single kick. Boxer's weak kicks are a stark contrast to his former strength, symbolizing how the state used and abused him until he was no longer useful to them—or able to survive for himself.

Suspiciously, Squealer notes that he's heard rumors that some animals believe Boxer went to the glue factory. This isn't true: Napoleon would never do that, for one, and for another, the veterinary hospital had just purchased a van from the glue factory and hadn't yet had the opportunity to repaint it. Squealer's descriptions of Boxer's death and of the misunderstanding calm the animals. On Sunday, Napoleon gives a speech commemorating Boxer and orders a wreath for Boxer's grave. He announces a banquet in Boxer's honor in a few days. On the day of the banquet, the pigs receive a crate at the farmhouse and spend the night singing. Rumors circulate that the pigs came up with the money to buy whiskey.

Once again, there's no way for the illiterate animals, who have no connections to the outside world, to confirm that Squealer is telling the truth here—but because they trust that Napoleon is looking out for them and because of Squealer's grasp of language, they're tricked into believing this lie. The speech Napoleon gives in Boxer's honor is simply lip service designed to make the animals believe he feels sorry for Boxer—while the cask of whiskey suggests that selling Boxer to the glue factory actually just gave the pigs the cash to keep profiting.

CHAPTER 10

Years pass, and soon, only Clover, Benjamin, Moses, and some of the pigs remember life before the rebellion. Everyone else dies and even Boxer is forgotten. Clover is now 14, but she's still not retired. Napoleon and Squealer are both huge and fat. There are many animals on the farm, but not as many as they'd projected to have by this time. Because of this, most of the animals don't grasp the importance of the rebellion. There are three other horses besides Clover, none of whom are intelligent. The farm is prosperous, bigger than ever, and better organized. The **windmill** is done, but they use it for milling profitable corn, not for electricity as Snowball had proposed. Napoleon insists that Animalism is about working hard and living frugally, not about electricity and a three-day workweek.

That Clover is 14 and not retired means that even if Boxer had survived, he too wouldn't have had anything great to look forward to: Animal Farm was going to continue to abuse him until he dropped dead, whether that was before or after the age of retirement. When Napoleon insists that Snowball's promises for the windmill weren't in line with Animalism, it's another way for Napoleon to corrupt the ideals to serve his own agenda. Insisting that Animalism entails living frugally allows him to justify keeping the animals in poor conditions, while living in luxury himself.



Though the farm seems richer, the animals, except for the pigs and the dogs, don't feel any richer. Squealer talks often about how much work the pigs must do to supervise and organize the farm, though he insists the other animals are too ignorant to understand what the pigs do. Regardless, the pigs and dogs don't produce food, but they eat a lot. The other animals are still hungry, sleep on straw, and labor in the fields. The older ones try to remember if life was better immediately after Mr. Jones disappeared, but they can't remember. They have nothing to compare their present to except for Squealer's figures, which show that life is getting better. Benjamin is the only one who supposedly remembers everything, but he insists that things have never been better or worse. Life, he suggests, is about being hungry and disappointed.

Notice that at this point, the pigs don't do much—so in this sense, they've become much like the humans they worked so hard to overthrow in that they don't produce anything themselves. This shows that while the rebellion may have had noble beginnings, thanks to Napoleon's corruption and his totalitarian rule, aren't actually any better. In this sense, Benjamin is right: things for the animals have always been horrible, as they've seldom understood their power to rebel or been able to use it to create a society that actually serves them equally, as Old Major envisioned.



The animals never give up hope and are proud to be a part of Animal Farm. They still feel immense pride at the sight of their flag, and they all believe that Old Major's foretold Republic of the Animals will still come. They secretly hum "Beasts of England" and take pride in the fact that all animals are equal on Animal Farm.

This passage speaks to the power of the state to make the populace feel nationalistic pride. That pride distracts them from all the things that are going wrong in their own lives, as they're encouraged to think only about the bigger picture—which, for the pigs, looks great.



One summer day, Squealer takes the sheep to an overgrown part of the farm to browse and leaves them there for a week. He tells everyone that he's teaching the sheep a new song. Just after the sheep return, Clover neighs in shock: Squealer is walking on his hind legs. The other pigs file out of the farmhouse on two legs as well. The dogs bark and the black cockerel announces Napoleon's entrance. Napoleon haughtily looks on the other animals and carries a whip in his trotter. The animals consider saying something, but at once, the sheep loudly bleat "Four legs good, two legs *better*!" The pigs go back inside.

The shift to walking on two legs represents one of the pigs' final steps toward becoming more human than animal. The maxim that Squealer teaches to the sheep shows again how easy it is to corrupt this kind of simplified language and twist or alter it to mean almost anything. Now, Squealer has come up with a phrase that, by all counts, actually supports human, two-legged superiority over everyone else—despite the stated ideals of the initial revolution.



Clover nuzzles Benjamin and leads him to the barn where the Seven Commandments are written. She says that she still can't read, but she thinks the wall looks different. Benjamin reads the entirety of the text: "ALL ANIMALS ARE EQUAL, BUT SOME ANIMALS ARE MORE EQUAL THAN OTHERS." With this, it doesn't seem strange when the pigs all carry whips, purchase a radio, and install a telephone. It's not odd when Napoleon starts to wear clothes and smoke a pipe.

The current text of the Seven Commandments is pretty meaningless. It corrupts the meaning of "equal" by making it clear that they don't actually mean that anyone is equal, no matter what the word actually means. Because of this, however, the pigs are able to make it mean whatever they want it to—in this case, they use it to justify their rule and to justify wearing clothes.

A week later, several dogcarts containing neighboring farmers drive up to the farm for a tour. They admire everything, especially the **windmill**. The animals aren't sure whether to be more afraid of the pigs or of the humans. That night, the animals hear laughter and singing from the farmhouse. They creep up to the house and the tall animals look in through the window. They see Napoleon sitting at the head of the table, surrounded by pigs and men all with mugs of beer. A card game is in progress. Mr. Pilkington stands to make a speech and says that he's thrilled that the era of hostility between Animal Farm and the human farmers is over. The farmers believed that pigs couldn't run a farm, but today, they saw that they were wrong—and the pigs are setting an example.

This dinner is a parallel to the Tehran Conference, in which Franklin D. Roosevelt, Winston Churchill, and Stalin met to talk about how to create peace after World War II. Orwell mocks everyone involved here by showing how the people who sought to get rich working with the Soviet Union made Stalin and the Soviet Union legitimate through giving them a stage like this—when, in Orwell's opinion, the pigs and Stalin have and had no business in such a negotiation. Pilkington's praise of Napoleon suggests that lording over a totalitarian state like this is appealing to many.

Mr. Pilkington says that the "lower animals" on Animal Farm perform more work and get less food than animals elsewhere—and he and his companions intend to copy Animal Farm's methods. He emphasizes that there's no reason for animosity between Animal Farm and the other farms. Mr. Pilkington chokes up on his own joke and then manages to say that if Animal Farm has its lower animals to deal with, the humans have their lower classes. Everyone roars with laughter and they toast to Animal Farm.

What Mr. Pilkington says about "lower animals" and "lower classes" makes it clear that the pigs—and Mr. Pilkington and the farmers—are in power exactly because they're profiting off of a class structure of their own making, in which they end up on top. It's a joke to them because they are so powerful in the grand scheme of things, which shows that they don't actually care about anyone below them.

Napoleon stands to make a speech. He says that the rumors that Animal Farm is rebellious and subversive are false; they just want to coexist peacefully and would never consider stirring up rebellion elsewhere. Though he knows nobody is suspicious anymore, he's going to make some changes. Animals will stop addressing each other as "Comrade," and they'll no longer observe the odd custom of marching past a boar's skull on Sundays. The flag is now plain green too. Napoleon's only criticism of Mr. Pilkington's speech is that he spoke of Animal Farm, which isn't the correct name anymore—the farm will go by its original name, Manor Farm. They drink to Manor Farm.

Changing the name of the farm back to Manor Farm is an attempt by Napoleon to begin manipulating the world at large through language. While Animal Farm is a name that speaks to the rebellious and revolutionary nature of the farm, calling it Manor Farm allows him to convey that the farm is normal, acceptable, and capable of existing as a part of polite society. The same goes for the other changes Napoleon mentions making; they all erase the farm's history.

The animals outside see something strange happening to the pigs but can't figure out what it is and creep away. They hear an uproar inside and return to the window. They see that Napoleon and Mr. Pilkington each played an ace of spades at the same time, and everyone is shouting. The animals can't tell the difference between the pigs and the men.

When Napoleon and Mr. Pilkington both play an ace at the same time, it shows that both of them are more than willing to cheat—in this sense, Napoleon is truly no better than any of the humans. The other animals are back exactly where they started: under the thumb of cruel, power-hungry, and cheating humans.



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Chapter – VII

Kanyadaan

Kanyadaan (Gift of a Daughter) (1983) is the play for which Vijay Tendulkar was awarded the Saraswati Samman.

But for the same play he was criticised and faced the anger of the audience in the form of Chappal throwing when it was staged in Marathi. The spectators considered it as an anti-dalit play and could not find the main purpose of the playwright. So while receiving the award Tendulkar says "As its creator, I respect both Verdicts."

"Kanyadaan, is the most controversial play of Vijay Tendulkar. It deals with extremely sensitive social and political issue, namely, the conflict between the upper caste (Savarna) and Dalits, a phenomenon still rampantly prevalent in several parts of India."

Nutan Gosavi writes in **"Kanyadaan : An expose of political progressives."**

"It is the first major play to be staged after **Ghashiram Kotwal** (1972) and, also as it happens, the last major play of Tendulkar to be staged. If one approaches the play as the successor or to **Ghashiram Kotwal** which, in ways other than merely chronological it is – one is likely to be somewhat disappointed. For here, there is no technical experimentation associated with Ghashiram Kotwal nor does the story of an intercaste marriage seem radical enough. In fact, the play in 1983 with its ambience of the sixties and the seventies looks a sadly dated one. In matters of technique too, Tendulkar has reverted to the discussion plays of the thirties. All in all, an antiquated play, one might exclaim, Tendulkar is flogging the dead horse of the intercaste marriage."

On the other hand, if one looks at the play as the last major one by Tendulkar, he seems to be setting his scores with the detractors of Ghashiram Kotwal, In connection with the earlier play, he had to suffer a lot of Public harassment and humiliation for his alleged attack on the orthodox Poona Brahmins during the Peshwa period. The political radicals, of course had no problems with the play. In fact, they were gleefully delighted by Tendulkar's satire on the Brahmin orthodoxy. The conservatives in their turn had challenged him to write a similar play on the other section of society, and proclaimed that Poona Brahmins, shorn

of their age-old eminence and power, were the softest target imaginable. Tendulkar to do him credit, did script a film called “Samana” in which he targeted the co-operative sugar industry, the most powerful political force in Maharashtra. But then the shenanigans of the co-operative sugar barons are far too well known for them to enjoy the iconic status of a Nana Phadnvis and there was no uproar about the film as there was about Ghashiram Kotwal. Now in Kanyadaan, Tendulkar takes on the members of the Poona Brahmin community on to the other side of the political spectrum, as political progressives with socialist leanings. What interests a student of Tendulkar the dramatist is the date of the play, 1983 is a time when, with the impending disintegration of the soviet union and its empire, the Leftist ideology crumbled into the dustbin of history as its internal self-contradictions came to the fore. Now, perhaps, time was ripe to launch an attack on the radicals and their naivette and hypocrisy which were always perceived but not openly pointed out for fear of being termed a reactionary. Tendulkar saw the chance of meeting the challenge thrown at him by the conservatives years before and in the process be with the times, killing, thus, two birds with one stone!”

An over idealistic democratic couple, their revolutionary daughter who marries a down caste poet and gets disillusioned in the consequent turn of

events due to the unexpectedly barbaric behaviour of her life partner are presented on stage by Tendulkar with a contemporary relevance." Kanyadaan, is a play with two acts, five scenes and it has limited characters.

As the title suggests, the play centers around marriage. It is an unusual marriage in the sense that it brings in its wake complex problem – problems at once self-created and unforeseen. Jyoti, the daughter of Nath Devalikar, an MLC who insists on democracy at home, has promised to marry Arun Athavali, a Dalit youth. When she informs her parents, her father is ecstatic, but her mother Seva and brother Jayaprakash are unhappy, after they meet Arun and are shocked by his language and behaviour. Arun's excuse for his attitude is the mistreatment meted out to his family and forefathers at the hands of society. Jyoti's decision to marry Arun leads to a crisis which worsens after marriage, as Arun proves to be a violent husband. Around them, the country too, is marching towards Emergency.

At the end, Jyoti is forced to come to terms with her fate as Arun's wife, as she realizes that it is not possible to improve people and change society. Tendulkar has focused on a problem that there is no bridge

between the various sections of society and that the attempt to overcome a taboo often leads to greater pitfalls than one can handle.

A close reading of the play reveals that it is written on the two modern trends of literature.

1) Dalit literature

2) Feminism

Through these he discusses

1. The problem of marital relation in the patriarchal society,
2. The class differences and the caste conflict in modern India.

❖ Caste Conflict in Modern Indian Society

The first ever reference regarding the varna system is found in the Rigveda, which says

"brahmno sya mushmasidbahu rajanya krtha

uru tadasya yad vaisyah padbhyam sudrah oja."

(Brahmin becomes his (Purusha's) Mouth, Kshatriyas became Arms , Vishyas became Thais, and Shudras were born out of His legs.)

In the last three decades Dalit literature has become popular and it has spread awarness among the people about the exploitation of the Dalit in one or in another way. Despite 55 years of independence Dalits continue to suffer abject, misery and ill treatment at the hands of the upper castes. Politicians, instead of trying to uproot this evil, seem to capitalize on it.

Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar's advice to the writers has become a source of inspiration for Dalit writers. He says –

"I tell very firmly to all writers that spread ideals, and our cultural heritage through your literature. Don't make your ideas narrow instead make it larger…….. you should not forget that in our country one distinguished world exists – the world of downtrodden, neglected people. Try to understand their agony and pain Dedicate your creativity in making their lives dignified through your literature."

These words of Dr. Babasaheb have become a source of inspiration to Dalit writers. The traditional literature deals with kings, princes, the so called people of upper "class" and "caste". In that literature no delineation of the downtrodden is visible. It depicts the "Gods" but not the "Man" who is suppressed, exploited. And today Dalit literature has come forward to give voice of such suppressed, exploited mass of the country.

In our Indian Society due to casteism & class differences the notable personalities like Sambuk, Karn, Aklawaya and Dr. Ambedkar had to suffer and they fought against the evils of the society.

With the passing of time changes have occurred in the society, culture, religion, and literature in India but the complete revolution has not taken palce yet. India has not produced the revolutionists like Karl Marx or Martin Luther. No doubt, Buddha, Phule, Gandhiji, Ambedkar, made a notable contribution in constructing new society. In India still the "Manu" of "Manusmruti" – the originator of class and caste differences is alive in the contemporary India. Still the down-trodden, suppressed group remains "Untouchable" and excluded from the main steam of the society. Their plight continues and so they have taken up the pen to express their agony, their culture, and society.

In literature the saints and writers like Kabir, Raidas, Tukaram, Dadu, Malukm Sahjobai, Nanak, Narsinh Mehta tried to express the "voice" of such down-trodden. In Bhojpuri language Hiradom wrote "Achut ki Shikayat". And that was the first official work of Dalit literature.

Dalit literature originated in the form of revolt against the injustice to the down-trodden people. In Dalit literature, suppressed Man is in the centre and the writer tries to –

- Establish new values & rejects old traditions.
- Establish new society & rejects the caste difference
- Establish new ideology & rejects the rigid thinking.
- Establish the dignified Identity for Dalit
- Advocate – liberty, fraternity, equality
- Advocate that – Dalit is not untouchable but a dignified human being
- Present the true picture of Dalit Society.

Through various forms of literature like novel, drama, poetry the writer gives voice to the agony of the down-trodden.

Vijay Tendulkar is not a Dalit writer but he is always concerned with predicament of human being. He says

"As an individual – or rather as a social being – I feel deeply involved in the existing state of my society (because I'm affected by it though not immediately in some cases or not as much as some others are) and in my

own way brood over it. As a social being. I am against all exploitation and I passionately feel that all exploitation must end."

About the genesis of "Kanyadaan" Tendulkar writes.

"All my creative writing begins, not from an idea but from an experience, mine or somebody else's which then becomes mine. It was such an experience of another to begin with, that provided the starting point for Kanyadaan."

In this play Tendulkar presents quietly different themes. Here he does not depict a Dalit character who is exploited by the society or neglected and who wants equality or rights in the society. But Arun Athavale, a young Dalit boy is able to get married to a Brahmin girl of upper class, and treats her as an object of revenge against all the persons of higher caste & class. Here, instead of Dalit person, a girl of higher strata, suffers humiliation, and tortures at the hand of a dalit boy. So many critics believe that instead of arousing sympathy for Dalit, this play produces anti-Dalit feelings.

Actually, Tendulkar does not want to create anti-dalit feeling by presenting its hero Arun Athavale as brutal man but he wants to analyse

the psyche of the Dalits. They are so much suppressed by ages that now even if the "Savaran" tries to accept them, they deny the acceptance. Their psyche is disturbed in such a way by the humiliation that, they want to remain "Dalit", "untouchable" and never trust the so called upper caste people, even though chances and opportunities are given. This sad reality of the present day India is depicted by Tendulkar in the play through the love story of Jyoti and Arun. Through the revengeful spirit of Arun, Tendulkar also highlights the exploitation of the Dalit in the past and its effect on the post Independence Indian Dalit. So in a way Tendulkar examines the pre-independent Indian Dalit life and post-independent Indian Dalit life and draws clear cut difference between the two.

The play presents the civilized family of Nath Devlalikar, who is "Gandhivadi" democrat MLC. He is not only preacher of Gandhian philosophy to public but practices it in his own family and observes democracy at home. Like Gandhiji he does not believe in casteism and holds liberal ideas. Critics believe that Nath is none other than Tendulkar himself and as Tendulkar writes –

"Nath Devlalikar, the protagonist of Kanyadaan is me and many other liberals of my generation whom I understand completely. The pain of these people today, the defeat they have suffered, the fundamental

confusion and naivete that has led to their pain and defeat, these form the theme of Kanyadaan and I wrote about it because it came so close to me."

Mr. Nath in the opening of the play states to his daughter about his disillusionment regarding independent India, he says –
"The visions we had of the future of this nation before independence! And what we are forced to see today! Disgusting it hurts."

But he advocates ideals, morals at home. He is very friendly with his children Jayprakash and Jyoti and they too follow the Gandhian principles in their lives. So when his daughter Jyoti expresses her desire to get married a Dalit youth – Arun Athavale, he does not feel surprise. On the contrary, he welcomes the liberal idea of his daughter. He says –
"I know it doesn't make a difference. But if my daughter had decided to marry into high caste, it wouldn't have pleased me as much ….."

But the mother Seva opposes the very idea of getting married to a dalit boy. Seva is also a socialist & democrat but a realistic woman. She is not blind to implement all the Gandhian philosophy at her home. So she is shocked and firmly resists Jyoti's decision to get married to a dalit. She interrogates Jyoti about Arun, his family background and his job. When

she comes to know that Jyoti is acquainted with him for the last two months she thinks that Jyoti has taken the decision in haste. When she finds that Nath is supporting Jyoti in her reforming idea, being realist she tries to persuade Jyoti. And actually her persuasion presents the theme of the play. She says –

"My anxiety is not over his being a dalit. You know very well that Nath and I have been fighting untouchability tooth and nail, God knows since when, so that's not the issue. But your life has been patterned in a certain manner you have been brought up in a specific culture. To erase or to change all this overnight is just not possible. He is different in every way. You may not be able to handle it."

The major problem of the barrier between "the Savarna" and "Shudra" is thus presented. Saint Kabir, Saint Mira, Narsinh Mehta and Gandhiji tried their best to remove caste barriers, but it remains an age old problem. This problem has become complex because there has not been any realization of institutional religion in India. Tendulkar, in this play tries to show that vast gap exists between the life-style of the Savaran and the Shudra. So though, in the independent India the Dalit takes higher education, the psyche has not been changed and none of the two is able to accept the other. It is presented through the characters of Arun and Jyoti.

Jyoti, like her father lives in a fantasy world and inspired by her father's Gandhian principle she wants to bring reformation. Nath believes that "Charity begins at home" and support his daughter in her decision of getting married to a dalit. The father and daughter want to provide "Space" to one dalit and dream about utopian society. But they are disillusioned at the end in their search for casteless or classless society and Tendulkar by presenting their disillusionment proves that the talk of "abolishing caste system or Varna system is useless.

This very urge of Tendulkar arouses the feeling that "Kanyadaan" is anti dalit play. But in order to present the psyche of dalit's mind the negative delineation of Arun's character is necessary. Tendulkar does not want to show the exploitation of untouchable of pre Independent India but, the plight of dalits in post independence India where abuse, physical torture, and dependence, are not showered but in the independent India ample opportunities are given to Dalits – education, job, economic independence, acceptance in the society, representation in politics and in religion. But for thousands of years they have been oppressed inhumanly so their psyche is not ready to accept "co-existence" with savaran. Though opportunities are provided they have accepted that they are

“shudra” and “the saravan” can not be their well wishers. It is just their hypocrisy and so Arun’s behaviour in this respect does not shock us at all.

Arun is dalit, who is doing B.A and also working in “sramik samachar.” Jyoti meets him in the socialists’ study group. His parents are living in a village known as Chiroli. The family has seven children and Arun is second child of his parents, since his father does not earn enough from the farm, Arun has to work and he sends money home every month. Jyoti is familiar with him for the last two months only. She is impressed by his poems as he writes excellent poem. He is gifted with poetic mind. Though he is dalit, Goddess Sarswati has endowed him with poetic genius as God does not make difference in imparting knowledge to human beings. His poetic gift inspires him to write his autobiography and this poetic genius of Arun attracts Jyoti. As Jyoti says

“His poems and his autobiography have inspired me with complete faith in him.”

Jyoti herself says that she has not fallen in love with Arun as she says-

Arun said, you don't think that I am an absolutely worthless fellow I said not He said, this is incredible, and added in that case let us get married. And I nodded".

So, the idealistic upbringing and being the daughter of socialist she believes the idea, of getting married to a dalit is reformative as she finds good qualities in Arun. The mother Seva and brother Jayprakash oppose the very idea and it is decided they should invite Arun for a cup of tea to become acquainted with him.

Nutan Gosavi writes in **"Kanyadaan : An expose of political progressirves"**

"When Jyoti declares her intention to marry a Dalit boy, the parents are rattled but they are too seasoned as politicians to show their inner unease. They realize that now their integrity as public advocates of inter-caste marriages and casteless society is on test. Naturally, the parents reaction is cagey and guarded. Seva's response to the news displays a gap between her theory and practice. She finds one excuse after another to stop the marriage although she is self-rightous enough to say that she is not

opposed to inter caste marriage per se. At first, she says that Jyoti is acting in haste and then she talks of the incompatibility of their lifestyle. In comparison, Nath's reaction is less ruffled and more in keeping with their professed ideology. But, the trouble here is that the more in accord with their public pronouncements, the more naive it appears."

The entry of Arun in Act I, scene II and the interview itself points out the life style of dalit and the psyche of a dalit boy. Each dialogue of Arun is enough to present the vast gap between the "Savaran and sudhra" Constantly he compares his life and Jyoti's life manner and life style. He does not even hesitate to satirize the "Savaran". He feels uncomfortable in the big house of Jyoti, which is not that much big but a house of higher middle class, But as a Dalit he lives in the last corner of the village, generally alone from the rest, Arun, says-

"If you see my father's hut you'll understand. Ten of us, big and small, lived in that eight feet by ten feet. The heat of our bodies warm us in winter no clothes on our back, no food in our stomach, but we felt very safe. Here these damn houses of the city people, they're like the bellies of sharks and crocodiles each one alone in them!

So, the residential matter is presented. The house is small but big enough to provide warmness & affection to ten people in comparison with the isolated life of the people who live in the big bunglows. Arun compares them with sharks and crocodiles. He feels suffocated in the four walls of cements and longs to merge into the crowd which provides him warmth.

During his visit to Jyoti's house Arun makes her aware about the life of Dalit. Critics find that Jyoti has sacrificed her life for the scavenger like Arun. But Arun is not at fault. He is not a deceiver but very frankly describes the life of dalit and warns Jyoti that her romantic world is totally different from the real world. She will not be able to adjust in the scavenger's world which evokes only, disgust to the civilized men. Arun's description of his life – the life of Dalit focus the plight of Dalits.

Arun says-

"Our grand fathers and great grand fathers used to roam, barefoot, miles and miles in the heat, in the rain, day and night…. Till the rags on their butt fell apart… used to wander shouting Johaar, Maayi- baap sir, Madam, sweeper'! and their calls polluted the Brahmins' ears."

With this very dialogue Tendulkar brings in to the drama the age old gap between the Shudras and Brahmins. In the 'Bhagavad Gita' we find a reference to divisions of caste according to quality and wok !

caturvarnyam maya srstam gunakarmavibhagasah

tasya kartaram api mam viddly akartaram aviya yam.

(The fourfoldorder was created by Me according to the divisions of quality and work. Though I am its creater know Me to be incapable of action of change.)

The emphasis here is on Guna - "aptitude' and karma "function" and not Jati - birth Dr. Radhakrishanan also expresses an opinion that fourfold order was designed for human evolution. There is nothing about the caste system, which has changed its character in the process of history. The present morbid condition of India broken into castes and subcastes is opposed to the unity taught by the Gita which stand for an organic as against an atomistic conception of the society.

The social difference in the Hindu society took the form of cast system. Caste system is not merely a division of labourers ─ which is quite different from division of labour ─ it is hierarchy in which the divisions of labourers are graded one above the othe

[Dr. Babasaheb Amedkar : Writing and Speeches. Bombay Govt. of Maharastra, (1987) 67]

“Manusmruty” is the originator of the caste system in which it is said.

(૧) બ્રાહમણનું અન્ન અમૃત, શુદ્રનું અશિષ્ટ

(૨) શુદ્રએ દ્રિજ વર્ણની સેવા કરવી

(૩) શુદ્રએ ધનસંચય ન કરવો.

(૪) શુદ્ર વેદ સાંભળે તો કાનમાં ગરમ શીશું રેડવું, વેદ ઉચ્ચારે તો જીભ કાપી નાખવી અને વેદજ્ઞ બને તો શરીરના ટુકડા ટુકડા કરી નાંખવાં.

And dalit started the plightful journey of life. Even the traveller from China, Fahiyan (**ખઈહઈ** 405 to 411) mentioned that “chandal has to live away from the village and when they enter they have to declare their entry before coming to the village”. That was “Gupt Age” So in India 600 B.C., the untouchability was already prevalent. And still in 2008 it is still

prevalent in the society. Arun further describes the miserable life of the Dalit He says –

“Generation after generation, their stomachs were used to the stale, stinking bread they have begged! Our tongues always tasting the flesh of dead animals, and with relish! Surely we can’t fit into your unwrinkled Tinopal world. How can there be any give and take between our ways and your fragrant ghee spread, wheat bread culture?”

Arun truly gives the description of the life – style of Dalits. Their destiny is to eat, the left out eatables of others which also they begged. Even the flesh of dead animal becomes delicacy for them, such a life style is totally opposite to the civilized culture of the Savarans. Arun knows that Jyoti is brought up in a highly sophicated culture and she has only heard about the hardships and disgustful world of Dalit. But the practical life with Arun in which begging, abuse, beating, stinking food will prove to be hell for Jyoti. He asks therefore –

“Will you marry me and eat stinking bread with spoilt dal in my father’s hut? Without vomiting? Tell me Jyoti, can you shit everyday in our slum’s village toilet like my mother, Can you beg, quaking at every door, for a little grass for our buffaloes. Come on, tell me!

“You thought of marrying me. Our life is not the socialists service camp. It is hell and I mean hell. A hell named life.”

This speech of Arun resembles with the famous poem of **Heera Dom**, written in **Bhojpuri** language. Which is titled as “**Achut ki shikayat**” and published in **1914 i**n the magazine “**Swarswati**.” This poem is regarded as the first Dalit poem by dalit poet. In the forty lines of this poem the poet presents the condition and miseries of dalit along with religion government and people as well as the god. He writes –

હમારે કૈસે લોરુ, તુમ્હારે કૈસે દૂધ,

તુમ્હ કૈસે બ્રાહમન, હમ્હ કૈસે શુદ્ર.....

They are pained by the abuse, and rude behaviour of savarns yet

''હમની કે દુઃખ ભગવાન ઓ ન દેખતા જે,

હમની કે કબલે કલ'સવા ઉઠાઈબિ''

the god does not grant happiness to them and no one even protests. Not only that but considering them as Dom” “Scavenger” people disgusted

them. The poet says we work from dawn to dusk and get two rupees in the month.

અપને પસિનવા કે પઈસા કમાઈબસ,

ઘર ભર મિલિ જુલી બોટિ ઓટિ ખાઈબિ.

We earn money by labour. The Thakur sleeps soundly at home and we work in the field. But who listens –

"હમની કે ઈનરા કે નિગિચે ન મઈલેજા,

પાંકે મેં સે ભરિ – ભરિ પિઅતાની પાની,

પનહી સે પિટિ – પિટિ હાથ ગોડ તુડિ કેલૈ,

હમની કે ઈતની કાટી કે હલકાની?"

With anguish the poet says we drink water with the help of our palm. People do not allow us to be near to them and beat us with their shoes and we bow down and return their shoes with gratitude. The poet asks why do people hate them like these? Why are they regarded so mean and degrading?

So, even today this untouchability prevails in the society though law and order are there in the society. In the deaf and dumb society, it is difficult to give voice to alive community of “Dalit”. It is voiced through poems from saint Raidas to Heera dome and the same anguish is presented by Tendulkar in this play through the character of Arun.

Arun wants to bring revolution. He wants to set the fire of revolt in which all the old customs, discriminations regarding caste, & class will be removed. Being aggressive and young he wants to kill upper class people He says. –

“At times a fire blazes - I want to set fire to the whole words, strangle throats, rape and kill. Drink up the blood of the beasts, your high caste society. I hen I calm down like the taantric when he comes out of his trance. Like a corpse, I live on.

So the fire of revolt burns within but limitations are given as he says just like corpse he is living physically. He is existing but all his sensitivity is dead seeing the injustice in the society. The fire extinguishes as economic, social, religious bondages are there. Arun’s anguish reminds the poem by Drarika Bharti, titled as “ Sailab”.

તમને બિલકુલ ગમશે નહિ, કદાચ૧

પરંતુ હું કહેવામાં અચકાઈ નહિ.

હું પંચમ સૂરમાં

કેટલાક લોકોનાં

''મર્સિયા'' ગાવા ઈચ્છું છું.

તેઓની ''મજાર'' પર જઈને

તેમની ભભૂકતી ચિતા પર

હું ભરપૂર થૂંકવા ઈચ્છું છું.

તેમના અસ્થિફૂલોને

હું હવામાં ઉડાડવા માંગુ છું.

મારો સઘળો ધિક્કાર તેમના ઉપર ઠાલવવા માંગું છું.

કોણ છે એ લોકો?

જેમનો દંભ ચીરી નાખવા

દ્રઢ સંકલ્પ છે મારો.

એ જાણવા માટે

તમે ફકત એક દિવસ માટે

માણસના બદલે –

ચમાર બનીને જુઓ

ચૂહડા બનીને જૂઓ

ડોમ બનીને જૂઓ

અને –

So “Hatred” or “Disgust” is inborn quality in Dalit as they face the injustice in the society and Arun is no exception. Arun realizes that he is causing Jyoti great pain by his outburst and he apologises to her asking her to forgive his mood for they arise out of his feeling of injustice, frustration, inner desire for revenge and his utter helplessness. It pleases Jyoti and she smiles. Arun in his excitement chants the childish rhyme. “Hasli re hasli, ek bamanee fasli.”

Incidentally, the English translation in the text is a jolly game! Caught a Brahmin dame - does not bring out the full import of the Marathi rhyme. Besides very awkward. For non - Marathi readers it will be easier to grasp the meaning if it is translated as “see, she has smiled and therein is a Brahmin wench trapped.” The word “Bamaneen” for a Brahmin woman is seen as uncouth and derogatory among Brahmins whereas, it is common for non- Brahmins to use the word “Shudra” or “Mharda” which is seen as casteist by the Dalit until recently freely used by non-dalits. The first meeting of Arun with Jyoti’s mother and brother is not at all positive. From the beginning Jyoti’s mother is against this marriage so when they meet the caste prejudice is already there and when Arun gives

the answer roughly, Seva, Jyoti's mother is shocked. Arun has also hidden hatred for the people of upper class. When Seva makes him aware about the hardships of city life and expenditures of city life as Arun has completed only B.A and not earning much, it would be difficult for him to provide luxury to Jyoti who is totally brought up in comfortable atmosphere. Arun thinks that Seva is mocking at his low status by reminding the expenditures of city life. In angry mood he gives the solution by saying.

"No problem. We shall be brewing illicit liquor. It is a first class profession for two persons. The man bribes the police and the wife serves customers. People call her aunty. The more striking the aunty's looks, the brisker the trade."

Seva is shocked by Arun's answer. Jyoti tries to make the atmosphere light but Arun who is already disturbed scolds her "you don't know a shit shut up". The father Mr. Nath arrives and being socialist, he is overjoyed finding Arun at home. He is happy at the thought that at last his home has become Indian in the real sense as they have broken the caste barrier. He warmly greets Arun and offers tea and snacks to him. After his departure Seva and Jayprakash reject him as Jyoti's suitor. They find him

uncultured, uncivilized, and his misbehaviour to Jyoti, shock them. Seva says

"But I will never accept him as my Jyoti's husband. Never."

Jyoti is also confused and can not give her frank opinion she says-

At time I feel I can trust him, but the very next instant I am left miles behind him. I ask myself- this thing that I want to do, is it the right thing…? He is complex.

But Mr. Nath tries to convince them that he has been brought up in the midst of poverty and hatred. His psychological make up is altogether different and they should try to understand him. He says in his favour –

"He may not be a gentleman, but neither is he a scoundrel... He is like unrefined gold, he needs to be melted and moulded."

Mr. Nath, being Gandhian supports Jyoti's decision but Seva firmly objects and says-

"You ran your democracy. To me Jyoti's decision seems to be absolutely senseless and as her mother I cannot accept it… This is a home, not your, party, where you can impose your discipline." But Jyoti takes a revolutionary step and gets married to a dalit youth. By presenting this marriage Tendulkar does want to show the reformation of independent

India but the play is a study of the psyche of Dalit. Reformation is not possible as they are not ready to leave their deep rooted life style. Any attempt by the upper class to uplift them is seen by them as a treachery, or merely a hypocrisy. So they do not accept the upliftment genuinely. It's difficult for them to imagine their lives without drink, abuse and beating and quarrels. Tendulkar does not want to show that a dalit youth has become a member of Brahmin family and lived happily but presents totally unexpected situation, as if Tendulkar tried to present the defeat of Gandhian ideal in the midst of Dalit world.

The married life of Jyoti and Arun is presented in dark light. An opportunity is given to a dalit boy to rise up in the society but Arun is shown incapable of utilizing that chance. He cannot escape from his Dalit mentality, and life style. Though educated, his wife Jyoti has become a mere thing for him on whom he can show his love whenever he is pleased and can show his anger by beating her if he is angry. Jyoti after months returns home and declares that she has left Arun forever. She says

"He….. he will not enter this house. Because I have left him…. I am not going back to him again… never." I must tell you, Bhai. I must. I am fed up with him Fed up! Fed up!"

The mother, Seva feels relieved as Jyoti is released from the animal like Arun. But Arun, arrives to take Jyoti back home. Still he is not changed. Mr. Nath invites him for dinner but he says

No, I am not fit to have dinner with people like you."

When Seva asks him the reason of the quarrel, he shocks them by saying that he has beaten Jyoti. He does not feel shy for his behaviour but defends himself by saying that abuse and beating are knitted in the webs of their lives. Jyoti is not used to such things so such things appear to her unnatural but it is part and parcel of their lives. He says –

"When have I claimed that I am civilized and cultured like your people, From childhood I have seen my father come home drunk everyday, and beat my mother half dead, see her cry her heart out. Even now I hear the echoes of her broken sobs. No one was there to wipe the tears."

For his behaviour he considers his upbringing as the key factor. The family life which he has seen consists of only abuses, beating and quarrels .Hence for him married life means love plus beating. His mother has tolerated such a life without complaint so it never occurs to him that a woman does not like it. Therefore Jyoti's behaviour to leave him sounds unfair to him. He says –

"What am I but the son of scavengers. We don't know the non violent ways of Brahmins like you. We drink and beat our wives….. we make love to them…. But the beating is what gets publicized."

For him the beating of the wife does not mean that he hates her. He loves her too, but according to him it is never appreciated but they are evaluated by their negative sides only. So he says "I am a barbarian, a barbarian by birth when have I claimed any white collar culture."

He does not even want to change himself because he does not want to lose his identity of Dalit. He believes that the upper class people only make a show of love for their wives but actually they never give "space" to them. After all it is a matter of being "Male" which is superior and "Wife" is merely a "second sex." Whether a male belongs to lower class or upper class, he dominates. He says.-

"I am what I am… and shall remain exactly that. And your Jyoti knew what I was even before she married me. In spite of that she married me, she did it out of her own free will."

And at last Jyoti decides to go with him despite the unwillingess of her mother and brother. Few months later in Act II, scene II it is presented

that Jyoti is expecting a baby, and her mother admits her at the nursing home in the sixth month due to internal bleeding. Through the neighbour Seva comes to know that Arun beats and kicks Jyoti at night. Mr. Nath is totally broken and finds it incredible as to how a man can beat a pregnant wife. Arun has recently written autobiographical novel which is sentimental as well as poetical. Mr. Nath, after reading it, is overjoyed and praised it like anything and now the disclosure of Jyoti's condition moves him and he laments ─

"Such heinous behaviour by someone who wrote this beautiful autobiography? How can he? Here in these pages he describe the humiliations he has undergone with extraordinary sensitivity… and the same man kicks his pregnant wife on her belly? How…

Seva, who is already against the marriage, ironically comments that their dalit son- in- law, who writes lovely poems and wonderful autobiography, is an idler, who lives on the money of Jyoti and drinks and beats his wife. She sarcastically points out the reality which Tendulkar wants to convey in order to justify Arun's behaviour towards his wife. Seva says –

"Doesn't his wife belong to the high caste? In this way he is returning all the kicks aimed at generations of his ancestors by men of high caste. It appears that this is the monumental mission he has set out to fulfill."

And here, Seva is absolutely right. Tendulkar does not want to present Arun with negative shades but he explores the psyche of a Dalit youth. Arun loves Jyoti very much but the Dalit part of his mind lives in his tormented past and unleashes torment on his high-caste wife. His past returns to haunt him every night and he turns into unpredictable savage beast, who has strange malice and, a sadistic desire to punish his wife for the suffering his ancestors have gone through the ages. He has crude satisfaction that he has "Caught a Brahmin dame." Not only the daughter is punished but Arun derives sadistic pleasure in abusing her parents too. Seva who is the leader of Sevadal is accused by Arun as a procuress who supplies girls from the Sevadal to the socialist leaders. Arun even accuses that Jyoti's real father is not Mr. Nath but "Guruji", the guide, and philosopher of Seva. Thus, by such accusation Arun tries to degrade morally the parents of Jyoti and thereby takes revenge on the upper caste. Arun's autobiographical novel gets published and he has become a celebrated Dalit writer. The association known as "The Progressive Dalit Literature Circle" has arranged a discussion on his autobiography. Arun along with other members, like Hammeer Rao Kamle, essayist of dalit literature, Vamanseth Nevrgaonkar, critic of dalit literature, arrives to invite Mr.Nath to preside over the function of the discussion on his

autobiography as Mr. Nath is a socialist, an MLA and also his father-in - law. Mr. Nath does not want to take part in the discussion and to appreciate the book. Arun, the writer merely a hypocrite like a savage beast is antagonist of the upper caste. He does not miss this situation. He reminds Mr. Nath about the social criticism if he was not present in the function. People would conclude that father in law and son-in-law are not in a good terms. The rise of the son-in-law could not be endured by the fathers-in-law etc. He further tries to convince him by reminding the gap between the upper caste and lower caste. Mr. Nath's rejection may be due to the fact that he does not want to mix with lower class people. Arun says –

"Your connections are with the elite. Our friends here belong to a low caste, brought up on the flesh of dead animals. Our ancestors trudged around with a load of shit on their heads. It is my great good fortune which made a fair and lovely bird from a well to do, high class background fall to my lot. My revered mother in law has always been angry with me. She would have liked a fair, rich, highly educated son in law with his butt glued to a high office chair. But fate wrote my name instead. A poet and a writer! And dalit at that!"

Again Arun's mind remembers the miserable plight of his ancestors who trudged in the realm of shit only and passed away. They never came above or their voice remained unheard only due to higher caste people who exploited them. This reality haunted Arun's mind and its memory he carries wherever he goes. The slightest rejection, or neglect is enough to remind him the fact that he belongs to "low caste" and so "rejection is his destiny. He is of the view that Mr. Nath is hypocrite as in the society Mr. Nath stands for liberal socialist ideas who has done many social works for the downtrodden, but actually he hates them from within, he does not like a dalit son in law so in this evocative scene

Arun ridicules Nath by saying –

"These people believed you were a well wisher of the dalit community. That you championed the cause of "a well in every village for the dalit" you launched a satyagrah for that cause. You deliver socialist addresses at the state Assembly. With the trumpet call of idealism you got your daughter married to a dalit. This taunting of Arun breaks Mr. Nath totally. Now he really starts hating him. May be Mr. Nath's two-facedness comes out when he is "offended" by the Dalit contemptuous mockery of him and after Arun's departure he says –

"His visit has polluted this drawing room, this house and this day… It stinks Seva you know you see I feel like taking a bath like cleaning

myself, clean everything ! This furniture, this floor… all this … he has made them filthy, dirty, polluted!"

Inspite of his unwillingness, for the sake of his daughter, so that Arun can not torement Jyoti more, he goes to the function. He praises the book publicly but Jyoti condemns her father as she knows that the speech of Mr. Nath was fake. Inwardly he hates Arun. Even Jyoti is disillusioned in her search of reformation. She suffers due to the idealism taught by her father. For Arun she is only a daughter of "savarna" who can never be his wife and the play ends when she takes up another mission to be the wife of a dalit and she leaves the house of her parents by saying that she is Jyoti Arun Athavale, a scavenger, because she has realized that only when she will live with dalit – live like insect only then the distance between the "savarna" and "shudra" can be crossed.

So the play explores the issue of Dalit's psyche in the post independent India. They are not ready to mingle with the main stream of the society. They want to maintain their Identity of Dalit. The genuine concern of the higher class people appears to them merely hypocrisy as they can not forget their intolerable past. The suppression of them in the past by the "savarna" haunts them and this reality is presented through Arun's

character. Tendulkar wants to suggest that if this is the reality how can the gap between the savarna and shudra be bridged? The idealism of few people to mingle with them will never work so the situation demands new means to overcome the gap between the upper class and lower class.

In order to present this reality Tendulkar has to depict the character of Arun with negative shades. So the play raises anti-dalit feelings. When the writer Meghna Pethe told Tendulkar that Dalit writers were angry about his misrepresentation of Dalits, the playwright observed testily.

"I pointed a gun at a wholly different target. What can I do if something else falls dead."

So "Kanyadaan" had fired at its salvos not at Dalits, against the hypocrisy of secular liberals, "People of my generation" who refused to face realities, and adopted easy solutions for complicated issues. Such illusions were bound to end in disaster.

(2) Gandhian Idealism v/s the Reality

Kanyadaan remains revelant even after 26 years. Tendulkar does not explore the issue of Dalit's psyche but also presents the vainness of Gandhian principles in Indian social structure, Karl Marx through his theory of "Dialectical materialism" talked about the abolishment of the lower, class and upper class. In India, the great man Gandhiji along with the talk of non violence and truth tried to remove 'untouchability' from the Indian society. It affected few people of India, who wanted to build new India on the principles of Gandhiji. But the post independent Indian society and its people are still not ready to follow the Gandhian principles in establishing new social structure. They have their own problems and views and so they are unable to mingle with the new social structure imagined by the idealist.

The play explores serious issues of caste divide, co existence and idealism in an atmosphere wreathed in strain and strife Mr. Nath Devlalikar, is a socialist, Gandhian, democrat MLA. who has practiced Gandhian principles in his home also and feeds his two children Jyoti and Jayprakash on his idealism. The play is not about the glorification of

Gandhian idealism but in this play Tendulkar depicts the disillusionment of Mr. Nath regarding the Gandhian principles. He is a political visionary and wants to create an utopian world on the base of Gandhian idealism but the end of the play presents that his idealism crumbles and he accepts the reality that social change in Indian society is impossible. For his realization he sacrifices his daughter.

From Act I, his disillusionment regarding the working of the nation is depicted. The play presents post independence era of India. Whatever hardships, struggle India did, the fruit was, gained in the form of "Freedom" and the Gandhians hoped for liberal, democratic honest, government But it proves to be merely a "vision". Mr. Nath wants an inquiry regarding the departing time of the bus for Asangaon But the controller fails to give him any information and Mr. Nath laments that such irresponsibility will never develop the independent nation. The controller must be fully informed about every single bus which departs from his terminal as he is appointed for that purpose only. He laments

"The visions we had of the future of this nation before Independence! And what we are forced to see today! Disgusting. It hurts!"

So, he knows that independent India is going astray and Gandhian principles remain in the books. But he is contented as he practices the principles in his personal life and does not merely teach it. He is not an orthodox father who dominates the lives of the children but practices democracy at home also. He has taught his children his idealism unaware about its destructive effect. When his daughter Jyoti wants to talk about her affair he says.

"Tell me something say it then. Who stops you? We have a democracy in this house and we are proud of it. Democracy outside and dictatorship in the home, we don't know these two timing tricks.

He wholeheartedly welcomes Jyoti's idea of getting married to a Dalit. He feels proud that his children, like him too follow the Gandhian principle and tries to reform the society. The progressive views of Mr. Nath inspire his daughter who wants to marry a Dalit and promises in delivering him from his devilish tendencies. Her father's lofty ideals have inculcated in her a spirit which tries to find the good in people, and strive to transform them. Mr. Nath gets excited and congrates his daughter for her idea. He is the only person who favours the daughter against the dislike of her mother. He rejects every argument of his wife Seva, who is

also socialist. Mr. Nath, is optimist and hopes that Jyoti's decision will certainly enlighten the dark life of a dalit. He says –

If they decide to do so, lifestyles can certainly be changed. And the ideal of stability can be different for every man……

Even during his first meeting with Arun, he makes the atmosphere very light and comfortable by offering tea to him. He is true Gandhian and against drinking. He belongs to upper middle class where drinking is considered to be status but as he says

"Arun, Let us celebrate over a cup of tea. Well, nowadays our socialists don't mind even liquor. But in this matter I continue to be somewhat old fashioned. A little worm called Gandhi ate into my brain in youth didn't he, therefore certain things slipped out of my life forever. Liquor is one, fancy clothes is another…

It is not a matter of pride for him that he does not drink but genuinely he keeps away from this bad habit. But it is his sad destiny that he gets a son in law who is a drunkard and talks of brewing illicit liquor. So Mr. Nath's Gandhian world is put in conflict with the world of reality, where only vices prevail. Like "Dry Day" he is against "Untouchability". Just as Gandhiji has given the name "Harijan" to all "shudra' and place them

near to God by calling them “Harijan”, Mr. Nath, being Brahmin, does not feel hatred for them. Arun, appears to him as the proper suitor for his daughter. He says, “Seva, until today.” ‘Break the caste system’ was a mere slogan for us I’ve attended many intercaste marriages and made speeches. But today I have broken the caste barrier in the real sense. My home has become Indian in the real sense of the term.”

The matter of marrying a dalit invites firey argument in the family and the wife Seva strongly opposes it on the ground of culture and life style But Mr. Nath defends Arun.

“Manners and culture, are they your ancestral property? He is a good boy… he is well behaved… can anyone be that without culture?”

He feels surprised that his ideology is not understood by his wife, then what about the world? He strongly believes in Gandhiji’s ideology to mingle the downtrodden with the main stream.Only then the barrier between the lower class and upper class can be crossed. Opportunity should be given and his family is taking the leadership. He convinces his wife.

“Look Seva, society cannot be transformed through words alone we have to act as catalysts in this transformation. The old social reformers did not

stop with making speeches and writing articles on widow remarriage. Many of them actually married widows, why did they do it…? That was also an experiment, a difficult experiment, but they dared to risk it."

So, he becomes the practitioner of his preaching and establishes "charity begins at home". He has hope that this bold step of his daughter would not merely cross the barrier but it would set an example for other upper caste members to follow. He is of the opinion that Jyoti's journey of reformation will enlighten others and in future the nation will be without any casteism.

But he gets disillusionment regarding his ideology. The married life of Jyoti and Arun proves futile. Mr. Nath's idealism, breaks into pieces after the marriage of Jyoti and Arun. Jyoti soon realizes that Arun is not the man whose poetry she adored, he is a Dalit, whose past returns to haunt him every night and he unleashes torment on his high caste wife. He is a beast one moment, a lover the next, the devil and the poet are one and the same person, they can not be separated, neither can he be cleansed of the vices like drinking, wife beating, which are a part of him. She leaves him and comes to her father for shelter Mr. Nath who believes in goodness in everyone is not ready to accept the reality. Gandhian principle can not be

vain, Jyoti has taken the right decision according to him. She should not leave Arun as it will take time for her to get adjusted herself in the world of Dalit. For him Arun is still good and his idealism will certainly work out, it may not remain in the book. He says

"Seva, let not this wonderful experiment fail! This dream which is struggling to turn real, let it not crumble into dust before our eyes! We will have to do something. We must save this marriage. Not necessarily for our Jyoti's sake… This is not just a question of our daughter's life, Seva this has…. A far wider significance …. This experiment is a very precious experiment."

So, he is a man, who has faith in the process of reformation. He wants Jyoti should set an example in the society that casteism is not barrier between two souls, but "LOVE" governs the world. When Arun arrives to take Jyoti back home he is overjoyed. The lamentation of Arun makes him understand that he is regretting and his experiment will be successful when Jyoti decides to go, he permits and says -

"Jyoti, I feel so proud of you, The training I gave you has not been in vain."

Arun writes auto-biography and Mr. Nath praises it wholeheartedly. He feels proud that Jyoti has selected such a man who moves the heart of everyone with his writing. But the revelation by his wife that Jyoti who is preganant, is in the hospital due to the kicking of Arun, Mr. Nath is shocked. His ideal world is shattered. His experiment has failed. He realizes that modern world cannot be run by "Bapu's" ideology. The sacrifice of his daughter's life has gone in vain. Arun remains the same and proves that the barrier between lower caste and upper caste can not be crossed. Arun invites him for the discussion on his autobiography organized by the Progressive Dalit Literature Circle. Mr. Nath is not ready to attend the function and praise the person and the book, because Arun, even as a human being not as a Dalit appears to him disgusting, who writes with sensitivity on the humiliations of Dalit and the same man kicks the pregnant wife. He is not ready to praise such a hypocrite, Arun excites him to accept the invitation by reminding the social criticism but he is firm and says "NO" to Arun. Now he is totally disillusioned. Instead of appreciation for Dalit, he has disgust and hatred for them. At the cost of his only daughter he made out the experiment but it proves futile. Now he realizes that Gandhian principle to remove untouchability, is impossible as Dalit themselves are not ready to mix with the upper caste. The miserable past has gone deep into the psyche of the Dalit and the

members of the upper caste are just only a tool for them to take revenge. He remembers his son Jayprakash's words and agrees.

"In other words, yesterday's victim is today's victimizer. If he has been, shot at yesterday, he shoots today……"

He feels insulted as his mild, soft nature is taken by Arun as a sign of powerlessness but now he proves to be the angry father of Jyoti and decides that he will never deliver a speech for Arun but Seva, his wife reminds him that his decision may be true but his refusal will bring more suffering for Jyoti, Arun will take revenge on Jyoti, and Jyoti is pregnant. Mr. Nath's refusal will make Arun to find new ways to torment her. She says

"If you don't go to the meeting, God knows what he….. in his madness.. will do to Jyoti…. Therefore, you will have to go, you will have to praise the book, because that is the only option left to us."

Here, Mr. Nath finds himself powerless before the predicament of his daughter, and praises his son in law's autobiography in the function, applause showering from his mouth and passion dripping from his eyes. He hopes that,

"My blatant lying today will make Jyoti's life a little more tolerable.

I did it for the sake of my brave and innocent daughter. What is this compared to her having ruined her whole life for my sake?"

So, he makes a glowing speech, showering accolades on the book. All this he had to do to preserve his progressive image in the public and also to ensure that it spares his daughter from getting beaten. For the first time perhaps he has said what he did not feel at heart. He breaks down completely by the painful awareness of his utter helplessness in the matter which forces him to carry this hypocritical task so repugnant to him.

The father who has taught his daughter the lofty ideals of humanity and socialism is defeated. He finds that his hope in human innocence is faulty and how she is a victim of his faith in pursuing this promise.

He says –

"I had this maniacal urge to uproot casteism and caste distinctions from our society. As a result, I pushed my own daughter into a sea of misery……"

This is self-knowledge indeed!

Being Gandhian he never speaks lie in the public but in the function he praised the autobiography which is not based on the truth. And in order to praise the book he had used the most beautiful world and writer like Byron and Kusumargraj only for the sake of his daughter. So that Arun can keep her happy. He thinks "what is her fault? Why does she suffer?" The only crime she has committed is that she had taken her father's words for gospel truth. She adopted her father's values and was guided by her father's humanism and liberalism. He hopes that his daughter will be happy as he has praised Arun in public.

But in the last scene of the play the exchange of words between father and daughter is surprising. Jyoti confronts her father's charitable, gesture in releasing his son-in-law's autobiography. Throughout her life she has observed her father frank and honest and today due to Arun he also became hypocrite and praised the book against his will. She says –

"Your speech today was not only lousy, it was a hireling's speech. You attended the meeting against your wishes you praised that book against your wishes."

She does not like this charitable act of her father who still considers her to be the member of Brahmin's family. She boldly says she now belongs to different family. She says –

“I belong to someone who makes your clean and pure soul impure by his touch.”

Jyoti makes the father realize that all his teaching has gone in vain. Her father has always told her that no man is fundamentally evil, he is good, he has certain propensities towards evil. They must be transformed and the earth will become heaven. It is essential to awaken the God slumbering within man. But through her own experience she has learnt that this idealism is totally false. She says –

“Putting man’s beastliness to sleep and awakening the godhead within is an absurd notion. You made me waste twenty years of my life before I could discover this.”

In a fit of anger, she denounces the teaching of her father and says –

“Come and watch Arun at night when he staggers home roaring drunk, if you have the guts. There is a savage beast in his eyes, his lips, his face…. In every single limb. And bestiality is something which cannot be separated from him. In the beginning like an idiot, I used to search for that Arun who is above and beyond this beastliness. I used to call out to him, take him in my arms. Hard experience taught me I would always

fail. Arun is both the beast and the lover. Arun is the demon and also the poet. Both are bound together one within the other, they are one."

Mr. Nath tries to convince her and proposes that if she wants to reject him he is ready to support her. But Jyoti tells that he has taught them that one must not turn one's back upon the battlefield. It is cowardly to bow down to circumstances. She reminds her father that you taught us the poems which said

"I march with utter faith in the goal!"

"I grow with rising hopes"

"Cowards stay ashore, every wave opens a path for me."

And according to her, this drug has entered and mingled with her blood and it has numbed her entire consciousness. She cannot run away.She says, She will follow.

"March on, oh soldier! and continue to lose our lives as guinea pigs in the experiment."

Mr. Nath's experiment to reform the society has totally failed. His own daughter is blaming him for teaching the principle of goodness and humanity. Gandhian doctrine may shine glorious on the pages but in real

life its practice is futile just as in the film “Lage Raho Munnabhai” it is shown, that modern India has forgotten Gandhi, though the “Bapu” lives in India through the names of road, pictures, statues, image on rupee, etc. but where he should live, in the “Heart” is totally missing. People do not understand or follow his principle of “Non-violence” or “Truth” and it sounds “Ridiculous” to most of the Indians. Plato, wants to establish an Ideal state where he will not allow poets or poetry as poetry is based on falsehood and it depicts the imaginary realities regarding gods and great heroes. The gods are presented as quarrelsome, envious, jealous, greedy and it may corrupt the younger minds so he will allow only hymns to his ideal state. He asks the governess to tell only those stories which have good moral in it. But it is argued that if a child gets only one-sided knowledge, if he is taught only the goodness, will he be able to cope up with the world in which he will have to live? The world is not good but full of vice and so he must be aware about it. In this manner, Mr. Nath has always taught only good lesson, faith in human being and under its effect the daughter has selected a Dalit to remove untouchability but her experiences has taught her different reality. She realizes that if she will live as a Dalit only then the distance will be crossed and her father’s experiment will be successful. So she says –

“I am not Jyoti Yadunath Devlalikar now, I am Jyoti Arun Athavale, a scavenger. I don’t say harijan. I despise the term. I am an untouchable, a scavenger. I am one of them. Don’t touch me. Fly form my shadow, otherwise my fire will scorch your comfortable values.

These last words of the play as opined by Nutan Gosavi “neatly sum up Jyoti’s reaction about Nath as her philosopher and guide and more painfully as her father. It is often said that in a marriage a father loses his daughter, but in Nath’s case the Kanyadaan – giving away of the daughter – has been doubly painful in his giving away Jyoti to Arun. He has lost her in more ways than one. His kanyadaan has turned out to be a sacrifice of his daughter on the altar of his socio-political ideology.

Thus, through a multi-layered content, Tendulkar finally drives home the point that the reality of one man is different from what the other man perceives it to be. The daughter finds her own reality in a filthy slum, where her man returns roaring drunk every night to beat her up one moment and caress the next. And once she realizes she must love Arun, the man and not Arun, the poet, she finds peace but not without discovering the emptiness of her father’s idealistic rhetoric.

❖ Dramatic techniques in “Kanyadaan”

Tendulkar writes

“Theater is a visual medium as much as it is a medium of words. This visual aspect needs to be used properly not only to create a relief in the barrage of continuously emoted words, but also to provide powerful visual insights into the complex content of the play. A play staged in a theatre is not a radio-play to be heard with closed eyes and enjoyed. The visual elements in a stage play, if not used properly can work against the magic of words and harm the play.”

Kanyadaan is a play with two acts and five scenes. It is naturalistic play. The interesting thing about the play is that though the play explores serious issues of caste divide, coexistence and idealism yet for its presentation variety of scenes are superbly omitted. It is the dramatic art of Tendulkar that the whole action of the drama is presented only in the drawing room. The play is set throughout in the drawing room of the Devlalikars adorned with typical high-caste urban antique furniture with a picture frame of Mahatma Gandhi, Achary a Narendra Dev, Yusuf

Meherali and Sane Guruji hanging form the wall complete with a creeper to resemble the garden outside.

Family jokes are plentiful to suggest liberal views of the Brahmin family like –

“The call of the nation is far more important than the call of a wife”

When Seva, the mother declares –

“If he had been a democratic, would I have been his wife?”

Or the ability of Mr. Nath to make fun of himself.

“That’s why I’ve lasted so long in politics” and

“One can take a first class nap during the dull speeches at the session.”

So, the play is laced with a gentle humour which presents happy family of Mr. Nath Devalikar.

This gripping play, which is decorated with fine dashes of humour, is charged with an undercurrent of violence, uncertainities and anger but it is the art of Tendulkar that violence is not presented on the scene but only brilliantly reported. Arun is depicted as a drunkard who beats his wife frequently even during pregnancy and speaks abuses. Abuses and beating

are not presented but reported through the speech of Seva and Jyoti and through the speech hatred for Arun is presented.

The play ends with Mr. Nath's whimper. Mr. Nath is disillusioned regarding his faith in Gandhian principle, humanity and Idealism. He is defeated as his experiment has failed though he sacrificed his daughter. In order to suggest this, the dramatist uses the sounds of huge buildings hurtling down. The crashing of buildings gets louder to suggest his despair. Mr. Nath breaks down. This final whimper appears as a heart-rending purgatory wail which could make a person cry. The dramatist through this scene creates Catharsis, the feeling of pity and fear. The audience feels "Pity" for Mr. Nath's defeat in his search for ideal society. He does not deserve such an end, where the daughter confronts him and blames him. He is good and always taught goodness to his children, but the world is not ready to accept this. And his condition also arouses the feeling of "fear" and the spectators think that if they follow the same idealism, they have to suffer like Mr. Nath as the world is not run by ideal view but one should be practical. So Tendulkar, brings classical Hamartia at the end. A woman crying does not have so much impact because the audience expects it, but a man crying can just destroy mental peace and "Kanyadaan" becomes an amazing play, with amazing script.

VIJAY TENDULKAR BIOGRAPHY

Biography

Birth Name:	Vijay Tendulkar
Date Of Birth:	Vijay Tendulkar is a leading contemporary Indian playwright, screen and television writer, literary essayist, political journalist, and social commentator.

Vijay Dhondopant Tendulkar was born on January 6, 1928 in a Bhalavalikar Saraswat brahmin family in Kolhapur, Maharashtra[citation needed], where his father held a clerical job and ran a small publishing business. The literary environment at home prompted young Vijay to take up writing. He wrote his first story at age six.

He grew up watching western plays, and felt inspired to write plays himself. At age eleven, he wrote, directed, and acted in his first play.

At age 14, he participated in the 1942 Indian freedom movement, leaving his studies. The latter alienated him from his family and friends. Writing then became his outlet, though most of his early writings were of a personal nature, and not intended for publication.

Vijay Tendulkar was a leading Indian playwright, movie and television writer, literary essayist, political journalist, and social commentator primarily in Marāthi. He is best known for his plays, Shantata! Court Chalu Aahe (1967), Ghāshirām Kotwāl (1972), and Sakhārām Binder (1972).Many of Tendulkar's plays derived inspiration from real-life incidents or social upheavals, which provides clear light on harsh realities. He provided his guidance to students studying “Playwright writing” in US universities. For over five decades, Tendulkar had been a highly influential dramatist and theater personality in Mahārāshtra.

Vijay Tendulkar died in Pune on May 19, 2008, after five weeks at the Prayag Hospital battling the effects of myasthenia gravis.

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Vijay Tendulkar's *Kanyadaan*: A Journey from Ignorance to Experience

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Vijay Tendulkar's seminal play 'Kanyadaan' is a ruthless criticism of this caste-ridden Indian society.But what is interesting is that Tendulkar highlights here caste system,rather he pinpoints how all attempts of social amelioration prove fruitless in our progressive post independent society.This article shows the predicament of Nath Devalikar,the protagonist of this drama when he confronts hazards in real life in his effort to abolish caste system.Side by side with this 'dalit' and 'elite' issue, this play also shows foolishness of a theorist who keeps his daughter's life at stake to prove the supremacy of his theory.The play also obliquely hints at the pathetic condition of women in a patriarchal society.

Vijay Tendulkar belongs to those avant- guarde group of dramatists who can represent reality as it is. His plays become sharp criticism of Indian society and the condition of women in such patriarchal society. They also deal with the complexity of human relationships. Each of his plays contains a subtle critique of modern Indian society ,and a distinct character and message. 'Kanyadaan' explores the texture of modernity and social change in India through marriage between two people of different castes and backgrounds. It shows that what we assume as social and cultural progress in modern India ,is nothing but a big hoax the play entitled ' Kanyadaan' alludes to the traditional hindu custom of marriage in our society-to give a marrigable daughter by one's guardian to an eligible young man who will give her safety and security in life.It is also desired that the young man will prove himself a constant companion of this woman Naturally it concerns much to the bride's father about her daughter's post-marriage life. The play 'Kanyadaan' is also about marriage, marriage between two persons belonging to different cultures. the dramatist shows that to obliterate caste system, to uplift dalit community ,such an inter-caste marriage can never be a solution.

The play opens in Nath Devalikar's house where we meet Nath,an idealist Gandhi supporter and an active social worker as well as an MLA is rebuking the irregular transport system of post-independent India.From the beginning,it becomes clear that Nath is very much idealistic.He is the father of Jyoti and Jayaprakash-who are also nurtured by Nath's idealistic philosophy.His philosophy is also based on democracy-both in thought and deeds.This progressive person hates casteism and he takes an active part to eradicate this social evil and to cause dalit upliftment.Nath's wife Seva is also an active social worker who works for the upliftment of women's causes in society.

Nurtured in this situation , when Jyoti expresses her desire to marry Arun Athavale, a dalit boy whom she has known for three months, Nath's happy family gets a sudden jolt. The family becomes divided in two opposite groups-one comprising Nath

Devalikar the idealist-reformist who dreams of changing this caste- ridden society with his daughter Jyoti as a soldier.Nath is naturally very elated as he declares in actI scene II, "Seva , until today, 'Break the caste system was a mere slogan for us.I've attended many inter caste marriages and made speeches. But today I have broken the caste barrier in the real sense….Today I have changed.''Nath's fervent zeal gets a jolt from his wife Seva and son Jayaprakash who feel apprehended of Jyoti'sdisastrous future after her marriage with that dalit boy.Actually Nath,in the halo of romantic illusion overlooks his concern and responsibility as a father.To quote the critic,=. By encouraging his daughter to be an experimental guinea-pig in the dalit uplift experiment'Nath betrays his monumental ego and sense of superiority as an intervener in the fate of the dalits as represented by Arun and women as represented by his daughter.

Almost all the speeches concerning Jyoti's marriage made by Nath Devalikar in actI is steeped in irony,which reveals that he is a dreamer to whom his daughter becomes a scapegoat.Seva as an active worker engaged in women upliftment,is very realistic and for this she strongly opposes Jyoti's marriage outside the territory of her cultural periphery.She bursts out,''I will oppose this marriage .In your words I shall break party discipline and revolt. Does Jyoti's revolt seem sensible to you.Tell me as a father,hand on heart.' Inspite of repeated warnings from his family ' Nath describes Arun 'as a human being he has potential.He has intelligence,drive and creativity……He is like unrefined gold,he needs to be melted and moulded.This is the need of the hour. Who can perform this task if not girls like Jyoti=
''He gives courage and support ,''Istand by you.Go ahead my child,let us see what happens.'' Nath's lack of fore-sightedness ultimately recoils back him .From here also begins his journey from ignorance to experience.

Arun Athavale, as projected from the beginning is a strong fellow both in body and mind.As a dalit boy having a poor financial and so-called backward 'cultural'background, he is supra sensuously conscious about his existence ,about his being a .He is a stubborn fellow who refuses culture and nurture. He is direct as he has no cultural pretensions.

His poetic self is also the product of his spontaneity.When his proposed wife's mother asks him about his financial condition in their very first meeting, he quickly understands her pricks and retorts her by talking about their traditional livelihood of illicit liquor –selling only to hurt Seva's culture.His manners and conversation with Seva, Jayaprakash and Nath prove his deep-rooted abhorrence for elite society and their culture.At the end of actI,virtually it becomes a confrontation of two cultures ,one elite and dignified ,another dalit and neglected.

The dramatist neatly divides the drama in two acts. If the actI is the representation of Nath Devalikar's deep-rooted idealism, his dream of social upliftment and his ignorance ,actIIshows the disastrous result of his ignorance.It depicts his excruciating pain and it becomes a saga of his failure. In actII, sceneI,we see Jyoti'no longer a joyous , happy married girl;but an experienced,=older' woman who bears the burden of his marriage submissively. Seva,as a mother is totally despaired of his consequence and tries io move his daughter against this unhappy marriage. She repeatedly bursts out against Jyoti's submissiveness to Arun,but Jyoti refuses to give in to her mother. Nath, Jyoti's father is also worried about Jyoti's present situation,but the dreamer in him cannot cast off his long-cherished idealism. Nath, the father cannot

separate himself from Nath the progressive party-worker, from Nath the democrat who believes in equality as he says ,''The values I uphold in my public I live by in my personal life. ''Like a responsible father, he offers Jyoti to stay in his home with Arun, only to prevent abuses and physical tortures done to his darling daughter. But Jyoti refuses to stay and inspite of her decision to leave Arun forever, when Arun comes to to her house and shows love theatrically before her parents,Jyoti leaves her father's house with Arun.It is not for Arun's love,but to give riddance to her family of this uncouth ,dalit ArunJyoti takes this decision. Here also Nath fails to understand his own daughter ignorantly shows her happiness because he thinks that his social experiment of breaking cultural barriers is not going to be failed. This is the reason why elated Nath cries out in joy,'' I feel so proud of you. The training I gave you has not been in vain.''

In sceneII of actII we see Nath reading and praising the autobiographical work written by Arun Athavale.To Nath it is a good specimen of dalit literature written in living language.Nath's enthusiastic praise stands out almost as an indecency against his wife's anxiety and angernat Arun's growing crime against pregnant Jyoti . In the previous act it has been made obvious how Jyoti is being physically and mentally harassed by a sadistic dalit husband.Already Nath's high idealistic notions about social upliftment have begun to get crumbled.Jyoti's pain and suffering makes Nath annoyed and distressed as a father.Meanwhile Jayaprakash,Nath's son informs his father about the Palestinian guerillas and attack continued on them by Israeli forces.These Israelists who were once beaten down is now launching fresh attacks on others.This is an eye opening incident because even the tortured people do not discard evil and violence.Rather they want to take revenge done to them by attacking others.If Arun- Jyoti incident and their unhappy marriage, Arun's violence and torture is microcosmic;attack of Isareli forces against the Palestinian guerillas are macrocosmic. Actually ,there is no progress and cultural upliftment in our civilization.

Very soon, Arun Athavale comes to invite his father-in-law in his book-launching ceremony.The way he invites his father-in-law in boastful manners is highly indicative of Arun's selfishness,his bestiality,who wants to aggrendize on elite sympathy to cater his personal needs.His language is that of a first–rate blackmailer with potential threatening.Arun's arrival makes Nath 'tense' and in disgust, he avoids eye contact with him. After Arun's departure, Nath becomes enraged and he bursts out against Arun's hypocrisy .What seemed to him true in actI, turned false before his own eyes. His hysterical cry "I was nauseated by his overweening arrogance. And he's the same man who wrote that autobiography….his visit has polluted this drawing room ,this house, and this day…It stinks….This furniture, this floor…all this …he has made them filthy, dirty, polluted! Why did I have to come into contact with a man like this?" Arun,far from being a representative character of dalit community 'emerges as a 'Machiavellian character eager to capitalize on the high tide of Dalit sympathy both in personal and intellectual fronts.'

Jyoti's mother,Seva Devalikar though never supports Jyoti for marrying Arun and bearing all pains silently still requests Nath to preside Arun's book-publishing ceremony. Her desire as a mother to see Jyoti as a happily wedded girl drives her here, because she is more practical. Her active participation in women's causes has made her mature. Following her advice, Nath attends the inaugural ceremony of Arun's autobiography and delivers speech which is nothing but hollow, rhetorical outburst. Nath

confesses before her wife and son that what he has done, done only to save her daughter's life. He knows well '…this kind of hypocrisy marks a rank opportunist. That book is no autobiography; it is pulp fiction based on half truths.[Taking a deep breadth.] No. Not all dalits can be like that. Nath goes through tremendous mental anxiety and a hopeless ,disillusioned father ,makes his son cautious not to follow his father's idealism' Jayaprakash, do me a favour. Reject your father. Learn to see through his naivete and idiocy. Don't ever rely on his wisdom.'

Tendulkar identifies the character of Nath Devalikar with himself. 'Nath Devalikar 'the protagonist of 'Kanyadaan' is me and many other liberals of my generation whom I understand completely. The pain of these people today ,the defeat they have suffered ,the fundamental mental confusion and naivete that had led to their pain and defeat, these form the theme of 'Kanyadaan', and I wrote about it because it came so close to me.'(VT104).

But it is not only Nath's mental confusion, his ignorance about dalit mentality and his naivete which are responsible for his tragedy; rather he has some inherent drawbacks also. Nath is an enthusiast ,a detached reformist who feels and boasts of his superiority of being a Brahmin and takes it as a social duty to uplift dalit community. His social experimentation as a reformist brings ruin to his family. Even his daughter who has hero-worshipped him turns against her father and finally denunciates his naïve, impractical wisdom.

Jyoti demands straight answer from his father for delivering such a hypocritical speech. Nath tries to patch up the matter by saying, "You are making a mistake .I don't hate Arun, I hate only those tendencies.. .'' Angry Jyoti retorts ''Tendencies! I grew up listening to such talk day in and day out. All false, vicious claptrap.''

She makes his father face to face with open reality. She further accuses her father of making them crippled from childhood by his ineffective theory. Raw experiences with reality make her acutely conscious of the fact that divinity and bestiality are inseparable. Putting man's beastliness to sleep and awakening the godhead within is an absurd notion. You make me waste twenty years of my life before I could discover it.'' Jyoti accuses her father also as a hypocrite and brings him in the same line as Arun Athavale, her hyposrite dalit husband. Jyoti's final breakdown reminds us of Louisa in Dickens' 'Hard Times' ,because in both cases ,their father's wrong philosophical attitude to life have destroyed their lives.

'Kanyadaan' is thus a deeply pessimistic play about the wrong philosophy of an ineffectual dreamer. Being puffed up by false romantic notions and by 'unworldly Gandhian viewpoints on the Harijan', he destroys his daughter's life. Jyoti arrives her true womanhood rejecting her father's wrong philosophy and accepting life as it is. Tendulkar has been awarded Saraswati Samman for this play, because this play extols reality and nothing but reality, however crude it is.

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"Kanyadan" by Vijay Tendulkar – A Drama Highlights the Class-Divide

By Anonymous (not verified) on Mon, 2009-11-30 03:43

If we talk about the modern Indian drama, the contributions of the playwrights like Mohan Rakesh in Hindi, Badal Sirkar in Bengali, Vijay Tendulkar in Marathi, and Girish Karnad in Kannad are remarkable.

Vijay Tendulkar is a prolific writer. Twenty eight long plays are to his credit. He has written several one-act plays as well as children plays. He often portrays socio-political problems in his dramas. In "Kanyadan", he depicts the conflict between the upper-class and Dalit. He criticizes the politicians on the base that rather than removing the evil of class-distinction, they capitalize it. He presents this evil as it is. He certainly arouses some questions in our mind but he does not bother to answer them. As a creative genius, he does not take side!

As the title suggest, "Kanyadan" deals with the theme of marriage. The problem and the consequences of the marriage Vijay Tendulkar shows is self-created. Nath Devlalikar is an MLA and his wife Seva is a social worker. Jayprakash is an M. Sc. student and Jyoti is an intelligent girl. This Brahmin family belongs to the upper-class.

The play is divided into two acts. In the first scene of the first act, Jyoti informs her parents her decision to marry Arun Athavle, a Dalit youth. Seva is shocked to know it but Nath is relaxed and happy inside because he wants to remove the class-system which is his dream. He consents Jyoti to get married with Arun, whom she knew for the last two months!

Nath wants to experiment with this marriage, which is a sort of political act. In the second scene of the act one, Jyoti brings Arun, who is dark Dalit youth doing his B. A. Jyoti is very much interested in his poetry and his autobiography. Arun feels uncomfortable in "big houses" and gets nervous and finally leaves home. What Jayaprakash and Seva most is Arun's intention to brew liquor in order to survive, if not anything remain.

In the first scene of the second act, Jyoti arrives perplexed and looking unhappy. Then Arun follows, rather drunk. He asks for Jyoti's forgiveness as he had beaten her. Jyoti leaves with him again. At this juncture also, Nath does not want his dream to get broken before his eyes though he's aware of the plight of his own daughter.

In the second scene of the act two, Arun's autobiography gets published in which he is dealing with the theme of oppression and miserable condition of the poor – the lower class. But the irony is that Arun himself exploits Jyoti and lives as a parasite on her. Though Jyoti is pregnant, he makes her work at home. His ill-treatment to Jyoti is a kind of answer back from the Dalits to the upper-class.

Arun asks Nath to deliver a public speech on his autobiography but he refuses to do so. But looking at the plight of his daughter, in the final scene of the second act, Nath gives a hypocrite speech by praising Arun's autobiography against his will. Nath wants to prevent Jyoti from further annoyance, but Jyoti does not tolerate this and she leaves home for forever. At the end, Nath, the idealist is turned into Nath the realist. He says at the end in rage that the entrance of such dalit (Arun) has polluted his home. That is how the drama ends with Jyoti's departure never to come back at the Nath's home.

The end of the drama leaves a question in the readers mind as to what is the future of Jyoti's marriage? The marriage does not succeed. It is suggested that the class-divide and the conflict between the upper-class and the Dalit would continue to remain, which is very sad!

Read:
(Kanyadaan by Vijay Tendulkar, Gowri Ramnarayan (Translator); Publisher: Oxford University Press, USA (August 15, 1996), Hardcover: 80 pages, ISBN-13: 978-0195638646)

Biography

Rakesh Patel (b, May 2, 1979) has a Masters degree in English literature from The Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda, India. He has served as a part-time/visiting lecturer in English for the past three years at two different Govt. Arts & Commerce Colleges of Gujarat, India. He has

been writing poems in free verse, the author of two self-published poetry books, contributing to various online poets' community websites, and also serving as an active Platinum member for EzineArticles.com.

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Features

Inter-Caste Marriage and the Liberal Imagination Vijay Tendulkar's KANYADAAN

Ania Loomba

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(This paper discusses the depiction of inter-caste marriage in Vijay Tendulkar's controversial play KANYADAAN (1983), which has enjoyed a recent revival both in India and abroad. Responses to the play have been split largely along caste lines, with upper-caste audiences and critics regarding it as an expose of liberal reformism, and dalits either ignoring it or regarding its depiction of dalit masculinity as offensive. But few have commented on how the play pits its version of female agency against a particular vision of dalit masculinity. This paper sets the play in the context of Tendulkar's particular engagement with Dalit Panther literature, but argues that it also speaks to ongoing debates on sexual violence and on the literary representation of transgressive passion. It shows how KANYADAAN both unravels and embodies the most troubled aspects of the relationship between caste and gender in postcolonial India.)

It is very hard not to react strongly, even violently, to Vijay Tendulkar's 1983 Marathi play KANYADAAN, a controversial, explosive depiction of an inter-caste marriage that has had a continuous history of performance, and seen a recent English-language revival in India and abroad. Its dalit anti- hero, Arun Athawale, has married Jyoti Devalikar, a brahmin woman. Arun is foul-mouthed and violent; he is increasingly abusive towards Jyoti, even during her pregnancy, but she stays committed to him, ultimately turning her back on her own family in order to do so. In response to him, various upper-caste characters in the play articulate the idea that dalits inhabit a different 'culture', a culture shaped by dalit histories of dis- possession but one that cannot, nevertheless, be easily changed. Written at the end of a particularly important decade of dalit activism during which dalit intellectuals and activists had themselves insistently articulated the idea of dalit 'difference' in order to demand equality and justice, the play seemed to both echo and subvert the language of dalit self-assertion.

It is hardly surprising that dalit intellectuals and others reacted negatively to the play. In 1988, when Tendulkar was inaugurating at the All India Dalit Drama Convention, a dalit writer hurled a sandal at the playwright.[1] But Tendulkar was also criticised from the opposite direction: one commentator in a mainstream English-language newspaper pronounced that he should have 'known better' than to try and 'rationalise' Arun's brutishness.[2] KANYADAAN had a robust stage life, how- ever, and eventually won the Saraswati Samman award; Tendulkar confessed that he was 'confused' by the award, since the play was 'not the story of a victory; it is the admis- sion of defeat and intellectual confusion. It gives expression to a deep-rooted malaise and its pains'.[3]

Today, viewers and critics continue to be hotly divided in their responses to the play. Many tend to see KANYADAAN as a powerful critique of liberal reformism (embodied by the father Nath) but for others, the play itself embodies the hypocrisy of such reformism. Some viewers cringe from its portrayal of Arun, but others continue to see that depiction as necessary for the play's take on the ideology of marriage. We can see these divisions as indexing various stances on caste politics itself, and even dismiss defences of the play as evidence of continuing casteism. But whatever our conclusions, the play obviously reverberates with long-standing debates about domestic and sexual violence, and about how such violence is raised in the context of dalit men. As such, it is worth paying careful atten- tion to its depiction of inter-caste marriage, and its polarisation of female agency against dalit masculinity. Comparisons have been made between the depiction of caste in KANYADAAN and theatrical representations of blackness and race, a subject which is also worth thinking about, given ongoing debates about the relationship between race and caste.

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Irony of Kanyadaan in Inter- Caste Marriage in Vijay Tendulkar's *Kanyadaan*

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Abstract

Division of society on the basis of caste and class is a prevalent phenomena in today's world. The gulf between the higher class and lower class is difficult to fill. The more the efforts are made to bridge this gap the wider it becomes. Present paper highlights this fact very aptly. Serious and deep study of Vijay Tendular's *Kanyadaan* has been conducted and sincere efforts are made to highlight this fact by presenting the disasterous effects of inter caste marriage of a Brahmin girl Jyoti with a dalit boy Arun. In the effort to bring social equality a father sacrifices his daughter's life considering this marriage a social experiment.

Keywords: inter caste marriage, social equality, class conflict, hollow ideals, scavenger, Brahmin, untouchable.

"But for the sake of the prosperity of the worlds he caused the Brahmana, the Kshatriya, the Vaisya, and the Sudra to proceed from his mouth, his arms, his thighs, and his feet".(The Ordinances of Manu, CH-1, 31)

The first ever reference regarding the varna system is found in the Rigveda, which says that Brahman becomes Purusha's mouth, kshatriyas become arms, vaishyas become his thighs and shudra his legs.

The Manu of Manusmriti who is the originator of class and caste differences is still alive in contemporary India. The suppressed and down trodden are still treated as untouchables and

are expelled from the main society. The suffering of these low caste people has increased to an alarming stage that writers have taken up pen in hands to express their pain and sufferings. One of the endemic and most prevalent feature of our society is class consciousness. Tendulkar through his play *Kanyadaan* probes deep into Indian caste-psychology and highlights the complications, conflicts and tension in relationships between higher class and socially outcaste untouchables. Even today this wide disturbing gap can be seen between the high class and low class people. Though efforts have been made time to time by reformers to bridge this gap but all their works and efforts to bring social equality went in vain.

According to Loomba, "The upper caste audience and critics regarded the play as an expose of liberal reformism, whereas the dalit intelligentia and audience either ignored the play or read it as an appropriation and stereotyping of dalit masculinity, which in turn is termed offensive." (Loomba, 101-102)

This concept in the play is presented by the relationship between a dalit boy Arun and a Brahmin girl Jyoti, which forms the theme of the play *Kanyadaan*. It is a play not about domestic violence but about some deeper, multiple and sometimes invisible layers of violence that are the integral part of the so called civilized society. It is the story of the intercaste marriage of a Brahmin girl Jyoti and a dalit boy Arun, who with his uncivilized inhumane ways sets his wife's life on torture. It is the most controversial play in which the characters fall a prey to their own hollow idealism, showing how a father's idealistic principles become the cause of misery for his own daughter.

According to Arundhati Banerjee, Tendulkar has presented the burning social question of untouchability through intellectual confusion. She rightly remarks:

"Tendulkar is highly realistic not only in the delineation of characters and human relationships but in the depiction of the setting in which these characters enact the drama of their lives."(Banerjee, 1992. p xv)

In the play the Brahmin girl Jyoti, the adult daughter of Nath Deolalkar and Seva, the two committed social activists, decides to marry a dalit boy Arun, whom she meets in college and is very much influenced and impressed by his poetry. As she has been brought up in an atmosphere filled with Gandhian principles, the values and ideals of secularism are inculcated into her blood by her idealistic father. Thus, she is not affected by Arun being him a lower class guy and she decides to marry him. Nath, her father is very much impressed and thrilled by his daughters decision because it will highlight his public image as a secular Hindu

Brahmin, who has no objection in marrying his daughter to a well educated dalit boy, who is also a budding poet. But on the contrary, Jyoti's brother Jayprakash and her mother Seva who too is a social activist does not approve this marriage and tries her best to warn her about the risks involved. But because Jyoti gets the support of her father she marries Arun and later on faces the evil consequences of her hastily taken decision as feared by her mother. Nath is not thinking from the absolute side of a father but is thinking from the point of view of a politician for whom his integrity as a public advocate of intercaste marriage and casteless society is on test. Whereas Seva becomes tensed and serious on this decision and tries to convince Jyoti that decisions about life must not be made so lightly. In marriage, they have to look for some kind of stability and compatibility in lifestyles. But Nath disagrees with Seva.

NATH: Lifestyles can certainly be changed. And the ideal of stability can be different for every man.(508)

However Seva disagrees on this marriage because she is conscious about the evil consequences that may follow. Being a mother she express her worries that could make her daughter's life a living hell.

SEVA: My anxiety is not over his being a dalit. You know very well that Nath and I have been fighting untouchability tooth and nail, God knows since when. So that's not the issue. But your life has been patterned in a certain manner. You have been brought up in a specific culture. To erase or to change all this over night is just not possible. He is different in every way. You may not be able to handle it.(509)

In Act one, scene one, Arun's encounter with Jyoti's family is presented. But both of them are like poles apart. Where on one hand civilization and culture are the mirrors in which Nath's family sees its face, on the other hand Arun is quite unaware of these two terms. Arun does not know how to control his reactions according to the environment. Though he is a talented poet and writer, he does not want to imbibe in himself the cultures and manners of the middle class people. This deep rooted concept of difference between the civilized and the barbaric behavior induces serious conflicts and tension in the play. Arun was habitual of small houses where he felt comfort amongst the low class people but for him city houses appeared like the huge bellies of sharks and crocodiles.

ARUN: If you see y father's hut you'll understand. Ten of us, big and small, lived in that eight feet by ten feet. The heat of our bodies to warm us in winter. No clothes on our back, no food in our stomach, but we felt very safe. Here, these damn houses of city people, they're

like the bellies of sharks and crocodiles, each one alone in them... As for me, I feel safe on the street. The bigger the crowds, the safer I feel... Our grandfathers and great grandfathers used to roam barefoot, miles and miles, in the heat, in the rain, day and night… till the rags on their butt fell apart….Our tongues always tasting the flesh of dead animals, and with relish! Surely we can't fit into your unwrinkled Tinopal world. (512-513)

Arun knows very well that it is difficult for Jyoti to adjust in his world and he asks Jyoti if she really wants to marry Arun and will she be able to adopt the ways of dalit life.

ARUN: Will you marry me and eat stinking bread with spoilt dal in my father's hut? Without vomiting? Tell me, Jyoti, can you shit everyday in our slum's village toilet like my mother? Can you beg, qaking at every door, for a little grass for our buffaloes? Come on, tell me… Our life is not the Socialists' service camp. It is hell, and I mean hell. A hell named life.(513-514)

Arun however was an educated boy but being a dalit he and his ancestors had faced so much tortures that he was not able to accept the middle class ways and life. When Seva asked Arun about his financial stability he gets irritated and loses control and insults Seva.

ARUN: It is a first class profession for two persons. The man bribes the police and the wife serves the customers. People call her aunty. The more striking the aunty's looks, the brisker the trade… (517)

When Jyoti tries to control the tensed situation Arun scolds her too.

ARUN: (Abruptly) You don't know a shit. Shut up.(517)

Jyoti gets confused about her marriage decision and Seva too denys for this marriage but Nath being a socialist first and a father second, did not want to delay this marriage. He wanted to practice the gandhian principles and ideals practically in his life because he thought that charity starts at home.

NATH: Until today, 'Break the caste system' was a mere slogan for us… But today I've broken the caste barrier in the real sense. My home has become Indian in the real sense of the term. (519)

However Jyoti's mother disagrees to Nath, and then Nath again speaks about his principles and ideals. Here Nath considers this marriage an experiment which could bring social equality.

NATH: Look , Seva, society cannot be transformed through words alone. We have to act as a catalyst in this transformation. The old social reformers did not stop with making speeches

and writing articles on widow remarriage. Many of them actually married widows. Why did they do it…? That was also an experiment, a difficult experiment. But they dared to risk it. (524)

Nath is of the belief that social environment can bring change in persons behavior and calls Arun an unrefined piece of gold that needs to be polished and refined.

NATH: He is like unrefined gold, he needs to be melted and moulded. (527)

Wadikar rightly remarks, "Jyoti and Arun get married, but what follows is a sequence of violence, misery and disillusionment". (Wadikar, 26)

But we find from Arun's behavior towards Jyoti and Nath's family that Arun being a dalit was not ready to accept the refined and cultured manners of middle class people. He after marriage used to come home drunk, used to torture, beat and abuse Jyoti and speak ill of Jyoti's parents. In fact we can say Arun was taking the revenge of the tortures done to his forefathers by punishing Jyoti. Jyoti could not tolerate this barbaric behavior and returns home.

JYOTI: I must tell you, Bhai, I must. I am fed up with him. Fed up! Fed up!(535)

But Nath still wants to save this marriage and was firm on his ideals and principles. Nath was thinking from the view of a socialist first and a father second and we can say that to fulfil his desire of social equality he sacrificed his daughter on the altar of his socio-political ideologies and principles.

NATH: Seva, let not this wonderful experiment fail! This dreawhich is struggling to turn real, let it not crumble it to dust before our eyes! We will have to do something. We must save this marriage. Not necessarily for our Jyoti's sake… This is not just a question of our daughter's life, Seva, this has… a far wider significance… this experiment is a very precious experiment. (537)

By presenting this marriage Tendulkar does not want to show the reformation of independent India but the play is a study of psyche of dalit. He has drilled deep into the dalit psyche in this play. He himself says:

"As a writer I feel fascinated by the violent exploited- exploiter relationship and obsessively delve deep into it instead of taking a position against it. That takes me to a point where I feel that this relationship is eternal, a fact of life however cruel, and will never end. Not that I relish this thought while it grips me but I cannot shake it off."(Tendulkar, 1992)

Reformation is very difficult infact impossible because dalits are not ready to leave their deep rooted lifestyle. Any effort made by the higher class for their upliftment seems to them like treachery or hipocricy. It is impossible for them to live life without drinking and abusing, without beatings and quarrels. Jyoti is not used to such barbaric behavior and to her it appears unnatural but forerun it was an integral part of his personality.

ARUN: When have I claimed that I am civilized and cultured like you people? From childhood I have seen my father come home drunk every day, and beat my mother half dead, seen her cry her heart out……. What am I but the son of scavengers. We don't know the non violent ways of Brahmins like you. We drink and beat our wives… we make love to them……. I am what I am…and shall remain exactly that. And your Jyoti knew what I was even before she married me. (540)

In act two scene two when Arun's autobiography gets published, Nath is very much impressed by that beautiful piece of work where Arun had penned down the humiliations he has undergone with extraordinary sensitivity. However Seva is angry and is not pleased with Arun's attitude towards Jyoti. She calls Arun a hypocrite.

SEVA: I will say that in this excellent book, whatever the author has said about injustice and exploitation is hypocricy of first order. Because this man himself exploits my daughter. Like a shameless parasite, he lives on my daughter's blood, and on top of that he gets drunk and bashes her up. Constantly he taunts her about her caste and about her parents, heaping foul abuse on them for being highborn. (545)

According to Seva when she came to know that pregnant Jyoti was been kicked in the belly by Arun and is in hospital due to internal bleeding she concludes that Arun misbehaves with Jyoti because she belongs to a high class Brahmin family. And as in past dalits have faced many tortures by upper caste people, Arun is taking their revenge from Jyoti and thus with the whole Brahmin caste.

SEVA: In this way he is returning all the kicks aimed at generations of his ancestors, by men of high caste. It appears that this is the monumental mission he has set out to fulfill. (544)

Jayprakash too speaks in favour of his mother Seva concluding that yesterday's victim is today's victimizer.

JAYAPRAKASH: In other words, yesterday's victim is today's victimizer. If he has been shot at yesterday, he shoots us today… Therefore, there is no hope of a man's gaining nobility through experience, he can only become a greater devil. (547).

Nath is shocked and surprised when he comes to know that Arun kicked Jyoti in her belly when she was pregnant. He bursts in anger and it was difficult for him to believe how could a writer of such a beautiful sentimental autobiography behave so barbaric and in an uncivilized manner.

NATH: Such behavior towards a pregnant wife! What happens if she dies? Such heinous behavior by someone who wrote this beautiful autobiography? How can he? Here in these pages he describes the humiliations he has undergone with extraordinary sensitivity…and the same man kicks his pregnant wife on her belly? How? How dare he do it to her? How dare he? (543)

Nath is so much angry and shocked that he started hating Arun when he came to know that Arun kicked Jyoti in her belly during pregnancy. When Arun comes to Nath's house requesting him to deliver a speech about Arun and his autobiography on his success, Nath denies. Then a new hidden face of Arun can be seen when he blackmails Nath saying that if he would not speak in public speech then anything could happen with Jyoti and people will speak bad about their family relations.

ARUN: But nowadays people have become very smart. They read too much into situations. They make one plus one add up to eleven. They will say that father in law and son in law don't see eye to eye; that I regularly torture your daughter…..the rise of the dalit son in law to literary heights caused heartburn in the upper caste, socialist father in law. (551)

After Arun's departure Nath felt like a helpless father who has become polluted and filthy when he came in Arun's contact. Describing his uneasiness and discomfort he says:

NATH: It stinks. Seva – you know- you see- I feel like taking a bath, like cleaning myself! Clean everything! This furniture, this floor… all this… he has made them filthy, dirty, polluted! (553)

But Seva being a concerned mother insists Nath to give speech on Arun's success because she is worried about Jyoti. She feels that if Nath will not agree to Arun, Jyoti will face the disasterous effects of it. Thus first time Nath felt like a helpless father who has no option left but to obey Arun just for Jyoti's sake. After delivering the speech in praise of Arun's autiobiography he himself feels ashamed of himself because for the first time he spoke what his heart did not permit.

NATH: I did it for the sake of my brave and innocent daughter. What is this compared to her having ruined her whole life for my sake? (557)

Nath now realizes his mistake that he blindly followed his principles and ideals and did not think practically and in his desire to make the dream of social equality come true he destroyed his daughter's life in this experiment.

NATH: I had this maniacal urge to uproot casteism and caste distinctions from our society. As a result I pushed my own daughter into a sea of misery… (557)

Nath is badly broken to the core and is disheartened and accepts that Jyoti's life was destroyed just because she followed her father blindly.

NATH: If she has committed any crime it is this: she took her father's words for gospel truth. She adopted her father's values. She was guided by her father's humanism and liberalism. (558)

"Father feels guilt-conscious thinking that his daughter becomes painful and miserable for having sincerely adopted his scale of values on the path of humanism".(Prasad,100)

But we find that earlier Jyoti used to follow her father blindly and used to trust him like God who could never be wrong. She had full trust in her father's ideals until she had not heard him delivering a fake speech. She breaks down totally and her faith that was firm in her father's teachings begins to shake badly and all her hopes for future died when she saw her idol breaking and giving up infront of circumstances, in front of her eyes. She realizes that her father gave up just because of Jyoti's sake and gets heartbroken on this attitude of his father.

JYOTI: Your speech today was not only lousy, it was a hireling's speech. You attended the meeting against your wishes, you praised that book against your wishes. (562)

Jyoti realizes her father's helplessness and finds her father speaking what his heart is not permitting. Jyoti expresses his anger in her speech towards her father.

JYOTI: In your false, deceitful speech! I know what you really wanted to say. I heard what you were unable to say. Whenever your eyes fell on him, they dripped poison. After the meeting he tried to see you, and I saw how you ignored the man you hold in such high esteem!....in your heart there's just hatered for Arun and nothing else.(563)

Jyoti blames her father for not telling her the full truth, for giving his children the false teaching of hollow principles and ideals. She considers her father responsible somehow for destroying Jyoti's life. If her father would have given him true practical knowledge not based on hollow gandhian ideals then her life would have been much easier.

JYOTI: It is essential to awaken the god slumbering in man… All false, vicious claptrap! The truth is, you knew very well that man and his inherent nature are never really two different things. Both are one, and inseparable. And either you accept it in totality, or you reject it if you can… putting man's beastliness to sleep, and awakening the godhead within is an absurd notion. You made me waste my twenty years of life before I could discover this. I had to learn it on the strength of my own experience. (563)

Finally Jyoti has realized the truth that all the ideals that her father taught her were hollow and without a solid practical base. She is now fully aware of the fact that her love can never change Arun.

JYOTI: Arun is both the beast, and a lover. Arun is the demon, and also the poet. Both are bound together, one within the other, they are one… Tell me, where is that beast I should drag out and destroy, where is that god I should rouse from his sleep?...Arun is made of all these things bound together and I have to accept him as he is, because I cannot reject him. (564)

Jyoti decides finally to accept her life like a dalit man's wife and face the circumstances bravely.

JYOTI: It was you who always taught us that it is cowardly to bow down to circumstances…..we cannot run away….. we shall continue to recite March on, Oh soldier!..and continue to lose our lives as guinea pigs in the experiment. (565)

She at the end screams in anger, walking out of the house she was born in, effectively cutting away from her roots and parents and breaks the relation ties with Nath family calling herself dalit scavenger and bids aideu to the family.

JYOTI: I am not Jyoti Yadunath Devlalikar now, I am Jyoti Arun Athavale, a scavenger… I am an untouchable, a scavenger…Don't touch me. Fly from my shadow, otherwise my fire will scorch your comfortable values. (566)

Talking about the play, Sarath Babu comments on Jyoti's situation:

"Jyoti thus becomes mindless and surrenders to the situation. She like her father plays the Rescurer while Arun plays the victim. Her rescuing, at first, makes him behave more helplessly and then triggers his feelings of inferiority. Consequently, he shifts to thereof prosecutor in order to feel powerful….Jyoti goes down to the role of victim. Thus the Rescuer-victim transaction. This Drama Triangle make not only Jyoti but also Arun mindless

to feel powerful. The unreal idealism of Nath and Jyoti reflects their favourite role of rescuing which impairs their perception of the reality."(Sarath, 1997)

Thus the play explores the issue of dalit's psyche in the post independent India. They are not ready to mingle with the mainstream of the society and want to maintain their identity as dalit only. The efforts made for their upliftment by the higher class seems hypocritical to them because they are unable to forget their intolerable past and this can be seen easily through Arun's character.

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TOPIC: KANYADAAN BY VIJAY TENDULKAR

If we talk about the modern Indian drama, the contributions of the playwrights like Mohan Rakesh in Hindi, Badal Sirkar in Bengali, Vijay Tendulkar in Marathi, and Girish Karnad in Kannad are remarkable.

Vijay Tendulkar is a prolific writer. Twenty eight long plays are to his credit. He has written several one-act plays as well as children plays. He often portrays socio-political problems in his dramas. In "Kanyadan", he depicts the conflict between the upper-class and Dalit. He criticizes the politicians on the base that rather than removing the evil of class-distinction, they capitalize it. He presents this evil as it is. He certainly arouses some questions in our mind but he does not bother to answer them. As a creative genius, he does not take side!

As the title suggest, "Kanyadan" deals with the theme of marriage. The problem and the consequences of the marriage Vijay Tendulkar shows is self-created. Nath Devlalikar is an MLA and his wife Seva is a social worker. Jayprakash is an M. Sc. student and Jyoti is an intelligent girl. This Brahmin family belongs to the upper-class.

The play is divided into two acts. In the first scene of the first act, Jyoti informs her parents her decision to marry Arun Athavle, a Dalit youth. Seva is shocked to know it but Nath is relaxed and happy inside because he wants to remove the class-system which is his dream. He consents Jyoti to get married with Arun, whom she knew for the last two months!

Nath wants to experiment with this marriage, which is a sort of political act. In the second scene of the act one, Jyoti brings Arun, who is dark Dalit youth doing his B. A. Jyoti is very much interested in his poetry and his autobiography. Arun feels uncomfortable in "big houses" and gets nervous and finally leaves home. What Jayaprakash and Seva most is Arun's intention to brew liquor in order to survive, if not anything remain.

In the first scene of the second act, Jyoti arrives perplexed and looking unhappy. Then Arun follows, rather drunk. He asks for Jyoti's forgiveness as he had beaten her. Jyoti leaves with him again. At this juncture also, Nath does not want his dream to get broken before his eyes though he's aware of the plight of his own daughter.

In the second scene of the act two, Arun's autobiography gets published in which he is dealing with the theme of oppression and miserable condition of the poor – the lower class. But the irony is that Arun himself exploits Jyoti and lives as a parasite on her. Though Jyoti is pregnant, he makes her work at home. His ill-treatment to Jyoti is a kind of answer back from the Dalits to the upper-class.

Arun asks Nath to deliver a public speech on his autobiography but he refuses to do so. But looking at the plight of his daughter, in the final scene of the second act, Nath gives a hypocrite speech by praising Arun's autobiography against his will. Nath wants to prevent Jyoti from further annoyance, but Jyoti does not tolerate this and she leaves home for forever. At the end, Nath, the idealist is turned into Nath the realist. He says at the end in rage that the entrance of such dalit (Arun) has polluted his home. That is how the drama ends with Jyoti's departure never to come back at the Nath's home.

The end of the drama leaves a question in the readers mind as to what is the future of Jyoti's marriage? The marriage does not succeed. It is suggested that the class-divide and the conflict between the upper-class and the Dalit would continue to remain, which is very sad!

To Wordsworth

POEM BY PERCY BYSSHE SHELLEY

Poet of Nature, thou hast wept to know
That things depart which never may return:
Childhood and youth, friendship and love's first glow,
Have fled like sweet dreams, leaving thee to mourn.
These common woes I feel. One loss is mine
Which thou too feel'st, yet I alone deplore.
Thou wert as a lone star, whose light did shine
On some frail bark in winter's midnight roar:
Thou hast like to a rock-built refuge stood
Above the blind and battling multitude:
In honoured poverty thy voice did weave
Songs consecrate to truth and liberty,—
Deserting these, thou leavest me to grieve,
Thus having been, that thou shouldst cease to be.

In a close reading of Percy B. Shelley's poem "To Wordsworth" a reader can learn that Wordsworth was more than just a poet of nature. Wordsworth was a voice of truth when his followers needed him within the expansion of the Republican Party within France. When Wordsworth, then, abandons his work later in exchange for a nicer lifestyle Shelley writes this poem in response. The diction of the poem "To Wordsworth" conveys both sadness and bitterness. However, through his playing with the Shakespearian Sonnet form and use of both common and high language Shelley denotes the greatness of Wordsworth. By denoting him Shelley then proves that he and other former followers can move on without Wordsworth.

The poem, in effect, reads like a eulogy at first. There are many moments where the reader believes that the Wordsworth that Shelley is writing about is gone with the ending line, "thou leavest me to grieve… that thou shoudst cease to be" (Shelley lines 13-14). In an initial reading there is a feeling of Shelley reminiscing about what use to be. Wordsworth use to have the same feelings as Shelley did about youthfulness of "childhood and youth, friendship and love's first glow" (Shelley line 3). These were common emotions felt by Shelley and the Wordsworth of his memory. This Wordsworth was described by Shelley as a "star" who would shine on those who were failing about in the darkness. The past Wordsworth was a "refuge" for those who were struggling even while he himself was within "poverty." The past Wordsworth was about "truth and liberty," but he has "cease to be." The old Wordsworth was something to behold in accordance to an initial reading of Shelley's poem, however this isn't really the case.

Let's begin an analysis with Shelley's use of high and low language between the addressing of Wordsworth and himself. There are nine moments, aside from the poem's title itself, where Shelley speaks to Wordsworth directly. The poem begins with the address of "Poet of Nature," which is literally setting this poem up as a letter. It is also establishing Wordsworth as a product of his work and not as a

person; we only see Wordsworth as a poet. Also, throughout this poem, Shelley uses words such as “thou,” “thy,” and “thee” in referring to Wordsworth whereas he uses “I,” “mine,” and “me” in reference to himself. This accent establishes a formality between himself and the nature poet who is now a man of ‘high-art.’ This formality is one of class hierarchy because of tone of voice shifting between the reserved term of ‘thou’ and the relaxed term of ‘I.’ Placing formality onto the character of Wordsworth makes him out to be more of someone readers have to look up to instead of someone whom we are inspired by. In contrast, Shelley places himself with the common man by referring to himself within the common diction. Shelley even calls himself a ‘frail bark in winter’s midnight roar,’ which gives an image of someone just floating around in the darkness trying to find light, whereas Wordsworth was the “rock-built refuge” (Shelley lines 8-9).

This changing of the diction between common friends who welt common woes to one of them being called by formal terms is twisting from friend to deserter (Shelley line 13). This can be later seen in the counter-sublime moment of taking the uniqueness of Wordsworth’s sublime poetry and making it into common ideas. Shelley takes Wordsworth’s ideas of “nature,” “childhood,” “youth,” “friendship,” and “love’s first glow” (Shelley lines 1-2). These are images used by Wordsworth’s poetry in order to convey the sublime. By stripping away its unique qualities Shelley has rendered Wordsworth’s concepts on the intangible as nothing more than simplicity.

This action is a poetic theory that has been called daemonization by Harold Bloom; where Shelley addresses earlier work of Wordsworth within this poem in order to show the reader how ordinary the previous work really is (Harold Bloom). This aesthetic change from the sublime to the counter-sublime is a shift from the intangible to the tangible within the natural world. Within Shelley’s poem the aesthetic is more toward the real world and helping the people that have been left by Wordsworth than being in awe of the star that Wordsworth once was.

This shift in aesthesis has been made even more propionate because of Shelley’s shifting of the Shakespearian Sonnet. From one reading there was no indication that this poem is anything more than just a sonnet, but from further reading, and more understanding of the daemonization between these two characters within the poem, there can be more understood for the poem’s styling. During this time there were many poets who would use imitation in order to write their poetry. Through this poem Shelley has established that Wordsworth has gone away from shining light onto art and liberty, and has now deserted these pursuits. Through the high and low language that is used by Shelley, it can only be gathered that Wordsworth has given up art for the imitating of being something higher. Shelley mocks this imitation by imitating a Shakespearian Sonnet. Instead of the common, though considered high-brow, rhyme scheme of abab, cdcd, efef, gg Shelley inserts the couplet between the second and third quatrain making the rhyme scheme of abab, cdcd, ee, fgfg. This shift from traditional to contemporary style show a change within the author; a change that he will no longer blindly follow his once northern star into imitation.

This slide away from the imitation can be shown through the great use of punctuation that Shelley displays throughout the poem. In reference back to the opening line of the poem: “Poet of Nature,” the comma indicates that this poem is meant to be seen as a letter to the entitled Wordsworth. At the ends of the poem lines there is a continuation of the initial thought. I say it’s a continuation because I once read that colons should be considered as gateways inviting readers to go on. It is these lack of stopping points are the most interesting within the poem; namely between lines seven and twelve. This is during Shelley’s lament on what Wordsworth was to so many that he, Shelley, got swept up in his recount. There are only colons that invite the reader to keep reading on that reside between these lines. Along with these colors there are also three enjambments that keep the reader going on and on, until a caesura appears at the end of line twelve in the form of a hyphen. Contrarily, the other punctuations where more indications to take a breath and move on it isn’t until this hyphen that the reader gets a break to pause and reflect on what has been stated.

This pause allows the reader to reflect on the twelfth line of the poem: “Songs consecrate to truth and liberty,-” (Shelley line 12). It is reading over this line that left a mark on me as a reader. The song that is being sung to us now is to inspire the reader to look for the, to quote Dr. Matthew Roudané, “capital T truth.” We are to look deep into what we are being sung, to pay attention to the star that is leading our bark, before we believe that we are following truth and liberty. Shelley is telling readers that everything isn’t what it seems, and that we must delve deeper before we start explications of truth.

This use of wit in changing the sonnet format coupled with the wit of language Shelley has shown that his not just an imitation of what he followed. This poem is more than just a writer lamenting the loss of someone he holds dear. This poem is about letting Wordsworth, and other readers, know that just because one of their political group has defected to the higher class doesn’t mean that he or the others would do the same. This poem is about one-upping Wordsworth in his strongest area of work; and proving that Shelley is more than the man that he once followed. Shelley may be in morning for the friend that he once had, but he will move on and be better than he once was.

Details

Form– for the most part, the piece follows the structure of a traditional sonnet, with an ABAB rhyme scheme. However it breaks this scheme at lines 9-10, the only couplet in the poem.

Rhetoric– lines 1-6 seem to have very polite, sympathetic language. Starting with line 7, the rhetoric changes so that the speaker is now directly addressing Wordsworth, and it is very strong up until line 12. Lines 13 and 14 seem to reflect the more somber tone of the first six lines.

Syntax- again, the syntax seems to imply that the speaker is either Shelley or a common person. None of it seems to be convoluted or vague.

Vocabulary- the phrase "rock-built refuge" in line 9 illustrates just how strong the speaker once perceived Wordsworth, as well as adding to the powerful and serious tone of that section. In line 12, it is interesting that Shelley chose to use the word "consecrate", because the word has both literal and religious connotations.

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To Wordsworth Summary and Analysis of lines 1-14

Summary

"To Wordsworth" takes the form of an apostrophe to the poet William Wordsworth, a first-generation Romantic poet. The poem is modeled after a Shakespearean sonnet with an altered sestet. Through form and content, Shelley engages in a dialogue with the older poet, expressing his sense of betrayal due to Wordsworth's changing political views. From the beginning, Shelley alludes to Wordsworth's famous poem "Ode: Intimations of Immortality from Recollections of Early Childhood" in which Wordsworth reflects on the loss of the wonder and majesty he felt toward the natural world as a child. He expresses his sympathy with Wordsworth's poems and the losses that he and Wordsworth share—losses that are common to all of humanity. But there is a particular loss that, while felt by both poets, Shelley hates: the loss of the Wordsworth that wrote poetry dedicated to "truth and liberty." This Wordsworth was a guiding light and a place of refuge for Shelley, but is now gone, leaving him in the dark and without a safe haven.

The poem operates around the metaphor of Wordsworth's death, referring to the change in Wordsworth's political leanings. The poem not only the loss of moments and emotions but also the feelings of the poet who witnesses and mourns the loss of what once existed. Shelley transitions through observations of a natural current state, referencing Wordsworth's being using figurative language. When he returns to try to find the old Wordworth he admired he is—in keeping with Wordsworth's own structure of poetic melancholy—already gone. Shelley concludes with the distillation of his sentiment, centering on the sadness that Wordsworth, who celebrated in *Intimations of Immortality* the moments that transcend time, has perished.

Analysis

The sonnet form hadn't been used much since Shakespeare and Milton until Wordsworth revived it for the Romantic period. Choosing to write his address "To Wordsworth" in the form of a sonnet was therefore no doubt a conscious choice by Shelley, addressing Wordsworth in a form that he had excelled in and made his own. In particular, Wordsworth had written a series of "Sonnets Dedicated to Liberty," published in his book *Poem, in Two Volumes* of 1807, and those sonnets were very important to Shelley as a young poet, because in them Wordsworth expressed his political allegiance to the ideals represented by the French Revolution. "To Wordsworth" is a Shakespearean sonnet, distinguished from the Petrarchan sonnet by the rhyme scheme and location of the volta; all of Shakespeare's sonnets use the following scheme: ABAB CDCD EFEFGG. Shelley adopts this form but alters the final six lines to EEFGFG, with the volta occuring after line 12. The sonnet form lends itself particularly well to argumentative structures; a problem or question is often introduced in the opening lines that is then resolved through the poem's turn. Shelley makes use of this formal ability of the sonnet in "To Wordsworth."

The poem opens with an apostrophic address to Wordsworth as "Poet of Nature." The opening quatrain references Wordsworth's great poem, very important to Shelley, "Ode: Intimations of Immortality from Recollections of Early Childhood," where Wordsworth reflects on and mourns the loss of his childlike relation to Nature: "There was a time when meadow, grove, and stream, / The earth, and every common sight, / To me did seem / Apparelled in celestial light, / The glory and the freshness of a dream." Like Wordsworth, Shelley makes use of the figure of the dream: "Childhood and youth, friendship and love's first glow, / Have fled like sweet dreams, leaving thee to mourn." While Shelley clearly has the "Intimations" ode in mind here, these are persistent themes in Wordsworth's work, so that these opening lines are a kind condensed summary of Wordsworth's poetry as a whole.

To begin the second quatrain, Shelley, in the kind of plain language that Wordsworth himself utilized in his work, expresses his sympathy with Wordsworth: "These common woes I feel." The use of the word "common" here is a conscious choice by Shelley, and carries with it particular associations. The British Parliament was divided between the House of Commons and the House of Lords, reflecting the strict class divisions within British society as a whole. Wordsworth and Coleridge had, in their major work of 1798, the *Lyrical Ballads*, attempted to write in "the language of conversation in the middle and lower classes of society" to express "a natural delineation of human passions." That is, they used ordinary language to try to express ordinary feelings of ordinary people. This in itself was a radical move to make in a book of poetry, and one that Shelley admired. He's expressing a shared solidarity with "the Commons"—everyday working people. But then Shelley introduces a breach between himself and Wordsworth: "One loss is mine / Which thou too feel'st, yet I alone deplore." We're not told what particular "loss" is felt, and it isn't until later that we realize that this loss that Shelley "deplores"—a very strong word to use—is the loss of the Wordsworth that wrote poetry dedicated to "truth and liberty." In effect, these lines introduce a dissonance that isn't resolved until the end of the poem.

In the lines that follow, Shelley constructs two complex similes, which create evocative imagery to express two different sides, or views, of what Wordsworth's poetry meant to him. In the first simile, Wordsworth is like a star that guides a small ship ("bark") through a difficult journey in a winter storm at night. In the simile, Shelley is the ship and the journey can be considered that of life. Like a sailor following the north star to guide them in the right direction, Wordsworth's poetry showed Shelley the way. That Wordsworth is the "lone star" in the sky shows the prominent position he once held for Shelley as a poet worthy of imitation and admiration. Shelley would later use this same image in *Adonais*, his famous elegy for John Keats (who died in Rome in 1821, while on his way to stay with the Shelleys in Pisa): "my spirit's bark is driven," he writes "Far from the shore, far from the trembling throng / Whose sails were never to the tempest given," concluding "The soul of Adonais, like a star, / Beacons from the abode where the Eternal are." The second simile expresses something similar, though the particular image brings a different resonance

and different connotations. Here, Wordsworth is likened to a refuge or fortress built high up into the rock; there is much danger below from "the blind and battling multitude," but Wordsworth's poetry offers a safe haven, a place to escape from the constant and senseless struggle below. Again, Wordsworth is in a place of prominence, above all others.

The next two lines sum up why Wordsworth was so important to Shelley: "In honoured poverty thy voice did weave / Songs consecrate to truth and liberty." The phrase "honoured poverty" has two intertwined meanings here. On the one hand, Wordsworth lived a simple life on a relatively modest amount of money. But, like the use of the word "common" earlier in the poem, the "poverty" also refers to Wordsworth's choice to simplify the language of his verse, to use the language of the poor and the workers. For Shelley, both of these choices were honorable. These two lines are a classic example of the way Shelley brilliantly used enjambment, a line-break in the middle of a sentence, in his poetry. "Weave" creates a visual, tactile metaphor for something airy and insubstantial: the voice. It also creates the expectation of a noun such as "tapestries," something that is actually woven, but instead, upsetting the reader's expectations, the noun following the line break is "Songs." Taken literally, this doesn't make much sense, but the metaphor of woven songs gives a sense of the subtle complexity of Wordsworth's poetry. Like a tapestry, it might seem simple on the surface, but when you look up close you realize the remarkable complexity and artistry involved. But weaving was also a common job; handloom weavers were numerous, one of the most common jobs in small towns. "Songs consecrate to truth and liberty" brings to mind, in particular, a series of sonnets published in Wordsworth's book *Poems, in Two Volumes* (1807) and titled "Sonnets Dedicated to Liberty." These poems expressed political ideals that Shelley still held and that Wordsworth by 1814 had renounced. As late as 1819, when Shelley wrote his great protest poem, still often quoted today, "The Mask of Anarchy," he was making reference to these sonnets by Wordsworth, showing their enduring important for him.

The final two lines complete the argument and the entire logical structure of the poem: "Deserting these, thou leavest me to grieve, / Thus having been, that thou shouldst cease to be." These lines show Shelley as a master of syntax, and have an almost epigrammatic density to them. Wordsworth had deserted truth and liberty; his political about-face between his early work and *The Excursion* was so extreme in Shelley's eyes that he had become like another person, or rather, the Wordsworth that Shelley thought he knew had ceased to exist. (Shelley never met Wordsworth in person; he only knew him through his work.) It isn't until these final two lines that we understand that the loss that Shelley deplores is the loss of Wordsworth himself, the death of the Poet of Nature. The evocation of the "Intimations" ode at the beginning is suddenly cast in a new light: just as the Wordsworth of "Intimations" mourns the loss of his childhood self, Shelley mourns the loss of the Wordsworth that he knew and loved during his youth. To put it colloquially, Shelley says to Wordsworth: "You're dead to me now."

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by **Percy Bysshe Shelley**

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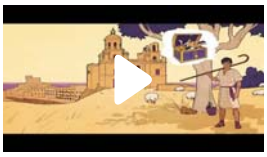
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To Wordsworth Poem Text

Poet of Nature, thou hast wept to know
That things depart which never may return:
Childhood and youth, friendship and love's first glow,
Have fled like sweet dreams, leaving thee to mourn.
These common woes I feel. One loss is mine
Which thou too feel'st, yet I alone deplore.

Thou wert as a lone star, whose light did shine

On some frail bark in winter's midnight roar:

Thou hast like to a rock-built refuge stood

Above the blind and battling multitude:

In honoured poverty thy voice did weave

Songs consecrate to truth and liberty,—

Deserting these, thou leavest me to grieve,

Thus having been, that thou shouldst cease to be.

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To Wordsworth Study Guide

"To Wordsworth" is an altered Shakespearean sonnet, written by Percy Bysshe Shelley and addressed to William Wordsworth, mourning Wordsworth's turn to reactionary politics exemplified by his 1814 book *The Excursion*.

In 1814, William Wordsworth published *The Excursion*. Upon reading it, Mary Shelley noted in her diary, responding to the new work of a once-legendary figure who had a singular influence upon her husband as well as their fellow Romantics: “He’s a slave.” Percy Shelley took that private observation of his wife one step further by composing his own poetic, emotional reaction to what was viewed as Wordsworth’s betrayal of his former radical idealism by moving further toward conservative views in the wake of the horror of the Reign of Terror during the French Revolution.

The Excursion was Wordsworth's first major publication since his 1807 *Poems, in Two Volumes*, and it marked a major shift in his political thinking. Like his friends Samuel Taylor Coleridge and Robert Southey, Wordsworth had been a political radical in his youth, supporting the republican ideals of the French Revolution. However, Wordsworth's enthusiasm cooled as the French Revolution lapsed into the Terror, followed by Napoleon's tyrannical rule. As a result,

he hardened into a reactionary conservative. *The Excursion* can be seen as Wordsworth working through this political shift in verse, rejecting the Enlightenment thought of figures such as Jean-Jacques Rousseau that was so important to the development of the radicalism represented by the French Revolution.

As a young poet, Shelley had deeply admired the work of Wordsworth. His politics and his poetic technique were influenced by Wordsworth's early work, such as his "Sonnets to Liberty," in which he expressed sentiments such as these: "We must be free or die, who speak the tongue / That Shakespeare spake; the faith and morals hold / Which Milton held." As late as his famous 1819 protest poem "The Mask of Anarchy," Shelley alluded to Wordsworth. Wordsworth's political shift to conservatism in *The Excursion* was experienced by Percy Shelley—and by Mary, who shared his political radicalism—as a deeply personal betrayal. "To Wordsworth" is Shelley's poem, a sonnet, marking his disappointment and his sense of betrayal over Wordsworth's shift from the roots of liberty and equality.

Unlike Wordsworth, Shelley would preserve until his death a commitment to the ideals of liberty, republican government (as opposed to monarchy), and equality. His attack upon Wordsworth for betraying his former ideals initiated a period of revisionism toward the older man by the younger generation. Foremost among these responses was Robert Browning's "The Lost Leader," whose title makes clear both the earlier admiration and the present sense of betrayal felt by Wordsworth's poetic descendants.

The idealistic younger generation's sense of outrage at the older man's move away from their own radicalism, it seems, went beyond mere criticism of his conservative political views. Intertwined with this objective critique is a deep subjective feeling of personal betrayal. The anti-Wordsworth reappraisal which Shelley's "To Wordsworth" inaugurated proved to be at least as strongly motivated by the universal feeling of disappointment one always when one discovers that one's heroes are not, in fact, infalliable. Shelley's poem thus stands as a complex testament, at once to the influence of Wordsworth, to Shelley's own politics, and to his sense of betrayal at the older poet's move away from political radicalism.

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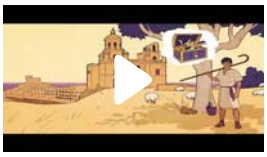
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To Wordsworth Summary

Opening with an apostrophe to Wordsworth as "Poet of Nature," "To Wordsworth"'s first quatrain conjures persistent themes of Wordsworth's earlier poetry, in particular his famous "Ode: Intimations of Immortality from Recollections of Early Childhood," in which the poet mourns the loss of the sense of wonder and mystery he felt in his youth: "there hath passed away a glory from the earth." Shelley, as Wordsworth did in his Ode, uses the simile of waking up from a dream. Just as the Intimations Ode mourns the loss of youthful wonder, *The Excursion* deals with the loss of the political idealism that Wordsworth once felt in his radical youth. Wordsworth feels this loss, but Shelley deplores it.

Addressing the poet and man William Wordsworth had become by 1814 with the publication of *The Excursion*, Shelley commences an ironically calculated quatrain that slyly touches upon many of the great themes associated most closely with William Wordsworth—nature, death and loss, nostalgia for the lost innocence of childhood and youth,

the bonds of friendship and the excitement of falling in love—before bringing down the blade that cuts by asserting that Wordsworth's contemporary work lacks all these things, leaving the aging poet to become someone who now only mourns the loss of these concerns. Then, Shelley asserts his sympathy with such sentiments as those expressed in the "Intimations" ode, and more broadly with Wordsworth's early body of work as a whole. However, Shelley turns suddenly to express antipathy toward the poet that Wordsworth has become in *The Excursion*.

The last six lines express a similar sentiment, but through the use of a very different simile. Here, Wordsworth is compared to a refuge built high up in the rocks, a safe haven away from the endless struggles of the world below. Wordsworth's poetry here is not just a way to escape from the tawdriness of daily life, but it is also a means of access to those truths of nature that are permanent. The next two lines state clearly what it was that Shelley valued most in Wordsworth's early poems: they were devoted to the cause of "truth and liberty." True to the Shakespearean sonnet form, the closing two lines tie together everything that came previously. Because Wordsworth has deserted his commitment to "truth and liberty," expressed in such poems as the "Intimations" ode and in his "Sonnets to Liberty," Shelley is left to grieve the loss of what had been both a guiding light and a refuge from a seemingly hopeless world. To put it colloquially, Shelley is basically saying to Wordsworth: "You're dead to me."

The eulogy cuts two ways, with Shelley on the one hand describing Wordsworth as a lone star only to immediately undermine that metaphor with imagery of the light from his star shining upon a bare tree in the middle of the night during winter. Wordsworth is then compared to the sturdiness of a refuge carved into rock only for that refuge to be perched above the blind multitudes below. This image sets the stage for Shelley to move his attack on Wordsworth from the literary to the political, as he references the poems the young Wordsworth wrote honoring the radical liberalism of the underclass fighting for truth and liberty. The poem ends on the image of Wordsworth having deserted these ideals as he aged into political conservatism. It is the loss of this Wordsworth that Shelley deplores, while Wordsworth merely feels the loss of his younger self.

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To Wordsworth Symbols, Allegory and Motifs

Wordsworth as "Poet of Nature" (symbol)

As noted previously, Nature was a key concept for the Romantic poets, and it carried assumptions about systems of religious belief. In this apostrophic address, Shelley is expressing his view that Wordsworth is a poet of the deist worldview that God and Nature and inseparable. Part of the power of Wordsworth's early poetry, for Shelley, came from how it expressed the power of nature as a force to develop morality and human sensibility.

"Fled like sweet dreams" (simile)

This simile—a rhetorical figure that compares one thing with another through the terms "like" or "as"— draws on Wordsworth's own language from his famous "Intimations" ode, a poem that exerted a great influence over Shelley. Just as "sweet dreams" disappear quickly after waking, Wordsworth's poetry, particularly the Intimations Ode, express how "Childhood and youth, friendship and love's first glow" also pass quickly away, but that a deeper appreciation of nature and of life can emerge in later life despite these losses.

Wordsworth as "a lone star" (simile)

This is the first of two elaborate similes that Shelley uses to express what Wordsworth meant to him. In the simile, Wordsworth is "a lone star" and the light from the star is Wordsworth's poetry, which guides Shelley, turned here into a "frail bark"—a small ship sailing alone through the difficulties of life (expressed in the simile as "winter's midnight roar"). That is, Wordsworth's poetry was a guiding light to Shelley through hard times in his life, when all else seemed dark and hopeless.

Wordsworth as a "rock-built refuge" (simile)

This is the second of the two similes that Shelley uses to express what Wordsworth meant to him. Here, Wordsworth is the "rock-built refuge," both sturdy and unshakable, and removed from the tumult of "the blind and battling multitude" that are experienced in everyday life. Wordsworth is not only a guiding light, then, but also a place of refuge and escape from the chaos of life. Whereas the multitude are blind, Wordsworth represents the eternal truths of nature, which have the lastingness of something built of stone.

"Thy voice did weave / Songs" (metaphor)

Shelley uses a common metaphor here of the poet as singer, but compounds it with the metaphor of weaving. This expresses on the one hand Wordsworth's position in the canon of great poets, often considered "singers," but on the other hand the artfulness of his poetry, which is like a woven tapestry in its complexity and beauty. But the most important part here, for Shelley, is that Wordsworth's art was devoted to "truth and liberty."

Death (metaphor)

Shelley uses the metaphor of death to describe the dramatic change in Wordsworth' political leanings. The poem reads like an elegy, though of course Wordsworth is still alive. His political betrayal of the principles represented by the French Revolution—political liberty and equality—is tantamount for Shelley to him ceasing to exist. Shelley had never met Wordsworth, so Wordsworth to him existed only through his books. With the publication of *The Excursion*, the Wordsworth that Shelley had previously known, the poet that he thought Wordsworth was, had ceased to be.

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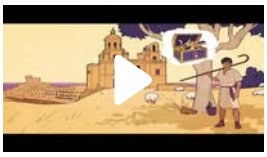
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To Wordsworth Themes

Changing of the Guard

One of the initial themes that Shelley examines in this short poem is the short-lived nature of literary heroism. He admits that Wordsworth is an iconic figure in the opening words by referring to him as “poet of nature.” But his true goal is illuminated in the fact that he uses just one line to list the thematic composition of Wordsworth’s most respected works: youth, love and friendship. Then the zinger: “These common woes I feel.” In one sweetly fell swoop, Shelley serves to undercut the high prestige enjoyed by Wordsworth by suggesting he, too, writes about those things and, perhaps, is writing about them at a higher level now than is Wordsworth. Shelley foreshadows the end of the poem here by offering himself as the logical inheritor of the mantle of “poet of nature.”

Eulogy for a Poet Past His Prime

The middle section of the poem is a brilliant display of Shelley's masterful use of language. He situates Wordsworth as the reigning king of his time by comparing him to a bright star, a solid fortress and a lion whose voice was enjoyed by the multitudes. But with judicious word choice, Shelley then recasts Wordsworth as a lonely star whose light shone in the past, a fortress constructed of rocks subject to weakening and crumbling, a man roaring to crowds suffering blindness. He both builds up Wordsworth as a great figure and subsequently tears him down by the admonition that he was great—in the past.

Loss and Grief

Wordsworth is one of the great poets of grief and loss. Here, Shelley takes one of Wordsworth's major themes and turns it against him, so to speak. This doesn't mean, however, that Shelley's expression of loss and grief here isn't sincere; it certainly is. One of the surprises of the conclusion of the poem is precisely the strength with which the feeling of loss is expressed. For Shelley, it is as if Wordsworth has died. The almost paradoxical formulation of this comes from the fact that the loss wouldn't feel profound enough to evoke death as a metaphor if it weren't for the strength of the feeling that Shelley felt for the poet that Wordsworth previously was.

Liberty

The word "liberty" took on a very precise political connotation in the aftermath of the French Revolution, the rallying cry of which was "liberty, equality, brotherhood" (in French "liberté, égalité, fraternité"). For Shelley, liberty stood for the overthrow of all forms of oppression, the main ones being the monarchy, the aristocracy, and the Anglican Church. It meant that the people would govern themselves in the form of a democratic republic. It also meant freedom from the mental slavery that Shelley believed was imposed on people by the falsehoods of Christianity.

Literary Influence

A significant part of the poem is devoted to the expression, through elaborate metaphor, of the literary influence that Wordsworth exerted over the young Shelley. Hence, Wordsworth is "a lone star" guiding the solitary and fragile younger poet like "some frail bark" through a dark and difficult world ("winter's midnight roar"); or Wordsworth is like "a rock-built refuge" by which the poet can escape "the blind and battling multitude." His influence came both through the expression of the common experiences of humanity—"Childhood and youth, friendship and love's first glow"—but also because his poems were "consecrate to truth and liberty." He also admired Wordsworth's "honored poverty," that is, the fact that Wordsworth devoted himself to his art rather than pursuing a career that would bring him more worldly success.

Nature

Nature was a very important concept for the Romantics, following after Enlightenment thought in which Nature had come to replace God at the center of the universe. For many Romantics, God was no longer a separate, personal being that controlled nature from above, but merely the force or energy of the universe itself. Wordsworth and Coleridge, in their youth, were much influenced by Baruch Spinoza, a Spanish philosopher and deist, for whom God and Nature were one and the same. Wordsworth wrote much about Nature and its importance to the development of human sensibility and morality. For Shelley, an atheist, such poetry was a powerful testament to the inherent goodness of Nature and hence provided support for the view that a moral life didn't require religious belief.

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The Revolutionary Desire for Ideal Utopia in Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound*

Lee, Chungeun

[Abstract]

Shelley envisages his revolutionary desire for an ideal utopia in *Prometheus Unbound*. He seeks to fulfill his imaginative vision after all the failure of the French Revolution, with the urgency to challenge the social conventions and the political authorities through the revolutionary vehemence in his age. The Romantic poet Shelley finds an ideal model for his romantic hero in Prometheus, who tried to save the haunted world from the tyrant Jupiter. In spite of Jupiter's malicious acts and cruelty, Prometheus showed the invincible will to redeem the world from, and his forgiveness and pity on, Jupiter seem to have inspired Shelley's poetic imagination. According to Shelley, it is in its union with the virtue of love and beauty that the revolution can complete itself in this masculine world. Prometheus comes to realize the significance and direction of ideal revolution when he has met Asia. In addition, Prometheus already recognizes that even human virtues can be distorted into self-destructive ones, unless any human virtues, including wisdom and will, would be associated with love. It is only through his reunion with Asia that Prometheus can liberate himself and realize the revolution for utopia, restoring One Mind. It means that, in his utopian vision, Shelley upholds the idealized community of One Mind and the ideal for individual freedom and creativity in *Prometheus Unbound*. In this

sense, Prometheus can be said to be Shelley's surrogate for his Utopian idealism, on whom Shelley's ideal of individualism and politics remains centered. In him, Shelley sees the symbolic representation of human psyche and the recovery of a true individualism.

Key Words: *Prometheus Unbound*, Revolution, Individualism, Freedom, Love

Ⅰ. Introduction

In *Prometheus Unbound*, Shelley reveals his revolutionary desire for ideal utopia. With the self-contained motivation for revolution, he determined to write *Prometheus Unbound* so that his imaginative vision can be fulfilled despite the failure of the French Revolution. As a young upstart, Shelley's "writings and actions are dominated by a belligerent passion for reforming the world" (Hope 403). Shelley realized the urgency of challenging the social conventions and the political authorities through the revolutionary vehement in his age. Moreover, he thought that the current age was filled with the oppressive power of monarchy and felt the necessity of democratic reform for the progress of human improvement. Recognizing the role of a romantic poet, Shelley creates his romantic hero, Prometheus as his ideal model, who saves the haunted world from the tyrant, Jupiter. Even though Prometheus is a victim of unspeakable torture and anguish, he feels lamentation on and sympathy with Jupiter and Furies that consistently try to annihilate the world.

In particular, Jupiter only "brings famine, toil, pain, terror, madness, crime, remorse, and self-contempt" in the earth (Steichen 44). As William Hope argues, for Shelley, Jupiter is not real being, not even a representation of a real being, but rather

an allegorical symbol for certain malignant forces, such as ignorance and greed, which have long been at work in society and which in the end will spell heartless tyranny and untold suffering for humanity in general (407). In addition, Jupiter's cruelty accelerates the suffering of humankind. In spite of Jupiter's malicious acts and cruelty, Prometheus's invincible will to redeem the world from Jupiter and his forgiveness and pity on Jupiter seem to have touched Shelley's poetic vision. Indeed, Prometheus tries to remove the oppressive power of Jupiter in order to resuscitate the repressed condition of England. It is through his own revolutionary spirit that Prometheus struggles to transcend the political boundary of Jupiter for the creation of freedom and social justice. Furthermore, Prometheus takes the pursuit of usurping the established power with his moral and political autonomy. Prometheus' revolutionary spirit and his humanitarian attitude function to bring about the internal awakening from the readers. Besides, Shelley upholds the idealized community as his utopian vision and ideal perfection for individual freedom and creativity in *Prometheus Unbound*. In this sense, Prometheus can be said to be Shelley's surrogate for reflecting his Utopian idealism. In this paper, I will discuss Prometheus' endless journey toward ideal Utopia which can be founded upon individual freedom and social justice.

II. Prometheus' Change of Mind On His Way to Ideal Transformation

It is Asia and Demogorgon that Prometheus has to rely on in order to accomplish his redemption and forgiveness. Moreover, the process of Prometheus's liberation is connected to the change of his mind; his hatred is purged with the ideal love of Asia

and the help of Demogorgon. Prometheus makes harmony with the love of Asia by reuniting his fate with her. In addition, the principle of the new world that Prometheus expects is only possible when Demogorgon's sublime power overthrows Jupiter. Jupiter, representing the evil or self-destruction, is doomed to be destroyed by the power of Demogorgon. According to Shadi Neimneh, *Prometheus Unbound* is "an advocacy of rebellion against all forms of tyrannical authority enslaving humans' soul and minds and limiting their imagination and potential" (21). In this sense, Shelley's philosophy of human progress and regeneration with no shackles, which is reflected in the image of Prometheus, is ultimately penetrated into One Mind[1)] throughout the poem. When Prometheus loses love toward humankind and struggles against Jupiter's sovereignty for the utopian desire, his personality becomes divided. Because everyone including Asia, Demogorgon, and even Jupiter, is part of One Mind, the division of One Mind makes human being evil and the world full of suffering. Moreover, Jupiter's reign reflecting the evil aspect of Prometheus can be said to worsen the world. Under this circumstance, Shelley's volition to save the humankind becomes actualized as the truth.

Prometheus's revolutionary desire for ideal utopia is first triggered when he brings fire to human being. Prometheus is an existence that knows the truth of the history and the possibility of reform. Furthermore, he thinks that informing humankind of the possibility of reform is his essence. Under the reign of Jupiter, however, the hope for future seems far away to be realized. In spite of the inevitable reality, Prometheus conducts his daring behavior of stealing fire, and he is eventually caught in Caucasus by Jupiter. After recognizing the intention of Jupiter who tries to annihilate human being, Prometheus groans his painful situation without help:

> No change, no pause, no hope-Yet I endure
> I ask the Earth, have not the mountain felt?

I ask you Heaven-the all-beholding sun,
Has it not seen? The sea, in storm or calm,
Heaven's ever-changing Shadow, spread below-
Have its deaf waves not heard my agony?
Ah me, me, alas, pain, pain ever, forever (I. 24-30)[2)]

The bulwark Prometheus clings to is associated with the social situation in which Prometheus cannot help but undergo. The extreme situation provides Prometheus with painful desolation and frustration, but it is something that should be eventually overcome by him. In addition, defining Jupiter as the fatalistic ruler, Prometheus assumes that the old servitude for Jupiter makes humankind lose some sort of hope and courage to reform the world. However, he does not fall into despair, but rather restores confidence in himself for future hope.

Prometheus's invincible will to bring humans to an ideal utopia becomes clearer, as suffering and frustration imposed upon him gets stronger. In particular, his will comes to be realized by clearing himself of negative feeling toward Jupiter. At first, Prometheus mistakenly regards Jupiter as the savor from the humankind, but he realizes that his thought is false. Even though Prometheus himself permits Jupiter to dominate the world, his initial mind is entangled with hatred and contempt toward Jupiter. Nonetheless, he tries to forget his negative emotion with the help of reason:

Disdain? Ah no! I pity thee.-What ruin
Will hunt thee undefended through wide Heaven!
How will thy soul, cloven to its depth with terror,
Gape like a Hell within! I speak in grief,
Not exultation, for I hate no more,
As then, ere misery made me wise,-The Curse
Once breathed on thee I would recall (I, 53-59).

The conflict between his revenge upon Jupiter and his pity on him, deeply embedded in Prometheus's inner mind, gradually surface. Nonetheless, as a rebel, he becomes wise and mature enough to be awakened. And, as the steps to overcome his emotional aspect, it is necessary for him to know both current and past identity. He is overwhelmed by his desire to hear the past curse against Jupiter. Since he knows that the curse toward Jupiter is a wrong thing, however, he does not want to repeat the same curse with his own mouth. On the other hand, he still tries to hear the curse from others. Earth is not afraid of repeating Prometheus's curse, but Prometheus cannot understand it, because of her dead language. What Earth as a venerable mother consoling Prometheus, tries to do is to converse with Prometheus through her interaction, as Prometheus comprehends Earth's words with imagination. Earth pushes Prometheus to recall the phantasm of Jupiter so that he can take revenge upon Jupiter and finally usurp his dictatorial position.

Recalling the phantasm of Jupiter, Prometheus starts to be convinced that the curse is the illusion of wrong intention. If Prometheus represents the spirit of human being, Jupiter symbolizes the evil instinct that inheres in Prometheus. Because of One Mind divided or conflicted, Prometheus cannot escape from the pressure of torture. It is essential for the recovery of Prometheus's One Mind to comprehend what Jupiter's true identity is. Jupiter is only the illusive phantasm; it is the help of Prometheus that enables Jupiter enthroned as a dictator. Accordingly, without the principle of Prometheus, Jupiter is doomed to be destroyed. In a word, Jupiter's power, though superior, is transient. Only during the moment when Jupiter thinks himself as an omnipotent god, he can remain omnipotent. By negating the consent for Jupiter's sovereignty, however, Prometheus threatens the destruction of Jupiter's omnipotent power. Shelley thinks through the relationship between Jupiter and Prometheus that all things are in the process of change and something omnipotent is relative.

After recognizing the contradiction of Jupiter's superior power, Prometheus begins to liberate himself and even humankind from Jupiter's dictatorship. Prometheus's imagination becomes wiser and mature, realizing that his curse upon Jupiter only increases his control over humankind. In other words, it is the change of his mind that enables Prometheus to liberate himself as well as humankind from Jupiter's influence. By retracting the curse and feeling pity on Jupiter, Prometheus's inner reform in morality is accomplished. Furthermore, he even knows the fact that someday Jupiter will be overthrown; he just waits for the future when he will be unbound from Jupiter. Above all, what is important here is that Prometheus does not despise Jupiter, but rather he shows pity on Jupiter. In other words, Prometheus has to change his attitude toward Jupiter so as to reform the world with his revolutionary vision. Overcoming hatred against Jupiter is made possible by Prometheus's awakening. However, the recant of curse drives Earth into despair, because Earth misunderstands Prometheus's behavior as the last submission to Jupiter. Even though Earth embraces Prometheus in her body, it appears that she does not recognize the maturity or the change of Prometheus's consciousness. Obsessed with the transient evil and revenge upon Jupiter, Earth cannot serve as some sort of catalyst to help Prometheus to be liberated from Jupiter any more.

Meanwhile, as the dictator, Jupiter sends Mercury to Prometheus in order to conciliate him as soon as Prometheus recants his curse, telling that he has to accept the self-contempt and Jupiter's power. The dictator does whatever he can do in order to strengthen and continue his control. He even compels the leading intellectuals longing for the revolution to sell their consciences. When the intellectuals resist against him, he secludes them from the society as he did Prometheus. Fear of the seclusion makes people including the intellectuals obey his power. Mercury as evil aide for Jupiter in seducing Prometheus tries to investigate the unknown secret of

Prometheus:

> ···There is a secrete known
> To thee, and to none else of living things,
> Which may transfer the scepter of wide Heaven,
> The fear of which perplexes the Supreme,
> Clothe it in words, and bid it clasp his throne
> In intercession; bend thy soul in prayer,
> And like a suppliant in some gorgeous fane,
> Let the will kneel within thy haughty heart,
> For benefits and meek submission tame
> The fiercest and the mightiest (I, 371-380).

Like Christ, Prometheus endures the mental torture upon himself Mercury imposes. He does not surrender and give up hope for himself and humankind because his concession means suffering and frustration for humankind:

> And yet to me welcome is Day and Night
> Whether one break the hoar frost of the morn,
> Or starry, dim, and slow, the other climes
> The leaden-coloured East; for then they lead
> The wingless, crawling Hours, one among whom
> -As some dark priest hales the reluctant victim-
> Shall drag thee, cruel King, to kiss the blood
> From these pale fee, which then might trample thee
> If they disdained not such a prostrate slave (I 44-52).

Finally, Prometheus's will leads to the denial of Jupiter's all efforts to reconcile. In addition, because revealing the secret means "death seal" for humankind, it is

impossible for Prometheus to disclose it. In this sense, it is Prometheus's will that enables him to carry out the revolution.

After the failure of Mercury's trial to seduce Prometheus, Furies come again to put Prometheus under Jupiter's control. As Kenneth Neill Cameron argues, "Furies are the tormenting thought-images of the aftermath of war and dictatorship of the French Revolution" (730). Throughout the first act, we inhabit a world of negation, a world which, as the imagery suggests, is endlessly empty. Emptiness and hollowness are everywhere; Jupiter's ministers, the Furies, are 'hollow underneath, like death while even Heaven itself is 'hollow' (Webb 697). In addition, Timothy Webb continues to say that the power of Jupiter is based on emptiness, he is himself a negation; therefore, it is entirely appropriate that he should be consumed by nothing (698). However, Prometheus does not surrender himself to the evil power sent from Jupiter, since he sees the Jupiter as the authority to oppress humankind:

> Yet am I king over myself, and rule
> The torturing and conflicting throngs within,
> As Jove rules you when Hell grows mutinous (I. 492-494).

It is through the Furies who don't recognize the tradition and the command that control them that Shelley implicitly shows people living like slaves without their true identities or free will. However, Furies also do not give up their will and try to instill in Prometheus's mind that his defiance is vain:

> The good want power, but to weep barren tears.
> The powerful goodness want: worse need for them.
> The wise want love; and those who love want wisdom;
> And all best things are thus confused to ill.
> Many are strong and rich, and would be just,

> But living among their suffering fellow-men
> As if none felt: they know not what they do (I. 625-631).

Nonetheless, Prometheus does not feel despair about the current phenomenon of human beings Furies suggest. And he does not give up the hope for humankind. Of course, even though Prometheus cannot escape from Jupiter's continuous imposing torture upon himself, what he selects is the sacred torture for recognizing his new identity and, in a broader sense, saving humankind. Such grand cause enables Prometheus to give up Furies' seduction and to let them leave Prometheus.

III. Prometheus' Understanding of Love For the Completion of His Journey

In spite of overcoming the seduction of Mercury and Furies, Prometheus feels frustrated by the extreme tremor the French Revolution leaves. Even though Earth sends Prometheus several spirits to console him, Prometheus is powerless, which serves to unite himself with Asia. According to David Bromwich, "Asia is the personal prophet of a great change and only love between Prometheus and Asia can bring hope and the possibility of reform into the world" (255). Indeed, Prometheus's fate is to become a savior for the tortured humankind with the help of Asia: "How fair these airborn shapes! And yet I feel / Most vain all hope but love; and thou art far, / Asia!" (I. 807-809). In Shelley's "A Defence of Poetry," Shelley shows his thought about love as follows:

> The great secret of morals is love, or a going out of

> Our own nature and an identification of ourselves with the
> Beautiful which exists in thought, action, or person, not
> Our own. A man, to be greatly good, must imagine intensely
> And comprehensively: he must put himself in the place of
> Another and of many others; the pains and pleasure of his
> Species must become his own. The great instrument of moral
> Good is imagination; and poetry administers to the effect by
> Action upon the cause (Shelley 282-283).

As mentioned above, for Shelley, love is to comprehend others and to meet the world around him. In addition, for Shelley, love is revolutionary one and the saving principle that is at work.

Shelley's point of view on love and its effect is reflected in the relationship between Prometheus and Asia in the poem. The forcible separation of Asia and Prometheus caused volcanic upheavals, as implied in the fact that Earth recalls the outbreak of "new fire from earthquake-rifted mountains of bright snow" when Prometheus was first enchained. However, eventually the consummation of Love and its immediate effect on Prometheus are to "initiate his reunion with Asia, his beloved, from whom he has been separated during the years of his torture on Caucasus" (Steichen 46). As Lilian Steichen argues, she is "the Ideal of Life, Beauty, Nature: she is All that mankind has ever hoped for or longed for or loved" (48). Thus, Prometheus "becomes his own preserver as he acknowledges and assumes the power of love, the quality that can exist only in the original state of his union with Asia" (Duerksen 626). Furthermore, Asia symbolizes Platonic love, which means the desire for the everlasting possession of goodness. Instead of despair surrounding Prometheus, Shelley provides Prometheus with the invincible and ideal type of love rather than with secular love. In a word, Shelley tells through Asia that he pursues some sort of altruistic love and the spirit of philanthropy. As the symbol of an ideal

beauty, Prometheus's reunion with Asia is to overcome their incompleteness in order to restore the complete human nature. Without ignoring the feminine characteristic inherent in Asia, Shelley believes that the revolution of masculine world can be completed through the union with the virtue of love and beauty. In this sense, Prometheus tries to harmonize the sacredness with Asia in order to fulfill his ideal utopia. As Richard Isomaki argues, the necessary reciprocity of love suggests that "Prometheus will be freed when he and Asia achieve an equivalence of position or outlook" (669). In addition, Prometheus already recognizes that even human virtues can be turned into the distorted and self-destructive ones, unless all human virtues including wisdom and will would be associated with love. That is, it is only through the reunion with Asia that Prometheus can liberate himself and realize the revolution for utopia and that he can restore One Mind.

However, Prometheus's ultimate desire for revolution can be actualized by combining the help of Asia with Demogorgon. Asia's inevitable response to the change of Prometheus is realized, only when Demogorgon is presented as destiny to punish Jupiter and to liberate mankind from his dictatorship. Thus, Asia and Demogorgon in the poem function as some sort of social existences to facilitate the liberal movement and to eliminate seclusion and isolation. Prometheus's travel with Asia in search of Demogorgon is followed by Panthea's dream that forecasts his liberation from Jupiter. Panthea apologizes for her delay, saying that she is able to remember one of her dreams about Prometheus:

> I saw not-heard not-moved not-only felt
> His presence flow and mingle through my blood
> Till it became my life and his grew mine
> And I was thus absorbed-until it past
> And like the vapours when the sun sinks down,

Gathering again in drops upon the pines
And tremulous as they, in the deep night
My being was condensed, and as the rays
Of my thought were slowly gathered, I could hear
His voice, whose accents lingered ere they died
Like footsteps of far melody. Thy name,
Among the many sounds alone I heard
Of what might be articulate; thought still
I listened through the night when sound was none. (II, i, 79-92).

.....
There is a change: beyond their inmost depth
I see a shade-a shape-'tis He, arrayed
In the soft light of his own smiles which spread
Like radiance from the cloud-surrounded moon.
Prometheus, it is thou-depart not yet! (II, i, 119-123)

As a personal prophetess, Asia is allowed to see Panthea's dream through her eyes that Prometheus is transformed as Christ and that even he appears to free himself from Jupiter's control with unselfish pleasure. Panthea's dream forecasts that the moment when the revolutionary desire for the utopian world is realized comes near at hand. Moreover, Shelley implies that Prometheus's love with Asia in the dream signifies the revolutionary love instead of simply sexual love. Asia's activeness enables her to recall the past days with Prometheus. This experience helps Asia to restore the love with Prometheus. Through the vehicle of dream, Shelley tries to awaken Asia from the realm of reality into that of possibility that Prometheus and Asia are capable of being liberated and saved from Jupiter's tyranny. As Neimneh argues, Shelley is deeply convinced that "Prometheus's moral regeneration caused by Asia can be interpreted as a form of revolt and as a turning point for the social and

political change" (21).

However, the darkness still lies on the way to get Jupiter dethroned even though the darkness is some sort of divine gloom toward Demogorgon:

> I see a mighty darkness
> Filling the seat of power, and rays of gloom
> Dart round, as light from the meridian sun (II. Iv. 2-4)

Demogorgon lives in a cave, because a cave is dramatically more appropriate than Bayswater. Why Demogorgon emits infra-red rays is because he is extremely hot; too hot to be visible. Demogorgon is, in fact, realized in terms of molten magma, the obscure and terrible volcanic agent hidden in the depth of the earth (Matthews 558). The dark and even secret passage is solved by Asia's direct experience in the summit of mountain; it ultimately expands the scope of Asia's consciousness in the long run. Moreover, as G. M. Matthews points out, Demogorgon's presence enables Asia's divine inspiration to be conceived and loosened in her breast (556). The accumulated maturity of self functions as the catalyst for the change of Asia's consciousness. Asia's new consciousness leads her to reveal the identity of Demogorgon, while he refuses to disclose his identity. Though Demogorgon realizes the necessity of reform from Asia, his refusal for the fear of Asia's revenging upon Jupiter stimulates Asia's curiosity.

At the same time, Asia is awakened to receive a new historical consciousness in the process of her journey; she thinks of Jupiter as an enslaved victim and comes to gain the revolutionary spirit that liberates even Jupiter in this revolving world. Shelley tells through Asia's awakening that all existences are entangled with fate, time, occasion, chance, and change. Only love can transcend these transient things to expand the permanent world. Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound* is based on the

structure of awakening and the expansion of existence. Revealing one's own identity is the impetus to reform oneself, which leads to the ideal world. Prometheus's inert awakening is engaged with Asia and Asia's inward awakening is connected to the world of Demogorgon. The awakening of love is associated with the complete unity with Prometheus. The conversation between Demogorgon and Asia implies the triumph of Prometheus:

ASIA
Who is the master of the slave?
DEMOGORGON
-If the Abysm
Could vomit forth its secrets:-but a voice
Is wanting, the deep truth is imageless;
For what would it avail to bid thee gaze
On the revolving world? What to bid speak
Fate, Time, Occasion, Chance and Change? To these
All things are subject but eternal Love.
ASIA
So much I asked before, and my heart gave
The response thou hast given; and of such truths
Each to itself must be the oracle.-
As my own soul would answer, did it know
That which I ask.-Prometheus shall arise
Henceforth shall the destined hour arrive?
DEMOGORGON
Behold! (II. iv. 114-128)

From the inexpressible truth, Asia knows the passionate certainty of heart's oracle and becomes the object of Prometheus's purified desire. In this way, to borrow John

Rieder's phrase, "Prometheus's aggressive desire in the revolution" can be fulfilled (787). John Rieder continues to say that the desire to end Jupiter's reign thereby becomes two wishes: one, the purified wish to reunite Asia and Prometheus; the other, the "evil wish" which disappears into the esoteric, unutterable power of the Abysm (788). The trust of Demogorgon enables him to destroy Jupiter. Jupiter's collapse is the predetermined fate Asia and Panthea wait for. Asia's intense love beats the darkness with its light and fever.

Shelley's reform for ideal utopia with no dictatorship culminates in Demogorgon's confrontation with Jupiter. Ironically, however, Jupiter does not recognize Demogorgon's identity because of his indifference to the change of heaven. Demogorgon's identity once lost is awakened and eventually restored with the help of Asia:

> Eternity. Demand no direr name.
> Descend, and follow me down the abyss.
> I am thy child, as thou wert Saturn's child;
> Mightier than thee: and we must dwell together
> Henceforth in darkness. (III. i. 52-56)

Jupiter, a transient figure, is destined to disappear within the inside of the permanent time. Demogorgon takes him to his cave, saying that there will be no tyranny anymore in the future. Jupiter cannot help but accept his miserable fate. In this sense, Jupiter's falling is the passive one caused by the power of fate. The fall of Jupiter under a 'bursting cloud" brings the concept of volcanic activity into close relation with that of the storm. The basis of much of the volcanic imagery surrounding Demogorgon's overthrowing Jupiter in Shelley's poem must now be clear; as Matthews notes, "this is the perception of revolutionary activity in the

external world and in the human mind-or irrepressible collective energy contained by repressive power" (563).

In the end, Prometheus becomes unbound from the fetters as a free existence. He runs toward Asia to complete their love and enjoys reunion with Asia. In some sense, the love with Asia helps Prometheus to liberate himself from all shackles and eventually to connect all to One Mind. However, Shelley tells his final lesson to his readers through Demogorgon:

> An empire o'er the disentangled doom.
> To suffer woes which Hope thinks infinite;
> To forgive wrongs darker than death or might;
> To defy Power, which seems omnipotent;
> To love, and bear; to hope will Hope creates
> From its own wreck the thing it contemplates;
> Neither to change, nor falter, nor repent;
> This, like thy glory, Titan, is to be
> Good, great and joyous, beautiful and free;
> This is alone Life, Joy, Empire, and Victory. (IV. 570-578)

This is the virtue and a code of conduct Promethean Man as Divine Man should keep in mind. The ideal utopia is not monotonous or fixed world; it is the creative and hopeful one. This is possible only when love is ample enough. As the spirit of love, the reform is to achieve the ideal utopia for all human beings. In this sense, Shelley's revolutionary desire can be said to be the spirit of love through the self-negation and the self-endurance of woes. In addition, the recovery of sacredness is combined with the restoration of beautiful nature and the expansion of consciousness.

IV. Conclusion

To conclude, Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound* requires an ideological and political reading in connection with his book entitled *A Philosophical View of Reform*. Indeed, as Kenneth Cameron points out, it is difficult to think of works that are more the antithesis of social skepticism with its cynical concept of the uselessness of human endeavor than *A Philosophical View of Reform* or *Prometheus Unbound* (589). Shelley's political and social views were essentially positive. Shelley believes that human nature was conditioned by social forces and that the source of political oppression lay in the ruling classes, as we can see in *Prometheus Unbound*, with their "standing army," their "legion of spies," and their control of the press and pulpit. He was confident that this "tyranny" would be eliminated by "reform" or "revolution." He was convinced that humanity was advancing to an egalitarian society. Shelley's political ideas seem to sound, at the theoretical level, extremely radical. Shelley continually holds up as his ideal a free, classless society in which there would be unlimited freedom of speech and interposition of government only to stop one person from infringing the rights of another (Reiman 595). Like Jefferson, he believed that the less government, the better, and thus his social thought parallels Godwin's brand of philosophical anarchism. But at the practical level, Shelley believed compromise and an orderly, step-by-step progression to the necessary (Reiman 595). Indeed he also dedicated his life and writing to the battle against social evils and to the realization of the ideals that he holds up, as in *Prometheus Unbound* and *A Philosophical View of Reform*.

Another political aspect to be dealt with in *Prometheus Unbound* is his positive and convincing attitude toward individualism. His individualism is the central theme in that "each man is king over himself and, therefore, the biological individual is the

One unassailable point of resistance to Jupiter" (Rieder 791). The relationship between power and freedom is implied as the ideological function in his poem. Shelley's political ideal is closely related to the spread of moral enlightenment and reform:

> The loathsome mask has fallen, the man remains
> Sceptreless, free, uncircumscribed-but man:
> Equal, unclassed, tribeless and nationless,
> Exempt from awe, worship, degree, -the King
> Over himself; just, gentle, wise-but man:
> Passionless? No-yet free from guilt or suffered them,
> Nor yet exempt, though ruling them like slaves,
> From chance and death and mutability,
> The clogs of that which else might oversoar
> The loftiest star of unascended heaven
> Pinnacled dim in the intense inane. (III. Iv. 193-204).

The revolution is wholly one of purification and unmask of deceit and falsehood, exempting from vice and slavery. In a word, as implied in the above, individualism and the political ideals that Shelley dreams of remains centered on the figure of Prometheus. Prometheus's struggle for freedom and his achievement of "the man" means, to borrow Rieder's phrase, "the disintegration of classes, tribes, and nations into a multitude of individual sovereignties" (792). Indeed, Prometheus is the symbolic representation of human psyche and the recovery of a true individualism.

Notes

1) "The words, I, you, and they are not signs of any actual difference subsisting between the assemblage of thoughts, but are merely marks employed to denote the different modifications of the one mind; P. B. Shelley, "On Life," p 508.

2) Quotations from Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound are from Shelley's Poetry and Prose*, ed., Donald H. Reiman and Neil Fraistat (New York: Norton, 2002).

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국문초록

셸리의 『해방된 프로메테우스』에 나타난 이상적인 유토피아를 향한 혁명적 욕망

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셸리는 『해방된 프로메테우스』에서 이상적인 유토피아를 향한 혁명적 욕망을 형상화한다. 프랑스 혁명의 실패에도 불구하고 셸리는 혁명적 열정을 포기하지 않고 자신의 대리인인 프로메테우스를 통하여 기존 사회 제도와 권위에 도전한다. 프로메테우스는 독재자인 주피터에 의해서 탄압과 고통을 당하는 인물로서 처음에는 주피터에 대하여 미움과 저주를 갖는다. 그러나 그 같은 부정적인 감정들이 자신에게 좌절과 절망만을 남겨준다는 사실을 서서히 인식하면서 프로메테우스는 마음속에서 내적 변화를 경험하게 된다. 자신과 인류를 주피터의 독재와 탄압으로부터 해방시키고자 노력하는 프로메테우스에게서 그와 같은 마음의 변화는 혁명과 해방을 위해서 근본적인 역할을 한다는 사실을 셸리는 보여준다. 주피터에게 폭력과 위협을 가하기보다는 사랑과 동정에 기초한 프로메테우스 자신의 내적 각성이 혁명의 필수조건임을 셸리는 강조하는 것이다. 프로메테우스의 혁명의지를 좌절시키기 위해서 주피터는 계속 고통을 가하지만 프로메테우스는 폭압과 독재의 세력인 주피터에게 굴복하지 않는다. 지속적인 고통을 감내하면서 인류의 희망과 자유, 그리고 개인주의를 꿈꾸는 프로메테우스는 아시아와의 만남을 통하여 진정한 혁명의 의미와 방향을 깨닫게 된다. 셸리는 혁명과 이상적인 유토피아를 이루는데 있어서 폭력이 아닌 타인에 대한 사랑과 동정심이 중요함을 프로메테우스와 아시아의 재결합을 통해 그리고 있다.

주제어 : 『해방된 프로메테우스』, 혁명, 개인주의, 자유, 사랑

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Prometheus Unbound

INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF PERCY BYSSHE SHELLEY

Percy Bysshe Shelley was born in 1792 in West Sussex, England. His parents were wealthy landowners and Shelley spent much of his early childhood outdoors in the English countryside. When he was ten years old, he was sent to Eton College to be educated. A studious and solitary child, Shelley was bullied relentlessly by his classmates during his time at Eton. He enrolled at Oxford University in 1810 where he developed his interest in writing and literature, despite rarely attending lectures. During his time at Oxford, Shelley began to experiment with writing novels and poetry and also to develop an interest in politics. He was expelled from Oxford in 1811 for writing a pamphlet called "The Necessity of Atheism," which was highly critical of the Church. After his expulsion, which caused a rift between Shelley and his father, Shelley eloped with Harriet Westbrook, a sixteen-year old girl who had become infatuated with him. Their marriage was unhappy however, and Shelley continued to court relationships with other women throughout this period. Shelley also began to spend time with William Godwin, a political writer whom Shelley considered his mentor and who had been married to the famous feminist writer Mary Wollstonecraft before her death. Shelley left Harriet and their daughter, Ianthe, in 1814 while Harriet was pregnant with their second child and entered a relationship with William Godwin and Mary Wollstonecraft's daughter, Mary, whom Shelley eventually married in 1816 after Harriet committed suicide. Percy and Mary Shelley travelled widely in Europe, spending time with Shelley's friend, the famous poet Lord Byron, who was also the lover of Mary's sister, Claire. Due to the fallout with his family, Shelley was often very poor and, although he was a prolific writer, his poetry was not a commercial success during his lifetime. His marriage to Mary was tumultuous and Shelley continued to have affairs throughout. The couple had two children, both of whom died in infancy, and an adopted daughter who also died very young. Shelley died in 1822 at age twenty-nine, when his boat sank in stormy weather off the Italian coast.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Romanticism was a direct reaction to the effects of new technology and industrialization, which was increasing at an unprecedented rate throughout the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. It was also a reaction against the general societal interest in rationality, reason, and empirical observation of the natural world, with a view to harnessing nature for industrial production. This period, which spanned most of the eighteenth century in Europe, was known as the Enlightenment or the Age of Reason and was a period of intense scientific and technological development that paved the way for modern industry and capitalism. Romanticism, as a literary movement, began towards the end of the eighteenth century with the work of writers such as William Blake, who criticized the damaging effects of industrialization on rural areas. With increased industrialization in cities, many people moved away from the countryside to work in factories in urban centers. Quality of life in these cities was very poor and unsanitary, and the Romantics felt that people would be happier and healthier if they spent more time in nature. Shelley and the Romantics were suspicious of Enlightenment attitudes towards scientific exploration and felt that the Enlightenment's focus on empirical observation of nature, rather than *appreciation* of nature, led to destructive tendencies among people who sought to use nature for profit or production without understanding the consequences of this behavior on the natural world. The Romantics were also radical thinkers in terms of their views on religion and politics. Shelley was an atheist and despised established institutions such as the Church, the Monarchy, and the institution of marriage. Shelley and the Romantics were inspired by the French Revolution, which took place between 1789 and 1799, in which the French monarchy were overthrown and executed because of their negligent attitudes toward the poor. Although the French Revolution devolved into tyranny, with a peasant mob executing thousands of people during the Reign of Terror, the Romantics were inspired by the political philosophy of individual freedom and rebellion against corrupt establishments that was central to revolutionary thought.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Prometheus Unbound is an example of an epic poem. Epic poetry borrowed themes from classical, Greek epics, such as *The Iliad* or *The Odyssey* by Homer, which focus on subjects like fate, heroism, conflict between mortals and deities, military combat, and journeys into other realms. Classical epics were rooted in Greek mythology and featured classical gods and heroes, while Christian epics such as *The Divine Comedy*, written in 1472 by Dante Alighieri, blend epic themes with Christian belief and theology. *Prometheus Unbound* makes use of Christian allegory throughout, though the story of Prometheus was originally written down by Greek authors such as Hesiod and the playwright Aeschylus. Shelley's poem is specifically based on a fragment from a lost play by Aeschylus. Shelley was heavily influenced by John Milton's characterization of Satan in his epic poem *Paradise Lost*, as can been seen in Shelley's in the depiction of Prometheus as a

rebellious hero who refuses to bow to a supreme authority. In this sense, Shelley is similar to Romantic poets such as William Blake, who depicted the Christian God as a tyrant and Satan as a spirit of knowledge and freedom in his 1793 illustrated poem *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*. Shelley was also directly influenced by, and directly influential on, the works of his friend Lord Byron. Byron used a Promethean Romantic hero character so often in his own poems like *Child Harold's Pilgrimage* or *Don Juan* that this type of character came to be referred to as the "Byronic hero." In his use of nature imagery and insinuations of nature worship, Shelley is also reminiscent of fellow Romantic poets such as William Wordsworth and Samuel Taylor Coleridge. Shelley's work was also influential on later, Victorian poets such as the Pre-Raphaelite group, which includes poets like William Morris and Dante Gabriel Rosetti. The Pre-Raphaelites were interested in depicting a pre-Renaissance, medieval world in their work because, like Shelley, they felt that the emphasis on rationalism and the scientific developments of the Enlightenment period had produced a detrimental effect on society and on man's relationship with nature. *Prometheus Unbound* also inspired political writers such as Karl Marx and Jean-Jacques Rousseau, as well as novelists like Leo Tolstoy, with its message of equality, liberty, and alleviation of suffering for the poor.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** Prometheus Unbound
- **When Written:** 1818
- **Where Written:** Italy
- **When Published:** 1820
- **Literary Period:** Romanticism
- **Genre:** Epic poetry
- **Setting:** A mountain and a valley in the Indian Caucuses, the underground realm of the Demogorgon, and Heaven.
- **Climax:** Prometheus, a Titan who has been bound to a mountain for all eternity by the tyrant Jupiter as punishment for giving humanity fire, is freed by Hercules, fulfilling a prophecy which predicts the end of Jupiter's authoritarian reign over Earth and which frees humanity from the bonds of ignorance, suffering, and mortality.
- **Antagonist:** Jupiter

EXTRA CREDIT

Julian and Maddalo. In 1818, the same year that he wrote *Prometheus Unbound*, Shelley spent a great deal of time in Italy with his close friend and fellow author Lord Byron. The pair discussed the social, political, and aesthetic subjects which feature in *Prometheus Unbound*, as well as in Byron's own epic poems. Shelley chronicled these discussions with Byron in his poem *Julian and Maddalo*, about two friends who explore Venice while discussing social causes.

Ireland. Shelley visited Ireland in 1812, when Ireland was under British rule, and was horrified by the poor living conditions he saw. He wrote a pamphlet entitled "An Address to the Irish People," which he sold at a low price and distributed by throwing copies of it from his balcony. This was seen as an act of extreme rebellion by the British government, who were interested in uniting Ireland under British rule, and gained Shelley a reputation as an anti-establishment figure.

PLOT SUMMARY

The Titan Prometheus has been chained to a precipice in the Indian Caucuses for all eternity by the tyrant god Jupiter, as punishment for giving humanity the gift of **fire**. He has been imprisoned for three thousand years thus far, and every day an eagle is sent by Jupiter to peck out his organs, which grow back overnight.

A night, the sea nymphs Panthea and Ione—daughters of the Ocean and sisters of Prometheus's wife, Asia—watch over Prometheus from the mountainside. Prometheus defiantly address Jupiter and tells him that, although Jupiter has supreme power over all the world, Prometheus does not envy him and would rather be chained to the mountain than reigning like Jupiter in Heaven. Although Prometheus cursed Jupiter when he was first bound, he has since forgotten the curse and asks the elements around him to remind him what he said. The elements admit that they remember his curse but are too afraid to repeat it. The Earth then speaks to Prometheus. She tells him that she is his mother and that his birth brought great joy to her as well as hope to mankind. Since his capture, however, the Earth has been sick with grief, sprouting poisonous plants and producing noxious vapors that have caused plague and famine among humanity.

The Earth calls up the Phantasm of Jupiter from the shadow world to repeat the curse for Prometheus, as the Earth does not dare repeat it herself for fear that Jupiter will punish her. The Phantasm of Jupiter approaches and Panthea and Ione cower before it, frightened by its likeness to the real Jupiter. The Phantasm repeats the curse, in which Prometheus states that he is the only being who will not bow to Jupiter and invites Jupiter to punish him as much as he likes because nothing the god does will make Prometheus respect his power. In his curse, Prometheus also hopes that Jupiter's power will cause Jupiter suffering that outweighs the benefits he reaps from making himself the supreme authority.

After the Phantasm vanishes, Prometheus laments that he had wished pain upon another being. When she hears this, the Earth cries out that Prometheus has been conquered and that he is now a slave to Jupiter's power. Ione, however, is confident

that this is just a "passing spasm" and points out that the messenger God, Mercury, is flying towards them through the breaking dawn, followed by the Furies, monsters from the world of the dead and servants of Jupiter.

Mercury has been sent by Jupiter to make a deal with Prometheus, which will allow Jupiter to keep his power but give Prometheus his freedom. Prometheus rejects his offer and tells Mercury that he will never stop resisting Jupiter because Jupiter has enslaved the world and humanity. Mercury begs Prometheus to accept because he does not wish to watch Prometheus suffer, but Prometheus steadfastly refuses and tells Mercury to let the Furies at him.

Mercury sadly departs and the Furies attack Prometheus, taunting him with visions of suffering and cruelty acted out by humanity. They tell him that, although he has tried to help humanity by giving them fire, they have turned on each other with acts of violence, malice, and war. One man tried to preach a message of hope and peace, the Furies say, but his message was abused and distorted. Prometheus weeps for this man but refuses to speak his name, which he feels has now become a curse. The Furies vanish and Prometheus says that their torture has only increased his determination to defy Jupiter because it has shown him the terrible suffering on earth under Jupiter's reign. The Earth then calls up a chorus of good spirits to comfort Prometheus. These spirits speak of a prophecy foretelling that Prometheus will kill death and bring new hope to humanity. Panthea tells Prometheus that he is deeply loved before she leaves to visit his wife, Asia, who is waiting in the valley below.

Panthea arrives just after sunrise and tells Asia that she is late because she was having strange dreams. Upon telling Asia that she cannot remember one of the dreams, Asia looks into her eyes, trying to divine the dream there, and is startled to see a shape beckoning her to follow. Panthea feels it too and cries out that it is her dream. The two nymphs follow the dream to the opening of a cave. A chorus of voices spur them on, and the two nymphs sink down, overcome by weakness, into the abyss, which is the entrance to the lair of the Demogorgon.

Panthea and Asia confront the Demogorgon on his throne and find that he is a shapeless spirit made of darkness. Asia explains to the Demogorgon that, when Prometheus first gave Jupiter knowledge, he gave it to him on the condition that Jupiter would "let man be free." Jupiter however, enslaved mankind. Prometheus gave humanity fire in retaliation, so that they could tame the brutal environment that Jupiter had created for them. Jupiter then chained Prometheus to the mountain as punishment.

The Demogorgon tells Asia that all things in the universe "are subject to Eternal love," and shows the nymphs a series of chariots racing around the earth's perimeter. The Demogorgon says that these are the **Spirits of the Hours** and that one among them, who flies on a different route, is the **Spirit of Love**. The Demogorgon takes them to meet one Hour, the shadow of a destiny, who awaits them. The sea nymphs and the Demogorgon get into the chariot and ascend towards Heaven.

In Heaven, Jupiter is celebrating with the other gods. Although, he has not yet dominated the will of Prometheus, he is confident that he soon be omnipotent because he and the goddess, Thetis, have produced a child who is mightier yet than him. This child is the Demogorgon, who arrives in Heaven in the chariot of the Hour as Jupiter speaks. Jupiter is terrified when he sees the Demogorgon, who drags Jupiter down into his lair, ending his reign. Ocean and Apollo, the sun god, stand amazed as they watch Jupiter's fall. They rejoice that they will no longer have to witness suffering on earth because the tyrant has been defeated.

Hercules frees Prometheus, and he is reunited with Ione, Panthea, and Asia. Prometheus tells Asia that there is a beautiful cave in which they will live together. He reminds Ione of a gift which Asia received on her wedding day, a shell which produces lovely music when blown, and tells her to give it to the Spirit of the Hour. He asks the Spirit of the Hour to fly around the world, sounding the shell, and the Earth delights that she can feel herself coming back to life now that Prometheus is free. She calls up a messenger, the Spirit of the Earth, to lead them to the cave which will be their dwelling.

The Spirit of the Earth calls Asia "mother" and talks with her playfully, telling her about the change which she has witnessed in the world since Prometheus has been free. The Spirit tells Asia that, as she was walking in a city, she heard a sweet music sounding in the night and all the people rushed outside to hear it. She watched as the people transformed, becoming joyful and filled with love. The Spirit of the Hour returns and tells them that he has done his job. He remarks on the transformation which has taken place among mankind, saying he has seen all the monuments of power abandoned and the courts of kings and rulers "unregarded" because man has no need for them.

Panthea and Ione go to sleep outside the cave of Asia and Prometheus. They wake to singing and witness the dead spirits of the Hours dancing in a funeral procession for the King of the Hours. They then witness a vision in which they see all the trappings of worldly power deserted and forgotten, as though at the bottom of the sea. As the Moon talks with the now gleeful Earth, water flows and plants begin to grow on the Moon's surface. The Earth and the Moon rejoice at this new life and, from the deep, the voice of the Demogorgon sounds across the universe, spreading a message of "Love, Joy, Victory, and Empire."

CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Prometheus – Prometheus is the protagonist and hero of

Prometheus Unbound. In Shelley's poem, Prometheus is a Titan (within Greek mythology, Titans are children of the Earth who are often in conflict with the classical gods) who has been punished by Jupiter for providing humanity with the gift of **fire**, which represents knowledge. As punishment for his transgression, Jupiter sentences Prometheus to be bound to a mountain for eternity. Shelley's Prometheus is a defiant, independent, and selfless character who is prepared to resist the despotic Jupiter regardless of the consequences. Prometheus views his supposed transgression—that is, giving humans fire—as morally correct because be believes that knowledge can alleviate suffering on earth and help humans navigate their environment. This emphasizes Prometheus as an independent thinker who does not automatically bow to authority if he feels that it is corrupt. Even as he values his ability to make his own judgements, however, he does not crave power to influence other people's and sacrifices his well-being for the greater good. Notably, when Jupiter offers him a truce at humanity's expense, Prometheus refuses and claims that he would rather be punished than compromise his values for the sake of personal gain. Although Prometheus is a very defiant character, he learns forgiveness and compassion during his punishment and even comes to pity Jupiter, who he believes must be unhappy in his all-consuming pursuit of power. This supports Shelley's characterization of Prometheus as a kind and selfless figure who is willing to suffer the loss of his own freedom for the sake of others'.

Jupiter – Jupiter is the villain or antagonist of *Prometheus Unbound*, the ruler of the Heavens, the Earth, the natural elements, and humanity. In Roman mythology, Jupiter was the ruler of the Gods and equivalent of the Greek Zeus. In Shelley's poem, Jupiter has reigned as the supreme authority since Prometheus's capture. Readers learn about Jupiter through the other character's reactions to him as well as through the Phantasm of Jupiter, which is called up to reveal Prometheus's curse. The Earth and other natural elements live in fear of Jupiter, suggesting that he is a cruel tyrant. This is further demonstrated when the Earth tells Prometheus that Jupiter has attached her to a "wheel of pain," forcing her to orbit round the sun. While Prometheus views **fire** as beneficial to humanity, Jupiter feels threatened that humanity's knowledge may lead them to question his authority. This shows that Jupiter is a totalitarian leader who does not believe in freedom of thought or information and is afraid of losing his power. He is willing to be cruel and violent towards anyone who opposes him and to keep humanity in servitude, despite the suffering this causes. In this regard he is the opposite of Prometheus, who is willing to suffer so that others might be free. Although Jupiter is very powerful, he is portrayed as very cowardly, hiding behind the Furies he sends to punish Prometheus, and living in constant fear of having his authority stripped from him.

Asia – Asia is Prometheus's wife, an Oceanid (otherwise known in classical mythology as a daughter of the Ocean, or a sea nymph), and the sister of Panthea and Ione. Asia as portrayed by Shelley is deeply connected to the natural world and affected by wrongs done to it. She mourns the loss of her husband, who she fears will be bound forever. During the poem, Asia is transformed from a figure in mourning with little hope into an emblem of love returning to the world upon Jupiter's fall and Prometheus's release. This supports her association with spring as it suggests the world being brought back to life after the winter of Jupiter's reign. Asia is also associated with the **Spirit of Love** and the classical goddess of love, Venus, as she is described as riding in an "ivory shell" on the ocean. This was a common image which depicted the birth of Venus and links Asia to the Spirit of Love's chariot, which is an "ivory shell." A shell is also used as a horn at the end of the poem, when the **Spirit of the Hour** flies around the world spreading the music of love from Asia's enchanted shell, which was given to her as a wedding present. Asia is called "mother" by the Spirit of the Earth, who is a symbol of nature, and which suggests that the union between Prometheus, who is a symbol of knowledge, and Asia, who is a symbol of love, presents a new hope for nature and invigorates the connection between man and the natural world.

Panthea – An Oceanid, or sea nymph, Panthea is the daughter of the Ocean and the sister of Asia and Ione. Panthea is depicted as loving and protective of her sisters and shows great compassion for Prometheus during his punishment, despite the fact that watching him suffer is very difficult for her. Although it is painful for Panthea to see Prometheus being tortured, she and Ione stay near him on the mountaintop, both to offer him comfort and for the sake of their sister Asia, who is Prometheus's wife. Panthea travels with Asia down into the realm of the Demogorgon, demonstrating her bravery. Panthea's name is also symbolic as it is closely linked to Pan, a pagan nature god, and the word "pantheism," which refers to a type of pagan nature worship in which Shelley and the Romantics were interested.

Ione – Ione is an Oceanid, or sea nymph, and is the daughter of the Ocean and the sister of Panthea and Asia. Like Panthea and Asia, Ione is portrayed as a compassionate nature spirit who is deeply affected by the punishment of Prometheus. Ione is portrayed as younger and more childlike than Panthea and Asia. She is described sleeping in an underwater cave with Panthea, with her arms wrapped around her sister like a child, and her role in the plot is less central than the role assigned to Panthea and Asia as she is not party to the dreams that they share and does not accompany them to visit the Demogorgon. Instead, Ione is depicted as a passive observer of Prometheus's torture, one who is sympathetic with Prometheus's struggle but who can do little to affect the outcome of events. She and Panthea provide a perspective through which the reader can witness Prometheus's struggle as he is tormented by Furies and

soothed by good spirits sent by the Earth, while he is chained to the mountain in Act 1.

Mercury – Mercury is a messenger God sent by Jupiter to seek a compromise with Prometheus during his imprisonment on the mountain, as Panthea and Ione watch from a nearby peak. Mercury is portrayed as a well-meaning but weak character. It is painful for him to see Prometheus suffer and he shows disdain for the Furies, who are waiting eagerly for Prometheus to reject Jupiter's compromise so that they can torture him. Mercury pleads with Prometheus to accept Jupiter's offer and this demonstrates that Mercury, unlike Prometheus, sees the value in negotiation and reaching an agreement which, to an extent, pleases both parties. Prometheus, however, views this course of action as self-serving, implicitly suggesting Mercury's willingness to value personal gain over the greater good. Mercury's weakness thus serves to highlight Prometheus's strength, in that he is willing to sacrifice his own wellbeing for the sake of humanity even though an escape from his torment has been offered. Mercury is clearly a powerful God, as he is the messenger for Jupiter and is able to frighten and hold off the Furies. His decision to work for rather than resist Jupiter, therefore, can be viewed as a personal weakness rather than a lack of knowledge or power. Shelley's depiction of Mercury draws upon Roman mythology, in which Mercury is a messenger god who negotiates between the realm of gods and the human world. He also frequently represents commerce, trade, and negotiation in classical stories.

Demogorgon – The Demogorgon in *Prometheus Unbound* is a spirit of the underworld, associated with the realm of night or the world of the dead in pagan mythology. He represents an eternal force in nature which cannot change the course of history but is privy to some secrets of destiny and fate. He is the child of Jupiter and the goddess Thetis, whom Jupiter has raped; the Demogorgon is more powerful than both his parents, as their powers have combined in him. When confronted by Panthea and Asia, who have been led to the underworld by a dream, the Demogorgon reveals that Jupiter, although he reigns supreme over earth and Heaven, is still subject to **the spirit of Love**, whom "everything in the universe is subject to." The Demogorgon travels with Asia and Panthea to Heaven and topples Jupiter down into the abyss, thus ending the God's reign. Demogorgon is reminiscent of the character of Death from John Milton's *Paradise Lost*, the child of Satan and Sin and who inhabits the vast realm of Night between Hell and the Earth. The Demogorgon is also associated with fate or destiny in Shelley's poem and is described as the "doom which lies coiled under the throne of Jupiter," suggesting that Jupiter's downfall has always been inevitable and that the God's attempts to cling to power are futile.

The Earth – The Earth is personified in *Prometheus Unbound* as a mother grieving for her child, Prometheus, and for her inhabitants, humanity. At the beginning of the poem, the Earth is fearful about what will become of her and the inhabitants of the planet if they further offend Jupiter. She fears being tortured further (describing her route around the sun as a "wheel of pain" which Jupiter has "linked" her to). When Prometheus asks to hear the curse that he'd uttered against Jupiter but that he has now forgotten, the Earth calls up the Phantasm of Jupiter from the shadow realm so that Jupiter's rage will "sweep through" the realm of phantoms rather than affect those who are alive on the Earth. The Earth's grief over the treatment of Prometheus is described as the "poisoned breath" of a mother grieving her child and, as a result of the Earth's pain, humanity too has suffered. "Poisonous weeds" have sprung up alongside nutritious plants and humans have struggled to live in harmony with nature since Jupiter imprisoned Prometheus. As Jupiter's reign has stripped humanity of their ability to use the knowledge that Prometheus gave them, human beings have damaged the Earth in their attempts to control their environment; the Earth suffers under the violence that man does to each other and that they do to the environment through industry and the building of cities. The personification of the Earth in Shelley's poem has its roots in Greek mythology, in which the Earth was symbolized by a goddess called Gaia. It also highlights Shelley's belief in pantheism, or nature worship, as well as the importance of respecting and maintaining a harmonious balance with nature rather than stripping the Earth of resources for the sake of industrialization.

The Spirit of the Earth – The Spirit of the Earth is a childlike spirit who was very fond of Asia, Prometheus's wife, before the corruption of Jupiter's reign. She used to play with and confide in Asia, whom she called "mother." During Jupiter's reign, in which man's relationship with nature was damaged, Asia notes that she has not seen the Spirit of the Earth. Once Prometheus is freed, Jupiter is toppled, and man's harmonious relationship with nature is restored, the Spirit of the Earth is set free once more and runs careless and wild through the world. It is implied that the Spirit of the Earth is the child of Asia and Prometheus. This suggests that the union of knowledge, symbolized by Prometheus, and love, symbolized by Asia, creates greater communion with nature among mankind. The Spirit of the Earth is associated with appreciation of and freedom in nature, reflecting Shelley's belief that time spent in nature was extremely important for man's wellbeing.

The Furies – The Furies are spirits from Hell who are sent by Jupiter to torment Prometheus while he is chained to the mountain. The Furies mock and torment Prometheus with visions of humanity's demise under Jupiter's reign. They are disdainful of all compassion, love, and of Prometheus's care for humans and morality. Although the Furies can invade Prometheus's body and mind to torture him, their power is depicted as illusory and reliant, in part, on a façade. When the Furies are taunting Prometheus about the punishments which

they intend to enact on him, one mentions the horrors of Hell that await him. This Fury is quickly hushed by another, as they say that it is better for Prometheus to imagine the powers of Hell rather than know them. This suggests that Hell's power is weak and relies on the anticipation of horror to frighten people into compliance, rather than wielding real power. In contrast, **the Spirit of Love** in the poem is depicted as a power which cannot be resisted and which "everything in the universe is subject to." The Furies are also subject to Jupiter and easily held back by Mercury, which suggests that they are servants of power rather powerful beings themselves. Like all the evil beings in Shelley's poem, the Furies cannot be truly happy because they are enslaved rather than free.

Hercules – Hercules is a demigod (half mortal and half god) who frees Prometheus from his chains on the mountain, where he has been imprisoned by the tyrant God Jupiter. In Roman mythology Hercules is the son of Jupiter and a mortal woman, Alcmene, and is a hero who performs many superhuman feats. It was common in epics and classical mythology for authors to include cameos by famous heroes in their stories; Shelley continues this tradition by including the famous figure of Hercules briefly in his narrative but expands very little on Hercules's actions within the poem.

Apollo – Apollo is the sun god, in both Greek and Roman mythology, who witnesses the fall of Jupiter after Prometheus has been set free. Apollo, like all the gods and natural forces in Shelley's poem, has been enslaved by Jupiter and is grateful to see the end of Jupiter's reign. Conversing with Ocean, the personification of and god of the sea, Apollo expresses his delight that he will no longer have to look down from the sky and witness cruelty and violence committed by man, who has been given the knowledge and freedom to act with compassion and kindness through the destruction of Jupiter and emancipation of Prometheus. Apollo is so shocked by Jupiter's fall that he stands and watches in wonder, causing the night to last into the day as the sun has forgotten to rise.

Ocean – Ocean is the god of the sea, the personification of the oceans, and the father of the sea nymphs Panthea, Ione, and Asia. Ocean, like all the natural elements, has been enslaved by Jupiter and is pleased to be set free when Prometheus is unchained and Jupiter falls from power. Ocean has a conversation with Apollo, the sun god, on the day of Jupiter's fall and expresses his pleasure that his waters will no longer be turned red with blood as a result of the cruelty and acts of violence performed by men. This reflects the return of harmony between mankind and nature, which has been restored as a result of Prometheus's defiance and Jupiter's fall.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Good Spirits – The Good Spirits are the counterparts of the Furies and are sent by the Earth to comfort Prometheus during his imprisonment after the Furies have tormented him.

The Phantasm of Jupiter – The shadow version of Jupiter who is called up by the Earth to repeat Prometheus's curse.

The Moon – The barren sister planet of the Earth who is brought back to life alongside the Earth after Prometheus's liberation.

THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



KNOWLEDGE AND FREEDOM

In the classical story of Prometheus, the Titan is punished by the ruler of the Greek Gods, Zeus, for giving humanity the gift of **fire**. By giving humans fire Prometheus gives mankind the ability to survive in the wilderness and to make use of the tools of his environment. Fire in the story thus symbolizes knowledge and civilization, while the fact that Prometheus is punished for his gift to mankind has traditionally suggested that providing humans with knowledge is an act of transgression. There are thus clear parallels between Prometheus's story and the Book of Genesis, in which Adam and Eve eat from the tree of knowledge in the Garden of Eden, against God's wishes, and, as a result, bring sin into the world. In his version of *Prometheus Unbound*, however, Shelley draws on both classical and Christian imagery to challenge the idea that knowledge is sinful or transgressive. Instead, his *Prometheus Unbound* suggests that knowledge is something that *helps* humanity because it gives them the capacity to fully understand their own behavior and, in turn, allows them to freely make wise and moral choices.

Shelley's poem opens on the image of Prometheus chained to the mountain, suffering under the punishment administered by Jupiter (the Roman counterpart of Zeus). This image immediately establishes Prometheus's action of providing humans with knowledge as an affront to the Gods. In fact, the entire first act of *Prometheus Unbound* focuses on Prometheus's torture at the hands of Jupiter, who has ruled supreme over Heaven, the Earth, and mankind since Prometheus's capture. By focusing on Prometheus's punishment rather than his transgression, Shelley highlights Jupiter's cruelty. This helps Shelley to frame Jupiter as the villain of *Prometheus Unbound* and center the rebellious and defiant Prometheus as the hero. This, in turn, positions the gift of knowledge as something worth any cost.

Jupiter's cruelty is further highlighted in Act 2, when Asia, a sea nymph who is Prometheus's wife, explains that Prometheus originally gave knowledge to Jupiter on the condition that the

god "let man be free." Jupiter however, enslaved mankind, and as such Prometheus gave human beings knowledge so that they could tame the hostile environment that Jupiter had provided for them. At first, man used this knowledge for good, inventing language, science, and the arts, until Jupiter captured Prometheus and spread his own negative example—of greed, fear and power-lust—among mankind. Asia's description of Prometheus's transgression, and Jupiter's response to it, highlights the fact that what is considered by Jupiter to be a sin actually had a positive effect on humanity and that, although Prometheus is punished like a criminal, he has really acted in humanity's best interests by trying to provide them with knowledge.

However, because Jupiter has bound Prometheus (who symbolizes knowledge and free will) humanity has become misguided and used its knowledge for evil instead of good. By binding Prometheus, Jupiter has placed restrictions on knowledge: though humanity makes use of the tools that knowledge has allowed them to create, they cannot use them effectively for good because they lack the self-knowledge and the free-will to fully comprehend their own behavior. This is in keeping with the fact that, although Shelley was a radical thinker who felt that education was a gift, he was also wary of the effects of unchecked scientific exploration, which was an ever-growing concern in the nineteenth century. Shelley felt that empirical science, with no sense of morals or ethics to underpin it, could lead humanity to disaster. (This is also the theme of *Frankenstein*, written by Mary Shelley, Shelley's wife, which had the subtitle *The Modern Prometheus.)* Shelley's *Prometheus* suggests that, in the wrong hands, knowledge can be a destructive force as well as a tool of freedom.

Prometheus is the only being in the world whom Jupiter cannot conceal knowledge from, and therefore cannot subdue. Jupiter is thus afraid of Prometheus and the influence that the Titan's guidance would have on humanity, as this would allow humankind to think for themselves and question Jupiter's authority. Ironically, then, although Prometheus is bound, he is truly free from Jupiter's evil influence as he fully understands both the potential evil and the potential good of his actions. As a result, Prometheus is able to choose wisely, with good, rather than evil, in mind.

After Jupiter has fallen, Prometheus is freed by Hercules and a new age of wisdom and freedom is established on earth. Jupiter's fall signifies the liberation of knowledge among mankind. The Furies previous description of a confused world in which the wise have no love, and the loving have no wisdom, has been defeated and, instead, knowledge mixed with love and compassion is available to all. Celebrating his freedom, Prometheus states that man is also "now free," explicitly linking his own fate with the whole of humankind's.

Prometheus anticipates that this liberation of knowledge will lead to the discovery of "arts unimagined" and notes that "man grows wise and kind, and veil by veil, evil and error fall." This suggests that the result of Prometheus toppling Jupiter has been an increase in knowledge among human beings. Shelley therefore suggests that knowledge, when used with noble aims in mind, is a positive force for mankind and will advance the progress of civilization, potentially alleviating suffering in the world. According to Shelley, it is only by making knowledge fully available to all, and by allowing people the freedom to explore and question beliefs, that humanity can advance as a species—because only then will people have the tools available to choose the wisest course for the greatest good.



AUTHORITY AND RESISTANCE

Shelley's Prometheus symbolizes resistance against authoritarian forces, even if that resistance leads to punishment or isolation. Shelley himself was a non-conformist and a radical thinker who was disgusted by the rigid social conventions and class systems of the nineteenth century, which he felt kept the poor enslaved and placed restrictions on the human mind, body, and spirit. Shelley despised conventions such as marriage and institutions like the Christian Church and the Monarchy. He believed that individuals must be free to think, act, and make decisions for themselves and that social institutions placed obstacles in the way of this, disrupting the natural course of life and deliberately misguiding people in order to achieve their own corrupt aims. In *Prometheus Unbound*, Jupiter represents a culmination of these forces that Shelley viewed as oppressive, while the poet's depiction of Prometheus celebrates the unwavering spirit of the individual who refuses to bow to corrupt powers.

Shelley demonstrates his own personal resistance to archaic and corrupt sources of power through his use of imagery in *Prometheus Unbound*. For example, he uses Jupiter's reign to symbolize the powerful institutions that the poet felt prevented social reform—reform that, in his mind, was desperately needed to alleviate suffering among the populace. Jupiter is notably referred to as a "Monarch" and described as carrying a "sceptre of pale gold." This associates Jupiter with the worldly powers that Shelley opposed, such as the Church and the Monarchy; the "pale sceptre" is a symbol of kingly power and also an item carried by the Pope, who is head of the Catholic Church.

Jupiter also symbolizes the restrictive social conventions in Britain during the Enlightenment period. Shelley felt that repressive social customs, which discouraged emotional expression and, instead, encouraged social order and rationality, were slowing the advancement of society and indirectly supporting outdated establishments like the Church and Monarchy. This is reflected in the poem when the Furies visit Prometheus in Act 1 and tell him that under Jupiter's corrupt reign, men are ruled by "hypocrisy and custom" rather than honesty and virtue. Shelley uses the image of Prometheus

reining in Jupiter, "as one who checks a wild-eyed charioteer," to suggest that powerful institutions need to be reined in by resistance from individuals among the populace. This image is later repeated by the image of **the Hours** as "wild-eyed charioteers," as the Hours are the slaves of Jupiter who, in turn, make humanity slaves to the passage of time and mortality. By including such imagery in his poem, Shelley hoped to inspire a spirit of resistance and nonconformity among his readers.

By undermining the will of Jupiter and giving humanity **fire**, Prometheus has challenged the established authority and, as a result, is punished. Shelley frames this behavior as heroic and ultimately successful, despite the pain it causes Prometheus. Prometheus is heralded as a "champion" of humankind because he is willing to sacrifice his own comfort in order to stand up to power and challenge Jupiter's "supreme" reign. Romanticism as a movement valued individual resistance to authority and felt that it was more noble to be ostracized from society than to compromise one's morals or ideals in order to conform or be accepted. This individualism is further reflected in Prometheus's refusal to reach a compromise with Jupiter when this option is offered to him by the messenger Mercury. In his Preface to *Prometheus Unbound* Shelley notes that he deviates from the classical subject matter, the Aeschylus text, on this point because in Aeschylus's version of the story, Jupiter (Zeus) and Prometheus reach a compromise and Prometheus accepts Jupiter's partial rule over the Earth. Shelley's Romantic hero, by contrast, is uncompromising and will not bow to Jupiter's oppressive authority regardless of the torment he faces as a result, inviting Jupiter instead to "pour forth the cup of pain." Prometheus's refusal to support Jupiter's reign, which he feels is detrimental to humanity, suggests that it is more heroic to actively support justice and morality for all than to make compromises with corrupt authority for the sake of comfort and personal gain.

Although Prometheus is tortured, he feels pity for Jupiter and refuses to repeat the curse that he had addressed to Jupiter when he was first chained to the mountain. This represents Shelley's belief in passive resistance as a tool for social change rather than violent acts of revolution. Similarly, Prometheus maintains that he is "king" over himself even as the Furies torture him. This reflects Shelley's belief in an individual's duty to control themselves, even if provoked, and not to give into the temptation of attacking their enemy in a way which compromises their own morals. Although Prometheus did initially curse Jupiter, he now pities him because he is evil and, therefore, can only feel negative emotions which "gape like a hell within." Prometheus, meanwhile, despite his torture, can feel "peace" in his own mind because he has stood by his principles and not abandoned a course which he believes to be moral. This demonstrates Shelley's belief in the individual as a force that can threaten powerful institutions.

Shelley uses the metaphor of resistance gathering "flake by flake" to form an avalanche to suggest that if enough individuals choose to resist corrupt sources of power, then eventually a collective change will be made. Indeed, the poet's imagery demonstrating the power of individual resistance has echoed throughout many of history's social justice movements, including the American Civil Rights Movement. By highlighting Prometheus's dignity, in his refusal to curse Jupiter, and his determination to resist Jupiter without sinking to Jupiter's level of cruelty, Shelley builds a case for passive resistance as a noble and heroic form of social action.



CHRISTIANITY AND FORGIVENESS

Despite his rejection of conventional religion, Shelley fuses the classical story of Prometheus with Christian allegory, referring particularly to the teachings of Christ and his message that love and forgiveness—rather than worldly powers—are the true strengths of humanity. Although Shelley felt that Christ's teachings had been distorted by the Church, he does reference Jesus and use Christian imagery to support his central thesis in *Prometheus Unbound*: that love is stronger than—and will ultimately triumph over—hate.

The Furies, monsters from the world of the dead who are sent to torture Prometheus, mock his dedication to the freedom of mankind by informing him that "one" man (Jesus) has already attempted to teach humanity about love and forgiveness but that people have rejected this message. Clearing referencing Jesus, the Furies tell Prometheus that "one came forth of gentle worth, smiling on the sanguine earth." Although Jesus's "words outlived him," his message has not been used for good but has been corrupted by men "like swift poison, withering up truth, peace and pity." This refers to the way in which the Christian Church has deviated from Jesus's teachings and, instead, uses Jesus's name to gain power for themselves. The Furies view humanity's treatment of Jesus and rejection of his message as proof that humanity is damned and that Prometheus's endeavor to resist Jupiter is in vain because, even if Jupiter were to fall from power, humanity is too corrupt to be saved.

The Furies taunt Prometheus about this to try and break his spirit. Although Prometheus still refuses to bow to Jupiter, he is saddened by the story of Jesus and weeps for Jesus's "mild and gentle ghost," who wails "for the faith he kindled." This suggests that Shelley was sympathetic towards the teachings of Jesus and felt that, based on his characterization in the New Testament, Jesus would dislike the actions of the Church which are carried out in his name. Jesus is presented as a tragic figure in the poem and Christianity as a philosophy that has strayed very far from its central message of forgiveness and compassion.

Despite Shelley's rejection of orthodox religion, there are many similarities between Christ and Shelley's hero Prometheus. Prometheus is described as the "saviour" of mankind, just as

Jesus is referred to as man's saviour in the Bible. Prometheus, like Christ, undergoes a sacrificial torture because he has tried to help humanity. Prometheus is also described as the "sun" of mankind, suggesting that he will triumph over darkness. It is common in Christianity for Jesus to be associated with sunrise as a force which chases out darkness, which is associated with evil. It is also predicted that Prometheus will "quell the horseman grim, woundless though in heart or in limb." This prophecy suggests that Prometheus will kill death (the horseman) and this will end humanity's servitude to time and mortality. This is reminiscent of Christ's triumph over death through his own sacrificial death in the New Testament. Finally, Prometheus, like Christ, overcomes his enemies through forgiveness and love. **The Hours** and Jupiter are overthrown by **the Spirit of Love**, which everything in Shelley's poem is "subject to." While Prometheus's curse has frightened Jupiter, it is Prometheus's pity and forgiveness towards Jupiter which breaks the curse and ends Jupiter's reign, just as it is Christ's love which triumphs over death in the New Testament.

Christ's passive strength in the face of immense suffering is emulated by Shelley in the figure of Prometheus and is a crucial aspect of Prometheus's heroism, highlighting Shelley's belief that it is more valiant to vanquish one's enemies with compassion and forgiveness than with hatred and revenge. This message is further echoed when Panthea, a sea nymph and Asia's sister, and Asia follow their dream down to the lair of the Demogorgon and, swooning, are urged to "resist not the weakness" for "such strength there is in meekness." This echoes Christ's teaching that the meek will inherit the earth for they have true, emotional and spiritual power as opposed to worldly power.

Although Prometheus had cursed Jupiter when he was first chained to the mountain, during the course of his torment Prometheus has forgotten his curse. While the elements of the world "meditate" on Prometheus's threats to Jupiter "as a treasured spell" which implies their eventual liberation, it is actually Prometheus's refusal to renew his curse which strips Jupiter of his power. After Prometheus has stated that he no longer curses, but instead pities Jupiter, Panthea and Asia share a dream which confirms the prophecy that Prometheus will triumph over Jupiter and unleashes the Demogorgon—"the doom" which sits "coiled" under Jupiter's throne—and which topples Jupiter from power. Shelley's emphasis on forgiveness *as* heroism has parallels in the portrayal of Christ as the savior of mankind. However, Shelley's replacement of Christ with Prometheus suggests that, while he supports the message of forgiveness which Christianity contains, he feels that this message has become too corrupt to be salvaged and therefore, a new, radical form of moral belief must take its place.



NATURE, IMAGINATION, AND THE SUBLIME

Shelley viewed nature as a source of poetic and spiritual inspiration, a fact reflected in his extensive use of nature imagery in *Prometheus Unbound*. The Romantics felt that there was a natural sympathy between emotions, imagination, and the natural world and that natural images were the most intuitive metaphors for describing emotional and psychological states. In his Preface to *Prometheus Unbound*, Shelley notes that he has composed his poem "upon the mountain ruins of the Baths of Caracalla, among the flowery glades, and thickets of odoriferous blossoming trees." The inspiration for the poem comes from the arrival of spring in this beautiful landscape and this corresponds with the poem's themes of "new life" and hope for mankind. Shelley continues such imagery throughout the poem, ultimately suggesting the dependence of humanity on nature and the importance of seeking reverence for rather than dominance over the natural world.

Shelley uses nature imagery and metaphors to convey imaginative sensation to the reader throughout *Prometheus Unbound*. In Act 1, when Prometheus hears the dead speaking but cannot understand their words, he describes the whispering sound as "tingling" through his frame the way lightening "tingles, hovering ere it strikes." This suggests that Prometheus is on the brink of understanding the prophecy about himself but that he has not quite been struck by its true meaning. This conveys a recognisable feeling to the reader—when one can almost understand something, but full understanding is just out of reach—through a phenomenon from nature. Humans are also depicted as deeply connected with nature in *Prometheus Unbound*. Describing the birth of Prometheus—as one of the Titans from classical mythology, the Earth is Prometheus's mother—the Earth says that "joy ran, as blood within a living frame" when Prometheus, the only hope for humanity, was born. This connects the human body to the planet itself and suggests a correspondence between the physical and emotional health of people and the health of nature and the Earth. The Earth is also enslaved by Jupiter, alongside humanity, describing herself as "linked to some wheel of pain" by the tyrant, which refers to the Earth's fixed route round the sun. This furthers the metaphor of a connection between humans and their environment.

Although nature is framed as a force which corresponds with and should exist in harmony with humanity in *Prometheus Unbound*, Jupiter's tyranny over the Earth has broken this bond between humans and nature and, as a result of this, humanity either struggles with its environment or seeks to destroy, consume, or control it. While Prometheus is chained (representing for Shelley the current state of humanity when he is writing) humanity is out of sync with nature and, therefore, nature presents a threat to humanity as well as a

source of inspiration and joy. Since Prometheus has been chained and Jupiter has ruled the Earth, plague and famine have ravaged humanity and plants, which should nourish humans, have been mixed with "poisonous weeds."

The potential for both beauty *and* destruction in nature (while Prometheus is chained) is encapsulated in the Romantic idea of the Sublime, in which nature is both an awe-inspiring and an incomprehensible force. A common Romantic metaphor for this is the image of shipwrecks which Shelly uses several times throughout *Prometheus Unbound*, as the image of a shipwreck symbolizes man's helplessness in the face of a natural force like the sea. Shelley's descriptions of "cities sinking in howling ruin" also suggest his hostility towards industrialization and urban expansion. Throughout the nineteenth century, rural agriculture declined consistently while the industrial revolution drove people to the cities where poverty and overcrowding led to disease and terrible living conditions in slums, as well as a diminishing of the surrounding countryside. Shelley's poem suggests that humans must accept that they will never be able to fully comprehend or control nature and that their arrogance in trying, through technological advancement and industrialization, is a threat to the natural world and to their own existence within it.

Hope to bridge the gap between man and nature comes in the form of poetry, love, and the imagination in *Prometheus Unbound*. This union is finally achieved when Prometheus is unbound and the Spirit of the Earth runs free again, filling people with wonder at the beauty of the natural world. When Prometheus is visited by the good spirits, one tells him that she has travelled to him from a poet's lips while he was composing an imaginative work and was immersed in nature. This suggests that the composition of poetry is a virtuous act that advances human society, especially when it is inspired by and draws the reader's attention to the natural world. Prometheus's release from the mountain and the fall of Jupiter represent the return of man's communion with nature and suggests that, from that moment on, humanity will be able to flourish in nature and will no longer struggle with famine, disease, or death, which Prometheus has banished.

The personification of the sun (Apollo) and the Ocean notably rejoice in this renewed harmony between man and nature, delighted that there will be "no more" "blood and groans." This implies that humanity and nature are profoundly linked and that, when humans mistreat each other, they also mistreat the natural world with which they are joined. This parallels the Christian idea that hurting one person means hurting all humanity, but Shelley extends this idea to the natural world as well. Through his personification of nature in *Prometheus Unbound* Shelley demonstrates that respect for nature and a better understanding of the natural world, rather than an over-reliance on industrial technology, will renew humanity's bond with its environment and remind people that, to an extent, nature and humanity rely on each other to survive.

SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



FIRE

Fire symbolizes knowledge in *Prometheus Unbound*. In the story, Prometheus "tamed fire" for humanity after Jupiter misused his power as a ruler and failed to share the knowledge, which he had been given by Prometheus, with humanity. Without this knowledge that was their "birthright," humanity had no power of thought or reason and therefore no ability to understand their emotions or to feel love. Rather than providing humanity with fully formed knowledge, however, Prometheus instead gave humankind fire, granting people the freedom to develop tools and advance civilization as they wished. The power and freedom contained within the gift of fire reflects humanity's instinct to explore, think, experiment, and discover things for themselves.

Prometheus, who is a "champion" of freedom and knowledge, gave this gift freely, while the tyrannical Jupiter fears, denies and represses it. Jupiter's fear of fire—really, his fear of knowledge and the independent thinking such knowledge inevitably entails—springs from the possibility that his role as supreme authority will be compromised if humanity learns to question the way he rules them. Knowledge in this sense is, like fire, a powerful and unpredictable force that cannot necessarily be contained once it is set free. The Furies imply as much when they suggest that Prometheus's gift of knowledge to mankind has "kindled" a desire for power that "outran" him. Although the Furies mean this in a negative sense, Prometheus insists that the benefits of knowledge outweigh its destructive tendencies when it is allowed to flourish unrepressed. The ending of Shelley's poem, in which the Earth is transformed into a planet suffused with love, suggests that true freedom requires full, unbridled knowledge, as only with such knowledge can humans make decisions based in love.



THE HOURS

The Hours represent the passage of time as humans experience it. They are the servants of Jupiter, who uses the Hours to enslave mankind; this personification of time suggests that humans are slaves to the processes of aging and mortality, which is a major cause of suffering in the world. The Hours ride around the world in chariots, some of them racing forwards "as though pursued" and others enjoying the speed at which they travel. This represents human's inability to live in the present. The Hours,

then, symbolize both the experience of wishing time would go faster and the sense of enjoying oneself so much that time seems to pass by too quickly. In either case, humanity cannot control time even as people use it to structure their lives.

The Hours also represent Shelley's dislike of the industrial work day, which, as factory jobs became more prevalent in urban centers, parceled the day up into working hours and dictated where people must be and what they must be doing at various times. Shelley felt that this was a type of modern tyranny being enacted upon the human spirit and that it went against the natural inclination of mankind, which was to follow the rhythms of nature. Shelley felt that the industrial work day—and the installation of public clocks in cities, which led to an increased awareness of time as a unit of productivity—increased the rift between humans and their natural environment and made city workers the slaves of the greedy and the powerful, who controlled every aspect of their lives.



THE SPIRIT OF LOVE

The Spirit of Love represents the most powerful force in the universe, to which all beings are "subject." The personification of Love as the highest being in the universe supports Shelley's message in *Prometheus Unbound* that love and compassion are more powerful than violence and aggression. Shelley depicts the Spirit of Love as an attractive youth who rides a chariot around the circuit run by **the Hours**, the spirits of time whom Jupiter has unleashed on the world and who have made slaves of humankind. The Spirit of Love is depicted as moving around the edge of this circle run by the Hours, suggesting that Love is not bound or constrained by time in the way that humanity is under Jupiter's reign.

The Spirit of Love's chariot is an "ivory shell inlaid with crimson **fire**." The "ivory shell" connects the Spirit of Love to the shell blown by Spirits of the Hour, which spreads love all around the world when it is sounded. This shell also originally belonged to Asia, Prometheus's wife: when Asia is described as riding on the sea in a shell, this evokes images of the birth of Venus, the classical goddess of love, and thus connects Asia with love. Asia and Prometheus's coupling, then, represents the union of love and knowledge. This is further reflected by the fact that Love's chariot is notably "inlaid with crimson fire" because Love and knowledge are inseparable in *Prometheus Unbound*. Humanity must have access to both in order to act in a way that allows hope to flourish in the world.

QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the W.W. Norton edition of *Shelley's Poetry and Prose* published in 2002.

Preface Quotes

I was averse from a catastrophe so feeble as that of reconciling the Champion with the Oppressor of mankind. The moral interest of the fable which is so powerfully sustained by the sufferings and endurance of Prometheus, would be annihilated if we could conceive of him as unsaying his high language, and quailing before his successful and perfidious adversary.

Related Characters: Prometheus

Related Themes:

Page Number: 206

Explanation and Analysis

In his Preface, Shelley sets out to justify some of the creative decisions he made while writing *Prometheus Unbound*. Shelley draws attention to the fact that he has adapted his story from a classical play of the same name, by the Greek writer Aeschylus, and seeks to justify the ways in which he has deviated from the original source material. Shelley is using his poem to make a statement of resistance against the establishments of the Enlightenment period, which he felt had become corrupt. Shelley draws attention to the fact that he deviates from Aeschylus's original subject matter, in which Prometheus and Jupiter reach a compromise, in order to strengthen the emotional resonance and the key message of his "fable." It is important that Shelley refers to his poem as a "fable," as a fable is a type of classical story underpinned by a specific moral that the reader is expected to understand and emulate in everyday life.

Shelley feels that his message about resisting corrupt forms of power, at the risk of personal injury and imprisonment, would be undermined if Prometheus settled his dispute amicably with Jupiter. Therefore, Shelley highlights this change to further cement the message of *Prometheus Unbound* in the reader's mind and to remind them that the themes and messages of poetry are meant to be treated seriously, as things to be emulated in the real world, and not simply as a form of light entertainment.

> The only imaginary being resembling in any degree Prometheus, is Satan; and Prometheus is, in my judgement, a more poetical character than Satan because, in addition to courage and majesty and firm and patient opposition to omnipotent force, he is susceptible of being described as exempt from the taints of ambition, envy, revenge, and a desire for personal aggrandizement, which in the Hero of *Paradise Lost*, interfere with the interest. The character of Satan engenders in the mind a pernicious casuistry which leads us to weigh his faults with his wrongs and to excuse the former because the latter exceed all measure. In the minds of those who consider that magnificent fiction with a religious feeling, it engenders something worse. But Prometheus is, as it were, the type of the highest perfection of moral and intellectual nature, impelled by the purest and the truest motives to the best and noblest ends.

Related Characters: Prometheus

Related Themes:

Page Number: 207

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage of the Preface, Shelley draws attention to the fact that he has partially modeled the character of Prometheus on the character of Satan as he appears in John Milton's 1667 epic poem, *Paradise Lost*. Shelley was a Romantic poet, and the Romantics were particularly influenced by Milton's personification of Satan in *Paradise Lost*, which describes Satan's fall from heaven and then his part in the Fall of Man in the biblical Book of Genesis. William Blake, one of the forerunners of the Romantic movement, portrayed Satan as a spirit of freedom and knowledge who was punished for challenging a corrupt and power-hungry God. Blake's portrayal of Satan in *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* was based on *Paradise Lost* and became an important influence on Romantic poetry. Shelley was also influenced by Milton in his combination of classical epic conventions with Christian allegory.

As Shelley wants his readers to emulate Prometheus's behavior, he does not wish to create a hero who is a bad influence. Instead, Shelley uses a figure who is similar to Satan (Prometheus, who transgresses against the gods by giving humans knowledge) but endows him with Christian virtues (such as kindness and compassion) so that his readers will emulate Satan's quest for freedom of knowledge, and Christ's message of love and forgiveness, but not Satan's negative qualities like "ambition" and "desire for vengeance."

> We owe the great writers of the golden age of our literature to that fervid awakening of the public mind which shook to dust the oldest and most oppressive form of the Christian Religion. We owe Milton to the progress and development of the same spirit; the sacred Milton was, let it ever be remembered, a Republican and a bold enquirer into morals and religion. The great writers of our own age are, we have reason to suppose, the companions and forerunners of some unimagined change in our social condition or the opinions which cement it. The cloud of mind is discharging its collected lightning, and the equilibrium between institutions and opinions is now restoring, or is about to be restored.

Related Themes:

Page Number: 207

Explanation and Analysis

In his Preface, Shelley lays out his belief that great literature is both the result of and an agent in producing social change. He gives several examples of this and relates these to the nineteenth century, the time in which Shelley was writing. The "golden age" that Shelley refers to is the Renaissance, which took place between the fourteenth and the seventeenth centuries in Europe. The Renaissance was a period of scientific exploration and artistic advancement that propelled Europe out of the medieval or the "Dark Ages," a period marked by cultural stagnation due to the powerful role of the Church in society and the lack of scientific advancement. The Renaissance, according to Shelley, represented a period in which people began to question the authority of the Church.

Shelley feels that John Milton, who wrote *Paradise Lost*, was a bold, enquiring mind, who questioned the status quo and, through literature, inspired others to do so as well. Shelley had an interest in "Republican" ideas, as opposed to rule by Monarchy, because of his interest in the French Revolution, in which the Monarchy were deposed, and a Republic established. Shelley believes another social change like this is imminent. He uses a metaphor to express this belief ("the cloud of mind discharging it's collective lightening") and to suggest that antiquated establishments like the Church, which still retained power in Europe, would soon become outdated as public opinion changed.

Act 1 Quotes

Monarch of Gods and Daemons, and all Spirits
But One, who throng those bright and rolling Worlds.
Which Thou and I alone of living things
Behold with sleepless eyes! regard this Earth
Made multitudinous with thy slaves [...]
[...]
Three thousand years of sleep-unsheltered hours
And moments—aye divided thy keen pangs
Till they seemed years, torture and solitude,
Scorn and despair,—these are mine empire:—
More glorious far than that which thou surveyest
From thine unenvied throne [...]

Related Characters: Prometheus (speaker), Jupiter

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 1.1-5, 12-17

Explanation and Analysis

For the past three thousand years, Prometheus has been tortured and chained to the mountainside, by the tyrant god Jupiter, as punishment for giving humanity the gift of fire. In this passage, Dawn is breaking on the mountainside, and Prometheus addresses Jupiter from his chains. Prometheus addresses Jupiter as the "Monarch of Gods and Daemons and all Spirits but One." This implies that Jupiter is the ruler of everything in the universe. The only thing he does not have control over is Prometheus's mind and his decision to oppose Jupiter. This is ironic because Prometheus is physically restrained by Jupiter and, yet, because of his refusal to bow to Jupiter, he is not fully in Jupiter's power and thus is not Jupiter's slave. Prometheus's mind is his "empire," which he has control over. Although Prometheus is tortured on the mountainside, he feels that his "empire" is "more glorious" than Jupiter's reign over the whole world. This suggests that Prometheus does not envy Jupiter for his power and feels that Jupiter is not entitled to rule over so much.

Prometheus also implies in this passage that he is only being in the world who has escaped becoming Jupiter's "slave." Prometheus, therefore, functions as Jupiter's opposite, or character foil, throughout the poem. While Jupiter is a symbol of tyranny and power, Prometheus is a symbol of freedom because he does not want power over others and refuses to bow to corrupt authority.

And yet to me welcome is Day and Night,
Whether one breaks the hoar frost of the morn,
Or starry, dim, and slow, the other climbs
The leaden-coloured East; for then they lead
Their wingless, crawling Hours, one among whom
—As some dark Priest hales the reluctant victim—
Shall drag thee, cruel King, to kiss the blood
From these pale feet, which then might trample thee
If they disdained not such a prostrate slave.—
Disdain? Ah no! I pity thee.—What Ruin
Will hunt thee undefended through the wide Heaven!
How will thy soul, cloven to its depth with terror,
Gape like a Hell within! I speak in grief
Not exultation, for I hate no more
As then, ere misery made me wise.—The Curse
Once breathed on thee I would recall. [...]

Related Characters: Prometheus (speaker), Jupiter

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 1.44-59

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Prometheus, still chained to the mountainside, continues his defiant speech directed at Jupiter. He tells Jupiter that the difference between Day and Night is meaningless to him because his whole life revolves around defying Jupiter, who is his torturer. Prometheus announces that he enjoys observing the passage of time because time brings him ever closer to Jupiter's inevitable demise, which he feels certain will take place even though he has no evidence for this. Time is personified in Shelley's poem: moments and hours are represented as spirits that Jupiter employs to bind humanity in the constraints of time and the constraints of their own mortality. Shelley disliked the tendency to divide the work day into hours, which was becoming more common in nineteenth-century society as industrial manufacturing jobs became more available. Shelley felt that this was a social tyranny that enslaved the individual and disrupted the natural rhythms of human life, which he felt should be based on nature and the individual's natural inclination.

Prometheus believes that one of these "Hours," or spirits, will bring the moment of Jupiter's defeat. Although this will bring about the defeat of his enemy, Prometheus genuinely pities Jupiter. This suggests that Jupiter's crimes are terrible and, therefore, will bring on a terrible retribution. It also supports Prometheus's claim that "misery has made

him wise" because he has learned compassion for Jupiter and feels that evil behavior cannot bring happiness and "gapes like a hell within."

> [...] Ye Mountains,
> Whose many-voiced Echoes, through the mist
> Of cataracts, flung the thunder of that spell!
> Ye icy Springs, stagnant with wrinkling frost,
> Which vibrated to hear me, and then crept
> Shuddering through India! Thou serenest Air,
> Through which the Sun walks burning without beams!
> And ye swift Whirlwinds, who on poised wings
> Hung mute and moveless o'er yon hushed abyss,
> As thunder louder than your own made rock
> The orbed world! If then my words had power
> —Though I am changed so that aught evil wish
> Is dead within, although no memory be
> Of what is hate—let them not lose it now!
> What was that curse? for ye all heard me speak.

Related Characters: Prometheus (speaker), Jupiter

Related Themes:

Page Number: 1.59-73

Explanation and Analysis

During his time chained to the mountain, as punishment for giving humanity the gift of fire against the wishes of the tyrant god, Jupiter, Prometheus has forgotten the curse he spoke against Jupiter when he was first imprisoned. He implores the elements to remind him of this curse.

Nature is personified in *Prometheus Unbound* and the elements Prometheus speaks to (the mountains, rivers, winds, and whirlwinds) have personalities and living spirits. Like Prometheus himself, they are timeless, immortal forces. Prometheus is a Titan, a group of semi-deities and the children of the Earth, or the goddess Gaia, in classical mythology. Prometheus is portrayed as more powerful than the natural elements, as they are enslaved by Jupiter and too afraid to challenge him. Prometheus notes that the elements "hung mute" when they heard his curse. This passage reflects Shelley's interests both in pantheism, or the idea that God manifests himself in nature (in other words, that all parts of the universe are made up of God), and in classical mythology in which nature was commonly personified.

Prometheus does not wish to renew his curse against Jupiter because he has learned compassion during his suffering and "aught evil wish is dead within" him. However, neither does he wish to bow to Jupiter and, although he does not wish to repeat his words, he acknowledges that they still contain a message of powerful defiance against Jupiter, which Prometheus wishes to maintain. This reflects Shelley's belief in non-violent resistant as an effective method for achieving social change.

> When thou didst from her bosom, like a cloud
> Of glory, arise, a spirit of keen joy!
> And at thy voice her pining sons uplifted
> Their prostrate brows from the polluting dust
> And our almighty Tyrant with fierce dread
> Grew pale—until his thunder chained thee here.—
> Then—see those million worlds which burn and roll
> Around us: their inhabitants beheld
> My sphered light wane in wide Heaven; the sea
> Was lifted by strange tempest, and new fire
> From earthquake-rifted mountains of bright snow
> Shook its portentous hair beneath Heaven's frown;
> Lightning and Inundation vexed the plains;
> Blue thistles bloomed in cities; foodless toads
> Within voluptuous chambers panting crawled;
> When Plague had fallen on man and beast and worm,
> And Famine,—and black blight on herb and tree,
> And in the corn and vines and meadow-grass
> Teemed ineradicable poisonous weeds
> Draining their growth, for my wan breast was dry
> With grief,—and the thin air, my breath, was stained
> With the contagion of a mother's hate
> Breathed on her child's destroyer [...]

Related Characters: The Earth (speaker), Jupiter, Prometheus

Related Themes:

Page Number: 1.157-179

Explanation and Analysis

The Earth, who is Prometheus's mother, describes his birth, which brought her "keen joy," followed by her despair when Jupiter chained him to the mountain. The Earth's despair causes tangible effects that change the nature of the planet, and are part of the curse of Jupiter's reign and Prometheus's imprisonment. The Earth suggests that Prometheus's birth brought her joy because it inspired "fierce dread" in Jupiter. This supports the idea that

Prometheus symbolizes and embodies freedom and knowledge, which creates a positive environment for humanity on Earth, while Jupiter embodies tyranny, violence, and corruption, which creates a negative environment on Earth. The fact that Jupiter is afraid of Prometheus suggests the Prometheus's power is stronger than Jupiter's, and that Jupiter knows this. His only recourse to protect his reign from Prometheus's power is to keep him imprisoned.

Jupiter's imprisonment of Prometheus negatively impacts the world, consequently emphasizing how Prometheus's birth positively impacted the world. The Earth tells Prometheus that, since his capture, the planet has become an inhospitable to humans, who are ravaged by "plague" and "famine"—direct results of the Earth's grief over Jupiter's actions. This suggests that the link between humanity and nature has been severed as a result of tyranny, ignorance, and power-lust, and reflects Shelley's belief that humanity and nature were closely linked and that what was bad for humanity was also bad for the planet.

> Aye, do thy worst. Thou art Omnipotent.
> O'er all things but thyself I gave thee power,
> And my own will. Be thy swift mischiefs sent
> To blast mankind, from yon etherial tower.
> Let thy malignant spirit move
> In darkness over those I love:
> On me and mine I imprecate
> The utmost torture of thy hate
> And thus devote to sleepless agony
> This undeclining head while thou must reign on high.
> [...]
>
> I curse thee! let a sufferer's curse
> Clasp thee, his torturer, like remorse,
> Till thine Infinity shall be
> A robe of envenomed agony;
> And thine Omnipotence a crown of pain
> To cling like burning gold round thy dissolving brain.

Related Characters: The Phantasm of Jupiter (speaker), The Earth, Jupiter, Prometheus

Related Themes:

Page Number: 1.272-281, 286-291

Explanation and Analysis

The Earth summons the Phantasm of Jupiter from the shadow world to repeat the curse that Prometheus has forgotten during his time chained to the mountain. In his curse, Prometheus willingly sacrifices himself to Jupiter's torments in the hope that humanity will one day be free. He is willing to suffer endless torture and even invites Jupiter's "malignant spirit [to] move" over those he loves so that some resistance to Jupiter's omnipotent reign exists within the world. This connects Prometheus to the figure of Christ, who dies as a sacrifice so that humanity may be freed from their sins and gain eternal life after death. Unlike Christ, however, Prometheus has spoken violent words against Jupiter in his curse, hoping that Jupiter's power becomes a "crown of pain" and burns his like melting gold, clinging to his "dissolving brain."

In his curse, Prometheus states that he hopes that Jupiter's evil actions will come back to haunt him, and that his power, which currently has negative consequences for everything on the planet, will eventually have terrible consequences for Jupiter himself. The reference to the "crown of burning gold" aligns Jupiter with worldly powers, such as kings, from Shelley's own society. Shelley hated the Monarchy and felt that powerful establishments of this sort should be dismantled.

> Awful Sufferer! To thee unwilling, most unwillingly
> I come, by the great Father's will driven down
> To execute a doom of new revenge.
> Alas! I pity thee, and hate myself
> That I can do no more.—Aye from thy sight
> Returning, for a season. Heaven seems Hell,
> So thy worn form pursues me night and day,
> Smiling reproach. Wise art thou, firm and good,
> But vainly wouldst stand forth alone in strife
> Against the Omnipotent [...]

Related Characters: Mercury (speaker), Jupiter, Prometheus

Related Themes:

Page Number: 1.353-362

Explanation and Analysis

Jupiter, who is omnipotent, hears Prometheus say that he does not wish to repeat his curse and takes this as a sign that Prometheus is vulnerable and that his position of defiance is weakening. He sends his messenger, Mercury (a messenger god in classical mythology, associated with compromise, negotiation, and trade), to try and tempt

Prometheus to compromise with Jupiter. Mercury admits that he runs Jupiter's errands "unwillingly." He implies that he does not agree with Jupiter's reign, even though he works for him, and calls Prometheus an "awful sufferer," which suggests that he hates to see Prometheus in pain. This suggests that Mercury wishes that freedom and knowledge were present in the world but is too cowardly to take a stand against Jupiter the way that Prometheus does.

Mercury admits that he is haunted by the image of Prometheus's suffering and that "Heaven seems Hell" to him. This suggests that compromising one's morals for personal gain will make that personal gain seem worthless. Mercury's experience suggests that it is impossible to truly enjoy the rewards he has received at the expense of his morals. Mercury is reluctant to take a stand against Jupiter because he believes that it is pointless and will do no good. This is why he believes that Prometheus's is suffering "vainly," or in vain. However, Shelley suggests that it is more noble to stand for a moral cause, even if it seems hopeless, than to give in to corrupt forms of power.

> Dost thou boast the clear knowledge thou waken'dst for man?
> Then was kindled within him a thirst which outran
> Those perishing waters: a thirst of fierce fever,
> Hope, love, doubt, desire—which consume him forever.
> One came forth, of gentle worth,
> Smiling on the sanguine earth;
> His words outlived him, like swift poison
> Withering up truth, peace and pity.

Related Characters: The Furies (speaker), Prometheus

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 1.542-549

Explanation and Analysis

After Prometheus declines Mercury's offer of a compromise, Jupiter sends the Furies, monsters from the world of the dead, to torture Prometheus. They show him images of suffering on earth, which they claim are the result of the knowledge he gave to humanity. The Furies suggests that Prometheus should not "boast" of giving humanity knowledge, as the knowledge he "kindled" has become a destructive force that "consumes them." This supports the symbolic link between knowledge and fire in the poem, as fire is something that can be both useful and destructive. This passage reflects Shelley's anxieties over the pursuit of empirical knowledge in the Enlightenment period, which Shelley felt "outran" its bounds and potentially threatened, rather than helped, humanity.

The Furies send Prometheus a vision of "one man of gentle worth," a reference to the figure of Christ. Shelley, who was an atheist, suggests that Jesus was a real figure but implies that he is not spiritually powerful compared to Prometheus. The Furies imply that humanity is beyond saving because they have distorted Christ's message. Instead of spreading compassion and love, Christ's message "withers up truth, peace, and pity." Shelley was critical of the Church, but he was sympathetic towards the teachings of Jesus and felt that Jesus's positive message of love and compassion had been corrupted and "poisoned" by the corruption of organized religion.

> [...] Nature's sacred watchwords—they
> Were borne aloft in bright emblazonry.
> The nations thronged around, and cried aloud
> As with one voice, "Truth, liberty and love!"
> Suddenly fierce confusion fell from Heaven
> Among them—there was strife, deceit and fear;
> Tyrants rushed in, and did divide the spoil.
> This was the shadow of the truth I saw.

Related Characters: Prometheus (speaker), Panthea, Ione

Related Themes:

Page Number: 1.648-655

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Prometheus tells Ione and Panthea about one of the visions that he witnessed while he was being tortured by the Furies. "Nature's watchwords" refers to the slogan, "Truth, liberty, and love." This suggests that this combination, of knowledge, freedom, and love, represents the ideal conditions for humanity to exist under. These "watchwords" also have a positive effect on nature, as the wellbeing of humanity is intimately connected with the wellbeing of the planet. This reflects Shelley's interest in pantheism and his belief that nature is a spiritual, living thing and an extension of human experience.

The image of "nations thronging" behind these words refers to the French Revolution, which took place between 1788 and 1799. During the French Revolution, rebels deposed

and executed the French Monarchy in an attempt to gain liberty for the French people, who were starving under the Monarchy's callous reign. The French Revolution's message of liberty, equality, and alleviation of poverty greatly influenced the Romantics. However, these aims were ultimately unfulfilled, and revolution ended in terror. Shelley connects these images of "fierce confusion" and "strife, deceit, and fear" to the central idea in his poem: that, without knowledge, freedom, and love, all attempts at revolution will end poorly and become tyrannical regimes. In the context of the poem, this reflects the negative influence of Jupiter's reign, under which humanity cannot reach its full potential.

Though Ruin now Love's shadow be,
Following him destroyingly
On Death's white and winged steed,
Which the fleetest cannot flee—
Trampling down both flower and weed,
Man and beast and foul and fair,
Like a tempest through the air;
Thou shalt quell this Horseman grim,
Woundless though in heart or limb.—

Related Characters: Good Spirits (speaker), Jupiter, The Furies, The Earth, Prometheus

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 1.780-788

Explanation and Analysis

After the Furies, Jupiter's servants and monsters from the world of the dead, have tortured Prometheus, the Earth calls up good spirits to comfort her son. These good spirits tell Prometheus of a prophecy that foretells hope and new life for the world, and that revolves around him. The Spirits tell Prometheus that, under Jupiter's reign, love has been displaced by ruin as the most powerful force in the world. This is because of the restrictions placed on knowledge and freedom under Jupiter's reign. Ruin and death are connected because ruin rides death's "winged steed." Ruin and death are described as inescapable, as everything on earth is doomed to die.

The spirits' prophecy of hope informs Prometheus that he will "quell this horseman grim," personifying death in the figure of a horseman. This is a common image because of a verse from the Book of Revelation, which describes death as one of the four horsemen of the Apocalypse who rides a pale horse. Although it seems that death is "woundless" and cannot be defeated, the spirits foretell that Prometheus will overcome him. This links Prometheus to the figure of Christ; Christ's death on the cross symbolizes a triumph over death because humanity gains the potential to enter heaven through Christ's sacrifice. Similarly, while currently "ruin" is "love's shadow," the prophecy will defeat this order and Prometheus will defeat ruin with an act of love.

Act 2, Scene 2 Quotes

If such live thus, have others other lives
Under pink blossoms or within the bells
Of meadow flowers, or folded violets deep,
Or on their dying odors, when they die,
Or in the sunlight of the sphered dew?

Aye, many more, which we may well divine.
But should we stay to speak, noontide would come,
And thwart Silenus find his goats undrawn
And grudge to sing those wise and lovely songs
Of fate and chance and God, and Chaos old.
And love, and the chained Titan's woeful doom
And how he shall be loosed, and make the Earth
One brotherhood—delightful strains which cheer
Our solitary twilights, and which charm
To silence the unenvying nightingales.

Related Characters: Asia, Panthea, Prometheus

Related Themes:

Page Number: 2.2.83-97

Explanation and Analysis

Panthea and Asia both receive prophetic dreams about Prometheus's release. Their dreams lead them towards the abyss and the realm of the Demogorgon, where they will learn a secret about the fate of the world. On the way, they pass a beautiful, enchanted glade and overhear two Fauns talking. The Fauns are discussing the idea that plants, flowers, and other elements of the natural world might contain living spirits. They suggest that there might be innumerable lives in the plant material all around them, like "under pink blossoms or within the bells of meadow flowers." This comment reflects Shelley's interest in pantheism, which is the belief in nature as a living, sentient being that is imbued with God or divinity. The Romantics. Shelley included, felt that humanity had become disconnected from the natural world and had forgotten how

to understand the natural world as a spiritual and vital part of their environment.

Pantheism is also common in pagan, classical culture, and this fueled the Romantic belief that older cultures were wiser than modern, industrial society, which often damaged nature through technological production. The description of sprites or spirits living in flowers is also reminiscent of the fairy lore that abounds in Shakespeare's poetry, as the poet was hugely influential on Shelley. This image of fauns and shepherds is also common in pastoral poetry: a classical style that represents idyllic scenes of rural life. The Fauns' wisdom is also demonstrated in their claim to know the prophecy about Prometheus and how "he shall be loosed, and make the Earth one brotherhood."

Act 2, Scene 3 Quotes

[...] Hark! the rushing snow!
The sun-awakened avalanche! whose mass,
Thrice sifted by the storm, had gathered there
Flake after flake, in Heaven-defying minds
As thought by thought is piled, till some great truth
Is loosened, and the nations echo round
Shaken to their roots: as do the mountains now.

Related Characters: Asia (speaker), Panthea, Jupiter

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 2.3.36-42

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Panthea and Asia reach the entrance to the lair of the Demogorgon. The entrance to the lair is in the mountains and the snow on the mountains reminds Asia of resistance gathering against Jupiter on Earth. In his Preface, Shelley states that he uses imagery from nature to reflect the internal working of the human mind. In this scene, Asia equates a view of the sun on snow capped mountains with the current state of humanity. The idea that the avalanche is "sun awakened" operates on two levels. First, avalanches are literally caused by the sun melting and loosening snow in the mountains. Second, the "sun awakened" avalanche represents knowledge, which illuminates the experience of humanity and inspires them to form an avalanche of resistance to Jupiter's tyranny. This relates to the comparison of Prometheus with the sun and the association between fire and knowledge, as fire is also a source of light and heat.

The image of the avalanche also suggests individuals within humanity acting together to form a mighty force. Although an avalanche is a large body of snow, this body of snow is made up of individual flakes. Shelley reveres both the collective force of the avalanche and the power of the individual flakes that make up a part of this mass. The phrase "heaven-defying minds" suggests both humanity's resistance to Jupiter in heaven and Shelley's personal dislike of the Church, which he viewed as a hindrance to knowledge.

Resist not the weakness—
Such strength is in meekness—
That the Eternal, the Immortal,
Must unloose through life's portal
The snake-like Doom coiled underneath his throne
By that alone!

Related Characters: Asia, Panthea, Jupiter, Demogorgon

Related Themes:

Page Number: 2.3.93-98

Explanation and Analysis

As Panthea and Asia get closer to the Demogorgon's lair, they are drawn down into a swoon that will take them through the final step of the journey. A chorus of voices urges them not to resist because their actions are necessary to fulfill the prophecy that will unseat Jupiter from power.

Panthea and Asia must give into "weakness" to fulfill the prophecy. This reflects Shelley's message that real strength exists in acts of love, sacrifice, and passive resistance, rather than through acts of aggression, power seeking, or violence. The idea that there is "strength in meekness" also mirrors Christ's message that the meek will inherit the earth as it is them who have true power, rather than power gained through violence or domination. This reflects Shelley's support of Christ's message despite Shelley's profound dislike of organized religion or the Church.

It is only through this act of voluntary weakness that Panthea and Asia will be able to "unloose" the "snake-like Doom" that sits "coiled underneath" Jupiter's throne, and bring about the end of Jupiter's tyrannical reign. The image of the Demogorgon as "snake-like" suggests that Jupiter's power is poisoned or corrupted and will one day bring about his demise. The image of a snake also connects the Demogorgon to the figure of Satan and reflects the

Romantic's use of Satan as a heroic, knowledge-giving figure, who opposes omnipotent authority; the Demogorgon will similarly help release Prometheus, who represents knowledge.

Act 2, Scene 4 Quotes

❝ Who reigns? There was the Heaven and Earth at first
And Light and Love;—then Saturn, from whose throne
Time fell, an envious shadow; such the state
Of the earth's primal spirits beneath his sway
As the calm joy of flowers and living leaves
Before the wind or sun has withered them
And semivital worms; but he refused
The birthright of their being, knowledge, power,
The skill which wields the elements, the thought
Which pierces this dim Universe like light,
Self-empire and the majesty of love,
For thirst of which they fainted. Then Prometheus
Gave wisdom, which is strength, to Jupiter
And with this Law alone: "Let man be free,"
Clothed him with the dominion of wide Heaven.

Related Characters: Asia (speaker), Demogorgon, Jupiter, Prometheus

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 2.4.32-46

Explanation and Analysis

Asia describes the origins of the world to the Demogorgon and describes Prometheus's role in giving Jupiter sovereignty over mankind. In classical mythology, Saturn is Jupiter's father and ruled over Earth and the gods. Shelley uses the themes of classical mythology (such as the rivalries between parents and children, and battles between the Titans and the gods) and suggests that Saturn was the original ruler of the planet, but that Prometheus helped Jupiter overthrow him by giving Jupiter knowledge. Saturn had access to knowledge but "refused" to share it with humanity. Knowledge is connected to fire as it is a tool that helps humanity "wield the elements." Knowledge is also connected with light, as intelligent thought is described as "piercing the dim Universe like light." This reflects the association of Prometheus with light and the sun, as Prometheus is destined to give knowledge back to humanity.

Saturn is also accused of inventing Time, which held "earth's primal spirits" in its "sway." This reflects the implication in Shelley's poem that living things are slaves to time because everything on earth is perishable and, therefore, constrained by time. Time is personified in the poem in the figures of the Hours, who were originally Saturn's servants and are now Jupiter's. While Jupiter had the opportunity to be a benign ruler, and to "let man be free," he has misused his power and become a tyrant like his father.

❝ First famine and then toil and then disease,
Strife, wounds, and ghastly death unseen before,
Fell; and the unseasonable seasons drove,
With alternating shafts of frost and fire,
Their shelterless, pale tribes to mountain caves;
And in their desert hearts fierce wants he sent
And mad disquietudes, and shadows idle
Of unreal good, which levied mutual war,
So ruining the lair w herein they raged.
Prometheus saw, and waked the legioned hopes
Which sleep within folded Elysian flowers,
Nepenthe, Moly, Amaranth, fadeless bloom
That they might hide with thin and rainbow wings
The shape of Death; and Love he sent to bind
The disunited tendrils of that vine
Which bears the wine of life, the hum an heart;
And he tamed fire, which like some beast of prey
Most terrible, but lovely, played beneath
The frown of man [...]

Related Characters: Asia (speaker), Jupiter, Prometheus

Related Themes:    

Related Symbols:  

Page Number: 2.4.50-69

Explanation and Analysis

Asia describes the state of humanity under Jupiter's reign, before Prometheus was chained to the mountain, and after Prometheus had given Jupiter the power to reign under the condition that he "let man be free." Jupiter, however, became a tyrant, so Prometheus gave humans fire so that they might subdue their hostile environment for themselves. Under Jupiter's negligent reign, and without knowledge to help them combat the elements or develop their intelligence, mankind struggles to survive. Asia describes the unpleasant conditions for man while Jupiter

withheld knowledge from them. They were unable to combat the seasons or the bad weather and unable to invent medicines to serve as pain relief or to cure diseases. They were also beset by "mad disquietudes," which suggests mental illness, delusional desires, or passions such as anger or greed that create and perpetuate suffering among mankind.

Prometheus, witnessing this, gave humanity knowledge so that they could conquer these problems themselves. As Prometheus is symbolic of knowledge and freedom of thought, it is important to Shelley's poem that he does not solve humanity's problems for them but gives them a means to solve problems themselves. Providing them with fire allows them to create heat, light, and tools. Prometheus also sends Love to dwell among humanity. This, coupled with the image of love "binding the disunited tendrils" of life's vine, reflects Shelley's idea that knowledge without love does not produce the ideal outcomes.

> He gave man speech, and speech created thought,
> Which is the measure of the Universe;
> And Science struck the thrones of Earth and Heaven,
> Which shook but fell not; and the harmonious mind
> Poured itself forth in all-prophetic song,
> And music lifted up the listening spirit
> Until it walked, exempt from mortal care,
> Godlike, o'er the clear billows of sweet sound;
> And human hands first mimicked and then mocked
> With moulded limbs more lovely than its own
> The human form , till marble grew divine,
> And others, gazing, drank the love men see
> Reflected in their race—behold, and perish.—
> He told the hidden power of herbs and springs,
> And Disease drank and slept—Death grew like sleep.—

Related Characters: Asia (speaker), Jupiter, Prometheus

Related Themes:

Page Number: 2.4.72-86

Explanation and Analysis

Asia describes the arts, which humanity created using the knowledge and the gift of fire that Prometheus gave them against Jupiter's will. It is implied that Prometheus's gift of knowledge allowed humanity to develop complex intelligence, including things like speech, thought, and self-awareness. The idea that "thought is the measure of the universe" suggests the philosopher Descartes' theory that man understands the world through thought, coining the famous phrase:], "I think therefore I am." Although Shelley was distrustful of an over-reliance on Enlightenment ideas of rationality and social order, he admired the intellectual principals behind the Enlightenment, which sought truth and knowledge and challenged ignorance and established authorities.

Asia observes the "Science struck the thrones of Earth and Heaven which shook but did not fall." This reflects Shelley's belief that knowledge and intellectual discovery present a challenge to established powers, such as the Church or the Monarchy. Although science has not toppled either of these powers in Shelley's society, Shelley recognizes that scientific advancements have at least shaken the Church and Monarchy, and he predicts their decline across future generations. Prometheus's gift of knowledge also allows humanity to invent the arts, which makes people "godlike" in their ability to create and suggests that people can be individual powers themselves rather than relying on traditional rulers.

> Such the alleviations of his state
> Prometheus gave to man—for which he hangs
> Withering in destined pain—but who rains down
> Evil, the immedicable plague, which while
> Man looks on his creation like a God
> And sees that it is glorious, drives him on,
> The wreck of his own will, the scorn of Earth,
> The outcast, the abandoned, the alone?—
> Not Jove: while yet his frown shook Heaven, aye when
> His adversary' from adamantine' chains
> Cursed him, he trembled like a slave. Declare
> Who is his master? Is he too a slave?

Related Characters: Asia (speaker), Demogorgon, Jupiter, Prometheus

Related Themes:

Page Number: 2.4.98-109

Explanation and Analysis

Asia tells the Demogorgon that Prometheus is being punished for giving humanity knowledge, and that without this knowledge, humanity is leading the world to destruction. She asks the Demogorgon who Jupiter's master is, as she does not believe that a ruler as weak as Jupiter can be a truly omnipotent force. By describing the achievements of humanity, which Prometheus's gift has

made possible, Asia highlights Jupiter's cruelty in punishing Prometheus, as well as the corruption of Jupiter's leadership. Jupiter's power only benefits him because humanity is not better off without knowledge. The lack of knowledge among humanity also leads to detrimental effects on nature and the planet. This is suggested by the image of man "look[ing] on his creation like a God" and driving on "the wreck of his own will." This suggests that, without knowledge or the love Prometheus gave them to temper knowledge, humanity is unable to recognize that they are destroying the planet through unchecked industrial advancement. This reflects Shelley's anxieties about modernization in the nineteenth century.

Asia feels that Jupiter cannot be a truly powerful God because he "trembled like a slave" when Prometheus "cursed him," and, therefore, his power must be tenuous and easily overthrown. If Jupiter had real confidence in his own power, he would not keep Prometheus chained to protect himself. Asia's comments support Shelley's idea that power gained by force or violence is not real power. Although Jupiter has enslaved the world, he too is a slave to his own lust for power.

> Fate, Time, Occasion, Chance and Change?—To these
> All things are subject but eternal Love.

So much I asked before, and my heart gave
The response thou hast given; and of such truths
Each to itself must be the oracle.—
One more demand . . . and do thou answer me
As my own soul would answer, did it know
That which I ask.—Prometheus shall arise
Henceforth the Sun of this rejoicing world:
When shall the destined hour arrive?

Related Characters: Demogorgon, Asia (speaker), Panthea, Jupiter, Prometheus

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 2.4.119-128

Explanation and Analysis

Asia and Panthea are in the lair of the Demogorgon, and Asia has explained to him the history of the world and Prometheus's imprisonment. She asks the Demogorgon to explain who the true ruler of Earth is, as she does not believe it is Jupiter. The Demogorgon tells Asia that all the powerful forces in the world, which dictate the fate of humanity, are subject to "eternal Love." Although Love has been temporarily deposed by ruin and destruction under Jupiter's reign, Love is still the most powerful force in the world, which is why tyrants like Jupiter try to keep it restrained.

Asia responds that she has always instinctively known this; Asia is a sea nymph and is associated throughout the poem with the goddess Venus, the classical goddess of love. Asia's innate understanding that Love is the most powerful force in the world supports the idea that she was once a goddess of love but has been subdued by Jupiter's evil influence. Asia now understands that when Prometheus is freed, love will be set free in the world. She compares this love, and Prometheus as an embodiment of this love, as a "sun" rising on the world. This connects Prometheus to the figure of Christ, who is often associated with the sun rising on the world and driving out darkness, sin, and death.

> The rocks are cloven, and through the purple night I see
> Cars drawn by rainbow-winged steeds
Which trample the dim winds—in each there stands
A wild-eyed charioteer, urging their flight.
Some look behind, as fiends pursued them there
And yet I see no shapes but the keen stars:
Others with burning eyes lean forth, and drink
With eager lips the wind of their own speed
As if the thing they loved fled on before
And now—even now' they clasped it; their bright locks
Stream like a comet's flashing hair: they all
Sweep onward.—

Related Characters: Demogorgon, Asia (speaker), Panthea

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 2.4.129-139

Explanation and Analysis

The Demogorgon shows Asia and Panthea the Hours, who drive around the world in chariots in an endless circle. The Hours are literal personifications of time, as it is divided up into moments and hours. The Hours are Jupiter's servants who enslave humanity by dividing their lives into units of time, which also represents mortality. This is an example of Shelley's use of metaphors and symbolism to express

aspects of psychological experience. For example, some of the Hours hurry their chariots along, which reflects the experience of wishing that time would pass more quickly. Others "lean forth" and drink "their own speed," which reflects the experience of time passing by quickly so that it seems impossible to appreciate or fully enjoy.

The Hours are depicted as extensions of Jupiter because they do his bidding in the world. They are described as charioteers, which mimics an earlier description of Jupiter, who holds the reins of power like a "fiend-drawn charioteer." The Hours also literally encircle the Earth; the symbolizes constraints or bonds encircling a prisoner, and reflects the round face of a clock, around which the Hours travel. Shelley felt that modern, industrial society placed too much emphasis on time and that the hours of the work day were a form of enslavement, dictating how a person could spend their time.

Act 3, Scene 1 Quotes

Rejoice! henceforth I am omnipotent.
All else has been subdued to me—alone
The soul of man, like unextinguished fire,
Yet burns towards Heaven with fierce reproach and doubt
And lamentation and reluctant prayer,
Hurling up insurrection, which might make
Our antique empire insecure, though built
On eldest faith, and Hell's coeval, fear.
And though my curses through the pendulous air
Like snow on herbless peaks, fall flake by flake
And cling to it—though under my wrath's night
It climb the crags of life, step after step,
Which wound it, as ice wounds unsandalled feet,
It yet remains supreme o'er misery,
Aspiring . . . unrepressed; yet soon to fall:

Related Characters: Jupiter (speaker), Asia, Demogorgon, Prometheus

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 3.1.3-17

Explanation and Analysis

In heaven, Jupiter addresses a congregation of gods and celebrates his omnipotence. Although Jupiter knows that he has not quite subdued humanity, he has produced a child with the goddess Thetis, the Demogorgon, whom he believes will be more powerful than him and will help him rule. In this passage, Jupiter reuses the metaphor of fire as a symbol of man's power and knowledge. While Prometheus views fire as a positive tool to give humanity, Jupiter views fire and knowledge as a threat to his power and something that should be "extinguished." Jupiter does not care for humanity's wellbeing, or the fact that humanity is "reproachful" towards him, but only cares about maintaining his own power. He acknowledges that humanity's hatred of him and reluctance to worship him could threaten his empire, which is built on intimidation and fear rather than real power through love.

Jupiter describes the curses he uses to quell mankind's resistance as falling on humanity like snow, "flake by flake." This is the opposite of Asia's use of the metaphor of gathering snowflakes, culminating in an avalanche, to symbolize resistance to Jupiter's reign gathering among individuals. Although Jupiter is convinced that man's resistance to him is "soon to fall," the reader knows that this is not true because of the prophecy that Prometheus will overthrow Jupiter and the knowledge that the Demogorgon is helping Asia. Jupiter's curses are only the work of one man, and thus have no power over the resistance of thousands. It is, therefore, ironic that Jupiter reuses these phrases right before his fall.

Act 3, Scene 4 Quotes

Thrones, altars, judgement-seats and prisons; wherein
And beside which, by wretched men were borne
Sceptres, tiaras, swords and chains, and tomes
Of reasoned wrong glozed on by ignorance,
Were like those monstrous and barbaric shapes,
The ghosts of a no more remembered fame,
Which from their unworn obelisks look forth
In triumph o'er the palaces and tombs
Of those who were their conquerors, mouldering round.
Those imaged to the pride of Kings and Priests
A dark yet mighty faith, a power as wide
As is the world it wasted, and are now
But an astonishment; even so the tools
And emblems of its last captivity
Amid the dwellings of the peopled Earth,
Stand, not o'erthrown, but unregarded now.

Related Characters: Ione, Panthea, Asia, Prometheus

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 3.4.164-179

Explanation and Analysis

When Prometheus is freed, Ione sends the Spirit of the Hour to circle the earth once more and tells him blow into a shell, which contains the music of love, so that everyone on Earth will hear it. The Spirit of the Hour returns and tells Prometheus, Asia, Ione, and Panthea about the change that he witnessed on Earth. The Spirit of the Hour says that he has seen "thrones, alters, judgement-seats, and prisons," all of which are now empty. Before Jupiter's fall, the Spirit of the Hour says that these institutions used to stand beside "wretched men" holding "scepters, chains, and swords" and wearing "tiaras." This represents the idea that powerful institutions, which rule nations and instill fear in people through the threat of punishment, are propped up by "wretched men" who seek power ("scepters") and wealth ("tiaras") through violence ("swords"). This highlights Shelley's antagonism towards institutions of power, such as the Monarchy, the Church, and the justice system, which he feels are corrupt and based in giving power and privilege to a handful of elite rulers.

Shelley feels that these powerful institutions are only kept in place by "ignorance" among the populace, who are too complacent with the established social order to challenge existing forms of power. In the description of the renewed world, these monuments to power and symbols of power stand "not o'erthrown" but "mouldering" and "unregarded." This reflects Shelley's belief that passive resistance is a more effective means of challenging power than acts of violent revolution.

Act 4 Quotes

❝ We come from the mind
Of human kind
Which was late so dusk and obscene and blind;
Now tis an Ocean
Of clear emotion,
A Heaven of serene and mighty motion.

From that deep Abyss
Of wonder and bliss
Whose caverns are chrystal palaces;
From those skiey towers
Where Thought's crowned Powers
Sit watching your dance, ye happy Hours!

Related Characters: Asia, Prometheus, Panthea, Ione

Related Themes:

Related Symbols:

Page Number: 4.93-104

Explanation and Analysis

After Prometheus has been set free, Panthea and Ione fall asleep outside the cave where Prometheus now lives with his wife, Asia. They wake to see the Hours, joined by the "spirits of the human mind," holding a funeral for the King of the Hours. The fall of Jupiter has led to the death of time, which is literally represented through the death of the King of the Hours. Although time still exists, it no longer enslaves humanity, and instead of being unable to control it, they can make time suit their own needs and purposes. The image of "Thought's crowned Powers" watching the "dance" of the hours suggests that, rather than hurrying through a work day and forcing oneself to meet the constraints of time, thought is now the master of time, and humans can spend however long they like in contemplation, rather than having time-bound tasks to attend to.

The Hour's song also meditates upon the change that has come over humanity since Jupiter's fall. Ignorance is now in decline, and humanity is no longer "dusk, obscene, and blind." Instead, knowledge is free among mankind and illuminates life for humanity. This reflects the connection between knowledge and light in the poem. The idea that time and the human mind are engaged in a harmonious dance with each other also suggests that humanity has undergone a positive change and can now live in, and fully appreciate, the present moment rather than being slave to time.

Gentleness, Virtue, Wisdom and Endurance,—
These are the seals of that most firm assurance
Which bars the pit over Destruction's strength;
And if, with infirm hand, Eternity,
Mother of many acts and hours, should free
The serpent that would clasp her with his length,—
These are the spells by which to reassume
An empire o'er the disentangled Doom.

To suffer woes which Hope thinks infinite;
To forgive wrongs darker than Death or Night
To defy Power which seems Omnipotent;
To love, and bear; to hope, till Hope creates
From its own wreck the thing it contemplates;
Neither to change nor falter nor repent:
This, like thy glory, Titan! is to be
Good, great and joyous, beautiful and free;
This is alone Life, Joy, Empire and Victory.

Related Characters: Demogorgon (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 4.562-578

Explanation and Analysis

The Demogorgon addresses the world, which answers as one united voice, and tells them how to release love back into the world if destruction and tyranny ever hold love captive again. The Demogorgon, who is privy to some secrets of the universe, tells the world that "Gentleness, Virtue, Wisdom, and Endurance" are the traits that keep violence and destruction contained. The Demogorgon acknowledges that during the whole of Eternity, humanity may become misguided again and fall into the hands of tyranny and ignorance. If they do so, the Demogorgon advises that humans should use the "spell" of love, compassion, wisdom, and non-violent resistance to find their way back to a state of harmony. This reflects Shelley's view that love is stronger than hate, and that forgiveness and compassion are more productive impulses than violence or revenge.

Shelley reinforces this point in the Demogorgon's closing words. The Demogorgon advises that people should "suffer woes," even if there seems to be no hope of alleviation for this suffering, as long as this suffering is for a good cause. Prometheus is a symbol of this notion through his relentless, resistance to Jupiter, which he continued despite feeling that his torment was infinite. His reward has been Love's return to humanity and the planet. Prometheus is like Christ in that his single but profound act of sacrifice has brought "glory" to the world. Shelley also wishes his readers to take the advice of the Demogorgon and feels that if poetry spreads a message of hope and compassion, then people in the real world may emulate such love and compassion.

SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

PREFACE

Shelley opens *Prometheus Unbound* with a "Preface." He explains the Greek origins of the Prometheus story and highlights the fact that classical authors often adapted material, which had been used many times before by poets and playwrights, and that they often made changes to these stories in their own versions to better suit their aims in retelling the story. Shelley notes that in the version of the Prometheus story which he has adapted, by the classical author Aeschylus, Prometheus reaches a compromise with Jupiter, the tyrant ruler of the world. In his own version of *Prometheus Unbound* however, Shelley states that he has avoided "reconciling the Champion with the Oppressor of mankind" to better suit the thematic aims of his "fable."

Shelley uses his Preface to acknowledge Aeschylus's version of the Prometheus story, which he has adapted for his poem. He notes that classical authors often adapted the old stories, showing that there is a precedent for this in the European literary tradition and to justify himself doing so in Prometheus Unbound. *Shelley was a Romantic poet, and the Romantics prized originality highly, so it makes sense that Shelley feels the need to explain why he has not created an original story. By calling his work a "fable," Shelley suggests that* Prometheus Unbound *has a clear message that he wants his readers to understand. This message has to do with uncompromising resistance to oppression, which is why Shelley chooses to deviate from Aeschylus's version of the story.*

Shelley compares his hero, Prometheus, with the biblical character of Satan, whom he also calls "the Hero of *Paradise Lost*," which is an epic poem by John Milton. He says that Prometheus is like Satan, but that Prometheus is a better and "more poetical" character than Satan because he is free from "the taints of ambition, envy, revenge, and a desire for personal aggrandizement" which Shelley feels corrupt Satan's personality. Prometheus, in contrast to Satan, is a moral character who has "the truest motives to the best and noblest ends."

Paradise Lost, an epic poem by John Milton written in 1667, heavily influenced the Romantic movement and Romantic poets like Shelley. The Romantics felt that Milton's personification of Satan in Paradise Lost *framed Satan as the hero of the story because he is determined to provide humans with knowledge against the wishes of God, who is an omnipotent authority. However, while the Romantics admired Satan's heroic qualities in Milton's poem, Shelley recognizes that Satan is an evil character because he is envious and vengeful towards mankind and does not offer them knowledge to help them but, instead, to simply spite God. Prometheus, on the other hand, is well-meaning towards humanity* and *is free from the evil qualities associated with Satan.*

Shelley explains that he composed his poem in Italy surrounded by beautiful landscapes, and that he was inspired by the arrival of spring in "that divinest climate." He notes that the imagery in his poem is inspired by the internal workings of the "human mind," which he feels is uncommon in modern poetry but is prevalent in the work of earlier, dramatic writers such as Shakespeare or Dante. He feels he is most inspired by classical, Greek writers who were able to "awaken" any type of emotion in their audience. However, he notes that people cannot help being influenced by the contemporary work they read and the age in which they live, and that while many writers may be able to imitate classical form, they may lack the talent, or the "lightning of their own mind[s]," to bring these subjects to life.

Shelley feels that beautiful landscapes provide poets with artistic inspiration. However, Shelley is also interested in representing human emotion, which he feels is best conveyed through imagery inspired by nature. The Romantics felt that pre-Enlightenment writers, like Shakespeare and Dante, were superior to Enlightenment and contemporary authors. The Romantics felt that the Enlightenment period produced bad poetry because it encouraged a rational, unemotional approach to life and preferred empirical observation of the natural world to artistic appreciation of it. Shelley uses a metaphor from nature, the "lightning of their own mind[s]," to demonstrate how effective nature is in portraying emotional experience.

Shelley notes that the great writers of the "golden age of our literature" were inspired by the "awakening of the public mind," and that the "great writers" of his own period are also the "forerunners of some unimagined change" in society.

The "golden age" of literature that Shelley refers to is the Renaissance, which was a period of scientific, philosophical, and artistic development spanning from the fourteenth century to the seventeenth century in Europe. Shelley feels that great literature is revolutionary because it rebels against established order in society and inspires real social change. He feels that society is changing around him and that "great writers" of his own age will document and encourage these changes.

Shelley describes poetry as a "mimetic art," or an art which relies on imitation. He notes that poets are inspired by their own minds, by beautiful scenes from nature, and from beautiful descriptions of nature that they read in the work of other poets. "Every man's mind" is "a mirror upon which all forms are reflected" and, therefore, poetical minds are inspired by everything that they see and read. There are similarities between classical authors such as Aeschylus and Hesiod, and if their beautiful works are "the result of imitation," then Shelley is happy to admit that he has imitated while writing *Prometheus Unbound*.

Shelley observes that poets are inspired by everything they see and read, and that men's minds are like "mirrors." This suggests that Shelley is trying to justify his choice to reuse an old story, rather than invent a new one. He strengthens his justification by noting that even writers whom he greatly admires, like Aeschylus and Hesiod, were influenced by what they heard and experienced; since he is aspiring to be like them, this justifies his recycling of the Prometheus story.

Shelley confesses that he has a "passion for reforming the world" but that he abhors "didactic poetry" and wishes to inspire his readers with visions of "beautiful idealisms of moral excellence." He feels that "until the mind can love, and admire, and trust, and hope" then moral lessons are "like seeds cast upon the highway of life" and will be "trampled into the dust."

Although Shelley wishes to convey a message of social change to the reader, he does not wish his poem to be "didactic," or purely read for educational purposes. Instead, he wishes his poem to be read artistically and with an appreciation for beautiful language. He feels that people will be unable to comprehend moral teaching until they can appreciate artistic and natural beauty, so it is noble to be a poet and to inspire these emotions in people.

Shelley feels compelled to write poetry and believes that people who are driven to produce art have a duty to use their abilities. If his efforts are unsuccessful, he implores the reader to "let the punishment of an unaccomplished purpose be sufficient" and not to draw attention to his poor attempt in case this makes his work famous "which might otherwise have been unknown."

Romantic poets, like Shelley, viewed art as extremely socially important and felt that it was an act of social duty to produce art if one had an inclination or a talent towards it. They believed that art and poetry could reform society.

ACT 1

Prometheus is bound to a mountaintop in the Indian Caucasus. Panthea and Ione, two sea nymphs, are seated at his feet. It is dark but near dawn. Prometheus addresses Jupiter as the "Monarch of Gods and Daemons, and all Spirits but One" and calls for him to look upon the earth, over which he is the supreme ruler and which he has made "multitudinous with his slaves."

Prometheus is a character from classical mythology. In classical myth, Prometheus was chained to a mountaintop for all eternity for giving humanity fire; an act that went against the will of the gods. Prometheus addresses Jupiter because Jupiter is omnipotent over all beings in the universe except Prometheus himself.

Despite Jupiter's power, Prometheus claims his own "empire" is more beautiful than the view that Jupiter has from his "unenvied throne," which Prometheus could have shared if he had "deigned to" instead of being "nailed" to the mountainside. Although he is in pain, Prometheus "endures." He describes his suffering when the freezing winter cold eats into him, when "Heaven's winged hound" mauls him, and when the Earthquakes and the storms shake him.

Prometheus only has power over himself and, even then, only over his own mind since his body is chained to the mountain by Jupiter. However, he does not envy Jupiter's power and would not accept this sort of power even if it was offered to him. Despite his terrible suffering, Prometheus "endures" and stands by his decision to oppose Jupiter.



Despite this, Prometheus still enjoys watching **the Hours** pass, as he knows that one of these hours will contain the moment in which Jupiter will "kiss the blood" from Prometheus's feet before he is pursued "undefended through wide Heaven" by some terrible force. Prometheus no longer hates Jupiter, and instead pities him, because has been made "wise" by his suffering. He now cannot remember the curse he once uttered against Jupiter.

Prometheus is confident that Jupiter will suffer negative consequences because he has abused his power. When this happens, Prometheus knows Jupiter will beg for his forgiveness. Prometheus pities Jupiter because he knows that Jupiter will inevitably be punished for his actions. Prometheus has become more compassionate and forgiving through his suffering as he does not want others to suffer the way that he does.



Although Prometheus feels that all hate is "dead within" him, he asks the elements—the air, the mountains, the springs, and the whirlwinds—if they remember the curse he spoke against Jupiter, which terrified them and made them fall silent when Prometheus spoke.

Prometheus has become so compassionate during his torture that he has even forgotten the curse that he spoke against Jupiter when he was first chained to the mountain. The elements are personified in Shelley's poem and are capable of feeling and speaking. This reflects Shelley's interest in pantheism (the belief that the whole universe contains God) and his interest in classical and pagan mythology in which natural forces were often given personalities.



The mountains reply that Prometheus's curse made them "tremble" as never before. The springs reply that they had never carried such a terrible sound to the sea before and that a "pilot asleep on the howling sea" spontaneously went mad and died as soon as the curse ran into the ocean. The air says that his cry caused the day to go dark, and the whirlwinds reply that they fell silent when they heard it, "though silence is a hell" to them. The Earth then states that the hills and the oceans cried "Misery!" when the curse was spoken and that the "pale nations" heard it too.

The fact that the elements fell silent when they heard Prometheus's curse suggests that he is more powerful than these mighty natural forces. Prometheus is a Titan (a classical deity whose mother is the Earth) and, therefore, is an extremely powerful being. Prometheus represents freedom for the natural elements and mankind, the inhabitants of the "pale nations," and that is why they cry "Misery!" when he is captured. Prometheus also speaks his curse in anger and hatred, and this spreads anger and hatred on earth because, in Shelley's poem, Prometheus's actions affect the whole of humanity. This is based in Christ's message that hurting one person is the same as hurting the whole of humanity and demonstrates Shelley's combination of classicism and Christianity in his poem.



Prometheus cannot hear the elements' responses and asks if they have forgotten him: he who "made his agony the barrier" between them and their "else all-conquering foe" who would have trampled the world like a "fiend-drawn charioteer." The Earth tells him that the elements "dare not" speak up, and Prometheus begins to hear a strange whisper, which "tingles" through him the way that "lightning tingles, hovering ere it strikes." The Earth tells him that these are the voices of the dead and that he cannot understand them because he is immortal. The Earth "dares not" translate for him into the language of "life" lest the ruler of Heaven should punish her.

Prometheus is the only "barrier" between the world and the total omnipotent rule of Jupiter. Prometheus's description of Jupiter as a "fiend-drawn charioteer" suggests that he is driving the world in a bad direction and foreshadows Shelley's personification of the Hours as wild charioteers who drive time along and make humanity slaves to the passage of time. The Earth insinuates that everything in the world has been metaphorically dead since Jupiter took control, as she no longer speaks in the language of "life." This suggests that nothing on the planet or in nature speaks this language anymore. Jupiter's reign, therefore, spreads death, as he does not permit the language of life to be used.



Prometheus asks the Earth, whose voice he does not recognize, who she is, and the Earth explains that she is his mother. She describes Prometheus's birth and the joy this brought her, how the downtrodden people of the Earth "uplifted their prostrate brows" when they heard him speak and how the "almighty Tyrant" "grew pale." When Jupiter bound Prometheus to the mountain, the Earth was racked with grief and unleashed "strange tempests." Plague and famine flourished, and the air became contaminated "with the contagion of a mother's hate." Still, she remembers Prometheus's curse and secretly repeats it as a mantra of hope which she "dares not speak" out loud.

In classical mythology the Earth, or the goddess Gaia, is the mother of the Titans. Prometheus, who gave humanity fire and knowledge, represents hope for mankind and allowed them to rise above ignorance and confusion. Prometheus's gift of knowledge to humanity is perceived as a threat by Jupiter, as knowledge allows humans to think for themselves and potentially question his authority. Jupiter's imprisonment of Prometheus has caused a rift between humanity and nature so that they can no longer exist harmoniously but must struggle to survive alongside each other. Prometheus's curse and defiance of Jupiter gives the Earth hope that Jupiter will fall, and that harmony will exist again between man and nature.



Prometheus begs to hear the curse. The Earth calls up the Phantasm of Jupiter from the shadow world to repeat it so that Jupiter himself cannot punish anything on earth for speaking the words. Ione and Panthea tremble with fear as the Phantasm approaches: "clothed in dark purple" with a "scepter of pale gold" in his hand.

The Earth's fear that Jupiter will punish her suggests that Jupiter is a cruel ruler. This is reinforced by the fact that Ione and Panthea are afraid of the Phantasm of Jupiter. Jupiter's costume aligns him with worldly powers, such as the Pope, who is the head of the Catholic Church and carries a golden staff and wears decorative robes.



The Phantasm of Jupiter is forced to speak the curse. The curse invites Jupiter to unleash all his torments on Prometheus, who is the "only being" that Jupiter "will not subdue." Prometheus vows to dedicate himself to "sleepless agony" while Jupiter "must reign on high" and hopes that his "sufferers curse" will haunt Jupiter and cause his power to become a "crown of pain." He hopes that one day Jupiter's external appearance will show the reality of his internal character and that, finally, Jupiter will fall.

Prometheus's curse defies Jupiter's power and suggests that nothing Jupiter can do will subdue Prometheus—Prometheus is determined to oppose Jupiter's reign even if he is the only being to do so. Prometheus is an example of a Romantic hero because he is willing to alienate himself from the rest of society rather than conform to something that he feels is morally wrong. Romantic poets like Shelley valued individual heroism as a powerful force against authority and corruption. In his curse, Prometheus hopes that Jupiter's actions and misuse of his power will come back to haunt him.



When he hears the curse, Prometheus laments that he once wished pain upon Jupiter, as he no longer wishes any "living thing to suffer." The Earth cries out that Prometheus is vanquished, but Ione contradicts her and says that it is nothing "but some passing spasm." She points out that there is a spirit traveling towards them through the dawn. Panthea recognizes the "world-wandering herald," Mercury, and that the Furies, "Jove's tempest-walking hounds," follow behind.

Prometheus's suffering has made him more empathetic and compassionate; he no longer wishes any being to suffer because he has experienced firsthand how awful it is. Although the Earth think this shows weakness, it really shows strength, as Prometheus has found the strength and compassion to forgive Jupiter despite Jupiter's cruelty. Meanwhile, Jupiter, who is omnipotent and does not understand Prometheus's compassion, thinks forgiveness is a sign of weakness and sends Mercury to try and bargain with Prometheus while he is vulnerable.



Mercury holds back the Furies while he begs Prometheus to accept a compromise with Jupiter in order to win his freedom. Prometheus refuses and claims that "evil minds change good to their own nature." He says that he gave Jupiter his power, and that Jupiter has repaid him by punishing and torturing him and by letting his "thought-executing ministers" oppress humanity.

Mercury demonstrates that he is a weak character because does not like seeing Prometheus suffer at Jupiter's hands but is too afraid to oppose Jupiter and continues to act as his messenger. Mercury tries to convince Prometheus that compromising with Jupiter is a moral thing to do, but Prometheus feels that "evil" people delude themselves into thinking that their actions are good when really their actions are selfish. Jupiter is "thought-executing," as he does not allow freedom of thought or knowledge among mankind.



Defeated, Mercury retreats and the Furies swarm Prometheus, mocking and taunting him. Although Prometheus is horrified by the Furies, he pities them because they are evil and can know nothing good. Prometheus invites them to torture him as he knows that he is "king over" himself and "rules" the pain which they administer. More Furies arrive and one of them tries to frighten Prometheus with a vision of Hell. Another Fury stops this since Prometheus "yet defies the deepest powers of Hell." The Furies then taunt Prometheus for giving man knowledge, which "kindled within him a thirst which outran" and filled him with desire that "consumes him."

Prometheus can withstand the Furies' torture because he has fully accepted his own decision to let himself be tortured and feels that it is both the right thing to do and worth the sacrifice of himself. This gives Prometheus immense self-control and allows him to even pity the Furies, who, unlike him, do not control their own feelings or behavior but are slaves to evil and to Jupiter. The Furies are afraid to tell Prometheus what is in hell because they fear that, once he knows, he will cease to be afraid of it. This suggests that hell has no real power, and that its power comes from individual's imagination. The Furies refer to knowledge among mankind as a destructive force, which causes man more harm than good because it is being used irresponsibly. This is supported by the symbol of fire as knowledge, because fire has the capacity to be both a useful and a dangerous element.



The Furies show Prometheus that one man "of gentle worth" did visit humanity, but that his message "outlived him" and became poisoned. They show Prometheus cities spewing smoke and crying out in despair and claim that they hear the gentle man's ghost "wailing" for the message he gave out, which only a few people now worship "in dread." They show this man bleeding and a hopeful nation transformed into a violent, murderous regime. Panthea and Ione also see these images, when they glance up from where they are hiding, and at one point see a "youth with patient looks nailed to a crucifix." Prometheus weeps for this man and cries that he will not speak his name as "it hath become a curse."

The Furies refer to Jesus Christ and suggest that his teachings about compassion and love have been misused by the Church. Shelley was an atheist and felt that the Church was an extremely corrupt institution; however, he deeply admired Christ's message of forgiveness and compassion and felt that Christ would be horrified by the ways in which the Church had used and distorted this message to gain power for themselves and to frighten and control the populace. The "youth" whom Ione and Panthea see is Christ, who is being crucified. The "hopeful nation" refers to France in the early stages of the French Revolution, which took place in 1780s and 90s, and which Shelley was politically influenced by. Shelley supported anti-establishment rebellion but was disappointed by the outcome of the French Revolution. Although it began as a rebellion against the French monarchy, who had been starving the French people, and sought liberty and equality for all, it turned violent and descended into a "murderous regime."

The Furies tell Prometheus that worse things than violence lurk within men's minds, and that humanity exists in a state of "hypocrisy and custom"; they do not care for each other and "the powerful lack all goodness," while the "wise lack love."

Shelley disliked the strict forms of etiquette and social custom which ruled Enlightenment society and which, he felt, placed restrictions on people's self-expression and prevented them from being honest about their emotions. In Shelley's mind, this lack of emotional honesty and understanding leads to confusion and suffering, which consequently leads to a general lack of understanding and compassion among people. Romanticism as a movement prioritized emotional expression and non-conformity over the Enlightenment values of social order and rational objectivity.

The Furies vanish, and Prometheus repeats his mantra of defiance. He states that the visions with which the Furies tortured him have only increased his determination to endure. The Earth sends good spirits to comfort Prometheus, and they tell him of a prophecy of love and hope that "begins and ends in" him. Ione sees two doves, and she and Panthea weep over their song. The spirits tell Prometheus that, in the prophecy they bear, he will "kill the horseman grim." The spirits vanish, and Prometheus laments his destined role as the "savior" of mankind. Panthea reminds him that he is loved, by herself and Ione, and by his wife, Asia, whom Panthea then departs to visit.

While Jupiter intends to break Prometheus's spirit by torturing him, this actually makes Prometheus more *determined to resist Jupiter, as he understands that Jupiter uses cruel, tyrannical measures to maintain power. This confirms Prometheus's belief that someone must stand against Jupiter, even if this means suffering for his defiance. The prophecy "begins and ends" in Prometheus because it relies entirely on him, and his continued resistance. The idea that Prometheus will kill "the horseman grim" suggests that Prometheus will kill death, which, under Jupiter's reign, humanity is subject to. Prometheus's title as "savior" links him to the figure of Christ who, in Christianity, triumphed over death through love and compassion for humankind.*

ACT 2, SCENE 1

Asia, Prometheus's wife, sits alone in a fertile valley in the Indian Caucuses. She is waiting for her sister, Panthea, to arrive and, while she does, she notices that spring is breaking in the valley. She observes that Panthea, who usually visits her at sunrise, is late and that the "wingless moments crawl" like "death-worms."

Spring is a common symbol of new life, and in the context of Christianity it is often associated with the hope of new life after death. This reflects Shelley's combination of Christianity and pantheism. Under Jupiter's reign, Asia is a slave to time, which moves slowly and prevents her happiness.



Panthea arrives and explains that she is late because of a troubled sleep in which she had two strange dreams. In one of the dreams, Prometheus was set free, and she was overcome with love until their spirits mingled together and she was "absorbed." The other dream she cannot remember. Asia looks into Panthea's eyes to try to divine the dream and is startled to see a shape moving there which beckons her to "follow." Panthea cries that this shape is the dream that she had forgotten. The dream "passes into" her mind and invites her to follow. Echoes then begin in the air, calling to Asia that there is a "voice unspoken" in the world which, "by her step alone, can its rest be broken." Asia and Panthea hurry after the dream.

Panthea's first dream represents the prophecy that love will come into the world when Prometheus is free. It also reflects the idea that Prometheus's release will cause a new harmony between beings on earth, and that they will merge together and be "absorbed" because they will recognize that all life is connected. Asia and Panthea are given a task which only they can fulfil. This mirrors the prophecy concerning Prometheus, which suggests that only he can end Jupiter's tyranny.



ACT 2, SCENE 2

Asia and Panthea travel through a gloomy forest interspersed with caves and boulders. Two fauns are resting on a nearby rock and the sea nymphs hear a chorus of spirits. The spirits describe the shady vale around them and tell Panthea and Asia that the sun never reaches this part of the forest and that the nightingales are always singing here. The air is full of soft music, which, "by Demogorgon's mighty law," leads spirits through this secret glade to the "fatal mountain."

Fauns are common characters in classical mythology and pastoral poetry, which centers around idealized descriptions of rural life in the paradise of Arcadia. Fauns live in enchanted forests or pastures, which contain nature spirits and nymphs. The gloom of the forest suggests that Panthea and Asia are approaching the realm of night or the abyss where the Demogorgon lives. Nightingales sing in the glade because they are birds that sing at night and are associated with sleep, dreams, and darkness.



The fauns discuss the spirits, commenting that, although they often hear them, they never see them and do not know where the voices come from. One faun says that spirits live in water-flowers that grow at the "bottom of lakes and pools" and send up bubbles. The other comments that if these flowers contain spirits then perhaps other things in nature also contain life. The fauns hurry away to listen to their shepherd telling tales of "fate, and chance, and God, and Chaos old, and love."

Shelley suggests that, although the natural world may not look alive to humans, this does not mean that spirits do not live inside natural things. This is a reference to the pantheism that was popular among Shelley and his Romantic contemporaries. Shelley suggests that mysterious aspects of nature, such as flowers that grow underwater, may have spiritual or supernatural explanations rather than scientific ones. The fauns' description of their shepherd aligns the scene with classical pastoral literature.



ACT 2, SCENE 3

Asia and Panthea find themselves on clifftop surrounded by mountains. Panthea recognizes the chasm in the mountain, which they hover above, as the entrance to the lair of the Demogorgon. This entrance is also a spring which sends up "oracular vapor." "Lonely, young men wandering in their youth" drink from this spring and it gives them visions of "truth, virtue, love, genius, and joy," which is "contagion to the world." The vapor affects Panthea and she cries out in worship of the spring. They look down from the mountain on an "avalanche," which reminds Panthea of a mass of "heaven-defying minds" gathering "flake by flake."

Although the spring is associated with sending young men mad, through the strange visions they encounter there, Shelley suggests that it is really the world that is mad and not these men. The visions are seen as "contagion" by the world because they talk about "truth, virtue, love, genius, and joy"—such extreme emotions present a challenge to the powerful forces that wish to keep people unaware of these ideas. The image of the "lonely young men" suggests the Romantic idea of the alienated and misunderstood poetic genius. Although there is ignorance in the world, Shelley suggests that he anticipates change and social reform as more people turn away from old ideas and established institutions. He uses an image from nature to reinforce the link between the natural world and the human mind.



A shape in the mist beckons the two nymphs onwards, and a chorus of spirits calls them to descend "through the shade of sleep" and "through the veil and the bar, of things which seems and are." These spirits lead them down through the abyss where Heaven's light does not reach and where One rules alone. This is "life's portal" through which "the Eternal, the immortal" must travel, and in it sits the "snake-like Doom coiled underneath his throne."

The Demogorgon is a spirit of the underworld, which is often associated with the world of the dead. The image of passing through a veil is commonly associated with passing between life and death in nineteenth-century fiction. The Demogorgon is described as "coiled" beneath Jupiter's throne, as he too will have a role in overthrowing Jupiter. The image of a snake links the Demogorgon with Satan and connects Prometheus Unbound to the Romantic idea that Satan is a hero and overthrows God, who is a tyrant.



ACT 2, SCENE 4

Asia and Panthea enter the cave of the Demogorgon. A dark, shapeless form, the Demogorgon sits on the throne and asks them what they want to know. Asia responds, "who made the living world" and the suffering in it. The Demogorgon replies that God made the world, but when she asks who made suffering, he replies, "he reigns."

Asia does not believe that God originally allowed suffering into the world. The Demogorgon implies that it is Jupiter who has caused suffering because he has seized power and severed the connection between humanity and God. This is reminiscent of the role of Satan in Christianity, as Satan was an angel who rebelled against God and was promptly cast down to hell.



Asia asks who reigns. She tells the Demogorgon that Heaven, Earth, Light, and Love existed first and then, when gods were born, "time fell" from Saturn's throne. Prometheus gave knowledge to Jupiter and told him to rule but to "let man be free." Jupiter however, let "famine, and then toil, and then disease" fall on man, and he played havoc with nature's seasons. Prometheus saw this and "tamed **fire**," which gave man tools of "iron and gold"; "the slaves and signs of power." From this power, man developed "speech, and speech created thought" and this created the arts, travel, trade, and science, which quelled "disease and death." For giving this gift to man Prometheus hangs on the mountainside.

Asia explains the origins of the world, as far as she knows it, to the Demogorgon. God, who created the world, created Heaven, Earth, Light, and Love. The introduction of time is associated with the introduction of suffering to the world, as the progression of time introduces mortality and death to human experience. Prometheus tried to prevent this suffering by giving humanity knowledge, symbolized by fire, which allowed them to discover tools, medicine, and ways to prevent death and suffering, but Jupiter removed their access to this knowledge and kept the power for himself by having Prometheus restrained.



Asia then asks who created the suffering which "rains down" on man since Prometheus's imprisonment. She thinks that it cannot be Jupiter because Jupiter "trembles like a slave" at the thought of Prometheus being freed. She wants to know who Jupiter's master is, and the Demogorgon replies that he does not know the secrets of the world but that everything in it is "subject to eternal Love." Asia replies that she has always felt this to be true and that Prometheus is the "sun" who shall arise on the world.

Although Jupiter is the cause of suffering in the world, Asia suspects that Jupiter is not powerful enough to create suffering himself. She believes that Prometheus is more powerful than Jupiter, and that is why Jupiter is afraid of Prometheus. Although Jupiter is powerful, his power is tenuous, and he is subject to more powerful forces. The Demogorgon confirms Asia's suspicious that Love is the most powerful thing in the universe. By comparing Prometheus to the "sun," Asia connects Prometheus with Christ, who is associated with light triumphing over darkness.



The Demogorgon opens the night sky and shows Asia and Panthea a series of chariots racing by, circling around the earth. The Demogorgon tells them that these are **the Spirits of the Hours** and that One, a spirit "with a dreadful countenance," waits for them. This spirit introduces himself as the "shadow of a destiny," which raises a "terrible shadow" from the Demogorgon's throne. Panthea sees another chariot; this one contains **the Spirit of Love**. She and Asia ascend in the chariot with the spirit of destiny.

The Hours are personifications of time. Shelley depicts them as charioteers to suggest the speed they travel at and to continue the metaphor of Jupiter as a "fiend-drawn charioteer," because the Hours are Jupiter's slaves and extensions of his will. The Hours consequently enslave humanity because humans are constrained by time. The shadow of destiny represents a moment that is inevitable or has been preordained. The Spirit of Love is separate from the Hours because, unlike the Hours, he is not subject to Jupiter.



ACT 2, SCENE 5

The Spirit of the Hour takes Asia, Panthea, and the Demogorgon into the heart of a cloud. The Spirit tells Asia that "the sun will not rise until noon" because Apollo "is held in Heaven by wonder." Panthea turns pale and Asia asks her what she sees. She replies that a change has taken place in Asia, and that Asia has suddenly become so beautiful that Panthea can hardly look at her. The nymphs recognize that some change has taken place in the world and that Asia is "unveiled," much like the day that Asia rose out of a "veined shell" which drifted on the "crystal ocean" and when Asia used to be known as "love."

In this passage, Asia is associated with Venus, who was the classical goddess of love. It is implied that Asia used to be called Venus, but that she is no longer known under this title because love has been forgotten in the world. In the European artistic tradition, the birth of Venus is often depicted as her rising out of the ocean in a shell. The idea that Asia has been "unveiled" suggests that Jupiter's reign has disguised love and foreshadows his fall, when love will be revealed.



At first Asia dismisses this change and says that "love is common as light." Yet when a voice on the air tells Asia that she is shining with the light of love, she feels her soul floating away on a tide of love.

Although love is a common human experience, this does not detract from its extraordinary power. Asia's transformation suggests that love has the power to elevate and illuminate human life and that, because it is so common, this experience is available to all.



ACT 3, SCENE 1

Jupiter, "on his throne in Heaven," addresses a congregation of fellow deities to celebrate the fact that he is now "omnipotent" over everything in the world. The only thing that still evades his influence is the "soul of man, like unextinguished **fire**"—yet he assures the gods this is "soon to fall." He tells them that he has produced an offspring, the Demogorgon, who will be more powerful even than himself. He hears the wheels of the chariot approaching and cries "Victory!"

Jupiter acknowledges that he has still not managed to subdue humanity's spirit. This suggests that, although they lack the knowledge to challenge Jupiter's reign, humanity still attempts to resist his rule. The reference to "fire" suggests that Prometheus's influence and the memory of knowledge still lingers in their souls, although Jupiter's reign has oppressed them. Jupiter believes that the Demogorgon, who is his child with the goddess Thetis, will be more powerful than himself and, therefore, will help him achieve total authority over the world.




When the chariot of **the Hour** arrives, the Demogorgon steps out and approaches Jupiter, who is horrified by its appearance. The Demogorgon demands that Jupiter follow "him down into the abyss," and the two plunge from Heaven; the Demogorgon dragging Jupiter down into his lair.

Jupiter is shocked when he sees the shapeless form of the Demogorgon because he realizes that the Demogorgon comes from the underworld and does not intend to join him in his power but to end his reign and take him to the underworld. Jupiter's literal fall from heaven mirrors Satan's fall from heaven in Christianity.




ACT 3, SCENE 2

Ocean and Apollo stand at the mouth of a river on the island of Atlantis discussing the fall of Jupiter. They have witnessed Jupiter tumbling through the air, entangled with an eagle. Ocean rejoices that his "realm, will heave, unstained with blood" while Apollo celebrates that he will no longer have to look down on "deeds which make his mind obscure with sorrow." They part ways joyfully.

Ocean and Apollo are classical personifications of natural phenomena: the sea and the sun. In this scene, Shelley reinforces the idea that all of nature is affected by human cruelty and suffers when witnessing violence and destruction. This ties in with pantheist ideas, as it suggests that nature is alive, and with Christianity because it suggests that hurting one person means hurting all people.





ACT 3, SCENE 3

On the mountaintop in the Caucuses, Hercules unchains Prometheus. Asia, Ione, Panthea, and **the Spirit of the Hour** gather around him. Prometheus tells Asia and her sisters of a beautiful cave in Asia's valley where they will live from now on. From this vantage point, they will witness the progress of mankind, who now will develop "arts unimagined" and grow "wise and kind" as "veil by veil, evil and error fall."

Hercules is a hero and a demigod (part god and part mortal) from classical mythology. It was common in epic poetry, and imitations of classical mythology, to include cameos of classical heroes who perform great deeds but do not feature heavily in the action of the story. Here, Hercules performs a heroic act by freeing Prometheus. Meanwhile, the fall of Jupiter allows knowledge to flow freely back into the world, and Prometheus predicts that, with this knowledge, humans will discover new arts and sciences. The image of veils fallings refers to the image of Asia, or love, being unveiled and revealed to the world, just as knowledge now is also revealed.



Prometheus instructs Ione to give **the Spirit of the Hour** the "curved shell" that was a wedding gift to Asia from "Proteus old." Prometheus then tells the Hour to fly around the world, blowing the shell like a horn and "loosening its mighty music."

In classical mythology, Proteus is a sea god. Asia's shell reflects her connection with Venus and Venus's birth from a shell in the ocean. The Spirit of the Hour is not only a menacing figure, who brings about Jupiter's doom, but also functions as a positive figure, sounding the horn (shell) which alerts humanity that tyranny has fallen, and love is brought back into the world.



Next Prometheus addresses the Earth. She is so delighted by his words that joy runs through her "icy frame" and deadly plants and poisonous insects are transformed into beautiful, nourishing versions of themselves. She also describes a cave "where her spirit was panted forth in anguish" while Prometheus was chained. The cave made those who went there mad, but it is now restored and will be Prometheus's home.

The connection between humanity and nature is reinforced in this passage, as the end of tyranny among mankind also means the rejuvenation of the natural world. The Earth is described like a human body, which is healed by the renewal of love in the world. This suggests that humans and nature are intimately linked and that violence hurts both while love and compassion heals and supports both.



The Earth calls up a childlike messenger, the Spirit of the Earth, to lead Prometheus, Asia, Panthea, and Ione to this cave, where there once was a temple in which people worshipped Prometheus as an emblem of hope.

The Spirit of the Earth is childlike because she is associated with new life, innocence, and purity. Now, as Prometheus and Asia's home, the cave will symbolize hope, knowledge, and love. This will replace the classical temple dedicated to worship of Prometheus. This suggests that people in classical society worshipped knowledge, but that this practice has degenerated in contemporary society. The fall of Jupiter represents a return to this classical reverence of knowledge and reflects Shelley's belief that modern society has deteriorated compared to the classical period.



ACT 3, SCENE 4

Prometheus, Asia, Panthea, and Ione are gathered at their cave in the forest with the Spirit of the Earth. Panthea tells Ione how the Spirit of the Earth used to visit Asia often and that she calls the Spirit mother, although Panthea does not know why.

This passage suggests that the Spirit of the Earth is the offspring of Asia, who symbolizes love, and Prometheus, who symbolizes knowledge and freedom. This reflects Shelley's belief that a combination of these elements will rejuvenate society.

The Spirit of the Earth runs to Asia and expresses her love for her. The Spirit of the Earth then tells Asia about the change that has come over her that day. She tells her that all the insects, "venomous" plants, and "malicious beasts" have vanished and that men and women, who used to look evil and cruel to her, have suddenly grown "good and kind, free and sincere." She says that, as she was traveling through a city, she heard a sweet sound ringing through the air, a sound which all the people in the city ran out of their houses to hear too. She hid in a fountain and, as she watched, saw the people transformed as though "some foul disguise had fallen" and "all things put off their evil nature."

The Spirit of the Earth describes the transformation that has taken place in both nature and humanity as a result of Prometheus's release and Jupiter's fall. Nature, which under Jupiter's tyranny became a hostile environment for mankind, complete with poisonous plants and insects, is now habitable and harmonious with the needs of men. The Spirit of the Earth's descriptions continue the metaphor of veils falling and love, kindness, freedom, and sincerity being newly revealed to humanity.

Asia returns the Spirit of the Earth's affection and tells her that they will not separate until the "frozen and inconstant moon" thaws and looks on the Earth with warm light.

The strength of Asia's love promises to achieve an impossible feat: to turn the Moon from a dead to a living planet. This insinuation of new life springing from death continues the use of Christian allegory in the poem.

The Spirit of the Hour returns and tells them that, after he had blown the shell over the world, a change immediately occurred as if love "had folded itself round the sphered world." The Spirit of the Hour tells them how he has wandered the Earth and seen that "thrones" are now "kingless," and that men no longer lie or flatter each other or seek power. Instead they are "frank and kind" and free "from custom's evil taint." They speak "with wisdom" they once would not even have been able to think of. The images of worldly power stand "not overthrown, but unregarded" and the monuments of power mold and rot.

The Spirit of the Hour observes the same rejuvenation of love among humanity that the Spirit of the Earth has witnessed. The fact that a shell being sounded like a horn heralds this love connects love to the classical goddess Venus. Symbols of worldly power, such as the "thrones" from which kings rule, are now empty. This suggests that traditional hierarchies (like the Monarchy that Shelley detested) have broken down. Shelley also demonstrates his belief in non-violent resistance to power, as kings have not been violently overthrown but have simply been forgotten. For Shelley, this demonstrates real social progression as opposed to violent revolution, which breeds tyranny. Social custom has also broken down, which means that people can speak honestly and freely, rather than withholding their opinions for the sake of conformity or etiquette. Shelley disliked social conventions that restricted personal expression.

ACT 4

Panthea and Ione are sleeping outside Prometheus's cave. They wake to hear a chorus of spirits passing by. These are the dead **Spirits of the Hours** holding a funeral for the King of the Hours. The spirits of the elements unite with them in a chorus, which is also joined by the "Spirits of the human mind." They rejoice that love is no longer "veiled" and that they now live in "splendor and harmony." A new age has dawned on earth—"a Heaven where yet Heaven never could be"—which is free from "death, chaos, and night." This age is "called Promethean."

The fall of Jupiter has led to the death of time. Humanity is now no longer bound to the conventional passage of time, and death has been triumphed over and is no longer a source of grief. Unity between nature and humanity is symbolized by the "spirits of the human mind" and the elements dancing together. "A Heaven where Heaven never could be" suggests the Christian idea of the Kingdom of God being made on Earth after the final judgement, when evil and death will be ultimately defeated.

The spirits disappear but their song continues to spread through the world in "Aeolian modulations." Panthea and Ione see a small, floating islet, around which a sleeping infant, the Spirit of the Earth, is being borne in a basket. They see a vision of all the emblems of power and tyranny in the world abandoned, sunk to the bottom of the sea and forgotten, as if they had never existed.

"Aeolian modulations" refers to a musical instrument, known as the aeolian harp, which was commonly used as a symbol of artistic creation by the Romantic poets. It relates to classical mythology because Aeolus was the god of the winds, and the aeolian harp produces sound when the wind blows through it. The Romantics frequently use this as a metaphor for the influence of nature on poets. Ione and Panthea see a vision of the forgotten symbols of worldly power, which are now considered worthless.

The Earth is frenzied with joy over the change that has come over her. The Moon, conversing with the Earth, confesses that she feels the change too and that it "penetrates her frozen frame." The Moon feels her frozen surface turned to "living fountains" as a spirit of the Earth bursts out from her and sets plants and flowers growing on the Moon. The Moon exclaims that it is "love, all love!" The Earth and the Moon are joined by this spirit and the Earth rejoices that man is transformed into a "chain of linked thought" which can no longer "be divided," and that all "familiar acts are beautiful through love."

The Earth's transformation is so powerful that it extends to the Moon, bringing the infertile, dead planet, back to life so that water begins to flow on her surface and plants begin to grow. The Moon recognizes that this change has taken place through love. This change has also produced total harmony among mankind so that they no longer think as divided individuals but as one, harmonious collective that acts with wisdom and love.

Panthea and Ione rise when they hear the voice of the Demogorgon addressing the world. The Earth and the Moon, voices from nature, humanity, and the spirits of the living and the dead all reply that their "great Republic hears." The Demogorgon announces that **the spirit of "Love**, from its awful throne of power" now rules the world and "bars Destruction's strength." The Demogorgon informs the world that if "the serpent" of destruction should ever be unleashed on the world again, compassion, forgiveness, and defiance of power are "the spells by which to reassume an Empire over the disentangled doom" and to lead man back to "Life, Joy, Empire, and Victory!"

The use of the word "Republic" reflects Shelley's hopes that republics based around individuals who rule themselves will replace absolute monarchies. The passage gestures to the way that Shelley was influenced by the formation of the Republic of France during the French Revolution. Love's throne is described as "awful" because it is so powerful that it is all consuming and nothing can withstand its power. This is different from tyranny, because love allows knowledge and freedom prosper. The serpent symbolizes destruction, hatred, and violence, and once again refers to the character of Satan, who appears as a serpent in the biblical Book of Genesis. Although it is not certain that the world will maintain its state of harmony, the Demogorgon makes it clear that love will triumph over hatred, and that love is the path back from these negative emotions if they ever enter the world again.

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Poetry of Percy Bysshe Shelley | Prometheus Unbound | Summary

Prometheus Unbound is a four-act play by Percy Bysshe Shelley first published in 1820. It is inspired by Aeschylus's Prometheus Bound and concerns Prometheus' release from captivity. However, unlike Aeschylus' version, there is no reconciliation between Prometheus and Zeus in Shelley's narrative. Shelley's play is closet drama, meaning it was not intended to be produced on the stage. In the tradition of other poets in the Romantic Poetry, Shelley wrote for the imagination, intending his play's stage to reside in the imaginations of his readers.

Summary

In the first act, the Titan Prometheus, chained to a precipice in the Caucasus Mountains and tormented by an eagle for stealing fire to give to humanity, is comforted by the sympathetic Earth. The scene is described by the Oceanids Panthea and Ione. Prometheus asks the Earth to recall the words to him that he used to curse Jupiter. When she will not, he summons a phantom to do so for him but regrets the curse, saying he does not wish anyone to suffer. Mercury arrives and sympathizes with Prometheus but says he cannot oppose Jupiter, who has sent the Furies to punish the Titan even more harshly. Mercury tells Prometheus he will be free and lauded if he reveals the secret he alone knows of Jupiter's downfall, but Prometheus elects martyrdom.
The second act follows Prometheus's lover, the Oceanid nymph Asia. The act begins with her summoning her sister Panthea to recount her time since Prometheus's punishment. Then, a series of echoes leads her through a forest of fauns and spirits to the cave of Demogorgon. There, she questions Demogorgon about the creator of the world. Demogorgon alludes to but does not name the Christian God and says he created everything in the world, both good and evil. Confused, Asia asks if he means Jupiter, who rules the world, and the two speak about Prometheus stealing fire and knowledge for humanity. Demogorgon declares that all who serve evil masters are enslaved and speaks about the unchangeable power of love, which Asia declares is the same as the answer her heart has given her. Asia asks when Prometheus will be free. Demogorgon leaves, and various hours pass by in chariots. One hour stops to speak to them and declares itself the dread hour when the tyrant will fall. A later hour offers to carry Asia and Panthea with it, and while it stops to rest, Panthea observes that love has transformed her sister into something radiant.
The third act begins in heaven with Jupiter on his throne. He boasts about having conquered everything on earth but the human soul, but he grows increasingly fearful as he hears the approach of Demogorgon. Demogorgon arrives and declares himself to be Eternity, Jupiter's more powerful child. Jupiter begs for mercy, but when that fails, he calls upon the elements to help him battle Demogorgon. The elements decline to help, and Jupiter falls into the abyss. With Jupiter gone, Hercules and other heroes free a grateful Prometheus. Prometheus thanks him, and Earth leads him and Asia to a cave where they can live in contemplative peace. Without the tyranny of Jupiter, humankind lives freely.

In the final act, which was written months after the first three, the spirits of the hours and the human mind praise love. The earth and the moon rejoice over the paradise of humankind freed from oppression. There are no more wars, and humanity lives in a state of perpetual delight. Science has become so far advanced that there are no longer any secrets and lightning is at humanity's command. Demogorgon rises one final time to proclaim Prometheus's triumph, as he has suffered unbending through his imprisonment but without malice to those who oppressed him. He has spread love and freedom throughout the world with his gifts, and in the end, he is victorious.

Analysis

The play *Prometheus Unbound* was first published in 1820. It is a closet drama, meaning it was never intended to be performed for an audience, merely enjoyed in its written form. Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound* is inspired by the play *Prometheus Bound* by the ancient Greek playwright Aeschylus (525/4 BCE–456/5 BCE). Aeschylus's original play was part of a trilogy. The other two plays exist only as fragments, and only *Prometheus Bound* exists in its entirety. Contemporary sources and prophecies within the first play indicate that Prometheus does in the end reconcile with Jupiter later in the narrative. In his

introduction to the piece, Shelley explains his deviation from the original ending by saying both that he does not wish to be a poor imitation of Aeschylus and that he cannot condone reconciliation with a tyrant. He also contrasts Prometheus as a rebellious mythological hero favorably against Milton's Satan from *Paradise Lost*, saying that Prometheus carries less of the cultural implications of Satan in the West and is not complicated by the moral failings exhibited by Satan in Milton's narrative.
Prometheus Unbound retells the Greek myth and play, but it is reimagined to reflect Shelley's own artistic and philosophical purposes. Demogorgon, for example, is an anachronism, as the character was a later invention popularized by Christian writers and possibly based on a mistranslation. Additionally, as he is being tortured by the Furies, Prometheus sees visions of modern warfare and Jesus's crucifixion, and in the final act characters in the drama allude to the harnessing of electricity, a technology still in its infancy as Shelley was writing.
Shelley was a political radical, and his characters reveal his attitudes about power and change. In his introduction Shelley states explicitly: "My purpose has hitherto been simply to familiarize the highly refined imagination of the more select classes of poetical readers with beautiful idealisms of moral excellence." In Prometheus, Shelley is providing a heroic example of what he considers virtuous: a figure who shares knowledge, defies unjust authority, and is motivated by love and kindness rather than personal ambition.

Shelley's version of Jupiter is an unambiguously cruel and petty tyrant whose authority derives from his power to oppress those beneath him. When faced with a real challenge to his power in the form of Demogorgon, he resorts to pleading and bargaining and ultimately relies on the strength of those he commands rather than his own. He lacks any moral authority to hold his position, and his downfall directly improves the world, creating a leaderless utopia. Jupiter represents the old order of the world, which had for centuries been conceived of as divinely ordained but which Shelley believed was arbitrary and harmful.

Prometheus, by contrast, is unwavering in his rebellion. He never repents stealing fire and technology to enlighten the world, nor does he acknowledge Jupiter's supposed right to punish him. At the same time, he endures his suffering with dignity and regrets his curse against Jupiter. He does not seek retribution, nor does he attempt to fill Jupiter's vacant throne, preferring instead a life of love and quiet contemplation. The text explicitly compares him to Christ in his martyrdom. Prometheus is not merely a revolutionary but embodies the moral characteristics Shelley believes are necessary for true peace: forgiveness, love, generosity, and a willingness to eschew power.

Reason vs. Power
One of the great themes of Prometheus Bound is the frustration and helplessness of reason and rightness in the face of sheer power. Aeschylus hammers the theme home by having Prometheus chained by two demonic forces with allegorical names. Violence, appropriately, is mute, and in many productions Violence is played as a kind of beast. Might is a ruthless, pitiless deity, without any will of his own. He is the fist of Zeus: cold, cruel, the institution of tyranny personified. Viewing Prometheus as reason, we see the play as partly the story of reason's tragic limits, and its helplessness in the face of brutal, unthinking force.

Individual of Conscience vs. Tyranny
This theme is closely connected to the theme of Reason vs. Power. As in the Oresteia, Aeschylus gives us a magnificent net of symbols and metaphor, all working on multiple levels at once. Prometheus is reason and wisdom personified; he is also the individual of conscience in a totalitarian state. Anxiety about tyranny surfaces often in Greek plays. For Athenians, who considered themselves freer than their neighbors, fear of losing that freedom was an obsession. Zeus, like the tyrants of the real world, crosses the lines of custom and unwritten law. His punishment of Prometheus is excessive and in poor taste.

Prometheus is the rebel with a conscience whose crime, his love of man, brings on him both the rage of the gods and the immediate sympathy of the human audience. Prometheus becomes a representative for those human champions of justice and principle who defy tyranny and pay the ultimate price.
Fate
Fate is another oft-explored theme in Greek tragedies. Part of the power of tragedy is the sense of inevitability. This play is unique in that the whole work is one extended Scene of Suffering. Prometheus is literally chained by his fate. Prometheus' name means "Forethinker"; through his connection with his mother Themis, the earth, he can see the future. This power is both gift and curse. Prometheus suffers, and knows he cannot escape his long years of torture. But he also knows that one day he will be set free, and he possesses

a piece of strategic knowledge that could preserve or destroy Zeus's reign. (See "Prometheus the Prophet and Visionary,"

Prometheus the Prophet and Visionary

This is perhaps the most powerful and all-encompassing of the titan's roles. Prometheus is a powerful metaphor for countless visionaries, scientists, statesmen, and artists whose work was not appreciated or understood in their own time. Many of these men and women tried to comfort themselves, as Prometheus does, by assuring themselves that one day recognition will come. But when the world is not ready for a certain kind of knowledge, being the bearer of that knowledge is painful and lonely. The Prometheus story reflects this pain and isolation in the punishment inflicted on its protagonist: part of his suffering will be the long, terrible years of loneliness he will spend, wasting away, not knowing if the sound of approaching footsteps signals a friend bringing comfort or an enemy planning to torture or ridicule him. Some versions of the myth credit him with creating man. This story reinforces Prometheus as a symbol for the supreme artist, suffering for his creation.

Prometheus the Craftsman, and Prometheus the Creator

Prometheus is the supreme artist, the master storyteller who holds the attention of the audience and the chorus, the master craftsman and creator who makes and then instructs man. Both Prometheus and fire are symbols of the creative and ingenious spark in man: "In one short sentence understand it all: / every art of mankind comes from Prometheus" (ll. 506-7). Significantly, Prometheus molds man to follow his example in some ways. He gives them fire, so that they will create. He instructs them to be craftsmen, as he is. Prometheus the Creator is also the visionary artist. His most beautiful creation, man, is also the most despised by Zeus.

Prometheus the Champion of Mankind, and Prometheus the Sufferer

Despite the fact that mortal men can do nothing to help him, Prometheus remains the staunch ally of human beings. He defies the gods on their behalf. Prometheus as the great sufferer is an important theme of the play. In a way, the titan prefigures Christ: he is a divine being who suffers horrible tortures for the sake of mankind. The other gods seem a bit mystified by his willingness to suffer for man; after all, humans can do nothing for him, and they are inferior beings. Prometheus' willing sacrifice is the ultimate gesture he can make for mankind, as well as an example for mankind to follow. Symbolically, he is every great man whose greatness made him into a target.

Dramatis Personæ[edit]

- PROMETHEUS.
- ASIA
- DEMOGORGON.
- PANTHEA
- JUPITER.
- IONE
- THE EARTH.
- THE PHANTASM OF JUPITER.
- OCEAN.
- THE SPIRIT OF THE EARTH.
- APOLLO.
- THE SPIRIT OF THE MOON.
- MERCURY.
- SPIRITS OF THE HOURS.
- HERCULES.
- SPIRITS.
- ECHOES.
- FAUNS.
- FURIES.

Prometheus Unbound: A Brief Synopsis

Like its Greek predecessor by the same name, **Percy Shelley's** drama, *Prometheus Unbound* centers on the titan, Prometheus,' release from captivity, but the similarities between Shelley's version of this play and Aeschylus' version from centuries before end there.

Shelley's 1820 version opens with Prometheus chained to the Caucasus Mountains, where he originally curses Jupiter, or Zeus, for having sentenced him to this fate. He revokes this curse though, once he becomes aware of the consequences of his hate and instead begins to pity the king of the gods for his insecurity. In spite of 3,000 years of torture--both physical and mental, including having had his liver eaten and regenerated each day--Prometheus will not be persuaded to abandon his hope for humanity and the world.

In Act II, **Panthea**, a daughter of Ocean and attendant to captive Prometheus, rushes to find the titan's lost love, **Asia**. Following the signs of Panthea's dream, the two goddesses travel to see **Demogorgon**. Though an ancient symbol of darkness, the genderless Demogorgon is persuaded by Asia to act on behalf of Prometheus and the betterment of humankind.

Act III sees Jupiter overthrown by his offspring, Demogorgon, and Prometheus is finally released from his imprisonment. He is reunited with Asia, and their bliss is mirrored with the harmonious union of Earth and Moon. In the last stanzas, Demogorgon heralds the news of this harmony and ushers in an age of peace and prosperity for all.



Many scenes like this one depict Prometheus as he is tormented by the eagle of Jupiter, having his liver eaten and regenerated each day.

Freeing Oneself

Many of us know the feeling of either holding a grudge or having one held against us. However, we've also known the liberation of letting bygones be bygones. When we visit Aeschylus' version of *Prometheus Unbound*, we find a play that details an ancient grudge-match coming to a close when Zeus (Jupiter) and Prometheus reconcile after 3,000 years.

Shelley's Prometheus also releases his long-held anger, but it is not through reconciliation. In fact, Shelley found the task of reconciling the champion, Prometheus, with the oppressor, Jupiter, of mankind to be impossible. This is because, through reconciliation, Prometheus would've been made to look weak and subordinate.

In Shelley's mind, Prometheus (which is Greek for 'forethought') was the embodiment of humanity's hope for a better tomorrow, free from the restrictions of government, class, religion or other social destinctions.

The Lady of Shalott

by Alfred, Lord Tennyson

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eNotes: Table of Contents

1. The Lady of Shalott: Introduction
2. The Lady of Shalott: Text of the Poem
3. The Lady of Shalott: Alfred, Lord Tennyson Biography
4. The Lady of Shalott: Summary
5. The Lady of Shalott: Themes
6. The Lady of Shalott: Style
7. The Lady of Shalott: Historical Context
8. The Lady of Shalott: Critical Overview
9. The Lady of Shalott: Essays and Criticism
    - Differences between Tennyson's 1833 and 1842 Versions of Poem
    - "Cracked from Side to Side": Sexual Politics in "The Lady of Shalott"
    - The Quest for the "Nameless" in Tennyson's "The Lady of Shalott"
10. The Lady of Shalott: Compare and Contrast
11. The Lady of Shalott: Topics for Further Study
12. The Lady of Shalott: Media Adaptations
13. The Lady of Shalott: What Do I Read Next?
14. The Lady of Shalott: Bibliography and Further Reading

The Lady of Shalott: Introduction

"The Lady of Shalott" tells the story of a woman who lives in a tower in Shalott, which is an island on a river that runs, along with the road beside it, to Camelot, the setting of the legends about King Arthur and the Knights of the Round Table. Every day, the woman weaves a tapestry picture of the landscape that is visible from her window, including Camelot. There is, however, a curse on her; the woman does not know the cause of the curse, but she knows that she cannot look directly out of the window, so she views the subjects of her artwork through a mirror that is beside her. The woman is happy to weave, but is tired of looking at life only as a reflection. One day, Sir Lancelot rides by, looking bold and handsome in his shining armor, and singing. The woman goes to the window to look directly out of it, and the moment she does, she knows that the curse is upon her. So she leaves the tower, finds a boat at the side of the river, writes "The Lady of Shalott" on the side of the boat, and floats off down the river toward Camelot. As she drifts along, singing and observing all of the sights that were forbidden to her before, she dies. The boat floats past Camelot, and all of the knights make the sign of the cross upon seeing a corpse go by, but Lancelot, seeing her for the first time, notes, "She

has a lovely face."

This poem was first published in 1832, when Tennyson was 23 years old, in a volume called Poems. Up to that point, Tennyson had received great critical acclaim and had won national awards, but the critics savagely attacked the 1832 book, mostly because of poems such as "The Lady of Shalott" that dealt with fantasy situations instead of realistic ones. The next year, 1833, Tennyson's best friend died, which affected the poet as greatly as would anything in his life. For a long time, during a period that later came to be known as "the ten years' silence," nothing of Tennyson's was published. In 1842, a new volume, also called Poems, was published, to great critical acclaim. The new book had a slightly revised version of "The Lady of Shalott," and this version is the one that is studied today.

The Lady of Shalott: Text of the Poem

I

On either side the river lie
Long fields of barley and of rye,
That clothe the wold and meet the sky;
And thro' the field the road runs by
     To many-tower'd Camelot;
And up and down the people go,
Gazing where the lilies blow
Round an island there below,
     The island of Shalott.

Willows whiten, aspens quiver,
Little breezes dusk and shiver
Thro' the wave that runs for ever
By the island in the river
     Flowing down to Camelot.
Four grey walls, and four grey towers,
Overlook a space of flowers,
And the silent isle imbowers
     The Lady of Shalott.

By the margin, willow veil'd,
Slide the heavy barges trail'd
By slow horses; and unhail'd
The shallop flitteth silken-sail'd
     Skimming down to Camelot:
But who hath seen her wave her hand?
Or at the casement seen her stand?
Or is she known in all the land,
     The Lady of Shalott?

Only reapers, reaping early
In among the bearded barley,
Hear a song that echoes cheerly
From the river winding clearly,
     Down to tower'd Camelot:
And by the moon the reaper weary,
Piling sheaves in uplands airy,
Listening, whispers "'Tis the fairy
     Lady of Shalott."

II

There she weaves by night and day
A magic web with colors gay.
She has heard a whisper say,
A curse is on her if she stay

To look down to Camelot.
She knows not what the curse may be,
And so she weaveth steadily,
And little other care hath she,
The Lady of Shalott.

And moving thro' a mirror clear
That hangs before her all the year,
Shadows of the world appear.
There she sees the highway near
Winding down to Camelot:
There the river eddy whirls.
And there the surly village-churls
And the red cloaks of market girls,
Pass onward from Shalott.

Sometimes a troop of damsels glad,
An abbot on an ambling pad,
Sometimes a curly shepherd-lad,
Or long-hair'd page in crimson clad
Goes by to tower'd Camelot;
And sometimes thro' the mirror blue
The knights come riding two and two:
She hath no loyal knight and true,
The Lady of Shalott.

But in her web she still delights
To weave the mirror's magic sights,
For often thro' the silent nights
A funeral, with plumes and lights
And music, went to Camelot:
Or when the moon was overhead
Came two young lovers lately wed;
"I am half sick of shadows," said
The Lady of Shalott.

III

A bow-shot from her bower-eaves,
He rode between the barley-sheaves,
The sun came dazzling through the leaves,
And flamed upon the brazen greaves
Of bold Sir Lancelot.
A red-cross knight for ever kneel'd
To a lady in his shield,
That sparkled on the yellow field,
Beside remote Shalott.

The gemmy bridle glitter'd free,
Like to some branch of stars we see
Hung in the golden Galaxy.
The bridle bells rang merrily
As he rode down to Camelot:
And from his blazoned baldric slung
A mighty silver bugle hung,
And as he rode his armour rung,
Beside remote Shalott.

All in the blue unclouded weather
Thick-jewell'd shone the saddle-leather,
The helmet and the helmet-feather
Burn'd like one burning flame together,
As he rode down to Camelot.

As often through the purple night,
Below the starry clusters bright,
Some bearded meteor, trailing light,
     Moves over still Shalott.

His broad clear brow in sunlight glow'd;
On burnish'd hooves his war-horse trode;
From underneath his helmet flow'd
His coal-black curls as on he rode,
     As he rode down to Camelot.
From the bank and from the river
He flashed into the crystal mirror,
"Tirra lirra," by the river
     Sang Sir Lancelot.

She left the web, she left the loom,
She made three paces thro' the room,
She saw the water-lily bloom,
She saw the helmet and the plume,
     She looked down to Camelot.
Out flew the web and floated wide;
The mirror cracked from side to side;
"The curse is come upon me," cried
     The Lady of Shalott.

IV

In the stormy east-wind straining,
The pale yellow woods were waning,
The broad stream in his banks complaining,
Heavily the low sky raining
     Over tower'd Camelot;
Down she came and found a boat
Beneath a willow left afloat,
And round about the prow she wrote
     The Lady of Shalott.

And down the river's dim expanse
Like some bold seër in a trance,
Seeing all his own mischance—
With a glassy countenance
     Did she look to Camelot.
And at the closing of the day
She loosed the chain, and down she lay;
The broad stream bore her far away,
     The Lady of Shalott.

Lying, robed in snowy white
That loosely flew to left and right—
The leaves upon her falling light—
Thro' the noises of the night
     She floated down to Camelot:
And as the boat-head wound along
The willowy hills and fields among,
They heard her singing her last song,
     The Lady of Shalott.

Heard a carol, mournful, holy
Chanted loudly, chanted lowly,
Till her blood was frozen slowly,
And her eyes were darkened wholly,
     Turned to tower'd Camelot.
For ere she reach'd upon the tide

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The first house by the water-side,
Singing in her song she died,
     The Lady of Shalott.

Under tower and balcony,
By garden-wall and gallery,
A gleaming shape she floated by,
Dead-pale between the houses high,
     Silent into Camelot.
Out upon the wharfs they came,
Knight and burgher, lord and dame,
And round the prow they read her name,
     The Lady of Shalott.

Who is this? and what is here?
And in the lighted palace near
Died the sound of royal cheer;
And they cross'd themselves for fear,
     All the knights at Camelot:
But Lancelot mused a little space;
He said, "She has a lovely face;
God in His mercy lend her grace,
     The Lady of Shalott."
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The Lady of Shalott: Alfred, Lord Tennyson Biography

Tennyson was born August 6, 1809, in Somersby, Lincolnshire, England. The fourth of twelve children, he was the son of a clergyman who maintained his office grudgingly after his younger brother had been named heir to their father's wealthy estate. According to biographers, Tennyson's father, a man of violent temper, responded to his virtual disinheritance by indulging in drugs and alcohol. Each of the Tennyson children later suffered through some period of drug addiction or mental and physical illness, prompting the family's grim speculation on the "black blood" of the Tennysons. Biographers surmise that the general melancholy expressed in much of Tennyson's verse is rooted in the unhappy environment at Somersby.

Lord Tennyson

Tennyson enrolled at Trinity College, Cambridge, in 1827. There he met Arthur Hallam, a brilliant undergraduate who became Tennyson's closest friend and ardent admirer of his poetry. Hallam's enthusiasm was welcomed by Tennyson, whose personal circumstances had led to a growing despondency: his father died in 1831, leaving Tennyson's family in debt and forcing his early departure from school; one of Tennyson's brothers suffered a mental breakdown and required institutionalization; and Tennyson himself was morbidly fearful of falling victim to epilepsy or madness. Hallam's untimely death in 1833, which prompted the series of elegies later comprising In Memoriam, contributed greatly to Tennyson's despair. In describing this period, he wrote: "I suffered what seemed to me to shatter all my life so that I desired to die rather than to live." For nearly a decade after Hallam's death, Tennyson published no poetry. During this time, he became engaged to Emily Sellwood, but financial difficulties and Tennyson's persistent anxiety over the condition of his health resulted in their separation. In 1842, an unsuccessful financial venture cost Tennyson nearly everything he owned, causing him to succumb to a deep depression that required medical treatment. Tennyson later resumed his courtship of Sellwood, and they were married in 1850. The timely success of In Memoriam, published that same year, ensured Tennyson's appointment as Poet Laureate, succeeding William Wordsworth. In 1883, Tennyson accepted a peerage, the first poet to be so honored strictly on the basis of literary achievement. Tennyson died October 6, 1892, and was interred in Poet's Corner of Westminister Abbey.

The Lady of Shalott: Summary

Lines 1-9
This poem starts off by giving a visual overview of the situation. The reader is shown the river and the road, and, far in the distance, the towers of Camelot. The people mentioned in this section are not given specific identities; rather, they are common people going about their daily business. It is from their perspective that the poem first shows Shalott, an island in the river.

Lines 10-18
The imagery here is of nature, of freedom, of movement. This is contrasted with the inflexible, colorless walls and towers of Camelot in line 15. The flowers in the next line are not described by their colors or even by their motion in the breeze, but are "overlooked" by the grey walls, as if they are held prisoner. This tone of severity in the middle of nature's healthy activity prepares the reader for the introduction of the Lady of Shalott in line 18.

Lines 19-27
Lines 19-23 focus again on the human activity going on around the island: small river barges pass with heavy loads; small, quick boats called "shallops" skim past the shore around the tower, referred to here as a "margin." With all of this activity, the poem asks who has seen the woman who lives in the tower, implying that she is mysterious, unknown, "veiled."

Lines 28-36
In the fourth stanza of Section I, the imagery changes from relying on the senses of sight and touch (as implied by the plants' motions in the wind in stanza 2) to the sense of sound. The poem tells us that the lady who lives in the tower has not been seen, and is known only to the farmers who hear her singing while they work in their fields so early in the morning that the moon is still out. Because they never see her but only hear her singing, the reapers think of the Lady of Shalott as a spirit, a "fairy." Up to this point, the reader has not been introduced to her, either, and knows only as much about her as those outside of the tower know.

Lines 37-45
The Lady seems to be happy where she is: her songs echo "cheerly" (line 30) and she weaves her picture in happy, gay colors (line 38) and she has no care in the world other than weaving (line 44). In this stanza, though, the reader finds out that the Lady will have a curse visited on her if she looks at Camelot. This idea

combines many familiar themes: readers generally recognize the maiden trapped in the tower from the tale of Rapunzel or the maiden placed under a spell from the story of Sleeping Beauty; in addition, according to Greek myth, Penelope, the wife of Ulysses, avoided men who wanted to court her while her husband was away by constantly weaving, but then unravelling her work at night so that she would never be done. This is an appropriate allusion because both Penelope and the Lady of Shalott use their craft as a substitute for human involvement. Strangely, the Lady does not know why she has to avoid direct interaction, nor does she seem to care.

Lines 46-54
Not able to look directly at the world out of her window, the Lady observes it through a mirror. This stanza describes a few of the things she sees in that mirror. The images she sees are described as "shadows." According to the Greek philosopher Plato we experience life like a person would who was chained up inside of the mouth of a cave: he cannot see out, he can only see the shadows of people passing the cave flickering on the wall, and he thinks that the shadows are reality. In that same way we all, according to Plato, mistake images of reality for actual reality, which we cannot see. For the Lady of Shalott, reality is not the broad landscape but the images (Tennyson calls them "shadows") she sees in the mirror.

Lines 55-63
The people in this stanza are in motion, going about their busy lives while hers is solitary and static. Reflected in her mirror she sees a group of happy girls, a clergyman, a page, and, sometimes, the knights of Camelot, riding in columns.

Lines 64-72
The action of the poem begins in this stanza, where the Lady's attitude changes: in line 55, she is delighted with the picture she is weaving of the outside world, but in line 71, the first time she speaks, she says she is unhappy with her situation. In between the two, she observes people participating in events—a funeral is mentioned first, then a wedding—that make her aware of how lonely it is to be unable to participate.

Lines 73-81
The image of Sir Lancelot shoots into the Lady's mirror with the force of an arrow fired from the roof just outside of her bedroom window. The description that Tennyson gives of the knight mixes his bold, powerful look with his chivalrous actions. Sunlight glints on his shiny armor, making him look as if he is on fire, and the speaker of the poem also tells us that he is the type of knight who always, even if dressed for battle, took time to kneel when he encountered a lady. His knighthood confirms that he is a man of the highest honor and nobility.

Lines 82-90
This second stanza of Section III shifts the description of Lancelot from the visual to the audible. The bells of his bridle ring "merrily" as he rides, his armor rings as well, and in his equipment belt, the "baldric," is a "mighty bugle"; the musical notes of which communicate the situation at hand.

Lines 91-99
This stanza, in which Sir Lancelot is likened to a meteor, glowing as if he were on fire, splendid in his armor and "trailing light," serves to emphasize what an impressive sight he was as he rode toward Camelot.

Lines 100-108
After the intricate description that the reader has been given of Lancelot, it is in this stanza, in line 106, that the Lady is able to see him for the first time. Tennyson says that he "flashed into the crystal mirror," which is fitting because his shining armor seems to flash everywhere he goes, but it is especially appropriate because the Lady earlier referred to the images in her mirror as "shadows" (line 71), which are of course dark and dull.

Also of significance is that Sir Lancelot sings. The immediate cause of the Lady's attraction to him, the thing that prompts her to look out of the window, is not visual, but audible; here Tennyson suggests the fullness of life that the Lady cannot avoid any longer. Lancelot sings a traditional folk refrain, which would be historically accurate and would invoke a sense of nostalgia in readers of Tennyson's time.

Lines 109-117
Although it is Sir Lancelot's singing that makes the Lady tempt fate by going to the window and looking out, she never actually sees him, just his helmet and the feather upon it. The irony of this is buried, however, within the rush of mystical occurrences which indicate that the curse the Lady mentioned in line 40 is indeed real: the mirror cracks, the tapestry unravels. This could also be given a psychological interpretation, with the events that are presented as "actually" happening being explained as symbols of what is going on in the Lady's head: in this interpretation, the moment the woman becomes involved in the outside world her sense of self (the mirror) and of her accomplishments (the tapestry) comes apart, as if social interaction is a curse to the ego.

Lines 118-126
The season has changed—earlier in the poem, when the barley was being harvested (lines 28-29), the setting was late summer; line 119 describes an autumn scene (the falling leaves of line 138 support this). Although the time described does not seem to allow for a change of seasons, the magical element (most obvious in the unexplained source of the Lady's curse) creates an atmosphere where this compression of time is not unreasonable. It is significant that the Lady takes the time to write her name on the side of the boat: if one accepts the interpretation that the mirror symbolizes self-knowledge, then she is a woman whose identity has been "shattered" at this point of the poem. She has no name to sign, just a title ("Lady") and a location ("Shalott").

Lines 127-135
"Mischance" means misfortune or bad luck—the Lady understands that she is doomed as she looks toward Camelot, which had been so attractive to her that it (in the person of Sir Lancelot) forced her to look, sealing her fate. Earlier, she looked at Camelot through a mirror, seeing it where her own reflection would normally be; in line 130 the look on her face ("countenance") is described as glassy, which suggests the mirror, but does not reflect.

Lines 136-144
"They" mentioned in line 143 are the reapers who earlier in the poem were so charmed by the Lady's voice.

Lines 145-153
The death of the Lady of Shalott is surrounded with standard death images: cold, darkness, and mournful singing, among others. This is a transitional stanza, connecting the dying woman's departure with the dead woman's arrival at Camelot.

Lines 154-162
The Lady's corpse is described as "dead-pale" and "gleaming," providing a stark visual contrast to the night as she floats past Camelot. Tennyson lists the occupants of the castle in line 160, as they are probably becoming aware of the Lady's existence for the first time, although she was very aware of theirs. They are described as curious, going out of their houses and onto the wharf to look, walking around to read the front of the boat. This stanza ends leaving the reader to anticipate what effect the sight will have on the people of Camelot.

Lines 163-171
In the first five lines of this stanza, the initial curiosity of the people of Camelot turns to fear, the primitive fear of seeing a dead person, and the way these Christian people respond in order to protect themselves when frightened is to make the sign of the cross. Tennyson brings this entire long poem to a climax at this point: the

Lady of Shalott was so enchanted with the idea of Camelot that she eventually was forced to look out of the window to see it herself, and in these lines she produces an emotional effect that is almost equally as strong. But Lancelot, whose stunning presence affected the Lady so personally that it ultimately drew her to her death, looks at her, thinks for "a little space," and finally, dispassionately, remarks that she is pretty. Tennyson makes Lancelot's next line a standard benediction of the time that might have been said over anyone, whether friend or stranger.

The Lady of Shalott: Themes

Deprivation
In this poem, the main character exists under a spell without knowing what its origin is or why it has been put on her and without thinking of how she can remove it. She seems to accept it as her fate: "And so she weaveth steadily, / And little other care has she" (lines 43-44), the poem explains. The one stipulation of this mysterious curse is that she cannot look out her window at the panorama of nature and humanity that is so clearly outlined in the poem's first section. She does not seem to care that she is deprived of direct contact with the world. She does not question why she has been cursed like this. Tennyson does not provide an explanation for the curse; he does not offer a reason why this woman is denied the immediate pleasures and problems of real life. Perhaps the poet wanted the psychology behind her captivity to be open-ended and to invite readers to apply various interpretations to her situation and behavior. The important point is that she is isolated, forced to observe the world indirectly through a mirror, and she does not seem to object to this deprivation until her interest in handsome Lancelot overcomes her initial detachment.

Art and Artifice
The Lady of Shalott's view of reality depends on the reflection she perceives in her mirror. Mirrors may be thought of as devices that accurately duplicate the scene they reflect, but images in mirrors are different than reality. They reverse the subject and relegate it to two dimensions. Moreover, the objects reflected in this mirror cannot hurt the Lady of Shalott the same way objects viewed directly can. The reflected scenes of the Camelot countryside are further altered by her artistic imagination, as she incorporates them into her tapestry: it is her delight "[t]o weave the mirror's magic sights" (line 65). The Lady is thus presented as an artist, more involved in her creative version of her indirect experience than with life experience itself. Indeed, she represents the nineteenth-century emphasis on the problems and issues connected to the artist's subjectivity. Reality as she knows it is flat but gives the sense of depth; she transforms that reality imaginatively with her bright threads, yet she also renders it two-dimensional. When she faces actual reality by looking out the window, it breaks the mirror that she no longer needs to see through and also destroys her handiwork. Reality makes the art she has created vanish.

Infatuation
Quite a few critics suggest that the Lady of Shalott dies of a broken heart because she is suddenly infatuated with the dazzlingly beautiful Lancelot and he does not return her affection. This reading applies to the traditional tale that is the source for the piece; in the story of Elaine of Astolat, Elaine does indeed suffer from rejection. The Lady of Shalott, however, is a variation on that character, different in several ways. Tennyson changed the setting from Astolat to Shalott, an ancient variation of the name. In his poem, the Lady and Lancelot never meet: when he does see her for the first time, dead in her boat, he expresses belated interest.

Readers are told of Lancelot's physical appeal well before the Lady knows anything about it. He is described as having a broad, clear brow; his shield bares a picture of a knight kneeling to a lady, and his saddle is decked with jewels. But what draws the Lady to look out the window is the sound of his beautiful singing. As soon as she sees him, her weaving literally flies out the window, and her mirror cracks. "'The curse is come upon me'" (line 116), she says.

This reaction can be seen as symbolic. Being distracted by Lancelot brings the curse upon her. The curse may be understood as the loss of her creative perception of the world. Stated differently, she loses her way of keeping her mind occupied with work. In turn, the mirror's cracking suggests the idea that she can no longer focus only on artwork once her interest in another person draws her into the world at large. She is not "rejected" by Lancelot because, in this version, he is unaware of her until the end; still, she finds herself so drawn to him that she takes her life into her own hands, just to see the face that goes with that voice.

Liberation
After she realizes that the curse has come upon her, the Lady of Shalott does not die immediately. Her exposure to the real world, even though it means her death, also means that she can express herself directly in the world. She leaves the tower, finds a boat, and writes her title on it before lying in it and casting off. Her trip down the river is her passive entry into the world of action. Or it could be understood as her acquiescence to her feelings. Curiously, even though it is Lancelot who distracts her from her weaving and thus seals her fate, her final action does not focus on him. She lets the river take her where it will, past all of the people and places she only has intuited partially in the mirror, and she sings, expressing herself in this moment to the world around her.

The Lady of Shalott: Style

"The Lady of Shalott" is a ballad. There is no standard structure for a ballad, but the term refers to a poem or a song that tells the story of a person or people, usually with details that give them qualities that are larger than life.

The poem is divided into four numbered sections, with each section, like a story, rising to a climax before it ends. This structure helps capture the reader's interest, enticing the reader to find out what will happen next. Each section is broken down, not quite equally, into stanzas, which are sections in poetry similar to paragraphs in prose. There are four stanzas in Parts I and II, five stanzas in Part III, and six in Part IV. Keeping the early sections shorter allows the poet to hold the reader's attention.

The stanzas all contain the same basic structure: there are nine lines, with a rhyme scheme of *aaaabcccb*. This means that in each stanza the final sounds of the first four lines (coded as the *a* sound) are similar; lines 5 and 9 rhyme (the *b* sound); and lines 6, 7, and 8 rhyme with each other. Unlike some poets, who try to de-emphasize or conceal rhymes, Tennyson brings attention to rhymes by making most of the lines end-stopped—the flow of words is brought to a halt by punctuation. This strong emphasis on rhymes helps to give the poem the feeling of an ancient tale, since it resembles poems from the time before printing was developed, when news was carried from town to town by word of mouth and rhyming aided memorization.

The lines of this poem are written in iambic tetrameter. An "iamb" is a unit of poetry (referred to as a "poetic foot") that has an unstressed syllable followed by a stressed syllable—in the first line, for example, the syllables "eith" "side" "riv" and "lie" are accented more heavily than the syllables that come before them. Iambic poetry closely follows the up-and-down pattern of English speech, making the poem's structure hardly noticeable. Tetrameter means that there are four feet to each line ("tetra" is the Greek word for "four"), for a total of eight syllables to each line.

The Lady of Shalott: Historical Context

Arthurian Legend
The character Tennyson calls the Lady of Shalott is based on Elaine of Astolat, one of the figures from the legend of King Arthur. Traditionally, she was identified only as "demoiselle d'escalot," the fair maid of Astolat. It was Sir Thomas Malory who gave her the name "Elaine" in his 1485 book Le Morte d'Arthur.

Tennyson wrote about her as Elaine, the Lilly Maid of Astolat, in *The Idylls of the King*, published in 1885, but in his poem "The Lady of Shalott," he has taken liberties, leaving her without a name and changing "Astolat" to the archaic "Shalott." In both versions, the character dies of unrequited love for Sir Lancelot and floats down the river in a barge, to be wondered about by the common people who are going about their daily concerns.

The legends of King Arthur and his knights are mythical, although many researchers have put forth theories about the actual historical existence of the people they describe. The legends began appearing during the Middle Ages between the fifth and fifteenth centuries. The earliest record of a King Arthur is in a seventh-century Welsh text. Arthurian stories were told all over Europe, particularly in France. The first continuous narrative of the legend, with most of the knights and supporting characters and specific episodes that readers know in the twenty-first century, appeared in the *Historia Regum Britainne* ("History of the Kings of Britain") by the English writer Geoffrey of Monmouth, published in or around 1139. It was this book that identified the Arthur of Camelot as the sixth-century king, son of Uther Pendragon, who kept council with his court of knights at a round table and was married to Guinevere. Other historians have guessed that there were other kings named Arthur who could have inspired the legends.

Lancelot, the bold knight who is mentioned in this poem, is not mentioned in the earlier legends. He first appears in the late twelfth century, in *Le Chevalier de Charette* by Chrétien de Troyes and *Lanzelot* by Ulrich von Zatzikhofen. This character quickly became an integral part of the myth, a favorite character because he embodies the qualities of courage and chivalry that befit the tales.

According to legend, Lancelot is born "Galahad" but has his name changed early in life when his family is killed by a fire (he later has a son named Galahad with Elaine of Corbenic, who is different than Elaine of Astolat). He is raised by "The Lady of the Lake," a mystical character who is said to have given Arthur the sword, Excalibur, which establishes him as king. It is her influence that establishes Lancelot on his eighteenth birthday as a knight of the Round Table. There, he proves to be the most valiant knight, but he also becomes treacherous: he and Arthur's wife, Guinevere, fall in love and have an affair.

It is their sexual relationship that destroys the court at Camelot. When Arthur finds out about it, he orders Guinevere to be executed for treason. Lancelot and his army attack, spiriting the queen away and killing many knights. Guinevere is returned to Arthur, and Lancelot goes to France where he establishes a rival court. In later years, the animosity between the two men cools, and Lancelot returns to Camelot before Arthur's death to ask his forgiveness. He then retires to live a secluded, monkish life at his castle.

Romanticism

In terms of literary movements, Tennyson is most closely associated with the Victorian era. Queen Victoria liked his work and appointed him Poet Laureate of Britain, a post he held from 1850 to 1892. The first version of this poem appeared in 1833, though, when Tennyson was in his twenties. Its sensibilities reveal a closer attachment to the Romantic movement, which was at its peak at that time.

No category can capture the sensibilities of all of the artists who worked in a particular time, but it is sometimes helpful to name philosophical movements and to group thinkers with similar ideas in order to get a sense of the prevailing mood of an era. Romanticism was the prevailing mood at the end of the eighteenth century and well into the nineteenth. It is a reaction against the previous mood, which is called the Enlightenment, so named because it emphasized rationality, which led to the drive for political equality as the most rational way for states to govern. Two thinkers associated with the Enlightenment are Thomas Jefferson and Jean-Jacques Rousseau, both of whom were instrumental in encouraging the cause of democracy over the rule of monarchs, and their writings contributed to the motivations behind the American and French Revolutions. The Enlightenment produced intellectual philosophers, and the art of the period was called Neo-Classical because it incorporated the logic, order, and balance of classical Greek art. (Neo-Classicism

co-occurs with explorations of Greek and Roman ruins in Greece and Italy.)

Many historians recognize the start of the Romantic Period as occurring about 1800, when William Wordsworth set forth a new theory of poetry in his Preface to *Lyrical Ballads*. The Preface summarizes some important traits of Romanticism: an emphasis on feeling as the source of creativity, a preference for subjectivity, an overall devotion to nature as a symbolic code for spiritual truth, and a desire to give voice to oppressed and rustic people. Poetry Wordsworth said, "is the spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings … recollected in tranquility." Poetry, then, is the expression of human feeling as it is remembered and continues to be felt. In the shadow of the French Revolution English writers like William Blake and Samuel Coleridge expressed similar sensibilities.

The second phase of Romanticism, from 1805 to the 1830s, produced other writers associated with the term, the most famous of whom are John Keats Percy Shelley, and Lord Byron (born George Gordon). In addition to stressing feeling, writers continued an earlier interest in national history and folklore. Sir Walter Scott wrote historical novels about legendary English characters; John Keats (as well as many others) rewrote the Robin Hood legends; and Tennyson focused on the tales of the Knights of the Round Table. Another relevant element is an interest in the occult and in morbidity; Mary Wollstonecraft Shelley's Frankenstein is an example as are the nightmarish visions in the poetry of the U.S. writer Edgar Allan Poe.

The Lady of Shalott: Critical Overview

Tennyson's early poems are not often analyzed by twentieth-century critics because his later pieces are considered much more thought provoking: as early as 1895, George Saintsbury noted that "'The Lady of Shalott' does not count among the poems that established Tennyson's title to the first rank of English poets." Still, to the same critic, it is one of the poet's "happiest" pieces, not because of the subject matter—after all, a curse kills the Lady in the end—but because of Tennyson's skillful use of words. "There is such a latent charm in mere words, cunning collocations, and in the voice ringing in them," famed poet Walt Whitman wrote, "which [Tennyson] caught and has brought out, beyond all others." Among the poems that he goes on to list as examples of this is "The Lady of Shalott."

Though its subject matter is considered by scholars to be light, there has been no denying that it was influential in its time and is probably responsible for other works of art with similar themes. Critic John D. Jump noted in his 1974 book about Tennyson that "The Lady of Shalott" shows how readily [Tennyson's language] can give access to that medieval dream world which attracted so many nineteenth-century writers and painters. Arthur Noyse noted that "his early Arthurian poems practically founded the pre-Raphaelite school in England." Whatever impression the modern reader has of Camelot and the age of chivalry, it probably bears some influence from Tennyson and the stunning pictures of that long-ago time that he painted with his words.

The Lady of Shalott: Essays and Criticism

Differences between Tennyson's 1833 and 1842 Versions of Poem

The story told in Alfred, Lord Tennyson's poem "The Lady of Shalott" obviously lacks a key narrative element, making it, at least in theory, a flawed attempt at storytelling. Handled less skillfully, it might easily have been rejected by readers and literary critics as a weak attempt to use powerful language to make up for its storytelling deficiencies. The poem concerns a damsel who lives in a stone tower, threatened by a curse that she knows, somehow, will kill her if she looks out her window at the world that surrounds her. The curse

is real; she does look, and she dies. The basic question that must go through the mind of anyone who reads this poem is how the curse came to be. Tennyson could not have failed to notice what an important aspect of the story he left out.

Assuming, then, that Tennyson left this crucial information out on purpose, it is very likely that he had that same purpose in mind while making changes to the poem between the first and second published versions, dated, respectively, 1833 and 1842. Neither version could have been written with the goal of writing a clear story, not with that glaring omission, and the revision does nothing to fill in the missing details. But adding up all of these oddities draws a line to Tennyson's true purpose. A comparison between the two versions shows more than just corrections or adjustments in the 1842 revision. The later version is even more mysterious than the original, which, unexpectedly, makes it more human.

The main reason that this poem is able to successfully present a magic spell without explaining why or how that spell occurred is its setting. The story takes place in Camelot, a mythical land that, if it ever actually existed, certainly was not the kingdom that the ancient stories present. Popular imagination has attached itself to the historical facts, adding stories about Merlin the sorcerer, the Lady of the Lake, and the magical Sword in the Stone, Excalibur, that could only be handled by a person who was good and wise. Because magic is, by its very definition, outside of the ordinary laws of nature, there is a tendency to accept it as unknowable and to leave issues of magic unexamined.

But it is wrong to assume that magic has no rules at all. Like the myths of ancient Greece and Rome, the medieval stories of the Knights of the Round Table used magic to pass judgements on morality. For example, Odysseus's ten-year journey home from the Trojan War was said to have been caused by his failing to properly offer a homage to the god Poseidon. Similarly, Lancelot, Camelot's bravest and most chivalrous knight, is not able to find the coveted Holy Grail because of his affair with Arthur's wife, Guinevere. Thus the honor of finding the Grail is passed to Lancelot's son. The major difference is that the Greek myths were based on religious customs, while the magic involved in the Arthurian legends affirmed Christian principles. Saying that the curse on the Lady of Shalott is "magical" does not remove the need for a cause, even if it helps to dampen readers' curiosity.

In both versions of this poem, Tennyson worked against natural human curiosity, tweaking it without satisfying it. Doing so tells readers that the details surrounding the curse are really not important to his message. In some ways, Tennyson's method anticipates Modernism which did not actually develop until the 1920s. The First World War (1914-1918) was so catastrophic that it changed many systems of thought, including literary theory. The Modernist poetry that resulted did more than just dictate poetic information to readers and invite them to appreciate the poet's verbal skill: it acknowledged that readers are aware that they are reading a poem that somebody wrote. "The Lady of Shalott" counts on its readers to be aware of its author's existence and to wonder about the thought process that led him to leave out critical information. The only sensible explanation that readers can arrive at is that he means to downplay the mystical aspect of this myth and to focus attention on the psychology of the character who is the poem's focus.

There are only a few differences between the version of the poem published in 1833 and Tennyson's 1842 revision, but, surprisingly, they serve to make the setting and the character even more obscure. Usually, poetry tries to render a vivid experience, and so an author's changes often serve to make the visual experience clearer, not hazier. Again, the assumption must be that Tennyson is trying to push the irrelevant aspects deeper into the background, with the hope that readers will focus more on personality than on situation.

The 1833 version of the poem tells readers what the Lady of Shalott looks like in two extended passages. The first is in the poem's fourth stanza, at the end of the first section. Details bring her to life, giving her an actual, physical presence. "A pearlgarland winds her head," the poem explains: "She leaneth on a velvet bed, / Fully royally appareled, / The Lady of Shalott." At this point the revision, which follows the same general shape,

describes the reaper in the field, listening to her song, rather than describing her looks. This brings in more a sense of the surrounding world, less a sense of the Lady.

The earlier version also has an entire stanza of physical description that Tennyson later removed. After the first stanza of the fourth section, after she has already come out of the castle, written her name on the boat, and climbed into it to float down river, the original poem says:

> A cloudwhite crown of pearl she dight,
> All raimented in snowy wight
> That loosely flew, (her zone in sight,
> Clasped with one blinding diamond bright,)
> Though the squally eastwind keenly
> Blew, with folded arms serenely
> By the water stood the queenly Lady of Shalott.

This version is specific about her clothes, her posture, and her general demeanor. The 1842 version is not only less descriptive about her looks, but it removes any detail about her visual presence altogether.

Another part that changed from one version to the next was the poem's initial emphasis on death. The early version is much more graphic; in the stanza before the last it includes the lines, "A pale, pale corpse she floated by, / Deadcold, between the houses high, / Dead toward Camelot." The corresponding lines in the revised version read, "A gleaming shape she floated by, / Dead-pale between the houses high, / Silent into Camelot." The revised poem does mention death, indicating that Tennyson' s intention remained to be clear that she dies. Yet the emphasis on death in the newer version is softened, which shifts its emphasis from spectacle to meditation.

W. David Shaw, in a 1976 essay for the Cornell University Press, noted that the two versions highlight the ways in which Tennyson "wavers between the impulse to write poems of pure sensation … and his impulse to test and enlarge his poetry." Shaw uses this difference to show differences in poetic theory from the Romantic period and the Victorian period (Queen Victoria took the throne in 1837, right between these two versions). Without even considering the significance to literary history of these two versions of the poem, it is still interesting to consider the two motives that Shaw attributes to Tennyson: the earlier version, the one that emphasizes death and the maiden's looks, is the one that he calls poetry written for "pure sensation," and in fact it is the one that gives the most chilling sensation.

Ultimately, each version is defined by its final lines. The first time the poem was published, the last stanza focused on the local people, referred to earlier in both versions as the "surly village-churls," who gather around the boat in amazement at the sight of a beautiful dead woman that they do not know. Lancelot may or may not be with them in this earlier form; certainly, the germ of the idea of making him an observer was there because Tennyson mentions a knight in the assembled crowd. This version ends with a quote from the Lady, written on a parchment that rests on her breast: "The web was woven curiously, / The charm is broken utterly, / Draw near and fear not—this is I, / The Lady of Shalott." The version of 1842, of course, has Lancelot approach the boat and presents his words, not hers, in the last few lines. He comments on her lovely face. Instead of the simple pathos of the baffled farm people finding out about her existence from a note that she has pinned to herself in death, something like a suicide note to strangers, the revision brings the story around to the person who unwittingly caused her death. It is mysterious and somewhat ironic in itself, but the true humanizing element is in the fact that Lancelot is attracted to her, perhaps as much as she was to him, but that neither of them will ever know.

In both versions of this poem, Tennyson managed to skirt the central issue of what it is that kills the Lady of Shalott. For those who take the poem at face value, believing the events as they are given, she is killed by a

curse, one that the Lady knows specific details about but that Tennyson does not share with his readers. A cynic who does not believe in magic can read the curse as being symbolic for some psychological state that keeps her from social interaction, one that Lancelot's beautiful singing voice draws her from, but that does little to explain why she would be this way. The most satisfying clues to why Tennyson chose to do it this way come from the changes he made while revising. Removing the most graphic signs of death and corpses gives more leeway for interpreting her "death" as a symbolic consequence for leaving her safe abode. Removing her physical presence takes the poem even further from reality, forcing readers to imagine her, giving the whole situation a more unreal setting, as a drama that plays out in her mind instead of in the physical world. And bringing Lancelot in at the end stresses the conflict between the Lady's view of the world and the world's view of her. In the first reality, she and Camelot exist beside each other with no interaction, but Lancelot's interest in her in the revised view implies an emotional bond that did exist but that was cut down by this mysterious curse. Readers do not need to know what this curse is in order to feel sorry for the Lady of Shalott and for Lancelot, and, by extension, for all of humanity.

Source: David Kelly, Critical Essay on "The Lady of Shalott," in *Poetry for Students*, The Gale Group, 2002. Kelly is an adjunct professor of creative writing and literature at Oakton Community College and an associate professor of literature and creative writing at College of Lake County and has written extensively for academic publishers.

"Cracked from Side to Side": Sexual Politics in "The Lady of Shalott"

Tennyson's "The Lady of Shalott" (1842) is often read by critics as a poem centrally concerned with the question of the relation between "art" and "life," conditions respectively symbolized in the worlds of Shalott and "many-towered Camelot." The poem resolves this question, it is usually argued, by the recognition that "life" is inherently antipathetic to the possibility of an ongoing artistic production—an insight taken in turn to be enacted by the death which befalls the Lady who gives the poem its title in the course of her attempted sortie from the one realm of the poem to the other. A paradigmatic formulation of this canonical approach is provided by Walter E. Houghton and G. Robert Stange in their anthology, *Victorian Poetry and Poetics* (1959). According to their notes to the poem, "The Lady of Shalott" suggests

> that the artist must remain in aloof detachment, observing life only in the mirror of the imagination, not mixing in it directly. Once the artist attempts to lead the life of ordinary men his poetic gift, it would seem, dies.

So persistent is this view that Alastair W. Thomson similarly claims, thirty years later, that Tennyson's poem "represents the dilemma of the introspective artist, condemned to a life of shadows, and risking destruction if he turns to reality."

No reading is ideologically innocent, however—least of all a canonical one (which, in these instances, also blithely turns the "she" of the text into the "he" of its readers)—and the ideology of approaches which see "The Lady of Shalott" as a proto-Yeatsian allegory of choice between "Perfection of the life, or of the work," might be described as implicitly "utilitarian": by reading Tennyson' s poem as "a myth of the poetic imagination" and concluding that the artist/poet must remain antithetically and irrevocably divorced from "life," the critic simultaneously consigns the text to just that condition of purely aesthetic limbo which largely defines the Lady's plight throughout the poem.

What the canonical/utilitarian approach fails to take into account, in other words, is the question of the relation of the poem itself to "life"—its implication, that is, in the specificities of its own historical moment. Hence it remains blind to the existence of a certain conflict between what "The Lady of Shalott" says about

the art/life relation and the way in which that relation is instantiated and configured by the text itself. At the level of the symbolic narrative within the poem, art and life would indeed seem to be fatally opposed to one another and the text to offer a reluctant manifesto for the romantically isolated poet. Yet, as Joseph Chadwick has shown, "The Lady of Shalot" itself constitutes an art-work produced and indeed enabled—albeit obliquely—through an active engagement with its own contemporary moment. For Chadwick, "despite the feudal setting of the poem … it is Tennyson's *own social order*, not the one from which he drew the Lady and Lancelot" that creates "the problems of autonomy and privacy [the poem] confronts." In this respect, the dialogue of the poem with its historical context ironically refutes the necessity for aesthetic withdrawal from "life" or history which it appears internally to affirm. Far from being mutually exclusive, what Tennyson's poem conversely demonstrates is that art and life, the aesthetic and the political, are fully interwoven: the involvement in the social world which is symbolically the destination of the Lady in the poem is, from the first, a condition at which the poem has already arrived. As such, "The Lady of Shalott" bears out Alan Sinfield's contention that "even poetry which appears to be remote from political issues is in fact involved in the political life of its society."

One of the concerns at the heart of the political (as well as intellectual, social, and cultural) life of Tennyson's nineteenth-century context is, as criticism generally acknowledges, the "Woman Question." While "The Lady of Shalott" addresses this question, it does so, as will be shown, in a systematically ambivalent manner, at once upholding and dislocating patriarchal assumptions about the issues which the question entails—those of gender, sexuality, the institution of marriage, and the space occupied by women in society.

I

As befits a text whose operations are profoundly equivocal, the landscape into which "The Lady of Shalott" draws its reader is one precisely ordered in terms of opposition and division: "On either side the river lie / Long fields of barley and of rye." Yet the opening description of place includes a detail whose effect is to disrupt the coherence of another opposition—between illusion and reality—which is central to the organization of symbolic space within the poem as a whole. While firmly divided from one another, Tennyson's "fields," we are told, nonetheless "meet the sky" fashioning a conjunction which, as Edgar F. Shannon, Jr. points out, is purely the result of an optical illusion. Though the text seeks to confine the presence of illusions solely to "The island of Shalott", it is evident from the outset that they exist in realms beyond its boundaries. Even before the opposition between "the silent isle" and Camelot can develop into an opposition between "the region of shadows [and] that of realities," the latter opposition is itself being skeptically revealed as illusory, problematic, in some way flawed.

Tensions between the setting up and upsetting of distinctions are operative not only in terms of the relation between illusion and reality but also at the level of the representation of gender difference in the poem, raising—as such—the question of its sexual politics. Feminist criticism maintains that the categories of gender (as opposed to sex)—"masculinity" and "femininity"—are not naturally or self-evidently given but instead ideologically produced by society and culture. Insofar as these categories are at the same time hierarchically organized in favor of men, the ground of their production is, as feminism also argues, a patriarchal one. The ideological sleight-of-hand by which patriarchy mystifies or tropes the cultural as the natural (thus preserving its dominion) is neatly summarized by Griselda Pollock:

> Patriarchy does not refer to the static, oppressive domination by one sex over another, but to a web of psycho-social relationships which institute a socially significant difference on the axis of sex which is so deeply located in our very sense of lived, sexual, identity that it appears to us as natural and unalterable.

The way in which the relations between the sexes, which constitute power-relations also, are ideally woven for and by patriarchy is itself graphically outlined in a passage from Tennyson's *The Princess: A Medley*, published in 1847, five years after the appearance of the revised version of "The Lady of Shalott":

Man for the field and woman for the hearth:
Man for the sword and for the needle she:
Man with the head and woman with the heart:
Man to command and woman to obey;
All else confusion.

These lines return us, by contrast, to "The Lady of Shalott," a text whose stance toward patriarchal ideology is substantially less didactic than that propounded by the old king—the Prince's father—who is their speaker.

At first glance, however, it would appear that, despite the medievalism of the poem, the disposition of social space in "The Lady of Shalott" accurately replicates, as the citation from Chadwick implies, the gender conventions informing Victorian society. On the one hand, the Lady is consigned to a private and socially peripheral space of "Four gray walls, and four gray towers," located on the far side of a "margin, willow-veiled", while on the other, the public realm of Camelot is inhabited by "bold Sir Lancelot": mythic past conforms to socio-historic present, as private and public spaces are respectively identified with "femininity" and "masculinity" in both.

Considered as a response to the patriarchal norms embodied in the Shalott/Camelot opposition, the inclination of Tennyson's poem appears—from the perspective of narrative structure—to be to support and maintain them. While the central action in the text concerns the Lady's attempted performance of a crossing from private/"feminine" to public/"masculine" worlds, this movement is one which, strictly speaking, goes uncompleted, or is permitted to occur only posthumously:

For ere she reached upon the tide
The first house by the water-side,
Singing in her song she died,
The Lady of Shalott.

Intercepting the Lady's crossing by means of death, the narrative of the poem registers its own resistance to the transgression of gender divisions—and hence the possibility of political change—of which that crossing is the sign.

As the index of resistance to such a possibility, the death which the text eventually imposes upon the Lady is only the formal or explicit culmination of a process which commences much earlier. This process works, through a series of strategies, to transform the future toward which the Lady travels into a repetition of the past she seeks to escape, thus creating the illusion that the patriarchally subversive crossing from Shalott to Camelot is itself illusory, since a future that repeats a past effectively erases the present that ordinarily facilitates the passage from one to the other. The first of these strategies occurs precisely at the point, in fact, at which the Lady prepares to leave Shalott: "She left the web, she left the loom, / She made three paces through the room." If these lines retard even the motion they describe—the Lady's crossing of her studio—through syntactic repetition, arresting "paces" into stasis, they are similarly and secondly followed by the typographical effacement of the larger crossing from Shalott to Camelot in the shape of the blank space between the third and fourth sections of the poem. The Lady's emergence on the other side of this space is accompanied by a sudden shift in seasons—from "the blue unclouded weather" of summer to autumn:

In the stormy east-wind straining,
The pale yellow woods were waning,
The broad stream in his banks complaining,
Heavily the low sky raining
Over towered Camelot;
Down she came and found a boat.

With this shift, as Chadwick notes, the Lady "finds a world just as gray as the one she has left", as the future again repeats the past.

The pattern of temporal inversion and elision we are outlining constitutes, to recapitulate, a kind of proleptic supplement to that resistance to the (ideologically disruptive) crossing from Shalott to Camelot which is made textually explicit with the Lady's death at lines 150-153. This pattern extends to include a further detail. Though, at line 115, the Lady's mirror is dramatically "cracked from side to side," it would appear, at line 130, to have been uncannily restored, in the figuration of her face—newly directed toward Camelot—as a "*glassy* countenance" (emphasis added). The effect of this detail—like that of those noted above—is implicitly to invert the Lady's *voyage d'amour*, slyly fold it back upon itself. Not only blocking the transition from Shalott to Camelot with death but also signaling its resistance to the subversion of patriarchal values which that action connotes through a range of subliminal gestures, "The Lady of Shalott" thus fairly lucidly confirms Arthur Hallam's definition of the contemporary poetic impulse as "a check acting for conservation against a propulsion toward change".

But the paradox which appears to render the strategies of resistance in the poem superfluous is that while the movement from Shallot to Camelot, "feminine" to "masculine" spaces, is symbolically transgressive, the desire which initially prompts it would seem, at the end of the second section of the poem, to be entirely compatible with patriarchal norms:

> But in her web she still delights
> To weave the mirror's magic sights,
> For often through the silent nights
> A funeral, with plumes and lights
> And music, went to Camelot:
> Or when the moon was overhead,
> Came two young lovers lately wed;
> 'I am half sick of shadows,' said
> The Lady of Shalott.

The "natural" reading of the last four lines of this stanza (alleged by Hallam Tennyson to contain "the key to this tale of 'magic symbolism'" is one which turns the Lady's cry, "'I am half sick of shadows,'" in the direction of an unequivocally confessional desire to substitute participation in the lived reality of marital love for the contemplation of its image. Even as the Lady's movement from Shalott to Camelot figures the deregulation of patriarchal gender codes and is variously resisted by the text, the desire which propels it—being for marriage—seems to work to reestablish the text in a relation of continuity with the patriarchal status quo.

Yet to define the Lady's discontent with the conditions of her existence as stemming from the self-conscious recognition of marriage as the telos of her desire is to mask the inscription of a subversive counter-meaning beneath the conformities of the textual surface of the poem, converting it into an instance of the Barthesian text of *plaisir* "that comes from culture and does not break with it, [and] is linked to a *comfortable* practice of reading." As frequently noted, it is possible to translate the predicament described in "The Lady of Shalott" into the terms of a neo-Platonic allegory. Just as in the tenth book of Plato's Republic, the work of art duplicates a reality itself only the copy of a higher realm of "essences," so the labor of the female artist in Tennyson's text is the weaving of the "magic web" out of the images which appear in her mirror as "shadows of the world", the reality of Camelot. But this is by no means to exhaust the allegorical potential of Tennyson's poem. As the site of the production of images—one of which is that of the newlyweds—which effectively are reality for the one whom they entrap, the Lady's "mirror clear" is not only analogous to the Platonic realm of "appearances" (figured, in Republic Book 7, as the wall of a cave on which the shadows of the absolute manifest themselves) but also to the mediation of experience by the processes of ideological re-presentation. In the contest of the construction of gender, these processes operate, as Pollock puts it,

> by means of winning our identification with the versions of masculinity and femininity which are represented to us … binding us into a particular—but always unstable—regime of sexual difference.

"All else confusion." To view the Lady's mirror from this perspective, seeing its "magic sights" as the mesmeric products of ideology, is equally to lead her cry in a different—indeed antithetical—direction to that which the "natural" reading comfortably assigns to it. Far from signaling a desire for marriage, the declaration "'I am half sick of shadows'" comes to seem symptomatic of a suggestive—and subversive—demystification of the institution of marriage as adequately expressive of female desire, sexual or otherwise. In the same way that the Lady's mirror hosts a panoply of images which significantly does not include her own, so Tennyson's poem covertly suggests its heroine's failure to identify herself with the patriarchal ideology which precisely posits marriage as integral to the completion of the destinies of women within Victorian society. Appropriately, the non-accommodation of the female subject to the narrative of an orthodox "femininity" occurs "when the moon [is] overhead," a moment symbolically associated, through the moon's own culturally defined link with menstruation, with one of the aspects of womanhood which Victorian definitions of "femininity" tend to repress.

Signifying as much the rejection of as the desire for marriage-as-telos, the Lady's utterance discloses a "key" which aporetically turns—like the poem as a whole—in two directions at the same time, both toward and away from patriarchy. If, as Tennyson instructs Boyd Carpenter, "the thought within the image is much more than any one interpretation", the effect of the subtextual excess at this point is subversively to expose a certain disjunction between the female subject and the construction or interpellation of that subject as "feminine" by patriarchal ideology. In so doing it also discloses the rationale which governs those apparently supererogatory strategies of resistance to the transition from Shalott to Camelot discussed above.

II

Gestures toward the subversion of the gender positions which patriarchal ideology seeks to promote, in Pollock's phrase, as "natural and unalterable" are additionally inscribed throughout the text in a number of ways, the first of which occurs at the end of the opening section of the poem:

> But who hath seen her wave her hand?
> Or at the casement seen her stand?
> Or is she known in all the land,
> The Lady of Shalott?
>
> Only reapers, reaping early
> In among the bearded barley,
> Hear a song that echoes cheerly
> From the river winding clearly,
> Down to towered Camelot:
> And by the moon the reaper weary,
> Piling sheaves in uplands airy,
> Listening, whispers 'Tis the fairy
> Lady of Shalott.'

As Herbert F. Tucker points out (following Lionel Stevenson), Tennyson's image of the Lady as an invisible singer defines her as a figure for the Romantic poet derived from Shelley's "To a Skylark" and particularly from the Shelleyan comparison of the "blithe Spirit" his poem eulogizes to a "high-born maiden / In a palace-tower." But, as Tucker also notes, the lines cited above simultaneously incorporate an allusion to Wordsworth and "The Solitary Reaper." Thus alluding to Shelley and Wordsworth, Tennyson's poem is itself as much "a song that echoes" as that produced by the disembodied voice within it. But the Tennysonian echo

of Wordsworth is an echo with what turns out to be a sexual difference, closer in fact to a kind of intertextual mirroring or simultaneous play of reflection and inversion. In Wordsworth's poem it is the male poet who listens—effectively transfixed—to the song of a female reaper, but in "The Lady of Shalott" we encounter a male reaper who hearkens, equally spellbound, to the song of a female poet, "'the fairy/Lady of Shalott.'" Tennyson's poem reproduces the Wordsworthian poet/reaper configuration but inverts it at the level of gender, placing the poet on the female side of the opposition and the reaper on the male side. The transgression of gender boundaries which "The Lady of Shalott" both symbolizes and blocks is discretely carried out by means of allusion as the poem unsettles the ideological fixities it vies equally to sustain.

Subversiveness of allusion is complemented in the penultimate stanza of the third section of the poem by a subversiveness of refrain. Prior to this point, and for the most part beyond it, the refrains of the poem are consistently organized in terms of strict gender distinctions. In each stanza the first refrain, located at its center, is reserved for references either to Camelot or Lancelot, while the second, located at the end or "margin" of the stanza, is given over to Shalott and the Lady. While the distribution of refrains in the poem could itself be said to be patriarchal (identifying the "masculine" as central and marginalizing the "feminine"), the customary pattern is significantly and symbolically usurped at this juncture, since it is a reference to Lancelot that appears in the space traditionally allocated to the "feminine":

> From the bank and from the river
> He flashed into the crystal mirror,
> 'Tirra lirra,' by the river
> Sang Sir Lancelot.

Though Lancelot lacks the "sword" essential to the conception of manhood outlined by the old king in The Princess, he is nonetheless constantly defined through images of phallic power. Distanced from the Lady's "bower-eaves" by a "bow-shot," he rides a "war-horse" that suggestively parts the "barley-sheaves", he possesses a "blazoned baldric" and "mighty silver bugle", his "helmet and...helmet-feather" burn "like one burning flame together", and he is likened to a "bearded meteor, trailing light." Yet despite the emphatically phallic terms in which the person of Lancelot is represented, he is here transferred to a space the refrain-structure of the poem defines as "feminine." As with the allusion to Wordsworth, "The Lady of Shalott" obliquely accomplishes, in terms of refrain, that re-inscription of gender boundaries which it both threatens and thwarts at the level of its symbolic narrative. Moreover, the resituating of Lancelot—his crossing from one side of the gender line operative at the level of the refrain to the other—is preceded by the utterance "'Tirra lirra.'" While the context from which it is taken (Autolycus' song in The Winter's Tale 4.3) endows it with the connotations of a promiscuous male sexuality, the shape of the utterance—being that of a "feminine" rhyme—has the precisely subversive counter-effect of unmanning the singer. As with Lancelot, so with the Lady who parallels and indeed surpasses his movement into the space the structure of the poem reserves for the "feminine" with her own threefold penetration ("She looked down to Camelot," "Did she look to Camelot," "She floated down to Camelot," into that which it ordinarily sets aside for all things "masculine."

The strategies by which the text might thus be said to "loose the chain" that binds men and women to the fixity of patriarchally conceived gender divisions ("a particular—but always unstable—regime of sexual difference") take an alternative form at lines: if Lancelot is "feminized" by refrain (and rhyme) the Lady is here analogously "masculinized" by the simile which likens her to "some bold seër in a trance / Seeing all *his own* mischance" (emphasis added), an effect underscored by the transposition of an epithet previously applied to Lancelot ("bold") to the visionary to whom she is compared.

In his essay-review of Tennyson's first published volume of poetry, Hallam praises the poet as one who (unlike Keats and Shelley) "comes before the public, unconnected with any political party, or peculiar system of opinions." But if the notion of "coming before the public" creates a curiously prophetic identification between the poet of *Poems, Chiefly Lyrical* (1830) and the eponymous heroine of "The Lady of Shalott"

(originally published in 1832), the Lady in turn suggests herself to be a figure for the politics—particularly the sexual politics—of the poem in which she is located. Just as the Lady makes an enigmatic debut before her public, "A gleaming shape she floated by, / Dead-pale between the houses high, / Silent into Camelot", so Tennyson's poem finds itself negotiating opposed political impulses—reaction and subversion, the weaving and the unthreading of the "web" of patriarchal ideology.

III

One of the most significant ways in which "The Lady of Shalott" manifests its politically self-divided stance toward the values of patriarchal ideology—colluding with and critiquing them at once—is by means of what might be called a discourse of the gaze. For patriarchy the difference between "masculine" and "feminine" sexuality is articulated in terms of a difference between activity and passivity. These differences are in turn rehearsed at the scopic level where the gaze—the act of looking—is identified with a "masculine" (rather than "necessarily male") subject-position while women come, as the silent and passive objects of the gaze (and the "masculine" desire of which it is the sign), to occupy the site of the "feminine" and are as such denied the possibility of experiencing themselves as actively desiring subjects.

Tennyson's poem begins its reflections on the gaze and the question of sexual power-relations to which it gives rise in the opening stanza:

> And up and down the people go,
> Gazing where the lilies blow
> Round an island there below,
> The island of Shalott.

Though the "Gazing" described here appears not to be gender-specific (it is collectively the practice of "people"), the poem nonetheless already suggests that the relation between gaze and object within its mythic realm is ordered in terms of a conventionally patriarchal logic, since the object of the popular gaze is "where the lilies blow … / The island of Shalott," locus of the central—if obscure—female figure of the poem. The complementary identification of the gaze with a "masculine" subject-position which this implies is made explicit in the next stanza:

> Four gray walls, and four gray towers,
> Overlook a space of flowers,
> And the silent isle imbowers
> The Lady of Shalott.

Displaced onto "Four gray walls, and four gray towers" that "Overlook a space of flowers," the gaze begins to emerge as a form of phallic surveillance of the female subject (or object) for which the "space of flowers" functions as a metonymy.

While the text thus appears to validate patriarchal structures by mapping the gaze/object relation in terms of an opposition between "masculine" and "feminine," it also subversively exposes the ideologically constructed nature of the "feminine," thereby circumscribing the claims for mastery—both erotic and epistemological—which men make over women. While the action of Tennyson's phallically gazing towers is to "Overlook" the field of their vision in the sense of surveying it from a higher position, they seem equally not to be all-seeing, to "Overlook" being not only to survey but also to fail to apprehend or recognize. The doubleness of the language of the poem shows the "masculine" gaze to be in a significant sense a blind or "castrated" one. The implication is that the way in which men like to see women—viewing and representing them, for example, as "feminine" objects of desire—is indistinguishable from a process of not seeing them, imprisoning the female within a set of culturally constructed images from which, paradoxically, it will always already have escaped: "woman," as Julia Kristeva argues, constitutes "something that cannot be represented,

something that is not said, something above and beyond nomenclatures and ideologies."

The question of the (non)representation of women is quite literally posed by the lines already cited from the third stanza of the poem:

> But who hath seen her wave her hand?
> Or at the casement seen her stand?
> Or is she known in all the land,
> The Lady of Shalott?

In the context of the blindness of the "masculine" gaze toward the female subject—which it typically chooses to see as a "feminine" object—the Lady's literal and particular failure to appear "at the casement" constitutes the ironic symbol of the generalized respect in which "woman," in the Kristevan sense, can only appear, as opposed to being ever plainly manifest or knowable, either within the space of representation for which the casement is a figure or on the horizon of the patriarchal gaze that frames her.

But if she is an unseen presence (as "woman" for Kristeva is always effaced) Tennyson's Lady is crucially unseeing also, interdicted from assuming the gaze, the "masculine" position of erotically desiring subject, by the threat of a "curse" which, like her mirror indeed, "hangs before her all the year":

> There she weaves by night and day
> A magic web with colours gay.
> She has heard a whisper say,
> A curse is on her if she stay
> To look down to Camelot.
> She knows not what the curse may be,
> And so she weaveth steadily,
> And little other care hath she,
> The Lady of Shalott.

Though the Lady herself is ignorant of the nature of the curse, its meaning and raison d'être are readily enough decipherable from the perspective of the analysis in the poem of the workings of patriarchal ideology. For the Lady to appropriate the gaze would be for her to effect the crossing of the patriarchal gender line from "feminine" to "masculine" and so to precipitate, through an act of female self-empowerment, the "confusion" to which the lines cited from The Princess refer and which her own poem both adumbrates and symbolically moves to oppose in causing the attempted transition from Shalott to Camelot to issue only in death, product of the curse.

Under these conditions, indirectly imposed by the anonymous "whisper," the Lady must herself mediate her gaze via the mirror:

> And moving through a mirror clear
> That hangs before her all the year,
> Shadows of the world appear.
> There she sees the highway near
> Winding down to Camelot.

The mirror is not only the site of "shadows" but also of light, that which bestows definition and shape upon objects and, as Isobel Armstrong puts it, "enables perception to occur." It is precisely the quality of light, as much as phallic power, with which Lancelot is associated throughout the third section of the poem—from the moment that the sun flames upon his "brazen greaves" to the brilliant crisis of his double reflection: "From the

bank and from the river, / He flashed into the crystal mirror." Thus constituted as a phallic figure of light, Lancelot personifies the very processes of patriarchal ideology, whose labor frames and fashions women (and men).

Though these processes in part entail the positioning of women as silently "other," passive objects to the "masculine" gaze, the poem, at lines 109-117, violently inverts these conditions:

> She left the web, she left the loom,
> She made three paces through the room,
> She *saw* the water-lily bloom,
> She *saw* the helmet and the plume,
> She *looked down* to Camelot.
> Out flew the web and floated wide;
> The mirror cracked from side to side;
> 'The curse is come upon me,' cried
> The Lady of Shalott. (emphases added)

Appropriating the gaze, the Lady enters the position of the desiring subject and so enacts—at the scopic level—the crossing from "feminine" to "masculine" gender positions originally figured in the projected foray from Shalott to Camelot. In this respect her action not only results in cracking the mirror literally, but also embodies an overturning of that for which the mirror is the figure—the ideological status quo. But if the literal mirror is subsequently found to be magically mended in the fantasmatic shape of the Lady's "glassy countenance," to what extent does the text duplicate this process in terms of the mirror-as-figure? How comprehensive, in other words, are its attempts to salvage the patriarchal gender images beyond which the iconoclasm of the Lady's gaze momentarily advances her?

Insofar as it equips her with a "glassy countenance" at all, it would seem that the intent of the text, at the beginning of its fourth and final part, is to restore the ideological mirror, since to "look to Camelot" with eyes of glass is not to see at all and for the Lady to become the precise opposite of what she had previously fleetingly been—not subject but object. Yet if she is thus objectified (and the continuity of the text with patriarchal values therefore reasserted) the Lady nonetheless retains a glimmer of transformative potential, being, at least until "her eyes [are] darkened wholly," an object of a particular kind—a looking-glass in fact, a mirror. As such, the Lady constitutes a reflective surface by dint of which the one who gazes into it (Lancelot) may behold himself in the act of seeing. In this respect she might be said to possess the capacity for inducing in the "masculine" gaze a certain self-consciousness as to its own strategies, a recognition of its own blindness with regard to the female subject and female sexuality and of the truth that the way in which men traditionally view women is critically discrepant from how women see themselves.

To the degree that it contains the elements of a critique of patriarchal ideology, "The Lady of Shalott" seeks, equally, to bring about—for the (male) Victorian reader for whom Lancelot is surrogate—just such an altered vision of the relations between men and women. Within the myth within the text, however, the revolutionary moment is badly missed:

> But Lancelot mused a little space;
> He said, 'She has a lovely face;
> God in his mercy lend her grace,
> The Lady of Shalott.'

Though Lancelot reflects "a little space," perhaps briefly speculating upon the possibility of seeing women other than patriarchally, he evidently does not reflect long enough, going on to re-articulate, with "'She has a lovely face,'" the orthodox perception of women as the object of the "masculine" gaze.

From this vantage it appears that the lazy blessing Lancelot confers upon the Lady at the conclusion of the poem is no better than a disguised version of the curse drawn into operation at the end of the third part of the poem, since the latter is elaborated precisely in terms of her transportation back across the gender line, from "masculine" to "feminine" positions, subject to object of the gaze, "Who" to "what":

> And at the closing of the day
> She loosed the chain and down she lay;
> The broad stream bore her far away,
> The Lady of Shalott.
> Lying, robed in snowy white
> That loosely flew to left and right—
> The leaves upon her falling light—
> Through the noises of the night
> She floated down to Camelot.

No longer the bold "see-er" she once had been, the Lady's course is emphatically re-assimilated to the criteria of the "femininity" she had previously violated—even "her blood," at line 147, is "frozen slowly," in a detail which suggests, amid this poem of moons and curses, a repression of menstruation as "unfeminine." "Lying, robed in snowy white," she becomes the very bride—submissive and virginal, desired not desiring—whose image had traversed her mirror to such equivocal effect at the end of the second section of the poem.

But if this passage seems to avenge female self-empowerment it goes on to counter its own actions. Recollecting lines 64-72, in which the socially symbolic rituals of marriage and death are arbitrarily juxtaposed, the text now transforms the one into the other: groom Lancelot, whose "bridle bells" not only ring, but also merrily pun at line 85 ("bridle"/"bridal") becomes a reaper, the lady her own elegist:

> And as the boat-head wound along
> The willowy hills and fields among,
> They heard her singing her last song,
> The Lady of Shalott.
> Heard a carol, mournful, holy,
> Chanted loudly, chanted lowly,
> Till her blood was frozen slowly,
> And her eyes were darkened wholly,
> Turned to towered Camelot.

In the context of the crossing from Shalott to Camelot, the supervention of death betokens, as we have seen, the reactionary orientation of the text, its resistance to the very questioning of the forms of patriarchal ideology which it seeks, conversely, to provoke at other levels. Yet the fact that the trajectory of death is at this point conflated with that of marriage has the effect of redefining—indeed reversing—the value of death-as-sign within the economy of the sexual politics of the poem. As a figure for marriage, death comes, that is, to re-open the ideologically dissentient potential of the poem by suggesting that marriage, far from entailing the fulfillment of each sex through the other (as in The Princess) is tantamount, for women, to a form of self-annihilation.

As a response to the questions which it raises, "The Lady of Shalott" proves itself, in the language of In Memoriam, to be "A contradiction on the tongue" from first to last, simultaneously affirming and displacing those patriarchal visions of women and the relations between the sexes which held sway throughout the Victorian period and which are still today predominant. Thus exhibiting a sexual politics which is continually at odds with itself—being neither reactionary nor radical but both at once—Tennyson's poem emerges as no less centrally fractured, or "cracked from side to side," than the mirror within it, precisely unsure in fact as to quite

which side of its own covert political and socio-sexual debate it is on—that of patriarchy and reaction or women and subversion.

Source: Carl Plasa, "'Cracked from Side to Side': Sexual Politics in 'The Lady of Shalott,'" in *Victorian Poetry*, Vol. 30, Nos. 3-4, Autumn-Winter 1992, pp. 247-61.

The Quest for the "Nameless" in Tennyson's "The Lady of Shalott"

> A gleaming shape she floated by,
> Dead-pale between the houses high,
> Silent into Camelot.
> Out upon the wharfs they came,
> Knight and burgher, lord and dame,
> And round the prow they read her name,
> *The Lady of Shalott*.

The questions "Who is this and what is here?" that the fearful, dull-witted knights, burghers, lords, and ladies are left pondering are those questions which gaze back at the readers of "The Lady of Shalott" long after its fluent lines have drifted away from the closing of the poem. They place the almost unsuspecting audience among the citizens of Camelot, looking at the inscribed name and wondering what to do with it: Who is the Lady of Shalott, and what is the meaning of her presence in Camelot? These questions and the accompanying unease of possibly being identified among the citizens tempt the reader to separate himself from the curious and unknowing crowd, leave the wharf, and step into the Lady of Shalott's boat—as if to take her part. In this shift, he moves to an understanding, a reading, the impulses of which are similar to those that press the Lady through the poem from the tower, to the river, to Camelot. These impulses reflect the movement from the doubly enclosed, piecemeal images visible from the tower to the more continuous and definite vision of the last section of the poem. There is a desire within the reader to move from a fragmented and metonymic space to a metaphoric landscape in which the Lady becomes continuous with her surroundings. But the metaphoric vision eventually destroys itself and dies with the Lady. In the end, this destruction places the reader closer to Tennyson's dilemma, his difficulty in leaving the world and passing into a "Nameless," shadow-less realm.

To understand the reader's desire to insert himself into a metaphoric relationship with the poem and to comprehend his ultimate undoing, we need to consider the Lady of Shalott's unfolding, for in many ways the two movements are analogous. In the beginning of "The Lady of Shalott," images come and disappear as pieces and shadows of the world proceed through the Lady's mirror. Between these abbreviated images are spaces which syncopate the continuous weaving motion—the winding of the river and the road, the coming and going of the people—that tries to hold the lines of the poem together. These intervals frustrate the almost mechanical advance of the procession, and throughout the early parts of the poem, come to be more visible and compelling than the images, especially when Tennyson marks them in time and in synecdochic forms. For instance, it is only "Sometimes" or at particular times of the day ("when the moon was overhead" that the market girls, the village churls, a shepherd boy, a long-haired page, a knight or two, a funeral, and "two young lovers lately wed" enter and exit from the domain of the mirror. And, when they do, it is the pieces of these images which have separated themselves out that impress the eye and engage the gaze of the Lady. In her passive way, she sees only parts: the red cloaks of the market girls, the curly hair of the shepherd lad, the long hair of the page, and the plumes and lights of the funeral procession. These glide singly and separately through her mirror like the individual pulses of the shuttle sliding through the warp.

Surrounding the tower, pieces neither reaching nor touching one another accent the spaces between images. The tower overlooks "a space of flowers." The reader, though, does not have to wait until the second stanza to

experience these spaces, for immediately in the opening lines, Tennyson plunges him into a gap which divides the fields and allows him to see that "On either side the river lie / Long fields of barley and of rye," and involves him in the Lady's initial view of a world dominated by separateness and without promise of continuity and wholeness. There is little sense of a mutual dependency, a dialectic of opposites, between the whole and the part. One does not take life from the other. Rather the pieces dislocate the continuity and create a landscape in which there are openings and discontinuities. The fields which are "Long" and "meet the sky" would extend without a break if the river and the road travelling through and dividing them did not interfere. The water itself would flow "for ever" if "Little breezes" did not cut into the waves and create patches of movement. These synecdochic images must necessarily admit beginnings and endings, so a "margin, willow-veiled" borders and cuts off the river from all that surrounds it; water must separate the Lady, the tower, and the island from the fields. In this land of pieces a shallop skims by and disappears, and the Lady's voice, isolated from her, leaves the tower and comes surrounded by space and silence to the reapers below. The sounds render her presence by echoing her just as the mirror reflects.

In the early verses the vision is metonymic as well as synecdochic, for these single images are always succeeding one another. They do not flow into one another; rather they live for a moment until they are replaced by others—as soon as the shepherd-lad exits, the damsels arrive to occupy the space he had temporarily filled. The verses proceed as a procession. Without succession the cloth of the poem cannot hold. It is as if there were an attempt to weave a poem, though with broken lines and threads. If the Lady of Shalott does not constantly replace one image or thread with another, the tapestry and the poem must fly apart, as the tapestry does.

This synecdochic and metonymic vision is no different when Sir Lancelot enters in Part III. If anything his coming intensifies all that has passed before, for like his double reflection, his presence exaggerates this disjunction of a world dominated by parts and motivated by replacement. Even more distant from the land than the Lady in the tower, Lancelot and the rays of images shining from him seem to dangle and dazzle in open space ("The gemmy bridle glittered free"; "A mighty silver bugle" hangs from his "blazoned baldric"), and like an arrow released from the bow, Lancelot himself flashes by, cut off from all about him ("Some bearded meteor" moving "over still Shalott"). Tennyson's description of Lancelot, however, concentrates not only upon the successive and separated parts of his armor but also upon his movements with which, like the road and the river, he cuts through the fields ("He rode between the barley-sheaves") and divides the landscape. The effect of his action, though, is quite different from that of the road or the river, for Lancelot's brightness when coupled with the sun's brilliance ("The sun came dazzling through the leaves") seems paradoxically both to expand and fill the gaps of his passage. His glistening presence wounds the fields, yet simultaneously fills and heals the scar. One rapid, brilliant piece blends with another and for an instant the collective aura overwhelms all boundaries and divisions: "The helmet and the helmet-feather / Burned like one burning flame together." When Tennyson compares the knight's brilliance to a meteor that is "trailing light," these blended pieces even seem to melt away the frame of the mirror. Now continuity and wholeness seem as possible as the promise of eternal faithfulness depicted on Lancelot's shield (the knight "for ever" kneeling "To a lady." That momentary presence pushes the Lady from her loom, her mirror, from her synecdochic and metonymic space, and urges her and the poem forward.

Once the Lady's perspective shifts, so does the landscape. In the first three parts, images move horizontally across her static, vertical world; now, because she turns away and comes down, she moves horizontally through static, vertical structures. With that change come other inversions: instead of passively watching images move through her mirror, she becomes the image which passes through. Over becomes under as she glides into towered Camelot "Under tower and balcony." Echoes swell to full sounds; the fairy name takes on form and becomes the inscribed name; once empty skies and placid river swell with the rain. Action, fullness, and inscription replace passivity, emptiness, echoes, whispers, and rumour. The Lady emerges as a Lancelot: she gleams, she reflects, she is the one who is paradoxically to cut through and to remind the onlookers of the absence of wholeness, but she does it in a different manner. Of course, the analogy cannot be exact, for

Lancelot's initial dazzling, doubly-reflected presence brings at best a promise and at worst an illusion of the Lady's metaphoric vision. At the end he is not in the Lady's vessel but somewhere apart by "a little space" from both her and the citizens. His isolation, his continuing the creation of spaces between images, suggests that there is something hypocritical, even Satanic, about him. This hint of evil is not, as some would have it, because he is indifferent to the Lady but because he has knowledge of her and her metaphoric vision which he chooses to avoid. It is as if in remaining apart on the wharf, he stood beside Tennyson who could never quite let himself completely enter the Lady's vessel even though the impulse toward the mystical and non-representational was strong within him.

The Lady is different from Lancelot because when she leaves the tower, inscribes her name on the prow of the boat, and floats down the river to Camelot, she turns her back on the vision of her past and inserts herself into a metaphoric relationship with her surroundings and her self. With this shift, she moves into the spaces between the fields and the people and fills them with her form: her name and her body. No longer is there a silence between her name and her body, a pause between her singing and the audible echoes. The true weaving and mingling of threads of experience take place, so that vertical and horizontal structures merge. The static tower blends with the moving, horizontal boat. When the Lady is in the boat that moves through the gaps between the fields, she closes the spaces, as her voice and her body spill over into the landscape, and, in turn, that landscape bends to meet her. Her white robe "loosely" flies "to left and right" and the leaves from the willows lining the bank fall lightly upon that robe. The sky reaches the earth; the inside, the outside; and together they eradicate the "as if" of the previous separateness. This separateness, dependent upon gaps, makes everything into an "as if"; but in Part IV there is rarely a gap between the image and its context. Tennyson relies little on simile. In fact, in revising the 1832 version of the poem he chooses to rid the lines of similes. The Lady herself becomes a metaphor. She is not "like" a brilliant meteor but is "A gleaming shape." With her "glassy countenance" she becomes both mirror, seer, and object.

As in the metaphoric landscape described above there is a yoking, a *glissement*, rather than an interrupting. Now it is the Lady who catches the others' gaze. It is she, not Lancelot, whom the people view and through whom they recognize the limitations of their own vision. When the citizens of Camelot regard her, understandably they are fearful because they fear to see a reflection of their own lack and emptiness. Although her name appears upon her boat, and her body is as an image, her coming tells of a world which does not have to depend upon image and name. As their questions reveal, the citizens are dependent upon such tangible tokens and are trapped, as the Lady once was, in a landscape of successive, unconnected images framed by "who" and "what." Theirs is not a place to admit transcendence or a unifying vision. The Lady's, however, is: Edgar F. Shannon, Jr., is correct—the Lady has moved to "insight." But that insight does not have to be regarded in a Christian mystical context, for her movement is not necessarily to a vision which exists beyond the image. Rather it is a journey to a pre-imagistic understanding which negates image and recaptures a condition that does not require representation. In her recovery of a pre-imagistic state, she participates in the metaphoric impulse, for, even though metaphor begins in the concrete and seems initially to depend upon the conjunction of representations, the tension between that yoking scatters the objects and discards them, and seems finally to strain to retrieve a knowledge which is not at all linked to representation. The metaphor seems to wish to forget image. It is, therefore, understandable that in the poem, all that remains for the citizens is that scattering—her dead body and her inscribed name.

When the Lady inserts herself into the spaces of the landscape and thereby acknowledges the possibility for continuity and similarity in experience, she also places herself within a context which recognizes differences and otherness. As metaphor teaches, similarity is impossible without difference. The Lady's act of writing her name is an important aspect of her involvement with metaphor. It is as if the name were an abbreviated metaphor. The written name brings with it hopes of continuity because it is a fixed designator; it also admits differences because the very act of naming acknowledges the presence of the Other and the necessity for that presence to break away from a metonymic relationship with her parent, the land of Shalott (she is, after all, the Lady of Shalott), and create her own identity.

In the early parts of the poem, the Lady's name seems indefinite, some arbitrary identifier imposed on her by the reapers. She is neither conscious of her name nor desirous to use it. She has "little care." It is only when she leaves the tower that she cares. Then by taking on the name (baptising herself if you like) and inscribing it on the very vessel of her mediation into her surroundings, she goes to Camelot. (It is interesting to note that when Tennyson revised the 1832 version of the poem, he moved the name forward from the stern of the boat to the prow.) This inscribed name, the mediator, becomes a mirror through which she can see and present herself as being distinct from others and allow them to discover how they in their imagistic-dependent world are different from her. It also becomes a means by which she, as Tennyson did on occasion when he would repeat his name to reach a higher plane, can separate herself from a world ironically enslaved to naming objects.

However, because she does write her name, death and wounding are also inevitable. On the one hand she escapes the limits of metonymy, but on the other hand she faces the experience of loss, for naming is also a form of mourning, like the mournful carol she sings at the end. To name is to experience closure. It is as Claude Lévi-Strauss writes, "as far as one can go." Naming involves death also because it aspires to the ultimate, to fix the margin. However, in attempting to fix the margin the name grows more conscious of the absence of the ultimate, that is of the difference between the fixed reference and the idea. As Walter Benjamin suggests, names are the incomplete and inadequate mirrors of meaning. They are the fact of knowledge; not knowledge itself. Names name the death of oneness and are dependent upon representation.

Because there is a sense of loss accompanying naming, when the Lady of Shalott asserts her name into the consciousness of Camelot, she wounds and ruptures the synecdochic order of the dull-witted society and exposes its emptiness. When the citizens gaze at her name, they feel an absence to which their only responses are questions tying them more tightly to their dependency upon representation and pulling them further away from the presence of the Lady's metaphoric vision, a vision which could heal the wounding of their consciousness by her name. Theirs is not a place from which they can travel beyond the rupturing of consciousness into the salvation of metaphor.

The citizens on shore cannot participate in the Lady's metaphoric world; consequently, they also cannot go where metaphor leads and follow her into the final stage of her journey—her death and the death of metaphor. Just as she reaches "The first house by the water-side," her blood freezes, her eyes darken "wholly," and her singing ends. With her death and the coming of darkness and silence, she moves into a realm where the elements—light, time, space, and place—which form and bind words, sounds, and images are neither present nor absent. Perhaps beyond the audible reverberations of the poem, her death takes her where metaphor reaches and reclaims what metaphor paradoxically aspires to grasp, but cannot: a state not linked to representation—hence, a state previous to itself, an accomplishment which ironically causes the death of metaphor by foreclosing its characteristic impulse which is a desire to undo itself as well as others' desire for it.

In the end, then, the Lady is relieved of the burden of the metaphoric impulse to reach for what it cannot grasp, a burden which stares back at those left on shore. While the citizens stand gaping, struggling with their limitations and their dependency upon image and name, she enters a nameless, imageless realm which exists prior to the assumption of metaphor, name or the "symbolic." But now that there is a glimmer, a suggestion, of that realm, her presence for others is more than the challenge of her metaphoric vision; it is also a reminder of the pre-symbolic, raw state which because of its very nature resists and irritates metaphor and increases its burden. Her death, therefore, offers a strange reversal, for it reveals vividly the limitations of the representational world, even those of that world's most integrative act—the metaphor—an act which when well done undoes itself. Her death frustrates whatever impulses there might have been for others to leave the metonymic space behind, recover and participate in the metaphoric, and, thereby, heal their wounded consciousness.

The Lady's journey to a metaphoric landscape and her release from that burden is important in itself, but it also needs to be reconsidered briefly in terms of the reader's movement through the poem. When the reader first encounters the poem he is separated from it, imprisoned in his own tower into which flash words, phrases, sounds, rhythms, and rhymes. These succeed each other as he moves from line to line—forgetting, losing, and replacing. He waits for some word, some rhythm, some figure of sound to catch and hold him and remind him, like the picture of eternal reverence on Lancelot's shield, that there is something which unites the spaces between images and words. Eventually the reader inserts himself into these spaces and, like the Lady of Shalott, becomes more aware of both the differences and similarities working with and against each other. Once he has entered the metaphoric relationship with the poem, the reader's impulse is to sustain that relationship and find salvation in its integrating act. But this impulse involves bearing the burden and treachery of metaphor.

If in becoming the agent for metaphor, the reader attempts not only to integrate one image, space, and word with others and create some sense of wholeness, but also to follow the desire of the metaphor to reach a pre-imagistic or pre-symbolic state, the reader courts his own undoing and discomfort, and faces his own duplicity. The reader tempts disaster, for at the moment of integration when there appears to be an understanding of the text, a feeling of reaching the "truth," the metaphor pushes on. Momentarily it goes where its impulses take it and bursts open to expose a prior, raw, non-representational "truth." That revelation (the death of the metaphor) destroys the promise of salvation which the reader thought he had found in metaphor. Now he is caught between image and non-image, between the symbolic and the raw, in a space between areas for which there is no integrating act. No longer can he rest; he has been trapped by the very act which supported him. In the end, he stands between the citizens and the Lady, belonging to neither world. Frustrated, the reader joins Lancelot and, perhaps, Tennyson on the wharf. Together poet and reader momentarily resemble and anticipate the doubters in "The Ancient Sage" (1885) who, in metonymic time measured by "Thens'" and "Whens," "creep from thought to thought." They stand powerless to follow the metaphoric impulse and pass into the "Nameless" and leave images, names, and words, the "shadows of a shadow-world," behind. They cannot die with the Lady. Neither can they be the ancient sage who, when he sits alone, "revolving in" himself, finds:

> The mortal limit of the Self was loosed,
> And past into the Nameless, as a cloud
> Melts into Heaven.

"The Lady of Shalott" is a poem that acknowledges the poet's and the reader's dilemma. It is as if Tennyson were attempting to use the poem as a vessel to rescue himself and his reader from an enclosed and image-bound landscape and move into a recognition of the non-representational. But, as much as he repeats the Lady's name, allows the sounds of the refrain to resound, and, in the manner of the ancient sage, lets the poem revolve in itself, he cannot push the poem into a "Nameless" state. The poem, like the Lady's boat, remains to stare back and remind Tennyson and the reader of their bondage to "mortal limits"— rhyme and words. Like the swallow on the lake "That sees and stirs the surface-shadow there," the most that the poem, Tennyson, and the reader can do is dip "into the abysm" beneath the rhyming shadow world.

It is difficult to refrain from reconsidering Tennyson's conclusion from the point of view of a later poet who entered the same lists, but attempted to achieve another outcome. In "Sunday Morning" Wallace Stevens acknowledges our dependency on detail (the "old dependency of day and night"), yet suggests that it is those very fleeting particulars which consummate our "dreams" and "desires." As for death, it is in fact death itself that engenders meaning ("Death is the mother of beauty,"). If Stevens is right, the poet and reader do not in the end have to fear "the immense disorder of truths" ("Connoisseur of Chaos"), but can stand beside that "pensive man" who is the "connoisseur of Chaos," and see "that eagle float / For which the intricate Alps are a single nest."

Source: Ann C. Colley, "The Quest for the 'Nameless' in Tennyson's 'The Lady of Shalott,'" in *Victorian Poetry*, Vol. 23, No. 3, Autumn 1985, pp. 369-78.

The Lady of Shalott: Compare and Contrast

- **1842**: An important source of entertainment is books and magazines. More middle-class people are familiar with the mythic stories as they have been preserved in literature for generations.

  Today: There is still some familiarity with King Arthur's Court, but most people know it as it is depicted in movies or in theme park recreations.
- **1842**: The English countryside is more open and unpolluted. Cities, particularly London, are crowded and polluted, but people who have been to the country can easily imagine the landscape that Tennyson describes.

  Today: For the most part, the English countryside is divided into walled-off fields and farm tracks. Since coal burning is illegal in cities, urban air pollution is reduced.
- **1842**: Alfred Tennyson was a young, struggling poet who had to quit writing for a time because he could not pay his bills.

  Today: Alfred, Lord Tennyson, is considered an important writer and his works are studied in English literature courses.
- **1842**: Scientists do not understand microbiological causes for death, which makes it more mysterious; thus, poets explore rich metaphorical possibilities for explaining what causes sudden death.

  Today: Microbiology explains many symptoms to be caused by viruses and fungi, and science measures correlations between physical health and longevity and psychological and emotional well-being.

The Lady of Shalott: Topics for Further Study

- Read about the presidential administration of John F. Kennedy. Why was it called "Camelot"? Find particular figures from the Arthurian myths that correspond to figures in U.S. politics. In particular, who would you say is most like the Lady of Shalott?
- The Lady of Shalott could only look at the world through a mirror, but mirrors were quite different in Tennyson's time than they are now. Research the history of how mirrors are made and explain how that would affect what she saw.
- Write a poem or a short story that explains how the Lady of Shalott came to have this curse put on her.
- This poem has been put to music several times. Adapt it to your favorite type of music, cutting out parts that you think are unnecessary. Explain your choices.
- The Lady of Shalott weaves a picture of what she sees outside her window. Research tapestries from the Middle Ages and report on what kinds of images they present and what kinds of stories they tell.
- Assume that the Lady of Shalott is not under a curse at all, that she cannot go outside because of psychological inhibitions. Report on what treatments are currently available for someone in her situation.

The Lady of Shalott: Media Adaptations

- A 1995 videocassette entitled *"The Lady of Shalott": A Poem and Its Readers* is available from Films for the Humanities & Sciences. It features a reading of the poem and responses by a variety of interested people.
- Encyclopedia Britannica Films produced a 16 mm. film in 1970 called *The Lady of Shalott*, with Cecil Bellamy reading the poem, plus a variety of music and visuals related to it.
- "The Lady of Shalott" is included on a Caedmon recording of *The Poetry of Tennyson*, read by Dame Sybil Thorndike and Sir Lewis Casson. It was recorded in 1972 and is also available on audiocassette.
- A four-album set released by Allyn & Bacon in 1955, *Master Recordings in English Literature*, includes this poem. V. C. Clinton-Baddeley reads.
- A two-album set, *Narrative Poetry*, part of the *London Library of Recorded English* series, includes this poem. It was released by Columbia in 1980, with selections read by Cecil Trouncer, Julian Randall, John Laurie, and V. C. Clinton-Baddeley.
- The second entry in the Argo series, *The English Poets from Chaucer to Yeats*, is devoted to Tennyson. This recording, Alfred, Lord Tennyson, made in association with the British Council and Oxford University Press, includes selections from Tennyson read by Frank Duncan, Michael Horndurn, and David King.
- "The Lady of Shalott" is depicted in a fantasy painting by John William Waterhouse in 1875. The painting became commercially available as a poster from Shorewood Fine Arts Reproductions in 1999.

The Lady of Shalott: What Do I Read Next?

- Edgar Allan Poe's poem "Annabel Lee" deals with the sudden death of a woman the speaker has loved, "many many years ago, in a kingdom by the sea." Poe's poetic music matches Tennyson's. Originally published in 1845, it is available in *The Complete Tales and Poems of Edgar Allan Poe*, published by Vintage Books in 1995.
- Sir Thomas Malory's version of the legend of King Arthur and the Knights of the Round Table, titled *Le Morte D'Arthur*, was published in 1485 by William Caxton and is still one of the most influential sources used today for information about the myth. It is available in an unabridged edition, a reprint of the Caxton original, from Sterling Publications, copyright 2000.
- John Steinbeck, the twentieth-century author who is best known for his realistic novels such as Of Mice and Men and The Grapes of Wrath, wrote one of the best updated versions of the Arthurian legend in his *Acts of King Arthur and His Noble Knights*, available from Noonday Press, 1993.
- Tennyson included a poem entitled "Lancelot and Elaine," which stays truer to the traditional legends about the relationship between the Round Table knight and Elaine of Astolat, in his book Idylls of the King, which is all about the legends associated with King Arthur. Portions of the book were published between 1859 and 1885, when the first complete edition appeared.
- Patricia A. McKillip's novel The Tower at Stony Wood, published in 2000 by Berkley/Ace, is based on the story of "The Lady of Shalott." The imagery gives a strong sense of the world that Tennyson discusses in this poem, although much of the story is different.
- Readers can see how a nineteenth-century U.S. writer imagined coping with being among the knights of the Round Table in Mark Twain's satiric novel A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court, his response to reading Malory's version of the legends. Originally published in 1889, this novel is available from Bantam Classics in a 1994 edition.
- Nineteenth-century poet and novelist, Elizabeth Stuart Phelps, covers the subject of this poem several times, most notably in her poem "Elaine and Elaine," written in 1885 and published in the 1891 collection *Songs of the Silent World*, which is still available through some library systems.

The Lady of Shalott: Bibliography and Further Reading

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Further Reading
Amis, Kingsley. Introduction to *Tennyson.* Penguin Books, 1973, pp. 7-19. Students who find scholarly work hard to follow will appreciate Amis's brief examination of Tennyson's life and importance. Amis, who could be one of the funniest novelists of the twentieth century, seems an unlikely choice for introducing Tennyson's poetry, but his essay is reverent and warm.

Buckley, Jerome Hamilton. *Tennyson: The Growth of a Poet*. Harvard University Press, 1960. Part biography and part criticism, this book gives some insight into Tennyson's psychological state as he wrote this poem.

Foakes, R. A. "The Commitment to Metaphor: Modern Criticism and Romantic Poetry," in *British Romantic Poets: Recent Revelations*. New York University Press, 1966, pp. 22-32. Foakes does not specifically talk about Tennyson, but he does talk about how Romanticism affected poetry that came after it. Readers can draw conclusions about where Tennyson fits into the scheme Foakes proposes.

Hollander, John. "Tennyson's Melody," in *Alfred Lord Tennyson*, edited by Harold Bloom. Chelsea House Publishers, 1985, pp. 103-26. Hollander's examination of the sound of Tennyson's poems, including "The Lady of Shalott," is rich and full of details.

THE LADY OF SHALLOT

Part I

On either side the river lie
Long fields of barley and of rye,
That clothe the wold and meet the sky;
And thro' the field the road runs by
To many-tower'd Camelot;
The yellow-leaved waterlily
The green-sheathed daffodilly
Tremble in the water chilly
Round about Shalott.

Willows whiten, aspens shiver.
The sunbeam showers break and quiver
In the stream that runneth ever
By the island in the river
Flowing down to Camelot.
Four gray walls, and four gray towers
Overlook a space of flowers,
And the silent isle imbowers
The Lady of Shalott.

Underneath the bearded barley,
The reaper, reaping late and early,
Hears her ever chanting cheerly,
Like an angel, singing clearly,
O'er the stream of Camelot.
Piling the sheaves in furrows airy,
Beneath the moon, the reaper weary
Listening whispers, ' 'Tis the fairy,
Lady of Shalott.'

The little isle is all inrail'd
With a rose-fence, and overtrail'd
With roses: by the marge unhail'd
The shallop flitteth silken sail'd,
Skimming down to Camelot.
A pearl garland winds her head:
She leaneth on a velvet bed,
Full royally apparelled,
The Lady of Shalott.

Part II

No time hath she to sport and play:
A charmed web she weaves alway.
A curse is on her, if she stay
Her weaving, either night or day,
To look down to Camelot.
She knows not what the curse may be;
Therefore she weaveth steadily,
Therefore no other care hath she,
The Lady of Shalott.

She lives with little joy or fear.
Over the water, running near,
The sheepbell tinkles in her ear.
Before her hangs a mirror clear,
Reflecting tower'd Camelot.
And as the mazy web she whirls,
She sees the surly village churls,
And the red cloaks of market girls
Pass onward from Shalott.

Sometimes a troop of damsels glad,
An abbot on an ambling pad,
Sometimes a curly shepherd lad,
Or long-hair'd page in crimson clad,
Goes by to tower'd Camelot:
And sometimes thro' the mirror blue
The knights come riding two and two:
She hath no loyal knight and true,
The Lady of Shalott.

But in her web she still delights
To weave the mirror's magic sights,
For often thro' the silent nights
A funeral, with plumes and lights
And music, came from Camelot:
Or when the moon was overhead
Came two young lovers lately wed;
'I am half sick of shadows,' said
The Lady of Shalott.

Part III

A bow-shot from her bower-eaves,
He rode between the barley-sheaves,
The sun came dazzling thro' the leaves,
And flam'd upon the brazen greaves
Of bold Sir Lancelot.
A red-cross knight for ever kneel'd
To a lady in his shield,
That sparkled on the yellow field,
Beside remote Shalott.

The gemmy bridle glitter'd free,
Like to some branch of stars we see
Hung in the golden Galaxy.
The bridle bells rang merrily
As he rode down from Camelot:
And from his blazon'd baldric slung
A mighty silver bugle hung,
And as he rode his armour rung,
Beside remote Shalott.

All in the blue unclouded weather
Thick-jewell'd shone the saddle-leather,
The helmet and the helmet-feather
Burn'd like one burning flame together,
As he rode down from Camelot.
As often thro' the purple night,
Below the starry clusters bright,
Some bearded meteor, trailing light,
Moves over green Shalott.

His broad clear brow in sunlight glow'd;
On burnish'd hooves his war-horse trode;
From underneath his helmet flow'd
His coal-black curls as on he rode,
As he rode down from Camelot.
From the bank and from the river
He flash'd into the crystal mirror,
'Tirra lirra, tirra lirra:'
Sang Sir Lancelot.

She left the web, she left the loom
She made three paces thro' the room

She saw the water-flower bloom,
She saw the helmet and the plume,
    She look'd down to Camelot.
Out flew the web and floated wide;
The mirror crack'd from side to side;
'The curse is come upon me,' cried
    The Lady of Shalott.

Part IV

In the stormy east-wind straining,
The pale yellow woods were waning,
The broad stream in his banks complaining,
Heavily the low sky raining
    Over tower'd Camelot;
Outside the isle a shallow boat
Beneath a willow lay afloat,
Below the carven stern she wrote,
    The Lady of Shalott.

A cloudwhite crown of pearl she dight,
All raimented in snowy white
That loosely flew (her zone in sight
Clasp'd with one blinding diamond bright)
    Her wide eyes fix'd on Camelot,
Though the squally east-wind keenly
Blew, with folded arms serenely
By the water stood the queenly
    Lady of Shalott.

With a steady stony glance—
Like some bold seer in a trance,
Beholding all his own mischance,
Mute, with a glassy countenance—
    She look'd down to Camelot.
It was the closing of the day:
She loos'd the chain, and down she lay;
The broad stream bore her far away,
    The Lady of Shalott.

As when to sailors while they roam,
By creeks and outfalls far from home,
Rising and dropping with the foam,
From dying swans wild warblings come,
    Blown shoreward; so to Camelot
Still as the boathead wound along
The willowy hills and fields among,
They heard her chanting her deathsong,
    The Lady of Shalott.

A longdrawn carol, mournful, holy,
She chanted loudly, chanted lowly,
Till her eyes were darken'd wholly,
And her smooth face sharpen'd slowly,
    Turn'd to tower'd Camelot:
For ere she reach'd upon the tide
The first house by the water-side,
Singing in her song she died,
    The Lady of Shalott.

Under tower and balcony,
By garden wall and gallery,
A pale, pale corpse she floated by,
Deadcold, between the houses high,
    Dead into tower'd Camelot.

Knight and burgher, lord and dame,
To the planked wharfage came:
Below the stern they read her name,
The Lady of Shalott.

They cross'd themselves, their stars they blest,
Knight, minstrel, abbot, squire, and guest.
There lay a parchment on her breast,
That puzzled more than all the rest,
The wellfed wits at Camelot.
'The web was woven curiously,
The charm is broken utterly,
Draw near and fear not,—this is I,
The Lady of Shalott.'

Summary of The Lady of Shalott

- **Popularity of "The Lady of Shalott":** Alfred, Lord Tennyson, a great British poet, wrote 'The Lady of Shalott', a ballad known for its themes of melancholy and death. It was first published in 1833. The poem unfolds the story of a lady who is mysteriously imprisoned in a tall building of Camelot. It then illustrates how magic plays a significant role in one's life.
- **"The Lady of Shalott" As a Representative of Death:** The poem narrates the tragic story of a lady who is imprisoned on an island. No one can see her except the farmers who listen to her song while working in their fields. Everything around her is gloomy and colorless. She is not allowed to look outside through the window. Rather, she sees the outside world through a mirror. To her, the reality is confined to the images she perceives through that mirror. The poem also provides a detailed description of the place around her and the movement of the people in Camelot. One day, she sees a knight coming from the fields of Barley. He grabs her attention, and she sees the Camelot through the window. As a punishment, she writes her name on the boat, signs her last song, and dies.
- **Major Themes in "The Lady of Shalott":** Isolation, detachment, and the supernatural elements are the major themes of this poem. The text revolves around the mystery of the Lady of Shalott, who is trapped. She accepts it as her fate and is emotionally and physically detached from the real world. She sees the world only through the mirror. Ironically, she dies when she gets out of that building and when the mirror breaks.

Analysis of Literary Devices in "The Lady of Shalott"

Literary devices are modes that represent the writer's idea, feelings, and emotions. Alfred has also used some literary devices in this poem to discuss the phenomenon of isolation and magic. The analysis of some of the literary devices used in this poem has been listed below.

1. **Assonance:** Assonance is the repetition of vowel sounds in the same line. For example, the sound of /i/ in "The willowy hills and fields among".
2. **Parallelism:** Parallelism is the use of components in a sentence that is grammatically the same, or similar in their construction, sound, meaning, or meter. This device is used in part three where "She left the web" is paralleling "she left the loom."
3. **Consonance:** Consonance is the repetition of consonant sounds in the same line such as the sound of /r/ in "Till her eyes were darken'd wholly" and /l/ sound in "His coal-black curls as on he rode".
4. **Alliteration:** Alliteration is the repetition of consonant sounds in the same line in quick succession such as the sound of /th/ in "They cross'd themselves, their stars they blest" and the sound of /w/ in "he pale yellow woods were waning".
5. **Imagery**: Imagery is used to make readers perceive things involving their five senses. For example, "There lay a parchment on her breast"; "She loos'd the chain, and down she lay" and "The pale yellow woods were waning".
6. **Symbolism:** Symbolism means to use symbols to signify ideas and qualities, giving them symbolic meanings that are different from the literal meanings. "Camelot" is the symbol of a fantasy world for the lady, "the Island" and "mirror" symbolizes isolation.
7. **Simile:** A simile is a figure of speech used to compare something with something else to make the meanings clear to the readers. For example, "The gemmy bridle glitter'd free, Like to some branch of stars we see Hung in the golden Galaxy". Here the horse' bridle is compared to a star constellation.

“The Lotos-Eaters”

Poetry by Alfred Lord Tennyson

Complete Text

“Courage!” he said, and pointed toward the land,
“This mounting wave will roll us shoreward soon.”
In the afternoon they came unto a land
In which it seemed always afternoon.
All round the coast the languid air did swoon,
Breathing like one that hath a weary dream.
Full-faced above the valley stood the moon;
And like a downward smoke, the slender stream
Along the cliff to fall and pause and fall did seem.

A land of streams! some, like a downward smoke,
Slow-dropping veils of thinnest lawn, did go;
And some thro’ wavering lights and shadows broke,
Rolling a slumbrous sheet of foam below.
They saw the gleaming river seaward flow
From the inner land: far off, three mountain-tops,
Three silent pinnacles of aged snow,
Stood sunset-flush’d: and, dew’d with showery drops,
Up-clomb the shadowy pine above the woven copse.

The charmed sunset linger’d low adown
In the red West: thro’ mountain clefts the dale
Was seen far inland, and the yellow down
Border’d with palm, and many a winding vale
And meadow, set with slender galingale;
A land where all things always seem’d the same!
And round about the keel with faces pale,
Dark faces pale against that rosy flame,
The mild-eyed melancholy Lotos-eaters came.

Branches they bore of that enchanted stem,
Laden with flower and fruit, whereof they gave
To each, but whoso did receive of them,
And taste, to him the gushing of the wave
Far far away did seem to mourn and rave
On alien shores; and if his fellow spake,
His voice was thin, as voices from the grave;
And deep-asleep he seem’d, yet all awake,

And music in his ears his beating heart did make.

They sat them down upon the yellow sand,
Between the sun and moon upon the shore;
And sweet it was to dream of Fatherland,
Of child, and wife, and slave; but evermore
Most weary seem'd the sea, weary the oar,
Weary the wandering fields of barren foam.
Then some one said, "We will return no more";
And all at once they sang, "Our island home
Is far beyond the wave; we will no longer roam."

Summary

Odysseus tells his mariners to have courage, assuring them that they will soon reach the shore of their home. In the afternoon, they reach a land "in which it seemed always afternoon" because of the languid and peaceful atmosphere. The mariners sight this "land of streams" with its gleaming river flowing to the sea, its three snow-capped mountaintops, and its shadowy pine growing in the vale.

The mariners are greeted by the "mild-eyed melancholy Lotos-eaters," whose dark faces appear pale against the rosy sunset. These Lotos-eaters come bearing the flower and fruit of the lotos, which they offer to Odysseus's mariners. Those who eat the lotos feel as if they have fallen into a deep sleep; they sit down upon the yellow sand of the island and can hardly perceive their fellow mariners speaking to them, hearing only the music of their heartbeat in their ears. Although it has been sweet to dream of their homes in Ithaca, the lotos makes them weary of wandering, preferring to linger here. One who has eaten of the lotos fruit proclaims that he will "return no more," and all of the mariners begin to sing about this resolution to remain in the land of the Lotos-eaters.

The rest of the poem consists of the eight numbered stanzas of the mariners' choric song, expressing their resolution to stay forever. First, they praise the sweet and soporific music of the land of the Lotos-eaters, comparing this music to petals, dew, granite, and tired eyelids. In the second stanza, they question why man is the only creature in nature who must toil. They argue that everything else in nature is able to rest and stay still, but man is tossed from one sorrow to another. Man's inner spirit tells him that tranquility and calmness offer the only joy, and yet he is fated to toil and wander his whole life.

In the third stanza, the mariners declare that everything in nature is allotted a lifespan in which to bloom and fade. As examples of other living things that die, they cite the "folded leaf, which eventually turns yellow and drifts to the earth, as well as the "full-juiced apple," which ultimately falls to the ground, and the flower, which ripens and fades. Next, in the fourth stanza, the mariners question the purpose of a life of labor, since nothing is cumulative and thus all our accomplishments lead nowhere. They question "what...will last," proclaiming that everything in life is fleeting and therefore futile. The mariners also express their desire for "long rest or death," either of which will free them from a life of endless labor.

The fifth stanza echoes the first stanza's positive appeal to luxurious self-indulgence; the mariners declare how sweet it is to live a life of continuous dreaming. They paint a picture of what it might be like to do nothing all day except sleep, dream, eat lotos, and watch the waves on the beach. Such an existence would enable them peacefully to remember all those individuals they once knew who are now either buried ("heaped over with a mound of grass") or cremated ("two handfuls of white dust, shut in an urn of brass!").

In the sixth stanza, the mariners reason that their families have probably forgotten them anyway, and their homes fallen apart, so they might as well stay in the land of the Lotos-eaters and "let what is broken so remain." Although they have fond memories of their wives and sons, surely by now, after ten years of fighting in Troy, their sons have inherited their property; it will merely cause unnecessary confusion and disturbances for them to return now. Their hearts are worn out from fighting wars and navigating the seas by means of the constellations, and thus they prefer the relaxing death-like existence of the Land of the Lotos to the confusion that a return home would create.

In the seventh stanza, as in the first and fifth, the mariners bask in the pleasant sights and sounds of the island. They imagine how sweet it would be to lie on beds of flowers while watching the river flow and listening to the echoes in the caves. Finally, the poem closes with the mariners' vow to spend the rest of their lives relaxing and reclining in the "hollow Lotos land." They compare the life of abandon, which they will enjoy in Lotos land, to the carefree existence of the Gods, who could not care less about the famines, plagues, earthquakes, and other natural disasters that plague human beings on earth. These Gods simply smile upon men, who till the earth and harvest crops until they either suffer in hell or dwell in the "Elysian valleys" of heaven. Since they have concluded that "slumber is more sweet than toil," the mariners resolve to stop wandering the seas and to settle instead in the land of the Lotos-eaters.

Form

This poem is divided into two parts: the first is a descriptive narrative (lines 1–45), and the second is a song of eight numbered stanzas of varying length (lines 46–173). The first part of the poem is written in nine-line Spenserian stanzas, so called because they were employed by Spenser in *The Faerie Queene* . The rhyme scheme of the Spenserian stanza is a closely interlinked *ABABBCBCC,* with the first eight lines in iambic pentameter and the final line an Alexandrine (or line of six iambic feet). The choric song follows a far looser structure: both the line-length and the rhyme scheme vary widely among the eight stanzas.

Commentary

This poem is based on the story of Odysseus's mariners described in scroll IX of Homer's *Odyssey* . Homer writes about a storm that blows the great hero's mariners off course as they attempt to journey back from Troy to their homes in Ithaca. They come to a land where people do nothing but eat lotos (the Greek for our English "lotus"), a flower so delicious that some of his men, upon tasting it, lose all desire to return to Ithaca and long only to remain in the Land of the Lotos. Odysseus must drag his men away so that they can resume their journey home. In this

poem, Tennyson powerfully evokes the mariners' yearning to settle into a life of peacefulness, rest, and even death.

The poem draws not only on Homer's *Odyssey*, but also on the biblical Garden of Eden in the Book of Genesis. In the Bible, a "life of toil" is Adam's punishment for partaking of the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge: after succumbing to the temptation of the fruit, Adam is condemned to labor by the sweat of his brow. Yet in this poem, *fruit* (the lotos) provides a *release* from the life of labor, suggesting an inversion of the biblical story.

Tennyson provides a tempting and seductive vision of a life free from toil. His description of the Lotos Land rivals the images of pleasure in Milton's "L'Allegro" and Marvell's "The Garden." Yet his lush descriptive passages are accompanied by persuasive rhetoric; nearly every stanza of the choric song presents a different argument to justify the mariners' resolution to remain in the Lotos Land. For example, in the second stanza of the song the mariners express the irony of the fact that man, who is the pinnacle and apex of creation, is the only creature made to toil and labor all the days of his life. This stanza may also be read as a pointed inversion and overturning of Coleridge's "Work without Hope," in which the speaker laments that "all nature seems at work" while he alone remains unoccupied.

Although the taste of the lotos and the vision of life it offers is seductive, the poem suggests that the mariners may be deceiving themselves in succumbing to the hypnotic power of the flower. Partaking of the lotos involves abandoning external reality and living instead in a world of appearances, where everything "seems" to be but nothing actually is: the Lotos Land emerges as "a land where all things always seemed the same" (line 24). Indeed, the word "seems" recurs throughout the poem, and can be found in all but one of the opening five stanzas, suggesting that the Lotos Land is not so much a "land of streams" as a "land of seems." In addition, in the final stanza of the choric song, the poem describes the Lotos Land as a "hollow" land with "hollow" caves, indicating that the vision of the sailors is somehow empty and insubstantial.

The reader, too, is left with ambivalent feelings about the mariners' argument for lassitude. Although the thought of life without toil is certainly tempting, it is also deeply unsettling. The reader's discomfort with this notion arises in part from the knowledge of the broader context of the poem: Odysseus will ultimately drag his men away from the Lotos Land disapprovingly; moreover, his injunction to have "courage" opens—and then overshadows—the whole poem with a sense of moral opprobrium. The sailors' case for lassitude is further undermined morally by their complaint that it is unpleasant "to war with evil" (line 94); are they too lazy to do what is right? By choosing the Lotos Land, the mariners are abandoning the sources of substantive meaning in life and the potential for heroic accomplishment. Thus in this poem Tennyson forces us to consider the ambiguous appeal of a life without toil: although all of us share the longing for a carefree and relaxed existence, few people could truly be happy without any challenges to overcome, without the fire of aspiration and the struggle to make the world a better place.

Source: http://www.sparknotes.com/poetry/tennyson/section3.rhtml

The Lotus-eaters

BY ALFRED, LORD TENNYSON

"Courage!" he said, and pointed toward the land,
"This mounting wave will roll us shoreward soon."
In the afternoon they came unto a land
In which it seemed always afternoon.
All round the coast the languid air did swoon,
Breathing like one that hath a weary dream.
Full-faced above the valley stood the moon;
And like a downward smoke, the slender stream
Along the cliff to fall and pause and fall did seem.

A land of streams! some, like a downward smoke,
Slow-dropping veils of thinnest lawn, did go;
And some thro' wavering lights and shadows broke,
Rolling a slumbrous sheet of foam below.
They saw the gleaming river seaward flow
From the inner land: far off, three mountain-tops,
Three silent pinnacles of aged snow,
Stood sunset-flush'd: and, dew'd with showery drops,
Up-clomb the shadowy pine above the woven copse.

The charmed sunset linger'd low adown
In the red West: thro' mountain clefts the dale
Was seen far inland, and the yellow down
Border'd with palm, and many a winding vale
And meadow, set with slender galingale;
A land where all things always seem'd the same!
And round about the keel with faces pale,
Dark faces pale against that rosy flame,
The mild-eyed melancholy Lotos-eaters came.

Branches they bore of that enchanted stem,
Laden with flower and fruit, whereof they gave
To each, but whoso did receive of them,
And taste, to him the gushing of the wave
Far far away did seem to mourn and rave
On alien shores; and if his fellow spake,
His voice was thin, as voices from the grave;
And deep-asleep he seem'd, yet all awake,
And music in his ears his beating heart did make.

They sat them down upon the yellow sand,
Between the sun and moon upon the shore;
And sweet it was to dream of Fatherland,
Of child, and wife, and slave; but evermore
Most weary seem'd the sea, weary the oar,
Weary the wandering fields of barren foam.
Then some one said, "We will return no more";
And all at once they sang, "Our island home
Is far beyond the wave; we will no longer roam."

CHORIC SONG

I

There is sweet music here that softer falls
Than petals from blown roses on the grass,
Or night-dews on still waters between walls
Of shadowy granite, in a gleaming pass;
Music that gentlier on the spirit lies,
Than tir'd eyelids upon tir'd eyes;
Music that brings sweet sleep down from the blissful skies.
Here are cool mosses deep,
And thro' the moss the ivies creep,
And in the stream the long-leaved flowers weep,
And from the craggy ledge the poppy hangs in sleep."

II

Why are we weigh'd upon with heaviness,
And utterly consumed with sharp distress,
While all things else have rest from weariness?
All things have rest: why should we toil alone,
We only toil, who are the first of things,
And make perpetual moan,
Still from one sorrow to another thrown:
Nor ever fold our wings,
And cease from wanderings,
Nor steep our brows in slumber's holy balm;
Nor harken what the inner spirit sings,
"There is no joy but calm!"
Why should we only toil, the roof and crown of things?

III

Lo! in the middle of the wood,
The folded leaf is woo'd from out the bud
With winds upon the branch, and there
Grows green and broad, and takes no care,
Sun-steep'd at noon, and in the moon
Nightly dew-fed; and turning yellow
Falls, and floats adown the air.
Lo! sweeten'd with the summer light,
The full-juiced apple, waxing over-mellow,
Drops in a silent autumn night.
All its allotted length of days
The flower ripens in its place,
Ripens and fades, and falls, and hath no toil,
Fast-rooted in the fruitful soil.

IV

Hateful is the dark-blue sky,
Vaulted o'er the dark-blue sea.
Death is the end of life; ah, why
Should life all labour be?
Let us alone. Time driveth onward fast,
And in a little while our lips are dumb.
Let us alone. What is it that will last?
All things are taken from us, and become
Portions and parcels of the dreadful past.

Let us alone. What pleasure can we have
To war with evil? Is there any peace
In ever climbing up the climbing wave?
All things have rest, and ripen toward the grave
In silence; ripen, fall and cease:
Give us long rest or death, dark death, or dreamful ease.

V

How sweet it were, hearing the downward stream,
With half-shut eyes ever to seem
Falling asleep in a half-dream!
To dream and dream, like yonder amber light,
Which will not leave the myrrh-bush on the height;
To hear each other's whisper'd speech;
Eating the Lotos day by day,
To watch the crisping ripples on the beach,
And tender curving lines of creamy spray;
To lend our hearts and spirits wholly
To the influence of mild-minded melancholy;
To muse and brood and live again in memory,
With those old faces of our infancy
Heap'd over with a mound of grass,
Two handfuls of white dust, shut in an urn of brass!

VI

Dear is the memory of our wedded lives,
And dear the last embraces of our wives
And their warm tears: but all hath suffer'd change:
For surely now our household hearths are cold,
Our sons inherit us: our looks are strange:
And we should come like ghosts to trouble joy.
Or else the island princes over-bold
Have eat our substance, and the minstrel sings
Before them of the ten years' war in Troy,
And our great deeds, as half-forgotten things.
Is there confusion in the little isle?
Let what is broken so remain.
The Gods are hard to reconcile:
'Tis hard to settle order once again.
There *is* confusion worse than death,
Trouble on trouble, pain on pain,
Long labour unto aged breath,
Sore task to hearts worn out by many wars
And eyes grown dim with gazing on the pilot-stars.

VII

But, propt on beds of amaranth and moly,
How sweet (while warm airs lull us, blowing lowly)
With half-dropt eyelid still,
Beneath a heaven dark and holy,
To watch the long bright river drawing slowly
His waters from the purple hill—
To hear the dewy echoes calling
From cave to cave thro' the thick-twined vine—

To watch the emerald-colour'd water falling
Thro' many a wov'n acanthus-wreath divine!
Only to hear and see the far-off sparkling brine,
Only to hear were sweet, stretch'd out beneath the pine.

VIII

The Lotos blooms below the barren peak:
The Lotos blows by every winding creek:
All day the wind breathes low with mellower tone:
Thro' every hollow cave and alley lone
Round and round the spicy downs the yellow Lotos-dust is blown.
We have had enough of action, and of motion we,
Roll'd to starboard, roll'd to larboard, when the surge was seething free,
Where the wallowing monster spouted his foam-fountains in the sea.
Let us swear an oath, and keep it with an equal mind,
In the hollow Lotos-land to live and lie reclined
On the hills like Gods together, careless of mankind.
For they lie beside their nectar, and the bolts are hurl'd
Far below them in the valleys, and the clouds are lightly curl'd
Round their golden houses, girdled with the gleaming world:
Where they smile in secret, looking over wasted lands,
Blight and famine, plague and earthquake, roaring deeps and fiery sands,
Clanging fights, and flaming towns, and sinking ships, and praying hands.
But they smile, they find a music centred in a doleful song
Steaming up, a lamentation and an ancient tale of wrong,
Like a tale of little meaning tho' the words are strong;
Chanted from an ill-used race of men that cleave the soil,
Sow the seed, and reap the harvest with enduring toil,
Storing yearly little dues of wheat, and wine and oil;
Till they perish and they suffer—some, 'tis whisper'd—down in hell
Suffer endless anguish, others in Elysian valleys dwell,
Resting weary limbs at last on beds of asphodel.
Surely, surely, slumber is more sweet than toil, the shore
Than labour in the deep mid-ocean, wind and wave and oar;
O, rest ye, brother mariners, we will not wander more.

MAN AND THE NATURAL WORLD

The Lotus-eaters" is all about a place. Sure, it deals with feelings and legends and wacky plants, but it spends a lot of time just describing the enchanted land of the Lotos-eaters. We hear all about the valleys and streams and waterfalls, as well as the calm, dreamy, tropical mood of the place, setting the stage for the song of the sailors. We don't really meet any individual characters in this poem, so in a way, the place itself becomes a kind of character. And Lotus land is one strange character…

TIME

Time is really screwy in "The Lotus-Eaters." The land of the Lotos-eaters seems to be stuck in some kind of endless afternoon, and the speakers of the poem are obsessed with eternity, death, and endless sleep. It sounds like a hoot. Over the course of the poem, we lose track of when and where we are. Tennyson takes us out of the everyday world of appointments and schedules and minutes and hours. He immerses us in a place where reality is subtly altered, and the strangeness of time is one of the big clues to that difference.

DEATH

There's a lot of death imagery in "The Lotus-Eaters." Maybe it doesn't jump out at you at first, but as you come back through, you notice that the sailors seem a little bit obsessed with death. Sometimes their sleepy, dreamy mood slips over into wanting to sleep forever, or in other words: D to the I to the E. At other times, the image of death comes from nature, from the endless cycle of birth, growth, and death. Whatever the reason for it, it seems like these guys are in kind of a bad place.

HOME

"The Lotus-Eaters" takes place in a strange and exotic spot, but there's also a lot of talk about home. The big problem in this poem is that the sailors don't want to sail anymore, and they would have to sail (or maybe just row) in order to get back to their wives and kids. So they make up excuses and tell themselves it isn't really worth going home after all. (Fathers of the year, they ain't.) In that way, this poem kind of flips the standard idea of homesick travelers on its head. These are travelers who don't want to go home. Still, given how much they talk about it, you can still tell that the idea of home has a pretty strong influence on their thinking (even if they're thinking under the influence of the Lotos).

About the Poem

The prescribed poem deals with a group of mariners who after consuming the lotos, went into a state of trance or temporal amnesia. The poem functions as a marked contrast to Tennyson's "Ulysses" that had as its motto, "*To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield*." This particular poem is diametrically opposite in theme as it stands for Victorian complacency. The background of the poem is scroll IX of Homer's Odyssey.

As they proceed from Troy, the mariners get thwarted by a storm from their intended destination. Instead of Ithaca, they arrive at a land where people eat 'lotos'(Greek for 'Lotus)'. No description of the country is given. Some of the mariners consume the lotos and sink into lassitude, a sluggish condition devoid of activity and aspiration. The condition is probably emblematic of the pseudo-modern way of life where advanced technology has made life devoid of activity and creativity. In such a condition,

The poem has been pointed by critics to be a subversion of the story in the Book of Genesis. In the Bible, Adam is condemned to tedious toiling as he dares to consume the forbidden fruit of the Tree of Knowledge. The lure of the fruit reigns supreme. Consequently, Adam is damned to droning hard-work. On the other hand, in "The Lotos Eaters", the proverbial fruit (the lotos) provides an outlet from a life of monotonous manual labor. Thus, it inverts and subverts the canonical myth. The fruit (the lotos) as opposed to the fruit of knowledge leaves the mariners in an indolent condition. Ulysses urges the recalcitrants to revert to their kingdom from their epicurean pursuits.

The Form

The poem has a narrative section penned in Spenserian stanzas that elaborates on the arrival of the Greeks in the Unnamed land. The description echoes the apathy of the people and mirrors their inertia. The poem concludes with eight stanzas entitled "Choric Song".

Explication

Odysseus points a conspicuous finger towards the land that was seemingly the destination for the mariners. The pointing of this finger not only functioned as a direction for guidance, it also infused them with positivism regarding reaching their target. The speaker is convinced and confident that the wave would usher them towards Ithaca. Eventually, in the afternoon, they do reach a land. However, it was not their intended destination. This particular place was singular as

it always seemed like afternoon here. The poet states that it “always seemed like afternoon” because there was no action to define time or vice-versa.

In the background, the lethargic air was typified in a state of trance. It seemed as though it was in a weary dream. The moon foregrounded the scene and stood full-faced above the valley. The phrase ‘full-face” has two meanings here; one that it was a full-moon day. The second implication is that the moon had a more clear–cut identity than the inhabitants of the island, as it was more aware of its basic functions. The mariners behold the stream that fell from the cliff. It had the appearance of smoke emanating from the mountains in a pause-and-play like stance. As the streams fell in slow motion, green lawns were revealed in the process, as though veils slowly dropped with care. Some streams in this ‘land of streams’ glided through wavering lights breaking shadows in their path. They seemed to descend into the ‘slumberous’ froth below .They are qualified by the adjective ‘slumberous’ as they were static as opposed to the kinetic streams. The mariners visualized “three silent pinnacles of aged snow”. The poet utilizes a transferred epithet as it is not the snow that is aged but the mountains.

The sunset appears to be ‘charmed’ as it is characterized by a roseate glow. Therefore, it appears to be blushing. As it lowered itself through the West, it was completely red. The palm seemed to be bordered in ‘yellow’ sunshine. The pine flourishing in the vale, and the meadows set with galingale foregrounded the scene. The monotonous nature of their existence made one feel that everything in the place seemed to be the same. The faces of the lotos-eaters seemed to be dark with the onset of dusk, as they gathered around the keel of the ship. Their eyes seemed to be hazed with drugged delusion. Though they are complacent, there is an element of guilt of relegating their responsibilities. Hence the phrase “The mild-eyed melancholy Lotos-eaters.”

Odysseus’ comrades find the inhabitants of the island, who offer them the fruit of the lotos. The mariners that have consumed the lotos find themselves in a somnolent state. As they sat upon the yellow sands, the only audible sounds to their ears were the rhythm of their hearts. They could not even perceive the sound of their companions. It sounded like a thin voice, as though voices emanated from the grave. The stagnation of their existence is symbolic of death itself. He seemed deep in sleep, yet he was awake. Therefore, it was a life-in-death and death-in-life like stance. They find it worthwhile to dream of their family and abode in Ithaca. The gushing of the waves comes across as a sound of mourning and raving.

The ‘shores’ now seemed to be alien with respect to the mariners; but in truth, it was them who were alienated or estranged from their homeland. The lotos rendered them sluggish. It makes them prefer a life of languor. They are tired of a life of persistent wandering and make the resolution that, “We will return no more.” They are so exhausted by their exploits that the very sea and oars seemed ‘weary’ to them, and the foam ‘barren’. They no longer revel in prospects of adventure, exploration and discovery. Therefore, the last line functions merely as an excuse to them, a kind of escapism from their predicament.

Through analysis, this Tennyson poem thus creates an existential awareness, and foregrounds the futility of human struggle. Heroic achievement and intellectual pursuits are reduced to naught in the course of the poem. Though the choric song reflects such a philosophy, the author of the poem utilizes understatements to echo the opposite. Especially, when he reiterates the idea of sameness screeching ‘boredom’ and the qualities of a monotonous sterile subsistence.

Wouldn’t it be nice to pass your life without having to toil and labour and work all the time? Or, indeed, any of the time? Instead, you could just relax and leisurely let life pass by in a dreamlike haze. This is what Tennyson’s ‘The Lotos-Eaters’ posits, using the episode from **Homer’s epic poem the *Odyssey*** as inspiration. In Homer’s poem, Odysseus and his crew are given the fruit of the lotus on an island, and this drug-like fruit induces forgetfulness and lethargy in them, causing them to forget that they’re meant to be sailing home after the Trojan War. It’s only thanks to

Odysseus' strength of mind that they recall their mission and leave the island of the lotus-eaters behind.

 In summary, then, 'The Lotos-Eaters' describes the arrival of Odysseus and his crew on the island of the lotos-eaters, and their subsequent lethargy and state of drug-induced slumber once they have tasted of the fruit and determined never to leave the island and return to a life of work. The poem's account of the crew's drugged state and their unwillingness to arise from their state of torpor is described with repeated use of words like *seem*, *stream*, and *dream*, which all rhyme together, their meanings flowing into one another (and, of course, *seem* paired with *dream* gives the sounds of *s-dream* – i.e. *stream*).

Is 'The Lotos-Eaters' simply about the Odyssean episode from Greek myth, or is it *about* something more contemporary to Tennyson's own time? How might we analyse the poem in its nineteenth-century context? Does the lotos plant represent something else? 'Opium' is one answer. As Ricks points out, around the same time that he was working on 'The Lotos-Eaters', Tennyson wrote a letter to W. H. Brookfield warning of the dangers of the drug opium: 'What are you about – musing, and brooding and dreaming and opium-eating yourself out of this life into the next?' Not only is 'The Lotos-Eaters' a poem about a group of men who would rather join the next life than return to their journeying life of toil on the seas, but against Tennyson's 'musing, and brooding and dreaming' we may set one line from his poem: 'To muse and brood and live again in memory'. But perhaps against *this* line, in turn, we might set the triumphant and decisive final line from Tennyson's other Odysseus-inspired poem from around this time, 'Ulysses': 'To strive, to seek, to find, and not to yield'. Those infinitives are very different: to *muse* is not necessarily a bad thing, especially for a poet, but it's far less animated and industrious than to *strive*.

Not that we should reduce an analysis of 'The Lotos-Eaters' to an anti-drugs poem, as if the whole thing were merely warning against the evils of laudanum. For one thing, the poem is out to depict the appealing aspects of a life of leisure alongside its drawbacks. There is something very alluring about leaving everything behind and just idling. And it's worth noting, as a final point of analysis, that Tennyson ends 'The Lotos-Eaters' with the same collective 'we' which resoundingly concludes 'Ulysses': 'O rest ye, brother mariners, we will not wander more.' That other poem, 'Ulysses', had ended with Ulysses/Odysseus calling for his crew to join him in wandering some more; 'The Lotos-Eaters' is the flipside to this vision of exploration and daring-to-dream. In 'The Lotos-Eaters', to dream is enough.

Analysis of *The Lotos-eaters*

Part I

First Stanza

"Courage!" he said, and pointed toward the land, "This mounting wave will roll us shoreward soon."
In the afternoon they came unto a land
In which it seemed always afternoon.
All round the coast the languid air did swoon,

Breathing like one that hath a weary dream.
Full-faced above the valley stood the moon;
And like a downward smoke, the slender stream
Along the cliff to fall and pause and fall did seem.
The poem begins with Odysseus of Ithaca driving his men onward through "mounting wave[s]." They are in the midst of their ten year journey home from the battle of Troy. Tennyson's poem begins after Zeus has swept Odysseus's' boat along to the land of the "Lotos-eaters"(as can be read in Homer's *Odyssey).* He adds in, and embellishes, details that Homer started.
Odysseus, is encouraging his men, telling them to have "Courage," in the face of these mighty waves that Zeus has sent them. This next one, he tells them, will surely "roll us shoreward soon."
His words end up being true and the men are brought to land by that "afternoon." The speaker of the poem then gives the reader a number of details regarding the land to which they have come. It is a place that, no matter the time of day, seems to perpetually exist in the afternoon. This could be due to the heat or the activities of those that reside on the island. The air seems to move very slowly around the island, it is "languid" and "swoon[ing]." These words foreshadow the change that will soon come over the men as they taste the lotos fruit.
The air of the land is further compared to "Breathing" as if one is in a dream. Each breath is long and requires effort. The moon is standing "Full-faced above the valley," and from there a stream weaves it's way "Along the cliff" pausing and falling.

Second Stanza

A land of streams! some, like a downward smoke,
Slow-dropping veils of thinnest lawn, did go;
And some thro' wavering lights and shadows broke,
Rolling a slumbrous sheet of foam below.
They saw the gleaming river seaward flow
From the inner land: far off, three mountain-tops,
Three silent pinnacles of aged snow,
Stood sunset-flush'd: and, dew'd with showery drops,
Up-clomb the shadowy pine above the woven copse.
In the second stanza of the poem the speaker is sharing the amazement he, and Odysseus's party feel upon seeing this land. It seems to them to be "A land of streams!" There are all different kinds around them, some thin, and some lumbering and powerful. Each of these streams connect to one river that is flowing "seaward."
Far in the distance the travelers and the omniscient narrator are able to see "three mountain-tops" that are like three old monuments of "aged snow." They are standing strong in the sunlight, unrelenting to the warmth. There is mention of a "shadowy pine," one dominating pine tree that is covered with dew and appears to "up-clomb" or climb up, the "woven copse," or small grouping of trees. This one larger tree is grander than the rest and it only seems to grow larger as they stare at the scene before them.

Third Stanza

The charmed sunset linger'd low adown

In the red West: thro' mountain clefts the dale

Was seen far inland, and the yellow down

Border'd with palm, and many a winding vale

And meadow, set with slender galingale;

A land where all things always seem'd the same!

And round about the keel with faces pale,

Dark faces pale against that rosy flame,

The mild-eyed melancholy Lotos-eaters came.

The sun is setting when they arrive, afternoon is moving on. But it is not moving quickly. It has "linger'd low" endowing the "West" with "red." The speaker and the travelers can see through or "thro'" the mountains to what is a "dale," or large valley, further in the distance. Even though they have just landed and are at sea level, they are still high enough to see far into the distance. The land seems to be "Border'd" with palm trees and "many a wandering vale / And meadow." In these places, and in the meadow, the speaker is able to see "galingale" a type of sedge found in Europe and Asia. This land is one in which of these things are equally beautiful. They are all a part of one another and make up the living environment.
The men are still on the boat as the speaker describes them looking down and seeing that while they have been entranced by the land the "Lotos-eaters" have come.They are gathered around the "keel," of the ship and are looking up at them with their "mild…melancholy" eyes and "pale /Dark faces."

Fourth Stanza

Branches they bore of that enchanted stem,
Laden with flower and fruit, whereof they gave
To each, but whoso did receive of them,
And taste, to him the gushing of the wave
Far far away did seem to mourn and rave
On alien shores; and if his fellow spake,
His voice was thin, as voices from the grave;
And deep-asleep he seem'd, yet all awake,
And music in his ears his beating heart did make.
The speaker continues his narrative by describing the lotos fruit which the "Lotos-eaters" brought to the sailors. They all had "Branches" that "bore…that enchanted stem." The branches were filled with the fruit and flowers of the lotos plant which the "Lotos-eaters" shared with each man from the ship.
After eating from the plant the men were overcome. What they "tasted" came onto the men like the "gushing of the wave" and made their problem seem very distant. Each man became extraordinarily tired and their voices sounded as those of dead men, coming from the grave. They were all still awake, but only in a semi-conscious state. It was if they were both asleep and awake at the same time. The fruit had some kind of magical affect on the men and cast a spell upon their intentions. Each became consume solely with their own self. The only thing they could hear was the "beating" of their own hearts.

Fifth Stanza

They sat them down upon the yellow sand,
Between the sun and moon upon the shore;
And sweet it was to dream of Fatherland,
Of child, and wife, and slave; but evermore
Most weary seem'd the sea, weary the oar,
Weary the wandering fields of barren foam.

Then some one said, “We will return no more”;
And all at once they sang, “Our island home
Is far beyond the wave; we will no longer roam.”
In the last stanza before the second half of the poem the men confess to a new desire. They sat themselves down “upon the yellow sand” at the shore of the land. Their thoughts were cast to “Fatherland,” their home and all that was waiting for them there. They dreamed of “child, and wife, and slave,” and all they left behind, but this desire for home was now deeply outweighed by their weariness. They no longer felt they had the energy or need to return to the ship and face the ocean once more. The men were more than content to remain with the “Lotos-eaters” for the rest of their lives.
They were, weary the oar, / Weary the wandering fields of barren foam,” or the vast expanses of the ocean.” A sight which once gave them all pleasure and excited their inner adventurer now means nothing.
They turned to one another and said that they would “return no more.” They did not want to return to the arduous ten year journey. They state that their island, Ithaca, is “far beyond the wave,” it is too far for them to reach or even try to get back to. They decide they will “no longer roam.”

Part II
First Stanza

CHORIC SONG
I
There is sweet music here that softer falls
Than petals from blown roses on the grass,
Or night-dews on still waters between walls
Of shadowy granite, in a gleaming pass;
Music that gentlier on the spirit lies,
Than tir’d eyelids upon tir’d eyes;
Music that brings sweet sleep down from the blissful skies.
Here are cool mosses deep,
And thro’ the moss the ivies creep,
And in the stream the long-leaved flowers weep,
And from the craggy ledge the poppy hangs in sleep.”
The second half of this poem is made up of eight stanzas. These stanzas act as a “Chroic Song.” In them, Odysseus’s crew describes the safety and comfort of the land of the “Lotos-eaters” and the lack of desire they feel to return home.
In the first of these stanzas the men begin by stating that this land is full of music that falls softly. It’s sound resembles the petals of “roses” blowing onto the grass or perhaps it resembles “night-dews” that softly collect on “still waters.”

They continue piling up metaphors and state that it is gentler than the feeling of closing one’s eyes when one is tired. It brings joy to them that is like “sweet sleep” falling down “from the blissful skies.”
They have everything they could want. The earth is made from “cool mosses” and is wound with “ivies.” This beautiful unity of plants is complimented by “stream[s]” that hold flowers and the “craggy ledge” which plays host to poppies.

The world around them resembles their own interior feelings. They are seeing their own inner peace reflected in plants, streams, and one another.

Second Stanza

II Why are we weigh'd upon with heaviness,
And utterly consumed with sharp distress,
While all things else have rest from weariness?
All things have rest: why should we toil alone,
We only toil, who are the first of things,
And make perpetual moan,
Still from one sorrow to another thrown:
Nor ever fold our wings,
And cease from wanderings,
Nor steep our brows in slumber's holy balm;
Nor harken what the inner spirit sings,
"There is no joy but calm!"
Why should we only toil, the roof and crown of things?
The second part of the choral song follows a particular theme of discontent. The narrator, speaking for the men, asks the universe why men have no rest, while all others do. They state that they are "weigh'd upon with heaviness" while also being "consumed by sharp distress." The men do not believe that this is fair as everything else in the world has "rest." Why should they be the only creatures to consistently "toil alone?"

As was found in the first part of this poem the men, after eating the lotos fruits are only concerned with their own well being. They no longer feel for those beyond their reach. They, the "first of things" are the only ones to "toil" and the only to make "perpetual moan[s]." The men are rejecting their previous lives of hard work and struggle in favor of one in which they will only rest. They no longer want to be thrown from sorrow to sorrow, "Nor" ever have to stop doing as they please in favor of working.

Third Stanza

III Lo! in the middle of the wood,
The folded leaf is woo'd from out the bud
With winds upon the branch, and there
Grows green and broad, and takes no care,
Sun-steep'd at noon, and in the moon
Nightly dew-fed; and turning yellow
Falls, and floats adown the air.
Lo! sweeten'd with the summer light,
The full-juiced apple, waxing over-mellow,
Drops in a silent autumn night.
All its allotted length of days
The flower ripens in its place,
Ripens and fades, and falls, and hath no toil,
Fast-rooted in the fruitful soil.
The third of these "Choric Song" stanzas speaks on how the men feel that unlike the rest of creation, they are unable to have a peaceful life that consists of living and then dying. They want to live as a leaf does. Budding, being blown on it's branch, growing green "and broad," never having to take a care, and then finally after being "dew-fed" under the moon, turn yellow and float to the ground. They are seeing the life cycle of the simplest parts of creation as the most appealing to them.
All things, the chorus states, are able to live to an "allotted length of days" and then be replaced by something else that will eventually ripen and fade. These lives are the most fulfilling as they have a distinct purpose that does not including toiling.

Fourth Stanza

IV Hateful is the dark-blue sky,
Vaulted o'er the dark-blue sea.
Death is the end of life; ah, why
Should life all labour be?
Let us alone. Time driveth onward fast,
And in a little while our lips are dumb.
Let us alone. What is it that will last?
All things are taken from us, and become
Portions and parcels of the dreadful past.
Let us alone. What pleasure can we have
To war with evil? Is there any peace
In ever climbing up the climbing wave?
All things have rest, and ripen toward the grave
In silence; ripen, fall and cease:
Give us long rest or death, dark death, or dreamful ease.

In the fourth stanza the speakers are bemoaning the fact that we are all heading towards death and must "labour" on the way there. They do not believe that life should be completely made up of "labour." They want to be left totally alone. Unbothered by the real world.

Their lives are moving very quickly and death will soon approach. While they are still alive they want to be left alone and have nothing else taken from them. There is no point that they can see fighting wars against evil as there is no pleasure in it. Nothing in the world is going to last, so why waste their time making dreadful memories.

By the end of the stanza they have come to the conclusion that it is better to just die now rather than live a life of labour.

Fifth Stanza

VHow sweet it were, hearing the downward stream,

With half-shut eyes ever to seem

Falling asleep in a half-dream!

To dream and dream, like yonder amber light,

Which will not leave the myrrh-bush on the height;

To hear each other's whisper'd speech;
Eating the Lotos day by day,

To watch the crisping ripples on the beach,

And tender curving lines of creamy spray;

To lend our hearts and spirits wholly

To the influence of mild-minded melancholy;

To muse and brood and live again in memory,

With those old faces of our infancy

Heap'd over with a mound of grass,

Two handfuls of white dust, shut in an urn of brass!

The fifth stanza of the chorus describes how sweet a life it would be to lay around in a "half-dream" all the time. The speakers are seeing all of the good parts of a completely simple life and

none of the bad parts of idleness. The men are dreaming here of a life in which they can "hear each other's whisper'd speech" while they are laying around "Eating the Lotos day by day." That is the only task which they have to complete and the more they eat, the more satisfied with their situation they will become.
The men will "watch crisping ripples" or waves, washing up on the beach and admire the "curving lines" of the spray which it creates. They will commit their bodies, "hearts and spirits" to "melancholy" and spend there rest of time "brood[ing]" over memories of the past.
They will remember all those that have passed away since they were born and that are now buried under a "mound of grass" or cremated and shut up in "an urn of brass!" They will not be bothered by death though ad they will know they are living the best possible version of their lives here on the island.

Sixth Stanza

VI Dear is the memory of our wedded lives,
And dear the last embraces of our wives
And their warm tears: but all hath suffer'd change:
For surely now our household hearths are cold,
Our sons inherit us: our looks are strange:
And we should come like ghosts to trouble joy.
Or else the island princes over-bold
Have eat our substance, and the minstrel sings
Before them of the ten years' war in Troy,
And our great deeds, as half-forgotten things.
Is there confusion in the little isle?
Let what is broken so remain.
The Gods are hard to reconcile:
'Tis hard to settle order once again.
There *is* confusion worse than death,
Trouble on trouble, pain on pain,
Long labour unto aged breath,
Sore task to hearts worn out by many wars
And eyes grown dim with gazing on the pilot-stars.
The men continue on, saying that they will not forget their past lives. Their "wedded lives" will remain "dear" to them, as will the last moments they spent with their wives. They are not going to forget everything that used to matter to them but are accepting of the fact that there is nothing they can do to get back to how things were. Their household's are probably "cold" they say and their sons, all grown up, having inherited their father's "looks." If they did return they would bring nothing but trouble to the home. They've been gone for so long that they do not believe things would ever go back to the way they were.
Or, they state, things could not have gone so peacefully at home. While they were fighting in Troy for ten years, "island princes" could have been "over-bold" and taken over their homes. The men's "deeds" could have been forgotten and their names smeared.
They have no intention of fixing this state of things if it is indeed the case, they are fine to let it stay broken as it is too hard to regain order once it is lost. Still, they believe they would only make things worse, even if things have not gone well from the start.
Seventh Stanza

VII But, propt on beds of amaranth and moly,
How sweet (while warm airs lull us, blowing lowly)
With half-dropt eyelid still,
Beneath a heaven dark and holy,
To watch the long bright river drawing slowly
His waters from the purple hill—

To hear the dewy echoes calling
From cave to cave thro' the thick-twined vine—
To watch the emerald-colour'd water falling
Thro' many a wov'n acanthus-wreath divine!
Only to hear and see the far-off sparkling brine,
Only to hear were sweet, stretch'd out beneath the pine.

In the seventh stanza of the "Choric Song" the men once more reiterate what the alternative to returning home and creating more chaos would be. They could, and want to, just stay here, "propt on beds of amaranth and moly," two different types of European plants, (moly is said to have had magic properties).

They will relax, with "half-dropt eyelids" and spend their days watching the river and "His" waters from their "purple hill." The sea will now be to them just a sight in the distance. There will be no more sailing or dangers they have to face. They will be guaranteed safety and endless days of "gazing" on the rivers of this land.

Eighth Stanza

VIIIThe Lotos blooms below the barren peak:

The Lotos blows by every winding creek:

All day the wind breathes low with mellower tone:
Thro' every hollow cave and alley lone

Round and round the spicy downs the yellow Lotos-dust is blown.

We have had enough of action, and of motion we,

Roll'd to starboard, roll'd to larboard, when the surge was seething free,

Where the wallowing monster spouted his foam-fountains in the sea.

Let us swear an oath, and keep it with an equal mind,

In the hollow Lotos-land to live and lie reclined

The final stanza of this section of the poems is longer than the seven that have preceded it. The speaker begins by describing how the Lotos blooms everywhere that they look. It survives in the most barren and most wet of places. The wind that gently "blows" through the island sweeps up the "yellow Lotos-dust," most likely a reference to pollen, and carries it from place to place, spreading the plant farther.

The men have had enough of "action" and being blown around on a ship from side to side. They no longer want to face the monsters of the deep. Instead, they state, they will swear an oath to ignore the rest of mankind and only exert enough energy to lay around on the island and eat lotos. They will be like Gods, observing but not interfering with mankind. This is a misrepresentation of the Gods of Greek mythology as they were most known for the inability to stop interfering with mankind. They were constantly changing the course of history.

On the hills like Gods together, careless of mankind.

For they lie beside their nectar, and the bolts are hurl'd

Far below them in the valleys, and the clouds are lightly curl'd

Round their golden houses, girdled with the gleaming world:

Where they smile in secret, looking over wasted lands,

Blight and famine, plague and earthquake, roaring deeps and fiery sands,

Clanging fights, and flaming towns, and sinking ships, and praying hands.

But they smile, they find a music centred in a doleful song

Steaming up, a lamentation and an ancient tale of wrong,

Like a tale of little meaning tho' the words are strong;

Chanted from an ill-used race of men that cleave the soil,

Sow the seed, and reap the harvest with enduring toil,

Storing yearly little dues of wheat, and wine and oil;

Till they perish and they suffer—some, 'tis whisper'd—down in hell

Suffer endless anguish, others in Elysian valleys dwell,

Resting weary limbs at last on beds of asphodel.

Surely, surely, slumber is more sweet than toil, the shore

Than labour in the deep mid-ocean, wind and wave and oar;

O, rest ye, brother mariners, we will not wander more.

In the second half of this stanza the sailors say that they see the Gods as spending all their time just as the men are now. The only difference being that they recline alongside "their nectar" while hurling bolts of lighting into the "valleys." The Gods, they state, do not care about the impact of "famine, plague, and earthquake" on the humans below them. They "smile" and listen to music while men suffer.

The speakers describe the music as being created by the God's indifference is consists of human lamentation and misuse. The maltreatment of humans by the Gods has been going on forever, it is an "ancient" problem and the Gods have enjoyed for all of time.

Mankind is forced to "Sow the seed, and reap the harvest with enduring toil." A person's life is made up of nothing but hard work and misery until "they perish and they suffer…down in hell." Others, the speakers state, are dwelling in "Elysian valleys," or paradise. These lucky beings are "Resting weary limbs on beds of asphodel," an immortal flower that grows in Elysian.

They conclude the poem by restating that "surely, slumber is more sweet than toil" and by reassuring one another that they will cease their wanders from now on.

In the myth on which this poem is based Odysseus, having not eaten from the lotos plants, is forced to carry his men back onto the ship and single handedly sail away from the island. The men eventually come to their senses once the magic of the plant has worn off.

About Alfred Lord Tennyson

Alfred Lord Tennyson was born in 1809 in Somersby, Lincolnshire, England. He was one of twelve children and had, by the age of twelve, written his first epic poem that consisted of 6,000 lines.

In 1827 Tennyson left his home to attend Trinity College, Cambridge. It was there the he and his brother, Charles, co published a book of poems titled, *Poems by Two Brothers.* This book put Tennyson on the radar of other prolific college writers and he made friends with another student, Arthur Hallam. After a brief but intense friendship Hallam died, leaving a bereft Tennyson to devoted a number of poems to his memory.

From 1830 to 1832, Tennyson published two more books of poetry. These were not met with outstanding reviews and the poet was greatly disappointment. His naturally shy disposition would keep him from publishing again for another nine years. Tennyson finally met with some success in 1842 after the publication of this book, *Poems* in two volumes. When Tennyson published *In Memoriam,* one of the pieces dedicated to his college friend, Hallam, his reputation was solidified throughout Britain. That same year he married Emily Sellwood, with whom he would have two sons.

Tennyson's popularity and success allowed him to continue writing full time and purchase a home for his family in the country. Tennyson died in 1892 and remains one of the most popular Victorian poets.

REVISION QUESTIONS

1. Write a note on the theme of *Jane Eyre.*

2. Explain briefly the characters in the novel *Jane Eyre.*

3. Write a note on the theme of *Animal Farm.*

4. Explain briefly the characters in the novel *Animal Farm.*

5. Write a note on the theme of *Kanyadaan.*

6. Explain briefly the characters in the novel *Kanyadaan.*

7. Write a critical analysis of *To Wordsworth.* Also mention the literary devices used.

8. Write a critical analysis of *Prometheus.* Also mention the literary devices used.

9. Write a critical analysis of *Lady of Shallot .* Also mention the literary devices used.

10. Write a critical analysis of *The Lotus Eaters*. Also mention the literary devices used.